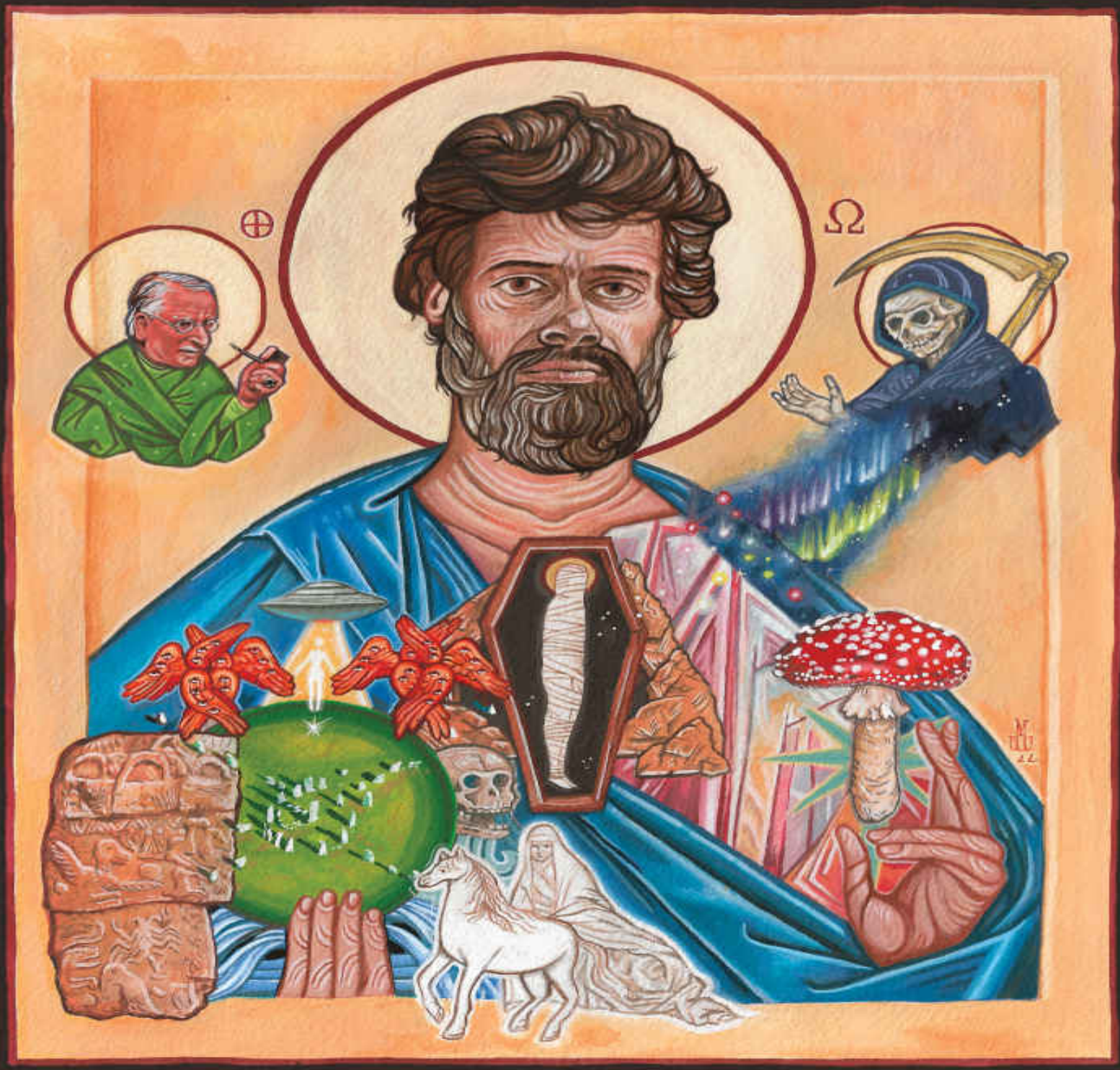
ECOLOGY OF SOULS

A New Mythology of Death & the Paranormal

~ VOLUMES ONE and TWO ~



Joshua Cutchin

This eBook comes with complete endnote citations

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VOLUMES ONE & TWO

by

Joshua Cutchin

OBJ

This has something to do with what we call death.

— Anne Strieber

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Cutchin, Joshua, *Ecology of Souls: A New Mythology of Death & the Paranormal.*

First Kindle edition in the United States, 2022

ISBN-13 for the print edition of Volume One: 978-1-7339808-5-2

ISBN-13 for the print edition of Volume Two: 978-1-7339808-6-9

ISBN-13 for the print edition of The Companion Book: 978-1-7339808-7-6

Published by Joshua Cutchin, Horse and Barrell Press

Publisher's website: www.joshuacutchin.com

Art by Johnny Decker Miller

www.johnnydeckermiller.com

Interior layout by Mike Clelland

Edited by Barbara Fisher

The information presented herein represents the view of the author as of the date of publication. The author reserves the right to alter or update his opinions based on new information. While every attempt has been made to verify the information in this book, the author assumes no responsibility for errors, inaccuracies, or omissions. Some names in the book are pseudonyms, and some minor details have been purposely altered to protect the anonymity of persons involved.



To Anne, Terence, the ancestors,
and all others who await us in the ecology of souls

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

With inexpressible gratitude for Barbara Fisher, whose edits, insight, and wisdom have proven invaluable in this process.

The author also wishes to thank the following individuals for their help in bringing this work together, in ways both big and small:

Chris Aubeck, Seriah Azkath, Greg Bishop, Cherylee Black, Chuck Carte, Mike Clelland, Wren Collier, Morgan Daimler, Susan Demeter, J.H., Rey Hernandez, Trey Hudson, Jack Hunter, Martin Kottmeyer, Jeffrey J. Kripal, Greg Little, Alex Matsuo, Tina McSwain, David Metcalfe, Johnny Decker Miller, Bernhard Reicher, Timothy Renner, Brother Richard, Miguel "Red Pill Junkie" Romero, Albert Rosales, Neil Rushton, Victor Soltren, Tyler Strand, Cyndi Vojvoda, Saxon Williams, Chris Woodyard, & Simon Young.

With special thanks to the following organizations:

Ask Terence McKenna, Dúchas.ie, Near-Death Experience Research Foundation, Foundation for Research into Extraterrestrial and Extraordinary Experiences, The Faculty of the University of Georgia Religion and Classics Departments, Erowid Center, and all the *6 Degrees of John Keel* and *Where Did the Road Go?* family.

And an abiding appreciation to my family and friends for their undying support.

ONE BOOK IN TWO VOLUMES…

Ecology of Souls was initially conceived as a single book. Yet, in researching the relationship between UFOs and death, it quickly became apparent that readers would need a significant amount of background information to fully appreciate the complexity of these two subjects. Thus, its length necessitated breaking the work into two separate volumes, with chapter numbers carried across both books.

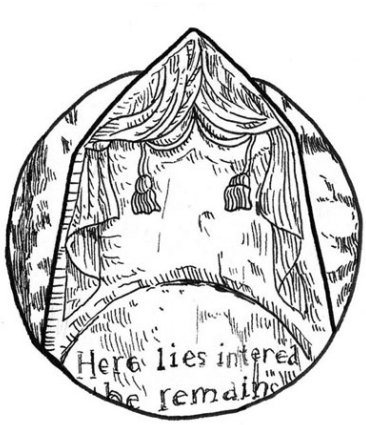
Volume One is meant to establish this foundation. It presents the reader with a working knowledge of ancient soul traditions. Volume Two examines how modern interpretations of UFOs and cryptids reflect the older themes presented in the first book, placing today's mysteries within traditions as old as humankind itself. With this destination in mind, we now embark on a journey, one that takes us from the depths of prehistory to the present—from the outer space of the cosmos to the inner space of the self.

…AND A COMPANION BOOK

The Endnotes and Bibliography for both volumes have been combined into a third supplemental book, titled: The Ecology of Souls Companion. This book also contains three appendices. This supplemental material can either be purchased as a physical copy, or accessed at this link: www.joshuacutchin.com/ecology-of-souls-companion

INTRODUCTION

OBJ



Wrapped in a blanket's comforting embrace, your head cradled by its pillow, you relax with the vulnerability only afforded in true security. If homes are castles, then bedrooms are their keeps, reinforced refuges where the owner ever shall in safety rest. Nothing penetrates this sanctum.

Half sleeping, half waking, but as yet neither fully, something catches your eye. A dark shape crouched in the corner of the room… Surely just some innocuous object—a shirt draped over a chair, an oft-overlooked oscillating fan—rendered threatening by the darkness, ill met by moonlight. You curse your overactive imagination. This explanation grants solace… until the figure steps closer.

The keep is breached. As if a switch were flipped, unearthly blinding light penetrates the room, infusing every nerve with fear and awe comingled. *Something is in the room with you*. Despite never wanting to run more in

your life, you cannot move. Sweat drenches your bedsheets. Insistent buzzing burrows into your brain. Panic amplifies tenfold. Mortal coils slip; you feel yourself—not your body, but your *self*—lift off the bed and miraculously pass through the ceiling, drawn inexorably into a beckoning night sky….

Upon retelling, you can't quite recall what message the small, glowing figure imparted, only its importance. A few memories flash clearer, but remain illogical, ineffable, impossible. They feel real—*realer than real, in fact*—yet awash in symbolism. You went somewhere, met someone (some*thing*?), and returned changed.

Was it all a dream, past the wit of man to say what dream it was? Or merely a fit of sleep paralysis? Or did you die and return to your body? Were you abducted by aliens, spirited away by faeries, or spiritually awakened?

… or all of the above?

One giant ghost story

"A New York psychiatrist once asked me if I'd ever heard of deceased people appearing in flying saucers," wrote paranormal researcher John Keel in 1976. "He told me how a young patient, a teenaged boy, claimed to have witnessed a UFO landing and was astonished to see his late father emerge from the object. The psychiatrist knew nothing of UFOs and assumed the whole thing was nothing but a childish fantasy. Actually, however, there have been hundreds of similar reports although they are usually ignored by the hard core believers in extraterrestrial spaceships."[1]

This is a book of contradictions. It is a book about ghosts; it is not about ghosts. It is a book about hauntings; it is not about hauntings. Most importantly, it is a book about death, but it is that neither. It is about existence.

After his 1987 book *Communion* became a pop-culture touchstone, author and experiencer Whitley Strieber was inundated with correspondence from readers detailing their encounters with the Visitors, presumably extraterrestrial abductors. After reading thousands of letters and compiling correlations, Whitley's wife Anne jotted at the top of a yellowed sheet of observations: "This has something to do with what we call death."[2]

Anne Strieber's insight haunts Ufology and, by extension, the interconnected supernatural as a whole. Why would dead loved ones appear in alien abductions? Why does western European faerie lore—describing

those short, subterranean spirits fond of kidnapping children—so inextricably associate them with the dead? Why do certain anomalous animals (i.e. *cryptids*) presage death? Forteans—those following in the footsteps of Charles Fort, pioneering researcher of the unexplained—are left wondering whether or not we are simply dealing with one giant ghost story.

The possibility is simultaneously reductive and compelling. Why shouldn't all great mysteries be related to The Greatest Mystery of All? Dying, like birth, is universal. If death and alien abductions are fundamentally connected, then paranormal experiences are implicitly universal, foundational birthrights of human experience. Continuing our contradictions, we all know *about* death, yet none know *of* it. We will all *experience* it, yet none of us *have* experienced it.

Or so conventional belief holds. An estimated ten percent of human beings have undergone a near-death experience (NDE), wherein they have died (to all outward appearances) and been revived, yet retain extensive memories of supernatural journeys, or even veridical recall of nearby events among the living, during their brief absence.[3] Since the term's first use in 1975 in psychiatrist Raymond Moody's *Life After Life*, NDEs have been compared to a variety of Fortean experiences including alien abductions, faerie encounters, psychedelic trips, and shamanic initiations. NDEs are therefore critical to any examination of death and the supernatural.

This work illustrates how paranormal entities—faeries, aliens, even many cryptids—might be best understood as an ecology of souls, viewed through the lenses of death and human soul tradition. More explicitly, these beings correspond closely to psychopomps (guides to the deceased), one of our

multiple souls, ancestors, and the generalized human dead—a flood of possibilities springing from the headwaters of death. Delving deeper, topics as disparate as altered states of consciousness, shamanism, ancient monuments, and ley lines enter the conversation, creating what is hopefully a fresh, wholistic perspective on these mysterious beings and mankind's relationship to them. The aim is to show how paranormal entities draw upon a tight, consistent suite of recurring imagery that restores death, or more accurately the soul, as a focal point around which the supernatural can be understood.

This undertaking is enormous. Death symbolism and folklore are infinitely rich, fertile ground, and their intersection with Forteana could fill a hundred books. Therefore, it is important to describe what this work *is not*. It cannot be comprehensive. No attempts are made to reinvent, redefine, or prove the existence of the afterlife, ghosts, or the nature of the soul. Having established that, this book presupposes the survival of human consciousness in some form following death. Though they appear by necessity, ghost stories, UFO cults and religions, and "ancient astronaut" theories are not a primary focus. This work is long enough without deep dives into psychology, latent psi phenomena, and *tulpas* (thought forms)—though again, these appear when necessity demands.

Patience is requested in the first three chapters, which focus on NDEs, psychopomps, and soul traditions. While these seem far removed from our primary goal—the intersection of death and encounters with paranormal entities in the modern era—each lays invaluable groundwork for a richer discussion, planting seeds which germinate and blossom in each successive chapter.

Another caveat: this work is *dense*, comparing traditions from across the world in lengthy lists. This unfortunate quality is inescapable when trying to illustrate a truly universal phenomenon. Multiple examples are required, often in quick-fire fashion, to prove how pervasive any given belief might be.

This study also exhibits an anthropocentric bias, in that it primarily focuses on the human experience of death and interprets many paranormal entities as human souls, rather than demons, nature spirits, or other alien intelligences; this by no means invalidates such viewpoints. To the contrary, these non-human beings play an import role in our analysis, and appear throughout, filling essential niches. They are simply not our primary focus.

Finally, this book is a thought experiment. All, some, or none of its proposals may be accurate, and many are undoubtedly dead ends of inquiry. When hypothesizing the supernatural, we all imperfectly cobble together speculations in our attempt to render the nonsensical sensible; we can but note similarities, naturally spawning accusations of preferential data selection. But, as Gregory Shushan notes in his *Conceptions of the Afterlife in Early Civilizations*, "one of the reasons comparative studies have so often focused on similarities is that the dissimilarities are both expected and incalculably vast."[4] Fortean studies thrive on comparative study.

Welcome to the ecology of souls.

A ghost primer

"The paranormal, to me, is essentially phenomena that wells up around death, and either anticipates death, or is some sort of running commentary during or after death," artist and author Christopher Knowles said in a 2020 interview. "When real paranormal things happen, it's almost always connected to death."[5]

Though varying from culture-to-culture, the broad strokes of what constitute ghosts and hauntings remain similar. Some old buildings or burial locations retain the souls, or at least active memories, of deceased humans or animals. Hauntings may be constant or activated by transition, liminality, interaction with living mediums or psychics, or even geographical features like mineral deposits or waterways. Hauntings feature ghosts: invisible forces, semi-transparent figures, or completely opaque full-bodied apparitions, sometimes repeating old actions, including moving along old paths now-obstructed, perhaps passing through solid structures. These specters variously ignore or interact with the living.

Other haunting hallmarks include moving objects, cold spots, opening doors and windows, feelings of dread, apparitions in mirrors, knocks or raps, lithoboly (thrown stones), disembodied voices and touches, mysterious music, strange odors, unexplained light phenomena, and a host of other oddities. Hauntings appear to last centuries and may be positive or negative; if the latter, they can manifest bad luck or danger for properties and persons. Ghost hunters sometimes claim objective "proof" of hauntings through

anomalous electromagnetic readings, photographs, video, or audio evidence. Chief among these is EVP, or electronic voice phenomenon, the unintentional or intentional capture of a sound or voice on audio equipment, typically inaudible at the time of recording.

Just why some unfortunate souls persist remains uncertain. Conventional wisdom dictates "unfinished business" tethers ghosts to Earth (especially unsolved murders), while others seem overly dedicated to their jobs post-mortem, are unaware they have died, or simply enjoy sticking around. Those of us who die and never return, or "move on" after resolving some issue, find ourselves either reincarnated (reborn) or in some version of the afterlife.

While Christianity's heaven and hell dominate modern Western thought, moral segregation is far from a universal concept. Reward and punishment are absent in the afterlife for many cultures. Nor do the gods and spirits of mankind always inhabit the same space—some cultures envision a singular afterlife, others multiple destinations.

In ancient Greece, Hades was neither heaven nor hell, but a "dark, sterile, and humorless realm" to which all were consigned; the gods selected some lucky souls for the paradisiacal Elysian Fields. Many indigenous populations describe plentiful lands similar to Earth. In some North American, Chinese, and African cosmologies, including that of ancient Egypt, the afterlife is a mirror universe practically indistinguishable from the living world, or may in fact be an undiscovered geographical location itself. It is impossible to speak monolithically of Indian religions (e.g. Hinduism and Buddhism) but, while focusing on reincarnation, some practices feature heaven and hell realms.[6]

Abrahamic religions exhibit surprising complexity. Catholic theology includes subsets like Limbo for the souls of the unassigned and Purgatory for those yet purified (Islam posits similar expiative existences). Judaism emphasizes living life over the afterlife, which according to various texts may be paradise or damnation, a stasis awaiting resurrection, or the Hades-like *Sheol*.[7]

While the idea that ghosts represent human souls remains popular, it is but one hypothesis. Another idea, the Stone Tape Theory, posits hauntings are "recordings" imprinted on environmental elements like rocks (perhaps even the buildings themselves) and "replayed" under certain conditions. Although interesting, the science remains dubious.[8] Others maintain ghosts are demons appearing as the deceased, or timeslips—essentially glimpses into the past. That the ghost of a single individual can appear at multiple locations, manifest with ahistorical or anachronistic accessories, or belong to an entirely fictional character further confuses the matter.

Famously, author Walter Gibson reportedly saw his character The Shadow skulking in the corners of his Greenwich Village home.[9] This fuels speculation of "man-made ghosts," i.e. thought forms or *tulpas*, a term borrowed from Buddhist teaching to describe semi-independent entities created solely through mental or spiritual discipline. The concept has merit. In 1972, a group of Canadian parapsychologists claimed they generated an artificial "ghost" named "Philip Aylesford" which correctly answered questions about its fictional "life" via raps and knocks. While compelling, the Philip Experiment doesn't prove thoughts can assume autonomy; an actual disincarnate intelligence may have imitated "Philip," or the sitters could have answered their own questions subconsciously.[10]

From ghosts to faeries, Bigfoot to extraterrestrials, Mothman to Dogman, we have ascribed similar features to all manifestations of "the Other" since time immemorial. Attempting to reconcile these varied entities, researcher Hilary Evans wrote, "It is still far from clear whether we are dealing with a single phenomenon, or different forms of a single phenomenon, or several phenomena that share certain characteristics. Clearly, there *are* shared characteristics: equally clearly, there are differences."[11]

Imaginal vs Imaginary

On August 6, 1977, 63-year-old Tom Dawson was moseying with his dog through a Pelham, Georgia cow pasture when a flying saucer descended from the sky, hovering just above the ground. Dawson, his dog, and the cattle were all frozen in place as five white, hairless, neckless humanoids emerged. The beings (three male, two female, three nude) had "sharp noses" and "pointed ears." They briefly examined Dawson who, the entire time, could hear someone inside the UFO repeatedly shouting, "I am Jimmy Hoffa!" (Since Hoffa himself famously "disappeared" two years prior, perhaps his soul was indeed trapped inside!) The beings chittered amongst themselves before returning to the craft, which rose 75 feet into the air and disappeared.[12]

Theater and symbolism are paranormal *lingua franca*. Encountering these persistent elements in UFO accounts of the 1970s, researcher J. Allen Hynek coined the term "High Strangeness" in an attempt to describe their absurdism and dream logic. Some instances are so extreme they render the paranormal difficult to take seriously. Thus, while acknowledging a genuine intelligence lies behind these phenomena, it is necessary to adopt a more subtle approach. Both literal acceptance and wholesale dismissal are a disservice.

"They speak a very different language from us, and I don't mean words," Whitley Strieber wrote of his Visitors. "I've never heard any words from them except a few in English here and there. However, there has been a rich

communication in symbols."[13] More recently he added, "Even when words are used, multiple meanings are conveyed."[14]

Symbols also permeate afterlife studies, particularly shamanism. (Broadly speaking, shamanism refers to indigenous religious beliefs in a spirit world accessed by human intercessors through ecstatic trances.) In his 2015 book *Death Walkers: Shamanic Psychopomps, Earthbound Ghosts, and Helping Spirits in the Afterlife Realm*, Fulbright Scholar David Kowalewski claims "nonordinary reality, as the wisdom traditions have recognized for millennia, is saturated with symbols, and the shaman who ignores that fact is, to that extent, ineffective. In shamanic journeys, symbols come out of nowhere, or better, out of the Big Everywhere."[15]

We must distinguish *imaginal* from *imaginary*: paranormal imagery may be *from* your head, but the phenomena are not *in* your head. Author Patrick Harpur alludes to this dichotomy in 1995's seminal *Daimonic Reality* (albeit using the term "imaginatively" instead):

> … it is easy to understand another kind of reality, of truth—for example, whenever we watch a drama on stage or screen… we feel that we are watching a revelation of some deeper reality, normally concealed in the muddle of our mundane lives. Even if it is not great art, we still—astonishingly—suffer all the emotions of suspense, joy, pity, and terror… We are seized because the drama is real—not literally real but imaginatively real.[16]

This brings contemporary Westerners into closer alignment with indigenous thinking.

"In the Kichagga language… there is no word for 'fiction,' because there is no sharp distinction between imagination and reality," wrote R. Sambuli Mosha of Tanzania's Chagga. "Thought and reality are closely related because imagination has the potential of bringing the imagined phenomenon into being." This lack of distinction applies to many of the world's oldest cultures.[17]

Author Greg Bishop suggests a Co-Creative process may be at play in UFO encounters: are "our subconscious minds trying to make sense of unexpected, startling, and/or frightening input, and leaving us with an insane placeholder when it can't decide on anything else?"[18] In 1987 Ufologist Jenny Randles suggested "our heads contain a 'mind store' of images from which we build our perceptions," implying either paranormal phenomena choose their appearances from witness expectations, or experiencers' minds involuntarily employ Bishop's "placeholder."[19]

Two examples illustrate this subjective nature and the importance of perception. In 1817, Keeper of the Crown Jewels Edmund Lenthal Swifte was dining with his family in the Tower of London when he perceived a blue-white "cylindrical figure, like a glass tube, seemingly about the thickness of my arm" floating in midair; though in clear view of everyone, only Swifte and his wife saw the apparition, while his son and sister-in-law could not.[20] We may surmise it was simply "not meant for them." Looking more recently, in the early 1990s an abductee reported a Grey alien which transformed into a blond-haired man—"This is the way you want me to look," she was told.[21]

Co-Creation is common in many afterlife beliefs. The *Bardo Thödol*, or "Tibetan Book of the Dead," for instance, "states that the being of light [in

the afterlife] will be perceived according to the individual's cultural/religious background and beliefs," according to Shushan. "Other images are mind-dependent manifestations of personal hopes, fears, desires and the like."[22]

A similar mechanism appears during near-death experiences. NDEs feature interactions with entities which, when not generic "beings of light" or deceased loved ones, typically correspond to one's religious beliefs or culture.[23] Since the aftereffects of NDEs suggest genuine events (i.e. not imaginary), as elaborated later, it appears these intelligences draw upon our expectations.

To assume encounters are solely "in our heads" misinterprets Co-Creation Theory. Any cursory survey of Fortean literature reveals physical effects from non-physical stimuli, including stigmata (wounds on devout Christians mimicking crucifixion) and dream injuries. In the 600s, St. Peter scourged Archbishop Laurentius in his dream before he awoke to painful lacerations.[24] More recently, a Scottish victim dreamt she was punched in the mouth—waking, she was bloodied, with several teeth painfully knocked loose.[25] This implies our modern dualism is a false dichotomy—consider psi studies and hauntings, where the intangible (i.e. psychic faculties, ghosts) influence the tangible (e.g. moving objects, leaving footprints, etc.)

"This is an important point to make, which the 'flying saucer people' are forever misunderstanding… saying that the flying saucer is a psychic object does not mean that it is not a physical object," said psychonaut-cum-philosopher Terence McKenna. "Jung, in *Mysterium Coniunctionis* is at great pains to say that the realm of the psychic and the realm of the physical meet

in a strange kind of ‘Never-Never Land’ that we have yet to create the intellectual tools to explore.”[26]

Carl Jung and the Collective Unconscious

McKenna's evocation of Carl Jung is apt. Born in 1875, the Swiss psychiatrist's contribution to psychology is frankly immeasurable, and students of paranormal topics ignore Jung at their peril. Not only did he seriously entertain their existence, but Jung was something of an experiencer himself, developing a model for understanding synchronicities (highly-improbable coincidences), attending séances, and, for lack of a better term, seeing ghosts.

"We are not quite certain about this end," Jung said of death. "… there are these peculiar faculties of the psyche, that it isn't entirely confined to space and time. You can have dreams or visions of the future… Only ignorance denies these facts. It's quite evident that they do exist, and have existed always."[27] If other luminaries of the 20th century had been equally open-minded, perhaps the 21st would look much different.

In one instance Jung found himself "overpowered by the image of someone drowning" while riding a train. Upon reaching his destination, he discovered his youngest grandson had nearly drowned "at exactly the time I had been assailed by that memory in the train. The unconscious had given me a hint. Why should it not be able to inform me of other things also?"[28]

Jung seemed to experience Co-Creation Theory in action while attending a Spiritualist séance where "four of the five people present saw an object like a moon floating above the abdomen of the medium," but he could not. "I know

of three more cases where certain objects were seen in the clearest detail (in two of them by two persons, and in the third by one person) and could afterwards be proved to be non-existent. Two of these cases happened under my direct observation."[29]

The psychiatrist's interests even extended into the UFO realm with his insightful 1958 essay *Flying Saucers: A Modern Myth of Things Seen in the Skies* (see Chapter 15). Though not his final conclusion, Jung hinted at one this work's central theses: "The idea that the Ufo might be a sort of Charon is certainly one that I have not met in the literature so far," he wrote, referencing the psychopomp of Greek mythology.[30]

Jung's groundbreaking theories of mind provide an elegant vocabulary for discussing supernatural phenomena. To Jung, not only are individual minds possessed of an unconscious, but so is humanity as a whole. He dubbed this the *Collective Unconscious*. From this wellspring arise *archetypes*, universal images and themes repeating independently across time, without cultural transmission. From a Jungian perspective, paranormal imagery may not be from *your* head, but from the *collective* head.

Late UFO researcher and Harvard Medical School professor John Mack suspected something similar was at play in alien abductions: the reified metaphor, or "metaphor made real."

"On the one hand, the experience is vividly and undeniably real and concrete for [abductees]," he wrote, "while at the same time it is deeply metaphoric or archetypal, including representations of death, birth, rebirth, transcendence, and enlightenment."[31]

Jungian archetypes like The Warrior, Crone, Magician, etc., appear in our art, religion, and myths. They also emerge in our lives. For instance, The Mother archetype emphasizes nurturing, care, and security, manifesting not only in the lives of new parents but also in patterns of behavior among hospitality and healthcare professionals. In computer science terms, archetypes are the "source code" of reality. Jungian scholar John Betts called Fairy Tales "the purest and simplest expression of collective unconscious psychic processes"; they may be better referred to as "Archetype Tales."[32]

An important archetype is The Trickster. As embodied in mythological figures like Coyote, Loki, Reynard the Fox, Puck, and Brer Rabbit, The Trickster has long been associated with High Strangeness. George P. Hansen's seminal *The Trickster and the Paranormal* outlines how this archetype—mischievous, humorous, vulgar, yet neutral, violative of order and structure—is embedded in every aspect of both these phenomena *and* their studies. The consistently underwhelming nature of paranormal evidence is, in Hansen's view, an aspect of The Trickster's self-negating nature.[33]

We return sporadically to The Trickster. For the moment, remember it is a guardian of thresholds—like death—and therefore a catalyst for change.

"The putative ETs have all the earmarks of human psychic components in symbolic form, which are in the process of manifesting in the psychic economy of a person undergoing a psychological transformation of a typical sort," wrote Dennis Stillings. "Perhaps that very transformation traditionally referred to as 'rebirth.'"[34]

The hard problem of consciousness

38-year-old "Dave" was among Mack's research subjects. In his book *Abduction: Human Encounters with Aliens*, Mack described a lifetime of interaction between Dave and apparent "extraterrestrial" intelligences beginning around age three. Over the decades, Dave developed a kinship with one of the female entities, and nursed a suspicion he was "as much or more part of them than human," that the beings might "have known us before, in other lifetimes." Further work revealed alleged memories of a Pre-Columbian "past life" as a member of Pennsylvania's Susquehannock tribe, during which he first ascended Pemsit Mountain and met "Velia," his female alien companion. Dave recalled later dying in battle and separating from his body, accompanied by Velia.

"When I floated out of my body, before I dissipated, she told me that she'd be with me even when I came back," he said. "Then I was born again in Virginia."[35]

Such tales repel traditional Ufologists adhering to notions of flesh-and-blood extraterrestrials traveling in nuts-and-bolts spacecraft. But stories like Dave's are too common to dismiss entirely—indeed, we addresses them extensively—and fit neatly into studies of the transmigration of souls, a belief that living beings are reborn into new bodies on Earth following death.

"The notion of reincarnation is very ancient and is still widely prevalent in every part of the world, especially in parts of Asia and in the native societies

of Africa and Australia," wrote afterlife scholar James R. Lewis. Ancient Greeks imported the concept from the East, finding popularity among thinkers like Plato, Empedocles, and Pythagoras, the last of whom maintained "human beings can incarnate in animal forms" as well.[36] While Christianity largely abandoned reincarnation by the early Middle Ages, the belief remains a central tenet of Asian religions and even finds acceptance among 33% of American adults, according to a 2018 poll.[37]

The gold standard for reincarnation studies can be found in the work of Jim Tucker and the late Ian Stevenson, both professors from the University of Virginia School of Medicine. Their compelling research examines hundreds of startling coincidences between the lives of deceased individuals and children's past life memories, including birth marks corresponding to fatal wounds. These children are too young to research obituaries, the deceased too obscure, their memories filled with details only known to family members. Stevenson's *Reincarnation and Biology* and Tucker's *Life Before Life* come highly recommended.[38]

Despite their rigor, such studies cannot "prove" reincarnation, even if we accept supernatural explanations. It is possible these children psychically read others' memories, rather than directly remember them. This seems possible given the strong likelihood that psychic abilities, or psi, exist.

Physicist Dr. Russell Targ claimed more evidence supports the existence of telepathy and precognition than supports the efficacy of aspirin in preventing heart attacks, statistically speaking.[39] A bold statement, until one examines the work of Dean Radin. In his book *Real Magic*, Radin cites laboratory-controlled consciousness research exceeding the six-sigma threshold: "the

overall odds against chance, after careful consideration of all known experiments investigating the same topic, are assessed to be over a billion to one."[40] Our ancestors interpreted these psychic effects—telepathy, precognition, psychokinesis, etc.—as magic, adding to the mix spirit interactions and visits to the Otherworld.[41]

Our brains may not *generate* consciousness, but rather *receive* it. If consciousness is more than a mere byproduct of brain activity, it may well be nonlocal—i.e. "not considered to be localized or confined to specific points in space, such as the physical brain and body, nor to specific points in time, such as the present."[42] If true, our current understanding of reality is upended. The Materialist/Physicalist paradigm, wherein matter is the fundamental component of reality, in which consciousness is mere illusion, is falsified. Any number of wondrous things become possible. Consciousness injects a volatile variable into every scenario.

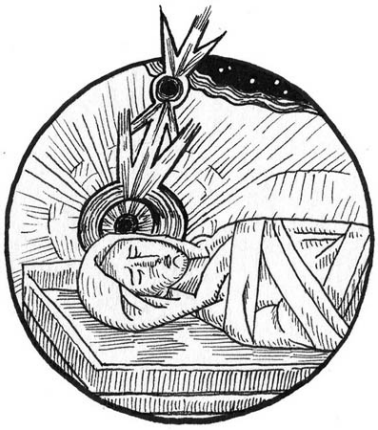
Poltergeist activity consistently manifests during and after supernatural experiences. Houses fill with mysterious raps and knocks, warm stones are thrown, objects fly or miraculously appear and disappear as *apports* and *disapports*, etc. Because of their ubiquity in hauntings and séances, poltergeists were once assumed to solely represent spirit activity (German *poltern*, "to knock," and *geist,* "spirit"). Later, parapsychologists realized poltergeists arise equally from living agents expressing latent psi abilities. Prevailing wisdom held these were typically pubescent females experiencing stress or sexual tension. Researchers like Christopher Laursen recently broadened this ageist, sexist interpretation, concluding that, while some people may be more prone, anyone is capable of manifesting poltergeist activity in any stressful situation, no matter how subtle.[43]

In short, these data suggest "the existence of an individual's immortal, nonlocal consciousness, a perspective affirmed by many philosophical and religious traditions for millennia," according to the website of NDE expert and cardiologist Pim van Lommel. Nonlocality strongly implies "consciousness pre-exists physical birth, and continues after corporeal death in a cycle whose dimensions we do not yet know…."[44]

1

NEAR-DEATH & OUT-OF-BODY EXPERIENCES

OBJ



In 1978, a heart attack landed Derrick Scull in surgery.

"I was lying there in an operation robe with a mask on my face, and obviously I'd received an injection of morphine or some sort of drug to keep me under control," he later recalled. "I wasn't experiencing pain; in fact, I was feeling at peace with the world." Without warning, Scull felt himself levitate into the corner of the operating theater, where he could see his entire body. "I was looking at my toes on the ceiling, sort of looking over, and there was my body immediately below me. I was in the corner, left hand corner of the room, looking down on this body, and I had a perfectly good eye view of the bed and the entrance to the ward."

Scull was suddenly aware of his wife, dressed in "a red trouser suit." The "very next thing" he remembered was awakening to his wife wearing the same outfit. "This is why I know it wasn't a figment of my imagination, because it was so clear." An identical experience elicited by a second heart attack "absolutely convinced" Scull that part of us "does, in fact, temporally detach itself from your body, goes to a vantage point, and looks back and reviews the situation."[45]

Scientific consensus maintains consciousness ceases upon death. Many of us know a conflicting, intuitive truth deep in our bones: consciousness persists, in some form or fashion, following death.

Despite inconsistent and dated polling, surveys indicate afterlife beliefs endure, even in the secularized West. In 2014, 73% of Americans believed in "life after death,"[46] followed by 46% of United Kingdom residents in 2017,[47] and 31% of 2018's French population.[48] Eastern statistics are harder to discern, but in places like India—where only 0.27% of the population identifies as irreligious—we can assume truly pervasive levels of afterlife belief.[49]

Science understandably answers to data, not faith. At least, this is how the scientific method is *supposed* to work. After almost half a century of research into near-death experiences (NDEs), the mainstream refuses to acknowledge the evidence. It looks less like healthy skepticism and more like willful ignorance—or, dare it be said, *faith* in outmoded Materialism. At a minimum, the possibility of consciousness's post-mortem survival is worth taking seriously.

If you ask ten near-death experiencers (NDErs) to define an NDE, you'll receive ten different answers. The Near-Death Experience Research Foundation (NDERF) website defines the NDE as "a lucid experience associated with perceived consciousness apart from the body occurring at the time of actual or threatened imminent death."[50]

Founded by respected NDE researchers Jeffrey and Jody Long in 1998, NDERF collects user-submitted experiences from around the world, boasting 4,900 entries in 38 different languages as of 2022. While suffering from the same issues plaguing other online databases—vague entries, poor grammar, complete fictions— all submissions are reviewed, and "extensive prior studies found that an Internet survey has validity that is equivalent to traditional pencil-and-paper surveys," according to the Longs.[51] NDERF remains an excellent resource.

A majority of the scientific establishment argues NDEs (indeed, all paranormal phenomena) should be rejected outright for their anecdotal nature. While anecdotes *are* subjective, they are frequently our only means of examining human consciousness. As riposte, consider the fact that, while brain *activity* can be objectively evaluated, a broad swath of conditions outlined in the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders*—the primary guidebook for psychiatric diagnoses—are only identifiable by subjective personal experience, i.e. *anecdotes*.

In one NDERF study, 95.6% of 1,122 NDErs claimed their "experience was definitely real." Even acknowledging their fallibility, these anecdotes suggest *something* anomalous occurs during NDEs. Long argues NDEs are notable for their lucidity, veridicality, and strong cross-cultural, interreligious consistency,

even while under general anesthesia, when clarity and recall should be inhibited. In fact, 83% of respondents in one survey described "more consciousness and alertness than normal" during their NDEs under general anesthesia. Their visions do not conform with dreams or hallucinations, which largely feature "living [people]… from recent memory," rather than the dead loved ones seen in NDEs.[52]

Out-of-body experiences (OBEs) can occur without near-death—covered later—but are central to NDEs. "An out-of-body experience (OBE) is the apparent separation of consciousness from the body," wrote Long. "About 45% of near-death experiencers report OBEs which involve them seeing and often hearing ongoing earthly events from a perspective that is apart, and usually above, their physical bodies. Following cardiac arrest, NDErs may see, and later accurately describe, their own resuscitation." In one NDE survey, 92% of claims were "completely accurate with no inaccuracy whatsoever" after investigation.[53]

One famous 1984 case featured a Seattle, Washington heart attack patient named Maria. She provided "detailed out-of-body observations of her resuscitation... Her consciousness passed outside the hospital, she said, where she observed a tennis shoe on the third-story window ledge." Maria provided staff with a detailed description: "It was a man's shoe, she said, left-footed and dark blue with a wear mark over the little toe and a shoelace tucked under the heel." A subsequent search of third-floor windows revealed the oddly-misplaced shoe "exactly as Maria had described it."[54]

NDErs sometimes learn about the death of a relative or friend in the NDE state long before anyone else in their family or social network. After her

resuscitation, one patient who died on the operating table claimed to have met her father, who sent her back to life. Family members dismissed the yarn. The patient's father was alive and healthy, they claimed. One of them had just spoken with him earlier that day. To their shock, they tried to contact him via telephone, only to discover he had died five minutes before his daughter.[55]

Others meet deceased relatives they never knew in life. One cardiac arrest patient was confused to encounter an unknown man in his NDE until ten years later when, on her deathbed, his mother showed him a picture of his biological father. It was a man he had never known, an extramarital affair of his mother's before he died in war: the same man from his NDE.[56]

The folly of dying brains

All this said, "near-death" is a misnomer. First, many NDErs aren't "near-death"—they are fully, clinically dead, usually for 10-15 minutes but sometimes much longer. Hospital staff even confirm their lack of vital signs, making NDEs more appropriately "Death Experiences."[57] Perplexingly, NDE-like experiences also transpire when a person is *neither* dying *nor* dead, but rather fearing death so strongly it "shocks" their consciousness out-of-body—a "near-near-death experience," if you will. While difficult to authenticate, aftereffects consistent with full-fledged NDEs validate some of these experiences.[58]

Excuses from the scientific establishment seize upon various "Dying Brain Hypotheses," suggesting the brain seeks to calm—Itself? Its owner?—by providing comforting imagery and sensations of euphoria.

"Why the mind should experience the struggle to sustain its operations in the face of loss of blood flow and oxygen as positive and blissful rather than as panic-inducing remains mysterious," admitted *Scientific American* writer Christof Koch.[59] Scientists popularly blame NDEs on hypoxia, a hallucinatory state of oxygen deprivation. Other reductionist excuses cite generalized brain trauma, neurotransmitter floods, false memories, birth memories, and hallucinations from resuscitative drugs. Psychological models are likelier, variously attributing depersonalization, expectancy of the afterlife, and—perhaps most accurately—dissociative states the power to induce NDEs.[60] All explanations remain unsatisfying.

(Scientists also appropriate research they otherwise criticize. Many suggest NDEs arise from a pre-mortem dump of *endogenous*, or internally-generated, *N,N*-Dimethyltryptamine [DMT], a chemical with psychedelic properties. While both DMT and dissociative states can model NDEs, this is a poor scapegoat for their mysterious nature: reductionists assume these factors *cause hallucinations*, rather than *alter perception*. Scientists may be mistaking the metaphorical key for the room it unlocks. Both dissociative states and DMT are pivotal to later discussion.)[61]

These scientists are simply ignoring science. No physiological nor psychological mechanism can account for the inaccessible knowledge retrieved during NDEs, nor their cross-cultural uniformity—while the minutiae of NDEs can be culture-specific, the experience's broadest strokes remain remarkably consistent worldwide. As Shushan notes, classic NDE elements can clash with religious beliefs, suggesting an objective reality to the experience. For example, bright lights and deceased relatives, absent in Zuni afterlife conceptions, appear nonetheless in Zuni NDEs. "Though individuals may be influenced by 'imagery and metaphor' in popular and religious culture, it has been found that prior knowledge of the NDE actually *decreases* the likelihood of having one," he writes.[62]

Again, these typically aren't "dying brains"—they are *dead.* Researcher Peter Fenwick emphasizes how cardiac arrest patients experience NDEs during flat EEG readings. In this state, there exists "no possibility of the brain creating images" because there is "no brain-based memory functioning… it should be impossible to have clearly structured and lucid experiences."[63]

The Dying Brain Hypothesis also fails spectacularly when faced with near-NDEs—if NDEs result from terminal brain activity, why do healthy-yet-frightened brains elicit NDE-like states, including sensations of consciousness leaving the body? No reductionist explanation encompasses both dying brains *and* healthy, frightened brains.

Moreover, *all* revived patients should report NDEs if they originate in dying brains. Yet according to Long, only around 17% of those resuscitated report NDEs. This statistic is a double-edged sword, refuting the Dying Brain Hypothesis but begging the metaphysical question: why don't NDEs happen to everyone?

"I have talked to a few people who were pronounced dead, resuscitated, and came back reporting none of these common elements," wrote Raymond Moody. "Indeed, they say that they don't remember anything at all about their 'deaths.' Interestingly enough, I have talked with several persons who were actually adjudged clinically dead on separate occasions years apart, and reported experiencing nothing on one of the occasions, but having had quite involved experiences on the other."[64]

"People don't all die at the same time, there's no specific point of death," noted Seriah Azkath, host of the *Where Did the Road Go?* podcast, citing claims from the channeled material *Seth Speaks: The Eternal Validity of the Soul*. While generally skeptical of channeling, Azkath finds value in the Seth Material for its discussion of NDEs. "Some people leave their bodies before they're dead, some stay in their bodies long after they're dead… That's probably *part* of [why everyone doesn't have a near-death experience]… The near-death experience is also a spiritual experience that helps us *here,*

because people have these experiences and come back changed, so maybe they were just on the wrong path, and needed to be corrected in some way."[65]

This is but a smattering of evidence supporting NDEs as genuine states during which consciousness exists independently. To fully appreciate the topic, consult the work of Long, Fenwick, van Lommel, Shushan, Sam Parnia, Bruce Greyson, Michael Sabom, Penny Sartori, P.M.H. Atwater, Raymond Moody, and Kenneth Ring, some of whom are discussed shortly.

Whether or not NDEs constitute full "survival after death" is debatable, but the data certainly suggests—at the very least—that the point of death is not nearly as finite as once suspected. Simply put, the time has come to relabel orthodox scientists not "NDE skeptics," but outright "NDE deniers."

Moody to Omega

Modern NDE studies began in 1975 with the publication of Raymond Moody's groundbreaking *Life After Life: The Investigation of a Phenomenon – Survival of Bodily Death*. Moody's work, compiled from over a decade of research sampling 150 cases, coined the term "near-death experience," which soon became accepted nomenclature. Although released on the heels of NDE investigation from grief pioneer Elisabeth Kübler-Ross, physician Russell Noyes, and OBE researchers Robert Crookall and Robert Monroe, *Life After Life* was the first book entirely dedicated to the topic.[66]

After 1975, researchers like Moody, Ring, Sabom, and Greyson brought NDE studies to academia, slowly garnering respectability. By 2001, attitudes had shifted so much that the premiere medical journal *The Lancet* accepted Pim van Lommel's large-scale, longitudinal study of NDEs among cardiac arrest patients.[67]

Humans have shared narratives from death's threshold since antiquity, as chronicled in Gregory Shushan's *Conceptions of the Afterlife in Early Civilizations* and *Near-Death Experience in Indigenous Religions*. Texts like the Tibetan Buddhist *Bardo Thödol* and Egyptian *Book of the Dead* may represent the earliest attempts to record NDEs, chronicling clear similarities to modern accounts.

One of the oldest Western NDEs comes to us circa 375 BC from Plato's *Republic*. After perishing in battle, Er, son of Armenius, regained

consciousness 12 days later. He described his soul traveling "with a great company… to a mysterious place at which there were two openings in the earth; they were near together, and over against them were two other openings in the heaven above." Through these portals "seated judges" dispatched souls of the just and unjust accordingly.[68]

Possibly the oldest recorded NDE of the modern era appears in Pierre-Jean du Monchaux's 1740 *Anecdotes de Médecine*, wherein an unconscious patient beheld a pure, bright light he assumed was heaven. Alas, the medical establishment's thinking has progressed little in the intervening centuries. Monchaux compared the experience to those of hanging, drowning, and hypothermia survivors, dismissing the vision as a byproduct of abnormal blood flow to the brain.[69]

In 1992, University of Connecticut psychologist Kenneth Ring released *The Omega Project: Near-Death Experiences, UFO Encounters, and Mind at Large*, comparing NDEs not only to alien abductions, but shamanic initiations as well. His connections, elaborated at length throughout the following chapters, are confronting, suggesting a root cause shared between all three experiences.

Ring proposed all manner of entities constituted an imaginal realm untethered to time and space, situated between fantasy and reality, accessible by altered states of consciousness like NDEs.[70] "Omega Prototypes"—those of us drawn into this space—might well push humanity towards the Omega Point, a singularity of collective consciousness.

The NDE, Ring maintained, contains "the seed of a higher humanity": "the millions of NDErs that modern technology has spawned [through

resuscitation], as well as millions of others who have had a similar spiritual transformative experience however it may have been brought about, might be regarded as the prototype of a more highly evolved type of human being….”[71] Ring was fully encouraged to pursue this line of inquiry after a May 1987 conversation with none other than Whitley Strieber.

“I would have to learn quite a bit more about the field I had so long resisted even hearing anything about,” Ring wrote, “The academically disreputable but now intriguing world of UFO studies, known to its adherents as ‘ufology.’”[72]

Omega Point and Prototypes aside, NDEs exhibit close consistency with Otherworld journeys in general—travels to Fairyland, the spiritual plane, psychedelic trips, dreamland, other dimensions, etc.—with some people even reporting encounters with non-human entities upon death. UFO encounters, specifically alien abductions, seem yet another variant on the “Otherworld journey” trope.

To experience an alien abduction or NDE is rare; to have both should be rarer still. Yet a 2013 study conducted by the Dr. Edgar Mitchell FREE foundation (Foundation for Research into Extraterrestrial and Extraordinary Experiences) of over 4,200 respondents from more than 100 countries revealed otherwise. “80% of [those experiencing contact with non-human intelligences] reported having had an Out of Body Experience (OBE),” while “37% have had a Near Death Experience (NDE).”[73] The FREE study categorized any experiences where witnesses met non-human intelligences as one of many “contact modalities,” a term often used here because of how well it strips away the surrounding baggage that culture has attached to

topics like NDEs, shamanism, altered states of consciousness, UFO/cryptid sightings, etc.

Even before *The Omega Project*'s release, Ring's comparisons drew criticism from Ufologists. "Ring might benefit from discussions with his psychologist," sniped prominent UFO researcher Stanton Friedman in 1989. For Friedman, Ring's "academic armchair theorizing" exhibited "obvious anti-ET [extraterrestrial] bias" lacking "a serious knowledge of hard data. His invention of an 'Imaginal' world to cover his biases is fascinating as fiction, but hardly appropriate for what is presumably non-fiction."[74] Bold statements given UFOs' unproven, ineffable nature.

Apparently, Ring's comparison was already made—*two decades prior*—by writer and researcher John Keel. In the Summer 1972 *Anomaly* journal, Keel compared UFO experiences to "death dreams." While the term has since been adopted by parapsychologists to describe death premonitions in dreams, it is obvious Keel was referring to NDEs.

"In a death dream the patient is often in a hospital or involved in a serious accident, and is comatose," he elaborated. "While he or she is close to death they have a vivid, life-like dream in which they are ascending a staircase to heaven, greeting deceased friends and relatives, or even meeting God." He continued:

> We have investigated several UFO experiences which seem based on death dreams. In one of the most recent, the victim was alone aboard a small boat in the fall of 1971. He heard a beeping sound and observed a brilliant blue light overhead. He had a history of heart attacks and was in an alcoholic stupor at the time. His entire

> experience lasted 12 hours, during which his boat (which was out of gas) moved several miles. Men in black suits appeared on his boat. Others in frogman garb came out of the water. They wanted him to go with them. Perhaps if he had consented to do so his dead body would have been found on the boat later.[75]

While his "alcoholic stupor" provides skeptics a bit of refuge, the experiencer's visions weren't delirium tremens-induced pink elephants—they were quintessential Men-in-Black (not exactly a hallmark of alcoholic hallucination). Aside from the initiating sound, bright light, beckoning entities, and the witness's fragile health, this example admittedly is not particularly comparable to NDEs; nonetheless, Keel's assertion presciently connected two "unrelated" phenomena. This connection also appeared pre-*Omega Project* at the 1981 Center for UFO Studies (CUFOS) Convention, where English professor Alvin H. Lawson attempted to dismiss the alien abduction experience as an amalgamation of "BT [birth trauma], hallucinations, and near-death experiences."[76]

Few paranormal encounters can be guaranteed, but aspects of the near-death experience implicitly await us all. What does that first step into the ecology of souls bring?

So you've decided to have a near-death experience

Threshold encounters like NDEs occur after clinical death, near-death, during comas, serious illness or trauma, or when experiencing intense fear of impending death.[77] Circumstantial evidence suggests cardiac arrest patients generate more consistent reports, but this may be a function of more effective resuscitation techniques, or the ease with which such cases might be studied—nearly a third of all heart attacks in America occur in hospitals, with 24% of patients surviving.[78] In any case, some, none, or all of the following may appear in your NDE.

After your initial trauma, you notice peculiar sounds. These are variously described as roaring, ringing, clicking, whistling, chirping, whirring, screeching, squeaking, or most commonly, humming or buzzing. You might compare it to swarming insects ("like a thousand bees buzzing at the same time"),[79] a choir ("a buzzing sensation or a humming, almost exactly like what the Buddhist monks chant"),[80] or the weather (a "whistling sound, like the wind").[81] As odd as these noises are, nothing compares to hearing yourself pronounced dead by medical staff.

You don't care, however, because the pain ceases and peace washes over you. One NDEr with severe head trauma remembered: "At the point of injury there was a momentary flash of pain, but then all the pain vanished. I had the feeling of floating in a dark space. The day was bitterly cold, yet while I was in that blackness all I felt was warmth and the most extreme comfort I have ever experienced… I remember thinking, 'I must be dead.'"[82]

When later describing what happens next, you'll likely be frustrated by language's limitations. Generally speaking, your consciousness separates, weightless, from your body, which you can see lying on the operating table or in bed. This sensation—the out-of-body experience (OBE)—is consistently described in ancient Egypt, Mesopotamia, India, China, and Mesoamerica.[83] Recalled one heart patient after coding:

> Then, I started rising upward, slowly. On my way up, I saw more nurses come running into the room… I drifted on up past the light fixture—I saw it from the side and very distinctly—and then I stopped, floating right below the ceiling, looking down. I felt almost as though I were a piece of paper that someone had blown up to the ceiling… I watched them reviving me from up there![84]

You now witness activity outside the room—within the same building, or perhaps at another far-flung location—making observations you can corroborate after returning to life. Though you may expect the infamous "light at the end of the tunnel," don't be disappointed if you simply continue ascending through the ceiling and into the sky; the "tunnel experience," once considered a defining NDE feature, is actually less common. Generally, NDErs recall a sensation of movement from darkness to light, congruent with ancient descriptions.[85]

"Often concurrently with the occurrence of the noise, people have the sensation of being pulled very rapidly through a dark space of some kind," Moody wrote. "I have heard this space described as a cave, a well, a trough,

an enclosure, a tunnel, a funnel, a vacuum, a void, a sewer, a valley, and a cylinder."[86]

Your journey invariably ends in light. Again, you are reminded of language's shortcomings, because it will never capture the incandescent, unearthly beauty—brilliant, "like a million suns," yet never painful. The light may embody a loving or welcoming presence or voice. One NDEr of Long's described "a beautiful light [which] drew me to itself; the light still touches me with awe, and tears come immediately." Another remembered "a brilliant white light at the end of the tunnel… I became part of the white light."[87]

Entering this light, a bucolic scene awaits: "a world of great beauty, with glorious colors, with meadows of golden grass, birds singing, or beautiful music."[88] Old and Middle Kingdom Egyptians described "a 'pure land' of green fragrant herbs," some Indian hymns "the 'pasture that shall not be taken away,'"[89] Aztecs "a luxurious tropical garden."[90]

According to one NDEr, her destination "had blue skies. Clear and clean, just like an autumn sky. It also had very large green fields of tiny flowers that spread all around. The field was full of white flowers and dandelions."[91] Others describe tropical beaches, lush gardens, and rainbows surmounting vibrant forests.[92] There are often bridges or boundaries like rivers, streams, fences, or doors which cannot be crossed.[93]

Your pastoral locale might boast distant, bustling "cities of light," an afterlife variant Moody noted in 1977. One survivor described "a glowing, seemingly endless city, bright enough to be seen over all the unimaginable distance between. The brightness seemed to shine from the very walls and streets of this place, and from the beings which I could now discern moving

about within it. In fact, the city and everything in it seemed to be made of light... The beauty of the countryside was incredible but even it could not compare with the splendor of the city because of the glow."[94]

Some enter a cave or cavern-like space, indirectly lit, distinct from the tunnel.[95] One NDEr described a land with "the greenest grass and the bluest skies" that also contained a crystalline cave. "The most brilliant yellow, warming light opened in the cave," he said. "I walked into the light, feeling my life end, no fear, no loss, just total peace." He awoke from a two-week long, drug-induced coma.[96] Another experiencer remembered "a soft subdued light" filling "a cave" with "a strange atmosphere."[97] Whatever the space, it *feels like home*, a return to origin.

At this point, note several sensations present from the NDE's beginning. Even if blind, you see "better than 20/20 vision," perceiving colors brighter and more varied than you've ever seen, perhaps even on all sides. "I had 360 degree vision," said one NDEr. "I could see above, below, on my right, on my left, behind, I could see everywhere at the same time!"[98]

Time has lost all meaning. "It seemed as though I experienced so much in such a small length of earthly time," a survivor told Long. Another claimed their NDE stretched longer than an hour, but medics only reported five-to-ten minutes of unconsciousness.[99]

You might hear ethereal music. Said one survivor, "The sound of that music I cannot possibly describe with words because it simply cannot be heard with that clarity in this world!"[100]

Most notably, you feel a sense of love, a singularity of oneness and knowledge. Ancient texts worldwide describe enlightenment or divine transformation into the godhead.

"The theme of love—self-love (in the sense of self-acceptance), love for others, love for the planet, love for the divine cosmos—is in fact the constant refrain in these NDE hymns," Ring wrote. "NDErs almost without exception are wont to say that it was the message of love that was the most important gift and indeed the very essence of their encounter."[101] While not generally carnal, some experience this love as sexual euphoria "like having a million orgasms all at one time."[102]

You notice other presences. Beings await, variously described as deceased loved ones—including pets—ancestors, non-human entities, or "light beings." If identifying as human, these intelligences comment on their relationship with you, often conveying love or apologies for earthly actions. They also advise best living practices, discuss the nature of the afterlife, exchange simple greetings, or clarify their well-being (e.g. "I'm all right, I'm happy," etc.).[103]

Your communication might be telepathic. NDEr Brian said his ancestors "were talking in telepathy, which caught [his] attention" because he "was born profoundly deaf." He recalled being able to "read or communicate with about twenty ancestors of [his] and others through telepathic methods."[104] Meeting dead loved ones is age-old and universal: the Egyptian *Coffin Texts* feature "clear reunions with deceased relatives," Mesopotamians dying in battle met their parents, and relatives and ancestors all greeted the newly deceased in ancient India, China, and Mesoamerica.[105]

During a late pregnancy hemorrhage, one witness "lost consciousness, and heard an annoying buzzing, ringing sound" before transporting to "a ship or a small vessel sailing to the other side of a large body of water. On the distant shore, I could see all of my loved ones who had died, my mother, my father, my sister, and others. I could see them, could see their faces, just as they were when I knew them on earth." They beckoned to her, but she rejected their call and the ship reversed course.[106]

In another instance, a Finnish woman named Anitta traversed the tunnel before someone took her arm. "Then I saw my father, just like he was when he lived," she recalled. "He said to me, 'Come here; here is good to be.'" Despite wanting to join him, she could not cross a border "like a wall that I could see through. Then I heard a dark voice that seemed to be everywhere, asking, 'Who?... not yet.'"[107]

According to sociology professor John R. Heapes, around 40% of NDE interactions involve nuclear family, the majority extended family (grandparents, aunts, uncles, etc). Heapes determined beings were slightly more often male, wearing either earthly garb or bright white "afterlife clothing." Regardless of their age at death, relatives appear "young and vital,"[108] consistent with folklore from both the East and West. Taiwanese ancestors reflect "their middle years"[109] and rural Irish described "the dead growing to the likeness of thirty years in heaven and remaining so."[110]

Don't be surprised if your welcoming party is stranger. It wasn't until age 26 that NDEr Greg learned his grandmother tried to smother him in the early throes of her dementia; he had always believed his childhood memory of ascending a pink marble stairway, led by a kind, wingless "Good Fairy" was

only a dream.[111] In 1994, four white-clad "elves or nymphs" surrounded the bed of a feverish five-year-old girl, "speaking in song, in a spiritual way."[112] Another NDEr pronounced clinically dead following a brain aneurysm returned to describe "a cave that was filled with light" in which she met a beautiful, telepathic "Grey alien"—short, spindly, bobble-headed, with bulging eyes—"who had a grey body but yet whose body was also made of light."[113]

"Beings of light" or angels feature prominently in NDEs. After her heart stopped during surgery in 1983, 16-year-old Valerie exited a tunnel into "a pure white space" where "an angel appeared; she had such a radiant glow to her beauty to behold." The pair dispassionately watched doctors' attempts to resuscitate Valerie before her guide sent her back to life. While out-of-body another NDEr, Jonathan, saw "glowing people that I can only describe as angels… guiding the hands of the staff they were standing next to" in his high-risk surgery.[114]

"During a near-death experience, these mystical beings may be sensed or heard but not actually seen," Long wrote. Some "described these beings as angels. They usually don't have wings. Rather, they may appear similar to earthly beings, or they may be described as beings of light, without easily definable features." Like all NDE lights, the brightness from these beings is spectacular, yet not uncomfortable to behold. [115]

The umbrella term "beings of light" encompasses deities. As seen in the next chapter, NDEs might feature gods and goddesses from a variety of cultures, but religious figures from Christianity predominate. This is to be expected: it remains the world's largest religion, and Western culture is saturated with Christian iconography.[116]

The Bible regularly employs light imagery when speaking of Jesus Christ, so some experiencers unsurprisingly jump to conclusions. "I didn't ever see a person in this light, but to me the light was a Christ-consciousness, a oneness with all things, a perfect love," an NDEr told Moody. "I think that Jesus meant it literally when he said he was the light of the world."[117] For another survivor, Jesus "was not in a body, but was a being of light in the brightest white, golden light, it did not hurt my eyes."[118]

Jesus can appear more explicitly, as in Sara's 1983 NDE. Following a car crash, she saw "Jesus dressed as the shepherd" in a painterly meadow, accompanied by the Virgin Mary. Sara was telepathically given the choice to stay or leave.[119] Other NDErs may describe the Holy Spirit ("I have never felt as good when in my earthly body. I am convinced that I was in the presence of the Holy Spirit.") or God Itself.[120]

In 2012, cardiac arrest sufferer Edward C. saw beautiful bright light pouring from the clouds "10,000 times brighter than the sun," yet easier to look upon. The light was both pure love and "Jesus Christ himself." Edward prostrated himself before God, begging for forgiveness, then awoke in the hospital. "I saw God!" he immediately exclaimed to the staff.[121]

God is more often sensed than seen. "It felt like God was on my right side and a little behind me," said Catalina after an autoclave exploded in her face in 2015. "It wasn't something that I had to see, but it was that peace that I felt when He is there." Catalina also said "some aspects of [her] life flashed" before her, "just like on a screen."[122]

As with the tunnel experience, don't be dismayed if your life doesn't "flash before your eyes," as "life reviews" only occur in 14%-22% of NDEs.[123] If it

does, you may see only fragments, or a panoramic depiction of your entire life. "I saw every important event that had ever happened in my life, from my first birthday to my first kiss to fights with my parents," said one experiencer. "I saw how selfish I was and how I would give anything to go back and change." Even forgotten memories can appear.[124]

While some believe Swedish theologian Emanuel Swedenborg originated the life review trope, ample analogues can be found from antiquity.[125] Mesopotamians experienced life reviews and judgment by afterlife adjudicators. The Egyptian afterlife tribunal, covered in the next chapter, reads much like a life review, which "regard[s] a lifetime as but an hour."[126] A life's worth of memories compressed into a moment— or *multiple lives'* worth, should NDErs experience reviews of *past* lives—reinforces time's fluidity in the NDE realm.

Finally, you're offered an ultimatum: stay in the afterlife or return to the living. While no one knows exactly what happens should you stay, plenty of testimony details the latter choice. It is frequently a reluctant homecoming, rife with pain and disappointment.

"Again I was in the tunnel, coming back very fast, and at the same time the pain in my body came back," Anitta said. "I had cried, 'No, no,' when I was coming back to consciousness."[127] Like Anitta, many other survivors lament this embodied return to our physical world, full of pain, suffering, and Monday mornings.

A final word of warning: not all NDEs are positive. As an amendment to *Life After Life*, Moody added another destination: "the Realm of Bewildered Spirits… a dark, gloomy, and hostile environment where millions of unhappy

and wicked people who are gray, bewildered, confused, miserable, anguished, dreary, angry and do not seem to communicate much, are confined until they can solve whatever problem they have that appears to be keeping them there."[128]

Unlucky souls landing in this hell describe absolute darkness, "screams, shrieks, heartrending, dreadful, terrible laughter," terrible odors, and incomprehensible pain inflicted by a variety of hideous beasts. One NDEr endured "all kinds of ghastly looking and terrifying creatures, some worse than others, who were snatching at me."[129] Another cowered in a dank dungeon while "a pack of fiends, monsters" gnashed behind a rotting door —"all I ever saw of them was a glimpse of claws, teeth, and fur."[130] "Misshapen dwarfs" with "huge parakeet-like beaks" terrorized another NDEr in "a dark and frightening place," nipping flesh from her legs.[131]

The most infamous "Bad NDE" comes from self-identified "selfish and cruel" former atheist Howard Storm. While on a field trip to Paris in 1985, the art professor experienced an agonizing duodenal perforation and raced to the hospital. Unable to receive treatment until that evening, Storm was drawn out of his body. At once he heard voices urgently beckoning from the hallway. [132]

"We are here to take care of you," they called. "We will fix you up. Come with us." A thick haze filled the corridor, shrouding silhouettes Storm could barely discern. As he followed them "for miles," the shapes multiplied, becoming increasingly antagonistic, only relenting when other voices hissed, "Shh, he can hear you."

Eventually, darkness enveloped the hallway, and "a wild orgy of frenzied taunting, screaming and hitting ensued," Storm wrote. "My pain became their pleasure. They seemed to want to make me hurt by clawing at me and biting me." Storm felt the entities were human, albeit "the worst imaginable [people] stripped of every impulse to do good… I was being taken apart and eaten alive, slowly…."

Finally a voice commanded, "Pray to God." Storm seized upon the opportunity while his assailants denied God's existence, berating him as he struggled to recall snippets of prayers and Sunday School songs. "When I did that, I saw, off in the darkness somewhere, the tiniest little star," he recalled. The light approached rapidly, wrapping Storm in indescribable love, familiarity, and protection.

A presence later attributed to Jesus comforted Storm and "called out in a musical tone," summoning several "luminous entities" whose beauty manifested "colors that I had never seen before." "For what seemed like a very long time," Storm and the beings conversed telepathically, until they presented his life review, highlighting his character defects and emphasizing their love for him. They also disclosed what the future might hold for the United States and the rest of the world: a crisis of scarcity, fueled by greed.

At last, Storm returned to his body, pain flooding back in. But with the pain, so came compassion: "I felt this overwhelming sense of love for everyone."[133]

Awakening

Life only gets stranger following your NDE.

After his experience, Storm was visited by a "doctor" whose presence illuminated the room—staff saw no one—and he continued to hear voices, one of which poorly advised him to return home against doctors' orders. Storm's demons were not finished with him: in an unsettling coda, he wound up fighting double pneumonia with a collapsed lung, extreme peritonitis, and hepatitis, only fully recovering after seven months. He was eventually ordained a pastor of the United Church of Christ.[134]

In mythologies embracing reincarnation, the dead must forget their past lives if they wish to move forward. To facilitate this, an amnesia-inducing liquid is offered: in Chinese mythology, those crossing the Bridge of Forgetfulness take the Broth of Oblivion,[135] for the ancient Greeks this was *lethe*, "either a plain of the underworld over which souls passed or a spring from which they drank, so casting off all memory of mortal life."[136] Only privileged individuals destined to become supernatural oracles and seers, like Tiresias or Amphiaraus, were allowed to abstain from drinking and retain their memories of death.[137]

If myths hold any truth, it is apparent why NDErs return with enhanced abilities: *they remember*. While most aftereffects nest within the broader context of psi or psychic phenomena, your newfound changes may manifest as entity contact, higher IQ, or increased synchronicities.[138] When near-NDEs

are genuine— those experiences generated by the mere threat of death— they produce similar aftereffects.[139]

These are all in addition to the special knowledge obtained during your NDE, details which corroborate its reality. As discussed earlier, NDErs view inaccessible locations while dead, encounter the newly deceased before anyone else, and meet previously-unknown relatives. Around 20% receive impressions of the future which may carry into their post-NDE life. These are not always accurate—one NDEr put her success rate around 75% for her family, "while everything else was 60% accurate."[140]

In addition to precognition, you may experience an additional "enhanced intuitive sensitivity" van Lommel identified in 84-92% of survivors: clairvoyance, telepathy, precognition, *déjà vu*, heightened intuition, dream awareness, OBEs, spirit contact, healing abilities, perception of auras, and generalized psychic phenomena.

One experiencer described the ability to "see who was in the room next door, and I knew what food the priest had ordered... sometimes I can literally read and intuit people's minds."[141] Another informed Long she accurately predicted the death of her spouse's business associate: "When my husband got the phone call and the man told him who had died, my husband remarked that he already knew about it," informed by his wife.[142] A pediatric NDEr named Pat spontaneously urged his mother into prayer around 8:55 p.m. one evening; they later learned his father and brother had lost traction in their truck and flipped backwards, nearly killing them "about five minutes to nine o'clock."[143] NDE literature is replete with thousands of similar tales, verified by third-parties.

When Moody revised his list of common NDE elements in 1977, he added several other claims, including "supernatural rescues," such as "having tumors disappear or a 'physical,' detached hand that suddenly appears from out of nowhere to pull the person to safety" before accidents.[144] In *Evidence of the Afterlife*, Long interviewed Anita, whose Stage 4 Hodgkin's lymphoma completely disappeared after her NDE, and Geralyn, whose Burkitt lymphoma disappeared after one chemotherapy session on the heels of dying during surgery and meeting three angels.

"Time and again the people who write these case studies use words like *miracle* or *I was healed*," he wrote. Long also cited a case from Penny Sartori, where an NDE during bowel cancer surgery left a cerebral palsy sufferer able to use one of his hands for the first time in his life.[145] Not only are NDErs healed, they become healers themselves: doctors, counselors, ministers, even possessed of miraculous healing abilities. According to Atwater, Margaret Fields Kean, a "hands-on healer," "successfully facilitated her own healing, and later that of thousands of others," following her NDE.[146]

You may need to invest in some lightbulbs after your NDE. Survivors commonly break wrist watches, lamps, dishwashers, etc. simply by their close proximity, especially during emotional moments. "Lights go out, the computer crashes, the car starter fails, or the supermarket checkout scanner refuses service," van Lommel writes.[147] Adjust your budget accordingly. The recurring ghost story trope of clocks stopping at the time of owners' deaths may also originate in this phenomenon.[148]

Speaking of ghosts, some uninvited guests may have moved into your home. Being brought so close to the veil, NDErs interact more easily with

what are perceived as spirits of the dead. After a vivid NDE at age 13, a girl named Lynn started seeing "people who had died in the hospital," talking to them with such frequency that the interactions became rather commonplace.[149] Equally often, post-NDE hauntings resemble poltergeist activity—but they may come from your own mind.

Cherylee Black, whose abilities have been studied at great length in laboratory settings, survived three NDEs, emerging from the second with recurrent spontaneous psychokinesis (RSPK)—poltergeist phenomena. In one instance, a book levitated and shot across the classroom after a teacher slapped Black for not paying attention (it was a different time!). Her proclivity for manifesting RSPK is so strong that late neuroscience researcher Michael Persinger dubbed it "the Ms. Black Effect." Black also experiences auditory and visual phenomena in the form of tapping noises, anomalous lights, and "luminous discharges" from her left hand.[150]

(As the paranormal-UFO-NDE connection reveals itself, a causal "chicken-or-the-egg?" debate arises: which comes first? While UFO and spirit contact follow many NDEs, the inverse also appears in the databases of organizations like NDERF and FREE, where survivors report visions of ghosts and flying saucers long *before* their brushes with death. These are explored in Chapter 11.)

If you push through post-NDE symptoms like depression and suicidal tendencies—battling feelings of shame, ridicule from others, doubt in your sanity, strained relationships, and unworthiness for being "rejected" from the afterlife—these factors upwell a profound spiritual awakening. During their experiences, many survivors claim "a sense of knowing special knowledge,

universal order, and purpose," understanding more about themselves and others.[151]

Not only will you no longer fear death, but you'll experience a "broadening and deepening" of every aspect of life. In addition to altered lifestyle trajectories like new occupations, Atwater found "the experiencer's energy accelerates, a sense of newness permeates everyday routines, possessiveness fades, long-term gratification often replaces a need for short-term pleasure," and "simple joys outweigh the desire for quick 'highs' or fantasy escapes."[152]

The near-death experience manifests an age-old archetype: death and rebirth. By skirting death's threshold, NDE survivors reenact a recurring narrative from world religions, becoming part of a timeless continuum in which dismembered Osiris was reconstituted into life, hanged Odin descended the World Tree from the brink of death, and crucified Christ emerged from the tomb resurrected.

They "die to death," returning from the ecology of souls with the spark of divinity.

Dissociation and out-of-body experiences

"About 10 % of the general population and perhaps up to 25% of children and adolescents have had a spontaneous sensation of being outside the body, usually on the threshold between waking and sleeping," van Lommel wrote. These out-of-body-experiences, or OBEs, are not only an integral component of NDEs, but also manifest as one of the most common aftereffects among survivors. NDErs are prone to "frequent spontaneous out-of-body experiences" while both waking and sleeping. This talent is especially prevalent among childhood NDE survivors.[153]

Also referred to as astral travel, bilocation, autoscopy, discorporation, ecsomatic experience, or the separation of the soul, the OBE state allows individuals to perceive their body from a third-person vantage point distinctly different from waking life, typically floating above themselves. In the most dramatic examples, "people perceive their consciousness to be escaping from their body, which is then observed as a lifeless object," wrote Lewis. "Usually a mist or ball of light or ethereal body seems to surround the escaping consciousness and to be attached to it by a silvery or white cord."[154]

OBEs correspond to ancient teachings where the soul—or, as discussed in Chapter 3, an *aspect* of the soul, like the double—can detach from our bodies and wander. Former Sorbonne Professor Claude Lecouteux writes that medieval OBEs

> …meant a state of *ecstasy* (from the Greek *ἐκ*, "on the outside," + *ἵστημι*, "to stand, to be outside oneself"), in other words, an exit of the soul from the body (*raptus extra corpus*), and, simultaneously, a state of revelation. The soul of the visionary is carried away by a bird… or by an angel or archangel….[155]

Modern OBEs typically occur during altered states of consciousness—sleep, hypnosis, trance, pharmaceutical influence, illness, pain, and the ultimate altered state, death. Death notwithstanding, these conditions exhibit a high likelihood for *dissociation*, a psychological concept which at its mildest presents emotional detachment from traumatic situations as a "defensive reaction to stress."[156] More extreme dissociative states include perceived *physical* detachment, wherein the self is observed from the outside. This is why psychological explanations for NDEs are more satisfying than medical excuses, as most posit a dissociative component.

Dissociative personalities are sometimes described as "fantasy prone." This diagnosis may be correct or, as alluded to throughout spiritual tradition, these individuals may simply dissociate from *this* reality into association with *another* reality. Dissociation's power to dislodge consciousness rendered it a powerful tool among indigenous cultures. Shamans from various traditions begin their vocation after supernatural forces "select" them via illness, or through rigorous initiation rites bringing them literally and symbolically to the brink of death. Once dissociation is forced upon them as a survival mechanism, lapses into this state become easier, allowing future communication with the Otherworld (altered states of consciousness and shamanism are explored in Chapters 6 and 7).[157]

These theories reveal a dark trend. "Sexual abuse and the threat of physical or mental abuse, which may trigger an out-of-body episode as a protection from pain and humiliation (so-called dissociation), are much more common among children than previously assumed," van Lommel wrote.[158] His statement is congruent with Ring, who found higher incidence of child abuse not only among NDErs, but also self-proclaimed alien abductees.[159] Looking to faerie folklore, we find additional correlation in the terrifying abuse of *changelings*, suspected faerie imposters of human children, a topic covered in Chapter 5. NDE researcher Suzanne Gordon calls this "the trauma of enlightenment."[160]

This isn't to claim abuse is a prerequisite for supernatural encounters; any trauma or stress may suffice, and plenty of experiencers *don't* remember abuse or trauma. Ring outlined three primary criteria as childhood antecedents: "native sensitivity to alternate realities, abuse and trauma, and cultivation of imaginative potential." The mediating psychological processes of dissociation and absorption (concentrated focus) are initiated by stimuli (NDEs, anomalous encounters) resulting in altered states of consciousness perceived as NDEs or alien abductions.[161] Evidence suggests dissociative skills result in encounter-prone lives—just like dissociation from NDEs causes documented aftereffects.

Some claim to induce OBEs at will, a tradition precedented in spiritual literature describing shamans, witches, seers, yogis, Christian saints, and magical practitioners alike. An entire subculture dedicated to cultivating this ability has arisen, greatly influenced by the work of Robert Monroe, whose writings come recommended, since they can only be cursorily covered here. Monroe Institute aficionados claim to reliably leave their bodies at will,

typically during sleep assisted by auditory stimuli called "binaural beats," slightly out-of-sync frequencies separated into each ear.[162]

Self-induced Otherworld journeys look much like traumaless NDEs. Following a "vibrating" or mild shocking sensation, voluntary OBErs hear a buzz, hum, or roar and feel their consciousness fall or levitate from their body to a new vantage point where they observe their surroundings, including themselves. Depending on their skill level, they are whisked to a new destination or select where they want their consciousness to travel, perhaps via the "tunnel experience." The destination may be in our reality or the Otherworld, populated by the living or the dead. As in NDEs, these experiences are often verified by third parties, who might even see a phantasm of the astral traveler. They also feature time compression and expansion—wrote Monroe after one OBE, "I had left what seemed a few minutes before. Lapsed time: one hour, five minutes!"[163]

The beings OBErs encounter can be non-human. In interviews with Fortean researcher Brent Raynes, Shirley Fickett of Portland, Maine revealed interactions with "a non-human being about four feet tall, with a coconut-shaped head, two slits for eyes, a tiny slit where the nose should be, and no visible mouth" during her 1969 astral projections.[164] Another "hideous monster" encountered during a 1930s OBE by English author and occultist Oliver Fox frightened him terribly: "a vague, white, filmy, formless thing… It had two enormous round eyes, like globes filled with pale blue fire, each about six or seven inches in diameter." Fox looked away and willed the creature out of existence.[165] Such tales blur the line between alien abductions and OBEs—do we arbitrarily split one single phenomenon into separate categories?

OBEs also exhibit High Strangeness. While out-of-body, Monroe once beheld an enormous flying saucer which shrank as he approached, revealing its pilot: a "replica, projection, hologram—whatever it was"—of film star W.C. Fields. The being claimed the impersonation "helped it think like a human" (given Monroe was a fan of Fields in his youth, we might see this as another manifestation of Co-Creation Theory).[166]

OBErs may be called upon to interact with the dying. In one heartbreaking incident, Monroe left his body and reached the room of a bedridden ten or eleven-year-old boy, lonely, afraid, and ill. He communicated comforting feelings to the child, promising to return. Several weeks later, Monroe met the now-discarnate boy again.

The boy was "bewildered, but not afraid," and asked Monroe, "What do I do now? Where do I go?" At a loss, Monroe hugged the child, instructing him to wait for friends to arrive and provide further instructions.

"The next day the newspaper carried the story of the death of a ten-year-old boy after a lingering illness," Monroe wrote. "He had died in the afternoon, shortly before I had begun the experiment."[167]

Monroe had unwittingly fulfilled a role described in mythology worldwide. He had become a psychopomp.

2

PSYCHOPOMPS


OBJ

Dying in the modern West is inelegant. What should be a courageous marathon victory is reduced to a pitiful limp across the finish line.

"A number of historical events created an atmosphere where death became such a taboo in the mid-twentieth century that even 'terminally ill' patients were not told they were dying," writes psychopomp scholar Laura Strong. "The accompanying shift towards prolonging life at all costs created new fears and anxieties, and now leaves many underprepared to face their final journey."[168]

Once upon a time, we were preoccupied with dying well. Numerous traditions—the Eleusinian Mysteries of ancient Greece, the

Egyptian Book of the Dead, the medieval *Ars Moriendi*—not only prepared us for the transitional voyage, but provided clear instructions to navigate its perils: how to traverse paths, cross rivers, thwart demons, or endure trials in the Otherworld. That so many souls appear lost (ghosts) suggests most are ill-prepared.

The *Bardo Thödol* explicitly guides readers through the afterlife, encouraging the dying to remain as lucid as possible when entering the Bardo between death and rebirth. Within this realm the dead realize their fate over several days before experiencing "the primary 'clear light' at the death moment"; those enlightened see it and ascend, all others drop to a lower level, experiencing visions created by their *karma*, the good and bad deeds of life. They must confront both "peaceful" and "wrathful" beings, human emotions incarnate, if they wish to move toward *nirvana*, liberation from reincarnation.[169]

According to Shushan, the *Bardo Thödol* "so closely corresponds to the [near-death experience] that it can effectively be seen as verification that the book genuinely *is* what it purports to be—a preparation for what happens at death (regardless of whether the dying experience is neurophysiological or spiritual)."[170] Jung would agree, having written that "every serious-minded reader must ask himself whether these wise old lamas might not, after all, have caught a glimpse of the fourth dimension and twitched the veil from the greatest of life's secrets."[171]

Contemporary religions generally present afterlife transitions as automatic. Ancient traditions, however, describe guiding figures, *psychopomps,* who incorporate humans into the ecology of souls. (Greek *psyche*, "soul," and *pompos*, "guide"—some contend the proper plural is *psychopompoi.*) These may be humans, animals, or deities—in the *Bardo Thödol*, a living lama fulfills this role, guiding the recently deceased by reciting ritual texts.

Psychopomps are complex. All lead, warn, comfort, and advise the dying. Typically neutral, they are not death itself, but may symbolize it, as well as rebirth; they are not solely death omens, but when seen by the living, might portend death. All psychopomps are death deities, but not all death deities are psychopomps. Psychopomps display healing abilities—even when not explicitly described, these cosmic gatekeepers are vested with the power to reject the dying, making them *de facto* resurrectors.

Psychopomps are NDE fixtures, manifesting both in traditional and less conventional forms and as sensed "presences," beings of light, and departed loved ones. Since NDEs so closely resemble other supernatural experiences, it begs the question to which this book returns: are aliens, faeries, cryptids, etc. actually psychopomps?

As managers of death's threshold, psychopomps are definitionally *liminal*. Liminality is the state of "betwixt and between," and arises

consistently throughout paranormal phenomena: the forest edge is dangerous, the devil appears at crossroads, trolls dwell under bridges, pixies appear at twilight, faeries steal children after birth but before baptism, Bigfoot is half-man-half-ape, ghosts and NDErs straddle the worlds of the living and the dead, OBEs occur between sleep and waking, UFOs hover between Heaven and Earth. The death-birth transition is the most liminal moment conceivable.[172] Because liminality is also a hallmark of The Trickster, many psychopomps fulfill dual mythological roles.

"In order for these psychopomps to achieve what so many others cannot, they must often make use of various trickster methods," Strong writes. "Throughout the stories of ancient Greece, Hermes can be found helping others by using such trickster tactics as deceiving nymphs, charming monsters, inducing hallucinations in others, and taking on numerous different guises."[173] According to Kowalewski, a practicing shaman himself, well-intentioned trickery sometimes provides stubborn souls motivation to transition.[174]

As liminal deities, psychopomps serve functions outside of death, acting in tutelary roles as "ushers, guides, travel companions, healers, and mentors" through major life events.[175] They change destinies and cultures, leading their wards to divine revelation.[176]

"Hermes as Psychopomp—Leader of Soul—keeps us moving in our lives, helps us get unstuck psychologically, and we follow him whenever our thoughts and actions and dreams draw us close to death," wrote University of Dallas psychology professor Robert Kugelmann.[177]

Psychopomps navigate "the border between the known and unknown aspects of ourselves."[178] This is how Jung used the term, describing mediators between our conscious (reality) and unconscious (underworld). In one Jungian's words, Hermes became "the patron" of psychology itself.[179]

A staggering number of psychopomps exist throughout religion and culture. We can comprehensively, if not exhaustively, examine them in five categories: animals, humans, deities, folk figures, and natural phenomena. Together, they provide a rich symbol set for filtering all numinous encounters; studied Forteans will perceive immediate connections. If at first our in-depth analysis appears tedious or indulgent, consider it preparation for our remaining discussion—we return to these figures time-and-time again, and unpacking the meaning behind psychopomp symbols here, rather than in every following chapter, establishes valuable shorthand for the future.

Animals

Animals are common psychopomps, appearing after death both as individuals (e.g. *a* deer) and archetypes (*the* deer spirit). The reasons behind this are obvious. To this day, some believe animals sense spirits. Nocturnal animals' ability to navigate darkness made them excellent underworld guides, like bats to the Peruvian Mochica.[180] Other animals are revered for their resiliency. Turtles' durability, longevity, and tenacity earned psychopomp roles worldwide, evidenced by archaeological digs in southern Mexico[181] and Turkey.[182] Chelonians also appear in Christian cemetery iconography.[183]

In December 2005, Eva experienced complications from an ectopic pregnancy, dying on the operating table. She awoke in her deceased grandmother's garden with Jesus Christ, her grandmother, and "two deer waiting for us." They were "kind and supportive." Eva's grandmother offered to watch over her unborn daughter, and she returned to consciousness after a week in the intensive care unit.[184]

Deer mediate between the natural and supernatural worlds in mythologies worldwide. Celtic and German stags were soul guides associated with *Odin*, a psychopomp in his own right,[185] and

Eurasian funeral rites bestow the dead with flying reindeer.[186] Like turtles, stags were absorbed into Christian iconography, sometimes as avatars of Christ himself,[187] their antlers symbolizing the tree of life.[188]

"Telling the bees," a charming custom of the British Isles, once urged keepers to inform hives of any new developments in the community, particularly deaths. "If this were neglected, it was thought that another death would soon follow the previous one," wrote Elias Owen in *Welsh Folk-Lore*. "Instead of speaking to the bees, it was the custom, in some parts of Wales, to turn the bee-hive round before starting the funeral. This was always done by the representative of the family, and it also was thought to be a protection against death."[189]

For various ancient cultures, bees symbolized immortality,[190] and ghosts might appear as swarms of bees.[191] Bees were psychopomps in ancient Aegean belief.[192] Their erratic flight paths embodied wandering souls to Teutons, to Christians their emergence after hibernation resembled resurrection.[193] Honey is also a natural preservative, warding off the effects of decay.

Bees find Trickster associations in the bee maidens, or *Thriae,* nymphs given to Apollo by Hermes. Though prophetic, these bee-

bodied women would also "sometimes lie and sometimes tell the truth," lending a Tricksterish aspect.[194]

It is unclear whether buzzing sounds during NDEs influenced the bee-death association. After a horrific automobile accident in 1995, one experiencer beheld a bright light and heard a disembodied presence say, "I'm here. You are going to be okay. It's okay to close your eyes and rest. I will be with you." Immediately prior to awakening in hospital five days later, she met a loving female being who provided a life review and a choice: stay, or return to have a child and carry out "a special duty."[195]

"She told me that I needed a lot of work and that her bees would need to heal me before I could wake and start to heal on the outside," the NDEr related. As she laid down, "thousands of bees swarmed" her, entering and exiting her body in "a fury" of movement. "I still to this day get phantom sensations from the bees buzzing and the feelings I had of them entering and exiting my body. They did so through my ear, nose, and throat, physically, and swarmed consistently all around my entire body."[196]

Domesticated animals love and serve loyally, assisting and guiding us. Llamas (Mochica),[197] cows (Indian),[198] bulls (Montoise),[199] sheep (Himalayan),[200] and camels (Arabian)[201] escort the dead to varying degrees in mythology. However, two domesticated mammals qualify

as psychopomps *par excellence*: dogs and horses. Their universality in this respect cannot be overemphasized.

"The shaman encounters the funerary dog in the course of his descent to the underworld," wrote historian Mircea Eliade in his pivotal *Shamanism: Archaic Techniques of Ecstasy*. By contrast, the horse offers otherworldly conveyance. "The horse carries the deceased into the beyond; it produces the 'break-through in plane,' the passage from this world to other worlds."[202]

Dogs' association with death is prehistoric. Before their domestication circa 20,000-40,000 years ago, canids consumed human bodies abandoned in the wilderness.[203] Wolves, coyotes, foxes, and jackals (Tricksters all) both hunt and scavenge.

"It seems likely that one of the earliest, primeval, barbaric images of death that we encounter is… a greedy, corpse-devouring wolf or carrion-eating dog," wrote German psychotherapist Edgar Herzog. "From the [Zoroastrian] *Avesta* we learn that Iranian dogs often interbred with wolves and that wolves instead of dogs are described as corpse-buriers [disposers]." Free food—both corpses and scraps—incentivized dogs to remain near human settlements, a crucial component in their domestication.[204]

Once tamed, canines displayed characteristics befitting psychopomps, serving us as companions, transporters, trackers,

guides, protectors, and herders. These intimate relationships even evidence telepathic connections. Rupert Sheldrake—whose research strongly suggests dogs "know" when owners will return home, no matter how distant—collected numerous accounts of pets who "seem to sense when their owners have had accidents or have died in distant places. On my database, there are 177 accounts of dogs apparently responding to the death or distress of their human companions, most by howling, whining or whimpering…."[205]

Dog psychopomps appeared among Indo-European cultures as early as the Neolithic period.[206] For Mesoamerican civilizations like the Aztec[207] and Teenek, dog psychopomps helped "the crossing of a body of water that separates the world of the living from that of the dead."[208] In the Indian *Mahabharata,* the hero *Yudhishthira* refuses to leave his dog behind when entering heaven.[209] A fattened dog with a red leash guarded Wuhan's dead on their return to Red Mountain.[210] Who's a good boy, indeed?

To ensure smooth transitions, dogs were buried, even sacrificed, alongside the dead—not solely as "pets," but also as essential grave goods. Amratian Egyptians[211] and Mesoamericans interred their departed with canines or clay dog effigies.[212] Dogs also guard mythic underworlds: the Greek *Cerberus* and Norse *Garm* (*Garmr*) infamously protect the dead, like similar watchdogs from Chinese and Eurasian mythologies.[213]

After entering a white void during her NDE, Abigail heard a genderless voice ask, "Do you want to go forward, or do you want to go back?" Choosing the former, she noticed a dog beside her, sensing "others close behind." It guided her to an archway flanked by two smaller entrances, where more dogs waited. "I tried to walk through [the smaller gate] with the dog and the other dogs telepathically told me that I needed to go in the larger gate," Abigail wrote. Entering the larger portal, she found herself awash with love, staring down a hallway terminating in light.[214]

"A guide or [someone] important to my life" awaited her. After a brief conversation the guide implored Abigail to return, but not before climbing a grassy hill to appreciate a perpetual sunset above a lake. She then returned to her body. Following Abigail's recovery, a coworker confessed she had accidentally killed a dog with her car earlier that week—its description matched her NDE guide.[215] It seems that dogs' limitless compassion truly knows no bounds.

Yet these positive stories belie supernatural canines' fearsome aspect in folklore. Uncannily large, red-eyed black dogs (hell hounds) remain death omens in many cultures. A Corsican dog barking twice predicts a woman's death, thrice a man's.[216] Black dogs typically augur doom in western European folklore, where they are closely associated with the devil and faeries (Chapter 5). In one German

legend, an elderly Schladern man watched a big black dog trotting ahead of him transform "into a black coffin—then the earth opened and swallowed it up."[217]

If dogs guard, horses transport, a variation on ships/boats/ferries carrying the deceased to the afterlife. "The horse is another animal that is endowed with the magical ability to guide humans to the hereafter," writes Strong. "Throughout the world, humans have long held a great respect for these noble and intelligent beings, which offer swift passage for the living and the dead."[218] Shamans worldwide symbolically mounted horses to reach the other side, using horse hides, hobby horses, and even equine sacrifice in their ecstatic trances.[219]

Horse worship arose in Eurasia at least as early as the Bronze Age, enduring today in some south Asian cultures. *Valaha*, Indian horse-lord, emerges from the sea to carry souls, blending dragon and water-spirit motifs.[220] Like dogs, horses were buried alongside the dead, particularly kings, queens, and shamans, solidifying a recurring motif of horses, royalty, and the sun—itself a psychopomp symbol for its continual death and rebirth. Many Indo-European cultures conceptualized the sun as a horse-drawn vehicle crossing the sky, including the Norse, whose *Skinfaxi* pulls *Dagr*'s (Day's) chariot above the Earth daily.[221]

"Among the Indo-European populations the horse had an essentially solar symbolism, together with a psychopomp character, being an animal associated to the Otherworld and the divine sphere," Fernando Augusto Coimbra wrote. "Furthermore, the horse was considered to be an animal of divine origin, always related to the aristocratic sphere, aspects that are deeply connected with its mythical and ritual background…."[222]

Following a severe car crash in 2007, a Texas man met his "paternal grandfather in heaven. He was on horseback and saddled another horse." The steed was "solid white… a beautiful beast." Though his grandfather remained silent, the NDEr knew the other horse was meant for him. He declined the offer, then emerged from his coma.[223]

Like dogs, horses hide a darker side. 15th century *necromancers* (magicians communing with the dead) conjured demons and spirits disguised as horses for Otherworld excursions,[224] and horse dreams presaged death for 13th century Icelanders. The stare of hearse-hitched horses doomed eastern Prussians, as did the low-hanging head of any steed bearing a priest in Estonia.[225]

Finally, we come to another potent symbol, the bird. As addressed later, these animals are associated with human souls, faeries, even UFOs—our current concern is their universal role as psychopomp. As

"messengers from the realms," birds are liminal, lending their wings to other psychopomps like angels and Valkyries. [226] Representations of doves are replete in Christian symbolism, but birds' origins as afterlife guides dates inconceivably earlier.

Vultures, buzzards, ravens, and crows were corpse-devourers like dogs, carrying the dead into the Great Beyond. Indeed, some cultures still practice "sky burials," leaving bodies exposed to the elements and scavenging birds. Vultures were depicted as psychopomps at least 12,000 years ago at Turkey's Göbekli Tepe.[227] Corvids probably appeared even earlier across Native American spiritualities, doubling as Tricksters.[228] Greek *harpies*—winged women—were an early form of death-demon.[229] Eagles,[230] swans,[231] cranes, doves,[232] practically any bird has appeared as a psychopomp. The fable of storks carrying newborns to their parents likely arises from their reputation as water-bearers to-and-from the Well of Souls.[233]

While not renowned for flight, roosters enjoyed psychopomp status in early Christian[234] and Hmong culture, strengthened by their solar association, announcing the sun's daily rebirth.[235] The Yoruba kill their fowl upon hearing about a death in the village, "in order that its spirit may guide the soul to heaven."[236] The NDE research of Peter Fenwick is littered with " birds who come into the room of the

dying, are seen on their windowsills, or collect in large groups around the hospice at the time the person is dying."[237]

Shamanic birds are archetypes of *transformation* rather than *transportation*. By obtaining wings, shamans easily fly into the afterlife to assist the dead, and bird talons became symbolic tools for snatching souls—recall Lecouteux's medieval description of OBEs as souls stolen by birds, *raptus in spiritu*.[238] In Yakut mythology of northeastern Eurasia, Eagle created "the first shaman."[239] Birds appear in numerous burial rites, exemplified by the thousands of mummified ibises recovered from Egyptian tombs.[240]

NDErs repeatedly compare their soul's flight to that of birds. Others describe actual avians. For instance, a car crash victim detected sinister figures in his peripheral vision while "a gray-blue, translucent raven" circled overhead. "The Raven landed on my arm, and gave off a loud caw, which seemed to chase the beasts off," he wrote. "I woke up in a hospital bed."[241]

All birds are harbingers of death, particularly if found inside or swarming near homes. Swallows, jackdaws, blackbirds,[242] kingfishers,[243] crows, ravens, cuckoos, magpies, ravens, and roosters[244] were ill-omened from Iceland to Borneo. Sometimes "death birds" are unidentifiable; whenever a Bishop of Salisbury lies

dying, "large white birds like albatrosses, with dazzling white wings which do not move as they fly" soar above Salisbury Plain.[245]

The Welsh *deryn corph*, or corpse bird, "came flapping its wings against the window of the room in which lay a sick person, and this visit was considered a certain omen of that person's death," wrote Owen. "The bird not only fluttered about the lighted window, but also made a screeching noise whilst there, and also as it flew away."[246] In other tellings the bird squeaks: "Come, come!"[247] The corpse bird was sometimes identified as a tawny or screech owl.

Owls are perfectly equipped to navigate the underworld's darkness, and their association with death deities in the Old World stretches into the Neolithic. Equally old, the Ojibwe afterlife was reached via "the owl bridge," their dead buried with owl feathers to facilitate passage.[248] Owls were Hopi and Mayan gods of death, the latter of whom, *Ah Puch*, incorporated dog symbolism as well.[249]

Owls were also sinister creatures, disguised spirits, demons, or vampires.[250] They are death omens from Africa to Eurasia.[251] "In China, the owl is called the bird who snatches away souls," wrote author and UFO experiencer Mike Clelland. "In Hungary, the owl is called the bird of death." Clelland is the world's foremost collector of spiritual owl sightings, and his book *The Messengers: Owls, Synchronicity and the UFO Abductee* is essential reading.

Owls presaged the deaths of Augustus, Commodus, Agrippa, and Julius Caesar,[252] and some families like the Irish Westropps, Wardour Arundels, and Nottingham Cliftons retain owls as death omens for their clans.[253] According to Lecouteux, in Austria "the mere presence of the owl is dreaded, for it is a herald of death"; in France, screech owls bring death to any home they land upon; in Germany, "if a tawny owl hoots close to a house, one of the people living there will soon die."[254] The obligatory hooting that filmmakers include when establishing a frightening forest scene makes much more sense in this context.

Dogs, horses, and birds—*particularly* owls— reappear in paranormal encounters more than any other animal psychopomps. These connections are examined in later chapters.

Humans

Therianthropes—humans either fully rendered animal, or possessed of animal attributes—combine the psychopomp potency of wildlife with human intelligence. Therianthropes from the Egyptian pantheon are familiar, but the archetype is truly universal and ancient, first appearing in Upper Paleolithic cave art. A 44,000 year-old example from Sulawesi depicts hunters with bird and reptile tails, beaks, and snouts.[255]

"In Europe, scholars have long been interested in the oldest known images of therianthropes in prehistoric art, because they are generally accepted to represent the earliest evidence for our ability to conceive of abstract entities that do not exist in the natural world," said Griffith University archaeologist Adam Brumm. "Depictions of therianthropes are also seen as an indication of early spirituality or religious-like thinking."[256]

Shapeshifting "is a favorite technique of tricksters and psychopomps alike," Strong writes. It was also recent superstition in the West that ghosts assumed the form of anything they pleased, animal or vegetable (as could our own souls, elaborated in the next chapter).[257] Ergo, any animal or therianthrope seen at death

represents an animal psychopomp, the self, a dead soul, or a shaman.

Attempted suicide by overdose in December 2020 sent Georgie into a vividly green forest infused with "a light clearly of mystical or other-worldly origin." She heard a voice—a friend's—urging her to enter the woods. Georgie hesitated. "The voice changed to a deep man's voice telling me I wasn't ready," she wrote. She returned to her body, "vomiting everything out of my system." Notably, the friend Georgie heard identifies as a shaman.[258]

Mentioned in passing, shamanism here deserves greater elaboration. While overused, the term is useful when describing indigenous techniques for interfacing with the Otherworld. Shamanic cultures fully recognize the ecology of souls, negotiating between our reality and the spirit world through human intercessors—shamans, witch doctors, medicine men, etc. This is usually facilitated via altered states of consciousness. As intermediaries between worlds, shamans are also liminal.

Shamanism, whose complexities are covered in Chapter 7, also has a strong psychopomp component. From M.N. Walter and E.J.N. Fridman's shamanism encyclopedia:

> The shaman escorts the souls of the dead to protect the living as well as to aid the deceased. Due to the common belief that newly dead souls can haunt the living and cause all manner of trouble, the shaman's ability to safely remove the departed person's spirit to the afterlife is essential to societal welfare. In some cultures, professional mourners assist in placating the soul of the recently dead, and other people may play important roles in funeral ceremonies. But it is always a shaman who enters trance, leaves his or her body, and conducts the soul to its last home.[259]

When escorting the deceased, shamans often mimic the soul's Otherworld journey (e.g. if the afterlife is atop a mountain they pantomime climbing, if overseas they sit in a symbolic boat, etc.). This sometimes demands therianthropy. By transforming into birds shamans fly to the Otherworld, perhaps acquiring other useful animal attributes like night vision.[260] Modern mediums, energy workers, and clergy find loose comparison to shamanic psychopomps when cleansing homes of hauntings.[261]

Dead friends and relatives also serve as psychopomps, presenting NDErs with ultimatums to "stay or return." They sometimes even adopt psychopomp iconography: in Wayne Thornton's 1945 NDE he met a "guy with a long robe and a shepherd's long staff with the crook on top." He didn't recognize the figure, but intuited it was "one

of [his] grandfathers." Thornton was telepathically told it "wasn't time yet" because he "had work to do."[262]

More dramatically, in March 1900 a Mrs. C.W. Lee of Danbury, Connecticut saw her father, dead 16 years, enter her home and carry off her mother, whose body was discovered immediately thereafter. Though not an NDE, Lee herself was ill.[263]

Contemporary Western NDEs regularly feature the remembered dead, i.e. those known during experiencers' lives. Looking across space and time, however, we also see ancestor spirits in these threshold encounters. Bad news for people who avoid family reunions.

Following a July 1979 post-partum hemorrhage, Laura visited a "beautiful, white, glistening beach," encountering a godly presence which introduced "hundreds if not thousands of [her] ancestors" bathed in light. "Notice," the presence said, "Your ancestors, all these beings, came together in your behalf, to make you uniquely you. You wanted to go to Earth to learn, to progress, and to contribute to creation. All these spirits came together to help you do that." After a sense of divine unity, Laura returned to normal consciousness.[264]

Speaking monolithically about ancestor traditions is difficult, because beliefs contradict and vary widely, sometimes within

cultures. That being said, offering the deceased love and respect is a universal tenet, as is the belief that our predecessors influence our lives; even monotheistic practitioners and some atheists ask dead loved ones for guiding support. This relationship can manifest as ancestor worship, a spirituality extensively practiced to this day on every inhabited continent. Ancestor veneration may include grave visitations, prayers to the departed, leaving offerings, and other simple interactions.[265]

These benefit both the living and the dead, as the deceased may seek recognition from relatives before fully transitioning to the afterlife. For instance, Tanzania's Luguru offer sacrifices at ancestor shrines after misfortunes or when seeking blessings. Vedic Hindu ancestors only successfully enter and remain in the afterlife through their descendants' consistent, proper ritual performance, rendering the living *de facto* psychopomps.[266] These practices may be daily disciplines or annual occurrences.

"Pre-Christian Irish/Celtic and Norse cultures both have established traditions of ancestor reverence," writes ancestral specialist Daniel Foor. "Halloween can be traced back to an older Celtic holiday called *Samhain*, brought to North America by Irish and Scottish immigrants. This traditional holiday was incorporated into the Catholic calendar as All Hallows' Eve in the ninth century, and it is still celebrated by modern Pagans and Christians alike as a time to

remember, feast, and perhaps communicate directly with the ancestors."[267]

Foor divides lineages into eight categories: the unborn, living descendants, the self, living elders, remembered dead, the lineage between ancestral guides and remembered dead, ancestral guides, and collective human ancestors (200,000 BC onward). All strata appear in NDEs.[268]

Not all dead become ancestors. In many African religions, "those dying of epilepsy, leprosy, and lunacy cannot be considered candidates for ancestorhood."[269] Because cultures practicing ancestor veneration are often animist—attributing souls to all things—ancestors may include (and transmigrate into) animals, plants, and inanimate objects like rocks.[270] Ancestors can include or evolve into folk heroes and heroines,[271] gods and demigods, and nature spirits (for more on this last connection, see Chapter 4).[272] Ancestors of significant time-depth may associate with unrelated bloodlines, even transcending race.[273] Such malleability is apparent in writings of the Han Dynasty, where Tung Chung-shu argued adopted children could carry a new family's ancestral rites.[274] The primary constant between all ancestor spirits remain their direct, personal connection to the living.

While generally benevolent and protective, ancestors can be angered if ignored. In Indonesia, "if the living neglect their duties towards the ancestors, the latter will punish them by inflicting all kinds of calamities: illnesses, bad crops, accidents," even among those converted to Christianity and Islam.[275] Disease and bad luck are generally attributed to ghosts (and faeries) worldwide.[276]

Ancestors' psychopomp roles remain consistent across cultures. "For practitioners of the [African] *Ifá/Òrìṣà* tradition, the elevated ancestors themselves may serve as support for the transitioning dead, as do various forces of nature, deities, or *ọ̀rìṣà* (e.g., *Èṣù*, *Ògún*, *Ọya*)," Foor writes.[277] Some Pacific Islanders teach that dead souls reach a tree at a chasm in the Earth, around which loiter the spirits of dead children, who provide directions.[278]

"In most cultures it is believed that ancestor spirits will come to meet the newly deceased and guide that soul through the completion of the death process," wrote shaman scholar Christina Pratt. "When the ancestors do not come or the rituals or funerary traditions are not performed, the soul of the deceased may get lost and wander. If this happens, souls become unable or unwilling to complete their death process unaided. At this point the shaman must be called in to act as the psychopomp."[279]

Ancestors sometimes work in tandem with shamans. "The Bororo in Brazil have a special 'shaman of the souls' who connects the departed soul with ancestor spirits who then conduct it safely through its dangerous journey in the land of the dead," wrote Kowalewski.[280]

Deities

Practically any god, goddess, or folk figure can serve as psychopomp. However, liminal deities are particularly qualified to cross the threshold, often boasting therianthropic qualities from psychopomp animals.

Some of the earliest Old World psychopomps hail from Mesopotamia. The singular god and dualistic emphasis of Zoroastrianism clearly influenced Abrahamic faiths, and it is often cited as the world's oldest monotheistic religion (c. 4,000 years ago).[281] Zoroastrianism's afterlife conception includes the *Chinvat (Činwad*) bridge, over which the dead must cross—in true Co-Creative fashion, the passage narrows or widens according to one's righteousness.[282] This journey may be attended by *Sraoša*, a divine messenger with multiple duties, including that of psychopomp.[283]

Mythologies commonly feature bodies of water as boundaries between the living and the dead, traversed either by watercraft or bridges: the Norse *Gjallarbrú* crossing the *Gjöll*, the Japanese Buddhist *Sanzu*, *Charon*'s ferry crossing the Greek *Styx*, the slippery log bridge to the Choctaw afterlife, the LoDagaa ferry to the land of Ghanaian ancestors, the Golden and Silver Bridges of Chinese

mythology. Traversing astral waters is an old motif: in the Sumerian *Epic of Gilgamesh* (c. 2100 BC), Sursunabu "agrees to ferry Gilgamesh across the world-encompassing ocean and the Waters of Death."[284]

"I was walking on a bridge that was ancient looking with rock and cobblestones," wrote Oscar. It was August 2010, immediately following a violent car accident. He was keenly aware of his surroundings, which otherwise consisted of infinite darkness. The bridge ended in an "old wooden door and a tall male figure standing by it." Behind the door seeped a "beautiful light." Shadowed in his hooded robe, the oddly-familiar being spoke with Oscar—though later he forgot the exchange—before placing his hand upon his shoulder. Oscar awoke in a medical evacuation helicopter.[285]

Zoroastrianism's Chinvat bridge is most often attended by *Daēnā*, who is not a deity *per se* but rather a projection of the self, able to "shapeshift from a beautiful young maiden into a hideous hag, depending on the merits of the soul." Dogs accompany her. Daēnā echoes not only Co-Creation Theory and the *Bardo Thödol*'s personified emotions, but fits nicely into later discussions surrounding multiple souls.

Yezidism isn't a household name, but it challenges Zoroastrianism's title as the world's oldest monotheistic religion, allegedly founded

seven millennia ago.[286] Yezidis believe God entrusted creation to seven angels; the central civilizing Trickster figure, *Malak Tāwūs*, is represented by a peacock. One of his manifestations is "*Nasr ad-din*, a psychopomp and angel of death."[287]

In the ancient Greek pantheon, a host of deities including *Iris* (goddess of the rainbow), *Thanatos* (personification of death), and *Hecate* (goddess of witchcraft, necromancy, and the crossroads, strongly associated with dogs) all might serve as psychopomps to varying degrees.[288] *Persephone*, daughter of *Zeus* and *Demeter*, was famously trapped in the Underworld after *Hades* tricked her into eating a cursed pomegranate seed—in this myth, we see the universal food taboo against consuming food in the land of the dead. Persephone herself took on psychopomp attributes as Queen of the Underworld, surfacing annually, escorted by Hecate and the most famous psychopomp of all: *Hermes*.[289]

Hermes, Son of Zeus and *Maia*; Hermes, Herald and Messenger of the Gods; Hermes, Protector of Travelers; Hermes, God of Commerce; Hermes, Trickster and Psychopomp. Commonly depicted as a male shepherd or traveler with wings on his head and sandals —"the ancient soul-bird symbolism," Eliade notes—Hermes guides the dead to the Underworld, carrying souls as he would messages from Mount Olympus.[290]

Jungian psychologist Mark Bortz writes:

> Hermes guides the human's soul along both sides of the great divide. He accompanies the human soul on its most difficult night-sea journey. Hermes is the god of the way, of the road. His modesty and his connection to the journey mean he needs no temple, only stones at the side of the road. As the gods' messenger, and the guide of the dead, Hermes is a frequent visitor to Hades, but he is also no stranger to Olympus. His comfort with all three realms, Hades, Earth, and Olympus, allows him to be the original psychopomp. Hermes' well-developed logos and eros energy allow him great comfort and skill with both paradox and imagination. The soul is his domain. Still, Hermes has a keen intellect. Even as a new-born baby, he managed to trick the great Apollo and then to cement a friendship between them; both deeds were no meager feat. In spite of, or perhaps because of his trickster energy, he has great honesty and integrity. Hermes is a god comfortable with his own sexuality; no stranger to death; a modest friend to humans; and open to soul, imagination, paradox, and feminine energy.[291]

As Trickster, Hermes specializes in liminality. Among his lesser-known functions is master of contracts and boundaries, lending his name to *herms*, small *cairns* (piles of stacked rocks) on the landscape erected at borders and crossroads which later developed into squared columns topped by carved busts. As master of

thresholds, Hermes *transcends* thresholds, making him "the great trespasser."[292]

In addition to his *talaria*, or winged sandals, Hermes is also associated with psychopomp animals like tortoises, roosters,[293] and obliquely with snakes. They entwine his sleep-inducing *kerykeion* (Latin *caduceus*), or winged staff—the kerykeion possibly references Sumerian underworld deity *Ningishzida*, a serpent therianthrope mediating between mankind and gods, to whom Hermes is compared.[294]

Rome's *Mercury* is Hermes. When appropriated by the Empire, however, Hermes lost his affable character, becoming sinister and, frankly, lazier—a victim of the slow, grinding wheels of bureaucracy (remember, the only two certain things are death and taxes). Unlike Hermes, "Mercury no longer guides the souls of the dead all the way to what is now envisioned as the infernal realm of the dead," writes Strong. "Instead, he delivers them to Charon, who is in charge of seeing them across the border."[295]

Charon, the surly Greco-Roman ferryman, awaits souls at the River Styx, pole in hand. Because Hades requires payment to cross, coins were sometimes inserted in corpses' mouths prior to burial, echoing Japanese Buddhists who inter the dead with six *mon* to pay their passage over the Sanzu River (death and taxes again!).[296] In Virgil's

Aenid, anyone unburied or unable to pay Charon is doomed to roam the shores of the Styx for a century.[297]

After a suicide attempt in 2002, Shawn found herself awash in red: red sky, red earth, and a "beautiful" red river. "There was a ferry and a boatman there," Shawn wrote. "I asked if he would take me across the river." He hesitated before granting the request. Reaching the opposite bank, Shawn visited an inn amidst beautiful gardens. "They wanted different money and I hadn't any such money," she recalled. Shawn briefly met her great-grandmother before returning to normal consciousness.[298]

The boat motif reappears in the self-navigating vessel of Irish sea god *Manannán mac Lir* (Welsh *Manawydan*), master craftsman, weather god, lord of the waves,[299] and—though not historically indicated —psychopomp to modern Irish pagans, based upon his knack for slipping between realities.[300] Like most psychopomps, Manannán is a Trickster and shapeshifter, also possessing a cloak of forgetfulness, a golden apple bough to heal or induce sleep, and *Enbharr*, an ocean-traversing horse.[301]

Other Celtic psychopomps include the Gaulish *Ogmios* (god of eloquence) and *Epona*, equine goddess who leads the dead across the sea to the Otherworld.[302]

"Generally depicted as a woman sitting sidesaddle on a horse, Epona is sometimes shown holding the bread and fruit of her abundance or she may be accompanied by a raven and a dog—representations of her otherworldly connections," writes Strong. "In France, there are cemetery monuments that show Epona on her horse leading what is presumed to be the souls of the dead, and she is 'often shown carrying a large key, which has been interpreted as a symbol of her ability to unlock the gateway to the Otherworld'" (this key echoes Hermes's kerykeion and Manannán's bough)[303] Epona, named after the Indo-European **ekʷos* (horse),[304] was worshipped widely throughout Europe, extending into northern Africa and Rome.[305] Some artifacts associated with Epona feature human-horse therianthropes.[306]

Further north, we find *Valkyries*, winged warrior maidens who pluck dying Norsemen's souls off the battlefield, ushering them into Odin's mountaintop hall of the slain, *Valhalla*. After gathering slain heroes, they return to *Ásgarðr*, the heaven realm, via the rainbow bridge, or Bifrost.[307]

Valkyries' wings evoke bird psychopomps, and even their Anglo-Saxon name, *waelcurge*, closely resembles "raven," *waelceasig*—*wael-* meaning "corpse" or the "slain."[308] Initially depicted as corvid wings, these appendages evolved into swans' wings and, eventually, "magical feathered cloaks" of transport.[309] Valkyries find close

association with shapeshifting swan maidens of Fairy Tales, who themselves appear as psychopomps.[310] Death-dealing winged women recur throughout European mythology; Greece, where sirens and harpies troubled heroes of legend, also produced apparent Valkyrie analogues, *keres*, fulfilling the exact same role, albeit more maliciously.[311]

Warriors not selected for Valhalla may arrive in *Fólkvangr* instead, the afterlife field of *Freya* (*Freyja*). This renders the goddess—otherwise associated with love, beauty, fertility, and war—a psychopomp in her own right. Her "raiment of birds' feathers… suggests that she is somehow connected with a bird of the dead," and indeed Freya is sometimes leader of the Valkyries.[312]

Odin (Wōden, Wûtan), the long-bearded, one-eyed Norse All-Father, is god of many things. As one of the most important deities, he rules wisdom, knowledge, battle, magic, and, like all psychopomps, healing and death. Odin *exudes* psychopomp symbolism. Like Mercury, he is a wanderer, sometimes brandishing a staff. He rules Ásgarðr, accessible only by bridge, overseeing a fallen army of dead men. He rides a flying, eight-legged horse, *Sleipnir,* able to "mediate between earth and sky, between *Ásgarðr*, *Miðgarðr*, and *Útgarðr* and between the world of mortal men and the underworld."[313] He is a shapeshifter, appearing as a ferryman in the poem *Hárbarðsljóð* and in *Volsunga Saga*, literally transporting a

corpse in the latter.[314] He is institutor of Norse necromancy, and is symbolized by the stag.[315] Finally, Odin keeps two wolves (*Geri* and *Freki*, "the ravenous") and two ravens, *Huginn* and *Muninn*, "thought" and "memory."[316]

A 1996 asthma attack launched Helen into an OBE. After floating above a dirt road amidst lush, forested hills, she alit and was forced into an ultimatum at "a crossroads where an old man was waiting," accompanied by a raven. "He had a wizard-like appearance with a long beard but no hat, and he had an ordinary-looking cane." Helen telepathically greeted the being, who instructed her "to choose a path." One led to some mountains, the other a forested valley. "I was about to choose the path to the valley and forests, when I decided to turn around and see where I had come from." The choice returned Helen to her body.[317]

African religions focus on animal and ancestor psychopomps, but a few specific deities warrant mention. According Kowalewski, the Dahomean sea king *Agwé* escorts the dead beneath the ocean. In Yoruba culture, *Olokun* controls "the passageway through which souls must transit between life and afterlife," while *Ọya* soothes the deceased, curtailing hauntings. "The Congolese water snake god *Simbi* controls water channels, including that separating the realms of living and dead, sometimes serving as a psychopomp for departed souls, especially those of shamans," writes Kowalewski.[318]

Egypt boasts the most complex recorded soul tradition. Different aspects of the self experience the afterlife in different ways; with the exception of pharaohs, who bypass this journey, death is an arduous process. From Lewis:

> In general, the newly dead, in the form of their [soul components] ba and ka, traveled in the boat of Ra the sun-god as he made his way across the sky. In the West, as Ra reached the underworld with his load of new arrivals, the deceased disembarked and proceeded through seven gates, each with a gatekeeper, watcher, and herald. At each gate, and at several other instances, they had to consult the Book of the Dead in order to recite the names and formulas that would allow further progress…
>
> Finally, with the ka clad in white, Anubis… would provide escort to the Hall of Justice.
>
> In the court proceedings, Thoth, an ibis-headed god of wisdom, acts as prosecutor, and Osiris sits on the judge's throne, flanked by Isis and Nephthys. Forty-two divine figures sit as judges.[319]

This trial culminates with the deceased's heart weighed for sins against a feather; failure means consumption by *Ammit*, devourer of souls, while the successful continue to the underworld, eternal life,

or rebirth.[320] Numerous gods and goddesses assist the Egyptian death transition. Of primary importance are *Osiris* (god of fertility and the dead, whose resurrection appears in Chapter 7), *Anubis*, and *Thoth*.

Anubis intermittently accompanies the dead, leading souls to the underworld entrance, reappearing upon their arrival, and escorting them through final trial and judgment.[321] Closely associated with Osiris, Anubis is either a theriocephalic (animal-headed) jackal/human hybrid or a faithful dog.[322] Jackals not only consumed the dead, but were seen by Egyptians as liminal, dwelling at the desert's edge between civilization and the wilderness.[323] In this capacity, Anubis served as death-devourer before becoming chief embalmer and protector of graves.[324] Some mummifiers even wore Anubis masks.[325]

Anubis is also called *Anpu*, *Enpu*, *Inpu*, or *Inpw*.[326] Conflation appears between him and *Wepwawet* (*Upwawet*), a jackal, dog, or wolf whose name means "Opener of Ways." As co-lieutenant of the dead, Wepwawet led warriors and mourners through death, sometimes "piloting the sun's boat during its nocturnal journeys."[327] Reads one of the pyramid texts: "Upwawet has made me fly to the sky."[328]

Following a drug overdose in 1989, "a blue fairy" took Jeffrey by the hand, leading him to a "proverbial 'Stairway to Heaven.'" After watching a dog lead another soul up these steps, three figures—his grandmother among them—appeared to Jeffrey, taking him on a series of journeys. At one point, he encountered a cadre of foul-smelling, jackal-headed people who demanded to know his identity and from where he had come. His journeys escalated in intensity until Jeffrey met Jesus and Mary before finally awakening in a hospital.[329]

Less of a psychopomp than Anubis, ibis- or baboon-headed Thoth is nonetheless inseparable from Egyptian afterlife journeys. Thoth oversees writing, wisdom, science, magic, art, and the dead, though he does not always escort them.[330] He holds a rod in each hand, a *was* (wand) and an *ankh*, symbolizing power.[331] Like Jesus Christ, "the Word made flesh," Thoth is John Mack's "reified metaphor" incarnate, having "created himself through the power of language."[332]

Thirty minutes of CPR finally resuscitated Latimer after his 2008 heroin overdose. He returned to describe "a dark place where this green baboon approached me from the darkness. I knew instantly that this being was Thoth... holding a set of gold scales." Also present was Osiris, bird-headed and speaking incomprehensibly, and "an indigenous Australian warrior." As it turns out, Latimer's rescuer

was of Australian aboriginal descent, though he did not resemble the vision.[333]

Anubis and Thoth were closely associated with Hermes, to the extent they were combined into entirely new figures. Anubis became *Hermanubis*, a cynocephalic (dog-headed) god whose priests carried Hermes's kerykeion and wore dogs' heads.[334] Thoth and Hermes became a singular legendary character, *Hermes Trismegistus*. A series of magical and alchemical texts called the *Hermetica* are attributed to this apocryphal figure, who remains influential in occult circles today.[335]

New World and Oceanic beliefs operated at time depths as deep or deeper than the Old World, yet present identical motifs. Compare Anubis/Upwawet to *Xolotl*, the Aztec red hound psychopomp who displays power over death by breathing on the bones of the dead and returning them to life.[336] 16th century Pokomán Mayans designated *Xblanque*, one of two Trickster twins who outwitted death itself, as an afterlife guide; his name is derived from words meaning "sun," "jaguar," and "hidden."[337] Jaguars reappear as Mexico's *Tepēyōllōtl*, another death-devourer.[338] The Cashinahua "Old Father" is a thunder god and psychopomp, protecting and leading the dead.[339]

The North American psychopomp *Muut* manifests to the Cahuilla either as an owl or, more ominously, only their hooting.[340] Glowing-eyed, skeletal figures like the Ojibwe *baykok* and Algonquin *pakàk* appear as death omens.[341] The Inuit *Pinga*, goddess of the hunt, brings the dead to *Adlivun*—"Those Who Live Beneath Us," the underworld.[342] Coastal Alaska's Kwakiutl believe *buk'wus*, a lanky wild man sometimes analogous to Bigfoot, presides over the drowned dead.[343]

Oceania boasts perhaps the world's oldest people, the Australian aborigines.[344] Alongside their ancestors, they are guided after death by *Barnumbir*, at once the Morning Star and a spirit who "follows the route taken by the ancestral beings in their mythical journey," writes John Ashton and Tom Whyte. "Like them, the spirit might ascend on the rays of the setting sun or by climbing a rope lowered down from the sky country by the ancestral beings. Alternatively, the spirit might have to cross an invisible bridge or reach the sky by journeying along the Milky Way."[345] Barnumbir was born on *Braglu*, island of the dead where all souls return. She ascends nightly, tethered by string, to serve as a spiritual lighthouse—stars, of course, appear in countless NDEs as guiding forces.[346]

Aumakua, Polynesian ancestors or nature spirits attached to families, take dead bodies, guiding them in spectral afterlife processions. Like all ancestor spirits—and, as addressed later, faeries

—they require regular propitiation. Anyone mistreating the aumakua wanders in death as a ghost, leading travelers astray until another aumakua shows mercy.[347] In Malaysia *Munkar* and *Nangkir* return Semai dead to the afterlife, and ancestress *Grandmother Siunsun Amas* escorts Indonesian Taman souls.[348] *Tuglibong* and *Mebuyan*, perhaps the same female deity, lead Bagobo souls in the Philippines,[349] in addition to *anito*, ancestral nature spirits who accompany souls to the afterlife.[350]

Mainland Hindu beliefs identify multiple psychopomps—the *Atharva Veda* lists upwards of 33.[351] Notable are *Shiva* (fertility and death), Lord of Dogs;[352] *Visnudutas*, messengers of *Vishnu*; *Savitṛ*, sun-god; *Agni*, fire-god consuming the cremated dead, appearing as serpent[353] or bird;[354] and *Pushan* (*Pūṣan*), driving the sun's golden boat.[355]

Yama (*Yamarāja*)—the first dead man, king of ancestral heaven, judge of the dead—appears as a four-armed, blue-skinned being, wielding a mace or sword and noose, astride a water buffalo. Later texts depict him as a soul-judge, measuring good and evil in an echo of Egyptian heart-weighing. The post-Vedic period emphasized Yama's psychopomp role, transforming him from king to conductor of the deceased.[356] Yama is closely connected to a "black thunder-horse"[357] and pair of four-eyed dogs who oversee the path of the dead. These canines—possibly originating from a quadruple-eyed,

yellow-eared dog guarding the head of the Chinvat bridge—identify with the sun and moon.[358] In Theravāda Buddhism, Yama oversees hell realms and sentences the dead, rather than fetching them himself.[359]

Buddhism generally delegates psychopomp duties to lamas attending the dying and, in Thailand, *Yamatoots* (Hindu *Yamadutas*). These messengers—"who take the deceased to judgment and to hell — are typical of Thai NDEs, [but] they are described in highly individualistic ways: for example, 'two white-robed young men,' three men in turbans, or one man three times larger than an ordinary human," writes Shushan.[360]

Inside the Bardo also wait *bodhisattvas*, enlightened beings more recognizable as psychopomps. Buddhist art sometimes depicts *yinlu* figures, indicating "a generalized role of the bodhisattva as a psychopomp."[361]

"Bodhisattvas are compassionate beings who are destined for enlightenment, but who have consciously chosen to postpone this ultimate goal for the sake of helping others," Strong writes. "They have dedicated themselves to the universal awakening of every single being [regardless of spiritual practice or cultural tradition], which they do by offering guidance to others, assisting those who are suffering, and lending support to those on a spiritual path."[362]

Among them are Chinese bodhisattva *Guan Yin* (Sanskrit *Avalokiteśvara*, Japanese *Kanzeon*), who also serves as protector of women, and Japanese shapeshifting bodhisattva *Jizō* (Sanskrit *Kṣitigarbha*, Chinese *Dìzàng Púsà*).[363] Despite being male, Jizō's original name combines Sanskrit for "earth" and "womb"—clearly The Mother archetype.[364] Jizō carries a tall staff and an orb-like jewel to combat the darkness, sometimes accompanied by a dog, referencing a legend in which he discovered his mother had reincarnated as a canid.[365]

Though psychopomp to all, Jizō and his counterparts exhibit special compassion for dead, miscarried, and aborted children. The *River Sai* of Chinese mythology demarcates the lands of the living and dead; those with few sins can ford it, but anyone less meritorious finds difficulty, including children who have not accumulated enough good deeds.

"Therefore, they must spend their time building *herm*-like piles of stones in honor of the parents they will not be able to look after in old age," writes Strong, referring to the cairns of Hermes. "More extreme versions of the tale include a demon who comes every day to knock down these cairns, at least until Jizō shows up to protect the children. Today in Japan, similar stone piles can be found on desolate beaches, where parents go to honor their dead children…

Such piles were also once common at crossroads—liminal places—where travelers stopped to ask for Jizō's protection."[366]

Finally, we come to Abrahamic religions. Because of their ubiquitous Western iconography and psychopomp deficit—God is officially sole arbiter of life-and-death—we cover them cursorily. Rabbi Daniel Jeremy Silver presented evidence for a "cult of Moses" in first century Egypt, citing Nubian priests who identified Moses with Hermes. "Moses at this time seems to have developed a reputation as a psychopomp," he wrote. "The staff of Moses is sometimes pictured on amulets as swathed as if mummified."[367] Some speculate Hermes Trismegistus and Moses were contemporaries, or even one individual.[368]

Abrahamic religions describe psychopomp angels, identifying Samael, Michael, and Azrael (*Israfil*) in Judaism, Christianity, and Islam respectively, though overlap exists.[369] Angels are *not* souls of the departed—that idea arose among thinkers like Swedenborg—but rather intermediary spirits created by God, kind or terrible.[370] Bird symbolism appears in their wings, often as not attached to shapeshifting humanoids or figures of unknowable configuration. Azrael is attributed 70,000 feet, 4,000 wings, and a body covered in eyes ("Be not afraid," they say again and again in the Bible—good luck with that). Rabbinical literature depicts the Angel of Death standing at the head of the dying, awaiting the soul's escape

through the mouth, sword in-hand.[371] They are soul harvesters, judges, guides, and guards.[372] In popular culture, guardian angels assigned to individuals may fill the psychopomp role.

For Catholics, certain saints like St. Michael may guide the dead, as may the Holy Spirit (as a dove) or Jesus Christ Himself (notably, Mohammad does *not* appear as psychopomp, even in Muslim NDEs, maybe reflecting the Islamic prohibition on images of the Prophet).[373] Christianity syncretized practically all psychopomp symbolism with Jesus, particularly animals like dolphins, which guide souls among coastal cultures.[374] Jesus-as-shepherd finds antecedent in Hermes, whom Naassenian Gnostics interpreted *as* Jesus in the Homeric epics.[375] As evidenced in the previous chapter, Western NDEs are replete with appearances from Christ, the Virgin Mary, angels, and Abrahamic concepts of God.

Western folk figures

Not all psychopomps are religious figures. Because this category murkily blends soul guides and death deities, we cannot enumerate them all. Instead, we focus on two western folk psychopomps pertinent to later chapters.

The infamous Grim Reaper—a robed, sometimes winged, skeletal figure wielding a scythe—was first named in 1847's *The Circle of Human Life*, his depiction diffusing through Europe. "All know full well that life cannot last above seventy, or at the most eighty years," the translated German text reads. "If we reach that term without meeting the grim reaper with his scythe, there or there about, meet him we surely shall." The Reaper's roots lie equally in universal personifications of death as a skeleton; the Greek *Charon*; scythe-bearing death-devils knocking on doors of the European doomed;[376] and the Angel of Death.[377] His hood signifies death as hidden or shrouded,[378] his scythe the harvesting of souls.[379] The Grim Reaper did not develop in a European vacuum, as similar specters appear in a host of cultures, like the Japanese *Shinigami* and Korean *chasa*.

On December 12, 2006 a school bus T-boned Steve's pickup. As paramedics arrived, he found himself standing outside, looking at

the accident. Turning to his right, he "saw the Grim Reaper, the dark robe, the sickle, no face…just blackness, blacker than anything I'd ever seen before in my life. It was as if you could take the brightest light you could find—the sun, or even a thousand suns and shined it in there—and it would just swallow it up."

"Come," the figure beckoned telepathically. Steve drew closer, the accident fading, until he remembered his son and wife. "Fuck you, I'm not going anywhere!" he shouted. "Then I was back sitting in the truck and one of the paramedics was saying, 'Come on, stay with me.'"[380]

With variants found in Normandy, Cornwall, Wales, and Ireland, the Breton *ankou* is typically the first or last person of the year to die in a given cemetery or parish. Male or female, its head is described variously as revolving 360°, topped by a wide-brimmed black hat, or absent entirely.[381] Its body is skeletal, shadowy, or emaciated, possibly carrying a scythe.[382] In its headless form, the ankou finds rough analogue in the Irish *dullahan*, or headless horseman, another death omen.[383] M. Anatole le Braz suggested the ankou originated in prehistoric death goddesses of Breton dolmen-builders.[384]

"The ankou characteristically drives a deathly wagon or cart with a creaking axle and piled high with corpses; a stop at a cabin door means sudden death for those inside,"[385] and the figure is sometimes

seen removing the dead from their homes.[386] The death cart is another variant on ships, ferries, horses, etc. as a means of afterlife conveyance. Elsewhere in France, the Cart of Souls is pulled by oxen, driven by the devil.[387] These carts were easily spotted on All Saints Day and Christmas[388] as they squeaked along unwavering, well-defined paths of the dead.[389]

The screech of the death cart's wheels compares to the wail of the Irish banshee, *bean sí*, or *bean sidhe*, "woman of the hills" or "faerie woman." Commonly misidentified as a psychopomp—she *portends* death, but never escorts the dead—this important faerie is discussed in Chapter 5. Are the shrill noises reported at the start of NDEs actually squeaking wheels and shrieking wails?

Natural phenomena

"According to Labrador mythology, the Aurora Borealis is said to be the flickering lights of torches that are lit each night by the spirits who live there to show the way for the deceased," Strong writes. "The soul must travel a very narrow pathway, which leads across a great abyss at the end of the land and sea. This pathway is so dangerous that only those who have died a voluntary or violent death, and the raven, have ever made it all the way across."

Ancient Scandinavians described the Northern Lights similarly. Inuits believed the Aurora Borealis were *angiaq*, faerie-like souls of dead infants.[390] In Suffolk they were Perry Dancers, the Scottish Highlands *Fir Chilis*, faeries or souls battling or dancing in the sky.[391]

The endless death-rebirth solar-lunar cycle encourages afterlife associations. "The sun seemed to the Egyptians and to many other ancients to be clearly immortal, as it 'died' every evening, traveled through the underworld, and was 'reborn' every morning," wrote Lewis.[392] Solar-affiliated deities appear in every culture, sometimes driving the sun as a ship or chariot. As noted earlier, psychopomp animals like horses and roosters are strongly related to the sun.

Shushan compares NDE light beings to solar deities like Egypt's *Ra*, Mesopotamia's *Utu*, and India's *Vivasat*, each found in funereal texts.[393] The Zoroastrian angel *Mithra* sometimes functions as psychopomp, a role perhaps inherited from his sun association.[394] The cult following *Zeus Baetocaece* in coastal Syria gave him a solar-eagle-psychopomp aspect.[395]

The sun itself might guide the dead to the underworld. Some Aztec souls accompanied the sun to their final destinations.[396] In Melanesia, Tangan dead "hitchhike" with the sun to the land of the dead. Bodies "are laid in state under the open sun," wrote Karl W. Luckert. "When the dead man's eyes are in focus with the sun, the westward journey of his ghost begins. In this manner, the rupture of the sea is transcended with the aid of the sun which functions as a psychopomp."[397]

The moon, another potent death and fertility symbol, was also linked to harvests and the menstrual cycle. The moon was a symbol of Thoth. "As the days of rejoicing with the dead fell together with the feasts of the moon's phases in Egypt, so also sacrifices were offered to Hermes," wrote Patrick Boylan.[398]

In short, long before flying saucers invaded our Collective Unconscious, mankind interpreted glowing discs in the sky as forms of transportation… not to Mars, but to the Otherworld.

"A flying saucer is simply a craft that can take someone to another realm," wrote Mike Clelland. "But so is the magic mushroom, shamanic initiation, and even death."[399]

Though each culture dictates their specific pageantry, psychopomps share core symbolism worldwide, symbolism appearing time-and-again across paranormal encounters: rivers, bridges, ships and ferries, hoods, staves and wands, and consistent animal imagery. They also exhibit a shared disposition—using deception like shapeshifting to achieve their ends, they mediate between known and unknown countries, exhibiting distanced concern for the well-being of our souls.

But what are souls?

3

SOUL TRADITIONS



OBJ

Soul models rival afterlife beliefs in their diversity. Some differentiate between spirit and soul, an important distinction when describing beings which never lived—e.g. nature elementals, demons, etc.—versus discarnate humans and other living creatures.

"A spirit is not accurately a ghost, or a spirit of the dead, though the distinction between the two is often vague," wrote Rosemary Ellen Guiley in her *Encyclopedia of Ghosts and Spirits*. "Nor is a spirit precisely the soul, though the term 'spirit' is often used in describing the soul."[400]

For our purposes, the soul is any aspect of human consciousness persevering beyond physical death. Contemporary Western concepts

originate among Classical philosophers, who posited *psyche* as the mental faculties of living creatures. Ancient Greeks implied souls only belonged to the living by employing the same word for "alive" and "ensouled," an attitude reflected in certain Mesopotamian notions where postmortem consciousness evaporates in a netherworld, the House of Dust.[401]

Subsequent traditions declared the soul immortal. Pre-Pythagoreans speculated the soul, though enduring after death, fled directly to Hades, never to return. Socrates and Plato later speculated "the soul was the very essence of a person, an incorporeal 'eternal occupant' who was central to dictating our behavior as individuals," perhaps possessed of the ability to reincarnate. The soul's individuation was debated; while Aristotle held it retained no memory of the self, Muslim philosopher-physician Ibn al-Nafis called the soul "what a human indicates by saying 'I.'"[402]

The etymology of "psyche" warrants examination. Its origins in the Greek *to breathe* finds identical descriptions elsewhere: the Islamic *rūḥ*,[403] Hebrew *neshamah,*[404] Upanishad *Ātman,*[405] and Proto-Austronesian **nawa* all denote the breath of life.[406] The word "spirit," from the French *spirit* and Latin *spiritus*, is also rooted in breathing, as is another Greek equivalent, *pneuma*.[407]

Breath gives life literally and figuratively. Genesis 2:7 says, "Then the LORD God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living being." Some speculate *Yahweh*, the Hebrew name for God, originated in onomatopoeia for respiration.[408] The word finds striking assonance in Polynesian (*Io*), Mesopotamian (*Ea*), and Greek (*IAO*) words for supreme creators,[409] as well as Eastern meditative syllables *Om* or *Aum*, which correspond to the aforementioned Ātman.[410]

Any further examination of the soul risks cumbersome expansion. Although we will return sporadically to this breath/mouth connection, our focus turns instead to soul traditions forgotten in the West: the soul's size, its winged aspect, its identity as one of several aspects of the non-physical self, and the mytheme of *katabasis*.

Let's get small

A wide variety of mythic humanoids are diminutive. Worldwide faerie folklore and contemporary UFO reports, particularly post-1960, exemplify as much: from *leprechauns* and *pixies* dancing in the moonlight to hairy dwarfs and Grey aliens disembarking parked flying saucers, short entities litter Forteana. If the Otherworld represents an ecology of souls, what do we make of this attribute?

The soul, wrote Scottish folklorist Lewis Spence, "could hardly be of the same size as the body, otherwise the latter could not contain it." This logic birthed an apparently universal belief in the soul-as-*manikin*, a miniaturized double of the human form.[411] Souls appeared "as an airy or ethereal body, as a homunculus (a little person or child), as a bird (in Celtic and Islamic lore), and as a bright or fiery sphere" in Early and Middle Ages European artwork, Patrick Harpur wrote.[412] Medieval artists almost exclusively drew souls as sexless, anonymous, and small. A Romanesque relief from 1115 AD shows God's hands receiving Christ's soul, which leaves His body as a tiny homunculus.[413]

It is unclear whether religious depictions bled into European folklore or vice versa, but given the ubiquity of small souls worldwide, we might safely assume the latter. *The Laying of Lord Fergus's Ghaist*, a Scottish poem, describes the dying soul as barely larger than a midge. Another Scottish tale "recounts a story of an innkeeper in the Highlands whose wife made him drunk with brandy" before decapitating him. At her confession, she "admitted that she had been haunted by the spirit of her slaughtered spouse," who appeared among "a number of small men" and "gave her a blow, which left a blue mark," from which she later died.[414]

Many contemporary Western concepts owe a great debt to Greco-Roman cultures, which were saturated in small soul belief. From Walter Evans Wentz's groundbreaking *The Fairy Faith in Celtic Countries*, to which we return regularly:

> Like their predecessors the Egyptians, the Greeks also often represented the soul as a small winged human figure, and Romans, in turn, imagined the soul as a pygmy with butterfly wings. These ideas reappear in mediaeval reliefs and pictures wherein the soul is shown as a child or little naked man going out of the dying person's mouth….[415]

The mouth as egress point directly references the breath-soul relationship.

Greek *lekythoi*, or oil vases, commonly feature "an upright slab or monument, or a low mound; over this a little figure is traced in silhouette or a few strokes, sometimes seen hovering over, or beside the tomb, to represent the soul of the deceased."[416] The *Hymn to Hermes* asserts the eponymous god will "'wander upon the earth leading little people around,'" wrote Greek mythologist Károly Kerényi. "The "little people"… are most likely the dead, who drift about insubstantially with a 'frail buzzing' or 'chirping.'"[417]

Small souls are not inherently Western. One European missionary, addressing Australian aborigines, declared that he contained "a little body" inside himself, freed upon death; his converts surprised him by eagerly agreeing, "Yes, yes. We also are two, we also have a little body within the breast."[418] The Egyptian *ba* and *ka*, aspects of the multipart soul, appear respectively in bas-reliefs as small birds with human heads[419] and as dwarfs.[420]

Mystic and author Lobsang Rampa chronicled many Otherworld journeys wherein he beheld spirits, yetis, and even flying saucers. Once in the astral state, a tall, enlightened soul explained, "Here we have people ranging from those smaller than you to taller than I."[421]

Tiwi aborigines refer to *nyingawi*, short, tiny ghosts.[422] The Fijian Nakelo escort dead chieftains to the riverside "where the ghostly ferryman comes to ferry Nakelo ghosts across the stream," the entire time holding fans just above the ground to shelter his soul, which "is only a little child."[423]

Hindu *preta* ghosts[424] and Malay souls are thumb-sized. In the New World, Nootka, Huron, and Inuit souls are also short.[425] Some cultures even grant our limbs their own souls: tiny simulacra of hands, feet, eyes, etc., offering renewed legitimacy to "phantom limb syndrome," wherein amputated appendages are still felt.[426]

Small spirits are spotted regularly during modern ghost investigations. Could paranormal investigators misidentify short souls as faeries or, more commonly, the ghosts of children?

"Imagining the soul as a newborn infant has a long history in religious beliefs," wrote art scholar Moshe Barasch. Medieval artists used infants to convey the soul's innocence.[427] If "small souls" have any basis in reality, we cannot with certainty declare small ghosts children at all, especially in the absence of historical corroboration.

Moreover, firsthand testimony suggests we change size at death. Some NDErs report growing smaller, sharing sensations like "I remember the physical sensation of shrinking...."[428] "As I was being poured toward this light, I began to shrink."[429] "I kept shrinking until

I was just like an atom."[430] Admittedly, it remains unclear whether these constitute changes in size, or simply the perception of consciousness expanding.

Though rarely remarked upon by Ufologists, some abductees describe shrinking during UFO contact. John Mack attended a hypnotic regression where alien abductee Paul remembered "a sense that he was 'shrinking'" during a childhood experience.[431]

"Terry Winthrop," studied by researchers Budd Hopkins and Carol Rainey, described "feeling tiny" in one of her encounters. "I feel like the size of... the point of a needle. My body is huge." Upon clarification, Hopkins and Rainey determined she meant "her soul, her ego… had become tiny, shrunken, inoperative, while by comparison her body, her physical self, had become 'huge.'" Unsurprisingly, she was a victim of childhood sexual abuse.[432]

Reincarnation and reentry into the womb may require this "soul contraction," as both ancient and New Age traditions logically describe prebirth souls as small. A 1999 automobile accident sent one woman "regressing to the womb. In a flash, I was shrinking and returning to the maternal belly and once there I came to a place of light." The experience included the afterlife meadow and an overwhelming sense of love.[433]

Diminutive stature afflicts the ancestral dead as well. "Small" and "little" should be interpreted in context—when ancestors achieve godhood, these terms refer to their status as lesser deities, rather than their size—but overtly short ancestor spirits appear in Gaelic,[434] Ainu,[435] Kanikkaran,[436] Fijian,[437] Nri,[438] Mende,[439] Yaqui,[440] and Aztec mythologies.[441]

"Dwarfs, in traditional Germanic cultures, were avatars of the ancestors," wrote history professor Nancy Caciola. "The society of the dead, and the ancient peoples of the region, is associated with small stature."[442]

Tiny "spirit homes" appear in Thai, Mayan, and Bantu practice, sometimes specifically erected for ancestors.[443] "Whether or not they consciously think of their dead as little shadowy figures, a few inches high…such is evidently the thought that suggested the erection of these miniature dwellings," wrote Alice Werner of the Zulu.[444]

Whether "tiny ancestor" traditions are a variation on small soul beliefs or another tradition entirely is unclear. In southern India, it was believed ancestors enjoyed great longevity during the Treta Yuga, but shrank as they aged. "They got so small at length that to keep them out of the way of harm it was necessary to place them in the little triangular niche in the wall," wrote one ethnographer. Eventually their descendants "placed them in earthen jars, put with

them in the jars a number of little vessels containing rice, water, oil, etc., and buried them near the village."[445]

Scientific explanations are no more satisfactory—although human height generally trended upward over the past few centuries thanks to nutrition and medicine, gains are neither consistent nor remarkable, measured in mere centimeters.[446] Some studies suggest average height actually *fell* following the agricultural revolution.[447]

Homer described near-constant warfare on the edge of the world between cranes and a race of pygmies. Aristotle repeated the legend: "these birds... fight with the pygmies; and the story is not fabulous, but there is in reality a race of dwarfish men, and the horses are little in proportion, and the men live in caves underground." Similar war stories were related by South Carolinian tribes in 1520 to the Spaniards.[448] These anecdotes are confounding until viewed through death symbolism: perhaps pygmies and cranes are metaphors for small souls resisting the afterlife transition, fighting off psychopomps.

Without spoiling later discussion, small soul beliefs clearly influenced faerie folklore. John Arnott MacCulloch asserted "the small size attributed to [faeries] in many regions may have been suggested by the common belief in the soul as a manikin."[449]

Even when not directly related to souls, some cultures understand faeries as a shrinking race, growing smaller over time. Scandinavian *vættir*, nature spirits, began human-sized before Christianity shrunk them.[450] Cornish legends like "The Fairy Dwelling on Selena Moor" cite similar mechanisms, describing a faerie captive who visited the human world as a bird, but each time "came back a little smaller than before, and so she was gradually dwindling as the Small People did."[451] More recently, Laura Forsberg suggested the proliferation of scientific equipment like the microscope, revealing heretofore-unseen miniscule ecosystems, may have played a role in concretizing Victorian conceptions of small faeries.[452]

To a degree, the point is moot. "Do not think the fairies are always little," warned William Butler Yeats—"everything is capricious about them, even their size."[453] Faeries were inveterate size and shapeshifters, an aptitude shared with psychopomps and ghosts. "We can make the old young, the big small, the small big," one told a Sligo seer.[454]

A Tipperary faerie queen once became a bird-winged, dragon-tailed horse, a flaming bull-headed man, and "a great ape, with duck's feet and a turkey-cock's tail," according to Irish antiquarian T.C. Croker. "But I should be all day about it were I to tell you all the shapes she took."[455]

Taking flight

Reports of levitation from NDE survivors likely contributed to the assumption that souls can fly. For prehistoric man, the only things capable of flight were the sun, clouds, and winged creatures; naturally, they attributed luminosity, ethereality, and wings to the soul. In some part deep within us, we know this to be true; how many times have you flown in dreams, and your first thought is, "This feels *familiar*"?

The psyche-breath connection hints at flying. *Keres*, a Greek word encompassing ghosts and fertility-oriented nature spirits, were not only souls escaped from *pithios*—jars used to contain the dead—but possibly the demons released from Pandora's Box.

"Winds were thought to be responsible for fertilizing crops with their lifegiving 'breath,' but winds and Keres could also be 'soul snatching' and (like the Norse Valkyrie, possibly from the Greek root *keres*) literally 'take one's breath away,'" wrote University of California-Berkeley's Richard P. Taylor.[456]

Alongside smallness, Greek souls were identifiable by their wings. "The most common alternative to conceiving of ghosts as humanoid

was to conceive of them as tiny winged creatures," wrote ancient history professor Daniel Ogden. "They are miniscule black figures hovering on wings, somewhat akin to dragonflies... Metaphors for ghosts in this aspect were afforded by bats, birds, and bees."[457] In some art the entire soul is rendered avian, particularly as a swan.

Birds are hands-down the most widespread symbol of our souls. We find bird-souls in Sumerian, Harappan, Indonesian, Malaysian, Solomon Islander, Melanesian, Papua New Guinean, Sumatran, Javan, Dayak, Formosan, Moriori, Bororoan, Isanna, Zaparo, Tapuyan, Mojave, Osage, Bilgula,[458] Cree, Ingilik, Hawaiian, Fang,[459] continental Indian, Aztec, Mixtec, Chinese,[460] Chepang,[461] Icelandic,[462] and Slavic spiritual practices; *even this list is incomplete*.[463] Birds perched on Eurasian World Tree imagery represent human souls.[464] Bird-soul belief endures in contemporary folklore: owls in Virginia are "ole folks talking"; gulls embody dead seaman's souls; French corvids are corrupt clergy; New England jays are dead lumberjacks; Arabic and Swedish murder victims become white owls and ravens, respectively. Irish and Scottish dead were often ensouled in birds and seals.[465] Once more, universality implies reality.

(As an aside, seals—long associated with faerie folk like mermaids, *merrows*, *selkies*, and, by extension, bird-winged Greek *sirens*—were also Celtic soul repositories, their barking presaging death.[466] As

elaborated in Chapter 18, one of John Mack's alien abductees disclosed a powerful spiritual experience while on holiday in Scotland, where he felt compelled to "sing hymns to communicate with the seals," only to have one of them follow him for half a mile.)[467]

Birds' migration, where they traverse great distances both vertically and horizontally in response to the seasons' rebirth cycle, became a symbol of transcendence.[468] Birdcalls can sound uncannily like human speech, and the "language of the birds" became an Old World esoteric concept suggesting birdsong encodes divine messages.[469]

Eliade wrote the bird-soul is "probably even older" than its appearance in ancient Egypt and Mesopotamia, stretching into prehistoric animism.[470] A Cherokee myth supports this, combining many of our symbols.

After Sun entered mourning for her daughter, the world was plunged into darkness. The people sought the wisdom of the Little People, who "told them that if they wanted the Sun to come out again they must bring back her daughter from *Tsûsginâ'ï*, the Ghost country, in *Us'ûñhi'yï*, the Darkening land in the west." Seven men were chosen, given sourwood rods.

"The Little Men told them they must take a box with them, and when they got to Tsûsginâ'ï they would find all the ghosts at a dance. They must stand outside the circle, and when the young woman passed in the dance they must strike [Sun's daughter] with the rods and she would fall to the ground." They were to put her in the box, opening it under no circumstances; this taboo was broken when she begged for air and escaped in the form of a little red bird. While daylight was restored, keeping the daughter imprisoned would have facilitated free passage of souls between our world and the afterlife.[471]

Popular depictions of faeries present them not only as small but winged, further underscoring the influence of soul tradition upon faerie lore. Although preceded by *sylphs* (Paracelsian air elementals) and any number of winged demons or spirits, the journey to winged faeries in art is long and circuitous, extensively chronicled in the work of folklorist Simon Young. His ongoing research roughly points to either William Blake or Henry Fuseli first depicting faerie wings around 1790 (an earlier engraving possibly dated 1769 presents "cherubic fairies with wings"). An earlier, literary allusion appears in a 1778 poem: "On Fancy's fairy wings conveyed." Mary Wollstonecraft also drew a connection between souls and faeries in 1796: "[my soul] taking its flight with fairy wing."[472]

Even before wings appeared, legend ascribed faeries powers of levitation and flight, closely associated with gusts of wind and storms, another soul connection. While any animal might represent a shapeshifted faerie in disguise, winged creatures predominate, especially swarms of flies,[473] bees,[474] and, of course, birds. In Brittany, "the *fée* is a magpie in a forest near Rennes—just as in other Celtic lands, fairies likewise often appear as birds."[475] A visiting banshee might perch atop your roof in the form of a crow.[476]

The entire subset of "Swan Maiden" Fairy Tales feature men spying on bathing women, forcing marriage by stealing their feathered robes or swan skins. These stories blur "whether the maiden appears as a bird or as a human (or fairy)... She is at once both and neither." Swan Maiden narratives may represent vague recollections of shamans and their spirit wives, a role faerie-like beings regularly filled.[477]

Birds are animals. Birds are also souls. They are spirits. Birds are psychopomps. They are shamans. Birds are UFOs, Mothman, faeries. Birds are, simply, *the Other*.

Though not as widespread as bird-souls, lepidopteran-souls (butterflies and moths) are another mythological trope.

"An altogether different function performed by the soul—in a sense, the very opposite of hovering above or near the deceased

and the tomb—is the animation of the body," explained Barasch. "In these rare cases the animating soul is rendered either as a butterfly or a small-scale human figure endowed with large butterfly wings."[478] "Psyche" has a third Greek meaning alongside "soul" and "to breathe": "butterfly."[479] The dead become lepidopteran-souls in Celtic, Byelorussian,[480] Spanish, and German traditions, drawing upon themes of transformation and rebirth from the cocoon.[481]

Butterfly-soul belief permeated Latin America, where shades of Aztec mythology endure in Mexico to this day. The annual Monarch butterfly migration coincides with *Día de los Muertos* celebrations. Michoacán's Mazahua population welcomes the insects, believing they are souls or psychopomps transporting the dead on their wings.[482]

On an archetypal level, we may perceive a *butterfly : solar : light : conscious :: moth : lunar : shadow : unconscious* dichotomy. Moths embody mystery, perhaps even foreboding. Columbian Goajiro ancestors took the form of large, white moths demanding respect, lest they take revenge. Bolivian Aymara viewed the same insects as death omens.[483] As discussed in Chapter 14, much of Whitley Strieber's post-2015 work features a white moth closely associated with his deceased wife, Anne.

Unsurprisingly, faeries appear lepidopteran, famously borrowing insect wings in popular culture. Famed German folklorist Jacob Grimm wrote, "The elf is connected with the ghostlike butterfly, the product of repeated changes of form," hinting at the transformational rebirth theme.[484] In Somerset, white moths at twilight are at once *Piskies* and the souls of unbaptized children.[485] A Tipperary informant described faeries who "flew in the form of butterflies and nested on the top of [their] fort."[486] Ojibwe and Cree Little People shapeshifted into butterflies; the latter's name, *Memegwesi*, may even originate in their word for butterfly, *memengwaa*.[487]

Though absent in earlier testimony, eyewitnesses commonly report faerie wings today, perhaps due to Co-Creation—artistic depictions influence expectations. In the early 2000s, a Staffordshire woman waiting on a bridge "saw something small from the corner of my eye. I looked up and there were a small number of [faeries], all winged. Some sitting on branches, some hovering. The wings were like butterfly wings." They observed each other for several minutes until she glanced away, after which they disappeared.[488]

Another witness was sitting on a dry Australian riverbank when a pink butterfly caught his eye. "On approaching it, the butterfly folded like origami, first into a flat looking faerie, then into a pretty little pixie," he wrote. "It was a small female figure with butterfly wings. It

was tangibly present and fled by flying away, not fading. I suppose it 'might' be an alien, but there was no technology present to suggest that."[489]

A peculiar English encounter from January 1979 blurs faerie-alien-soul distinctions further. While investigating an orange-white glow from her garden, Jean Hingley unwittingly opened the door for three buzzing humanoids to float inside her Rowley Regis home. Hingley watched in alarm as the creatures accosted her Christmas tree. They were dressed in silver, wearing transparent helmets over "waxy white, corpse-like, diamond-eyed" faces and, most surprisingly, sported *wings*.

"Their wings were wonderful, large, oval-shaped and glowing with rainbow colours—red, violet, gold, blue, green, but *more beautiful than our earthly colours* [author's emphasis]." The trio settled down, revealing they followed "only one Lord," that they "came from the sky," and felt houses of worship were unnecessary (these two final details preclude the possibility of trick-or-treating Jehovah's Witnesses). Hingley offered water and mince pies, the latter of which they carried back to their ship, an orange-glowing, "shining plastic," oblong shape topped by "a scorpion tail" structure.[490]

The scorpion tail is an interesting detail, replete with death symbolism. "Pluto [Classical god of the dead] is the ruler of Scorpio,"

wrote mysticist Manly P. Hall. "The sign of Scorpio is represented by four different symbolic creatures: the scorpion, the serpent, the eagle, and the phoenix… As the eighth sign of the zodiac it was associated with death…."[491]

Polypsychism

Modern society rarely addresses *polypsychism*, or multiple souls within us. The idea appears today most often in psychological diagnoses of dissociative identity or "multiple personality" disorder, characterized by the presence of at least one additional personality state. Sigmund Freud separated consciousness into Id, Superego, and Ego. Jung proposed Ego, Personal Unconscious, and, as mentioned, Collective Unconscious, postulating aspects of the self could appear as "the Other"; ergo, we wonder whether paranormal entities are somehow projections of ourselves.[492]

Abrahamic religion deemphasized polypsychism, despite its appearance in older texts. *Neshamah yeterah,* an additional soul given to every Jew "from the entrance of each Sabbath until its termination," resembles ancient notions of the *Shekhinah*, a divine, sometimes feminine aspect.[493]

"Indeed, the arrival of the Sabbath Queen, which is one of the names of the Shekhinah, and the arrival of the extra soul on the Sabbath is simultaneous," wrote Judaic scholar Howard Schwartz.[494] In Islam the *qareen* is a contentious figure, our constant companion from birth, similar to the *djinn* yet also an integral "other self"

representing our internal struggle—it either influences its owner towards evil, or its owner influences it towards good.[495] Christian figures like St. Gregory redefined the soul as a singularity, yet tension nonetheless surrounded mankind's dual existence in the Middle Ages.[496]

"The notion that the human person had a double nature, being comprised of both a spiritual and a material self in intimate union with one another, was central to Christian anthropology," wrote Caciola.[497] Said Egyptian mythologist Don Webb:

> Christianity has the simplest soulcraft of anybody. You've got a body… you've got a soul. *Maybe* you've got something called a spirit—we're not quite sure what that is… It does not explain wanting to do different things. It doesn't explain how you could have two completely separate impulses at the same time… The real condition of human beings is [that] we could have a lot of different thoughts going on, and impulses, and moralities, being pulled in a lot of directions. If you have a *polypsychism*… you can understand your existence plain *better.* [498]

Whereas the church distanced itself from pagan polypsychism, its precursors embraced the concept. Alongside the Shekhinah, Jewish Kabbalah espouses three souls: *nephesh* (lower, animalistic soul), *ruach* (moral spirit), and *neshamah* (higher, intellectual soul), with

further divisions encompassing *chaya* (a part of God) and *yechida* (oneness with God).[499] Reaching earlier, the Zoroastrian psychopomp Daēnā was a facet of the self.[500]

Bipartite (two-part) polypsychism flourished worldwide. China's *yin* and *yang* correspond respectively to *p'o* (lunar, feminine, physical) and *hun* (solar, masculine, intellectual) souls. Similar Native American beliefs present an ambulatory free soul and a vital, animating soul,[501] a sky-earth dichotomy popular among North American mound builders.[502] Jamaicans imported bipartite belief from Africa.[503] Each Kalabari possesses *biomgbo*, the self, and *teme*, which knows the former's future,[504] while Zulus house two *ehloses,* good and evil.[505]

"Fiji Islanders believe that every person has two souls— a dark one which exists in his shadow and goes to Hades, and a bright one which exists in his reflection on the surface of water or in glass which remains nearby his place of death," wrote psychoanalyst Otto Rank.[506] These dualities emerge in the cartoon "shoulder angel/demon" trope, itself influenced by Greek descriptions of *agathodemons* and *cacodemons*, good and bad spirits assigned to each person.[507]

Three-in-one

Where Homer perceived a bipartite soul, Plato asserted a tripartite (three-part) psyche: *logos* (reason), *thymos* (emotion), and *eros* (desire).[508] According to Claude Lecouteux, tripartite souls prevail in shamanic cultures, especially the Turko-Tarters and Siberians: a lower soul remains postmortem in the skeleton, the second stays loosely attached but wanders during life, the third separates at death as a ghost.[509] In the *Jaiminiya Brahmana* the deceased meet the seasons personified, who strike their merits "into three parts, which dissipate, go to the seasons, or accompany him/her to Svargaloka, where there is no place for sinners."[510]

The number three is symbolically potent. Three features not only in Christianity—the Trinity, Christ died around 3:00 p.m.—but also ancient traditions. Three fates assigned Hellenic people their destinies. While the Roman goddess *Diana* identifies with Artemis, she was also *Trivia*, embodying Diana, Luna (moon), and the Greek Hecate (underworld), endowed with dominion over crossroads.[511] In the East, three Chinese *Guan Dadi* embody the universe and judge the dead,[512] and Jizō iconography comes in sixes.[513]

French legend ascribes Provence's Christian conversion to "the Saint Marys of the Sea": the Virgin's sister, the mother of apostle James and John, and Mary Magdalene. Medieval literature professor Philippe Walter suggests the Three Marys "could be nothing other than the Christian metamorphosis of a triad of fairies. Bishop Burchard of Worms compared the medieval fairies to the Three Sisters and the Three Fates of antiquity."[514]

The occult is replete with additional examples: Wicca's Rule of Three, three humps emerge from Loch Ness, UFOs appear triangular, 3:00 a.m. is "the witching hour," demons leave three scratches on victims, etc. The parapsychological literature is *filled* with lights and raps signifying the death of someone in the household, often in groups of three or nine (three groups of three).[515] Paranormal entities commonly appear as trios: three spirits, after all, visit Ebenezer Scrooge in Charles Dickens's *A Christmas Carol.* Have you ever noticed how it seems celebrities die in threes?

Many-in-one

Two polypsychic mythologies deserve elaboration. Egyptians conjectured up to *nine* souls, notably the aforementioned avian *ba*, the personality, and the *ka*, the living life force, a dwarfen double.[516] The *akh* was a crested ibis, *ab* the conscience center weighed in the afterlife trial,[517] *khet* the physical body.[518]

Scandinavian polypsychism, replete with doubles, confusingly overlaps in ways incongruous with our modern perspective. The *hugr* and *hamr* are roughly mind-soul and appearance, though the latter is also an individual's physical double, an externalized soul animated by the former.[519]

The *fylgja* ("female follower") is another Norse double.[520] Associated with one's destiny, these guardian spirits were zoomorphic, appearing in owners' dreams as animals. Lecouteux finds correspondence between shapeshifting *fylgjur* and witch, werewolf, and faerie folklore, discussed later.[521] Fylgjur may follow bloodlines,[522] preceding the healthy but lagging behind the dying.[523] The *hamingja*, a sort of female guardian angel, resembles the hamr and flygja[524] as well as the *dís*, a female protective clan spirit.[525]

Patrick Harpur wrote that the *Anima Mundi,* the World-Soul, "is usually feminine and appears, for example, as a female daimon or goddess who, as Jung would say, 'personifies the collective unconscious."[526] These figures' recurrent feminine aspect evokes the experiences of Whitley Strieber, who intermittently interacts with a similar presence.

Strieber wrote early in his Visitor contact that "the most essentially and powerfully feminine presence I have ever known came to me and had me dragged out of the house and essentially beaten until I realized that she was real and I was not dreaming. During those horrific moments, I awoke both physically and spiritually."[527] There is an ongoing sexual component to Strieber's encounters; "sexual elements or relationships were not uncommon between a man and his *fylgja*-woman."[528] Was Strieber's feminine presence Shekhinah, Anima Mundi, his fylgja, another part of himself or, somehow, all of the above?

It can be unclear which polypsychic traditions describe entirely discrete souls residing in the same body and which describe a singular soul divided into multiple parts. In either case, they assemble to form a singular human consciousness, expressed in Jungian terms as a *totality*, a reconciliation of all aspects of our psyche.[529] From religious scholar Jeffrey Kripal:

> When one reads [Strieber] carefully, what one finds is a very modern version of what one finds when one reads classical mystical literature… there is ego, there is the human subject, there is "you" and "me." And then there is mind, which may not be restricted in any way to a brain, a skull, an individual ego, a culture, or a religion… This, it turns out, is a very old idea that can be found in any number of forms, including the medieval European notion of the *anima mundi*… Such a soul-of-the-world or cosmic mind, after all, would be us and not us *at the same time*. And it would behave much like the lights dancing on the movie screen: it would take on *any* cultural narrative (or myth), *any* subjective form (or ego), including some really cruel and really stupid ones, but it would remain, despite all of this, pure white light—without a form, without a story, and without a religion. The Human as Two.[530]

The implications polypsychism poses regarding faeries, UFOs, and cryptids are discussed in their respective chapters. Let us sit a little longer with our alter egos.

The Daemon

Bipartite polypsychism expresses ancient belief in "Higher Selves," our true, omnipotent identities, existing eternally, guiding our actions from the spiritual plane. These "voices in our head" may speak to us throughout the day or in dreams, and may be drowned out by our lower, carnal, base selves. Some Muslim teachers describe a struggle between our ego or self (*nafs*) and the compassionate, selfless, wiser Higher Self, at one with Allah (*rūḥ*).[531] *Rūḥ* equates to the Holy Spirit, which Christianity sometimes compares to the Higher Self, particularly among those "born again." Christ's lessons embody this synthesis, presenting his lower, physical body in harmonious singularity with his Higher Self, God (e.g. John 10:30, "I and my Father are one").

"In Hinduism, the higher self (or atman) is a divine reality, man's true identity, the core of our being, and is called *sat-chit-ananda* (pure existence, pure consciousness and pure bliss) in Hindu scriptures," wrote Bansi Pandit. "Self-realization means self-awareness, a state of being aware of one's true self, which reveals our eternal being."[532]

Higher-lower selves roughly correspond to a mind-body opposition. Some, like Theosophists, interpreted them literally, and welcomed the concept with open arms. This belief system bases itself upon late 19th century teachings from Russian philosopher Helena Petrovna Blavatsky, who claimed secret, supernatural Ascended Masters intervene from time-to-time in mankind's affairs. Theosophists influenced many of our modern paranormal conceptions, from faeries to séances. Their legacy is inescapable.

"The central doctrine of Theosophy, that round which all else revolves, is the doctrine of the *Higher Self*," wrote early Theosophist William Kingsland. "Briefly stated, that doctrine teaches that our own true Self, the immortal Ego, is ONE with the universal SELF, with that which in ordinary phraseology is called 'God.'"[533] The Higher Self is further rooted in the *Daemon*, a Neoplatonic intermediary force.

"Just as the human soul mediated between spirit and body, so the world-soul mediated between the One (which, like God, was the transcendent source of all things) and the material, sensory world," Harpur wrote. "The agents of this mediation were called daimons… who, as it were, populated the Soul of the World and provided the connection between gods and men." Daimons were beings of folklore and myth—elves, faeries, giants, fauns, etc.— transformed into Christian *demons* by pagan affiliation.[534]

Among these daimons was one's personal Daemon, charged with protecting and guiding its human ward.[535] Author Anthony Peake drew upon these ancient concepts for his excellent *The Daemon: A Guide to Your Extraordinary Secret Self:*

> … all human beings have a lower and a higher self. The two elements can communicate, but it seems to be a one-way process. It is usually the higher self—the Daemon—that does the 'talking.' The Eidolon [Lower Self] seems to be a totally passive receiver of information. However, there are mystic traditions in which an Eidolon, through rigorous training, can open up the communication channels by itself. In this way it can access the knowledge and perceptions of its Daemon. The implication here is that the Daemon has knowledge not available to its lower partner, a knowledge that it is happy to impart if asked in the right way.[536]

Perhaps the altered states of conscious accessed by shamans, alien abductees, and NDErs, including dissociation, open these communication channels. Peake's Daemon-Eidolon communication resonates with Dogon belief: "the nonmaterial [spiritual] universe is characterized by having perfect knowledge, but an inability to act, whereas the material universe has imperfect knowledge and full ability to act."[537] Channeling and mediumship exemplify this relationship, where Higher Selves grant permission for the living to access the spirits and convey otherwise inaccessible information

(Theosophy's Akashic Records, a spiritual library of everything in existence).[538]

Higher-Lower Selves can be compared to video game players and their onscreen avatars. Players guide these figures through the game, but players exist after the game is over. If they begin a different game, the avatar (Lower Self) is different but the player (Higher Self) remains constant (one can only imagine our Higher Selves chugging Mountain Dew, grasping their game controllers in ephemeral, Cheeto-stained hands). By persevering through multiple lives, Peake asserts we "Cheat the Ferryman," Charon.[539]

Yet in another sense our Daemons *are* the Ferrymen, psychopomps leading lower souls from life to life. Where do Daemons end and psychopomps begin? The concept of dedicated guardian angels belonging to each of us clearly began in the Daemon. *Rūḥ* is the Islamic soul, Higher Self, and Holy Spirit, but is sometimes archangel Gabriel, *Rūḥ al-Qudus*.[540] Some Egyptians believed one's own ka guides us through the afterlife.[541] The fylgja is guide, guardian, *and* an aspect of ourselves.

Peake suspects the Daemon's "most important role," its "final manifestation" if you will, is "the Being of Light so regularly reported in the Near-Death Experience."[542] Further blurring lines, we each

carry our ancestors within our genes; ergo, ancestor lineages, full of psychopomps, could constitute the Higher Self as well.

Prone to wander

A Seneca legend describes a man whose Sky spirit, "never as solidly hinged to the human form as the Earth spirit," separated from his body while walking home. His wife, several steps behind, watched his spirit take an alternate route at "an 'oblong loop' in the path, which, after a short space, came back together again into one path." Unsure of which represented her corporeal husband, the wife chose the righthand trail. "As the two paths reconverged, the woman saw her husband's two spirits reconverge." Following her husband's Sky spirit would have led her to death.[543]

"Wandering souls" appear whenever cultures ascribe autonomy to other aspects of ourselves. For example, Puerto Rico's Taíno differentiate between *hupia* and *goeiza*—ghosts of the dead and wandering "ghosts" of the living—in rough correspondence to Zoroastrianism's *ano-sharawan* and *zinda-rawan*. Tikopian islanders believe a person's *mauri* can "come and go from his host as it pleases, usually doing so when the person is asleep."[544]

These narratives seem to describe OBEs but, unlike most modern accounts, the ego's perspective sometimes remains stuck in the physical self. Our "astral bodies," or "second bodies" as Robert

Monroe termed them, often start as exact duplicates before deteriorating over the course of the OBE. In this state, our consciousness accesses the astral plane and, in Sylvan Muldoon's words, becomes "the condenser of cosmic energy [which is] the breath of life, omnipresent in every living thing."[545]

We are all familiar with the concept of our souls leaving our bodies after death. According to many indigenous populations, however, our souls are capable of temporarily leaving our bodies while alive, especially during sleep, trances, and illness—consistent with OBEs and other altered states of consciousness.[546] The Māori *wairua*, for instance, is comparable to the Egyptian ka, "the shadowy self which leaves the body during dreams and wanders afar off," sometimes returning with actionable knowledge regarding intertribal strife, hunting, etc.[547] The ka also manifests exteriorly, perceived by its own ba.[548]

"Our ancestors believed in the existence of the Double, an independent alter ego freed from the body when the body is dulled by sleep, frozen in trance, weakened by illness, or immobilized in coma," Lecouteux wrote. "Those who are not aware that they posses a Double… interpret what they have seen as a dream; but those who… have this knowledge, know with certainty that they have not dreamed, but instead have doubled themselves."[549]

In Britain, village seers held "Church Porch Watches," staying awake through the night in the churchyard, awaiting "the spectres of those who would die in the course of the following year." As the seer watched, the wandering souls of the doomed would file in through the church door and back out again, often following funeral procession pathways.[550]

As in death, wandering souls commonly exit via the mouth. An apocryphal Cathar story tells how "a creature that looked like a lizard came out of [a] sleeping man's mouth," crossing a stream using a plank. An observer removed the plank, and "the sleeping man began to thrash about greatly," but did not awake, despite attempts to rouse him. Replacing the plank, the observer watched the lizard cross and re-enter the sleeper's mouth, who awoke and recounted a dream of an impassable river.[551] A similar story involving a mouse, a sword laid across a stream, and a dream of "a great iron bridge" is attributed to Socrates.[552]

"There is a German belief that the soul escapes from a sleeper's mouth in the form of a white mouse or a little bird, and that to prevent the return of the bird or animal would be fatal to the sleeper," famed anthropologist and folklorist James George Frazer wrote in *The Golden Bough*. "Hence in Transylvania they say that you should not let a child sleep with its mouth open, or its soul will slip out in the shape of a mouse, and the child will never wake."[553]

Thus, wandering souls are therianthropes, appearing to the living as lizards (in Wales, the black *madfall đu*),[554] hares,[555] mice, cats, and, of course, flying creatures like birds and bees.[556] Other forms include miniature human manikins, storm clouds, and whirlwinds.[557]

Controlled OBEs allowed gods and magical adepts to shapeshift. Odin "was believed to send his spirit to range the world in a variety of animal forms while his body lay asleep or dead," and a famous anecdote from *Hrolf Kraki's Saga* features a warrior lying entranced while a bear—either his soul or a real animal ensouled by him—eviscerates his enemies.[558] In the Balkans, disembodied spirits of *kresniki*, shaman warriors, roamed the countryside on pagan holidays, fighting other sorcerers to defend the health of harvests, livestock, and the land.[559] Muscogee shamans "could shape-shift their Earth spirits into ghost lights, horned owls, and other such Earth manifestations, to fly about in the dusk."[560] Metaphysical, rather than physical, transformations gave rise to stories about man-beasts like werewolves (see Chapter 18).

These wild assertions pose problems for OBE researchers, as modern literature rarely reports small animals leaving astral travelers' bodies. However, would we recognize disguised souls? Any bird or bee seen through the window during someone's OBE would be dismissed as natural. (At the same time, a measured approach is

advised when applying this to daily life. Please don’t go around saying birds are astral travelers; they’ll lock you up.) While not always describing bird transformations, many astral travelers are inspired by fantasies of flight, attainable during OBEs. We can thus understand shamanic journeys as voluntarily-induced OBEs, in which specific soul-forms are chosen, often those of animals, to reach the Other Side.

Beside myself

While our separable souls ramble, our bodies or "physical souls" are left vulnerable. The Kwakiutl prohibited harming owls, lest they kill the owner of a disguised, wandering soul.[561] Similarly, the Irish warned against shooting "any wild-duck or any birds you see flying—for tonight they are all poor souls traveling."[562] In Corsica, nighttime dream-hunters named *mazzeri* stalked about in spirit form, "compelled to attack animals, and for a fleeting moment they were able to see a human face superimposed on that of an animal they had killed. This would be the visage of a person from the community who was soon to die."[563]

"The absence of the soul in sleep has its dangers, for if from any cause the soul should be permanently detained away from the body, the person thus deprived of the vital principle must die," wrote Frazer. These concerns extended to moving or altering the sleeper, "for if this were done the soul on its return might not be able to find or recognise its body, and so the person would die." Simply painting someone's face,[564] touching,[565] or waking them could be a death sentence.[566] Folklorically, this may be why so many of us die in our sleep.

For these reasons *autoscopy*—seeing yourself from another vantage point—is universally regarded as a danger or death omen, emerging as a common literary device signifying doom: your separable soul has wandered, leaving your physical self vulnerable. Scots, Irish, and English people seeing another person's *wraith*, *fetch*, or Double in the *morning* meant its owner would recover from any illness, but an *evening* sighting limited their lifespan within the year.[567] Fylgjur, sometimes equated with fetches, abandon their owners if seen in waking life, causing death.[568]

Nowhere is autoscopy better explored than in German *doppelgänger* ("double goer") tradition, popularized by Catherine Crowe's 1848 *The Night-Side of Nature*. Yet doppelgängers do not always indicate harm—they may represent innocuous bilocation stemming from an OBE. Christian saints bilocated without detriment.

"Arrival cases" featuring the Norwegian *vardøger*, like the Finnish *etiäinen,* are harmless forerunners of a person's actual appearance. We have all expectantly awaited someone, perhaps hearing doors slam and keys fall, only to discover they have yet to arrive. Now you have a word for it.

In July 1955, American importer Erikson Gorique was warmly greeted at an Oslo hotel by the clerk, who insisted they met earlier. Gorique had never been to Norway nor the hotel (he didn't even

have reservations), yet the clerk was adamant he remembered his name and appearance from several months earlier.[569]

Similar experiences plagued Fortean researcher John Keel. A last-minute West Virginia motel stay was met with "a sheaf of nonsensical message slips" from the clerk, as if he had reservations or was already checked in[570]—yet this may have been a cynical prank perpetrated by fellow UFO author Gray Barker.[571]

Pupils of French teacher Emile Sagée saw her double while she was employed at a girl's school in Riga. A second Emile would mirror her as she wrote on the chalkboard, or stand behind her during mealtime. She was eventually asked to leave and moved in with her sister, whose children eventually acclimated to having "two aunts."[572] In another case, "a girl attending a southern university" was studying late one night when "a mirror image of [herself] seated on [her] bed" appeared. "I let out a little cry of surprise and the other 'me' smiled, crinkled up its nose, and after about six or seven seconds, disappeared."[573]

German poet Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, during a stressful absence from his lover, "saw, not with the eyes of the body, but with those of the mind, my own figure coming toward me, on horseback, and on the same road, attired in a dress which I had never worn." The grey-and-gold bedecked figure vanished. "Eight years afterward,

I found myself on the very road, to pay one more visit to Frederica, in the dress of which I had dreamed, and which I wore, not from choice, but by accident."[574]

Still, many doppelgängers are ill-omened: English poet John Donne allegedly saw his wife's double the night their daughter was stillborn. "I have seen my dear wife pass twice by me through this room, with her hair hanging about her shoulders, and a dead child in her arms: this, I have seen since I saw you," he told a friend.[575] While at sea in June 1893, Vice-Admiral Sir George Tryon's double wordlessly drifted through a party the night he died in a ship-to-ship collision.[576]

A month before he drowned on July 8, 1822, the double of English poet Percy Shelley asked him, "How long do you mean to be content?" The figure was corroborated by a Mrs. Williams, who saw his double on June 15, the day before his wife—*Frankenstein* novelist Mary Shelley—experienced pregnancy complications, culminating in a nearly-fatal miscarriage.[577] One night in 1978, a mother whose child died three months prior saw herself stooping over her bed, wearing the same dress as when she leaned over her child's body.[578]

That so many poets experience doppelgängers speaks to their affiliation with the numinous. These "phantasms of the living," as

coined by the Society of Psychical Research in 1886, may even attack their owners. A young Okinawan lady encountered her doppelgänger—"with a 'sharp, unkind expression'"—while shopping and misplaced one of her parcels in the process. Upon returning home, the package was waiting. She fell ill the next day, and the double came to her door, "trying to strangle her and to cut her tongue with a pair of scissors." Her husband found her after the attack and raced to the hospital.[579]

Other doppelgängers *save* their owners, drawing comparisons to guardian angels and, of course, Higher Selves. A German theology professor returning home from work was unable to shake his double, at last seeing the figure enter his home ahead of him. His maid handed it a candle, and the professor was compelled to rush inside hot on its heels. He ascended the stairs "in time to hear a loud crash in his room." The ceiling had collapsed—an accident which surely would have proven fatal had he arrived a moment sooner.[580]

Doppelgänger stories lead to a few reasonable conclusions. Autoscopy of the physical self (i.e. seeing yourself in an OBE) appears less dangerous than autoscopy of the soul (seeing a doppelgänger while awake). Contrary to tradition, doppelgängers are *not* unanimous death omens, and may be harmless byproducts of dissociative states, or constitute attempts to warn us. These warnings may come from our own subconscious, our Higher Selves,

or the Collective Unconscious. When death *does* follow, the appearance of our double likely indicates an anticipatory loosening of the bond between body and soul.

A few questions also arise. Worldwide, souls assume a variety of forms, including animals universally regarded as psychopomps. These doubles—wholly of the self— also appear as guides and representatives of one's fate, responsibilities commonly relegated to psychopomps. Are doppelgängers both Higher Selves *and* psychopomps? Our multipartite souls share many attributes with other paranormal entities, as discussed in later chapters—are they one and the same? If Co-Creation Theory has any merit, do we sometimes project images of humanoid "Others" like aliens, faeries, or Bigfoot onto our wandering souls? Could childhood imaginary friends be the exteriorized self?

Perhaps all these are true; perhaps none. To understand the Other we must understand ourselves, and to understand ourselves, we must travel inward. We must descend deep into the subconscious, where the Other dwells.

Katabasis

Tripartite cosmologies are widespread: heaven is for gods, earth for mankind, the underworld for the dead. Tungusic, Samoyedic, Chukchee, and Turko-Tatar people, "to mention only some of the most important groups, know and revere a celestial Great God," wrote Mircea Eliade. "Sometimes the Great God's name even means 'Sky' or 'Heaven'... Even when the concrete name of the 'sky' is lacking," they present "characteristic attributes— 'high,' 'lofty,' 'luminous,' and so on." More often than not, the heavens housed divine spirits, rather than the dead.[581]

"Gods above, dead below" is by no means universal. Plenty of indigenous dead travel the Milky Way to an afterlife in the sky, or a distant, earthly locale. Starlit "stellar underworlds" in ancient cosmologies meld cave and sky, waystations for the sun's nightly disappearance. Christianity presented Heaven as a temporary dwelling for redeemed souls between death and resurrection, remaking the underworld into a repository of the damned—yet cultures naming an underworld as the sole afterlife destination are so plentiful they preclude enumeration.

As discussed, *chthonic* (pertaining to the underworld) locales from world mythologies typically lack a moral component. They were simply where all souls went, a logical extension of buried corpses. The dead "live" underground, as do any number of paranormal entities: Fairyland is subterranean, extraterrestrials build underground bases, Bigfoot lurk around abandoned mines, and caves harbor monsters.

Underworlds even extend below the waves. Thompson's folklore index lists Motif F93.2 as "Lake entrance to lower world," providing a new context through which to interpret mermaids, sea serpents, and lake monsters hiding below the surface. Indeed, "soul"—rooted in Gothic *saiwala*, Norse *sála*, Saxon *sêola*, or Old English *sáwol*—may be connected to the word "sea," or ancient western European ideas that oceanic depths hold the dead.[582] Modern monsters rise from underground and underwater; our other selves, our souls, arise from our subconscious.

Naturally, the underworld became a psychoanalytic metaphor describing the unconscious. Like psychopomps guiding souls to chthonic depths, psychologists guide patients inward, resurfacing with useful information hidden from the waking self. A successful descent and return echoes the ancient mytheme of *katabasis* (Greek "going down").

"The descent into the underworld is a common narrative found in a diverse number of mythologies around the world, with a hero or deity journeying into the Underworld or land of the dead in search of a loved one or enlightenment," wrote magical practitioner Wren Collier. "Perhaps most famously known in Western culture is the descent of Orpheus to bring his lover Eurydice back to the land of the living, a task in which he notably fails by transgressing and looking back at her as they climb out."[583]

Collier cited other katabasis myths including Izanagi's trip to the Japanese underworld to rescue his wife, Izanami, after she died in childbirth and—perhaps earliest—"the descent of the Mesopotamian goddess Inanna into the underworld of Kur in an attempt to overthrow her sister, Ereshkigal." Inanna was disgraced and slain for her hubris, but returned after the god Enki's successful rescue. "However, Ereshkigal's guardians, the *galla,* take Inanna's husband Dumuzid in her stead, only permitting him to leave one half of the year while his sister Geshtinanna replaces him in Kur, thus resulting in the mythological basis for seasons in the upper world." Collier noted this legend's congruency with the Greek Persephone myth from our previous chapter.[584]

It is a contradictory concept, but consistent with the counterintuitive nature of paranormal phenomena: to ascend, one must descend. Heroes in katabasis narratives may acquire hidden

knowledge from chthonic oracles, or permanently weaken boundaries between the living and dead. The final and most dangerous labor of Heracles involved kidnapping Cerberus from his post guarding the dead; returning through *nekumanteion* sites, he "enhanced their necromantic power for having dislodged the warden of ghosts."[585] Ergo, katabasis protagonists are not only liminal—they *transform*, returning from death with secret knowledge or abilities… much like shamans, NDErs, and alien abductees.

In fact, shamanism may have inspired katabasis tales. A Telumni Yokut legend from North America closely mirrors the Orpheus myth: a man fails to retrieve his wife from *Tipiknits*, Lord of the Underworld. His transgression is falling asleep, rather than looking backward.[586] A Pawnee warrior successfully retrieved his wife from the afterlife using "four mud balls," but after speaking ill of her to his new spouse, lost her forever.[587] Writes Eliade:

> As to Orpheus, his myth displays several elements that can be compared to the shamanic ideology and techniques. The most significant is, of course, his descent to Hades to bring back the soul of his wife, Eurydice. At least one version of the myth has no mention of the final failure... Orpheus also displays other characteristics of a "Great Shaman": his healing art, his love for music and animals, his "charms," his power of divination. Even his character of "culture hero" is not in contradiction to

> the best shamanic tradition—was not the "first shaman" the messenger sent by God to defend humanity against diseases and to civilize it?[588]

Faeries litter katabasis myths. Persephone became Rome's Proserpine, christened "Queen of the Fayrye" in the Middle Ages. In England, the Orpheus myth was reinvented as a faerie legend, wherein "Sir Orfeo" must rescue his wife—not dead, but kidnapped by faeries—from a lush, green subterranean Fairyland overseen by the "King of Fayré."[589]

Ancient humans saw caves and caverns not only as shelters, but as chthonic entry points, sites of worship, and the abodes of oracles.

"In all parts of the world gorges and fissures in the earth are regarded —both in mythology and popular belief—as the gaping jaws of earth, the entrance to the underworld, and the place of the dead," wrote Herzog. Yet an immeasurable transformative potential abides underground: totality. "The Mother Earth that bears and nourishes is the same as that which gapes open with threat of death: the Earth is a Mother with the wolf's gaping jaws… nourishing life and devouring death—are brought together in one image."[590]

Symbolically speaking, to enter and emerge from a cave is an expression of death and rebirth. In Christianity we see this not only

in the empty tomb, but also—loosely— baptism's submersion and emergence anew. Seeking their own katabasis, mystic initiates of the distant past entered these spaces prepared to commune with the dead and emerge enlightened.

"Caves play an important part in the initiation of North American shamans; it is in caves that aspirants have their dreams and meet their helping spirits," wrote Eliade. Similar beliefs ascribe sleeping on a grave or tomb instilling the gift of prophecy. "The underlying idea is the same: the dead know the future, they can reveal hidden things, and so forth."[591] (Belief that caves impart spiritual knowledge may further originate in sensory deprivation, as darkness and silence both induce altered states of consciousness, addressed in Chapter 6.)

The relationship between caves, katabasis, and enlightenment is no better represented than in ancient Greece's Eleusinian Mysteries. These annual rites venerated Hades's abduction of Persephone near a cavern in Eleusís, with initiates symbolically descending, searching, and ascending from the underworld.

"People standing on the Sacred Way to the Hall of the Mysteries (*telesterion*) were able to see the upper part of the cavern and the façade of the temple," wrote historian Yulia Ustinova. "The cave consisted of two chambers: the larger one housed the temple, and

the smaller one had an aperture through which it was possible to pass to the outside. This complex probably served as the setting for a part of the sacred drama of the annual return of Persephone. The ritual was perhaps staged as a search for the goddess, which culminated in her discovery…."[592]

No ones knows exactly what took place at Eleusís, as participants were sworn to strictest secrecy. Tantalizing tidbits survive: "a form or appearance of some kind hovering above the ground," the telesterion "filled with spirits," "the division between earth and sky melted into a pillar of light."[593] Work by researchers like Brian C. Muraresku strongly implies mind altering substances like psychoactive beer heightened the experience.[594]

Psychedelic use would certainly be consistent with themes of shamanic initiation worldwide and—regardless of whether or not altered states of consciousness represent an objective "other reality"—the experience would certainly be harrowing. Archaeologists like Paul-François Foucart suggested a theatrical version of the Mysteries complete with illusory effects "led the initiates through gloomy infernal regions, with horrible images and ghostly shapes," followed by "subsequent representations of a blissful afterlife in the company of the goddesses and other initiates" to instill "a profound sense of relief and spiritual rebirth."[595]

All of this remains speculative, however—we simply don't now what the Mysteries entailed. We can only judge their results, which appear profound: "If you come to Eleusís, you will never die," as Muraresku puts it. "Aristotle once said the initiates came to Eleusís not to *learn* something, but to *experience* something… One inscription found on the site says, 'death is for mortals no longer an evil but a blessing.'" Other endorsements of the Mysteries Muraresku cites come from 5th century BC poet Pindar—"Blessed is he who has seen these things before he goes beneath the hollow earth; for he understands the end of mortal life, and the beginning [of a new life] given of God"—and playwright Sophocles: "Thrice blessed are those among men who, after beholding these rites, go down to Hades. Only for them is there life [after death]; all the rest will suffer an evil lot."[596]

Whether by psychedelics, theatrics, or actual magic, the Eleusinian Mysteries seem to have been, for lack of a better term, a "Near-Death Experience Simulator": a descent into death followed by ascension and rebirth. Ancient testimony joins the refrain from modern NDErs; *this* is the secret of NDEs, the secret of shamanism, of the Greek mystery cults. Die to death so you might live.

The tight consistencies surrounding death narratives—among cultures crossing time and space, cultures without cross-contaminated values—render the possibility of an objective,

underlying reality difficult to dismiss. We see NDEs, psychopomps, and souls consistently described in countless mythologies. Not only is death a shared human experience… it seems our *beliefs* surrounding death are just as universal.

While difficult to believe, such consistency is at least conceivable. It beggars belief why faerie folklore should remain as consistent—unless the Good Folk are as real as death itself.

4

FAERIES & THE DEAD


OBJ

"Mine is yours, and yours is mine!"

John Roy of Glenbrown, Scotland uttered these words and threw his cap into a passing company of elves one night. Knowing faeries were contractually-minded creatures bound to honor even inferior exchanges, Roy received in return "a beautiful woman, by her dress and language a Saxon." She lived with Roy for seven years until he offered lodging to a traveling Saxon captain and his son, the former of whom "regarded the English lady with so much attention."[597]

"I am struck with the resemblance of this woman to my deceased wife," the captain finally explained, mentioning her name. Hearing it, she recognized and embraced her family. "The Elves who inhabited

the Shian of Coirlaggack had undertaken an expedition into the south of England, and made no scruple to steal the woman even during her illness," wrote Croker. "A false being was laid in her room, who died a few days after; and the husband, supposing it to have been his own wife, had her buried."[598]

Conceptions of tiny, effete, winged ladies contradict older, more ambivalent faeries from folklore. Their disposition is best described as capricious. Respected, well-propitiated faeries ensured good luck, robust harvests, or tidy households, while offended faeries unleashed their boundless wrath, inflicting illness and torment, ruining food, kidnapping victims, or generating misfortune.

Nor were faeries uniformly diminutive. This aspect is notably absent from professor Diane Purkiss's eight key faerie characteristics, wherein all faeries exist outside human communities; abduct the vulnerable; ensnare others in their "eternal, storyless youth"; possess "anomalous" bodies; maintain close ties to specific areas; feature in "peasant cultures"; and, notably, are "either once people or are like people… trapped at a certain indeterminate phase of life," presenting clear links with the dead.[599] To this list, we might add looser associations with wind, levitation, anomalous lights, underground dwellings, supernatural time lapses, offerings, and changelings, faeries substituted for humans.

Fae folk answer to various culture-specific names worldwide, encompassing elves, dwarfs, gnomes, trolls, sprites, nature spirits—even beings rarely identified as faeries like mermaids, ogres, and giants. Though most famously associated with England, Ireland, and Scotland, a 2006 survey of 300 Native American tribes found "Little People" in 85% of mythologies.[600]

So what are faeries? Professor John Rhŷs wrote, "I should hesitate to do anything so rash as to pronounce the fairies to be all of one and the same origin; they may well be of several."[601] Faeries messily overlap with all spirits. In Christianized countries they often adhere to the same rules as demons, dismissed by the church as fallen angels "too good for hell, too bad for heaven" dwelling among the hills, forests, and waterways where they landed. Others suggest faeries are forgotten pagan gods, location-bound spirits, or land spirits (i.e. the *soul* of a landmark, *genius loci*).[602]

Yet according to Simon Young, "Traditional fairy-believing communities in the nineteenth century tended, if they thought about the meaning of fairies at all, to associate them with the dead; and it is even possible that fairies were originally born from an attempt to make sense of death."[603]

Faerie belief is obviously complex, perhaps confused by observer expectations or sloppy descriptors—the word "faerie" was once used

much like we employ the term "paranormal" today. Some strongly distance faeries from the dead, with many modern faerie witnesses going out of their way to emphasize their sightings *do not* resemble ghosts.

During the 1950s, for instance, an English witness out for a walk was running ahead of her family when she saw an eight-to-ten inch tall faerie dressed in green. She finally overcame her speechlessness and shouted for the others to come see, but the creature disappeared. "It was definitely a fairy, not a ghost, as I have had experience with ghosts and it was entirely different," she said. Another childhood witness in the 1930s saw a pink, winged faerie fly through a window—"The fairy was as real as a kitten to look at but common sense told me I would not be able to touch it. No sense of the numinous attached to it as with an angel or, I would imagine, a ghost."[604]

Faeries often posses a corporeality ghosts lack.[605] Some traditions explicitly draw distinctions between faeries and ghosts—for instance, Iceland's *landvættir* clearly precede faerie-dead conflation.[606] The *Tuatha Dé Danann*, oft-cited inspiration for Ireland's faeries, were either an extinct race or more likely a race of gods, overtly precluding human origins.[607]

At the same time, the Tuatha are sometimes called *siabra*,[608] an Old Irish word interchanging "fairies, sprites, or ghosts."[609] The words *boggart*[610] and *púca*[611] are also shared between faeries and ghosts. A faerie-dead connection clearly exists, but the relationship itself remains unclear.

"My opinion is that they are both spirits of the dead and other spirits not like the dead," Outer Hebrides informant Marian MacLean hesitantly told Walter Evans Wentz.[612] Spirits mingling with the dead —could these be psychopomps or Higher Selves?

Theosophic faeries

When discussing faeries today, most people think of "nature spirits" or "elementals." London medium Claire H. Cantlon regularly saw faeries, claiming they "help me very greatly with my garden and will make beautiful flowers come up for me, but in the house they hide things in a most annoying way, and seem to delight in making me vexed." In 1950 a Lucy Bruce of Iona claimed her garden hosted "a colony of elves" which "put vitality into the soil and help things grow."[613]

In Western culture, "nature spirit" faeries may be traced to Swiss philosopher Paracelsus, who in 1566 laid the groundwork for modern "elemental" traditions. Drawing upon Classical interpretations, Paracelsus described "supernatural nature spirits, which were able to manifest within physical reality: Undines (water), Gnomes (earth), Sylphs (air) and Salamanders (fire)," according to faerie folklorist Neil Rushton.[614]

In the early 20th century Austrian philosopher Rudolf Steiner adapted Paracelsian elementals into *devas* corresponding to earth, water, air, and heat/light "responsible for entire autonomous landscapes, through to the smaller nature spirits charged with the

growth of vegetation."[615] Steiner's writings in turn influenced Theosophy.

"Fairies were recast, by spiritualists and particularly by theosophists, as nature spirits or even 'elementals,'" Young wrote. "This was not an original idea—in the Renaissance Neo-Platonists had played around with similar notions, there are even hints of this in [Shakespeare's] *Midsummer Night's Dream*—but it was one that proved potent and went mainstream with remarkable speed."[616]

Faeries' "folkloric mischievous immorality does not seem to correspond with the perception of them as energy fields feeding the vital life-force of nature," wrote Rushton. "But this misses the point somewhat. The faeries of folklore and the nature spirits do fit into a single phenomenon of supernatural beings that need to be observed, understood and propitiated by humans."[617]

Therefore, Theosophic faeries are not wholly "incorrect"; like winged faeries, they are simply overemphasized. Faerie lore likely represents convergent evolution between nature spirits and superstitions surrounding the dead. Lecouteux says of Eurasia's revered dead:

> When a man was remembered well after his death, when his life was beneficial to the community, he enjoyed for a short time after his departure a particular status: the pagans made him a god or spirit, the Christians a saint, but the reaction is the same… It should be noted that a figure deified in this manner is intrinsically linked to a specific place… the good dead and the spirits were distinct from one another originally. They were gradually merged together, and then combined with other creatures.
>
> …the local spirits and the dead worthy of offerings were merged with elves by virtue of the latter's beneficial nature and their habitat; [and] all were the object of agrarian and/or domestic worship, and they were therefore demonized by the Church and merged with the dwarves, creatures reputedly malevolent and dreadful.[618]

Humans are earth itself, Eliade's *homo-humus*—"dust thou art, and unto dust shalt thou return." Graves fade from memory, their revered occupants morphing into land spirits, protecting or ensouling landmarks, trees, boulders, etc. For instance, ancestral Australian aborigines might "'become' a rockhole, a mountain, or some other natural feature,"[619] much as in Eurasia. After constructing their own coffins, Buryat shamans are temporarily buried, then reinterred at a chosen location where their "spirit becomes the guardian or presence of the place," merging with the surrounding landscape.[620]

Polynesian *tiki* are both deified human souls and nature spirits. Among Borneo's Iban, *tua* form whenever "a person renowned for their bravery" dies. After their body is abandoned at some isolated landmark and left offerings, the individual eventually becomes a spirit of the land, the location a pilgrimage site where divine intervention is sought.[621]

"The general idea of the 'little people,' the fairy folk and the fairy world, can grow out of the beliefs concerning the spirits of the dead," wrote folklorist MacEdward Leach. "The formula is the dead -> animated spirits of the dead -> manifest in any variety of material forms -> a separate, though supernatural entity not at all associated with the dead."[622]

The revered dead can even fulfill the nature spirit role in the ecology of souls, helping plants thrive. "The ancestors were buried underground, just as were the seeds that brought the harvests," wrote Caciola. "Thus the friendly dead might be expected to assist the germination and growth of crops for their descendants from their privileged vantage point under the earth."[623]

Lecouteux's explanation, while not comprehensive, illuminates at least some conflation between human souls and nature spirts. Having given Theosophic faeries their due, this chapter and the next

compare faeries not only to the departed, but also death omens, wandering souls, prebirth spirits, and psychopomps.

Faeries as the dead and ancestors:

Ireland, the British Isles, and Brittany

Acclaimed faerie folklorist and anthropologist Walter Yeeling Evans Wentz (1878-1965) collected many stories featuring faeries and the dead in 1911's *The Fairy-Faith in Celtic Countries*, noting especially strong associations in Ireland and Brittany.

"The Breton peasant thinks of the dead as frequently as the Irishman thinks of fairies," he wrote of the near-identical traditions. The Breton dead are small, vanish at will, accept food offerings, and troop across the countryside with their own "faerie king" in the form of the ankou.[624]

When not describing them akin to elementals, many of Evans Wentz's informants equated faeries with the souls of the dead. For instance, a County Armagh witness said, "If you have many friends deceased you have many friendly fairies, or if you have many enemies deceased you have many fairies looking out to do you harm." Summarizing Celtic death superstitions, Evans Wentz wrote, "often no essential and sometimes no distinguishable difference"

separates faeries from human ghosts, "nor between the world of the dead and fairyland."[625]

Two decades later, mythologist John Arnott MacCulloch (1868-1950) downplayed this connection, arguing the faerie-dead similarity "rather points to their not having a common origin, but reminds us that similar traits are ascribed to all kinds of supernaturals, and that through the mingling of traditions the traits of one class easily pass over to another." A fair, if incomplete assessment. Nonetheless, MacCulloch favored the notion that faeries represented a "folk-memory of earlier races," a controversial theory covered later.[626]

Lewis Spence (1874-1955) so staunchly equated Celtic fae folk with dead souls that his 1946 *British Fairy Origins* flirts with oversimplification. "A greater number of resemblances seem to exist between the dead and the fairies than differences divide them," he wrote. "A close resemblance exists between the dead ancestors and the fairy, who equally demands a portion of human sustenance as his right and who reveals a close interest in human affairs which he seeks to control by a code of decorum, as do the ancestral spirits."[627]

Eminent faerie scholar Katharine Briggs (1898-1980) never shied from addressing the faerie-dead connection, but entertained more ambiguity. "It is arguable, of course, that in primitive times all the dead were fairies, and that Christianity has removed most of them

out of the fairy power," she wrote. "… but on the whole one might say that those of the Dead who inhabit Fairyland are people who have no right to be dead at all."[628]

Faerie-dead connections are most explicit in these Celtic cultures. English philosopher Thomas Hobbes equated the two—"The Fairies are Spirits and Ghosts," he claimed—as did Scottish theologian John Aubrey, who claimed magical practitioners communed with "ghosts & spirits, or as they commonly call them, the fairies or fairie-folk." Robert Kirk (1644–1692), author of the foundational faerie text *The Secret Commonwealth of Elves, Fauns and Fairies*, was told by one such seer that faeries were "departed souls."[629]

Faeries earned this association from the company they kept. The dead marched among faeries, husbands recovered deceased wives from faerie dances, and dead souls dined in Fairyland.[630] Anyone stumbling into a faerie gathering might be warned by departed acquaintances against accepting their hospitality, lest they remain permanently imprisoned in the faerie realm.

In 1674 an Irish servant passed several faeries playing cards in a field; joining them, a man "dead seven years" cautioned, "Do nothing this company invites you to."[631] A Cork midwife summoned to a faerie birth met a departed friend who advised her to "take all [you want] except money." An identical Shetland story features a

dead cousin warning the midwife against using her Christian name or consuming food, lest she become trapped in Fairyland.[632] Another famous Irish tale finds "Jemmy Doyle" in a faerie palace, instructed by a dead relative to pour out rather than drink his punch, lest he suffer the same fate.[633]

Testimony from Scottish witch trials, though obtained under duress, mentions specific deceased individuals encountered in Fairyland. Alesoun Pearson "met with the spirits of young Maitland of Lethington and the old laird of Buccleuch, Scottish notables both of whom had been dead for some considerable time." Bessie Dunlop named "Thome Reid," casualty of the Battle of Pinkie, as a Fairyland resident.[634] Johne Stewart, kin to cunning woman Elspeth Reoch, visited her and identified as "ane farie."[635]

Other Celtic tales, by no means an exhaustive list, present the dead alongside faeries:

- In 1827, Eleanor Dorcey and friends encountered a faerie host near Machaire More. "A dark person" broke off and attacked her, but was thwarted by "her mother (dead six years)." Dorcey's leg remained paralyzed until her mother reappeared over two weeks later, aiding her recovery through herbs and prayer.[636]

- In 1938 a Tobracken boy recalled a story where a man followed music into a faerie fort, only to find a girl "dead for years" dancing among the fae folk. She followed him home, but he denied her entry and never returned to the fort.[637]

- A Cloontiprucklish bride who died on her wedding night revisited her husband, instructing him to "stand at the gap near the house and catch me as I go by." He found her among the faeries, but froze—"there was a scream and she was gone."[638]

- Another Irish seer claimed "the gentry [faeries] are everywhere," among them the drowned uncles and grandfather of John McCann, one of Evans Wentz's informants. McCann claimed his uncle had also seen "his drowned friends" with faeries. [639]

- In one story, an Irish villager followed playful lights on November Eve to a great crowd hosting the Faerie King and Queen. The people cajoled him to dance, among them "a girl that had died the year before, then another and another of his friends that he knew had died long ago; and then he saw that all the dancers, men, women, and girls, were the dead in their long, white shrouds."[640]

- A Cruachmaa boy constructing a wall was assisted by a group of faeries which included "many neighbours that were dead among them." Another faerie troop knocked down the wall just before completion, "and the boy died not long after."[641]

- A man trespassing near Cnoc-na-Briona encountered faeries who "beat him while he was with them, and he saw there a great many of his friends that were dead."

- Animalistic shapes surrounded an Irish boy leaving an old churchyard, following him until he reached "an old forth [fort] and a faery bush," and started praying. His attackers fled when the boy saw "a woman that he knew before, that was dead, and so he knew that she was amongst the faeries." "It's well for you that I was here, and worked hard for you," she chided, "or you would have been brought in among them, and be like me."[642]

"People killed and murdered in war stay on earth till their time is up, and they are among the *good people*," John Graham, who lived near the Tuatha Dé Danann center of Tara, told Evans Wentz. "The souls on this earth are as thick as the grass," he said, dragging his walking stick through a clump for emphasis, "and you can't see them; and evil spirits are just as thick, too, and people don't know it."[643]

Mixing the dead with faeries and short nature spirits was not solely relegated to Celtic countries. The trend encompasses the entire

globe.

Faeries as the dead and ancestors:

Continental Europe and colonial exports

Scandinavian elves may have arisen "as the protective spirits of dead ancestors,"[644] though this assertion remains contested.[645] Today's "garden gnomes" resemble the region's *nisse* or *tomte*, household spirits once believed to be the souls of a farmstead's original owner, dwelling within burial mounds on the property.[646] In Finland, *menninkäinen*, leprechaun analogues, were also "returned spirits of the deceased."[647]

Iceland has a rich history of supernatural entities. The word *troll* once designated not only hostile, lumbering faeries but sometimes ghosts or magicians.[648] Other Icelandic faeries, the elfin *huldufólk* ("hidden people"), are respected to this day. Herzog suggests *huldu* connotates "shrouded," implying "*Huldren* are the Shrouded Ones, and the victims of Hel," the Norse death goddess, making them "the dead themselves." Herzog further speculated the huldren attribute of being "hollow at the back like a kneading trough"—a recurring faerie motif—symbolizes the effects of decay.[649]

Similar beliefs applied broadly to Norse-Germanic mythology as a whole. "The dwarves are dead," wrote scholar Chester Nathan Gould. Gould compared Norse dwarfs to "the shrunken and shrivelled corpse… there was no distinction made in the old Scandinavian literature between the dead laid to rest in the howe, the elves and the 'Underjordiske,' which would include the dwarves."[650]

Some speculate the *draugr*, Norse folklore's reanimated undead, relate to *trows*, corpse-grey trollish faeries of the Orkney Islands. This assertion is supported by the archipelago's longstanding cultural exchange with Norway as well as etymology—"draugr" and the Old Orcadian word *drow* are strikingly similar. Like faeries, draugr dwell in burial mounds, guard treasure, manifest anomalous lights, and present extreme danger. In the 16th century Jo Ben, earliest chronicler of the Orkneys, claimed islanders "who die suddenly spend their lives thereafter with [trows]…."[651]

Vestiges of the faerie-dead conflation in Italy can be found in a 1390 inquisitorial trial prosecuting two Milanese women. "One defendant confessed that she regularly attended the games of the 'good folk,'" Caciola wrote. The woman testified that "both living and dead people attend, but those who have been decapitated or hung are very shamefaced and do not dare hold up their head in that society."[652]

European colonial forces sometimes brought their faerie mythologies with them to new lands. This begs the question: did Old World notions connecting faeries to dead souls syncretize with preexisting "Little People" legends elsewhere? Or did indigenous populations connect the two prior to occupation? This avenue of study is severely under-investigated.

A few examples illustrate the question's complexity. Though an English colony, Jamaica's faerie belief appears *African* rather than European in origin, yet still conflates dead souls with "an order of supernatural beings" in the form of *duppies.* (*Duppy* means "child" or "ghost" in Sierra Leone,[653] while *Adope* means "dwarf" in Ghana.)[654] The Filipino *anito,* nature spirits and ancestors combined into faerie-like psychopomps, clearly boast a Spanish name (the -*ito* suffix), yet their existence predates occupation.[655] Mayan *alux* belief is equally syncretic—though appearing in pre-Columbian culture as both tiny nature spirits *and* the dead, alux clearly subsumed aspects of *duendes* (an Iberian faerie import)[656] and even appear in regional UFO testimony today.[657]

One New World example clearly influenced by European folklore but no less remarkable comes from North Carolina's Uwharrie Mountains. The legend highlights the complex relationship between faeries, the dead, and witches. Two entwined pine trees along Rocky

River Road earned a haunting reputation after a ghostly man was seen hanging from their boughs. Upon seeing the specter, multiple furry goblins would swarm the carriage of anyone approaching the trees, warning them not to pass between "the Squeaky Pines." Alternately, the goblins would be replaced by three, black-clad, hook-nosed witches—"never both at the same time"—who encouraged just the opposite.[658]

Local lore held the hanged man was the phantom of a plantation owner killed by his slaves. Mountainfolk "figured that the goblins were the ghosts of the slaves and the witches were the ghosts of the hanged man's sisters—the goblins coming back to win sympathy and justification for lynching their cruel master, the witches to get revenge for their brother's death."[659] (Readers will note a racist undertone in assigning African American spirits a simian aspect.)

Sightings continued until a local doctor, fetched by Cleo Burroughs to attend his wife's labor, saw both the goblins *and* the witches at the Squeaky Pines, delivering their conflicting messages. Determined to reach his patient, the doctor rushed through "a shaft of flame" past the trees, which "began a slow, grinding, limb-ripping crash, then lay smoldering on the ground." The haunting ceased.[660]

In short, there is no clear answer to the question of European contamination. Faerie lore in colonial countries represents a complex

interplay of both occupier *and* indigenous belief, but connections to the dead remain present regardless.

Faeries as the dead and ancestors:

Africa, Asia, Oceania, and Polynesia

While typically more malicious than European Little People, the Islamic *djinn* closely correspond to faeries, casting spells, replacing children with changelings, and shapeshifting, sometimes into spirits of the dead.[661] Though the Qur'an denies ghosts' existence, pre-Islamic belief systems in the Middle East connected the djinn to "spirits of ancient people."[662] Persia's *peris* disappeared into djinn tradition, but originally presaged death by filling homes with music and feasting to "welcome the newcomer" to their world.[663]

In South Africa, the Xhosa hold a robust set of beliefs surrounding *abantu bomlambo,* who are at once fishtailed river spirits and ancestors.[664] Bush spirits are distinct from ancestors to Nigeria's Wawa, but both are "described as wind, they are both represented by masks, they live in the same places, they are responsible for the same kind of disorders, and they have the same powers (both answer prayers addressed to ancestors)."[665]

Botswana's Hambukushu people believe in *harumba*, monkeylike "ghost spirits" turned from corpses into "malicious fairies."[666] The

mischievous, dwarfen *Mmortsia* are the diminutive spirits of humans in West African Akan belief.[667] Both harumba and Mmortsia bear rear-facing feet. They share this attribute with creatures elsewhere, including various faeries and the Aztec psychopomp Xolotl. Some folklorists believe these backwards feet symbolize "the process of return or resurrection."[668]

In Asia, Ladakh's Buddhist Dards tell of a "ghost-cum-fairy called *sMon-mo*," a young girl who tempts shepherds to their doom.[669] Russian *domovoye* "take on the form of a recently-departed male ancestor of the family,"[670] part of broader traditions surrounding household spirits like Scottish *brownies*.[671]

(Returning to Europe for a moment, note that brownies appear as children or tiny simians, sometimes the souls of those murdered in the house, still sporting death wounds.[672] All household spirits may originate in Roman *lares*, ancestral home guardians with a psychopomp pedigree: they were conceived by Mercury *en route* to the underworld.)[673]

Some compare the *alcheringa* of Australian aboriginal lore to both ancestors and faeries.[674] Elsewhere in the Pacific, Fijians attribute natural processes like rainfall to *veli,* short ancestral spirits.[675] Polynesia's *menehune* and *kakamora* blur lines between small non-human spirits and ancestors.[676] The Nightmarchers, a spectral

vanguard of ancestral warriors, mirror Ireland's trooping faeries by parading nightly through Hawaiian forests.[677]

Faeries as the dead and ancestors:

The Pre-Columbian New World

A legend tells how two *nûñnë'hï* (faeries), appearing human and identifying as Cherokee, invited the people of the *Käna'sta* settlement to join them in their underground kingdom, free from war and illness. The realm was accessible through a giant stone door in the side of Pilot Mountain near Brevard, North Carolina, and only those who fasted could enter.[678] The refugees agreed, and Käna'sta became known as "the Lost Settlement," the only village to escape the impending suffering at the hands of the white men.[679]

Nûñnë'hï are sometimes "referred to as the spirits of deceased Indians who carry on their old way of life not far from the living people."[680] As seen throughout this and future chapters, the nûñnë'hï share so many attributes with Old World faeries we are faced with but two possibilities: Cherokee legends were irrevocably contaminated by European belief, or both cultures described a genuine phenomenon independently.

Other indigenous New World cultures roughly equating faeries and the dead include the Paiute (*mukwitch*, "dead ones"), Gros Ventre

("ghost" dwarfs), Blackfoot ("Little Ghost People"), Caddo ("lost people in the thickets"), Inuit (*tupilaq* and *tarneq*, reanimated corpses or an aspect of the soul), Tukano (*wax-ti* ghosts), Comanche ("little men" ghosts), Ojibwe (lost souls turned into "little people"), and Oglala (*yuwipi,* ancestors or animal spirits).[681]

Unsaved & Unshriven

Anglo-Saxons held executions at prehistoric monuments—fae folk dwellings—to which new corpses were added, "influenced by the wish for the criminal to be tormented in the afterlife by the evil spirits which dwelt in the mound."[682] (If that isn't cruel and unusual punishment, what is?) Oftentimes these souls endured in the immediate area, mortal identities fading from memory as they evolved into something else. One's character defined the type of spirit they became, with some evil dead metamorphosing in local lore from negative spirits to bad faeries, then devils.[683] Even when not directly derived from the dead, Scots sometimes divided faeries into "good" and "bad" factions (*Seelie* and *Unseelie* Courts), vaguely paralleling moralistic interpretations of the afterlife.[684]

"Whether all that die go among them I can't say," wrote Irish folklorist Lady Gregory, paraphrasing a Connemara woman, "but it is said they can take no one without the touch of a Christian hand, or the want of a blessing from a Christian that would be noticing them."[685] Some faeries are obviously the heroic dead, while others were variously sinners[686] or came from "bad deaths," those lacking last rites, neither saved nor damned but doomed to haunt the

land.[687] As Wirt Sikes noted, this fits some descriptions of Welsh faeries, the *Tylwyth Teg* ("Fair Family"), but unless tested, it was unclear whether one had met "a fairy or a spectre."[688]

Unbaptized children fell into this "unsaved" category. Whenever the church rejected lost souls, the fae folk welcomed them with open arms. The time between birth and baptism was highly liminal, the child born into the world but not yet born into the church. As such, these babes were ripe for the taking.

In Lowland Scotland and Somerset, unchristened infants who died reappeared as "small white moths" or *spunkies*, called *pisgies* in Western England. "Pisgie" reflects the Cornish *pixie* or *pistie*, which were also imagined as unbaptized children, faeries, or both.[689] In addition to those who died unbaptized, children who were murdered, miscarried, or stillborn might wind up among the faeries, answering to many names: *taran* in northeast Scotland,[690] the *mamuny* or birdlike *navky* in Slavic countries,[691] *angelitos* in post-colonial Latin America,[692] *ogre, rain,* or *water babies* among Native American tribes.[693]

The motif expresses itself in global occultism. In Thailand, anyone lacking a household spirit might enlist a black magician to fashion a *kuman thong*, a "sanctified young boy," from a human fetus.[694]

Dead, unbaptized children also serve households of magicians in the French Alps.[695]

That children so readily assimilate into faerie ranks is unsurprising. Their proportions resemble the Little People's dimensions, and children seem more closely connected to the Otherworld than adults —their souls are "freshly minted," as it were.

Jung felt children remained "in the collective unconscious until they acquire a small consciousness of their personality, until they say 'I,' or 'me,' or their name."[696] Though dismissed as adolescent imagination run amok, children report greater instances of psychic abilities and humanoid sightings, including faeries.

"Small children often have a high degree of ESP, but as they grow older and develop reason—and skepticism—and their minds become more disciplined to the material world around them, these powers seem to slip away," wrote Keel. "It is probable that small children make excellent contactee material because of these factors, and that may explain why so much UFO, ghost, and poltergeist activity seems to surround children."[697]

Don’t follow the lights

Dead-infants-cum-faeries go hand-in-hand with anomalous orbs of light, commonly called “faerie lights,” “ghost lights,” or *will-o'-the-wisps*.

“The Catholic Church used to believe that the orbs of light so often reported were souls that were on fire, thus suffering,” wrote Whitley Strieber. “They were free to roam, which suggested that they weren’t trapped in hell. So the conclusion was that they were souls in purgatory.”

Spunkies, Wendish *blud*,[698] and Finnish *liekkö* all represent unchristened children in the form of dancing mystery lights.[699] The Alpine goddess *Perchta*—whose name, from Old High German *pergan*, reveals Herzog’s “shrouded” death motif—is sometimes identified as “a leader of the souls of the dead,” counting among her retinue the *heimchin* .[700] These followers are identified either as dogs or ghost lights representing the souls of unbaptized children.[701] (Note that *heimchen* is German for “cricket,” recalling the insectine sounds witnesses report at the onset of their experiences.)

In 1987 English scholar Peter Alderson Smith described seeing faerie lights:

> At night, particularly in November, lights often travel along these paths and hover over the sidhe [fairy mounds]. They sometimes move in formation. They may be all white, or they may be of different colours—'red, green, blue, yellow.' A very old gentleman from Collrai, Co. Sligo…. tells me that the lights move rapidly*, and I have myself seen white lights moving at high speed up the side of Ben Bulben,* a mountain renowned for this phenomenon. These lights have been known in Ireland since antiquity. In 'The Colloquy with the Ancients' Bodh Derg refers to Brugh na Boinne as 'yonder brugh chequered with the many lights hard by you here'… They are genuine phenomena, but no scientific explanation has been found for them.'[702]

Ghost lights, alternately referred to as "orbs," are still seen today, especially on haunted properties, burial sites, and other faerie locales. They appear in literally every culture, associated with sorcerers, witches, dragons, devils, and—even when not dead children specifically—ghosts or faeries. The djinn, for example, were conceptualized as "smokeless fire."[703] Ghost lights overlap significantly with UFO sightings, covered later.

Ghost lights also carry a universal warning: do not follow them. It's a bad idea. You will wind up lost or dead. *Chota admis*, ghost

lights in Darjeeling, India, are "thought to be the lanterns of the Little Men," and chasing them "is to court illness and death."[704] Will-o'-the-wisps across European folklore should never, ever be pursued. In Germany for example, glowing orbs allow themselves to be spotted before drifting off… any pursuers become horribly lost, and the light disappears.[705]

Our Halloween "Jack O-Lanterns" are named after ghost lights, though the exact origin varies: in the oft-repeated Irish legend "Stingy Jack," a trickster convinces the Devil to transform into a coin to pay a drinking tab. Leaving the bar, Jack simply pockets it. Unable to collect his soul after death, the Devil traps Jack between Heaven and Hell, wandering the earth with "a single burning ember" to light his way, carried inside a hollow turnip.[706] Similar legends interchange the turnip for a candle or lantern.

Ghost lights foretell death, their number, size, and color sometimes corresponding to the number of victims, their age, and sex, respectively. In Wales, white lights signified female deaths, red male deaths.[707]

"The corpse candle, or *canwyll corph*, was a light like that of a candle, which was said to issue from the house where a death was about to occur, and take the course of the funeral procession to the burial place," wrote Owen of Welsh ghost lights. "This was the usual

way of proceeding, but this mysterious light was also thought to wend its way to the abode of a person about to die."[708] Ghost lights' affinity for "corpse roads" is shared not only with the ankou, but also trooping faeries: as small lights, the Tylwyth Teg "never fail going the way that the Corps will go to be buried."[709]

The association of ghost lights with death stretches far beyond Ireland and the British Isles, into Iberia and across the Atlantic.[710] "Amongst the Indians of New England, and the Eskimo, lights seen on the roofs of their wigwams and huts portend death," wrote M.J. Walhouse. "Lights seem everywhere associated with death. Mahommedans place lamps in small triangular recesses made in the heads of their tombs. The custom of *chapelles ardentes* may have had some such origin."[711] Flames and lanterns carved upon grave monuments carry on this tradition today.[712]

Despite regional discrepancies, despite "faerie's" catch-all nature as a descriptor, their connection to the dead is universal. These connections are deep—*subterranean*, in fact.

In Otherworlds

Every culture's afterlife corresponds to another culture's Fairyland: alternate dimensions, the sky, a distant isle, underwater, a faraway western land, or, of course, the underworld. Mountains in pagan belief commonly housed the dead in a sort of "second life," so Fairyland hid beneath hills, ancient fortresses, or prehistoric burial sites.[713] This magical realm was accessed via holes, caves, tunnels, moveable boulders, or by "simply passing through the solid earth, as fairies were sometimes seen to do."[714]

Caverns were Fairyland entrances not only for Celts, but cultures on literally every inhabited continent. Among the West African Dagara, *kontomblé* are two-foot tall, red creatures with gigantic genitals who pay respects whenever a powerful medicine man dies. Appearing weak, they are in fact "the strongest, most intelligent beings God ever created." Their world, *Kontonteg*, is accessible by caves, but these are strictly illusory: their realm is "far bigger than our Earth, yet very difficult to locate in our time and space."[715]

While some stories portray dank caverns, most describe Fairyland as a beautiful mirror of our world, a land of endless summer holding lush hills and resplendent palaces. Celtic Fairyland often is

"exceedingly fair, green, and pleasant, although also usually said to be in a perpetual twilight," wrote faerie scholar Morgan Daimler.[716] In the folktale *Elidor and the Golden Ball*, the protagonist follows "two little men… through a road, at first, subterraneous and dark, into a most beautiful country, very much embellished with rivers and meads, woods and plains, nevertheless obscure, and not brightened with the open light of the sun."[717] Other stories portray "gorgeous gardens," "a great city with large houses where all the people never seemed to lack anything," or "great halls… full of treasure and jewels."[718]

In short, Fairyland corresponds with startling specificity not only to afterlife *locations* but afterlife *descriptions*, particularly those seen in NDEs. One NDEr so fondly recalled "some kind of fairyland" from her childhood NDE that she "rode her tricycle *down the steep basement stairs* thinking it would somehow get [her] back into the light [author's emphasis]."[719]

Even minutiae are shared. Sometimes Fairyland has "no sun, moon, or stars" and springs gushing blood, perhaps a boundary demarcating their world from ours, like the expanse of blood from the Scottish balled *Thomas Rhymer*. Recall the red river from Shawn's afterlife in Chapter 1.[720] The image is appropriately Biblical, recalling how the Nile flooded with blood in Exodus, or the bloody waterways of Revelation.

"After natural death human souls might find themselves in fairyland," wrote historian Emma Wilby. "Alternatively, living humans taken into or visiting the fairy realm could find themselves unwilling or unable to leave, resulting in the death of the mortal body."[721]

To that end, some directly equate Fairyland and the afterlife, or at least hold the former as "a mytho-poetic discourse" regarding the latter.[722] For instance, a Breton maiden of legend, wielding a wand, opened a portal to "Fairyland as a world of the dead," where she married a deceased priest. Early English poets frequently combined Fairyland with Hades, exemplified in medieval retellings of the Orpheus myth.[723]

Both faeries and the dead might be encountered on sacred days including Beltane, Midsummer, and around Samhain, today called Halloween.[724] On these days, the veil between worlds thins.

"In Celtic mythology the date of Samhain [Halloween] is often invested with the notion of transition or passage [liminality], for this is the moment when the beings from the Beyond pay a visit to mortals," wrote Philippe Walter. "Samhain thus corresponds to a period that favors communication with the *sid*, the Otherworld of Celtic tradition."[725]

While an *Otherworld* to the Irish, Fairyland was not the *afterlife*; the concepts are "close but not synonymous."[726] Celts speculated numerous realms existed besides Fairyland and Earth, frequented by humans and spirits alike: a westerly island Otherworld called *Mag Mell*, or Plain of Happiness, where select individuals gain immortality; a Land Beneath the Waves, *Tir fá Thuinn*; and various Otherworlds "adjacent to and co-extensive with this world… sometimes a kingdom but frequently a four-cornered castle (sometimes of glass) that magically appears and vanishes."[727]

As outlined in texts like the *Mabinogion*, the Welsh Otherworld *Annwfn* overlays our own landscape, its denizens and environment coexisting both in our world and the Otherworld without apparent contradiction.[728] Spence speciously suggested the Celts invented their Otherworlds to segregate the souls of vanquished foes from those of their victors, but this ignores their complexity.[729]

Writes Lecouteux:

> For the ancient Celts, the beyond was a pleasant land that bore a variety of names: *Tír na n-Óg* (Land of the Young), *Tír na mBéo* (Land of the Living), and *Tír Sorcha* (The Shining Land), among others. This is not a kingdom of the dead, as these names clearly indicate. Yet the historian Procopius of Caesarea (ca. 500–565 CE) informs us that the souls of the dead were transported to [the mythological Isle of the Blessed] Brittia…

> The most famous of these isles is that of Avalon (the Apple Orchard) where King Arthur was taken.[730]

Irish souls first visit Tech Duinn (Bull Rock) off the coast of County Cork to sojourn with *Donn*, God of Death and Faerie King of the *aos sídhe*. From there they continue to their final destination. Donn is held either as a "primordial ancestor" or deity.[731] "Donn is in many ways very similar to Odin in that Donn is a leader of the dead, is the god of wind and storms, and is connected with many hills," wrote Richard P. Taylor.[732]

Thomas Rhymer, mentioned above, exemplifies the ambiguous destination of the dead in Celtic cosmology. The "Queen of Elfland" shows Thomas a narrow road to heaven, a broad road to hell, and a "bonny road… to fair Elfland."[733] Another tale presents *five* roads, indicating the Otherworld's pluralism.[734] In Plato's *Gorgias,* such afterlife crossroads symbolize judgment: souls find themselves at the juncture of two intersecting paths, awaiting a verdict that will either send them toward the Isles of the Blessed or infernal Tartarus.[735]

Medieval Christians, having demonized faeries, would posit *Thomas Rhymer*'s third road led to Purgatory, an unpleasant "in-between" realm for purifying souls before entering Heaven. Sure enough, some European fae folk seem desperate to receive Christian

redemption. Faeries told one Irish traveler, "We are the Chlann Sighe, and wish you to declare that at the last day our lot may not be with Satan. Say that the Savior died for us as well as for you."[736] Quebec *lutins*, imported from France, were occasionally identified as human souls languishing in purgatory.[737]

"Theologians identified fairyland with either hell or purgatory," wrote Wilby, even though "the fairy realm… bore far more resemblance to the underworld (and, less frequently, the upper world) of the tribal shaman than it did to the lower worlds of the Christian cosmology."[738]

Despite the church's attempts otherwise, the Irish laity rejected this conflation: "All go among [faeries] when they die except the old people," an informant told Lady Gregory, "And it's better to be there than in the pains of Purgatory."[739] Setting aside the Christian interpretation's accuracy, conflating Fairyland with Purgatory is at least consistent with folklore describing faeries as the unshriven.

Dining in Dreamland

Purgatory eventually became a physical location. According to legend, St. Patrick, doubtlessly influenced by pre-Christian legends, claimed Christ showed him the realm's entrance: an island cave in Ireland's sacred Lough Derg.[740]

The knight of *Owayne Miles* enters a Fairyland version of St. Patrick's Purgatory containing a "mystic bridge which when crossed guarantees the traveler against evil spirits, just as in Ireland a peasant believes himself safe when fairies are pursuing him if he can only cross a bridge or stream." The tale also includes a "celestial city… like the Christian Heaven and the *Sidhe* [faerie] world" and "angel food."[741]

After eating this food, the knight "had no desire to return to earth," embodying the long-held taboo against consuming food in Fairyland. Visitors found themselves trapped in the realm forever if they consumed it. In Spence's words, "to eat of food proffered binds one to the giver... the eater partakes of the nature of his host."[742] In Brittany, where faeries and the dead strongly conflate, anyone offered food by the departed "will never be able to return among the

living."[743] Those eating food of the dead accept communion with them, joining their community.

The myth that taking Otherworldly food leads to imprisonment is widespread. Many scholars claim it originates in the Persephone myth, but the motif arose independently in cultures worldwide, including the New World and Oceania. For instance, a woman from a Māori story claimed she was ferried to a village filled with welcoming ancestors after dying; her deceased father warned her against touching any food they offered before returning her to life.[744]

In Wales, the food taboo may relate to the practice of *sin eating*, where individuals acquire the sins of the deceased by eating a ritual meal, removing their transgressions. If faeries in Fairyland are actually souls in Purgatory—a contentious interpretation—then food exchange narratives viewed through sin eater tradition become desperate escape attempts: the food becomes a vector for the offeror to transfer their sins to the consumer and thus move on to redemption.

"The Green Children of Woolpit," a brother-sister pair, allegedly surfaced in Suffolk around the early 12th century. Villagers discovered the children—speaking an unknown language, strangely garbed, and green-skinned—beside a hole in the ground (a wolf pit dug for

hunting). After learning English, the children explained they hailed from a faraway land, where they consumed only legumes.

The Green Children "seem far from being ghosts, yet the land they came from, St. Martin's Land, bears some resemblance to a country of the dead," Briggs wrote: subterranean, sunless, moonless, bathed in twilight, accessed via cave. "It is to be noticed, too, that the habitual food of the children was beans, the food of the dead."[745]

The bean-dead association originates in ancient Greece, perhaps inspired by the food's *levodopa* content, which in significant doses causes insomnia, nightmares, and even waking hallucinations (fussy eaters, feel free to add this excuse to your repertoire). Beans, in fact, may have once been deliberately used to contact the dead via altered states of consciousness and prophetic dreams.[746] Fairyland is likely not a physical location, but rather this altered state.

"In medieval belief the Otherworld could be reached in a person's dreams," wrote Daimler. "Indeed, it is not an uncommon belief even into the modern period that [Fairyland] can be reached in dreams and trances…."[747]

We have always connected sleep to death (a relationship explored in Chapter 6). Before our "eternal rest" we are "dead to the world" tens of thousands of nights. Dreams represent the astral plane, where our souls wander and interact with the Other: apparitions

appear during sleep paralysis, haunted houses come alive at night, aliens snatch us from bed, ghosts appear in dreams.

Dreams offer prophecy, divination, and a communication channel with the Higher Self. In Australian aboriginal studies, "The Dreaming" refers to an ancestral Otherworld detached from time, a Fairyland "everywhen" inseparable from the creation of the universe. NDEs are often compared to dreams, albeit much more vivid. Waking paranormal encounters—sometimes repressed and remembered *as* dreams—exhibit dream logic in the form of High Strangeness. Kenneth Ring believed discontinuities like those found in dreams (e.g. "the next thing I knew," "suddenly I found myself") constituted integral signifiers of numinous experiences.[748]

Faeries like the *sandman*, French *la dormette,* and German *pechamnderlin* controlled sleep in folklore. When faeries tried to kidnap her baby, one Irish mother tried rousing her husband, but "all she could do wouldn't waken" him. Witnesses in ghost, alien, and even Bigfoot stories drift asleep in the most harrowing circumstances, or fail to awaken their bed partner. After observing "five spindly entities with skinny bodies and big black eyes" through his bedroom window, Mike Clelland remembered his "response to this frightening image was to nonchalantly lay my head down on the pillow and promptly fall back asleep."[749]

"In dreams we go amongst them, and play with them, and combat with them," wrote Yeats of the fae folk. "They are, perhaps, human souls in the crucible—these creatures of whim."[750]

Near-death Fairyland

The drowned body of Patrick Noan, a County Sligo priest, was miraculously resuscitated by his brother Dominick, also a clergyman. Father Dominick read from his breviary then whistled three times, after which "Father Patrick's spirit appeared in the doorway" and entered his body. "Where were you when I whistled the first time?" Dominick inquired.

"I was at a hurling match with the *gentry* on Mulloughmore strand," replied Patrick. At the second, "I was coming over Corrick Fadda," a forest on the southern coast, "and when you whistled the third time I was here at the door."

Father Patrick preached for years following his near-death experience. His allusion to the "gentry" is notable; while the historical record presents few faerie-related NDEs recognizable by modern definition, a wealth of NDE-like stories come from people who were "taken," suffering long-term illnesses and comas blamed on the fae folk. Even in the absence of trauma, other faerie encounters include features common to NDEs.

- **Sound.** Humming or buzzing often precedes faerie sightings. The Fairy Investigation Society (FIS) Census, compiled by Simon Young, is *stuffed* with modern descriptions: "a high pitch buzz type noise," "humming (frequencies) that harmonize," etc. Though sometimes attributed to faerie wings, such noises occur in their absence.[751]

During an infamous 1645 Cornish case, Anne Jefferies was "taken," losing consciousness and suffering convulsions from which she did not fully recover until the following year.[752] When Jefferies awoke, she claimed she'd been away with the faeries, who sent her back amid "strange noises… as if a thousand flies were buzzing around her."[753] Curiously, Greco-Roman ghosts issued "a thin, high-pitched, continuous, plaintive, and mournful sound" compared to squeaking wheels or tweeting birds,[754] their voices eerily similar to some faerie voice descriptions.[755]

Yet many NDEs are marked by a conspicuous *silence*, according to Jeffrey Long.[756] This eerie aspect resembles the "Oz Factor," a term coined by British Ufologist Jenny Randles, in which paranormal witnesses (especially of UFOs) notice complete silence: no ambient noise, no birdsong, no wind, suggesting a "cocoon" effect wherein the witness(es) solely experience anomalies.[757] We are reminded of the colloquial "silence of the grave," or the fact that one of the Jewish underworlds, Sheol, was a realm of silence.[758]

The Oz Factor appeared in a 2000 Welsh sighting of two, three-foot tall, golden, winged faeries in a garden—"Didn't hear any sounds, it was eerily quiet"—and a 1990s case. After separating from his sister in a forest, an Arkansas boy and his dog were approached by a luminous, blonde-haired lady wearing "a long, white dress." "There was no noise of crunching leaves or anything. It was completely silent and still. The birds and wind didn't

even make a sound." When the boy glanced at his dog, the lady vanished.[759]

- **Sense of peace.** Though often frightening, fae folk encounters can include "a sense of calm and peace," as a 1970s Devon witness put it. In the 2010s, an Oregon Forestry Service worker frequently smoked marijuana in a secluded clearing until one day the underbrush started moving—although initially frightened, "an unexplainable peace" washed over him, and he saw a little man, solid green, four-fingered, noseless, with pointed ears, a teardrop-shaped head, and black eyes (calm down, skeptics: other, sober contact later occurred).[760]

- **Inaccessible knowledge.** On their travels to Fairyland, seers like cunning men/women and faerie doctors asked its clairvoyant denizens for advice. These individuals often derived wisdom and powers of prophecy from their time among faeries.[761]

- **Levitation/OBE.** As noted, even wingless faeries fly, sometimes using this power to kidnap. Jefferies "became blind, and felt herself whirled through the air at a great rate" by her abductors. Witches also traveled with faeries through the air.[762]

- **Tunnel experience.** Jefferies's faerie abduction loosely matches Raymond Moody's description of the tunnel experience. Moreover, paths to Fairyland involve subterranean tunnels, perhaps inspired by *souterrains*—long passageways, some over 100 meters, used for storage, hiding, and escape—found beneath Iron Age ringforts and monuments, traditionally

regarded as fae folk dwellings and Otherworld access points. Similar corridors penetrate "passage tombs," earth- or rock-covered Neolithic burial chambers equally associated with ghosts, faeries, and anomalous lights.[763]

- **Bright light.** Fairyland's twilight contradicts the bright light seen during NDEs, but faerie lore is filled with other light phenomena. Witnesses say ghost/faerie lights and even UFOs are "different from the normal bright lights they encounter in their daily life," reminding us of the indescribable illumination during NDEs.[764] A literal "light at the end of the tunnel" appeared in a souterrain beneath a County Galway "fairy liss," rumored to house "Jack the Lanthorn" (Jack O-Lantern).[765]

- **Landscapes.** As discussed, Fairyland resembles the pastoral scenery from NDEs and Moody's "cities of light."

- **Enhanced perception.** An Oxfordshire witness regularly saw an 18-inch tall, "shambling" figure in grey around dawn during the summer of 1980. Each time she described "an acute awareness of the natural sounds around [her]."[766]

- **Interiors.** Caves appear both in NDEs and travels to Fairyland. Some Irish colloquially refer to passage cairns as "caves," and Otherworld portals lie within certain caverns.[767] Some tales feature magical ointment which, when rubbed in the eyes, reveals Fairyland as but "a big rough cave, with water oozing over the edges of the stones."[768] In the myth of

King Herla, the eponymous hero is invited into a cavernous dwarfen lair lit "not from the sun or moon, but from a multitude of lamps."[769]

- **Supernatural lapses of time**. The Herla myth contains an early example of Fairyland's abnormal passage of time. Despite a perceived absence of three days, centuries had passed in the mortal world, confirmed when one of Herla's company dismounted and, touching the earth, crumbled into dust—"time takes back its rights and does its work," Lecouteux wrote. This motif, identical to Ufology's "missing time" trope covered later, consistently features in Otherworld visits: anyone entering faerie spaces—their dwellings, or even their dancing rings—risks returning years later.[770] In one Scottish tale, a newlywed groom *en route* to in-laws slipped into a roadside faerie-dwelling, vanishing for two generations. "The township in which his bride's house used to be was depopulated and in ruins for upwards of twenty years, but to him the time had seemed only a few hours; and he was just as fresh and youthful as when he went in the fairy-dwelling."[771]

Tales describe one of three temporal misalignments: days, months, even years pass in the Otherworld, while little or no time elapses in our reality; little or no time passes *there*, while years, even centuries elapse *here*; and a handful of minutes among the fae folk are revealed to be "any length of time up to a year and a day"[772] (a duration perhaps referencing Leap Years or "Teltown Marriages," wherein couples married 366 days could divorce by entering and exiting a County Meath faerie fort).[773]

While NDE time perception usually corresponds to the first variant, tales of the second variety "suggest that faerieland is the world of the dead, immune from the passage of time, and that return to the world of the living

is not possible as the mortal body has aged and decayed in line with the physical laws of this world," according to Rushton.[774]

The motif isn't exclusively European: a Zulu man, after chasing "an ugly little hairy man" to the land of the dead, returned to find he was "given up for dead himself," his belongings disposed of by his wife, his neighbors "shout[ing] the funeral dirge" when they saw him.[775] In Japan, similar temporal distortions occur in interactions with mischievous supernatural beings called *tengu*, reincarnated spirits of the arrogant and proud equally fond of abduction as European faeries.[776]

Missing time in any encounter almost always implies *travel* into an Otherworld space, even when the journey remains unremembered. This might explain why time in "mundane" faerie, ghost, and UFO sightings—those at a distance—passes normally, while more intimate encounters are marked by amnesia.

Missing time features in only a handful of ghost stories. These are more accurately deemed "time slips." In one example from John Janaway's *Ghosts of Surrey,* a visitor *en route* to Merry Hall, home to the late writer Beverley Nichols, experienced 20 minutes of missing time, claiming to have stepped back into the past. Details of her experience—which recreated the final hours of a previous Merry Hall owner—were corroborated using an 1895 map of the area.[777]

A ghost hunt near Charlotte, North Carolina contains hints of a supernatural time lapse. Chuck Carte "noticed absolutely nothing out of the ordinary" while investigating paranormal activity at a gas station overnight, at least until he returned home. "After the investigation, while maintaining equipment, I noticed that every piece of equipment I brought to the scene suddenly had corroded batteries and no longer functioned," he said. While

Carte noticed no missing time, the scene had been eerily quiet, and new batteries simply do not corrode overnight.[778]

Folktales of missing years likely exaggerated shorter durations. An attendee at a May 2009 County Donegal shamanic workshop suffered a restless first night, feeling someone tug the nape of her neck and vaguely recalling a "wee being" creeping the rafters. At dawn, she saw a small, winged, armed light flickering near the ceiling, confirmed by her roommate. They watched it moving from one wooden beam to another "for a few minutes"—but experienced "missing time of about one hour," and couldn't recall how the figure left the cottage.[779]

Time feels especially malleable in dreams, where hours pass in perceived minutes, or vice versa. Time stops when we die. Seeking wisdom, Classical mystics like Pythagoras and Aristeas disappeared for centuries in the underworld, yet emerged alive; Epimenides remained youthful until age 300 because he slept in the Idaean cave for 57 years.[780]

- **Love.** Spirits take keen interest in human sexuality, even producing hybrid offspring. Ancient Mesopotamia's seductive demons evolved into *incubi* and *succubi*, and even the Church espoused "bridal theology," wherein communion with Christ was compared to wedlock.

Equally preoccupied, faeries commonly kidnapped or seduced humans for marriage and interbreeding. The fae folk "sometimes were identified with particular dead women; yet they also could rejoin the living and even give birth." In the early 1200s, Gervase of Tilbury claimed, "some men have become lovers of larvas [ghosts] of this kind, which they call fays. And when they have transferred their loyalties toward marriage with other women, they die."[781]

No NDE checklist mentions "spirit coitus," but it can appear. A stabbing victim's October 11, 1998 NDE featured a sexless, ageless being, neither "living nor dead," who goaded him into passionate—yet "evil"—lovemaking.[782] The French expression *la petite mort* ("the little death") compares post-orgasm consciousness to death; according to Herzog, amorous elves embody the seductive power of the "Death-Bride" archetype.[783]

- **Music.** The fae folk play "music that mortal man never heard the like," described by Evans Wentz's informants as "wondrous, grand, finest," and "most beautiful."[784] Identical sounds fill modern faerie sightings, NDEs, and ancient Indian, Chinese, and Mesoamerican funereal texts.[785]

- **Beings.** NDEs can feature faeries, remembered dead appear in Fairyland, faeries take the form of "light beings," and Faerie Kings and Queens are "often beings who we know were once Gods."[786]

- **Ultimatum.** While rarely presented as a literal "stay or leave" decision, "those who go willingly to [Fairyland] must adhere to specific prohibitions to stay there," Daimler wrote. In one Pembrokeshire tale, a young lad joined a faerie dance and was taken to their realm. He "lived there happily for years, under the single prohibition that he not drink from a fountain in the center of a garden. When he finally did so he was immediately returned to mortal Earth, where he realized only a few minutes had passed."[787]

- **Amnesia.** Although not specifically a faerie story, one retelling of Ireland's Cúchulainn myth sees the hero forget his Otherworld love affair with Manannán's wife after the god offers a "drink of forgetfulness" similar to Greek lethe.[788]

- **Healing, new abilities, and spiritual awakenings.** English witch trial testimony mentions a faerie hill where ill visitors could ask a Faerie Queen for a miraculous "white healing powder."[789] Mystics often obtained their healing abilities from faeries, who also directly treated the afflicted: for instance, the Croatian folksong "Peter Kovačevič in Bela Krajina" features a wounded knight healed by a faerie.[790]

A Welshman once claimed Fairyland was a world "quite unlike ours, and mortals taken to it by [the Tylwyth Teg] were changed in nature."[791] Seers gained magical abilities like perceiving spirits, predicting the future, influencing events, and healing from their time among faeries. William Berry, a Rutland cunning man, "invoked a healing fairy by breathing into a woman's mouth."[792] Jefferies famously became a faith healer and clairvoyant after her abduction. In 1586, Alesoun Pearson received "a salve that could cure every disease" after returning from Scottish Fairyland.[793]

It was common for church-oriented abductees to join the clergy following their faerie-induced spiritual awakenings.[794] Others experienced post-NDE-like depression: a man from a Danish legend drank wine from the *elle-maids*, but spent his remaining days despondent and eager to return to them.[795]

- **Poltergeist phenomena.** Poltergeist phenomena were blamed equally on ghosts and faeries. Household spirits and fae folk alike moved objects,

rapped on walls and roofs, misplaced objects, threw stones, generated apports, levitated people and objects, and inflicted invisible blows, pinches, and general abuse.[796] Cherokee *Yûñ'wi Tsunsdi'* slam doors, take food, and exhibit a fondness for silverware, pots, and pans, which they move and misplace.[797]

While electrical interference appears infrequently among faerie abductees, many historical trips to Fairyland predate electricity. Notably, faeries themselves sometimes cause malfunctions: during a 1577 storm a black faerie dog appeared in a Bungay, Suffolk church, leaving two people dead, one crippled, the church door scratched, and its clock "twisted and broken."[798]

More recently, a Staffordshire family's car engine died one morning in December 1975 for no apparent reason. After checking under the hood, the father returned to his seat. That's when three, hideous, hook-nosed "trolls" slowly, deliberately approached from the trees: "But that's all we remember. The next, it's all gone; nothing. Neither of us remembers seeing them go, and the next thing it was about two o'clock and the car started fine, then."[799]

Notably, life reviews rarely appear in trips to Fairyland—but neither do they feature in every NDE. An honest examination of these shared data points between Otherworld travels and NDEs reveals they are *related*, if not *identical*, states of altered consciousness by which we penetrate the ecology of souls.

Markers on the land

As mentioned, faeries most commonly reside in natural landmarks like glens, hills, mountains, lakes, etc. They also favor Neolithic monuments. This distinction might clarify which beings hold nature spirit status and which more closely align with the dead (though plenty spirits-of-place are human ghosts).[800] Across Europe, cairns—similar to the herms of Hermes—belonged to faeries, no matter how small. Some served as grave markers, and disturbing them incurred faeries' anger. In Ireland, a stone often commemorated any spot where someone met an untimely end, to which respectful passerby added additional rocks.[801]

Many man-made faerie sites are sepulchral places like barrows, burial mounds, passage tombs, grave cairns, cemeteries, and graveyards, all clearly connected with interment. Others were simply sites of human habitation or worship, like stone circles, standing stones (*menhirs*), or Iron Age ringforts, called faerie forts, forths, hillforts, *dúns*, *lisses*, *ráths*, or *lios* in Ireland. Human hands unambiguously erected these structures, yet at some point faeries "moved in"—or, like a haunted house, their inhabitants never left.

"In Cornwall the 'spriggans,' or elves, haunt only those standing stones which are associated with sepulture," wrote Spence. "Those fairies who exhibit the closest resemblance to the dead are naturally of that type who haunt, or are supposed to reside in, the burial mound, the tumulus, the stone circle, or the isolated standing-stone."[802]

Even when not originally intended for burials, any settlement is a site of conflict, murder, and heartbreak, with remains doubtlessly buried nearby. Moreover, some non-sepulchral sites gained associations with the dead over time as burials accrued. Though especially prominent in Europe, deeming ancient structures portals to the Otherworld populated by faerie-like beings is an international constant (Chapter 8).

Some believed cemeteries and graveyards held only corpses, while *souls* went to nearby faerie hills. Orcadian witch Katherine Jonesdochter claimed to see "the trows (trolls, or fairies) rise out of the kirkyard… and on the hill called Greinfall."[803] In Scandinavia, the first body buried (or, in older times, sacrificed) became "the tutelary spirit of the place," sometimes called its *kirkrå.*[804] Drawing upon psychopomp symbolism, Slavonians buried a horse in the churchyard to serve the same purpose.[805]

Faeries also lurk about more recent burials. In the modern era, FIS member Marjorie Johnson collected numerous sightings of Little People in cemeteries.[806] A Pontrhydfendigaid (Wales) resident told Evans Wentz:

> My grandfather told me that he was once in a certain field and heard singing in the air, and thought it spirits singing. Soon afterwards he and his brother in digging dikes in that field dug into a big hole, which they entered and followed to the end. There they found a place full of human bones and urns, and naturally decided on account of the singing that the bones and urns were of the *Tylwyth Teg.*[807]

Unmarked famine graves called "hungry grass" were associated with bad luck in Ireland, unleashing death omens in the form of weakness and sharp hunger pangs to those who dared tread; others claimed these patches signified where people had eaten, but failed to offer food to the faeries.[808] Here we see a mixture of beliefs surrounding disturbing graves and trespassing in faerie areas. The buried famine victim sometimes represented *fear gorta* ("hungry man"), a faerie-ghost which travels roads begging for food.[809]

Because both manifest poltergeists, it can be difficult to determine whether hauntings involve ghosts or faeries. Abandoned houses or

burial grounds in South America may invite faeries like Bolivia's *anchanchu*, Brazil's *yurupari,* and Colombia's *uahtí*.[810] In 1853, Edward Bulwer mused how entities conjured at séances "profess to be spirits of the dead, but I much doubt, supposing they are spirits at all, whether they are not rather brownies or fairies. They are never to be relied on for accurate answers, though sometimes they were wonderfully so, just like clairvoyants."[811] Like hauntings, faerie "lives" can last centuries, millennia, or indefinitely.

A 1983 Somerville, Massachusetts haunting featured poltergeist phenomena, inexplicable basement floods, sensations of dread, and "a feeling of a presence at night… almost like an animal, as though it had claws or wanted to bite me." The resident's suspicions were confirmed by a new roommate, and together they hired a psychic, who claimed these anomalies represented attacks from a "troll" living in an underground spring beneath the house, the cause of the flooding. Together, they banished the spirit.[812]

Markers on the land: Faerie flora

Believers across Europe warn against interfering with faerie thorns, bushes, or trees like hawthorn, ash, and elder. Anyone foolish enough to fell them invites bad luck, especially if they cut down a "faerie tree," a solitary specimen in an otherwise empty field. Simply pruning or touching these plants might cause illness, blindness, paralysis, death—or corporate failure. One apocryphal story claims the DeLorean Motor Company's financial failure stemmed from a faerie tree cut down to build their factory in Dunmurry.[813] If only *Back to the Future*'s Doc Brown had been around to travel into the past and warn them.

"The elder-tree, in Manx *tramman*, is supposed to be inhabited by fairies," said Reverend J.M. Spicer. "Through accident, one night a woman ran into such a tree, and was immediately stricken with a terrible swelling which her neighbours declared came from disturbing the fairies in the tree." In another story, a County Meath man tried to fuel his fire with bits of faerie bush, but the tinder remained unlit and he "pined away gradually," dying within six months.[814]

These beliefs are partly rooted in global animistic worship, which recognized trees as symbols of life, youth, immortality, and wisdom,

housing spirits. Wrote poet William Anderson: "What we call tree worship… as though it were a willed choice of faith in a modern sense… was a natural form of participation with the spirits of groves and forests."[815]

Palestinian djinn can inhabit trees, inspiring the proverb, "Sleeping below a carob tree is not recommended."[816] Similarly, duppies congregate around Jamaican cotton trees, hiding among the roots before dawn.[817] Siberians install trees, "roots and all," inside new homes, declaring to their household *domovoy,* "This is for you, father and neighbor, a truly warm house and a shaggy juniper."[818] To name a few other beliefs, ancient Greeks saw in trees *dryads*, the Burmese *boomasoh*, the Japanese *kodama*, West Africans *ombwiri,*[819] Visayans *lonok* or *balete* tree spirits.[820]

"In other words, the tree came to express everything that religious man regards as *pre-eminently real and sacred*," Eliade wrote.[821] Druids and Celts revered both singular trees (Irish *bile*) and groves. Navan Fort in Armagh, Ireland "once sported a ritual post 39 ft (12 m) tall that had been fashioned from a two-hundred-year old oak tree."[822] Citing the pagan scourge of idolatry, early Christians eliminated or appropriated the practice, removing trees, warping them into crosses, or adorning them in saint icons.[823]

While faerie trees and bushes at first glance support Theosophic interpretations of nature spirits, they also suggest ties to the dead. In Ireland, unchristened children and aborted infants were commonly buried underneath "monument bushes." Usually placed by roadsides or at the center of intersections, monument bushes were affirmed faerie and ghost haunts. Any God-fearing person passing these bushes in a funeral procession stopped at each one, doffing their cap and reciting *De Profundis*.[824]

Plantings universally serve as memorials, and markers fashioned after stumps can be found in many modern cemeteries. Highlighting this connection, Jung cited *totenbaum* ("tree of death"), colloquial German for "coffin"—a hollowed log into which "the dead are delivered back to the mother for rebirth."[825]

Canaanites erected poles or trees near religious locations to serve as umbilici between worlds in honor of the mother goddess *Asherah*. Judaism's Tree of Souls, situated in Eden, is a wellspring from which all souls flower. Some rabbis of the early modern period behaved quite animistically, acting as if trees possessed their own souls. Rabbi Nachman of Bratslav learned a tree was felled through a dream in which he "was surrounded by the bodies of those who had been murdered… it was the souls of the trees that cried out to me." Another rabbi, Isaac Luria of Safed, claimed "trees were resting

places for souls," "crowds of spirits" who "did not repent during their lifetimes."[826]

Widespread belief points to trees as "reservoirs of souls"[827] into which the dead migrate and become "indistinguishable from genuine vegetation spirits."[828] In County Sligo, "ghosts and apparitions are commonly said to live in isolated thorn-bushes, or thorn-trees."[829] Trees and thorns in northwestern England often housed ghosts called *boggles*, and in 1856 sap from a Lancashire sycamore tree famously "emerged in the form of a recently deceased man, attracting vast crowds."[830] Australia's Dieyerie, some Filipino islanders, and certain New World tribes all view trees as their forefathers.[831] As recently as the 1940s, certain Egyptian villagers venerated sacred trees they believed housed the souls of sheikhs buried in nearby tombs.[832] In Hinduism, *brahmadaityas*, dead Brahmin priests, return to live in trees.[833]

Critics decry the anthropocentric interpretation of a landscape ensouled with human spirits, but their umbrage is misplaced.

"Certain strands of the occult-metaphysical traditions, such as theosophy, view the 'souls' of almost everything—from rocks to plants to animals—as being involved in the reincarnation process," wrote Lewis.[834] Perhaps *all* souls are laundered through humans,

animals, mountains, rivers, and trees: an ecology of souls, *both human and non-human*, underpinning our environment.

Goblin face and form

"Whence comes the inspiration which depicts the masculine fairy in art and illustration with enormous eye-sockets, in which roll large and 'goggling' eyes?" asked Spence. "From what model is drawn the emaciated face, prominently revealing the bony structure, the skinny frame, the wasted hands?... To anyone whose avocation has at any time brought him into touch with the wards of great hospitals, the origin of the goblin face and form is only too clear. It represents humanity sick unto death, on the verge of mortality."[835]

No uniform faerie description exists. As Daimler notes, "like so many other things fairy-related, there are very few hard and fast definitions and a lot of names for beings, which can change their meaning depending on context or circumstance."[836] Modern faerie sightings display a hodgepodge of ancient beliefs, pop-culture depictions, and individual assumptions; therefore, we can only compare *some*, rather than *all*, descriptions of fae folk to the dead.

As explained in the previous chapter, faeries' small size and intermittent wings may derive from soul traditions. With the exception of beings such as mermaids and more exotic outliers like the one-eyed, one-handed, one-legged *fachan*, they are humanoid—

but can shapeshift, just as demons or ghosts might.[837] A Hampshire faerie witness described "a skeleton made out of sticks… twice human height" which jumped from a tree, made eye contact, then returned to the canopy and fled across the branches, accompanied by "a strong smell of decay."[838]

Similar death-stenches appear across faerie lore: Italian *orculli* giants smell like corpses, household British *drakes* exude rotten egg odors, some Irish *pookas* reek of sulfur. Yorkshire clergyman M.C.F. Morris was told faeries smelled like "a very crowded 'place of worship' wherein the people had been congregated for a length of time"; Morris perceived a resemblance to "the gushes of hot air one sometimes comes across on broken ground," i.e. sulfur compounds, key components in decomposition.[839]

This decay motif is further expressed in telltale defects common among Otherworld denizens, from faeries to djinn.[840] Folklore describes faeries often as beautiful, yet possessed of a single deformity which they are not always able to conceal. While commonly fanciful—goat hooves, single nostrils, webbed feet, ludicrously pendulous breasts—other faults signify deterioration (limping, the aforementioned hollow backs), and all point to *corruption*.[841]

Oversized eyes and heads, as Spence noted, are recurrent, though not defining, faerie features. German *nixen*, drowned-babies-cum-water-faeries, "could be recognized by their large, dreadful eyes," as could some changelings.[842] Many modern sightings describe these eyes as entirely black.

In the early 2000s, a County Meath witness perceived several "passive but curious" beings with "large, black slanted eyes except for one who was bearded and seemed to be in charge" inside a Neolithic tomb; they otherwise looked human. A 15-year old British Columbia girl hiking with friends on March 30, 2006, glimpsed an androgynous 5'6" figure with dark brown skin and fair straight hair, wearing only a long skirt or dark pants: "They had a mostly human looking face but their eyes were a bit too big," she said, "I couldn't see any whites in their eyes, just dark."[843] Non-European fae analogues like djinn,[844] duppies,[845] menehune,[846] and Memegwesi (*mannegishi*) can all sport large eyes and/or heads.[847]

As death symbols, gigantic, black eyes evoke the gaping eye sockets found in human skulls. To accommodate connective tissue, fat, and muscle, our sockets are three times larger than our eyeballs themselves. Larger sockets correlate with higher latitudes, likely influenced by longer dawn-dusk periods; perhaps here exists a connection to Fairyland's twilight, and the emphasis faerie lore enjoys in northern climes.[848]

Faerie faces, especially those of changelings, are repeatedly (again, not universally) described as swarthy, wrinkled, and weathered. A farmer's story recorded by folklorist Jane Wilde—Oscar Wilde's mother—described "a little old wizened woman" who emerged from a hawthorn tree to steal milk from a cow, "then retreated into the tree again."[849] In the "Romance of Thomas and the Fairy Queen," the pair rendezvous beneath an elder tree for sexual intercourse, after which the gorgeous Queen warps into "a loathly hag" with sunken eyes, her "skin shrivelled and turned leaden in colour… the likeness of a decaying corpse."[850]

While visiting a historic Norwegian home around 1990, one witness spied a brightly-dressed, three-foot-tall being with a "male, deeply tanned and wrinkled" face and "black, button-like eyes." Realizing he'd been spotted, this nisse vanished behind the sofa. "So, you have met my little gnome!" the homeowner laughed, seeing her guest's surprised expression moments later.[851]

"The nearest thing I've seen to them is these 'bog people' they've dug up in the Netherlands, with a really tan skin," said a modern Scottish witness of the filthy faeries he encountered near Perthshire's Schiehallion, referencing millennia-old, naturally-mummified corpses recovered from European bogs. "Their skin was really like that… that

really sums them up for me, visually, even down to the wizened sort-of skin."[852]

Like human spirits, faeries can suddenly vanish, float, and phase through solid objects like walls. Kirk called them "spongious, thin, and delicate," not unlike a desiccating corpse.[853] "Where MacEwen's house stands was a noted fairy place," claimed an Irish informant. "Men in building the house saw fairies on horses coming across the spot, and the stone walls did not stop them at all."[854] At the same time, faeries exhibit physical qualities, capable of being touched or carried.

Often, faeries are heavy or capable of changing weight. One Irish changeling grew "heavy as lead," bursting a quilt like "a heavy stone would through a muslin handkerchief."[855] Demon offspring and witches hide deceptive weight,[856] as do *konakijijii,* wrinkle-faced babies from Japanese folklore whose cries lure rescuers, only to crush them.[857] A similar Scandinavian spirit, the *myling*, is an unbaptized child's ghost who leaps onto the back of unsuspecting travelers, demanding transportation to the closest cemetery—nearing, the myling grows ever heavier, but rarely kills its victim.[858] A central North Carolinian legend describes the ghost of a toddler in Caesar Swamp who, when saved by a kind-hearted soul, transforms into a giant creature capable of crushing its rescuer's mule.[859]

Green is the new black

Faeries generally wear clothing fitting the fashion of the region, "although sometimes a bit out of date in style," much like ghosts. While practically every color is represented, green is perhaps the most common, and certainly best-known.[860]

"Several euphemisms for the fairies in different areas are based on the color green including Greenies and Greencoaties," Daimler writes. "In some places, like parts of Scotland, it is so strongly associated with the fairies that it is considered unlucky for women in particular to wear green."[861]

Green is "the colour that nearly all the fairy-folk of Britain and Ireland wear," Evans Wentz noted. "It symbolizes, as many ancient mystical writings declare, eternal youth, and resurrection or re-birth, as in nature during the springtime, when all vegetation after its death-sleep of winter springs into new life… Green is thus associated with a hero or god who is immortal and unchanging, like the Tuatha Dé Danann and fairy races."[862]

Green is not only a vegetal color, but is associated in Celtic lore with the dead,[863] a relationship equally present in ancient Egypt,

China, and Mesoamerica. The presence of green NDE meadows reflects the afterlife as "a place of fertility and rebirth."[864] In something so simple as the color of their clothing, faeries reveal their dualistic roles as nature spirits *and* the dead.

"Taken"

As Yeats opined, faeries reveal "one most malicious habit": kidnapping the vulnerable, especially women and children.[865] To meet this goal they use a variety of means, physically seizing victims, luring them with ghost lights, inflicting illness, pulling them underwater, tempting them with dances and parties, or plucking them up on the wind. Their motivations vary. They seek slaves, lovers, entertainers, foster children, or souls to satisfy a tithe (*teind*) to hell. One of the most popular reasons was that faeries sought "to inject the dwindling stock" of their dying race "with fresh blood and human vigor."[866] Whatever their impetus, faeries fit into a broader tradition of spirit abductors including modern monsters like aliens and Bigfoot or, of course, the dead. We find kidnapping ghosts worldwide.

"The Leper Islanders believe that ghosts steal men, as fairies do, 'to add to their company,'" wrote Spence.[867] Yoruban ancestors, *Egungun*, ensure peaceful communities by spiriting away unpleasant neighbors.[868] At festival time, Roman *lemures* (ghosts) "roamed abroad and looked to steal away the living from their homes," but were thwarted by throwing beans over one's shoulder as a substitute

for victims.[869] Among indigenous Australians, human ghosts kidnap the living into the bush, rendering victims "insensible and eventually killing them if they are not rescued in time."[870] Puerto Rico's hupia, island southeast Asia's *wewe gombel*, and Bolivia's *hapinunu,* all once mortal, represent ghost abductors—to say nothing of non-human spirit kidnappers.[871]

Adaptations of Dickens's *A Christmas Carol* present not only spirit abduction and the "entity trio" motif, but also levitation, dreams as Otherworld travel, a life review, disconnect from time, temporal dilation ("The Spirits have done it all in one night!"), spiritual rebirth, and—in Robert Zemeckis's 2009 production, where Ebenezer Scrooge and the three spirits share the same actor—multipartite souls. Fiction notwithstanding, kidnapping ghosts appear infrequently, if at all, in modern Western stories, suggesting faerie lore stepped in to fill this role.

Though conceptualized physically, abductions were probably spiritual. Illnesses in shamanic cultures indicate someone's soul has either strayed from their body or been kidnapped by spirits. To retrieve them, Nlaka'pamux shamans enter the land of the dead prepared "to fight the ghosts before he can wrest the patient's soul from them," while the Nootka, rescuing souls from aquatic spirits, dive into the ocean.[872] Ghosts—including ancestors—are common disease vectors in animistic societies, inflicting sickness by their mere

presence. As in faerie abductions, children are particularly vulnerable.[873]

Anyone "away with" or "taken" by faeries might be physically absent, but often as not was simply ill. Protracted maladies were regularly blamed on the fae folk. Even Cherokee nûñnë'hï[874] and Arabic djinn[875] can cause disease. Faerie ailments include paralysis, comas, and consumptive diseases, historically signifying Otherworldly predators like vampires. According to some, the otherwise invisible Manx *lhiannan-shee* ("faerie-lover") reveals her beauty to a victim, seducing him while slowly draining his body and soul.[876] Scotland's *baobhan sith* ("wicked female faerie") is more vampiric, exsanguinating her victims.[877]

Anyone "taken" in this manner could remain bedridden "for years in a condition of collapse or even semi-consciousness, brought about, of course, by some obscure nervous or other allied complaint," Spence observed.[878] Those recovering might recall their time in Fairyland and return with new psychic abilities, while those worsening might see other "taken" predecessors or the departed on their deathbed before eventually joining them.[879] "Away" and "taken" also applied to anyone in the company of faeries via mental illness or trance, though some made a distinction.

"In a trance the soul goes from the body, but to be among the Sheogue [faeries] the body is taken and something left in its place," Lady Gregory recorded.[880] By these altered states of consciousness, witches and other mystics voluntarily visited Fairyland through what can clearly be compared to astral travel or an OBE.

"Country people" rejected the astral notion, insisting faeries *bodily* abducted the "taken," leaving behind a double or changeling indistinguishable from their victim (changelings could also replace livestock and children, the latter discussed in the next chapter). When these substitutes died and were buried, the actual victims remained alive—still "taken," still "away"—in Fairyland, a stunningly overt conflation of the faerie realm with the afterlife.[881]

Mothers passing away in childbirth were also regarded as "living" in Fairyland, and any "captive" woman's soul might wander back into our world to visit loved ones or nurse children.[882] Some of the "taken" aged in Fairyland before returning home, elderly, for their last rites.

"Hence, many people really suffered two deaths: the first, a life serving the 'others,' the second, the actual death," wrote professor Carole Silver. "Only the old died 'natural' deaths and went to heaven, hell, or purgatory; the young were actually 'elsewhere.'" With this

"came the possibility of a flawed resurrection," causing anxiety among the pious. [883]

In the Cornish "Selena Moor" story mentioned in Chapter 3, a "Mr. Noy" wanders into Fairyland, meeting his ex-fiancée Grace Hutchens, declared dead three years prior. Hutchens forbids Noy to consume "the Small People's" fare, warning him this was the cause of her current misfortune. She had eaten faerie food, trapping her in Fairyland.[884]

"What was buried for me, however, was only a changeling or a sham body," she says, "never mine, I should think, for it seems to me that I feel much the same still as when I lived to be your sweetheart."[885]

OBE and NDE implications aside, faeries also physically kidnapped victims by dragging them underwater. In numerous cultures, both aquatic fae folk and the drowned dead, like China's *shui gui*, drag victims beneath the waves.[886] Irish seer Peggy Gillin cured patients using secret herbs revealed to her by her dead brother, who had been "drowned and *taken* by the fairies."[887] Archaeologist Georg Weicker asserted Greek sirens (mermaid precursors resembling Egypt's ba) were "essentially representations of the souls of the dead"; mermaids in turn resemble the dolphin, a psychopomp symbol.[888] Green Russian *rusalki,* drowned maidens who became

nature spirits, either helped fishermen[889] or pulled hapless men underwater.[890]

As seen in future chapters, trauma from severe illness often serves as a precursor to shamanic initiation, and NDEs can arise during the same comatose states once described as "taken." It seems reasonable, despite folkloric indications to the contrary, to streamline faerie belief and assume any so-called "changelings" that were buried constituted victims' actual, physical selves, albeit deprived of their souls.

In some ways, whether faerie abductions were physical or spiritual is inconsequential. Like NDEs, they result in two possible outcomes: death or recovery, often with new psychic abilities.

“Taken”:

Dancing

Spying circles of Little People dancing was once commonplace. Upon discovery, they either disappeared, attacked the interloper, or extended an invitation. Though seemingly innocuous, joining could prove disastrous.

“When a young man got into one of the rings the fairy damsels took him away,” claimed folklorist John Rhŷs, “but he could be got out unharmed at the end of a year and a day, when he would be found dancing with them in the same ring,” albeit sickly, skeletal, or pale. One Welsh boy, after his rescue over a year later, perceived five minutes of dancing—yet his brand new shoes were tattered. [891] Yeats recorded an Irish girl’s seven year disappearance into a faerie dance, during which she “danced off” all of her toes.[892] Others returned centuries later, or vanished entirely.[893]

These revels generated “faerie rings,” round patches of barren earth or circular rings of fungi.[894] Such spaces remained dangerous sites of abduction long after faerie dances ended. In the late 1700s Welshman William Jenkins repeatedly spotted faeries congregating

around an oak tree, only to find "a reddish circle upon the grass" after investigating.[895] Similar formations called "faerie circles," equally inexplicable by modern botanists and attributed to spirits among the natives, appear in arid Namibian grasslands.[896]

Just about all supernatural beings from folklore enjoy a good spin, from witches at sabbaths to the devil himself. The early Church therefore condemned dancing: "The dance is a circle, in the midst of which is the Devil," St. Augustine scorned, proclaiming dancing, especially counter-clockwise motion, sinful.[897]

Above all, skeletons and corpses danced, leading the living in an ancient and widespread tradition immortalized as the medieval *danse macabre*.[898] According to Caciola, the faerie or elf dance likely evolved from the dancing dead, who "were usually (though not always) female," perhaps reflecting their less violent tendencies. "… not only did the dead dance in churchyards, but so too did the living dance, both in cemeteries and at vigils, wakes, or commemorations for the dead.[899] Both dancing faeries and the dead adopted region-specific styles, such as Britain's "hornpipes, jigs, strathspeys, and reels."[900]

Croker tells of Irishman Davy Roche who fell in with a funeral procession on his way home. The attendees seemed "strange to him"—save one man among them whom he knew, but had thought

dead. No sooner was the body interred than a lively jig began. "Take a partner," Roche's acquaintance said, "Show what you can do, but take care and don't offer to kiss her." Overcome by his partner's beauty, Roche ignored this advice and the dancers vanished, stranding him in the churchyard "a great many hours later than he thought it."[901]

Some contend ideas of the dancing dead reinvented Celtic pagan revels, but the motif occurs worldwide.[902] The afterlife arrival of Egypt's dead included dancing "Watchers," "mummiform entities" reanimated by the sun's return to the netherworld.[903] In the Iroquois dance for the dead, it was thought the departed returned and participated."[904]

Why dancing? There is no clear answer. Ritualized dance is a critical component of many shamanic rites, like Yakut psychopomp ceremonies.[905] Epilepsy, a possible cause of shamanic trances as outlined in Chapter 7, may have produced medieval "dancing epidemics" like Saint Vitus's Dance, John's Dance, and Guy's Dance.[906] Others speciously imply faeries, serving as nature spirits, dance to invigorate flora.[907]

Even wilder theories exist. Citing faeries' talent "to travel from one end of the world to another in the twinkling of an eye," author Graham Hancock speculated dancing circles represent dimensional

portals, “spiritual technology… for jumping between worlds.” Attacks on faerie dance witnesses are “triggered if the dance is interrupted before the required momentum to jump the gap between worlds has been built up.”[908]

“Taken”:

Rades & storms

Kidnapping “faerie rades” once tore across Scotland in “a grand procession of fairy knights, led by the Fairy Queen or King.” These *rades,* antiquated Scottish for “raids” or “rides,” “were dangerous to any humans that they came across, but also offered the opportunity to free captives to those brave enough to confront them,” wrote Daimler.[909] (This concept resembles the Wild Hunt and spectral armies covered in Chapter 9.)

Faerie rades bring to mind the Scottish *slua sí* or *sluagh*, variously described as a faerie host or the unforgiven dead, who soar through the sky grabbing victims. Like all faeries, the pale, hideous, dark-eyed, toothless sluagh shapeshift, but this cannot mask their stench of decay. Since they hail from the West—direction of the sunset and death—all westerly entrances and windows should be secured to prevent abduction, especially if someone in the household is ill.[910]

Like other faeries, the sluagh moved across Scotland on violent gusts of wind and storms.[911] Wilde wrote faeries in Ireland “are rushing by in the whirlwind intent on carrying off some mortal victim

to the fairy mansions."[912] In one of Lady Gregory's examples, a windy storm occluding the moon preceded a Connemara boy's "taking."[913] Risk of faerie abductions increased on "misty days, during storms, or on days of *gwlithlaw*, the Welsh term for 'dew-rain.'"[914]

Abducting winds are another widespread superstition. Romulus, founder of Rome, was taken into the heavens on a whirlwind,[915] and the Pueblo thought they caused miscarriages or stole children.[916] Faerie abductees sometimes disappeared into the sky; in the Irish *The Wooing of Étain*, the protagonist is seized by her right arm and disappears with her captor through the roof's smoke hole, "from which two swans were then seen flying away."[917]

As noted, "soul" has strong "breath" and "wind" connotations. Souls might exit the body as a whirlwind, and ghost stories commonly describe spirits as mists or fog.[918] Lenâpé ghosts "cohere into clouds," rolling along pathways "and causing strokes in anyone who touched them," wrote University of Toledo professor Barbara Mann. "These ghosts were 'felt as a slight wind.'"[919]

In medieval literature—and more contemporary fare like *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz*—violent weather marks departures from and arrivals to our reality, according to scholar Martin Puhvel: "… the passage through the magic storm 'seems to be another form of the

motif of a dive through the water of a spring or lake which in many Irish stories... is the mode of entrance to the Other World.'" [920]

In short, violent weather marks these transitions, particularly into the afterlife. In Iran, whirlwinds are psychopomps, perhaps angels.[921] Donn and Odin**,** psychopomps themselves, find close association with storms and wind. To the Welsh, mid-winter thunder and lightning warn of impending death, echoing similar superstitions regarding storms worldwide.[922]

Interactions with faeries and the dead

Faeries' wrath was avoided through countless euphemisms: the People of Peace, the Wee Folk, the Good Folk, the Gentry, etc. These were often region-specific: the Welsh called faeries "the Fair Family," *Bendith y Mamau* ("the Mother's Blessing"), and *Plant Rhys Dwfyn* ("the Children of Rhys and the Deep").[923] Scots might add the phrase, "A blessing attend their departing and traveling" after discussing faeries.[924] Perhaps inconsequentially, our dead receive similar euphemisms: departed, deceased, those passed away, or, like those suffering Irish faerie afflictions, "taken" and "away." Upon death, we "pass away," "give up the ghost," "move on," "kick the bucket," etc.

No relationship more strongly illustrates the fae folk's connection to ancestor worship than leaving offerings. Just as dutiful descendants ensured rain or abundant crops by providing their dead food and drink, believers held well-propitiated faeries improved one's lot in life—or, neglected, imposed misfortune.[925]

In the ancient world, deities and the dead alike craved worldly goods. Greco-Romans brought "milk, honey, wine, water, and oil, and offerings of grain and flowers" to tombs; these both appeased

the dead and, in the case of necromancers, allowed favors to be asked, to which blood or an animal sacrifice might be added for extra effect.[926] Psychopomps and gods accepted sacrificial offerings, including Hermes, whose followers hoped "he might lead up the soul of his worshipper without delay" if sated.[927]

Unsurprisingly faeries, variously interpreted as ancestors, the dead, or gods, also welcome offerings. Jenny Butler wrote of Irish practice:

> It has been suggested… that veneration of the ancestors carried on as customs of leaving offerings for the fairies. A traditional offering left for the fairies was some *poitín* (anglicized as poteen)—a distilled beverage that can be made from grain, cereals, whey or potatoes—poured on the ground. Another offering might be the colostrum or 'beestings' from a cow, which is the first milk drawn from the animal after she has given birth. In some cases [these] would be thrown into the air for the fairies.[928]

Any respectful Worcestershire homeowner, finding an item misplaced, offers honey- or milk-dipped bread in apology, then requests the faeries return the missing item[929] (ghost hunters find their belongings similarly misplaced by spirits).[930] Cherokee women leave cornbread for Yûñ'wi Tsunsdi', "gone the next day with crumbs left on the table or trailing across the room to the kitchen door."[931] In

Palestine, "some will not even occupy a newly built dwelling until a sheep is immolated, to please the *djinn* who have already taken their abode in it."[932] The Scandinavian Yuletide feast to the dead and ancestors also appeases spirits, earning the name "sacrifice to the elves (*álfablót*)."[933]

"The relation of fairy sacrifices to the cult of the dead was noticed quite early," wrote Éva Pócs. From the beginning, folklorists could see that "offerings given to the *nereids* in Greece [were] actually the same as the Christian offering to the dead, the *pomana*… Fairy offerings presented by Romanians during Rusalia week are strongly influenced by the fact that this is also the week of sacrificial offerings to the dead."[934]

Both the Irish dead and faeries visit homes at nighttime, and are delighted to discover a fresh supply of water in a clean, warm kitchen.[935] Dead homeowners might metamorphose into small house spirits, continuing their residency alongside newer, mortal tenants, a servitude which could extend to other structures and outbuildings. Germany's *schrat*, a stable spirit, is also "a small child, fast as the wind, and a soul in torment"—in Brittany, similar "sprites of the stable" represent former farmhands.[936]

Household spirits like Scottish brownies and Eurasian domovoye—often deceased family members or former residents—keep

beneficiaries' domiciles tidy and operational in exchange for foodstuffs like milk and biscuits, but reject spoiled food. Some are quite particular about the presentation of offerings, accepting food if left out casually, but taking great offense if a master-servant relationship is implied. [937]

This fickle disposition applied to ancestors as well. In a drama by Roman playwright Plautus, a tutelary ancestor benefitted his faithful female descendant, but abandoned her brother after his food offerings stopped. The ancestor's withdrawal plunged his heir into poverty.[938]

Offerings are restricted neither to the laity nor their households. Balkan faerie magicians healed by offering "milk, honey, wine, bread or cake… preceded or followed by a ritual invocation of the fairies in the presence of the sufferer."[939] To this day, it remains wise to leave something at faerie sites, including honey, libations, or coins. In some instances, it was believed this provided sustenance to anyone "taken" into the fort or hill (i.e. the dead).[940]

Faeries hoarded treasure within these sites, a legend perhaps inspired by gold and silver grave goods interred with bodies at burial grounds. Treasure could be obtained one of two ways: by waiting for it to emerge from the mound, glowing, then reverently collecting it within seven years; or by traveling directly into Fairyland.[941] The

Otherworld holds immeasurable riches for those brave enough to enter.[942]

Another trope claims captured leprechauns reveal their hidden gold caches. Given that immortality is itself the ultimate treasure, this might parallel legends wherein heroes or shamans succeed "in vanquishing Death and [take] him prisoner." By keeping Death in a bag and hanging him over a fire, the hero puts both their own demise and the deaths of others on hiatus, though Death inevitably escapes.[943]

Little People delighted in leading people astray with ghost lights, strange noises, or enchantment. Anyone unaccountably led to unfamiliar areas—or finding themselves in familiar areas rendered unrecognizable—might be deemed *pixie led* or *pouk-ledden.*[944] This disorientation either serves as a prelude to abductions, or equally often wanes until the path home is eventually rediscovered. Of course, many a wayward husband might employ such excuses for a night out drinking.

Victims are also pixie led by actual apparitions. For example, a man hiking to a County Mayo fair encountered two mysterious men a mile after departing, who, warning of rain, convinced him to attend a fair closer to home. They walked all night until the strangers

vanished at daybreak, leaving the man 20 miles from where he began.[945]

Ghosts divert travelers as well. In Asia, anyone following evil possessing spirits called *oni* (perhaps originating in Chinese ancestor traditions, but best known in Japan) might find themselves lost.[946] In his youth, "*Wi-tapanóxwe*, the great Lenâpé herbalist" and his brother "followed a ghost. Horrified by their recklessness, their mother warned them 'never to follow a ghost like that as it would lead [them] astray and finally to a pile of bones.'"[947]

A rich bachelor's ghost was regularly seen between 11:30 p.m. and 12:30 a.m. at West Huron's Woolverton Farm, according to the February 1899 *Fort Wayne [IN] News*. One witness described "a weird glow" manifesting, "like an incandescent electric lamp." The light illuminated "the form of a human being… invested with a bluish tinge," before revealing a dazzlingly bright "skeleton" within. "It beckoned for me to follow it, but I was afraid to do so."[948]

Do these distracting apparitions reflect ancient traditions wherein the dead, faced with temptations, must unwaveringly follow specific paths to the afterlife?[949]

Defense against faeries and the dead

Numerous methods arose to ward off Europe's faeries. Fire was effective, equally potent against ghosts and undead revenants like draugr.[950] This perhaps reflects fire's purificatory power, or the widespread funereal practice of crematory rites. Even as distantly as North America, "the primary method of stymieing an Earth ghost was cremation."[951] Bells, particularly from churches, repelled both fae folk and the dead.[952] Salt kept faeries at bay, and—maybe inspired by its preservative, decay-inhibiting properties—was also employed throughout Europe to deter ghosts and predict deaths.[953]

A lesser-discussed means of breaking faerie spells involves turning clothing inside-out. By this method Mr. Noy escaped Fairyland in the "Selena Moor" tale with his gloves.[954] It is not particularly obvious why this works. Perhaps inverting clothing in their backwards realm "short circuits" faerie magic.

Ancient texts often describe the afterlife as a place of *inversion*. Writes Shushan of various interpretations: "A reversal of the earthly order is a common fear in Egyptian spells against being upside-down, being hunted with nets, and the reversal of the digestion process; in the Vedic warning that the deceased will be consumed by

the food he/she has eaten; and in Mesoamerica where food and drink cry out."[955] In Mesopotamia, Nergal rebirths the cosmos via a campaign of inverted violence: pacifists fight, melee brawlers use bows, the weak defeat the strong, the crippled outperform the swift.[956]

Faeries' aversion to iron is well-documented. Most (though not all) recoiled at its very sight. Iron or steel placed in cribs prevented child abductions, and thresholds were lain with the metal to prevent evil spirits' entry. Folklorist Edwin Sydney Hartland speculated the phobia's origin lay in faeries as "representatives of the stone age":

> When the use of metals was discovered, stone implements were discarded in ordinary life; but for ages afterwards knives of stone were used for religious purposes... The gods, having been served with stone for so long, would be conceived of as naturally objecting to change… [Stone blades were] associated with the discarded deities, or their allies, the Nymphs and Oreads and Fairies of stream or wood or dell, and with the supernatural generally.[957]

Why else might faeries fear iron? In their search for answers, scholars have pointed to iron's seemingly "magical" ferromagnetic properties, the element's synonymity with strength, or humans'

mastery over ironworking, which suggested our superiority over nature. Thanks to iron, ancient civilizations found trees cleanly hewn and rocks easily cleft.[958]

"Smiths and shamans are from the same nest," claims a Yakut proverb, and blacksmiths are even *more* powerful than shamans to the Dolgan.[959] Classical necromancers used iron because it was "a metal superior to ghosts,"[960] and Saxons refrained from using iron in cemeteries, for fear it would repel souls.[961]

Yet—refuting interpretations of faeries as the dead—modern tales rarely ascribe an aversion of iron to ghosts and vampires. "Many a house with an iron threshold or charm reputedly has been haunted," wrote Rosemary Ellen Guiley. "A few classic ghosts haunt with their rattling of iron chains."[962] In short, ghosts seem *attracted* to iron under some circumstances.[963]

Finally, faeries could be evaded by crossing running water, a universal boundary motif familiar from afterlife conceptualizations.[964] If they indeed represent dead souls, it makes sense why the fae folk would be unable to cross this symbolic threshold into "the living world."

Earthly bridges—liminal places—are guarded by trolls in folklore, and a handful of bridges in the Isle of Man and Skye are designated "fairy bridges." If faeries ever crossed running water at all, boats

were typically required. “Numerous stories exist of fairies and troll-folk ferrying over streams in such a manner as recalls the passage of dead souls across the Styx,” Spence wrote.[965] It would prove a lovely point to link the two words together, but unfortunately no etymology connects the homophones “faerie” and “ferry.”

All manner of supernatural creatures are stopped by running water, including vampires and ghosts on both sides of the Atlantic. In North America, “water protected and facilitated ritual space, for Earth ghosts could not cross water, whereas Sky spirits had to cross water,” wrote Mann. “Thus, one major significance of water near mounds and earthworks was to keep disruptive spirits out of the arena of ritual, where they would degrade ceremony.”[966]

The extinct race hypothesis

A once-popular theory posited faerie lore as long-forgotten memories of an extinct race, rendered supernatural by the mists of time. This *euhemerist* approach—ascribing mythology to real events—is attractive, if problematic. "Extinct Race Hypothesis" (ERH) proponents claim faeries arose from "a more primitive race driven into hiding by the invaders, lurking in caves or fens, some of them half-domesticated and doing chores about the houses like the shaggy and unkempt brownie."[967] It is true the Celts interpreted Ireland's history as "a succession of invasions."[968]

"The fairies of any one race are the people of the preceding race—the Fomors for the Fir Bolgs, the Fir Bolgs for the [Tuatha Dé] Dananns, and the Dananns for us," an Irish college professor told Evans Wentz. "The old races died. Where did they go? They became spirits—and fairies."[969]

ERH evidence is compelling, if circumstantial. "Faerie" artifacts like pipes and arrowheads are clearly remnants from older peoples. Forts and tombs, now faerie sites, housed their living and dead, filled with souterrain tunnels. Megalithic sites associated with faeries once hosted human religious ceremonies. Faeries fear iron, perhaps

representing invaders' superior weaponry. Faerie women, like females from any subjected race, might be captured by humans (invaders); conversely, faeries strike-out, guerilla-style, kidnapping women and children, as it was believed indigenous people might against oppressive occupying forces.[970] Offerings were once attempts to placate "restless natives."

Some scholars claimed "primitive, dwarfish English aborigines or prehistoric settlers had stolen healthy Celtic or Saxon babies and attractive young girls to increase their dwindling, malnourished population," leaving in place their own sickly stock: changelings.[971] The kingdoms of faerie royalty map "with almost political exactness" onto historical Irish territories, and seem "at times to tally with those of the great septs which represent the tribal organization of ancient Ireland."[972] As noted, humans *have* grown taller over time, if not drastically so, and there exists some indication Irish hunter-gatherers may have been darker-skinned than modern Anglo-Saxons.[973]

From these people, ERH advocates claim, arose the corpus of faerie lore. Even esotericists flirt with euhemerism in their respective disciplines: Robert Monroe admitted the OBE realm, e.g. an Otherworld, "might be a memory, racial, or otherwise, of a physical earth civilization that predates known history."[974]

Advocates like MacCulloch suggested numerous races for these remembered faeries.[975] David MacRitchie, whose ideas Evans Wentz dubbed "the Pygmy Theory," suspected faeries represented memories of "a very early, prehistoric, probably Mongolian race" somehow dwelling in western Europe. Citing evidence he believed indicated underground lifestyles, MacRitchie also posited a pre-Pictish race or the Picts themselves, purportedly evident in the Scottish faerie names *pech* or *peht*.[976] Some similarly maintain the Cornish "pixie" derives from "Pict."[977]

Other candidate races in Ireland and the British Isles include the Druids;[978] Romans;[979] Danes; a race of short Welsh magicians called *Coranians*;[980] *Muryans*, ancient Cornish heathens doomed to forever shrink; marooned Moors who became the Hebrides's "Blue Men of the Minch";[981] victims of Noah's flood;[982] or, grotesquely, "Jews from the Roman period, sent [as Cornish knockers] to the mines as punishment for an imagined role in the crucifixion."[983]

In continental Europe, faeries and elves were attributed to memories of Gauls,[984] Lapps, Letts, and Finns.[985] New Zealand author James Cowan even applied the ERH to tales of *patu-paiarehe*, Māori beings roughly corresponding to faeries.[986]

Yet for all the ERH's parsimony, it fails to explain every aspect of faerie belief, and many facets of the theory are simply ahistorical.

Souterrains were for storage or hiding, not living.[987] Picts actually *used* iron, and no evidence suggests they were shorter than Scots or Norsemen.[988] Nothing accounts for faeries' wizened visages, magical abilities, or extreme shortness. While witnesses occasionally describe clothing consistent with indigenous cultures, more often faeries wear clothing of the more recent past, like that of the Middle Ages… which, by extension, implies medieval witnesses perceived *contemporary* clothing, the garb of the invaders. Explanations for Fairyland's supernatural lapse of time—like Kenny Klein's assertion that Picts dosed visiting Celts with psychedelics—fall laughably short.[989]

Speaking in the parlance of his time, Evans Wentz wrote: "Beyond the borders of Celtic lands—in Southern Asia with its islands, in Melanesia with New Guinea, and in Central Africa—pygmy races, generally called Negritos, exist at the present day; but they themselves have a fairy-faith, just as their normal-sized primitive neighbours have, and it would hardly be reasonable to argue that either of the two fairy-faiths is due to a folk-memory of small-statured peoples." Evans Wentz concluded "the Pygmy Theory probably does explain some ethnological elements" of faerie lore but is only a partial answer.[990]

Evans Wentz's quote evinces the ERH's nastier side: racism, derived from Darwinist conceptions that civilizations fall on a

spectrum of "primitive" to "civilized." The ERH represents xenophobia towards indigenous people, demonized as killers, kidnappers, and rapists. This tendency overtly reared its head in phrenological interpretations of extinct races as "long-headed," attempting to correlate skulls with large-headed faeries.[991]

Racist ERH ideology even crept into anthropology, inspiring a competition to discover the "worldwide pygmy race" responsible for faerie folklore. Sir Harry Johnston, in "The Pygmies and Ape-like Men of the Uganda Borderlands," wrote that tribes like the Echuya Batwa strongly evoked "the traits attributed to brownies and goblins of our fairy stories." British officer Sidney Hinde described the pygmies as "small demons." Since many faeries—brownies and their ilk especially—were ugly, hairy, and "simian," the underlying implication is that African features are apelike and less-than-human.[992]

It is a complex issue because, despite these factual and egregious moral flaws, certain indigenous cultures also explain faeries as extinct races. In Africa, "the mysterious Vazimba, traditionally held to have been the original inhabitants of central Madagascar," became diminutive, salt-averse intercessor spirits of the land, their tombs worshipped.[993] Japan's *koropokkuru* ("people under thatch") display faerie hallmarks—short stature, underground environs, exchanging gifts with humans, building ancient structures—but, according to the Ainu, were already present in Hokkaido when their ancestors

arrived.[994] Menehune, who are clearly faeries, are also "essentially human" ancestors of modern Hawaiians—"during the rule of Kaumuali'i of Kaua'i (d. 1824), a census listed 65 people in the Wainiha Valley who were classified as *menehune*."[995]

Obviously the ERH contains *some* value if one strips away its literalism, which in turn removes its bigotry. Euhemerists miss the crucial supernatural element: to speculate boldly, perhaps faerie lore represents not races as they *were*, but races as they *became* after death.

Few of these races lived underground—but their bodies "dwell" there now. Nor were they significantly shorter—but our souls may be. If their complexions weren't darker, the ravages of time made them so, as in recovered bog bodies. They abduct women and children because *all* spirits abduct people, not because they were rapists and kidnappers. If they didn't fear iron in life, perhaps they do so in death as ghosts. Perhaps their non-indigenous clothing is rooted in Co-Creation Theory. In short, perhaps the Extinct Race Hypothesis should be the Extinct Race *Ghost* Hypothesis.

If faeries indeed represent *us*, albeit in a transformed state, our fear of them belies a poetic irony of the human condition: we see danger in the *Other*, when in reality, it is embedded within *us*. Our non-paranormal "Others"—divisions racial, geographical, religious,

political—are illusory. We are all the same, all spirits playing critical roles in maintaining a healthy ecology of souls.

The only *true* threats are our own. The threat from any "Other," earthly or unearthly, pales in comparison to the danger posed by our own prejudice and hate. Death is nothing more than an equalizer. It harms flesh alone, but if we realize our own immortality—if we die to death—we are invulnerable, and might focus on bettering ourselves and others in the manifold lives we have yet to live.

Despite these concessions, aspects of folklore resist the interpretation of faeries as human souls… yet they undeniably connect to death *somehow*. Our next chapter focuses on fae folk as death omens, doubles, agents of reincarnation, and psychopomps.

5

FAERIES & DEATH TRADITIONS

OBJ



"They are fairies," Falstaff warns in *The Merry Wives of Windsor*. "He that speaks to them shall die. I'll wink and couch. No man their works must eye."

Interactions with faeries are risky business, no matter what culture. Besides more obvious transgressions like interfering with their property or speaking ill of them, the mere act of *seeing* fae folk could instigate misfortune.

The Welsh believe "their very look is deadly, or at least exceedingly dangerous," wrote Croker. "Sickness, violent fever, and loss of reason, is the consequence. A youth once saw a brown dwarf; he was seized with a tedious illness, and died in the course of the year."[996] Among the Abenaki, sightings of mermaid-like *nodumkanwets* foretold a drowning within a year,[997] as did

any German nixen "dancing on the waters."[998] Nightly mumbles around homes in India indicate a short, red-toothed *virika* is near, and that a resident will die soon.[999] Such beliefs may derive from universal "evil eye" superstitions, where sorcerers inflict curses with nothing more than a glare.

As "preludes to the final 'taking,'" faeries also attack from afar using "elfbolt," "elfshot," or "elf-arrows," tiny, invisible projectiles conflated with small Neolithic arrowheads unearthed in Ireland and the British Isles.[1000]

"A youth in the Isle of Man withdrew from the caresses of a [water faerie], who, quite enraged, threw something after him," wrote Croker. "Though he felt himself but slightly touched by a pebble, he experienced from that moment a fearful dread, and died in seven days after."[1001]

Almost every culture describes invisible spirit projectiles, sometimes attributed to psychopomps or the dead. MacCulloch claimed "savage ghosts kill with invisible darts."[1002] The Ojibwe baykok attacks with either a club or invisible spirit arrows.[1003] Evil Dagara magicians in East Africa attack funeral attendees with various *lobie*, undetectable projectiles, which embed in their bodies.[1004] Among the Amazonian Baniwa, poisonous thorns or darts called *uephetti* embed in victims' canoes before invisibly penetrating their targets; the environment is filled with such "spirit darts," which "fly about in the air when there are storms."[1005]

In the Christian tradition, St. Teresa of Ávila encountered a short, shining "angel" who plunged a golden, fire-tipped "dart" into her heart several times. Withdrawing it, Teresa "thought he was carrying off with him the deepest part of [her]; and he left [her] all on fire with great love of God."[1006]

At close range, faeries employ "faerie kisses" or "touches" and "faerie blasts," wind-delivered boils stuffed with detritus (twigs, leaves, bones, string, etc.). Any of these methods might be viewed as a "faerie stroke," from which our modern medical term "stroke" derives. In addition to cerebrovascular damage, any faerie attack could culminate in the victim being "taken" or suffering general illness: full or partial paralysis, comas, trances, epilepsy, and, of course, death.[1007] We find precedent in Greco-Roman beliefs where even the most benevolent ghosts might drag innocent bystanders to the Underworld.[1008]

"Folk narratives say that people who attack or touch a ghost become sick or paralyzed for a while, and fairy legends tell of someone blinded for seeing fairies when they do not wish to be seen or permanently paralyzed after passing through a crowd of them," wrote folklorist Thomas E. Bullard.[1009]

Death omens: On the move

Once upon a time, witnesses observed faeries moving *en masse* in their rades, in nightly marches across the land, in funeral processions, or as a mass exodus from the land of men.

Though not a death omen *per se*, the departure of the faeries—a parade of Little People out of the hills, belongings packed on tiny wagons or miniature horses—is noteworthy for its symbolic content. No one knows their final destination, nor when or why the fae decided to relocate. Possible motives include Christianity's encroach, the Industrial Revolution, urbanization, science's ascendancy, etc. The evacuation is clearly a lengthy process, appearing at least as early as Chaucer's *The Wife of Bath's Tale* (14th century) and continuing well into 20th century sightings.

Let us presume for a moment, as Spence suggested, that faeries represent "ghosts of, say, late Stone-age man, while what we call 'ghosts' are the shades of the dead of more modern times"—that "elfin spirits may represent the shades of the dead who are as yet in a state of contact with the living and not finally translated to a more distant bourne."[1010]

If this is the case, then perhaps the faeries' departure represents earthbound souls migrating to the afterlife—which in turn explains why the diaspora never ends. (Patrick Harpur elegantly noted that, while "fairies are always going, going—but never gone," UFO believers swear extraterrestrials "are always coming, coming— but never here.)[1011] In literature, we see the

faeries' departure represented in J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy in the passing of the elves, who embark for westerly "undying lands." The ringbearers' departure with them reads like their death, at least symbolically. Faerie exoduses fit within broader traditions surrounding "processions of the undead," covered in Chapter 9.

Whereas the "departure of the faeries" motif may represent a *symbolic* transition from life to death, faerie funerals are *literal*. Witnesses describe anomalous sounds, processions of light traversing paths to graveyards, or even tiny figures.

A Cornish fisherman heard muffled church bells before seeing "the bier borne between six—whether men or women he could not tell—but he saw that the face of the corpse was that of a beautiful female, smaller than the smallest child's doll… 'as if it were a dead seraph,'—so very lovely did it appear to him."[1012] Visionary artist William Blake (perhaps the first illustrator of faerie wings) claimed he noticed "a great stillness" in his Sussex garden before "a procession of creatures the size and colour of green and gray grasshoppers" appeared, "bearing a body laid out on a rose-leaf, which they buried with songs" before vanishing."[1013]

Blake's sighting was uncharacteristically romantic. Faerie funerals were commonly death omens, either for witnesses or the community. A rabbit trapper in one Irish yarn awoke in the night to four faeries bearing a coffin, attended by a crowd of "crying and lamenting" mourners, which marched past him into a nearby lake—"shortly afterwards he took ill and died."[1014] Another Irish witness told Lady Gregory of "a little funeral, a very little one"

passing into a fort, after which an ill child died.[1015] Cumbrian faeries also held wakes on clouds and mountaintops.[1016]

Parsing faerie funerals versus ghost funerals can prove difficult. In Southern Wales, light processions—or even full-bodied funeral parties—are called "*toilu*, *toili*, or *y teulu* (the family) *anghladd*, unburied; in Montgomeryshire it is called *Drychiolaeth*, spectre."[1017] All are associated with the Tylwyth Teg.[1018]

The ability of these processions to predict death might owe to the fae folk's renowned knowledge of future events, or events taking place in distant lands.[1019] Though its origins are disputed, the word "faerie" could originate in the Latin *fatum*, "thing said," from which *fata*, or fate, was conflated with "female fate, goddess" or "an individual female with supernatural powers" (today, extraterrestrials are attributed the power of prophecy, albeit with quite the spotty track record).[1020] This omniscience is consistent once again with ghosts: one of the primary goals of shamans and Hellenic necromancers is learning future events from the dead who, decoupled from time, know all things past or yet-to-be.[1021]

Death omens: Colors and cries

Black-clad faerie funerals were ill-omened on Rathlin Island.[1022] Even outside of these processions, other specific colors elicited alarm.

Named for their headwear, English Red Caps, "the most dangerous types of goblins" according to Daimler, haunted murder sites, "perhaps indicat[ing] that they were once humans, I might surmise wicked men, brought over to Fairy who still fear their old faith."[1023]

Other faeries *feared* the color red themselves, because of its resemblance either to fire or blood. For this reason "they will also avoid sharp, pointed objects... which might prick them, remind them of their lack of blood, and 'make them hysterical.'"[1024] Is this hysteria that of the departed, realizing their death? (Given its high content in human blood, this may also overlap with the fae folk's aversion to iron, discussed earlier.)[1025] Notably, "people of the recent palaeolithic period often put ochre (which is the color of blood) in the grave with the dead or poured it on the grave as libation…."[1026]

People worldwide fear faerie sounds. Cries of infants in the absence of children appears repeatedly across Fortean topics, from Bigfoot to UFO sightings, and faerie lore—from both the Old and New Worlds—is no exception.[1027] European dwarfs, faeries, and indigenous American Little People can all sound like infants in distress.[1028] In some instances, these sounds mean death is at hand. A baby born with sharp teeth in Chugash legend was interred alive with her mother after she died in childbirth, and

"the baby's cries years afterward foretold death."[1029] There you have it: tonight's nightmare fuel, all sorted.

By far the most feared faerie sound among the Irish was the keening of the banshee, an undeniable death omen heard wending through the night. "Almost always" conceived of as a departed ancestor keeping tabs on her family[1030]—perhaps "a long-dead virgin"[1031] or a woman who died in childbirth—banshees presided over specific clans, allegedly the only ones able to hear her cries.[1032] Banshees haunt the O'Brien, O'Grady, O'Connor, O'Neill, and Kavanagh families,[1033] although other lineages fear her equally.

"I heard the Banshee crying not long ago, and within three days a boy of the Murphy's was killed by his own horse," Lady Gregory was told. "Six families it cries for, the Hyneses and the Fahys and I forget what are the others."[1034]

Her wails are sometimes beautifully sorrowful, other times horrifying, but always uncanny. The Michigan granddaughter of an Irish immigrant with cancer described "atonal moaning/singing from outside the house":

> A hollow, moaning "song," horrible to hear, but not unmusical… The range was from baritone to soprano. But it was one voice. I had to drown out the sound with the television. It helped, but didn't entirely block it. It was almost as if the sound were in my head, but I was definitely hearing it with my ears, hard to explain…
>
> I've lived in rural areas all my life. Even spent time in the deep woods. No animal sounds like that... My grandfather died a short time later...

> I always imagined the banshee as angry. But it wasn't. It was sad. I think it's possible that she may not be called upon again. The family name may not carry onto another generation.[1035]

Skeptics naturally blame animals like foxes. Even those admitting this possibility still attribute the cries supernatural qualities, as did a Rathlin Island informant: "It's not really the banshee, it's normally maybe a dog howling or a cat screaming," but "the only ones that heard it were… the ones that were related" to the dying.[1036]

Typically red-eyed from her continual crying, the banshee appears as a woman with long hair in a green dress under a grey cloak, though others clad her in white—the color of bloodless corpses and ghosts,[1037] or Greek spirits who appeared "pallid" because they were "deprived of the sun."[1038] She loves brushing her hair, "and it is considered very dangerous even today to pick up a stray comb you find laying on the ground, in case it belongs to the Fairy Woman."[1039]

In the Highlands, banshee analogues might present "only one nostril, a large protruding front tooth and long hanging breasts."[1040] Related Scottish figures like the *bean nighe* (washer woman) or *caoineag* may appear more childlike, washing the doomed's grave-clothes alongside streams or rivers. The MacDonalds' caoineag allegedly wept the night preceding 1692's Massacre of Glencoe, when approximately 30 of the family and their associates were killed.[1041]

Wailing ghost women portend death across other cultures. The Welsh banshee, *Gwrach-y-Rhibyn* ("Hag of the Dribble/Mist"), "is said to come after dusk and flap her leathern wings against the window where she warns of death, and in a broken, howling tone, to call on the one who is to quit mortality by his or her name several times."[1042] In Germany, the weeping *bažaloshtsh* ("God's plaint") presaged Wendish deaths, *die weisse frau* ("white lady") warned of highborn deaths, *ahnfrau* ("ancestress") of lowborn deaths. Any tragically-killed girl or child might create an *acheri* in India, whose singing signifies imminent death or illness.[1043]

Banshees also evoke stories of sirens and mermaids, whose enchanting voices lured sailors to their doom, or Spanish-language tales of *la Llorona* ("the weeper"), the ghost of a woman seeking her drowned child. Her sobbing attracts young men.[1044]

Death omens: Don’t knock it ‘til you’ve tried it

Knocks or raps, a staple across hauntings and poltergeist cases, are another universal death knell overlapping with faerie activity. An entire subset of faeries, the most prominent of which are the *knockers*, *tommyknockers,* and *coblynau* of Cornwall, Devon, and Wales, predominate deep underground in mines, where their tapping either leads workers to new veins of ore or warns of peril. These faeries “announce the doom of a miner by knocking three times distinctly, and when any lesser evil is about to befall him they are heard digging, pounding, and imitating other kinds of work.”[1045]

Raps also occur above ground in houses. German “little men of the mountains foretell death to the mountaineers by knocking three times at their door.”[1046] Similar sounds reminded the Welsh of carpenters hammering as they fashioned coffins.[1047]

An alternate interpretation suggests these noises presage *transition* more broadly. Just as they call the dying to Fairyland, knocks also draw faeries to our world—“one could summon both fairies and the dead by striking the ground.”[1048]

Other faerie death omens include the *bodach glas* (“dark grey man”), a male Irish boogeyman faerie, who signifies death if encountered three times.[1049] The Irish dullahan, or headless horseman, resembles the ankou but, instead of a death cart, may be on horseback or drive a death coach, sometimes pulled by decapitated horses.[1050] “The Death Coach, or Headless

Coach and Horses, is called in Ireland, *Coach a bower*," Croker wrote, "and its appearance is generally regarded as a sign of death, or an omen of some misfortune."[1051]

The Higher (S)elf

Most older faerie encyclopedias contain entries for doubles of the living… a curious inclusion if they are only nature spirits. A closer look reveals tantalizing similarities between the two bodies of superstition. Seeing your double can signify bad luck or impending death, just as seeing a faerie might. Some people seeing doppelgängers note an aspect of the doubled individual is slightly incorrect—hair too long, eye color wrong, etc.—bringing to mind our previous chapter's "faerie defects."[1052] Even Theosophists, who primarily view faeries as nature spirits, describe their *dependency* upon humans for food, offerings, procreation, etc.

This "doubling" occurs at the community level as well, with the structure of faerie societies resembling those of mortals. Faerie celebrations and ceremonies can parallel events in their accompanying human culture. *Nagumwasuck*, Passamaquoddy Little People, followed tribal migrations before setting up on reservations, "singing laments when there is a death in the tribe and rejoicing and dancing when there is a wedding."[1053] According to one text, a European clergyman celebrating a Mass for the dead "suddenly saw the church fill with dwarves the size of a finger."[1054]

"Domestic Elves celebrated their marriages on the same day as the people," according to Croker. "Their children were born on the same day; and they mourned their dead on the same day."[1055] Some stories, however, invert this relationship.

"There is an old Celtic belief, recorded by the Greeks and Romans, which hints at the idea of rebirth or reincarnation, that a person born in our world was dying in the Other World and a person who died in this world was born in the Other World," Daimler elaborates. "This idea, perhaps, explains the reason that fairies who wed mortal men were known to cry at births and laugh at funerals."[1056]

How rude. Yet the trend seems common enough. Grimm claimed "the dead 'belong to the fairies, and they therefore celebrate the death of a person like a festival, with music and dancing.'" One Welsh faerie bride "expressed displeasure at marrying a dead man, as the Fairies call us."[1057]

"*You* are *our* hidden folk," the huldufólk argue, according to a teacher whom podcaster Kendra Maurer met in 2021 while attending Reykjavik's "Elfschool."[1058] The Otherworld may be the Well of Souls itself, a revolving door of continuous death-and-rebirth.

If dead souls become faeries, perhaps living souls can as well, leaving our bodies as discussed in Chapter 3 to wander in shrunken, perhaps winged form. There are fleeting suggestions this takes place.

In addition to faeries and ghosts, luminous orbs were sometimes interpreted as doubles of the living called "fetch lights," hence their infamy as death omens (recall how wandering souls leave their owners vulnerable).[1059] Robert Kirk considered *co-walkers*—another double—to be a type of faerie appearing at funeral banquets, assisting as pallbearers[1060] and accompanying their owners through life before returning to Fairyland at death.[1061] Cherokee Little People appear as doubles of ill tribespeople, "seen outside when the

real person is still in bed"—or, interpreted differently, are souls detached by sickness or trauma.[1062]

In *Goblin Tales of Lancashire,* James Bowker tells of two witnesses to a faerie funeral named Adam and Robin. One night at Langton Church they heard the bells ring 26 times, corresponding to Robin's age. "Both men stepped back affrighted as a little figure clad in raiment of a dark hue, but wearing a bright red cap, and chanting some mysterious words in a low musical voice as he walked, stepped into the avenue." Hidden amidst the trees, the men watched pairs of similar beings walking together, hats-in-hand, bearing a tiny, black, open coffin.

"Robin, mi lad, it's th' pictur o' thee as they hev i' th' coffin!" whispered Adam. Robin fearfully reached out to touch their leader, causing the entire faerie crowd to vanish. A month after seeing his tiny double, Robin himself suffered injuries from a fall and perished.[1063]

In *Witches, Werewolves, and Fairies: Shapeshifters and Astral Doubles in the Middle Ages*, Claude Lecouteux outlines several medieval texts wherein faeries "bear a strong resemblance to the Double/fylgja, the tutelary genie." Souls leave the body during our sleep or trances, altered states of consciousness which facilitate visits to Fairyland; fylgjur appear in dreams. Both faeries and fylgjur can communicate telepathically, know our future, and adopt similar animal disguises. Faerie Queens, fylgja, Caciola's dancing dead women, and Zoroastrianism's Daēnā—an expression of the self in her own right—impart a powerful, authoritative, feminine identity.[1064]

(Speaking of Zoroastrianism, Iranian faeries [peris] "have many traits in common with the *fravashi*," which were personal spirits—souls—to

Zoroastrians. They were female by default, and both wandered during life and endured after death. Fravashi are symbolized by winged discs, which carry obvious UFO implications.)[1065]

Faeries have been identified akin to guardian angels or Higher Selves, but this is largely a New Age conception. Vague antecedent can be found in Andrew Lang's 1893 introduction to Kirk's *The Secret Commonwealth,* where he claims "the guardian Angel of the Roman superstition is merely the Double or Co-walker."[1066] Once again, Theosophists are primarily to thank—or blame—for faerie-angel conflation, combining nature spirits with Eastern concepts of devas which, while not always angelic, generally represent divine beings which intercede in human affairs.[1067]

In any case, stories here and there see faeries acting protectively. Some rescued children, as in one Scottish tale where a child was whisked from a hillside to his mother, lest he "come to harm with the cold."[1068] More recently, a Cornish motorist and his family "saw a brown leathery-skinned, very angry looking old man, standing about two and a half feet high, completely naked apart from a loin cloth type clothing" pointing at him from a hedgerow. Startled, he "braked sharply only to realize the road was falling sharply towards a sea wall. If I hadn't braked I would have driven over the sea wall and over the cliff face…." [1069]

Another connection obliquely points to faeries as the self. Demons, the departed, and faeries commonly served witches as their familiars, spirits assisting in magic and spellcraft.[1070] Familiars appeared as humans, dwarfs, or small animals like birds—forms commonly assumed both by faeries and

wandering souls. When projecting their souls, shamans and witches—the two comparable if not analogous—took the form of animals as well.

Simply put, familiars may represent one of their masters' multiple souls externalized in faerie form, an interpretation supported by esoteric philosopher Pierre A. Riffard's definition:

> A familiar spirit—(alter ego, doppelgänger, personal demon, personal totem, spirit companion) is the double, the alter-ego, of an individual. It does not look like the individual concerned. Even though it may have an independent life of its own, it remains closely linked to the individual.[1071]

Suffolk witch Anne Hammer claimed in 1645 that her faerie familiar "came out of her mouth," access point for the soul since antiquity.[1072] An early 1200s Swedish law provided an example of slander against women: "I saw you ride on a hurdle, with hair disheveled, in the shape of a troll, between night and day," indicating Scandinavian witches (or their projected souls) traveled in faerie form.[1073]

According to Daimler, the fetch in (modern) traditional faerie witchcraft "is an essential spiritual guide," typically appearing as the opposite sex. "There is some blurring, however, between the witch's own soul here and the realm of fairy… the fetch is that part of ourselves which is most strongly tied to the Otherworld."[1074] Based on historical texts, Daimler believes fetches are distinct from familiars,[1075] but it is impossible to know if these accounts reflect an objective interpretation of such spirits.

Changelings or walk-ins?

There are also physical faerie doubles. The previous chapter addressed adult changelings, but the superstition commonly surrounded infants and children. An otherwise cheerful, healthy child—typically an unbaptized infant—suddenly acts ill, peevish, and listless, crying constantly and, though ravenous, remains thin. It is no longer human. Faeries have taken the actual child, leaving behind *something else*: a changeling, variously described as a sickly faerie infant, elderly faerie, fetch, or *stock*, sometimes a beglamoured log enchanted to appear like a child.[1076] Folklore from various locales describes changelings left not only by faeries but demons, djinn, wild men, spirits, and all manner of nonhuman abductors.

After consulting a magician (sometimes called a "faerie doctor"), the kidnapped child is either rescued—through magic, rituals, or other techniques addressed momentarily—or lost forever when the changeling dies. Graves of kidnapped adults and children alike hold not their corpses, but lifeless faerie replicas.

It is said Robert Kirk himself, in punishment for revealing faerie secrets, never died, but was "taken": the body found by the Aberfoyle faerie hill was but a stock. Kirk allegedly visited a relative following his own funeral, swearing he would reappear in spectral form at his posthumously-birthed child's christening. A dirk thrown at him would break the enchantment and free him from Fairyland, he explained. When Kirk materialized as promised, the dirk-thrower froze in astonishment, "and the chance was lost."[1077]

Practically all child changelings look terminally ill, their limbs skeletal, heads enlarged, and faces wrinkled as though elderly. Citing these attributes as well as their behavior, most historians believe changelings represented developmentally disabled children. The assertion is accurate in many respects, with various conditions like autism matching some descriptions. However, if physical afflictions like illness originate in spiritual abduction—as many indigenous cultures hold—*both* scientific *and* paranormal perspectives on changeling narratives hold *some* truth.[1078]

Alternately, attempts to "rescue" these "stolen" children may have in fact *caused* their aberrant behavior. Operating under the assumption that faeries re-exchanged stolen children if the substitute was mistreated, parents violently abused suspected changelings. Tragically, many were pinched, poisoned, beaten, stabbed, burned, drowned, whipped, and abandoned in the elements, leading to shocking infanticide rates in Ireland. If survived, such trauma—visited upon otherwise healthy children—undoubtedly induced dissociative states; and, as explained in previous chapters, dissociative states might grant access to supernatural realms and abilities. Overly superstitious, abusive parents, not faeries, may have sent their children to "Fairyland" and back again. Unsurprisingly, many "recovered" children exhibited miraculous talents consistent with NDEs and shamanic awakening, growing up to become priests, magicians, and seers themselves.[1079]

Abuse also invites spirit attachment. Changelings might represent "walk-ins," a New Age term popularized by Ruth Montgomery's 1979 book *Strangers Among Us*, but resonant with older traditions.

"A walk-in is an entity that occupies a body that has been vacated by its original soul," James R. Lewis summarized. "The situation is somewhat similar to 'possession,' although in possession the original soul is merely overshadowed—rather than completely supplanted—by the possessing entity."[1080] Walk-ins occur whenever the soul wanders: during sleep, trance, abuse, trauma—even NDEs, where some survivors report their old selves permanently evacuating their bodies, replaced by entirely new souls upon resuscitation.[1081]

The stocks of changeling stories—often attributed to corpses or the comatose—correspond to people whose souls have wandered. Each time Scottish witch Isobel Gowdie visited Fairyland, "she left a 'fairy stock' beside her husband in bed," indicating "she underwent her experiences in a catatonic trance."[1082] Perhaps changelings are faerie squatters inhabiting abandoned human bodies, their victims' souls "away" in the altered state that is Fairyland.

"That fairies or elves are capable of possessing humans may seem like a strange concept… but it is a power that they were always understood to have until recently," wrote Daimler. Faeries were once known for "displacing the spirit and taking over control of the person's actions."[1083]

Walk-ins are consistent with the abrupt personality shifts changelings display. Happy children turn ornery, then themselves again, perhaps representing another soul's entrance and departure. It is worth noting that, in tales where children are recovered, their *physical* return often goes unobserved; in others, the homecoming is evidenced in mind, rather than body. In one story, a Breton "changeling is replaced by the real child, the

latter, as though all the while it had been in an unconscious trance-state," awakening and exclaiming, "Ah! Mother, what a long time I have been asleep."[1084]

Adults exhibit similar personality changes. After collapsing from a "fairy-dart" while dancing, Rickard the Rake was bedridden, rendered from a "jovial, reckless, good-humoured buck" to "a meagre, disagreeable, exacting creature, with pinched features, and harsh voice, and craving appetite; and for several weeks he continued to plague and distress his unfortunate family." His status as changeling was confirmed after his family heard the previously-unskilled Rickard playing bagpipes. A male-female faerie doctor pair restored him with threats of abuse—red-hot shovels and tongs, foxglove poisoning, and drowning.[1085]

> Then there was a rush at the door, and a bursting into the room; but there was no sign of the changeling on the bed, nor under the bed, nor in any part of the room. At last one of the women shouted out in terror, for the face of the fiend was seen at the window, looking in, with such scorn and hate on the fearful features as struck terror into the boldest. However, the fairy-man dashed at him with his burning tongs in hand; but just as it was on the point of gripping his nose, a something between a laugh and a scream, that made the blood in their veins run cold, came from him. Face and all vanished, and that was the last that was seen of him. Next morning, Rickard, now a reformed rake, was found in his own bed.[1086]

A spiritual awakening accompanied Rickard's return. He forsook alcohol, tobacco, and dancing, thereafter focusing upon "his reaping-hook, his spade, his plough, and his prayer-book."[1087]

Christianity exclusively blames possession on demons, but the same cannot be said for other cultures, where any spirit or deity might inhabit a victim's body—including the dead.[1088] In Casablanca in 1943, Dr. Natalie Monat consulted with a merchant whose son was "possessed by an evil spirit," later revealed as a Moroccan woman who had died long ago at a young age. Her soul since waited for a hapless youth to possess "so she could live a long span of years." After an asylum stay failed to help his son, the merchant took him to a witch in the desert.[1089]

"She chalked a big circle on the floor where my son was seated," the merchant told Monat. "He tried and tried but never could step out of that circle and the girl inside him screamed with rage all the while." The witch demanded the ghost depart in the name of Allah. After a time the boy was ashen, sweaty, frothing at the mouth and convulsing. "Suddenly a terrifying blood-curdling scream, a howl of rage and despair, came from my son's lips—the last sound the girl emitted."[1090]

"What's the matter?" the boy asked. "Why am I sitting on the floor? What are you all doing here staring at me?"[1091]

Reincarnation gone wrong

To amend Anne Strieber's infamous quote: "This has something to do with what we call death *and birth*." If the Otherworld is, as alluded earlier, both a destination and departure point in the ecology of souls, then faerie lore (and changelings in particular) may offer insight into the reincarnation process. Maybe souls arriving in our world represent departures from Fairyland and vice versa. Perhaps faeries supervise, rather than participate in, reincarnation.

Regardless of whether faeries represent nature spirits or ancestors, their mastery over fertility is implied. Theosophy's "elementals" spur vegetal growth, while medieval European "ancestors symbolized generational change, not only in terms of the past but also in terms of guaranteeing the fertility of the present and the arrival of the next generation," according to Caciola.[1092]

Deities like *Áine* identify equally as faerie queens or fertility deities.[1093] Citing folklorist Alfred Nutt, Spence argued faerie predecessors "the Tuatha De, as deities, were regarded as givers of life and as the patrons of growth and fertility."[1094] Celtic *Matronae*, mother goddesses, "were quickly incorporated into the goddesses of Fate, into the [Roman destiny goddesses] Parcae and, by means of etymology, into the dead," wrote Lecouteux. These figures were "quickly identified with midwives as well," *parcae* sharing a root with *parere*, "'to bring into the world.' Successors to the Parcae and the

mother goddesses, medieval fairies, inherited their attributes and were in turn mother goddesses, deities of fate, and messengers of death."[1095]

Trios of similar beings, also known as *Norns*, *Wyrds*, and *Moirai*, allot destinies to mortal infants "from India to Ireland." In French romances and *chansons de geste*, they are faeries: six fae folk bestowed gifts to Ogier the Dane at his birth, three to Garin de Monglane, and Galien, son of Olivier, was named by a faerie. Arthurian texts like *Brut* (c. 12 century) place "elves at the birth of Arthur" who "grant him gifts" for his rule.[1096]

Cultures disagree on exactly when humans are assigned souls. Though many religions pinpoint ensoulment at conception or sometime during pregnancy, other traditions believe children's souls enter their bodies sometime after birth. Stoic Greeks granted children animating "animal souls" at birth, but no "rational souls" until age 14 (many parents of teenagers will agree!).[1097] American clairvoyant Edgar Cayce claimed souls take as long as a full day to enter newborns,[1098] and some Jewish views place ensoulment long after birth, when a child says their first "Amen."[1099] Even after assignment, connections remain tenuous: in Kyrgyz shamanism, both mothers weakened from childbirth and newborns "are particularly vulnerable to attacks of bad spirits within forty days following birth, because the 'free soul' (*chymyn dzhan*) can easily leave the body."[1100]

If not walk-ins, could changelings represent mistakenly-assigned souls during this liminal period? Some occultists "thought that changelings might be the souls of the dead returned to inhabit the bodies of mortal children," wrote Silver. "Their old faces and wizened forms were indicators of the fact that they were reincarnations, that such changed children were really 'old

souls.'"[1101] Spence suggested those having "enjoyed more than one reincarnation," who "lived before in the locality"—i.e. location-bound ghosts—created changelings by ensouling children in their vicinity.[1102]

Lady Gregory recorded a corroborating story from the Aran Islands:

> There was an old man died, and after three days he appeared in the cradle as a baby; they knew him by an old look in his face, and his face being long and other things. An old woman that came into the house saw him, and she said, "He won't be with you long, he had three deaths to die, and this is the second," and sure enough he died at the end of six years.[1103]

Lady Gregory also wrote that faeries "bring back the old to put in the place of the young."[1104] If the lifeless "stocks" of changeling stories represent empty, soulless bodies, then perhaps children replaced by "elderly faeries" or "sickly faerie infants" are an attempt to describe reincarnation gone wrong: souls too aged, unripe, or unprepared for their earthly return, which falter and kill their hosts.

A psychopomp menagerie (pt. 1)

A list of the most prominent faerie fauna reads like a psychopomp animal catalogue, admittedly with a few outliers like cows and cats. These creatures either belonged to the fae folk or were shapeshifted faeries themselves. (The robust faerie traditions of "water horses," "water hounds," and "water bulls" are saved for our lake monster discussion in Chapter 18.)

- **Birds & owls.** As noted, faeries masquerade as birds, one of the most common animal psychopomps. Owls, another regular soul-guide, join the faerie host in one retelling of 1014's Battle of Clontarf.[1105] Three species of dwarf inhabit Germany's Isle of Rügen: the White, appearing as doves or butterflies; the Black, who cry like children or screech like owls; and the Brown, who nightly "frighten, in the shape of owls, thieves and lovers, or, like Will-o'-the-wisps, lead them astray into bogs and marshes…."[1106] County Waterford faerie lights were attributed to "luminous owls."[1107]

Ciguapa, elves of the Dominican Republic, share a vernacular name with the country's rare Stygian Owl (*Stygian* presents another connection to Underworld mythology, meaning "pertaining to the River Styx").[1108] Like some other faeries, Ciguapa display rear-facing feet, a feature some suspect originates in owls' eerie ability to rotate their head nearly 360°, giving their bodies a reversed appearance.[1109]

- **Deer.** Among the most common faerie animals, deer (either as disguised Little People or their livestock) live up to their psychopomp reputation by "lead[ing] people into Fairy[land] or to places that fairies wish them to be."[1110] The stag

"symbolizes the temporary liaison Samhain allows between the human world and the enchanted world of the fairies," Walter wrote.[1111]

- **Bees.** Iroquois fae folk change into robins, owls, bats, dogs, butterflies, ghost lights, stars, or bumblebees, psychopomps in their own right.[1112] In Cornwall, an invisible faerie guardian answering to *Browney* rounds up bees if called upon.[1113]

Faeries sometimes shapeshifted into bee swarms[1114]—as T.P. Ellis wrote of Welsh tradition, "When you begin to talk about fairies, you must begin with the bees, for they are the messengers of the fairies, and will lead you to them and their habitats."[1115] *Gobnait*, syncretized as an Irish saint, founded her Ballyvourney pilgrimage site after seeing nine white deer—a sure indicator of faeries—and "had a strong relationship with bees and used the properties of honey in the treatment of illness and healing of wounds."[1116]

- **Horses.** Powerful psychopomp symbols, horses are common disguises for faeries like pookas. Horses are also faeries' predominant mode of transport, both normally-proportioned and pint-sized, appearing in countless stories, traversing land, sea, and air with equal aplomb. The sound of invisible horses, as noted at Scottish Beltane celebrations in 1810 and 1825, may indicate a passing faerie rade. "A 19th century anecdotal account of the Fairy Rade seen near Bealtaine described it first as the noise of bridles and hooves, then appearing as a glowing troop of green-clad riders on white horses," Daimler wrote.[1117]

White steeds typically signify faerie royalty. Other faerie horses are black or grey, like the legendary Macha's Grey (*Liath Macha*) which emerged from and, dying, returned to a faerie hill. All three colors connote death. According to Daimler, the Tuatha Dé Danann "were renowned for their fabulous horses," which the faeries inherited as "exceptional mounts."[1118]

Lecouteux, comparing legends of "the land where no one dies," outlines a French variant where a man finds several immortal locales, but each is destroyed until he at

last meets a faerie.

> Peter met a fairy who transported him onto the star where she lived and where no one ever died. He remained there for centuries, but he grew bored and wanted to see his village again. Unable to dissuade him, the fairy gave him a horse to carry him there and ordered him not to dismount. He came to the village that had replaced his and whose inhabitants could barely understand his language. He pushed on farther and saw a cart stuck in the mud whose driver asked him for help. He set foot on the ground, but the carter was Death. The cart transformed into a pile of shoes: all the ones that Death had worn out looking for Peter.[1119]

"There are two points here to emphasize," Lecouteux writes. "The world of the fairy, which is that of immortality (like Avalon), and the psychopomp horse."[1120]

Like the dead departing on psychopomp steeds, anyone "taken" could be seen passing on horseback in faerie processions, during which they might be rescued. In the famous Scottish ballad, Tam Lin is saved by his mortal love, who plucks him off a white faerie horse, "holding him without faltering when the Fairy Queen transforms him into a variety of fearsome things."[1121] A father to one Irish changeling successfully restored his son after learning that, should he wait by a river, he would see his child "riding a white horse and if he could catch the white horse they could have him back."[1122]

Catherine Reddy of Raheen once cavorted with the faeries, traveling "up in the sky" and landing any place she liked, until one day they took her altogether. Two diligent boys, advised by a faerie doctor, recovered her by waiting in a County

Waterford field until midnight. They then shoved a white-handled knife and fork into opposite sides of a ditch, which revealed Catherine, "seated behind a man riding a white horse." She was rescued as she passed between the cutlery.[1123]

Household spirits are "particularly fond" of horses.[1124] It once was common to blame tangled manes on witches or faeries, who braided equine hair into makeshift stirrups for their nightly rides; today, many cryptozoologists attribute braided manes to Bigfoot.[1125] One explanation for Cornish faerie rings claimed pixies rode stolen horses in circles.[1126]

- **Cats.** Though cats are not prominent psychopomps in mythology, *cat sí*—large, black felids with a single white spot on their chest—serve as such, albeit nefariously. Writes Daimler:

> Fairy cats are usually viewed as malicious spirits and they have a strong association with the dead, but unlike other fairies this isn't because they are believed to be the dead themselves, but rather that they are thought to steal newly dead souls. In Scotland the bodies of the newly dead are carefully watched and special protections are used to ensure that a Cat Sí doesn't sneak in and steal the soul before it has separated from the body.[1127]

Today, Forteans catalogue "phantom cats" or alien big cats (ABCs) seen in Ireland, the British Isles, and the United States as anomalies because, despite enduring folktales, black panthers are not native to any of these locations. Even America's indigenous big cats, Florida panthers and pumas, have failed to yield any confirmed melanistic specimens. ABCs—which coincidentally appear in areas known for UFO, ghost light, and Bigfoot activity—can display supernatural abilities: they vanish, mutilate livestock, remain uncatchable, sometimes fail to leave footprints, and exhibit humanlike cunning.1128

- **Dogs.** One of the most common psychopomps, dogs appear in phantom form throughout faerie lore, distinguishable from natural animals by their ability to pass through objects, their large, glowing red eyes, their propensity for shapeshifting, and their immense size, as large as calves or ponies. Though typically black—"No matter how dark a night is, *you can always see the Dog* because he's so much blacker," one witness remarked—they sometimes sport white neck-rings, and also come in dark green or white with red ears.[1129] Regionally called *cwn annwn*, *Devil's Dandy Dogs, Gabriel Ratchets*, or *Hell Hounds,* these canids can all be roughly labelled *cu sí,* faerie hounds.[1130]

The cu sí lurk along roads, waterways, at intersections, by execution sites, on faerie hills, and in graveyards—whatever area is haunted. [1131] They are also spied circling faerie trees, on faerie rades, or during the Wild Hunt, as covered in Chapter 9.[1132] Some guard buried treasure, particularly in Scotland.[1133] If met on lonely lanes, they often pace witnesses until reaching liminal zones like crossroads or bridges, where they vanish in a flash.[1134] Like faeries, the cu sí are sometimes rumored to live underground, accompany storms, and appear alongside (or transform into) anomalous lights.[1135]

Such faerie creatures overlap with ghostly "black dogs" of Ireland and the British Isles like the solitary *Black Shuck, Padfoot, Grim,* or *Bogey*.[1136] There even exists a rough Islamic analogue: the *hinn*, lowest of the djinn, disguised as black dogs.[1137] A northern English name, *Barguest*, perhaps derives from the German *bahrgeist*, "spirit of the bier," clearly linking black dogs to the dead.[1138]

Like ghost lights or faerie funerals, the cu sí might follow paths regularly trod by funeral processions, and were almost always regarded as death omens. The Welsh cwn annwn were "heard to pass by the eaves of several houses before the death of someone in the family."[1139] (Interestingly, Wirt Sikes wrote, "That the Cwn Annwn are descendants of the wish-hound of Hermes, hardly admits of doubt.") [1140] A dog with "long shaggy hair and eyes like coals of fire" waylaid a man walking near Ramsey on the Isle of Man in 1927—"They looked at each other, until finally the dog moved so that the witness could proceed. His father died soon afterwards."[1141] In 1960, "a black dog haunting a road from St. Audries to Perry Farm" in Somerset appeared "just before" the deaths of two witnesses.[1142] "It isn't clear whether the dog causes the

death or, like the Irish Banshee, the dog shows up to warn of an impending death," wrote Daimler… though like banshees, their cries alone anticipate tragedy.[1143]

Some interpret cu sí not as faeries or their companions, but rather the Devil, witches, or ghosts. Their "blacker than black" coloration, shared with other paranormal entities, finds precedent in Classical ghost descriptions, which presented dead souls as "terribly black."[1144] In Scotland, ghosts became cattle, deer, or dogs as divine punishment for earthly crimes: in 1700s Perthshire, a black dog informed a Blairgowrie farmer it was the ghost of murderer David Souter, doomed to wander earth until his victim received a Christian burial. After the body's discovery and interment, no one saw the creature again.[1145]

A Cornish folktale describes "a strange spotted dog" only visible to a widow which "transformed into the ghost of her husband" and, later that day, carried her into the sky to a churchyard populated by "a great many spirits, some good and some bad." She was returned missing her shoe and newly deaf—"I must take something from you; either your eyesight, or your hearing," her husband apologized. During her sojourn, the widow's husband provided useful information to restore her station in life, deprived since his death. This exemplifies the lesser-discussed role of phantom dogs as positive forces.[1146]

"In one story from Swancliffe a man has a black dog appear twice and accompany him through a dark wood only to find out later that the dog had saved him from being robbed and killed by highwaymen," wrote Daimler.[1147] In this protective capacity, the cu sí resonate strongly with psychopomps and mythical guard dogs.

Faeries as psychopomps

Sometime in the 1930s, a young County Laois witness reading in her family orchard noticed "many small voices." Looking around, she saw a friend approaching—a local vicar, dead just a few days earlier, not yet buried—"looking pale and stricken." "Several fairy people, about the size of small children" pulled the vicar by his cassock. Frightened, she ran inside, never privy to her friend's fate.[1148] This remarkable tale from the FIS Census is one of only a handful of modern stories alluding to faeries as psychopomps.

Hints of this role lurk at the margins of popular culture. Perhaps inspired by his older brother's childhood death, J.M. Barrie created Peter Pan, "the boy who never grew up." In *Peter Pan in Kensington Gardens*, children's souls appear as birds until they are assigned parents—Peter flew away at seven days old, never returning, remaining in a liminal prebirth state. In *Peter and Wendy*, Mrs. Darling outright designates Peter a psychopomp: "… after thinking back into her childhood she just remembered a Peter Pan who was said to live with the fairies. There were odd stories about him; as that when children died he went part of the way with them, so that they should not be frightened."

There certainly exists evidence that faeries, if not the dead themselves, fill *some* sort of managerial role in the afterlife. Perhaps, as some suggest, they guard the dead.[1149] In other instances, faerie queens and kings rule the Underworld, like Proserpine or Finnbheara.[1150] Lady Gregory wondered in

passing whether "spirits in dress of ancient authority," i.e. faerie royalty, were "the shepherds of the more recently dead."[1151]

Medieval artists and authors long ago merged *nymphs*, Greek nature spirits, with faeries. *Calypso*, "the nymph who encountered Odysseus… is an embodiment of death," according to Herzog, paraphrasing Indo-Germanist Herman Güntert. Her name originates in "hide in the earth" or "bury" (*kaluptein*). She shares associations with Persephone and Hecate, both chthonic figures, and "the island of Ogygia, the home of Homer's Calypso" presents "the characteristics of a garden of death, however enchanting and lovely it may be," though the nymph herself lives in a cave.[1152]

But just as death omens are not psychopomps, neither are chthonic deities. We must continue our search for psychopomp faeries.

Faerie lore adopted a handful of explicit psychopomps, some already mentioned. Áine "rewarded the learned by leading them when they died into fairy realms."[1153] Donn is both a faerie king and leader of souls to the afterlife.[1154] Manannán mac Lir, by dint of his membership among the Tuatha Dé Danann, finds association with faeries.[1155] Ogmios may originate in *Oghma*, another Tuatha Dé Danann figure.[1156]

The Blessed Virgin Mary can serve as a Christian psychopomp, but her iconography remains complex. Joan of Arc, alongside countless other visionaries, "often seems to mix up standard vernacular terms for the fairies —'white ladies,' 'good ladies'—with those for the Virgin ('Our Lady')." Diane Purkiss noted how Bernadette Soubirous, frequenting a known Pyrenean faerie locale, saw *uo petito damizela*, "a little lady"—the site became the

fountain of Lourdes, her sighting a Marian apparition.[1157] Such conflation calls into question the identity of every psychopompic Mary seen during NDEs.

The most prominent psychopomp associated with faeries is *Gwyn ap Nudd*, "The White Son of Nudd" (Nudd perhaps the same character as Tuatha Dé Danann king *Nuada*). Gwyn ap Nudd was "a British deity of battle and of the dead, who conducted the slain in to the other-world"—the Welsh Annwfn—"and ruled over them there."[1158] Over time, Gwyn ap Nudd's role diminished from "a Celtic Pluto"[1159] to king of the Welsh faeries, sometimes leading the Wild Hunt, a psychopomp retinue of the dead covered in Chapter 9, accompanied by the cwn annwn.[1160] Gwyn ap Nudd is strongly associated with Glastonbury Tor, a hill in Somerset.[1161]

If faerie royalty can be psychopomps themselves, it stands to reason they might enlist their subjects in such a massive undertaking. Alongside sirens and mermaids tempting sailors to doom with their voices, other Greek sea nymphs, *nereids*, overtly appear as psychopomps in several Classical texts.[1162]

"The oldest Germanic story of a dwarf makes him guardian of the portals of the dead, the summoner who calls men to enter the world underground," Chester Nathan Gould wrote—very close to a psychopomp role.[1163] *Anito* of the Philippines, as noted earlier, are at once nature spirits, ancestors, and leaders of souls to the afterlife.[1164]

Several New World faeries are psychopomps. In some Jamaican folktales, duppies are heard "calling the living to the land of the dead."[1165] The Miami *paissa*, "little ones," served "as guides to lead the spirits of the dead along the Milky Way to the afterlife."[1166]

"Before the Removal, [Cherokee nûñnë'hï] invited the occupants of several villages to come and live with them and the new houses of these towns could later be seen at a certain place in the bottom of a river," wrote indigenous folklorists John Witthoft and Wendell S. Hadlock. "These nunnéhi may be the spirits who lead the souls of the dead through the highways of the streams up to the springs which are the doors to the underworld."[1167] This speculation was rendered explicit in the 2000 testimony of a Cullowhee, North Carolina informant: "When old folks were dying, when they were sick and all, these Little People appeared before them…."[1168]

Dromintee seer Biddy Grant related a similar story with psychopomp overtones. "I saw *them* once as plain as can be—big, little, old, and young. I was in bed at the time, and a boy whom I had reared since he was born was lying ill next to me." Two, then three faeries examined the boy. One of them held a book and "put his hand to the boy's mouth; then he went away, while others appeared, opening the back window to make an avenue through the house; and through this avenue came great crowds." The boy recovered.[1169]

Generally speaking, rank-and-file faeries rarely exercise the altruism, patience, or neutrality required to lead souls—yet they sometimes perform functions similar to psychopomps. Their mastery over fate implies "past all dispute that they infallibly foreknew the time of Men's death," and exercise clear power over the threshold of life and death.[1170] Psychopomps finalize or reverse death by escorting or rejecting the dead, respectively; we have alluded to mystics obtaining healing power from faeries. Like all Tricksters—and by extension many psychopomps—faeries are mischievous, gender fluid, liminal, and sexually transgressive. The Tylwyth Teg live "halfway between

something material and spiritual."[1171] Mexican *chaneques* dwell in "places where the world of men and death touch each other."[1172]

Faeries *lead* us into Fairyland, sometimes under duress, in the form of lights, faerie animals, or in corporeal form. Many of those drawn into Fairyland remain there forever, functionally dead to our reality. As guides to the Otherworld, faeries even carry people away in psychopomp boats: the lay of *Guigemar*, for instance, features a knight who falls asleep in "a splendid ship that is totally deserted," awakening in the arms of a faerie lady.[1173] Perhaps drawing upon his German heritage, Jung described archetypal dwarfs as "kinsmen of the unconscious," "protect[ing] navigation" as "guardian[s] of the threshold of the unconscious."[1174]

A word on wands. Wands signify royalty and leadership. Consider kings' scepters, or marching bands and orchestras led by baton. Wands also appear in various guises as a psychopomp motif: Hermes's kerykeion, Yama and Wepwawet's maces, the Etruscan psychopomp Charun's hammer, Guan Yin's willow bough, Odin's staff, Manannán's bough, Epona's large key, the Valkyrie Göndul's spear shaft, Thoth's wands, even Charon's oar and the Reaper's scythe can be viewed as wands of a sort. References to wands for summoning the dead fill Greco-Roman necromantic texts.[1175]

Wands are also devices of transition, revealing pathways into the Otherworld. Jizō's staff pries open the gates of hell, Hermes uses his kerykeion to induce sleep, and entrance to Fairyland is sometimes granted by knocking the ground—the "ceiling" of the underworld—with staves. (In a humorous 1961 Welsh account, a dogwalker tapped his muddy walking stick on a road sign three times, accidentally summoning a three-foot tall, green-

clad faerie).[1176] Indeed, James Frazer's epic folklore collection *The Golden Bough* derives its name from a moment in the *Aenid* when the *Sibyl* and Aeneas use the golden bough to enter Hades.[1177]

Ergo, we might assume wands—which, alongside wings and small size, have become a staple in faerie depictions—represent crucial Otherworld navigation tools for psychopomps, perhaps hinting that faeries may be psychopomps themselves. At first blush, this accessory seems another artistic flourish, but the use of wands by faeries stretches back at least a millennia, into aos sídhe mythology.

"It's fairly well established that the wand was an important tool used by the Druids in general, and Celtic magic users as well," wrote Daimler.[1178] Woods of various types also provided protection: according to Wilde, in "tales of the fairy dances with the dead, the mortals drawn into their company are infallibly safe if they get possession of a branch of the ash-tree, and hold it safely till out of reach of the evil spell."[1179]

Other narratives clearly feature faerie psychopomps collecting the dead—with seemingly nefarious motivations. Elves "divided among themselves the souls of men, and considered them thenceforth as their property," Croker chillingly asserted. "After death they become the property of their Elves… The dead belong to the faeries…."[1180]

This alludes to the aforementioned "teind to Hell" owed by faeries. Informed by witchcraft testimony and poetic invention, 16th century southern Scots believed faeries collected souls either annually or every seven years.

"The core concept behind this payment seems to be the idea that the fairies are the vassals or subjects of Hell and its ruler and so owe it and him rent on a set basis," wrote Daimler. "This rent is paid, we might say, in the currency of Hell—people."[1181] The idea of a faerie "soul harvest" is chilling, the harvest a longstanding symbol for life's "double mystery": the confluence of fertility and death.[1182]

The teind largely represents a Christian attempt to appropriate Celtic folklore (often framing fae folk as fallen angels), but a few unsettling stories describe faeries collecting souls. One recorded by Croker, "The Soul Cages," describes a County Clare fisherman who meets a *merrow* (mermaid) in a seaside cave, finding rows of cages holding "the souls of drowned sailors." On each subsequent visit the protagonist out-drinks his host and releases more captives. A lovely story—but an admitted fabrication without any folkloric basis, passed along to Croker by story-collector Thomas Keightley.[1183]

Though admittedly an embellisher of folklore as well, Yeats supported faeries-as-harvesters: "When the soul has left the body, it is drawn away, sometimes, by the fairies. I have a story of a peasant who once saw, sitting in a fairy rath, all who had died for years in his village. Such souls are considered lost."[1184]

More recently and more credibly, an English witness's mother on her deathbed in 2013 regularly saw—first in dreams then on the cusp of waking—a young, silent "child with curly golden hair."

> As her illness progressed, the child would visit her more and her appetite decreased as it became apparent that this child was feeding her in her dreams. Whilst she was half-asleep I would see her raise her hand to her mouth and chew. This made things difficult for me as when I woke her up to feed her, she would argue that she was already full from feasting on the bramble pie and the meat and greens [from] the golden-haired child… I struggled to get her to eat something and later still even to drink.[1185]

The witness, an author and illustrator of faerie lore herself, immediately thought of the faerie food taboo. Even in the absence of heavy medication, her mother started losing all sense of identity, her eyes clouding "black as if her pupils were dilated to entirely cover her irises," reminding the witness of "the 'stocks' of folklore." She began describing phantom cats, butterflies, and ghosts, including dead friends, in the room. Her mother finally died—or was "taken"—in hospital.[1186]

The Schiehallion faerie witness from the previous chapter experienced theft of a different kind. After unearthly music announced the "cheeky wee bastard's" arrival, a female companion appeared at his feet, silver shears in-hand.[1187]

"She's working away around my toes, cutting the shadow off at my toe," he said. "I just sort of went, 'Oy!'… He looked at her, and she looked at him, and poof, you know? Gone." Neither afraid nor angry, the witness was nonetheless disturbed. "I don't think they were trying to do me any favors—it doesn't seem like a favor for someone to take your shadow away. That sounds like death."[1188]

We again invoke Peter Pan, locked in eternal pursuit of his own shadow. Shadows, of course, enjoy a reputation as doubles and aspects of the soul, extensively covered in the work of Otto Rank. Indigenous people guarded them from supernatural theft and prevented their shadows from casting upon taboo objects: "Whoever casts no shadow, dies; whoever has a small or faint shadow is ill, while a well-outlined shadow indicates recovery."[1189] Anomalous shadows, a common paranormal manifestation, are often interchangeable with ghosts. Ergo, our Schiehallion faerie may have been attempting to take the witness's soul.

Psychogogs

A subset of legends where women act as midwives to faerie births hints at the reciprocal role we play with faeries in the migration of souls. In these narratives, a lady is typically summoned by a black rider to a faerie birth, and while attending may be warned against accepting any gifts in compensation. Sometimes a special ointment is rubbed on the infant or its eyes, the midwife forbidden to use any herself. In stories where she does so, faerie glamour is dispelled, or the midwife is able to perceive the faeries. Later, upon noticing one of their kind in public, she is punished for her transgression, perhaps blinded.[1190]

We have already touched upon the association of Roman parcae, fate deities related to faeries, with midwifery. In tales of "Midwives to the Faeries," death commonly rears its head—the black horseman or coach is a death symbol, and dead souls appear as faerie captives. Sometimes "it is the woman whom the midwife is to attend who is mortal, again often a neighbouring woman who had died in the recent past."[1191]

Inversion equals representation in these stories. Seemingly oppositional motifs often share a root source. For example, the faeries are ever-leaving, extraterrestrials ever-arriving in their respective folklore. (As analogy, consider intervals in Western music: the pitch A sounding above a C is a major sixth, while a C sounding above an A is a minor third—non-comparable intervals, theoretically speaking—yet the components are identical, save for octave and placement.)

Human midwives bring faeries into birth, suggesting faerie psychopomps bring humans into death, a possibility if entry into one world represents death from another. In this sense, midwives are "psychopomps in reverse" to faeries—to coin a phrase *psychogogs*, leading out of, rather than into, the Otherworld (*gog* the opposite of *pomp*).

Like psychopomps, midwives are liminal, mediate between worlds, lead souls from another realm, and in some cultures were even bestowed powers of life-or-death.[1192] In Japan, "At a birth the midwife could ask if the infant was to be kept or should be sent back to the realm of the gods," wrote Zen author Jan Chozen Bays. "The decision was made jointly by the husband and in-laws, not by the woman alone."[1193]

Our faerie discussion brings us no closer to answers. This is partially due to the inherently confusing, conflicting nature of faerie lore. As Daimler puts it, "The human dead aren't fairies, except when they are. Fairies aren't the human dead, except when they might be."[1194]

Despite their association with death, faerie activities are lively affairs, emphasizing pleasures of the flesh: feasting, drinking, playing music, dancing, etc. Perhaps in stories of human midwives to faeries, their true nature emerges: they are avatars of the *cycle of life*, rather than its end alone. They are life *and* death, a contradiction, both shades of ourselves *and* nature spirits focused on growth, rather than decay. Faeries serve as stewards to the ecology of souls, planting new lives, pruning dead branches, facilitating growth. (We are not finished with faeries—any intellectually-honest Ufologist sees clear parallels to the modern "extraterrestrial" conundrum, explored in Chapter 10 and beyond.)

It may seem distant, impossible to reach, open by invitation only, but in truth you hold a passport to the Otherworld. It is right there, inches from your nose. You must simply open your eyes… or your mind.

6

ALTERED STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS

OBJ



"Real" is a finicky word. What we conceptualize as a binary state, conflating "real" with "material," is in fact more of a spectrum. Yes, that junked 1990 Dodge Dynasty in the neighbor's driveway is real, you can touch the damn thing, but so is a political party, and we only verify the latter's existence by its members' (often contradictory) actions. You can't touch love, yet we know it is more "real" than any body politic, authenticated by internal gnosis, remaining evergreen as the world around us—the "real," as reductionist Materialism asserts—contorts into new meanings none of us recognize. Entire societies cede control of the "real" to authority figures acting only in alignment with *their* internal realities.

Thus the "psychedelic renaissance" of the late 2010s, while a welcome respite from decades of closed-minded thinking surrounding drugs, seemed

nothing short of irritating. Spurred by books like Michael Pollan's *How to Change Your Mind* (2018)*,* this movement pushed psychedelics back into polite society. Discussing mind-altering, vision-inducing, consciousness-expanding drugs became fashionable overnight.

The topic became unavoidable at every family reunion and soirée: "Have you heard? Psychedelics might have legitimate value!" The establishment finally conceded permission to respect these substances, even suggesting altered states of consciousness might contain a reality all their own.

Do you know who *doesn't* pop up in conversation at cocktail parties? The Shipibo. The Bwiti. The Witoto, or literally thousands of indigenous cultures who have used psychedelically-induced altered states of consciousness to enrich their lives since time immemorial. A near-constant refrain of ridicule from scientific Materialists tacitly implied these cultures were "superstitious primitives."

"There are indigenous traditions, thousands of years old—[Pollan] hasn't really talked about those things," noted Dennis McKenna, brother of late psychonaut-philosopher Terence McKenna, in 2018.[1195] We should never have waited to destigmatize psychedelics.

Other altered states of consciousness (ASCs) were never taboo. While difficult to define, ASCs represent any deviation from standard, normal, waking awareness. Psychology professor Dieter Vaitl outlined five categories: *spontaneous*, including day dreaming and near-death experiences; *physical and physiological*, including sexual intercourse or fasting; *psychological*, including meditation, hypnosis, and music-induced states; *pathological*, including brain damage and epilepsy (or, among Dying Brain adherents,

NDEs); and *pharmacological*, induced by psychoactive substances like psilocybin ("magic mushrooms"), *N,N*-Dimethyltryptamine (DMT), or lysergic acid diethylamide (LSD or "acid"), to name but a few.[1196]

Many ASCs provoke dissociative states, a recurring theme throughout this work. Though not listed among Vaitl's categories, death is the most profound, permanent ASC imaginable, even in an atheist model.

ASCs interest Forteans because they follow the dream logic prevalent in so many encounters, particularly visits to the Otherworld like out-of-body experiences, travels to Fairyland, or alien abductions. Perhaps this is why psychonauts call their experiences "trips," since they not only feature visions overlain on our reality, but entirely new surroundings as well—their consciousness seems "taken" to other dimensions of High Strangeness, populated by the same beings witnesses report encountering in (presumably) waking life.

Researchers bucking the trend of orthodoxy have long suspected ASCs play a critical role in understanding UFOs. John Keel, for instance, entertained this possibility in 1975's *The Eighth Tower*, yet the trend has only become fashionable in the past few decades.[1197] Modern Ufologists, imprisoned by the Materialist paradigm, remain conservative at their own peril, as ASCs may represent the most consistent method available for interacting with UFO intelligences.

"Psychedelic drugs are as important to the study of UFOs as the telescope was to the redefining of astronomy," argued Terence McKenna (hereafter "McKenna"). "You can meet the alien. Tomorrow night, if your connections

are good enough. And you can meet the alien over, and over, and over again."[1198]

Though not noted above, both sensory deprivation and exhaustion also induce ASCs. The former is why spiritual revelation takes place during katabasis: deprived of input from eyes and ears in the depths of the earth, minds wander, perhaps even open, allowing input from other realities to seep in. People also report ASCs during meditative states in float tanks, soundproof, pitch-black chambers filled with body-temperature water. Regarding exhaustion, visionary faerie artist Brian Froud, fatigued by a book tour across America, "started to have—it seemed to be—psychic experiences with fairies... they were sort of, like, popping up."[1199]

ASCs vis-à-vis the paranormal deserve exploration in an entire book, not a chapter, but that task is left to others. Within this limited space, our primary focus falls upon psychedelics, with distant secondary emphases on dreams and meditation, and their relationship with death. First, a brief note on hypnosis.

You are getting very sleepy…

Ufology has a hypnosis problem. Hypnotic regression, wherein a witness is placed in an ASC and narrates suppressed memories from their encounter's "missing time," became *de rigueur* among alien abduction researchers in the latter half of the 20th century. While effective for behavior modification and psychological complaints like depression and anxiety, promises of hypnosis as a memory retrieval tool fall short. Evidence indicates the hypnotized fabricate details or, worse, incorporate the hypnotist's leading questions into their narrative.[1200] (Having said this, later chapters include UFO accounts both consciously recalled and retrieved under hypnosis, though the latter are indicated whenever possible.)

Another caveat: if hypnosis is an ASC, is it possible—as suggested by paranormal personalities like Miguel "Red Pill Junkie" Romero—that hypnotic regression represents an Otherworld visit created "in real time"? Put another way, is the subject's narration of "memories" actually a running commentary on an experience unfolding on the hypnotist's couch, their consciousness accessing another realm on a journey conflated with their initial sighting?

A few points support this possibility. Hypnotists sometimes encourage UFO witnesses to "leave their bodies" or "project their spirits" during regression.[1201] Entire abduction narratives have been successfully implanted in non-experiencers during hypnosis, leaving room for the possibility that hypnotists guide people into other realms (rendering them semi-psychopomps themselves).[1202] Jim Schnabel, while dismissing the interaction

as pure imagination, relates one case where Jenny Randles attended the hypnotic regression of experiencer Susan Day:

> As the questioning went on, it became clear that the woman hadn't asked the aliens these questions unprompted, during the previously reported abduction. No, she'd been passing the questions to the aliens then and there, while under hypnosis! Randles would ask a question, and Day would be silent for a while as she mentally relayed the question to the aliens, and then she would speak up and relay the aliens' answer back to Randles.[1203]

There seems to be *something* objectively real occurring in these states, at least occasionally. Hypnotized subjects, even in the absence of any paranormal experiences, can replicate in specific detail "scenarios to which they have not had access by any conventional means," Hilary Evans wrote. "In the state of hypnosis—and it is reasonable to conjecture that other states may serve equally well—*subjects appear able to obtain access to material by non-physical and non-sentiment means* [author's emphasis], and then to re-structure that material on a creative and selective basis, using it to construct a dramatic, circumstantial and persuasively coherent account."[1204]

Hypnotic regression is not confined to alien abduction study—it is also the primary means by which past life "memories" are obtained. Most recollections are flattering (it seems Cleopatra reincarnated into thousands of people), but others are more humbling: an arrogant 21-year-old man named Andy, regressed by hypnotherapist Michael Newton, discovered his most

recent incarnation was as black Georgia sharecropper named Otis who died penniless at 45.[1205]

Newton's nonprofit, The Newton Institute, offers scripts for hypnotists to help patients contact deceased loved ones.[1206] This application of hypnotism has a storied history. Occultists have long utilized *scrying*—gazing into reflective surfaces like water, crystal balls, or black mirrors—to induce hypnotic states in which the dead might be contacted.

NDE pioneer Raymond Moody, inspired by Greco-Egyptian stories of the Oracle of the Dead at Epirus, resurrected the notion of the *psychomanteum*: a small, enclosed scrying space for contacting the dead. Moody felt psychomanteums showed great potential for resolving grief,[1207] saying, "I'm confident we have developed a reliable method where people can be conducted through a procedure and they will see a full apparition of a departed loved one."[1208]

Such communications can evolve into full-fledged possessions. In Zimbabwe, music allows "spirits of the ancestors" to inhabit Shona mediums in "something akin to hypnosis or even self-hypnosis."[1209] More recently, mediums of the Spiritualist tradition self-induced hypnotic states to invite communication from the dead in séances, with varying degrees of authenticity. In genuine cases, spirits spoke or wrote through hypnotized mediums, who retained little recall of the evens (shades of amnesia or missing time).[1210]

Another, more spontaneous form of hypnosis may play a role in sightings. It seems possible some UFO and cryptid sightings reported by motorists are facilitated by "highway hypnosis," an ASC induced by the monotony of the

road in which the journey is navigated safely, but with little recollection of specifics.

In one example, Beauford E. Parham, driving home late the evening of June 29, 1964, saw a bright light above Lavonia, Georgia. The UFO—a six-by-eight-foot object complete with masts and portholes, hissing "like a million snakes"—instantly snapped into his headlights, prompting Parham to follow it in a "near trance-like state." The UFO appeared twice more before vanishing in a "split second," leaving Parham with a burning sensation on his arms and an oily substance on his car, which suffered mechanical issues afterward. Parham's psychopomp ship embodies McKenna's Jung-inspired "Never-Never Land'" in which the psychic and physical meet.[1211]

Subjective versus objective

Materialists commonly dismiss ASCs as mere "hallucinations." While this can be true, hallucinations generally lack the profound revelatory qualities of true psychedelic visions. "Superstitious" indigenous testimony ardently contends the latter are *objective*, as opposed to *subjective* hallucinations.

The peculiar phenomenon of shared visions implies psychedelics can have an objective quality. A young couple from Atlanta, Georgia were enjoying psilocybin mushrooms in their backyard circa 2010 when the girlfriend left to fetch a cup of water. Through the kitchen window, she saw her boyfriend bathed in light, a UFO dangling above him—a hallucination, surely. But her boyfriend was visibly disturbed: "You wouldn't believe it," he said upon her return, before she could speak. "I was about to be taken by a bright light in the sky."[1212]

Others under the influence of psychedelics learn things they have no ability to know. In Peru, six Cashinahua who had consumed *ayahuasca*—an indigenous psychoactive medicine discussed later—informed anthropologist Kenneth Kensinger of his grandfather's death, confirmed two days later via radio. Herbalist Manuel Córdova-Rios, drinking the brew himself, learned of his own mother's death independently.[1213]

Still others receive divine inspiration: Francis Crick, discoverer of DNA's double-helix structure, is widely believed to have done so under the influence of LSD, though this is perhaps urban legend.[1214] Fellow Nobel Prize winner

Kary Mullis, however, staunchly contended that acid revealed to him the polymerase chain reaction method, by which laboratories copy DNA.[1215]

Skeptics assume psychedelics are solely responsible for such experiences, rather than entertaining the possibility they may only represent the *mechanism* by which such experiences enter our consciousness; to repeat an earlier analogy, this mindset is akin to thinking the contents of a room lie within the key it unlocks. Rick Strassman, supervisor of a five-year study of DMT at the University of New Mexico, compared the compound's effects to changing channels on a television, wherein the brain is a receiver, rather than the generator, of consciousness.

Psychedelics are remote controls for the television of the brain. Under their influence, "no longer is the show we are watching everyday reality, Channel Normal."[1216] Like oppressive older siblings, our authority structures seem intent on keeping our televisions set to Channel Normal. It's long past time for Big Brother to stop hogging the remote.

Brain imaging supports Strassman's model, revealing how compounds like psilocybin reduce brain activity in the claustrum by 15-30%. Prior to this, many assumed psychedelics *increased* brain activity, evidenced by the highly imaginal nature of trips.[1217] Esotericists see this as evidence that our brains employ engrained defenses to "filter out" other "channels," outlined in numerous ancient traditions where "Channel Normal" is illusory. Hinduism calls our waking "unreality" *Maya*.[1218]

"It is on the whole probable that we continually dream, but that consciousness makes such a noise that we do not hear it," Jung said.[1219] Aldous Huxley dubbed this governing filter a "reducing valve,"[1220] Jenny

Randles "the doorman," "a facet of our mind that determines which data to allow into consciousness and which to keep out of reach."[1221] By "dropping the veil" we perceive, as McKenna put it, "the burning, primary reality that lies behind the dross of appearances."[1222]

Not all psychedelic trips are revelatory or important. But, objective or subjective, these substances contain genuine therapeutic value. MDMA (3,4-Methylenedioxymethamphetamine, or "ecstasy"), a psychedelic in the broadest sense, is wildly successful in couples counseling.[1223] Ketamine and psilocybin both treat fear and depression. Their effects last months.[1224]

"The most interesting and remarkable finding is that a single dose of psilocybin, which lasts four to six hours, produced enduring decreases in depression and anxiety symptoms, and this may represent a fascinating new model for treating some psychiatric conditions," said Roland Griffiths, professor at the Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine.[1225]

Psychedelics like psilocybin and even LSD demonstrate enormous potential for terminal care. Psychiatrist Stanislov Grof found "that most people who undergo LSD therapy eventually experience a death and rebirth sequence similar to those described in various rites of passage and ancient mystery school initiations," according to Laura Strong. "They documented the fact that during the course of such therapy, their patients' 'concepts of death underwent dramatic changes. Fear of their own physiological demise diminished, they became open to the possibility of consciousness existing after clinical death, and tended to view the process of dying as an adventure in consciousness rather than the ultimate biological disaster.'"[1226]

Psychedelics, in other words, help us die to death.

Dreamland

Even the most sober individuals experience ASCs nightly during sleep. Like other ASCs, dreams vary on a spectrum from believable to nonsensical, but were long regarded as trips of the soul or consciousness to the Otherworld.

A sort of inconsequential, short-term amnesia plagues dreams, which often fade from memory unless immediately recorded. German mystic Friederike Hauffe, the "Seeress of Prevorst," slept "a period of six years and five months, and then awoke as from a one-night sleep with no memory of what she did during that time; but some time afterwards memory of the period came to her so completely that she recalled all its details."[1227] Dreams share this attribute both with Otherworld travels—recall lethe offered to the Greek dead, or missing time—and psychedelic trips.

"Perhaps every night we go as deep as these psychedelic drugs take us," McKenna offered. "There's apparently very little short-term and long-term memory trace laid down by these experiences."[1228]

Strassman, speaking with "early DMT pioneer" Stephen Szára, learned subjects given too much of the compound "could not remember anything. They could not bring back memories of the experience. The only thing that remained with them was the feeling that something frightening had happened."[1229]

Another quality shared across ASCs and Otherworld journeys is time's compression or expansion. You have undoubtedly napped for what felt like hours, only to awaken minutes later; similarly, a perceived momentary doze during a film might end as the credits roll (psychedelics exhibit similar contractions and dilations, covered later). Dreams also allow descent along Jung's *via regia* ("royal path") "to the unconscious and hence to self-knowledge," a nightly katabasis from which we emerge with new insight.[1230]

"It must be emphasized that although dreams are inner experiences they are not subjective," Harpur wrote. "That is, our conscious minds do not create them. They do not belong to us: they happen to us. The ancient Greeks were correct when they never spoke of *having* a dream. but always of *seeing* a dream. They also made a fundamental distinction between significant dreams and non-significant."[1231]

This distinction, defined in other traditions as "big dreams" versus "small dreams," separates the precognitive from the frivolous. "Big dreams" might deliver prophecy, accessing some unidentified store of knowledge—perhaps Theosophy's Akashic Records—to provide information untethered from cause and effect. These foretell future events or offer inaccessible knowledge, particularly regarding the transmigration of souls.

Anecdotes claim mothers learn of pregnancies long before taking any tests.[1232] Sometimes children declare themselves reincarnated family members in dreams before their birth. Ian Stevenson called these "announcing dreams."[1233] Just as ayahuasca told Kensinger and Córdova-Rios about familial loss, dreams also warn us of death.

David Ryback and Letitia Sweitzer recorded many examples of dream death omens in 1988's *Dreams That Come True*. In December 1975 Allison dreamed of her daughter on a train track. "Killed" during the rescue attempt, she shared the nightmare with her husband. Two weeks later, they were sending friends off at the station when something the daughter wished to retrieve fell on the track—the train killed them both. In another account, a young woman dreamt of "her grandmother lying very pale in her bed at home" hundreds of miles away in Tennessee. The old lady's breathing grew shallower before she smiled, jolting the dreamer awake. It was just after 5:00 a.m., later confirmed as within minutes of her grandmother's actual passing.[1234]

Ryback and Sweitzer also tell of a Marcia C. of Huntingdon, Pennsylvania, who dreamt of her son David's funeral visitation in 1975—soon after, he died in an automobile accident. Marcia viewed the dream perhaps as a warning, but more like "a message that David's existence would not end at the casket but goes on just so sweetly and happily as before."[1235]

Terminal patients report death dreams immediately before passing away. According to New York hospice doctor Christopher Kerr, 80% of 1,400 subjects "reported dreams or visions leading up to their deaths." "It's life-affirming, I can tell you that," he said, adding that such dreams remove patients' fear.[1236] Even if only anticipatory preparations from the subconscious, these dreams, like Marcia C.'s, help us die to death.

Dreams also avert tragedy. One morning in the 1980s, the brother of North Carolina paranormal investigator Tina McSwain—part of a family of sensitives—rushed into her home, convinced a fire was imminent. "He went straight to

an outlet, removed the cover, and found the wires smoldering," she said.[1237] In autumn 1964, Caroline Somerfield, age 12, dreamt a truck forced her father's car off the Jersey Turnpike, causing an accident so violent the engine dislodged. Despite his caution, Caroline's father was involved in an identical accident, but survived.[1238]

Like other ASCs, dreams are not infallible. Aristotle mostly ascribed dream precognition to coincidence. In genuine cases, he believed the dreamer's consciousness reached into the future, whereas Democritus suggested future events reflected backward.[1239] Dream researcher Andrew Paquette kept fastidious logs of his dreams, finding 12 individuals in 50 precognitive death dreams died without his foreknowledge (24%)—an impressive, but not spotless, track record. [1240]

As mentioned in Chapter 4, dreams are associated with death at deeper levels. In Greece and Rome the relationship binding "sleep, death, dreams, and night was tight," wrote Ogden. "Homer's Hermes escorts the souls of the dead suitors to the underworld by taking them past the 'people of Dreams,' and he guides them there with the golden rod with which he also lulls the living to sleep or wakes them."[1241] Thanatos, the winged Greek personification of death, was brother to *Hypnos*, sleep, from which we get the English *hypnosis* ("sleep condition").[1242] Hesiod's *Theogony* calls Night the "mother" of sleep, dreams, and death—night, when so many paranormal encounters occur.[1243] Sleep dissolves boundaries between life and death, a feature recognized by shamans since the beginning of time, who used them to obtain actionable intelligence about our reality.

"I suggest [we] take seriously the idea of a parallel continuum, and say that the mind and the body are embedded in the dream and the dream is a higher-order spatial dimension," McKenna said.[1244] Even today, many see dreams as crucial access points for consciousness, allowing souls to wander in OBEs or astral travel.

Dreams not only transport us into the Otherworld, but allow the Otherworld to visit us. Faeries and fylgjur visit the sleeping, and the alien abduction experience might well represent dreamtime consciousness "kidnappings."

The departed visit us in dreams to reassure us or bid one final farewell —if it hasn't happened to you, it has happened to someone you know, probably after a funeral. A 2013 *American Journal of Hospice and Palliative Medicine* survey of 278 bereaved respondents discovered 58% "reported dreams of their deceased loved ones, with varying levels of frequency. Most participants reported that their dreams were either pleasant or both pleasant and disturbing, and few reported purely disturbing dreams."[1245]

Rosemary Ellen Guiley recorded a poignant dream visitation from Alan, a husband who suffered a fatal head-on automobile collision, leaving behind his wife Robin and their toddler. After months of grieving, Robin dreamed of Alan in a garden "lit with an unusual light that was somehow different from sunlight" (recall NDEs and Fairyland). After laughing for a time, Robin suddenly remembered Alan's death. Taking her hand, he stared into her eyes, telepathically saying, "It was all good. I'm fine, and everything will be fine for you and [our daughter]." Before Robin could reply he added, "I've

got to go." Awakening from her dream, Robin was convinced she met Alan, and felt a profound sense of peace moving forward.[1246]

While some—perhaps many—represent the subconscious processing our grief, other post-death visitations are verifiable. The most infamous example is West Virginia's "Greenbrier Ghost." After dying from "female trouble" on January 23, 1897, the ghost of Elva Zona Heaster appeared to her mother. Official records called them dreams, but her mother insisted they were waking visions interrupting her sleep. Zona's head rotated 180° in her visitation to illustrate how her neck had been broken by her husband, a violent drifter likely involved in the deaths of several other women. Zona's mother insisted upon an exhumation, which verified the ghost's accusation. At the ensuing trial, the defense introduced Zona's testimony on cross-examination to discredit her mother. The strategy backfired, and Zona's husband was convicted, dying in prison in Moundsville, West Virginia.[1247]

Ghost visitation in dreams represents a continuation of ancient belief. Dreams allowed communication from ancestors, spirits, or even God in Zambia.[1248] In Greco-Roman literature, dreams were "how Patroclus appeared to Achilles in the *Iliad*, how Diapontius appeared to Philolaches in Plautus's *Mostellaria*, and how his dead son visited Epicrates in first century A.D. Nakrason in Asia Minor," Ogden wrote.[1249]

Unlike the unreliable information obtained in Spiritualist séances, Classical ghosts always spoke truthfully in dreams. Any physical contact with them—exchanging gifts, kisses, sleeping on graves—was mostly viewed as a death omen for the sleeper. "To dream of weeping over a corpse predicts successful business, and to dream of the dead returning to life predicts turmoil and

losses." Some texts asserted these visions were not ghosts, but instead "the dreamer's own soul or from the gods." [1250]

Releasing the inner god

"This society, not only does it not care, it's specifically interested in seeing that you don't have [the psychedelic] experience," McKenna said. "Well, it's part of the birthright. This is what religion *was* for the first million years... It was the celebration of an ecstatic reality that could be coaxed out of a magical relationship with nature."[1251]

McKenna refers to *entheogen* rituals, the ancient context in which psychedelics were used to contact the Otherworld. For millennia, access to this realm was available on-demand, outside sleep, even to those lacking meditative talents. Through exhaustive trial-and-error, mankind discovered natural substances in our environment which provoke ASCs.

Access to entheogens (Greek *éntheos*, "filled with the god," and *genésthai*, "becoming") was restricted to sacred contexts, employed by shamans or those seeking spiritual enlightenment. This distinction is crucial: not all psychedelics are entheogens, but all entheogens are psychedelics. Substances like ketamine and LSD, for instance, were too recently formulated to accrete any formalized belief system, while entheogens used recreationally become mere psychedelics.

Though shamans access the Otherworld by many means, most if not all involve ASCs, and entheogens represent one of the most reliable methods in their toolkit. By consuming these substances, they either travel to or communicate with this other realm, which imparts secret knowledge or

insight. Entheogens grant the user's consciousness passage to *other* planes of existence, the ability to perceive invisible aspects of *our* reality, or eyes to see *within*—the visions induced by ayahuasca, for example, are sometimes turned on or off simply by opening or closing one's eyes, though they can bleed through into waking vision.[1252]

"Entheogenic epiphany is commonly described as a state where all distinctions and boundaries between the individual and the metaphysical realm dissolve into a mystical and consubstantial communion with the Divine," wrote Walter and Fridman—a liminal space.[1253] Entheogens were gifts from the gods, if not their literal flesh or fluids. Ayahuasca is sometimes conceptualized as divine semen, for instance. Like other psychedelics, every entheogen has its own unique character, imagery, and spaces. [1254]

Entheogen use is truly ancient, evidenced at the emergence of Neanderthal culture circa 60,000 years ago. Analysis from Göbekli Tepe, "the world's first temple," points to psychoactive beer facilitating "interaction of the living with the dead" no less than 12,000 years in the past.[1255] "Linguistic evidence for Siberian mushroom inebriation goes back at least 7,000 years," wrote Walter and Fridman.[1256]

Entheogens are typically derived from fungi or plants. To that end, botanomorphic shamans appearing in ancient art worldwide, including in Denmark, Siberia, and Scandinavia, likely signify entheogen use. Petroglyphs at Algeria's Tassili plateau, circa 20,000-7,000 years old, feature a bee-faced shaman covered in mushrooms. Similar art from Texas's Panther Cave shows humanoids' arms flowering datura,[1257] a plant used to induce ASCs for at least 3,000 years.[1258]

Though famously associated with Siberian shamanism, *Amanita muscaria* (fly agaric) mushrooms also grow in the New World. Their presence as grave goods, offerings, and effigies at sites like Mound City in Chillicothe, Ohio hints that they may have been used to induce Otherworld travels in pre-Columbian America.[1259] Indigenous civilizations from the southeastern United States also employed a mysterious "black drink" to induce vomiting since the Late Archaic period (8,000 BC);[1260] while not psychedelic *per se*, it did contain massive doses of caffeine capable of causing hallucinations (we've all been there).[1261]

Ancient Egyptians used blue water lily, poppies, and mandrake to enter "a profound hypnotic state terminating in an extended period of somnolence." Any one of these plants is capable of inducing deep sleep and vivid dreams, "the symbolic death so necessary to shamanic tradition."[1262]

In 1967 Károly Kerényi, collaborating with LSD discoverer Albert Hoffmann, found evidence within the ancient *Hymn to Demeter* for a psychedelic recipe: poley oil obtained from mint (*Mentha pulegium*), which in significant doses "induces delirium, loss of consciousness, and spasms." Kerényi and Hoffmann went one step further, arguing poley oil and alcoholic *kykeon* might "have produced hallucinations in persons whose sensibility was heightened by fasting" during the Eleusinian Mysteries, amplifying the rite's death-rebirth message.[1263]

These ancient rituals may have influenced Christianity. In 2020's *The Immortality* Key, Brian Muraresku suggests a continuity between ancient psychedelic sacraments and "the earliest, Greek-speaking Christians, for

whom the original Holy Communion or Eucharist was, in fact, a psychedelic Eucharist."[1264]

While Muraresku's research focuses on fortified alcohol, others perceive the influence of cannabis or mushrooms in Abrahamic religions. Exodus 30:22-23 mentions an anointing oil containing *q'aneh-bosm* (cannabis).[1265] The "Forbidden Fruit" from the Garden of Eden's Tree of Knowledge may symbolize a psychedelic plant or fungus. A fresco in France's Abbaye de Plaincourault features the tempting serpent coiled around an immense fly-agaric. (The Genesis story, wherein Adam and Eve are unable to return home after consuming Otherworldly food, mirrors faerie lore's "food taboo,").[1266]

John Marco Allegro's controversial 1970 book *The Sacred Mushroom & the Cross* proposed Christianity's origins lie in ancient mushroom cults, kickstarting decades of further speculation on the religion's possible psychedelic roots.[1267] Earl Lee's *From the Bodies of the Gods* (2012) proposed shamans' moist, shallow graves, their robes contaminated with spores from years of mushroom consumption, sprouted psychoactive fungi.

"I think that at some point the bodies were accidentally unearthed and people saw these mushrooms growing on these bodies and decided that this person was particularly holy and that the mushrooms that come from a corpse are probably particularly valuable in terms of communicating with the gods or the next world or the afterlife," he summarized in one interview. "That linked in people's minds that this is what we use to communicate with the dead." According to Lee, ancient Hebrew "Cults of the Dead" on the fringe of society syncretized their mushroom consumption with Jesus Christ's immortality-granting "flesh and blood" consumed during communion.[1268]

Ergo, ASCs represent not a *deviation* from spiritual norms—they *are* the spiritual norm. Their friction point with modern religion arises from the use of psychedelics, which are simply a quicker means of attaining ASCs when compared to the arduous, lengthy task of meditation. As Terence McKenna frequently joked in his characteristically charming style:

> There's a story of a man who lived by the side of a river, and he wanted to cross. So he practiced a siddhi of levitation so that he could walk across the water. And it took him 40 years to perfect this siddhi and finally he could cross. Buddha was preaching in the neighborhood and the guy came to him and he said, "Master, look what I've achieved, I can walk on the water to cross the river!"
>
> And Buddha said, "Yeah, but the ferry only costs a nickel."1269

Entheogens' peculiar ability to "release the inner god" invites comparisons to the Higher Self. These substances allow our inner divinity to emerge. Entheogen consumption among ancient Greeks was "apotheosis, or deification,"[1270] reflecting universal concepts of our afterlife status. Egypt's dead were "completed as every god," reassured their "identity will not perish."[1271]

"This is particularly apparent in Egypt where the deceased becomes Osiris, and in Mesopotamia when Bilgames and Ur-Namma become underworld judges; and perhaps where Inana is referred to as an Anuna god—that is, one of the gods who judged her," wrote Shushan. "In India, the deceased

'unites' with Yama," given "the power of omnipresence, and has become effectively divinized."[1272]

Gods are immortal, eternal, and by releasing the inner god, by deifying the self, entheogens help us become the same: we die to death. They, like the Eleusinian Mysteries, are Near-Death Experience Simulators.

Entheogens are also communication vectors. A few were renowned for uniting the living with the dead.

- **Soma**'s identity is a mystery, save that it was a sacramental liquid among early Hindus, closely identified with an eponymous lunar deity (also called *Chandra*, god of night and vegetation). Many psychoactive plants and fungi, including mushrooms, have been proposed. The Rigveda presents over a hundred verses dedicated to soma, consumed during rituals by Vedic initiates and priests. "We have drunk Soma and become immortal; we have attained the light, the Gods discovered."[1273]

  Soma intersected with death, psychopomps, the feminine, and fertility in a three day festival, culminating in suffocating a horse. The animal was lain with the king's primary wife, who took its member in her lap.[1274] Soma's "divine milk" reputedly raised the dead,[1275] finding application in Indian ancestor worship.[1276]

- **Alcohol**, especially combined with other psychoactive substances, enjoyed widespread entheogenic use. Augmented by legumes and other plants, "graveyard beer" was used in Levantine mortuary rituals which venerated both ancestors and the dead. An Attican vessel from 470 depicts Hermes directing souls from a wine pot: "Some fly off to the underworld on angelic wings. Others, more demonic, are being crammed back into the holy wine from which they came." According to Muraresku, wine was an "immortality potion… unit[ing] the Ancient Greeks of the

final centuries BC with the paleo-Christians of the early centuries AD."[1277] We see vestiges of this in modern Christian communion, which still uses wine as the Blood of Christ.

- **Iboga**, employed in prehistoric pygmy rites before its adoption by Gabon's Bwiti, rebirths users as *baanzi*, "one who knows the other world." Today, it is gaining traction as a method for curing addiction.[1278] In its origin myth, iboga grows from a dead folk hero's digits, becoming "the plant that would enable men to see the dead" if taken at near-toxic levels. "Many report meeting their deceased fathers or grandfathers, who act as guides for them in the spirit world," Hancock wrote. He himself saw flashes of his own departed father under iboga's influence.[1279]

"Iboga is intimately associated with death," wrote Richard Evans Schultes. "The plant is frequently anthropomorphized as a supernatural being, a 'generic ancestor' who can so highly value or despise an individual that it can carry him away to the land of the dead."[1280]

- Mazatec shamans use ***Salvia divinorum*** "in divinatory rituals as a facilitator for contacting the spirits of the dead."[1281] Author J.D. Arthur discovered this ability during his Salvia trips, regularly encountering the dead—and being singled out for still living. On one occasion, two young girls escorted him into the Salvia realm before recoiling, saying, "'You're not dead!' in an accusatory fashion." On the same trip, a male presence "said something to the effect of, 'They're usually dead when they're here.'"[1282]

- Like iboga, **kava** grew from a legendary corpse, a dead Pacific Islander's vagina, or her breast in Vanuatu belief. Kava inebriation's symbolic death-state provides "communicative links with the supernatural world," particularly ancestors. "In order to converse with the dead, it helps to be somewhat 'dead' oneself."[1283]

- California's Chumash ingested **datura** "to communicate with the spirits of the dead; those who still missed some loved one, particularly a dead child, sometimes took Datura for this reason." Fatal datura poisoning was viewed as a choice to stay in the afterlife.

"The *Datura* drinker could see the spirits of the dead, and he might speak with them," wrote Richard Applegate. "Certain spots were particularly auspicious for contacting the dead in a Datura trance; the best known of these was *ka^aqtawaq* 'north wind,' north of Ventura, an ancient sycamore tree in whose rustling leaves the *Datura* drinker could hear the voices of the dead. *Datura* also enabled a person to see the supernatural creatures thought to inhabit various places." Šimilaqša, the western afterlife, was only easily reached by those who had taken datura in life.[1284]

- In Siberia, red-capped, white-flecked ***Amanita muscaria*** mushrooms held anthropomorphic spirits. Chukchi consumers encounter the mushroom as one-armed, one-legged, fungal persons, who serve as escorts "to visit the land inhabited by the dead." Fly agaric was used to visit dead relatives, "sometimes to learn from them what intrigues were being planned by the spirit of illness."[1285]

Two entheogens demand special attention: psilocybin mushrooms and DMT, the psychoactive component in ayahuasca.

Adventures in Wonderland

Despite *Amanita muscaria*'s ubiquity in psychedelic art, it is unreliable and dangerous. "It's seasonably variable, genetically variable, geographically variable," McKenna said. "You hear once in a while amazing *Amanita* stories. Most *Amanita* stories are that it's toxic and horrible."[1286]

McKenna was much more enamored with *Psilocybe* mushrooms. Long-documented in spiritual disciplines from around the world, this genus produces a broad spectrum of effects, from the relatively mundane (enhanced colors or "tracers" in the air) to entire, robust spaces and discrete entities. McKenna's infamous "Stoned Ape Hypothesis" indebted humankind itself to psilocybin: following herds of animals moving across the landscape, our predecessors undoubtedly discovered *Psilocybe* growing in dung. Consuming this fungi made humans more perceptive, prolific, and imaginative: "At the lowest dose, psilocybin increases visual acuity, which means better success at hunting. Then, at the middle dose level, it creates this hypersexual activity. Then, at still higher doses it creates the full-blown psychedelic experience…."[1287]

Because psilocybin stimulates Broca's area, which is associated with language, "spontaneous glossolalia is a phenomenon of high-dose psilocybin use," McKenna pointed out. "Glossolalia is linguistic activity that seems to be not willed by the ego but that is just simply an upwelling from the dynamics and architecture of the organism."[1288] From these humble, nonsensical mouth

noises, McKenna suspected, arose the first languages, by which we became the most novel species on the planet.

Mushrooms present obvious connections to the dead, appearing on rot and aiding in decomposition of organic material (this, coupled with their vague resemblance to penises, also imbues fertility symbolism). Some cultures rendered this death connection explicit. Lithuanians once considered mushrooms the fingers of *Velnias*, cycloptic god of the Baltic dead, "reaching up from the underworld to feed the poor."[1289] Some Africans view mushrooms as repositories of human souls, and Siberia's Oroch believe the dead are reborn on the moon as mushrooms.[1290]

"Contemporary patterns of usage of the mushroom among indigenous communities in Mexico, although long unknown to Western science, are consistent with [psychedelic] use patterns [worldwide]: they are used ceremonially for obtaining spiritual visions of the land of the dead and for communing with the spirits of the natural world for healing and knowledge," wrote psychologist Ralph Metzner. "Finds of mushroom effigies in the tomb of Mayan nobles suggest an association with the Lords of Xibalba, deity rulers of the land of the dead…."[1291]

Metzner's "land of the dead" and "spirits of the natural world" should be familiar by now. Faeries and mushrooms appear together extensively in art, encoding centuries of shared folklore. Mushroom caps became faerie tables or gathering places in European art and literature. Welsh and Gaelic names for fungi like *pookies* or *fairy-mushrooms* deliberately reference fae folk,[1292] and the connection between mushroom circles and faerie rings was noted in

Chapter 4. Writes author Mike Jay on the Romantic, rural sensibilities of Victorian faerie lore:

> In parallel to a growing scientific interest in toxic and hallucinogenic fungi, a vast body of Victorian fairy lore connected mushrooms and toadstools with elves, pixies, hollow hills, and the unwitting transport of subjects to fairyland, a world of shifting perspectives seething with elemental spirits. The similarity of this otherworld to those engendered by plant psychedelics in New World cultures, where psilocybin-containing mushrooms have been used for millennia, is suggestive. Is it possible that the Victorian fairy tradition, beneath its innocent exterior, operated as a conduit for a hidden tradition of psychedelic knowledge?... Fairy rings and toadstool-dwelling elves were recycled through a pictorial culture of motif and decoration until they became emblematic of fairyland itself. [1293]

The connection extends deeper and farther afield than Victorian England. Breton *corrigans* left mushrooms after dancing.[1294] Some Chinese folklore describes mushrooms shapeshifting into mountain dwarfs, seven-to-eight inches high; catching and eating them grants immortality.[1295] Indigenous tribes from Guyana, Honduras, and Belize believe "little spirits inhabit the forest," opening "jumbie umbrellas"—mushrooms—whenever it rains, leaving them behind afterward.[1296] "*Little earth beings* are mushroom stems that turn into little men during Mazatec trances induced by eating *Psilocybe* mushrooms," wrote faerie story collector John E. Roth. One Chinantecan tribe believes in "pretty female and male children who resemble one-inch-high female and male mushrooms."[1297]

Unsurprisingly, UFOs are staples of psychedelic states, including those from mushrooms, whose caps superficially resemble classic flying saucers. Taking psilocybin, comedian Bill Hicks watched "UFOs split the sky like a sheet," emitting seven lights that escorted him to their "ship," where he learned "we all are one and there is no such thing as death." Like an NDE, the trip left Hicks with profound feelings of oneness, love, and universality.[1298] McKenna felt this "ideological catalyst" of UFO contact was the most common motif in psilocybin trips, "apocalyptic concrescences that haunt the historical continuum, igniting religions and various hysterias, and seeping ideas into highly tuned nervous systems."[1299] Inspired by the discovery that mushroom spores can survive deep space, McKenna espoused a panspermic model wherein *Psilocybe* arrived on Earth to impart a message.

"I've mentioned that psilocin, which is what psilocybin quickly becomes as it enters your metabolism, is *4-hydroxy-N,N-dimethyltryptamine*," he said, "the only 4-substituted indole in all of organic nature." This "unique chemical signature," to McKenna, suggested artificiality, or perhaps off-world origins. "I was suggesting that it was a gene—an artificial gene—carried perhaps by a space-borne virus or something brought artificially to this planet, and that this gene has insinuated itself into the genome of these mushrooms."[1300]

McKenna felt *Psilocybe* mushrooms could represent an extraterrestrial invasion—not as a conquering force, but as benign messengers. "Look at how delicately the mushroom touches the earth," he said. "It lives only on decaying matter."[1301] McKenna detected irony in our search for aliens amongst the stars, while "within the shadow" of "the world's largest radio telescope [at] Arecibo in Puerto Rico… mushrooms grow in the fields and the cows munch quietly in the sunshine."[1302]

Yet for all his pontificating on extraterrestrial fungi, McKenna saw in the mushroom something far grander, a *mysterium tremendum* not unlike staring into the yawning grave.

> Whatever this thing is, it keeps itself masked. I've literally had the experience on mushrooms of saying to it, "Show me what you are, for yourself." Well, it's like there's this enormous organ chord, the temperature falls, black velvet curtains are raised—and after about 20 seconds of that, I'm saying, "That's enough of what you are for yourself! Let's go back to the dancing mice…" So what I mean is that our journey through time, our historical journey to this moment, has not been unaccompanied. We have always been accompanied by this thing.[1303]

Vine of the dead

One of the few animal-based entheogens is 5-methoxy-*N,N*-dimethyltryptamine, or 5-MeO-DMT. Like the related compound bufotenine, certain New World toads generate 5-MeO-DMT, perhaps influencing amphibians' role as Mesoamerican chthonic figures, fertility symbols, and psychopomps.[1304]

Author James Oroc, smoking 5-MeO-DMT in New Orleans, saw his dead friend Brigid bid him a lovely farewell. Afterward, Oroc's (entirely sober) sitter tearfully told him a tiny orb of light had left his chest, splitting into "two perfect copies" of Oroc. Distraught, the sitter closed her eyes to meditate. When she opened them, a woman appeared in the room, consistent with Brigid's "appearance and personality, though she did not know her at all."[1305]

Since monoamine oxidase enzymes neutralize DMT in the stomach—thankfully so, as it occurs in edible plants we eat every day—botanical DMT is traditionally inhaled or snuffed. The Tukano, for instance, use virola snuff to "contact the supernatural sphere" of ancestors and "spirit beings above." DMT from acacia trees and shrubs is ingested similarly. Benny Shanon, Hebrew University psychology professor, suggested Moses's Old Testament "burning bush" revelation was a DMT vision induced by ignited acacia.[1306]

DMT is famously the psychoactive ingredient in ayahuasca. Somehow—over 4,000 years ago, out of 80,000 plant species—70 Amazonian tribes rendered DMT orally active by combining plants like *Psychotria viridis* with

vines containing monoamine oxidase inhibitors, *Banisteriopsis caapi* or its cousin *B. inebrians*.[1307] Since neither is palatable as food, there remain two options: either tribes tested over *three billion* combinations in the hope of obtaining something mystical or, as the *ayahuasqueros* suggest, "the vine called."[1308]

The resultant mixture, also called *yagé*, tastes like "a mixture of foot-rot, raw sewage, battery acid, sulfur and just a hint of chocolate," as Hancock put it.[1309] Following a strict *dieta* of fasting, food restriction, and sexual abstention, drinkers brave this flavor, guided by singing shamans. The ritual lasts all night. Invariably, ayahuasca's purgative qualities induce vomiting and diarrhea, conceptualized as the medicine dispelling negative energy (suffice to say, recreational use is nonexistent).[1310] Manifold Westerners claim their lives improve dramatically after drinking ayahuasca, repairing relationships, beating addiction, and awakening spiritually.

"To drink *yagé*… is to return to the cosmic uterus and be reborn," anthropologist Wade Davis wrote. "To tear through the placenta of ordinary perception and enter realms where death can be known and life traced through sensation to the primordial source of all existence."[1311]

Users report a colorful kaleidoscope of ecologically-themed visions. Existence shatters into atoms. Latticework of ineffable geometry and spinning discs crystalize. Entities—sometimes animal psychopomps—creep into vision. These visions are highly consistent. According to Shanon, 75% of ayahuasca drinkers "reported visions of death, birds, reptiles, divine beings, creatures and beings, palaces and temples, and forests and gardens."[1312] Jaguars manifest commonly; in 1972, Andrew Weil wrote that even Inuit

tribesmen given *yagé* in studies "see visions of huge cats," and urban drinkers, despite never leaving their cities, see jungles and jaguars.[1313]

There are also serpents. Cramping intestines evoke, as one drinker described it, snakes entering the mouth and traversing the digestive tract, cleansing the body the whole way.[1314] Psychologist Shyloh Ravenswood perceived ingesting "a live boa" writhing "through the acidic labyrinth of [his] guts, pausing to squeeze them tight in sequential spasms."[1315]

The most prominent serpent is Mother Ayahuasca. Like soma, ayahuasca is an entheogenic trinity of plant, drink, and deity, and, while not a psychopomp, she is a spirit guide, the vine her domain. Hancock described Mother Ayahuasca as a female entity who shifts between a human woman, snake, jaguar, or therianthrope. Encountering her serpentine incarnation, she coiled around him, imparting love and power. "Her business is the planet, but she has time for *me*," he recalled.[1316]

"The name *ayahuasca* is from Quechua, a South American Indian language: *huasca* means 'vine' or 'liana' and *aya* means 'souls' or 'dead people' or 'spirits,'" Metzner wrote. "Thus 'vine of the dead,' 'vine of the souls,' or 'vine of the spirits' would all be appropriate English translations."[1317]

Like datura, ayahuasca can be viewed as afterlife preparation, a confrontation with death to dispel fear. Peruvian shaman Don José Campos equates ayahuasca with both "an after-death realm" and dreams. In one session, Campos saw his brother's death several days before his mother informed him. "From that experience I realized that Ayahuasca is able to take me to another dimension, so that I could enter other worlds. Worlds of… the dead."[1318]

"If you go to the shamans who access these places through ayahuasca… they will say: 'Well these are our ancestors. Didn't you read Mircea Eliade? Don't you know that shamanism works through ancestor magic?'" McKenna said.[1319]

"It takes a while for the implications of this to sink in," he added in another lecture. "They're talking about *dead* people… They're suggesting that the dearly departed do not evanesce into sunlight or something cheerfully non-specific like that, but that this actually is simply one level of a cosmic system of some sort where birth and death are transitions from level to level."[1320]

Artist Lucy Delics's ayahuasca vision conveyed ancestral trauma from both World Wars. "I flew over the fields, and their souls were… trapped in the Earth," she said. "I had to sing to them so they could be released."[1321]

Ayahuasca drinkers also see faeries. In Peru in 2010, Dan Perriam consumed ayahuasca and was sitting on a log when several "leprechauns" beckoned him to "come have a drink." "Never one to turn down a party, I blindly followed," he admitted, approaching an imaginal stairway leading underground. Just as the wooden door opened, "my consciousness shifted back to the hut as the secondary shaman was anxiously yelling at me to stop and come back now. His concern was palpable."[1322]

One of Hancock's sessions involved two "light-elves," four feet tall, resembling Grey aliens or NDE beings of light: "Their white light faces glow like neon and are approximately heart-shaped with big domed foreheads and narrow pointed chins." Their nostrils and mouths were slits, their eyes "completely black and apparently without pupils."[1323] In another ayahuasca

session, tiny green "jungle elves" appeared to psychologist Raoul Adamson, dissecting him and installing "an improved, more flexible, more comfortable body-mind," akin to the surgeries described in alien abductions. "Not to worry," they told him, "We'll put you back together, you're fine." (Dismemberment themes are discussed in our next chapter.)[1324]

Where the dead appear, so do faeries; where *faeries* appear, so do *extraterrestrials*.

The spirit molecule

When smoked recreationally, DMT trips are orders of magnitude shorter than ayahuasca sessions. "It's called the 'Businessman's Trip' because it's so short," McKenna said. "The old thing in the '60s was that you could do it on your lunch hour."[1325] In fact, "you feel completely normal 15 minutes after taking it—the shortest recovery time of any drug."[1326] Onset is also rapid. Administering DMT intravenously, Strassman reported subjects reached their peak at one to two minutes.[1327]

Yet within this brevity, perception stretches into eternity. "I felt 50,000 years away from where I was before—not in the past or future but in one of the other directions away from the planet of time," wrote author Tao Lin. "It seemed possible I *did* experience 50,000 years, hour by hour, before returning with amnesia of my exile, to my life in the universe, where only five minutes had elapsed."[1328]

The DMT realm differs from ayahuasca's, but remains roughly consistent across users' descriptions. After the first "toke," visual acuity is enhanced; the second transports. McKenna's travelogue embodies many of the motifs discussed.

> You see a floral pattern rotating in space, usually yellow-orange… "the chrysanthemum." [author: a flower denoting immortality in cemetery symbolism][1329] … this chrysanthemum will actually part and there is a sound like

> the crumpling of a plastic bread wrapper, or the crackling of flame… and a tone—a [humming ascending in pitch]… there's an impression of transition. It's as though there were a series of tunnels or chambers that you are tumbling down… What I've noticed about this tunnel is the walls and ceiling flux and come down to meet each other and where they touch, they pull apart with a [sucking sound]… then you are 'there'…
>
> And where is 'there'? It's underground. How you know this you cannot say but there is an irreconcilable sense of enormous mass surrounding you… You're at the center of a mountain or something… you're in a room which aficionados call "the dome"… It's softly lit, indirectly lit, and the walls… are crawling with geometric hallucinations: very brightly colored, very iridescent with deep sheens and very high reflective surfaces. Everything is machine-like and polished and throbbing with energy… This space is inhabited…
>
> You break into this space and are immediately swarmed by squeaking, self-transforming elf-machines. These things which are made of light, and grammar, and sound that come chirping, and squealing, and tumbling toward you. And they say "Hooray! Welcome! You're here!" and in my case, "You sent so many and you come so rarely." And my immediate impression, no matter how many times I do this… is that they are welcoming. There is something going on… love that is not like Eros or not like sexual attraction, I don't know what it's like exactly.[1330]

Thus was born the meme of McKenna's self-transforming machine-elves. Some controversy surrounds how often these techno-fae appear in the DMT realm. Stockton University professor Jennifer A. Lyke, parsing trip reports, noted 75% of experiences involve at least one entity, broken into "poorly-defined or formless beings (29%); humanoid beings (22%); divine beings (10%); aliens (8%); elves and fairies (7%); animals (6%); voices (4%); faces (4%);" and "miscellaneous entities" (3%)."[1331]

McKenna faced the occasional argument that the machine-elves were solely his invention—that they have no objective basis, and his lectures planted seeds in the minds of psychonauts to encounter them in future trips. As riposte, McKenna quipped, "Do you think you saw elves because you read my book?... Well, *I* didn't read my books when I saw elves!"[1332] One could further argue that folklore presents faeries appearing as any one of Lyke's entities.

"It was the transformation of language that made these experiences so memorable and peculiar," McKenna wrote. "Under the influence of DMT, language was transmuted from a thing heard to a thing seen." His elves spun visible language, presented as gifts, evoking the caterpillar's hookah from Disney's *Alice in Wonderland* adaptation.[1333]

McKenna's experiences would be equally at home in a faerie story or NDE. His "visible language" shows up in some UFO encounters. For instance, lifelong alien abductee Suzy Hansen claimed enrollment as a child in a sort of ET preschool, where instructors mentally projected holographic lessons in the air.[1334] In the 15th century NDE of Quetzalpetlatl (daughter-in-law of Aztec ruler Moquihuix), "a sickly, deformed youth"—shades of changelings and alien hybrids—presented her with gifts, singing, "Let us die for only a day!"[1335]

Just as fae folk (and UFOs, seen later) could portend death and bad luck, so might heavy DMT use. Following an unnerving trip, Lucas, one of Strassman's subjects, experienced automobile trouble. His wife retrieved him, but "two messages awaited them upon their arrival: a friend had shot his

head off in a suicide, another friend was dying rapidly of cancer." Lucas told Strassman the suicide occurred "at just about the time I took the DMT."[1336]

"A wide range of difficulties"—some expected, others sinister—"began affecting our psychedelic drug studies," Strassman wrote. "Their cumulative effect led to my leaving New Mexico and stopping the research." Notably, his ex-wife developed cancer, his stepson dropped out of school because of depression, a psilocybin patient became withdrawn and hostile, and his spiritual community rescinded their support for his project.[1337]

The spirit molecule: The third eye

Despite these supernatural risks, DMT is remarkably safe, physiologically speaking. Foolishly designated in America as a Schedule I drug—highly abuse-prone, medically worthless, unsafe—the substance is naturally-occurring (endogenous). *It is inside you right now*. Its purpose is not entirely clear.

"We don't know what it's doing in the brain," said University of Michigan professor Jimo Borjigin. "All we're saying is we discovered the neurons that make this chemical in the brain, and they do so at levels similar to other monoamine neurotransmitters."[1338] Some suspect DMT plays a role in vision, others as a neurotransmitter,[1339] while the metaphysically-minded claim it solely exists to facilitate divine interaction: "the Spirit Molecule," as Strassman opined.[1340]

Molecularly speaking, DMT is closely related to psilocybin, serotonin, and melatonin, the latter two also endogenously-produced. Supplemental melatonin, a hormone regulating our sleep cycle, increases dream vividity, reinforcing comparisons between dreams and DMT trips. Perhaps DMT provides waking access to dreamland.[1341]

We don't know why our bodies produce DMT, and we don't exactly know where it comes from, either. Our lungs produce a bit, corroborating ancient associations between the soul and breath. Notably, various spiritual practices place emphasis upon breathing exercises.[1342] A form of lengthy, controlled

hyperventilation called *holotropic breathwork*, pioneered by Stanislav Grof, induces ASCs, though this is likely oxygen-related.[1343]

Another hint lies in DMT's similarity to melatonin, which is produced in the brain's pineal gland, a pinecone-shaped organ in the epithalamus. The pineal gland began its evolutionary journey as an eye—some reptiles, like New Zealand's tuatara, still boast a third, vestigial "pineal eye"—and uses light to trigger melatonin production.[1344] Could this be the source of endogenous DMT?

Ancient (albeit circumstantial) evidence supports the pineal-DMT link. The Eye of Horus/Ra, an Egyptian spiritual symbol, startlingly resembles a cross-section of the thalamus, with the pineal gland at its center.[1345] Strassman recalled "the chill along [his] spine" when he learned that the pineal gland appears in fetuses 49 days after conception—"the Tibetan Buddhist Book of the Dead teaches that it takes forty-nine days for the soul of the recently dead to 'reincarnate'… forty-nine days is also when the fetus differentiates into male or female gender. Thus the soul's rebirth, the pineal, and the sexual organs all require 49 days before they manifest."[1346]

Philosophers long suspected our pineal glands were spiritually important. "Since [the pineal gland] is the only solid part in the whole brain which is single [unpaired], it must necessarily be the seat of the common sense," wrote René Descartes in the 17th century, designating it "the principal seat of the soul."[1347]

Perhaps coincidentally, the Vatican's Fontana della Pigna features an immense pine cone, and similar iconography fills cemeteries.[1348] Today, many New Age disciples refer to "the Third Eye," a mystical, invisible organ inside

the center of the forehead, building off of Eastern traditions from as early as 1700 BC.[1349]

Third Eye symbolism appears in UFO literature. A human-Grey-reptilian alien hybrid approached Bret Oldham in one of his more frightening abductions, its hand reaching towards his head. "He touched me between my eyes at the spot of the third eye," he wrote. "I instantly blacked out and remember nothing more of the incident."[1350]

Esotericists have long claimed pineal glands produce DMT, but couldn't verify their suspicions—until 2013, when Borjigin confirmed DMT's presence in rodent pineal glands. Though a follow-up in 2019 failed to replicate this finding, the results intrigued Strassman: "the requisite enzymes for DMT synthesis occur" in the pineal gland, he said, "and I believe that the jury is not yet out" regarding pineal production.[1351]

Borjigin's findings breathed new life into an old theory: does endogenously-produced DMT, generated in the pineal gland, regulate paranormal experiences? Though some speculate stress or trauma triggers DMT release, there is no documentation of such an event (barring NDEs, discussed below).

However, consider the anomalous light phenomena common in supernatural encounters—could these lights, often attributed peculiar characteristics, broadcast a spectrum promoting DMT production in the photosensitive pineal glands of witnesses? If so, they may represent the "naked" Other—pure, distilled souls—accessing our biochemistry to Co-Create encounters, clothed in an imaginal wardrobe of faeries, UFOs, and cryptids.

Near-death trips

Current scientific thought generally agrees psychedelic trips, particularly those from DMT, closely model the NDE state.[1352] While this acknowledgement is refreshing, many scientists weaponize the similarity to bolster the Dying Brain Hypothesis. They contend that both trips and NDEs are "mere hallucinations," without acknowledging the experiences' physical affects or how individuals obtain knowledge otherwise inaccessible.

"I've looked at the literature of near-death experience," McKenna mused. "What those people are describing is far more mundane than a DMT trip."[1353]

Emphasizing the key-room fallacy, Strassman wondered if "DMT and its ilk produce such psychedelic experiences during the NDE, because that is what our consciousness is experiencing at that time—it is what we see, feel, hear, think, as we are dying, and DMT is the aegis through which this happens. And, rather than DMT just producing a blank, dark, empty nothing state, which some people think is what happens at death, it produces quite the opposite."[1354]

Since Eastern religions believe the soul enters us at the same time our pineal glands form, some speculate endogenous DMT serves as "fuel" for the "rocket ship" of our consciousness to break into our world—or escape its "gravitational pull."

"It seems likely that our physical lives are a type of launching pad for the soul," McKenna wrote. "Apparently at the moment of death there is a kind of separation, like birth—the metaphor is trivial, but perfect. There is a possibility of damage or of incorrect activity. The English poet-mystic William Blake said that as one starts into the spiral there is the possibility of falling from the golden track into eternal death. Yet it is only a crisis of a moment—a crisis of passage—and the whole purpose of shamanism and of life correctly lived is to strengthen the soul and to strengthen the ego's relationship to the soul so that this passage can be cleanly made."[1355]

Though many return reassured of their consciousness's immortality, psychedelic users often feel as though they are dying at peak intoxication. "I thought I was going to die," said one of Strassman's subjects.[1356] Poet Allen Ginsberg, taking ayahuasca, "felt faced by Death."[1357] Hypnotic regression induces similar sensations: "I just felt like my body was going to die if I remembered any more, so I had to wake up," one of Budd Hopkins's alien abductees confessed.[1358]

Without mistaking keys for the rooms they unlock, consider the parallels between NDEs and other ASCs.

- **Sound.** While some patients hear buzzing sounds in their past life regressions,[1359] initiatory noises are most common in psychedelic experiences—recall the "crackling" in DMT trips, alternately described as whistling[1360] or "pulsating-buzzing."[1361] Nearly every psychedelic can produce buzzing noises at their onset.[1362] "The harmine molecule [in ayahuasca], which is structured like a little bell, gives a bell-like chiming and buzzing sound," Terence McKenna's brother Dennis theorized.[1363]

- **Sense of peace.** Strassman's DMT patient Cassandra described "a deep serene peace she had never known," consistent across other ASCs. Psilocybin created "my own globe of peace" as a user floated above a gathering of humanoids.[1364] Drugs of abuse obviously ease pain and produce similar sensations. According to the American Psychological Association, hypnosis can alleviate pain, its affective components, and trauma.[1365]

- **Inaccessible knowledge.** Recall examples during dreams, hypnosis, and trips, including precognition. In a September 2005 survey by David Luke and Marios Kittenis, 50% of regular psychonauts reported telepathy using psychedelics; 36.5% clairvoyance; 21.2% precognition; and 18.8% communication with the dead, all greater than infrequent or non-users, whose percentages generally hover in the low single digits. Interestingly, these abilities increased nearly 20% among regular drug users when *not* under the influence, implying the gateways of perception remain open long after psychedelics' effects wane.[1366]

- **Levitation/OBE.** In the same study, 64.7% of psychonauts reported OBEs "on the material plane" (44.7% during trips), 52.9% reported OBEs "on another plane" (43.5% during trips).[1367]

Consider a few examples. An American soldier administered ketamine in the Vietnam War became "a bodiless point of awareness and energy" before returning to his body.[1368] Hancock described DMT as "being drawn up out of my body by some utterly irresistible impersonal force, like a flood or a whirlwind, and carried off to a far-off, high-up place," evoking faerie abductions and NDEs.[1369] In one instance, a mushroom trip began when the user "could see [themself] from head to foot as well as the sofa on which [they were] lying."[1370]

One of the earliest Western descriptions of ayahuasca (1858) included "an aerial journey" with "gorgeous views, great cities, lofty towers," and "beautiful parks."[1371] As shown in Chapters 1 and 3, OBEs are common in dreams, and hypnosis sometimes involves "floating upwards."[1372]

- **Tunnel experience.** Hypnosis patients sometimes enter tunnels, as do DMT users.[1373] "At first it felt like I was going through a cave or tunnel or into space, at a fast rate," a Strassman subject recalled.[1374] Taking mushrooms and cannabis, one psychonaut was "skyrocketed" down a dark tunnel into a bright light.[1375]

- **Bright light.** 45.9% of psychonauts reported "seeing an aura of light" in the 2005 survey.[1376] One member of Strassman's study remembered thinking, "This is dying and this is okay" as she hurtled down a "bright light tunnel" terminating in a multidimensional "deep space, with white stars." "I thought I could see light down below, the world's light. It was like a little flap was lifted, like a simultaneous alternate reality."[1377]

Floating upwards into "a vast open space," LSD created "bright light everywhere, so I can hardly see anything" for one American user. It also presented past life memories as a World War II seaman and immense, winged lions whose "flesh [was] like looking at the sun."[1378]

- **Landscapes.** Salvia presented "a rolling green landscape" populated by "a thousand blue men" in one account. "I'm dead. Dying," the user panicked before awakening in bed.[1379] A psychonaut taking a homemade ayahuasca analogue soared above "a beautiful meadow that looked straight out of *Lord of the Rings* or *The Wizard of Oz*."[1380] Mushrooms showed one user "a beautiful meadow. Colors are so bright and full it's amazing."[1381]

We also find variations on afterlife bridges. Another Salvia smoker encountered "a dirt road looking at a bridge."[1382] Yet another saw meadows and a beam of light transform into a luminous "golden cobblestone bridge." In this case, two children

appeared, beckoning him; declining, "another boyish figure" left his chest "and started skipping up the bridge, and into the ceiling"—one of his souls crossing into the Otherworld?[1383]

- **Enhanced Perception.** DMT and psilocybin alter and enhance vision in small doses. At higher levels, "the colors and vibration were so intense" for one user they "thought [they] would pop."[1384] These psychedelic visuals are indescribable, an "orgy of vision," as one user said.[1385] Mother Ayahuasca appeared to Brian Muraresku as "more real than real."[1386] McKenna claimed waking reality "*is the most limited form of existence that you will ever know*. You can't *be* deader than this."[1387]

- **Interiors.** McKenna's subterranean DMT dome evokes caves, another trip motif. "You hear the music way off down in a cavern, and suddenly it is you who is way down in the cavern," one LSD user related.[1388] Another learned his "dark underground cave" filled with toothy monsters was Sheol, the Hebrew underworld.[1389]

Domes, a staple of DMT trips, also appear in NDEs. During surgery, Jaime visited her deceased grandmother's afterlife home, which boasted a peculiar, "dome like" ceiling. A loud popping noise revived her.[1390] Another NDEr remembered a room with "a cloudy glass dome. There was a balcony, and on the balcony, looking down at me, were dozens of people in long white gowns."[1391]

We even see domes in ancient NDEs. According to the Rigveda, Yama rules over "the triple dome, in the third heaven of heaven, where the worlds are made of light."[1392]

- **Supernatural lapses of time.** Like NDErs, dreamers, and those hypnotized, psychonauts perceive time differently. Time most often expands, rather than contracts, more consistent with NDEs than Fairyland visits. "Every minute felt like at least ten," said one psychonaut.[1393] "What felt like centuries was a meager 30

minutes since I had taken the 'shrooms," reported another using LSD with psilocybin.[1394]

Comedian Ari Shaffir slipped into a different life after smoking a "massive dose" of Salvia on a live podcast. He "started living in this underwater lake" as a seahorse therianthrope for "between six months and two years." "I had a life… friends… a job. I had this woman I had a relationship with." One day he popped above the surface and saw a friend from his waking life, after which he regained consciousness. When given water, he kept spitting it out—"You *breathe* water, you don't *drink* water." Only ten minutes had elapsed.[1395]

Nonetheless, time *does* compress with alcohol, methamphetamines, cocaine, and some other substances.[1396] A 1913 mescaline trip report described the future "rushing on at chaotic speed,"[1397] and a 2014 study of psilocybin users found time perception both dilated *and* compressed, perhaps due to serotonin interference.[1398] An uncharacteristically brief DMT experience left one user with 20 minutes of missing time—they said it was "more like an alien abduction than a trip."[1399]

- **Love.** A sense of oneness pervades positive ASCs, with 56.5% of psychonauts experiencing "universal consciousness" during trips.[1400] Mother Ayahuasca exudes love, and Grof's LSD patients felt "love, tranquility, and peace."[1401] Cassandra's DMT experience left her feeling "very loved."[1402] According to Newton Institute-trained regressionist Karen Joy, those undergoing past life regressions "feel a sense of overwhelming love."[1403]

Another of Strassman's subjects, Marsha, felt "a sexual energy of wanting more, of being stimulated." Sexuality is much more common in trips than NDEs. Another patient made love to "insects" who simultaneously feasted upon him.[1404] Taking 5-MeO-DIPT on a field trip to see *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, one user felt the characters morph into "Sexual Fairies of Justice"; a subsequent trip watching *The Tempest* revealed "the whole world was based on love and sex."[1405] Hopefully he didn't make his fellow audience members uncomfortable.

"I've even read a trip account by a person who claimed to have made love with a plant!" researcher Jeremy Knight wrote.[1406]

- **Music.** Ayahuasca shamans guide drinkers with *icaros*, "songs of the spirits that have become the allies of that particular healer."[1407] Strassman's study included "calliope music," film scores, and other "beautiful music."[1408]

- **Life review.** Dreamers and (allegedly) hypnosis patients recall old memories. Past life regressions often include life reviews.[1409]

Turning to psychedelics, a DMT-mugwort experience presented "flashes of what was my life. I saw my family, my boyfriend, my pets, friends, strangers, possessions, everything."[1410] DMT from phalaris grass displayed another life review: "my whole life flashed before my eyes."[1411]

- **Ultimatum.** While uncommon in ASCs, ultimatums can occur. "I *distinctly* remember having the choice to stay in this amazing place for another eternity, or I could return to my body," recalled a DMT user.[1412] After his first DMT experience, Strassman's patient Stan "felt the choice was mine to stay or come back" during subsequent trips, including those from psilocybin.[1413]

- **Amnesia.** As noted, dreamers and psychonauts may remember part or none of their ASCs.

- **Healing, new abilities, and spiritual awakenings.** The entire point of non-recreational psychedelic use is spiritual enhancement. Some report full-fledged rebirth, others renewed compassion, all from realizing that reality extends further than we can ever imagine. This awareness allows many to "die to death." In this sense, ASCs heal mental and spiritual ills.

From a physical perspective, mycologist Paul Stamets's work with mushrooms including psilocybin demonstrates their potential to heal neural pathways, even reversing neurotoxins in mice. Anecdotally, a colleague with hearing loss told Stamets he could hear ants walking while under psilocybin's influence.[1414]

Luke's research suggests psychedelic use increases belief in the paranormal and that psychonauts report a greater number of paranormal events. Psychedelics might also trigger what Hindu texts call a *kundalini* experience, "a syndrome of various psychophysiological phenomena described as bodily energy surges and certain transpersonal experiences"—i.e. a spiritual awakening.[1415]

Electrical interference is evident in Lucas's truck breaking down after taking DMT in Strassman's study, or the testimony of one passenger on LSD: "As we were driving, her car broke down. I knew this to be another supernatural occurrence, and I still can't explain the coincidence of it."[1416]

- **Poltergeist phenomena.** Psychedelic users might report an increase in recurrent spontaneous psychokinesis (RSPK) and hauntings.

"*Psilocybe* mushrooms too demonstrated some relatively widespread capacity to accompany psi experiences of all kinds, particularly clairvoyance but even PK to some extent," Luke wrote. "However, possibly because of the more infrequent experience of PK, there did not seem to be any one substance that was related to it, with the possible exception of *Psilocybe* mushrooms, mescaline, and LSD…."[1417]

Other miscellaneous ASC-NDE connections include prebirth memories (one Salvia user visited the place "where I was before I was born"),[1418] dancing entities, and *macropsia*, the psychoactively-induced sensation of objects enlarging or the self shrinking. This final detail appears in *Alice in Wonderland,* where mushrooms control the protagonist's height.

Macropsia is a common symptom of DMT intoxication from virola snuff.[1419] It also appears to a lesser degree with other substances. "I noticed a few changes in the way I perceived size: for example my friend looked as if she towered over me," said one psilocybin user. "This fleeting sensation of shrinking lasted maybe 15-20 minutes overall."[1420]

A different state of beings:

Psychopomps and the dead

Dismemberment and non-human entities constitute two notable omissions from the list above. The former is covered in the next chapter, as it presents a thoroughly shamanic quality; while already discussed sporadically, the latter warrant their own detailed examination here. What other intelligences dwell in these altered states of consciousness?

Obviously, anything imaginable can haunt our dreams. Aliens appear regularly in hypnotic regressions, even among those lacking evidence of UFO contact. Compare the dwellings of paranormal entities to the settings in which psychonauts enjoy tripping most: in nature, the domain of faeries; under the stars, awaiting UFOs; in abandoned buildings, holding lurking ghosts; in the dark, where things go bump in the night.

Contemporary religious figures like God, Jesus, angels, Vishnu, Buddha, etc. appear in trips with a regularity precluding discussion—there are simply too many examples (although, as in NDEs, Mohammad is conspicuously absent). In addition to specific spiritual beings, psychonauts meet generic gods, personifications of nature, and—of course—psychopomps, both in the form of animals and deities.

Strassman noted that some of his DMT subjects reported bees.[1421] Taking 4-AcO-MPT, another psychonaut felt "birds… sitting all over me, occasionally

taking wing and flying off with pieces of my consciousness in their talons, carrying them to far-flung corners of the world."[1422]

One LSD user entered "a world of blue horses. The land heaved gently" as their heads and necks "rose and fell as waves on the planet's surface. It was a land of perfect peace, a blue equine paradise."[1423] These horses evoke Enbharr crossing the sea carrying the sometimes-psychopompic Manannán, whose presence was noted by name in one Irish psychonaut's LSD trip: "I felt connected to Manannán, the ocean."[1424]

Other psychonauts encounter psychopomp deities as well. On a Costa Rican beach, a ketamine user saw "a bright light above" carrying "an old, white-bearded man" described as "Saint Nicholas (without all the Christmas baggage)"—in other words, Odin.[1425] "Bad trips" may introduce Death itself: taking the deliriant *Brugmansia*, a user watched as "the Grim Reaper stood in the corner of my room. I slurred, 'Hello' and he waved back at me."[1426]

Psychedelics' indigenous use supports their efficacy for contacting the dead, apparent in the examples listed several sections ago. In contemporary Western reports, these can be the generic or specific departed. "When I look at clouds [on LSD] the faces tend to look more like skulls, corpses, and ghosts that are all attached and piled on top of one another, each screaming silently," said one psychonaut.[1427]

Such accounts can easily be dismissed as pareidolia. This explanation is less helpful in the case of another LSD user who started listening to music, only to be joined by his dead grandmother within the first half hour.[1428]

Salvia's association with the dead reared its head for one psychonaut after "a hand made of indigo and violet hues reached into the space from another dimension," stretching like putty before tearing. "It was my mother, reaching out to me."[1429] Another Salvia user saw a fast, counterclockwise whirl of faces: "Faces of family, deceased and alive, and faces I've never seen before but I felt as if I knew them forever."[1430]

A different state of beings:

The Higher Self and doubles

As in other paranormal experiences, discerning where another intelligence ends and the Higher Self begins can prove tricky because, whether internal or external, the entities found in trips have access to infinite knowledge. They seem to know us better than we know ourselves.

One Salvia user learned "the mind-self of word-based thinking is really a small part of who I am… that the higher self is always there to communicate with me and guide me."[1431] A psilocybin trip exhibiting curious Fairyland overtones—"I stared around, a giant in the middle of a subterranean city"—involved a childlike "clay entity" who "taught me a lot about my inner self… my inner/Higher Self showed me my true thoughts…."[1432] Another psychonaut "traveling from life to death" saw his "shadow, and it was the shadow of an alien."[1433]

As suggested in Chapter 3, doppelgänger sightings may simply represent OBEs from a waking perspective. Your conscious mind sees your soul. If this is the case, then any trip involving an OBE can be considered a doppelgänger case—albeit from the *double's* point of view. Your conscious mind sees your *body*.

Other accounts fall into a more classic vein, but can be difficult to distinguish from paranoia. In a classic example of "Don't try this at home," a

"heroic dose" of Adderall convinced one user that a sinister "doppelgänger had taken [his] place in all [his] family photos."[1434] A cannabis user articulated the dissociation so many drug users experience: "I'm a cloned puppet of myself, just discovering my true nature—and true limitations."[1435]

A different state of beings:

Therianthropes

Therianthropes are so prevalent in trips that the concept may actually originate in them. Animals with human intelligence abound. Hybrid creatures like Mother Ayahuasca materialize. Benny Shanon collected ayahuasca accounts of humans combined with "fish, felines, reptiles, birds, and canines," as well as winged versions of "creatures who ordinarily do not have wings" like horses and elephants.[1436]

One of Graham Hancock's ayahuasca sessions involved a living, crocodile-headed, man-bodied statue.[1437] Chris, a subject of Strassman's, also encountered lizard-like entities. The three beings, which emitted light, appeared "reptilian and humanoid" and attempted to communicate, "not with words, but with gestures." It may sound terrifying, but Chris called it "the most reassuring experience of [his] life."[1438]

Strassman noted the presence of insect therianthropes in his studies.[1439] Psychonauts had already been reporting them for decades. One DMT user (unrelated to Strassman's study) encountered "intelligent insect alien god beings who explained that they had created us, and were us in the future, but that [the trip] was all taking place outside of linear time."[1440]

These insectoids are often compared to mantids. Another DMT account featured creatures possessed of a "human body with a mantis head," who

were "very impartial" to the psychonaut's presence.[1441] Although not through entheogens, alternative healer Anita Gamba has met mantids during her astral travels, noting "the praying mantis is the oldest symbol of God" in parts of Africa, its name derived from "the Greek word for prophet or seer."[1442]

Taking ayahuasca in the 1960s, anthropologist Michael Harner found himself in a water-filled "celestial cavern" with "a canopy resembling a geometric mosaic of stained glass." Therianthropic bird psychopomps stood watch.[1443]

"I could make out large numbers of people with heads of blue jays and the bodies of humans, not unlike the bird-headed god of ancient Egyptian tomb paintings," he recalled. Simultaneously, "some energy-essence began to float from my chest up into the boat." Despite being "an atheist, I was completely certain that I was dying and that the bird-headed people had *come to take my soul away on the boat* [author's emphasis]."[1444]

As in NDEs, sensations of flight induced by drugs are regularly compared to birds, echoing shamanic use of entheogens to acquire avian attributes for passage into the Otherworld. Users may also feel their consciousness literally transformed into that of a bird's. In one instance, a horrified mushroom consumer watched their fingers morph into bird talons.[1445]

A different state of beings:

Faeries

Faeries—sometimes famous therianthropes in their own right—are endemic to all psychedelic states.

Some maintain Western culture's Christmastime imagery is directly influenced by Siberian *Amanita muscaria* shamanism, citing several curious coincidences. The fungi are often dried in stockings by the fireplace; predominate at the base of coniferous trees; are beloved by reindeer; and might produce visions of McKenna-esque elves bearing gifts. Santa Claus, "a right jolly old elf," dons the mushrooms' red-and-white coloration, engaging in shamanic flight with "eight tiny reindeer" (further speculation mixes mythologies, drawing parallels to Sleipnir, Odin's octo-legged steed).

As the pseudonymous psychonaut "Zarkov" once wrote: "You give DMT to ten people. They've never had DMT before, and you tell them only that they might see something. If nine out of ten of them come back with descriptions of elves, and four of them use the word 'elves' unprompted, we think you should investigate the phenomenon of elves seen on DMT."[1446]

This trend predates the counterculture revolution by centuries, if not longer. In a fascinating story from Inishark related by Lady Wilde, a young girl, bereaved of her lover, meets a beautiful lady in white by the roadside who offers her a "ring of herbs." Looking through it, she perceives her pale,

dead partner dancing "with a grand company"—faeries, obviously—on a hillside.[1447]

Given a larger wreath, she is instructed to "pluck a leaf from it and burn it; and a great smoke will arise, and you will fall into a trance; and in your trance your lover will carry you away to the fairy rath, and there you may dance all night with him on the greensward. But say no prayer, and make no sign of the cross while the smoke is rising, or your lover will disappear for ever."[1448]

The girl shuts herself in her room nightly, burning the leaf and finding exquisite joy in Fairyland. Eventually her mother, noting her daughter's despondency each morning, falls to her knees and begins praying, signing the cross over the girl. Without warning, she falls into a fit, and a priest is called; alas, she dies before midnight.[1449]

What was this magical plant? It doesn't sound like a mushroom. It was obviously inhaled. Other psychoactive plants from western Europe tend to be topically ingested. Barring an import—the Crown encouraged Irish hemp cultivation in the 17th century—it remains a mystery.[1450] Perhaps its power derived not from the herb itself, but from its ring-like arrangement: Athenians hung wreaths on doors "because they charm[ed] souls… of both the living and the dead."[1451]

A different state of beings:

"Come in, little green men"

In the 20th century, extraterrestrials started materializing during trips… or, more elegantly, the plant intelligence behind entheogens adapted to psychonauts' modern sensibilities. From McKenna:

> I usually follow a line I learned in an old I Love Lucy rerun where she's explaining to Ethel how she contacts flying saucers and she says, "I just say, 'Come in, little green men! Come in, little green men!'" So on mushrooms I do this, I say, "Come in, little green men!" and what begins to happen is this sound like bells, like very distant bells. Then it becomes louder and louder, sort of like bells with wind. It becomes louder and louder and more complicated and more complex, and at a certain, very-hard-to-precisely-define moment, it begins to spill over into the visual cortex.[1452]

Before science fiction seized our imagination, UFOs dominated trips in the form of lights, ships, or other aerial apparitions. These truly "unidentified flying objects" naturally merged with "extraterrestrial visitors" following Kenneth Arnold's 1947 "flying saucer" sighting. Within this context, modern psychonauts frequently report traveling into orbit, seeing UFOs, and meeting aliens.

One DMT user "was fixated on the earth below and realized [he] was moving south, apparently in polar orbit over Siberia." Another saw a UFO, "electrically buzzed and illuminated by [his] own pulse," complete with intelligences that "took parts out of [him] and/or put parts in." Yet another entered an Egyptian courtyard: "Above me hovered a metallic 'halo' of the approximate consistency of a ring-shaped air bubble rising through water. This halo, if seen over an Iowan cornfield, would no doubt be described as a UFO."[1453]

Pop-culture representations of UFO occupants also appear. Wrote another psychonaut, "As the first wave of DMT shot over my consciousness I became instantly aware of what could be described as the 'Greys,' your classic alien. Much to my surprise they came running over and started to perform a series of tests as if to monitor my trip."[1454] Though the Greys were largely absent in Strassman's study, one subject described a reassuring female entity with an "elongated head."[1455]

Correspondence from self-proclaimed shaman Shonagh Home to Mike Clelland described a mushroom journey where "a white sphere" approached from the distance. Nearing, it transformed into a white owl, then a beautiful, feather-clad woman who introduced herself as "White Owl." She took Shonagh in her wings to a tree top, where "Mother Earth" whispered, "You are dying, Daughter Who Longs."[1456]

White Owl told Shonagh she was to be reborn into the godhead as "Daughter Who Knows." "I found myself radiating luminous blue light," Shonagh wrote. "Then I was catapulted into what I can only describe as the Cosmos, the Universe, the All."[1457]

Terence McKenna's "Ecology of Souls"

What is this place—or places—where gods, faeries, aliens, and the dead might so intermingle? It feels like a real territory, begging to be mapped.

Maybe all ASCs are dreamland, though this recursive logic is unhelpful; what is dreamland? Perhaps merely the subconscious, or, more exotically, Jung's Collective Unconscious. To McKenna, this was a "more friendly" approach to psychedelics than Materialist models, "closer to his presupposition" of shamanic experience:[1458]

> In the Freudian variety, it's all about repressed sexual stuff and wish-fulfillment and what he calls "day residues," meaning jumbled memories of recent experience. The Jungian model is a broader model because it says—again, countervailing these geneticists who say DNA only contains protein-sequencing information—Jungians want to say that there is … a Collective Unconscious, that you can go deep into the self and reach beyond personal memory and personal trauma to racial memory and racial trauma, and ultimately… all life, all of the Gaian biosphere becomes available.[1459]

Philosopher Michael Grosso posited the "Mind at Large," a Jungian variation with some Aldous Huxley thrown in for added measure.[1460] According to Grosso, "Mind at Large is the transpersonal aspect of mind; it is distinct but able to interact with matter," an interconnected network of

individual minds emerging at "critical junctures" like conception, death, etc.[1461]

McKenna's reveries skewed more toward Otherworlds, dimensions, and "non-Euclidian and hyper/higher plane geometry" where "the mind is a multidimensional manifold of some sort, but it takes the shape of its vessel, in the same way that a liquid takes the shape of its vessel."[1462]

Whatever they represent, ASCs are *liminal*. Trips "dissolve boundaries," McKenna observed. "This turns out to be tremendously important because the only other points in life where boundaries are dissolved is at the brink of the yawning grave, and at orgasm, and at the edge of sleep. And dissolution of boundary is somehow the precondition for understanding reality."[1463]

McKenna's description hints at the supernatural's sexual obsession, evidenced in human concubines to the gods, incubi, succubi, amorous faeries, alien sex pests, and stories of wild men rapists abducting women. Sigmund Freud reduced mankind's drive into two fundamentals embedded from birth: Eros, the Grecian love personification, and Thanatos, that of death. We seek "little death" and "big death" in equal measure. While "sexuality never amounted to mere procreation, which Freud calls the genital (*das Genitale*)," it is nonetheless intimately linked.[1464] Therefore, the supernatural's sexual obsession is a *birth* obsession.

"There is sex only because there is death," wrote Jeffrey Kripal. "If there were no death, there would be no need for sexuality. Sex and death are two sides of the same biological coin, and we are that flipping coin."[1465] We enter life via a tunnel, the birth canal, and apparently exit through one as well, if NDErs are to be believed.

Of the DMT realm's true nature, McKenna said:

> You say, "My god, is it possible that what we're breaking into here is an ecology of souls?" That these are not extraterrestrials from Zubenelgenubi or Zeta Reticuli Beta, these are the dear departed. And they exist in a realm which, for want of a better word, let's call eternity. And somehow this drug—or whatever it is—is allowing me to see across the bay at the veil. This is the lifting—you want to talk about boundary-dissolution!...
>
> So the testimony of DMT for me is that there is a nearby dimension teeming with intelligence that, from one perspective—and one of the more conservative perspectives—seems like an ecology of souls. It seems as though that what the shamans always said they were doing was, in fact, precisely what they were doing.[1466]

This book adopted Terence McKenna's elegant phraseology because "ecology" implies the robust variety of entities found in paranormal encounters. Ecologies thrive on diversity, and the ecology of souls is no different, yet undergirded by a fundamental animating presence: soul itself, distilled through every living thing, real and imaginal, varied in expression but singular in source.

McKenna conceded the notion's unpalatability.

"I think it's much easier to believe in meddling extraterrestrials than that Uncle Herman and Aunt Fanny are somehow reaching in from the Great Beyond," he said.[1467] McKenna saw this as a failing in modern spirituality, that

"the human soul is so alienated from us in our present culture that we treat it as an extraterrestrial. To us the most alien thing in the cosmos is the human soul."[1468]

"After all, if you believe they're extraterrestrials who came from the stars, then you're supposing and hypothesizing all kinds of things," he argued. "Since [DMT entities] are interested in human beings, since they can converse with human beings, since they seem to know our boundaries and limitations, they must *be* some kind of human being."[1469] The same could be said for today's aliens and yesterday's faeries.

If psychedelics take us to the afterlife, then they provide guided tours in an "afterlife vehicle" of sorts, a soul safari allowing the path to be scouted and navigated correctly at death. In some disciplines, this is their entire purpose.

"Both the psychedelic dream state and the waking psychedelic state acquire great import because they reveal to life a task: to become familiar with this dimension that is causing being, in order to be familiar with it at the moment of passing from life," McKenna said.[1470]

Contemporary culture endorses meditation as a vector for psychological health. Its ancient application equally emphasized afterlife preparation, much like datura, ayahuasca, and psilocybin use. In this sense, *altered states of consciousness themselves are psychopomps*, providing foreknowledge of the afterlife realm.

A three year long, longitudinal study from 2018 demonstrated Buddhist meditation practitioners can voluntarily induce NDEs, to scout "the Bardo

plains."[1471] In the earliest stages of death among Buddhists, "all of the events that have occurred are the same as those that can be experienced during meditation, therefore, the deceased is reminded of his or her spiritual practice, which has hopefully prepared them for this transition," Laura Strong wrote.[1472]

As elaborated in Chapter 14, in 1998 Whitley Strieber claimed to have met a tiny, wizened, enigmatic being—"The Master of the Key"— in his hotel room. The ensuing metaphysical conversation reinforced Strieber's suspicion that meditation serves as preparation for the afterlife.

"This is why we have been so insistent that you meditate," the Master told him. "Otherwise we will lose you when you die and we don't want that. If a being cannot self-maintain after the elemental body no longer does it automatically, it is absorbed into the flux of conscious energy. You go into the light, as it were."[1473]

DMT is no different. McKenna claimed to have "turn[ed] a very prominent Tibetan lama onto DMT, a name that you would recognize," who told him, "It's the lesser lights. You can't go further than that without breaking the thread of return."[1474]

Adopting this language, McKenna called DMT trips "bungee-cording into the Bardo… It jerks you back, so you get *that* much of a look into the yawning grave."[1475] Strassman agreed, saying DMT "pull[s] back the veils" to the Bardo, "open[ing] our inner senses to these betwixt states."[1476]

In his lectures, McKenna hinted at reincarnation in the DMT realm, speculating the "language toys" of the elves represented *something's* "idea of

a reassuring environment for a human being," like mobiles in a "maternity ward playpen."[1477]

"It's where you start your existence in this other dimension," he mused. "The entire space has been 'prepared for baby,' and *you're* the baby… I suspect that when you die, this is what you get, and that familiarity with the after-death vehicle… this trip is you're peeking over the edge into eternity, and questions you never thought you would have answers to are answered."[1478]

Recall how human deaths represented faerie births. They were celebratory occasions—a reaction McKenna's effervescent elves share upon our arrival in the DMT space. A word of caution, however: McKenna was familiar with faerie folklore, even citing Evans Wentz in his lectures, so contamination of his ideas cannot be ruled out. Nonetheless, the congruency is shocking.

"What if where we are now is the dark side, Hades, Sheol, the land of the dead—which, ironically, we think of as the land of the living?" Strieber wondered. "But if it is the dark side of the mandala, it is also the womb. Our lives here are preparation for a rebirth into timelessness, or so my experience suggests to me."[1479]

Ego death

Regardless of whether or not DMT and NDEs take you to the same place, most trips signify another kind of death: that of the ego.

"How much of one's self (whatever that means) is going to be carried over, I don't know, but it looks to me like probably not much," McKenna warned.[1480] Ego death—a loss of individual identity—brings again to mind dissociative states, and the loss of any sense of ourselves during some dreams or NDEs.

Ego dissolution is a cornerstone of mythology and religion, long symbolized by death. Joseph Campbell described ego death as self-surrender and transition, a pivotal part of the hero's journey and a requisite step on the path to rebirth and victory.[1481] In Eastern disciplines, ego—different from the Freudian concept—is illusory, a stumbling block to enlightenment, an attachment to be disposed of. If reincarnation exists, recollection of our past lives rarely persists after childhood.[1482]

Ego death is a knife's edge in psychedelic trips, however. Anyone unprepared might emerge irrevocably broken, even schizophrenic, echoing how malicious faeries inflict madness. Perhaps this is what ancient Egyptians meant when resigning the fate of the dead with heavy hearts to Ammit, devourer of souls.

Jung called ego death "psychic death," "a fundamental transformation of the psyche" only achieved by unifying archetypal opposites. This task can be painful, but success means the psyche is reborn.[1483]

Jung found within alchemy the perfect analogy for ego death. Alchemy is an ancient process of self-improvement often described as "turning lead into gold," a spiritual path often misconstrued as a literal quest for riches. Encoded in this metaphorical discipline are two methods for purifying materials to obtain "the Philosopher's Stone," the apex of enlightenment: a wet way and a dry way. The former was slow and methodical, but safe, the latter fast but treacherous for the inexperienced, causing madness and a loss of self.[1484]

Within this, we see meditation as the wet way, psychedelics the dry way; the ferry may only cost a nickel, but it isn't necessarily seaworthy. Is it coincidental that Hermes Trismegistus—the apocryphal figure fused from two psychopomps—is considered the father of alchemy?

Knowledge and wisdom are not synonymous. It is one thing to use psychedelics recreationally… it is another to incorporate entheogens into your worldview. Accessing the Otherworld responsibly requires a sufficient epistemology: shamanism.

7

SHAMANISM

OBJ



In the 15th century Marsilio Ficino proposed the concept of *prisca theologia* ("ancient theology"), a singular, true religion passed from the divine to man in the depths of antiquity. Hoping these teachings might encourage reform in the Catholic Church, Ficino and subsequent scholars focused upon Neoplatonism and Hermeticism, but overlooked another strong candidate: animism.[1485]

In this worldview, the entire landscape is ensouled—not only humans and animals, but rivers, mountains, even individual rocks and trees. While rooted in problematic, outdated, Western concepts of "mind" and "soul," the term "animism" nonetheless usefully describes mankind's earliest attempt to understand reality. It is our *prisca theologia*.[1486] Millennia before the first hieroglyphic was inked in the Egyptian Book of the Dead, shamans in animistic societies were interacting with the ecology of souls.

Though previous chapters established shamanism's fundamentals, the opportunity to expand upon it here in more depth is welcome. Anyone desiring a deeper dive into shamanism should read the scholarship of Mircea Eliade, which—while not above criticism, particularly regarding his treatment of Australian and African traditions—remains unparalleled, especially regarding the cultures from which the term was borrowed.[1487]

Ones who know

Originally, *shaman* (perhaps from the Tungusic *šaman*, "one who knows") strictly referred to Siberian intercessors with the spirit world. Since its Western introduction in the 1690s,[1488] the term has grown to encompass religious figures from every indigenous culture: witch doctors, sorcerers, magicians, faerie doctors, seers, mystics, cunning folk, witches, medicine men, magi, wise men and women, even some yogis, saints, and ascetics.

These disparate figures would rightly bristle at the broad application of such a region-specific term, but all can be understood (to varying degrees) within a shamanic context. As Eliade wrote, "they transform a cosmo-theological concept into a *concrete mystical experience*," interacting with the spirit world through altered states of consciousness, serving as humanity's diplomats.[1489]

Those searching Classical texts for a *prisca theologia* underestimated animism's influence upon thinkers like Plato, whom Karl Meuli and E.R. Dodds argue derived concepts such as the separable soul from Black Sea Scythian shamans.[1490]

"The Greek language preserves a family of terms related to *goēs* [enchanters] which bears close resemblance to shamanistic experience," wrote Michelle Gellrich. "Especially in their early history, these terms concern the binding of souls, notably those of the dead, by a figure of great prestige, a charismatic leader. Indeed, the *goēs* is originally a psychopomp who

presides over funeral rituals and ensures that the deceased is safely situated in the afterlife, his honor appeased and his potential for harm allayed by the proper ceremonies."[1491]

Shamanism's origins are lost to time. It may have come from psychoactive plants, though shamanism appears in entheogen-poor regions. Many, like Mongolia's Uriankhai, attribute divine intervention: *Bö-Khân*, the first shaman, courted a celestial maiden (or "fairy," as Eliade puts it) who, discovering he was married, "caused the earth to swallow him and his wife. She then gave birth to a boy, whom she abandoned under a birch tree to be fed by its sap. From this child comes the race of shamans (*Bö-Khä-näkn*)."[1492]

Whatever its inspiration, shamanism's ancient universality befits Ficino's *prisca theologia.* Gregory Shushan suspects these traditions followed Siberian peoples—themselves originating in China—across the Bering land bridge to the Americas, although he concedes the theory's shortcomings.[1493] Nonetheless, traditions of North American medicine men and women equally embody the "fairly specific set of ideas and practices" of northern Eurasian shamanism.[1494] For instance, Cherokee medicine people, like their Old World counterparts, retain special knowledge of nature's intricate workings, heal both physical and spiritual sickness, communicate with the world of spirits, and supernaturally alter circumstances, earning them reputations as "conjurors" among white invaders.[1495]

Bering Strait transmission might explain similarities between Siberian shamanism and its New World equivalents, but falls short when comparing Australian techniques, which clearly did *not* originate in northern Eurasia. *Karadji*, "Clever Men" or "Men of High Degree," pushed animistic views of

landscape one step further with "dreaming tracks," attributing spiritual significance to even the most mundane landmarks, enabling a preternatural sense of space and direction for hundreds of miles that baffled European colonists. A crucial component are the karadji's extrasensory abilities, including telepathy and levitation, obtained through trance states.[1496]

Identifying Siberia or China as shamanism's ur-source also undermines sub-Saharan traditions which—if the "out of Africa" theory holds—must represent an earlier practice which survived migration to Asia intact. Rough shaman analogues like the Yoruba *babalawo* and others mediate the spirit world, see the future, consult major life events like birth or marriage, communicate with animals, heal patients, negotiate intertribal disputes, and visit the Otherworld.[1497]

A more parsimonious assumption is that shamanism's international consistency represents objective spirit contact obtained independently. For Eliade, shamans' extensive knowledge of death directly results from their ability to leave our reality and "*see* the superhuman beings," to the extent they established a working "funerary geography" adopted by mythology and religion worldwide.[1498]

This alluring authority and antiquity naturally encouraged appropriation by the New Age movement. Modern "shamans," particularly in the United States, mix and match traditions with cringeworthy disregard for individual belief systems. "Thus, despite claims of traditionalism, [American] Indian spirituality that has been repackaged so as to appeal to modern-day sensibilities constitutes yet another 'new religion,'" observed James R. Lewis.[1499]

New Age trends always bleed into Ufology. Animism's "Star People" transformed from stellar spirit beings into flesh-and-blood extraterrestrials. Entheogens became vectors for alien contact rather than supernatural forces. Simultaneously, earnest folklorists sought not to appropriate shamanism, but merely compare undeniable similarities between its initiations and journeys and UFO contact. Few make the case better than Thomas E. "Eddie" Bullard, author of 1987's seminal *UFO Abductions: The Measure of a Mystery*, and the late Australian parapsychologist Simon Harvey-Wilson, whose doctoral thesis drew extensive comparisons between the phenomena.

"Put simply, both types of experience involve people being taken unexpectedly by unearthly beings to a strange, otherworldly location where they may undergo a variety of often frightening indignities or challenges," Harvey-Wilson wrote. "Upon their return they are often traumatized and bewildered, but may later manifest an increased interest in spiritual matters and the environment as well as claiming various paranormal abilities such as healing." Alien abductions "invariably also result in the development of an animistic perspective in which the abductees regard the natural world as filled with unseen spiritual forces, leading them to express a deep concern for animals and environmental matters." Harvey-Wilson saw meaningful similarities in shamanism's sometimes-familial inheritance and aliens' obsession with genetics (including heredity), as well as themes of dismemberment, covered later in this chapter.[1500]

It’s a living

“For smaller-scale societies, especially for hunter-gatherer groups, shamans perform all of the functions that doctors, priests, and therapists (and sometimes mystics and artists as well) perform in contemporary Western societies,” wrote Lewis.[1501] In addition to settling disputes, shamans use their good standing with the spirit world to obtain inaccessible information and perform duties otherwise impossible: speaking to animals, luring game, tracking or controlling weather patterns or herd migration, balancing the “karma” of the village (to use an unrelated term), exorcising spirits from the living, retrieving lost souls, and guiding the dead to the afterlife.[1502]

As healers, shamans cured both physical and spiritual ailments. To jaded modern eyes, their techniques can resemble outright deception.

“Shamans simulate paranormal events throughout the world, and the sham of shamanism appears to be one of its most pervasive characteristics,” wrote George P. Hansen, referring to placebo healing and sleight-of-hand used to “extract” foreign spirit objects from patients’ bodies. While appearing uncharitable, Hansen’s declaration ties into his greater thesis that hoaxes can encourage genuinely miraculous events—consider the Philip Experiment from the Introduction. By embodying the Trickster archetype and allowing *room* for the paranormal, supernatural occurrences reach in to “bridge the gap”; an appeased *imagination* empowers the *imaginal*. Shamans do not operate in

physical reality, but patients want to *see* physical results, thus the need for trickery.[1503]

Having said that, not every shamanic technique involves deception. Some apparently remove actual objects from the afflicted, and successful "soul retrieval"—one of shamans' primary duties—speaks to authenticity as well.

Animistic views of illness primarily place their root in the spirit realm, signifying souls lost or abducted in the Otherworld, often the land of the dead. Walter and Fridman perceived similarities between this view and faerie lore.

"In shamanism, an illness is often seen as the result of a debt owed to the Otherworld, a debt that has not been paid," they wrote. "Similarly, in European tales and legends, when the fairies are displeased because some obligation has not been met or some taboo has been violated, they give a punishment."[1504]

In soul retrievals, shamans become soul hunters, descending into the underworld via trance to rescue the ill, or convince them to return. Wrote Eliade:

> Disease is attributed to the soul's having strayed away or been stolen, and treatment is in principle reduced to finding it, capturing it, and obliging it to resume its place in the patient's body. In some parts of Asia the cause of illness can be the intrusion of a magical object into the patient's body or his "possession" by evil spirits; in this case, cure consists in extracting the harmful object or expelling the demons. Sometimes disease has a twofold cause—theft of

> the soul aggravated by "possession" by evil spirits—and the shamanic cure includes both searching for the soul and expelling the demons...
>
> …the human soul… is, as a precarious psychic unit, inclined to forsake the body and an easy prey for demons and sorcerers. This is why, all through Asia and North America, and elsewhere as well (e.g., Indonesia), the shaman performs the function of doctor and healer; he announces the diagnosis, goes in search of the patient's fugitive soul, captures it, and makes it return to animate the body that it has left. It is always the shaman who conducts the dead person's soul to the underworld, for he is the psychopomp par excellence.[1505]

A poem from northeastern China's Manchu people chronicles one such journey during the Ming Dynasty. After a wealthy couple's son died in a hunting accident, the shaman Nišan offered to retrieve him. Traveling below to the "world of the dead," she encountered numerous spirits, including her own dead husband, before locating the young man. Nišan ascended with his soul, and the boy revived.[1506]

Not all shamans are as successful. Failed soul retrievals result in death. The shaman shifts roles from soul hunter to psychopomp, no longer leading souls *from* death but rather *to* it. Chapter 2 cursorily covered this topic, but further elaboration is warranted.

Shamans start leading dead souls to the afterlife in various post-mortem timeframes. Some cultures call upon them the moment villagers die, while others allow souls to linger. Among the Nanai (Goldi), Nenets (Yurak), and Altai of northeastern Eurasia, shamans only escort the dead following the funeral banquet, while other Tungusic shamans might only be sought if the soul refuses to move on, i.e. haunts the living.[1507] Likewise, some Mongolian

shamans not only send the dead to the Lower World, but "also work with the souls of the dead that are still in this world."[1508]

In this sense, shamanism overlaps with Spiritualism, a belief system equally preoccupied with communication from the dead.[1509] Parallels can be further drawn between mediums of that tradition and shamans, though the latter primarily travel to the spirit world, versus bringing spirits to ours.[1510] Like shamans, mediums and psychics can also serve as psychopomps, encouraging the dead to move on to the afterlife.[1511]

Shamanic rituals "have often been compared with Western séances at which mediums demonstrate their powers," Lewis noted. "Spiritualistic phenomena may indeed occur, and those assembled to witness the rite may hear voices, rappings, and other noises." Other observations include poltergeist effects, especially shaking tents, objects moving, levitation, "and howling animals, which are sometimes interpreted as representing the 'voices' of spirits."[1512]

Following a tribe member's death, the Ojibwe erect "ghost lodges," simple tents whose walls flutter at the entrance of the *tcisaki* (shaman), ostensibly from winds conjured by *manitous* (a species of spirit). Via drum- and chant-induced trance, the spirits are contacted, speaking both through the tcisaki's voice and independently; the winds pick up. "Spark-like lights were said to appear within the tent itself," wrote Paul Devereux. Refuting "the sham of shamanism," one dying tcisaki insisted to an anthropologist he "did not deceive you at that time," maintaining the shaking lodge and voices were not fabrications.[1513]

Eliade, citing Wilhelm Radloff, described a Siberian shamanic "séance":

> The ceremony takes place in the evening. The shaman begins by circling the yurt, beating his drum; then he enters the tent and, going to the fire, invokes the deceased. Suddenly the shaman's voice changes; he begins to speak on a high pitch, in falsetto, for it is really the dead woman who is speaking. She complains that she does not know the road, that she is afraid to leave her relatives, and so on, but finally consents to the shaman's leading her, and the two set off together for the subterranean realm. When they arrive, the shaman finds that the dead refuse to permit the newcomer to enter. Prayers proving ineffectual, brandy is offered; the seance gradually becomes more lively, even to the point of the grotesque, for the souls of the dead, through the shaman's voice, begin quarreling and singing together; finally they consent to receive the dead woman. The second part of the ritual represents the return journey; the shaman dances and shouts until he falls to the ground unconscious.[1514]

Souls' hesitancy is noted in the contemporary practice of shaman David Kowalewski. As mentioned earlier, Kowalewski is not above incentivizing—through bribery, the lure of dead loved ones, etc.—or even tricking wary souls to transition into the afterlife.[1515]

In another example, anthropologist S.M. Shirokogoroff, staying among the Manchu, attended three shamanic séances where Chinese, Manchu, and Tungusic spirits were invoked. In one instance, an eight-year old girl was ill, and, after asking these spirits for help, the shaman began drumming. His fall to the floor indicated a spirit had possessed him—in this case, a wolf—and was open for questions. His assistants determined the illness's cause was "not the soul of a dead person, as had been thought before the seance, but

a certain spirit, which, in return for a cure, demand[ed] that a small temple (*m'ao*) be built for it and sacrifices offered to it regularly."[1516]

A little help from my friends

After their initiation—covered shortly—shamans primarily contacted the ecology of souls through trances, both planned and spontaneous, via rituals or entheogens. These are often referred to as *ecstatic*, from the Greek *ekstasis*, "to be or stand outside oneself," i.e. an ASC inaccessible to ordinary tribe members.

"The shaman's switch to an altered state of consciousness is expressed as a journey in space," wrote Piers Vitebsky. "Though the shaman may also fly around the known local landscape, it is also very common to travel up and down through a many-layered cosmology in which our world occupies a position somewhere in the middle."[1517] The motifs embedded in these subsequent journeys are detailed throughout the remainder of this chapter; for now, our attention turns to the spirits contacted therein.

As evidenced by Tungusic and Mongolian traditions, relationships between shamanic figures and the dead extends beyond the psychopomp role. The dead, armed with the Otherworld's timeless store of knowledge, were sought for counsel or cures for the living. Hungarian seers initiated trances between St. Lucy's Day (December 13) and Christmas for this purpose, while Scandinavian mystics practiced *utiseta* ("sitting out"), waiting atop burial mounds or in cemeteries. Elsewhere in Europe, witches obtained knowledge by "interrogating the returning ghost" of someone recently deceased.[1518]

The enlightened Grecian dead might return as "schoolmasters of the living."[1519] Greek necromancers and shamans were arguably indistinguishable, encompassing notable figures like Pythagoras, Empedocles, and Epimenides.

"These men included necromancy among a range of allied miraculous powers," wrote Ogden. "The 'shaman' tradition is sympathetic toward and ostensibly more 'internal' to its subjects, and so can perhaps give us an idea of how at least some ancient necromancers perceived themselves." Ogden further asserts "the performance of necromancy in many ways resembles initiation into mysteries" like those of Eleusís.[1520]

Since the deceased represent highly-sought repositories of knowledge, it is unsurprising some shamanic practices deem them "spirit helpers," a description calling to mind witches' familiars, who themselves could be dead humans (the concepts are related, but distinct). The Zulu call these *imilozi*, ancestors who "live among the people and speak to their diviner in hoots and a low whistling tone, passing along messages from the 'other side' as well as the secrets of the gods."[1521]

Especially helpful are dead shamans, a recurring motif. "Deceased Inuit shamans, for example, keep working in the afterlife for the living," wrote Kowalewski.[1522] In the Sakha Republic, departed shamans called *amagyat* return to assist their living counterparts.[1523] *Dto-mba Shi-lo*, mythic founder of Tibetan Nakhi shamanism, "received the power to conquer demons and send souls to the realm of the gods," a talent he oversees to this day when invoked by his followers.[1524]

Often as not spirit helpers are non-human. (Or at least so distant from human experience they have become something else entirely. In a belief system where everything is ensouled, how can one distinguish a bird spirit from an ancestor in avian form?) In addition to the dead, shamans count gods, generalized spirits, faeries, and animals among their helpers. Arabic sorcerers might consult a *tabi* "on matters concerning the deceased and needing to speak with the dead."[1525] Like other spirit helpers, tabi are neither caught nor controlled, but assist of their own volition.

In fact, spirit helpers are "far from being harmless for their own master," wrote Waldemar Bogoras. "When the shaman has sent them for a fight and they cannot overcome the hostile spirits, or more especially the assisting spirits of a rival shaman, they will turn back in full displeasure and assuming their actual terrible shape will slay their own master."[1526]

Many spirit helpers are diminutive, even explicitly regarded as fae folk.

"The relationship which Bulgarian, Serbian and Greek fairy magicians maintain with the fairies can in many cases be seen as verging on communication with the dead," wrote Éva Pócs. In Serbia and Romania, for instance, "good faerie" patrons known as *the saints* assist female magicians as they fall into trances to "communicate with the dead regularly at the time of the major Christian feasts of the dead... We also know of magicians who, although fairy magicians by name (*vilarka, vilevniak*), mostly transmit messages of the dead to the living during their spontaneously induced states of trance."[1527]

Faerie-shaman relationships appear worldwide. During séances, Malay *belian* shamans (known for shapeshifting into tigers) invite *chinoi*, short

nature spirits appearing as birds, into their bodies. Japanese sorcerers retain ghostlike, child-sized *shikigami* for assistance.[1528] Upon meeting an *azôv* (capricious, embedded in the land, accepting of offerings—clear faerie analogues), any of Nigeria's Tiv might descend into madness, a prelude to "becoming a diviner."[1529] Middle Eastern *sahirin* practitioners form close alliances with djinn.[1530] Ayahuasca introduces Peruvian shamans to *doctoritos* ("little doctors") who offer icaros, train them as diagnosticians, and instruct them in plant medicine.[1531]

Faeries play prominent roles in North American shamanism, where "children being raised to be wizards were often supposed to go away and talk with the 'little people,'" wrote Willard S. Bacon. "The Creek believed they were capable of endowing people with supernatural powers."[1532] Any Tunica boy winning a wrestling match with *Tonop*, a magical dwarf, becomes a great shaman. Yurok shamans are helped by *helkew ni'wo*, small mountain spirits. Subterranean *Eeajuatsiaq* assist Inuit shamans in trances and sacred language.[1533] "A little green man" protects medicine men of the Great Basin, firing arrows at their targets.[1534]

According to author Tom Cowan, the Celtic "fairy faith" is a variation on shamanic belief. Though a controversial stance overlooking many requisites of shamanism, the similarities are evident.[1535] For instance, University of Edinburgh's Julian Goodare argued practices surrounding "the 'seely wights,' Scottish fairy-like nature spirits," had all the makings "of a shamanistic cult," albeit lacking "communally realized rituals" for their trance states.[1536]

Recall Cornish faerie abductee Anne Jefferies, left with miraculous abilities following her illness, a common form of shamanic initiation. Another woman

in Tuam, Ireland gained "second sight" after languishing in sickness "with the faeries" for seven years.[1537] Famed Irish seer Biddy Early fulfilled her community's shamanic role, including healing the sick and seeing the future, all by contacting both faeries and the dead.[1538] European faeries even directly assume shamanic roles themselves, curing and prophesying: look no further than Morgan le Fay and the Lady of the Lake from Arthurian literature.[1539]

Animals represent another category of shamanic spirit helpers. These are often, but not always, fauna with psychopomp associations. Ecuadorian shamans, for example, utilize *pasuk*, which appear as "spirit birds" or tarantulas.[1540] The *ié-kyla* ("animal mothers") of Yakut shamans are eagles, colts, bulls, elk, or bears; "those who have wolves or dogs are least favored." These are not to be confused with *ämägät*, tutelary spirits in the form of dead shamans or lesser gods.[1541] Spirit helpers in various North American practices may be foxes, bears, dogs, coyotes, deer, antelope, sharks, eagles, owls, or other birds.[1542] Within these ancient shamanic traditions, Claude Lecouteux perceives the origin of a common medieval trope: animal guides to the Otherworld, like white hinds leading to Fairyland.[1543]

All too familiar

"With respect to animal helpers… the relationship may be a totemic one, meaning that the initiate in some way exhibits the nature of the animal," wrote Lewis.[1544] In this sense, boundaries between shamans and spirit helpers blur, raising the question of whether spirit helpers are simply shamans' Higher Selves.

Indeed, these spirits' "presence is manifested by the shaman imitating animal cries or behavior," resembling possession or, more accurately, the "taking possession of his helping spirits by a shaman," as Eliade put it. "It is the shaman who turns himself into an animal, just as he achieves a similar result by putting on an animal mask."[1545] Thus, spirit helpers and their individual shamans conflate.

Just as familiars might be interpreted as one of their witches' multiple souls, spirit helpers may reflect an aspect of the shaman, a reading supported by Mongolian tradition. If a Buryat shaman's *khubilgan* (spirit helper) dies, they die as well; similarly, a khubilgan defeated in battle with another khubilgan leaves its shaman "gravely ill." In Mesoamerican tradition, the term *nagual* interchangeably refers to the "animal disguises" shamans wear *and* their spirit helpers.[1546] Totem animals, faerie familiars, spirit helpers, wandering souls, shapeshifting shamans—do these all represent the same phenomenon, one of our multiple souls externalized?

Dying to death

Like all spiritual vocations, shamanism calls to individuals, albeit more forcefully than in Western religion. Augmented by entheogens, shamans reach the pinnacle of indigenous spiritual hierarchies through the symbolic rebirth of trauma, illness, and spiritual discipline.

Shamanic initiations sometimes resemble more extreme versions of the rites of passage reserved for rank-and-file tribe members. This period of liminality, largely forgotten in the West, involves the transition of individuals from one group to another, usually childhood to adulthood, typically involving endurance, pain, or other adverse situations.

According to Jung, any rite of passage "takes the novice back to the deepest level of original mother-child identity or ego-Self identity, thus forcing him to experience a symbolic death. In other words, his identity is temporarily dismembered or dissolved in the Collective Unconscious. From this state he is then ceremonially rescued by the rite of the new birth."[1547]

Shamanic initiations typically occur early in candidates' lives, often around puberty, permanently arresting children's proximity to the spirit world before it disappears into the cynicism of adulthood.[1548]

(Immediate comparisons can be drawn between early shamanic initiation and the paranormal experiences of children, especially childhood contact with faeries or aliens. Bullard noted that UFO abductions are "a hazard of

youth, with children but especially teenagers and young adults the most vulnerable."[1549] These encounters even engender later ASCs. For example, Lisa Terrell met a short, asexual, triangle-faced, cat-eyed, luminous being in a German forest in 1959, when she was just nine years old. She felt thereafter propelled into "a different reality," experiencing mild psychic abilities and waking visions.)[1550]

Shamanism is often inherited, though others—regarded as less powerful—self-nominate or are selected by the tribe. While Yakut shamanism is *not* hereditary, ämägät tend to select future shamans within the same family.[1551]

"Among the Tungus of the Transbaikal region he who wishes to become a shaman announces that the spirit of a dead shaman has appeared to him in [a] dream and ordered him to succeed him," Eliade wrote. This is only regarded as legitimate if the candidate expresses madness.[1552]

Shamanic initiations are typically painful or arduous, consistent with inductions in secret societies and mythology. Consider fraternal hazing, the symbolic use of swords in Masonic initiation, or how Odin—founder of Scandinavian necromancy who could change into animals, shamanically dispatching birds "to the four corners of the world"—gained knowledge after self-crucifixion.[1553] For Africa's Dagara shamans, "initiation is a dangerous commitment that can—and sometimes does—result in death," wrote Malidoma Patrice Somé.[1554]

"Certainly the most striking aspect of most traditional initiations is the manner in which the initiate is symbolically slain," Lewis elaborates. "Often the person undergoing the ritual is made to feel pain—pain as might actually be experienced if the person were killed," ranging from "as mild as the

discomfort of fasting" to "as excruciating as having an incisor knocked out."[1555] Initiatory "death" imparts knowledge from the Otherworld, specifically the toolkit to reenter and successfully navigate it at will—it is, once again, the motif of "dying to death" and returning with supernatural powers.

The violence of initiation evokes both the abuse of suspected changelings and Ring's observations, where childhood trauma enables NDEs and alien abductions later in life. Initiation's goal is dissociation. The conventional explanation is that individuals with dissociative tendencies are more fantasy-prone, unable to differentiate reality and more vulnerable to dissociative identity disorder;[1556] Whitley Strieber feels "abuse shatters the child's expectations, increasing the chance that things that are not supposed to be there, but are, will be seen."[1557]

UFO contact, shamanism, and dissociation collided in the life of Vusamazulu Credo Mutwa, a sometimes-controversial South African *sangoma* (medicine man) "caught between" the teachings of his Christian father and the heritage of his Zulu mother. In his conversations with John Mack, Mutwa claimed *mantindane*, spirits he equated with Grey aliens, bestowed supernatural knowledge upon him as a schoolboy. A lifetime of violence, including rape, forced Mutwa to become, in Mack's words, "an 'expert' in dissociation." Recalling a stabbing, Mutwa said, "I could feel the knives going into my body… I split into two, and so I escaped the pain." In this OBE, he saw "the bloodied mess that looked like me."[1558]

The violence of shamanic initiation, with its attendant lessons on safely traversing the ecology of souls, explains "bad trips" in recreational

psychedelic use. Inexperienced psychonauts, using entheogens improperly, are unprepared for what awaits; they do not receive the wisdom, say, an Australian Yaralbe shaman offers: "When you lie down to see the prescribed visions, and you do see them, do not be frightened, because they will be horrible."[1559]

The Otherworld can frighten even the initiated, so anyone lacking formal training is primed for unpleasantness. Adventurous sophomores in their dorm rooms don't stand a chance. Shamans safely employ "the dry way" of obtaining ASCs—entheogens—because they are students of ancient traditions. They have crossed through hell; all else pales in comparison.

"However selected, a shaman is not recognized as such until after he has received two kinds of teaching," wrote Eliade. "(1) ecstatic (dreams, trances, etc.) and (2) traditional (shamanic techniques, names and functions of the spirits, mythology and genealogy of the clan, secret language, etc.)." No boilerplate for shamanic initiation exists, but "the initiatory ecstasy" of Siberian shamanism often follows "certain exemplary themes":[1560]

> ...the novice encounters several divine figures... before being led by his animal guides to the "Center of the World," on the summit of the Cosmic Mountain, where are the World Tree and the Universal Lord; from the Cosmic Tree and by the will of the Universal Lord himself, he receives the wood to make his drum; semi-demonic beings teach him the nature of all diseases and their cures; finally, other demonic beings cut his body to pieces, boil it, and exchange it for better organs. Each of these elements in the initiatory story is consistent and has its place in a symbolic or ritual system well known to the history of religions.[1561]

To reify these mythopoetic themes, candidates are forced into ASCs (perhaps involving entheogens, though such substances are equally prominent in later journeys). Training may begin with something as innocuous as drumming. Others sleep atop tombs, graves, faerie hills, etc., but initiates more commonly embark on katabasis.

Various North American, Australian, Pacific Islander, and Siberian shamans begin training with sensory deprivation, descending into caves, ancient symbols of revelation. Subterranean spaces and labyrinths "are concrete symbols of passage into another world, of a descent to the underworld," Eliade asserted. "According to the earliest accounts of the Araucanian shamans of Chile, they too received their initiation in caves, which were often decorated with animal heads." Some nocturnal Inuit initiations involve approaching a cliff riddled with caves—future shamans enter easily, the cave mouth sealing behind them. When it reopens they flee or remain there forever.[1562]

Exiting the cave signifies rebirth, more overtly realized in initiations where candidates are buried alive. Somé's burial had "nothing to do with fear, but it was filled with pain… There are no words to describe how it feels to be buried alive." Sweltering heat, inaccessible itching, and crushing pressure pushed him into an ASC where "the whole area around me suddenly became light," filled with smoky figures. Somé left his body, walking some distance before ascending into the universal consciousness of the cosmos.[1563]

Alternatively, spirits elect future shamans by surrounding them with supernatural phenomena like levitation, inflicting illness, or striking them with lightning (the Buryat grant lightning fatalities the same burial rites as

shamans, their family extended the right to initiation).[1564] This trauma alone might serve as initiation, or may be accompanied by further rituals. To refuse the call invites the wrath of the gods.[1565]

Sick to death

Illness—source of dissociative OBEs—is among the most common forms of shamanic initiation, aligning with animistic beliefs representing sickness as a soul's departure. Villagers might call this illness "death," as among the Yakut, where the ill experience visions (including Otherworld travel and dismemberment) while "lying in state" for three days, fasting. One Avam Samoyed villager was almost buried after battling smallpox for three days, only to emerge a healthy shaman.[1566]

Initiatory illnesses appear in UFO lore, evidenced by a grave childhood affliction that Whitley Strieber suffered. A fever—107°, so violent his mother feared for his life—induced visions of a nun, "a monstrosity made up of thousands of tiny triangles," and "Eddie Death" (a little on-the-nose), a boy wearing a white t-shirt with "an insignia that looked like the triangles creature." A wrestling match with this final visitor ended in a conversation where the boy told Strieber he *wasn't* death—rather, that "'there is no death. You are born into a higher life'… Finally he waved good-bye—at which point the fever ended."[1567]

Sometimes a family history of epilepsy or mental instability designates shamans. Indonesian cultures select "sickly or weak subjects for the office of magician." In one example cited by Eliade, a Buryat "anti-shamanist" fell ill before reluctantly trying shamanic cures; "he was immediately cured, and became a shaman for the rest of his life."[1568]

Lewis wrote, "It is easy to see the parallels between [shamanic] initiation and the near-death experience."[1569] In fact, Ring argued NDEs are "the prototype of the shamanic journey," with both states embodying initiation and rebirth; he correctly extended this to UFO contact. The alien abduction is, as Ring put it, "an almost archetypal *journey of initiation* with its familiar invariant triadic sequence: separation, ordeal, and return."[1570]

NDEs may in fact be *required* to become a shaman. The discipline is all about dying to death. Shamans "learned consciously and voluntarily to enter into the same realm that the NDE[r] is thrust into, without warning or preparation, by virtue of falling victim to a life-threatening crisis," Ring wrote. "Or to put it the other way around, the NDEr has been inadvertently initiated into the first stages of the shaman's journey."[1571]

Near-death initiations and travels

Because shamanic initiations are often literal NDEs, it is somewhat disingenuous to treat any comparison of the two as revelatory. Nonetheless, it is fascinating to see how NDEs were subsumed into shamanic mythologies, how their hallmarks became integral components in both initiation and subsequent Otherworld journeys. Skilled shamans travel to other realms innumerable times throughout their lives, self-induced voyages that can be compared to those embarked upon by meditative Buddhist monks.

Gregory Shushan observes that both NDEs and shamanic experiences resemble lucid dreams, wherein dreamers maintain conscious awareness of the experience as it unfolds. He also perceives shamanism's influence on afterlife concepts—yet cautions against "over-generalizing their diversity, and oversimplifying their consistencies with the NDE. Shamanic journeys do not always involve realms of the dead, for example," and, existing within established spiritual systems, are "apt to be influenced by expectation."[1572]

The way expectations color these experiences can be seen in modern encounters. Comparing NDEs, shamanic experiences, and UFO contact, Eddie Bullard wrote, "Anyone familiar with folklore, mythology and comparative religion feels a shock of recognition on reading [alien] abduction stories, because they could pass for technological updates of age-old themes like the descent into Hell and the magical quest." Alien abductees find themselves—for all intents and purposes—in an Otherworld populated by supernatural

beings, their consciousness altered before returning to our world, often with newfound psi abilities.[1573]

One case Bullard examined reeks of shamanic awakening. On September 27, 1974, a pair of Australian hunters were floated into a bright craft by two spindly humanoids (tall, hairless, with large heads) who examined them before sending them "through a transparent wall" into a blue void. "After a time in this void they came down to a place and the younger witness found he had the body of a fox."[1574]

He enjoyed this incarnation "until a heavy snow buried him. A large faceless being dressed in furs pulled him and a woman out of the snow." The woman somehow "belonged" to the witness—a spirit helper? After returning to our reality, the witness experienced "occasional premonitions and an apparition."[1575]

In another time, another place, "extraterrestrials" would never have entered the equation. Modern reinventions aside, one theme persists across millennia.

"In a manner, having contact with the souls of the dead signifies *being dead oneself*," Eliade commented regarding shamans. Centuries earlier, famed faerie chronicler Robert Kirk might as well have been describing the same thing: "… our Seer is put in a rapture, transport, *and sort of death* [author's emphasis]…."[1576] The numinous state of being that shamanic travels present isn't death *per se*, but it is as close as we are allowed to get—bungee-cording into the Bardo.

- **Sounds.** Altaic shamans penetrate successive layers of the underworld, the second accompanied by "metallic sounds," the fifth by "whistling."[1577] In the beliefs of various people including Northern California's Wintu, spirits announce themselves with whistles.[1578]

- **Sense of peace.** Mayan shamanic testimony indicates their "celestial travels are generally reported as peaceful and joyful, giving information about the future and a sense of unity with nature, the souls of the deceased, and future generations," wrote Walter and Fridman.[1579]

- **Inaccessible knowledge.** Learning the unknowable represents shamanism's entire purpose. Many, including Brazil's Krahó, "learned their extensive knowledge of medicinal plants directly from the plants themselves during drug-induced visions," to say nothing of weather patterns, herd migrations, and deaths.[1580]

- **Levitation/OBE.** The soul's ascent is universal in shamanic practice, evidenced in the adoption of bird wings and traveling to the heavens both in initiations and subsequent journeys.

"Shamanic vocation or initiation is directly connected with an ascent to the sky," wrote Eliade. "A great Basuto prophet received his vocation after an ecstasy during which he saw the roof of his hut open above his head and felt himself carried off to the sky, where he met a multitude of spirits."[1581] Sometimes flight is the primary means of conveying souls to the afterlife.[1582]

The Taoist word for shaman, *xian*, can be translated as "the power to ascend."[1583] Buryat shamans travel to the "Assembly of the Saaytani" in the sky.[1584]

"Among the Araucanians, for example, the illness that determines the career of a machi is followed by an ecstatic crisis during which the future shamaness ascends to the sky and meets God himself," wrote Eliade. North American and Siberian shamans also fly,[1585] as do witches in folklore worldwide.[1586]

Many believe the European motif of airborne witches likely represents the sensation of flight brought about by topical psychoactive substances. Shamans are no different, their trajectories taking them not only into the Otherworld, but across the Earth as well, imparting perfect knowledge of the landscape.[1587] Inuit shamans fly to the moon.[1588]

The sky may be reached by supernatural *tools* rather than wings. Brāhamanic mystics reach heaven by ritually ascending ladders, perhaps an origin for the infamous "Indian Rope Trick" where magicians allegedly ascend a rope tethered in the air. Some Australian aboriginal shamans climb invisible ropes at night to "converse with the star people."[1589] Since Fairy Tales often encode shamanic symbolism, the "Jack & the Beanstalk" story might represent ascent to the Otherworld via "the tree or plant that grows to heaven," another animist motif.[1590]

Shamanism and polypsychism overlap, with separable souls appearing both in human and animal form. Lappish people believe in explicit shamanic doubles.[1591] Older Inuit shamans, *angakut*, extract initiates' souls through their intestines, brain, and eyes, after which they can self-induce OBEs.[1592] Saami shamans appear "in two places at one time."[1593] Saints—essentially Christian shamans—commonly bilocated, as could Greek mystics like Epimenides and the *goēs* Aristeas, who "could send his soul roaming out of his body whenever he wished" in the form of a crow.[1594]

- **Tunnel experience.** Iglulik Inuit shamans visiting sea spirits must first enter a tunnel protected by "a fierce dog," echoing other mythological dogs guarding the dead like Cerberus.[1595] Shamanic OBEs are characterized by "the mental structure of a tunnel, often disguised as the feeling of moving along or through the visionary image of a steep valley, an alleyway, a straight road, and so forth," wrote Paul Devereux. Devereux sees tunnel parallels in one account of a Hungarian witch who described moving "with a speed like the wind's… rushing down the road."[1596]

Though not a tunnel *per se*, Australian shamans of the Forrest River region ascend via rainbows.[1597]

- **Bright light.** Emergence from initiatory katabasis involves stepping out of caves and into the sunlight. Initiations may begin with lightning or "a meteor in the form of a ball of fire" striking candidates.[1598] Some Australian initiates find themselves in "a place of light." Anomalous lights represent faeries or ghosts in some cultures; in others, they are disembodied shamans, witches, or sorcerers. After their soul's extraction, Inuit shamans experience "a mysterious light" throughout their bodies, illuminating all hidden things.[1599]

Even Christian "shamans" are attended by bright light. During an illness the year preceding his death, St. Thomas Aquinas was touched on the head by "a big star" that entered the window before exiting the same way.[1600]

- **Landscapes.** Some shamans reach the Otherworld via symbolic bridges constructed by the tribe. Hellenic travels described as "shamanic" often involved paradisical Otherworlds.[1601] Australian spirits called *Iruntarinia* carry initiates deep within caves, a land of "perpetual light" and "cool springs… the paradise of the Aranda."[1602]

The afterlives to which shamans escort souls often resemble NDE destinations. After one OBE, Shawnee prophet Tenskwatawa portrayed this land as "a rich, fertile country, abounding in game, fish, pleasant hunting grounds and fine corn fields."[1603]

- **Enhanced perception.** According to Eliade, shamans access "ultimate reality." In his proto-shamanic NDE described in Chapter 1, Er, son of Armenius, beheld "the colors of heaven."[1604] The "realer than real," yet dreamlike quality of other contact modalities is evident in Nevill Drury's definition of shamanism: "a type of mythic 'lucid dreaming.'"[1605]

- **Interiors.** In addition to serving as initiatory spaces in our world, the Otherworld also features caves. Samoyed shamans enter "a bright cave, covered with mirrors," lit by "something like a fire" in the center.[1606] Like Fairyland, subterranean shamanic realms are "sometimes characterized by dim light."[1607]

- **Supernatural lapses of time.** The Avam Samoyed shaman described above—who suffered from smallpox for three days —experienced his body boiling in an Otherworld cauldron for three *years*.[1608] "Shamanism abounds in cases of such contraction or extension of time," wrote Waldemar Bogoras. Rituals lasting 15 minutes might take years in shamanic space, or briefly-perceived trances might last days: "he does not feel his absence as long at all."[1609] Because of these discrepancies, animist cultures often view time cyclically.[1610]

- **Love.** Walter and Fridman wrote that "mystic experiences of unity through time and space, and unity with the Divine, are celebrated in the origin stories of many religious traditions."[1611] As our likely *prisca theologia*, the cosmic unity described in NDEs and other ASCs is a thoroughly animist worldview.

Sexuality pervades shamanism. Depictions of male trances often involve erections, possibly spurred by entheogens. This "'ithyphallic' condition is frequently experienced by shamans entering trance, who associate it with the 'boiling' excitation of 'supernatural potency' in the abdomen," Hancock explained.[1612] Phalluses are important symbols in many shamanic rituals.[1613]

Relationships with spirit helpers often take on carnal dimensions, with shamans claiming zoomorphic and anthropomorphic "celestial spouses" worldwide. Recall Bö-Khân's faerie-like spirit lover. Orkney cunning woman Elspeth Reoch confessed in 1616 to sexual congress with a faerie man.[1614] India's Savara shamans have spirit marriages.[1615] Others might have "sex with large numbers of female spirits" before selecting a "wife in the sky."[1616]

"It is natural that the 'celestial wife's' intervention in the shaman's mystical experience should be accompanied by sexual emotion," Eliade wrote. "Every ecstatic experience is subject to such deviations, and the close relations between mystical and carnal love are too well known for the mechanism of this shift in plane to be misunderstood." Like faeries, spirit lovers are jealousy-prone, their infatuation both "helping and hindering" shamans.[1617]

Nanai shamans take small lovers "comparable in many ways to the Norse fylgja and the Celtic faeries," Lecouteux wrote. "They all choose a human for a lover, take over his life, and become his protector genie." One Nanai described seeing "a very beautiful woman, very slim" on his "bed of suffering" who professed her love to him, promising to teach him the secrets of shamanism. She remained with the shaman ever since, visiting him from her "little hut on a mountain." "I lie with her as if she were my real wife, but we have no children," he said.[1618]

Other unions generate human-spirit hybrids, calling to mind faerie and alien offspring conceived with their abductees. These children were occasionally presented to shamans under cover of night, so that no one else might see them. More often they dwelt in the Otherworld. [1619] Through these hybrids, entire shamanic lineages might be established, as in Bö-Khân's case.[1620]

- **Music.** Music not only features prominently in shamanic rituals, but appears in the Otherworld itself. During initiations of British Columbia's Secwépemc shamans, animal spirits approach candidates, bestowing "a certain song with which to summon him up. Therefore every shaman has his own song, which none else is allowed to sing…."[1621]

- **Beings.** The beings shamans encounter in the Otherworld are often a source of their power, and appear consistent with those encountered in NDEs. Many are dead humans.

"Like fairyland, the shaman's underworld is inhabited by both spirits of non-human origin and souls of the dead," wrote Emma Wilby, citing a South American shaman

who met her Guajiro relatives in the underworld. She was forbidden by her spirit helper to engage with them. "The dead look like people here," she said. "They live the way people used to live on earth, and the place we went to in the Beyond is just like here."[1622]

The deceased father of Tinite, a Canadian Tłįchǫ shaman, carried him to heaven "through a hole in the sky," granting him power over the sun, the wind, and the earth.[1623] Other spirits tasked with teaching candidates in the Otherworld might be dead shamans, ancestors, or ghosts.[1624]

UFOs appear in shamanic trances as well. Lakota shaman Wallace Black Elk claimed his spirit helpers could "take you any place. If you want to visit the moon, they'll take you up there. They'll put you in one of those little flying saucers, and they'll zoom you up there in no time. Then, they'll bring you back."[1625]

We also find "flying saucer" pageantry, though it may be purely coincidental. "Metal disk 'mirrors' are another common feature found on a majority of Siberian, as well as Mongolian and Northern Chinese, shaman costumes," explain Walter and Fridman. The disks vary in number and composition. Sometimes spirits reside within these metallic pendants.

"Nganasan shamans when interviewed have described them as variously being there 'to break the ice' when going to the Lower World of the dead, or more simply being there 'for beauty,'" they continued. "In the Goldi culture of the Amur River the mirror is used to see wandering spirits and to hold helpful spirits." Other animist cultures, like Mexico's Rarámuri, conceptualize reality as layers of disks called *namókame*, creating a cosmos resembling "a stack of tortillas" (reality never tasted so good).[1626]

- **Amnesia.** It is not amnesia, but the lack thereof that defines shamans. They *always remember their encounters*; perhaps shamans' true source of power is clear recall, like NDErs, or the Greek figures from Chapter 1 who became seers by retaining memory of the afterlife. Notably, in the Australian example provided by Bullard above, the witness's abilities emerged *only after he remembered the encounter* through meditation nine years later.[1627]

At the same time, some initiations involve "drinks that make the candidate unconscious," and rigorous initiations "are designed to make the candidate forget his past life." Abandonment of the old self is essential to rebirth—"when the novice returns to the village he acts as if he had lost his memory and has to be taught all over again to walk, eat, dress," wrote Eliade.[1628]

- **Healing, new abilities, and spiritual awakenings.** Alongside obtaining inaccessible knowledge, learning these abilities is the primary goal of shamanic practice. Shamans don't believe consciousness persists after death; they *know* it. Candidates learn the same lessons taught at Eleusís, the same values expressed in NDEs, the same truths revealed by ayahuasca. Empowered, they become guides of the tribe, living and dead.

Spirits may possess shamans, resembling post-NDE "walk-ins"—but are never ceded full control, due to their hosts' training. In the modern West, NDErs sometimes adopt shamanic disciplines following their experiences, consistent with Ring's interpretation of NDEs as initiations.[1629]

"Kundalini activation," mentioned in the previous chapter, also occurs after NDEs and signifies spiritual enlightenment in Hinduism. Roughly speaking, yogis with active kundalini energy are shamans, or at least shamanically-inclined.[1630]

Wrote Sivananda Saraswati, "Supersensual visions appear before the mental eye of the aspirant, new worlds with indescribable wonders and charms unfold themselves before the Yogi, planes after planes reveal their existence and grandeur to the practitioner and the Yogi gets divine knowledge, power and bliss, in increasing degrees, when Kundalini passes through Chakra after Chakra, making them to bloom in all their glory."[1631]

Though appropriated by the New Age movement—like all things shamanic—concepts similar to kundalini activation are apparent in "Meso-America, Asia, India, the steppes of Mongolia, to Old Europe, and later the Celtic nations." These often envision kundalini as divine, feminine "serpent power" coiled about the base of the

spine which, when activated, rises along the vertebrae to the top of the head, resulting in consciousness transformation.[1632]

The multicultural symbolism here is elegant and rich. In parts of Benin, snakes are "ancestors incarnate."[1633] Mother Ayahuasca is the feminine enlightening serpent. To Jung, serpents were not only death symbols but mothers as well, protectors of treasure, in this case spiritual awakening, the immortality offered when dying to death.[1634] The traditional kundalini image of serpent-and-spine evokes Hermes's kerykeion, the winged staff around which snakes are entwined.

- **Poltergeist phenomena.** As noted, RSPK and light phenomena often accompany shamanic rituals. "Being struck by lightning might be the closest a traditional shaman gets to experiencing an electric malfunction," wrote Harvey-Wilson in his master's thesis comparing alien abductees to shamans. He also cited a South American shaman who, constructing a magical harpoon, cut a branch which unleashed "a flood of water"—though not discussed in earlier chapters, poltergeist infestations commonly feature liquid oozing from surfaces like walls and ceilings.[1635]

"Haunting cases, shamanic performance, and psi groups illustrate a continuum regarding 'control' of anomalous perceptions," wrote sociology professor James McClenon. "Haunted people have little control; shamans summon spirits and generate effects but do not attempt scientific investigation; psi groups seek both to regulate paranormal events and to determine features conducive to their incidence."[1636]

Rarely do life reviews or ultimatums feature in shamanic narratives, though experienced shamans do possess the choice to stay or leave the Otherworld. Other notable overlaps between shamanic experiences, NDEs, and other encounters include food taboos (shamans are sometimes "forbidden by the spirit who guides them to either speak to the dead or eat their food")[1637] and sensations of shrinking. In some Australian traditions, the

“initiatory master, magically changing himself into a skeleton, reduces the apprentice's stature to that of a newborn infant.”[1638]

I fall to pieces

Shamanic initiates' dismemberment in the Otherworld takes many forms—beatings, surgeries, amputations, decapitations, self-disfigurements, mutilations—but the underlying conceit of disintegration and reconstitution remains consistent worldwide.

Eliade noted the motif throughout northeastern Eurasia. Spirits cut off, then reattach Yurak-Samoyed shamans' hands during ceremonial drumming. One Yakut tradition describes evil spirits who kidnap future shamans for three years, beheading them so candidates may watch as their bodies are sliced "into small pieces, which are then distributed to the spirits of the various diseases… [Their] bones are then covered with new flesh, and in some cases [they are] also given new blood," returning a fully vested healer.[1639]

Another version sees "Bird-of-Prey-Mother" nurture the initiate for three years before a trio of "black 'devils' come and cut his body to pieces, thrust a lance into his head, and throw bits of his flesh in different directions as offerings. Three other 'devils' cut up his jawbone—a piece for each of the diseases that he will be called on to cure."[1640] Eliade continues:

> The same experiences are found elsewhere. A Teleut woman became a shamaness after having a vision in which unknown men cut her body to bits and cooked it in a pot. According to the traditions of the Altaian shamans, the spirits of their ancestors

> eat their flesh, drink their blood, open their bellies, and so on. The Kazak Kirgiz *baqça* says: "I have five spirits in heaven who cut me with forty knives, prick me with forty nails," and so forth.[1641]

In one Australian example, two spirits pursued a Warramunga candidate, revealing they were his dead brother and father before disemboweling him and reinstalling new entrails. Elsewhere on the continent, an aforementioned Iruntarinia grabs a future shaman, then "tears out his internal organs and gives him others, which are completely new."[1642]

An important variation on dismemberment is the sensation of being devoured. Many indigenous North American initiates offer their own flesh for consumption by spirits in animal form; "sometimes the animal that tortures him becomes the future shaman's helping spirit." In the earlier Yakut legend, Bird-of-Prey-Mother might allow the spirits of disease to consume their allotted portion of the shaman.[1643]

Within this variant lies another Campbellian-Jungian archetype: "the belly of the whale," from which the hero continues initiation. Consumed by the monster, the hero emerges from the world-womb reborn.[1644]

These tormenting animal spirits are often psychopomps like wolves, birds, or bees. Ju/'hoansi shamans from southern Africa suffer imaginal bee and insect stings across their bodies, as did one Gitksan shaman in Canada: in the Otherworld, he "saw huge bee-hives, out of which the bees darted and stung me all over my body."[1645]

Eliade noted nearly identical shamanic dismemberments across the New World, Africa, and Indonesia.[1646] There simply exist too many examples to enumerate. The motif even extended into early Christianity, where saints' corpses were physically dismembered, their body parts deified in church reliquaries.[1647]

I fall to pieces:

NDEs, faeries, and psychedelic trips

We find accounts of dismemberment with regularity across other contact modalities. Howard Storm's NDE and harrowing descent into hell in Chapter 1 included entities which rent his flesh, eating him alive.[1648] Another NDE in 1991 featured foul-smelling, "big angry animals or devils" which dug claws into the experiencer's skin, tearing her apart, eating her alive, and ripping her arms off "several times."[1649]

During his surgery-induced clinical death in 1983, another NDEr met short, hooded figures wielding butcher knives who "decided to dismember [him] so each could have a piece." "I heard no one command them," he wrote. "They just stopped and left," entering a nearby cave. "The next thing I knew a nurse was telling me it was time to wake up."[1650]

Full-fledged dismemberment is uncommon among faeries, though their punishments do include torment. A Breton informant told Evans Wentz of a girl who revealed too much about her corrigan friends—the faeries "came into the house, beat her, and dragged her from bed." Welsh faeries might pinch lazy maids in their sleep, leaving them bruised come morning. A southern Aranmore islander whose only transgression was watching a faerie hurling match was left with a facial laceration and, returning later, "got five times as bad a beating"—but "when he woke up in the daylight he was none the worse for his beating, for the fairies had rubbed something on his

face."[1651] (Because Christians conflated faeries with evil spirits, they were also commonly blamed for "demonic" pain and injury.)

Several trip reports from the last chapter featured dismemberment, most dramatically Raoul Adamson's elfin ayahuasca surgery. In another of his sessions, he was devoured by and disassembled within an enormous, serpentine dragon.[1652] In her first ayahuasca journey, Lucy Delics took an elevator to the pinnacle of the cosmos into a hospital filled with "glowing purple" aliens or angels; they surgically "rewired her heart," reassuring her the whole time.[1653]

Other psychedelics produce similar visions, evidenced when one ketamine user found himself in "a realm of flesh and vegetables that was moving like a complex circuit of gears dismembering my body." It felt entirely real, the separation dramatic (his head wound up "kilometers from the left arm, the legs other miles away").[1654]

Initiatory trances among Tungus shamans linked to *Amanita muscaria* consumption are accompanied by sensations of arrow wounds, extracted bones, and flaying.[1655] One psilocybin user underwent "a multitude of dismemberment experiences":

> I was swallowed and then spat out by giant beings. It took a while for me to be reassembled and at first I was given the wrong head back. Evil entities appeared and started laughing and mocking me for having inappropriate body parts. The Mushroom spirits told me that I had to lie still all night, without eating, drinking or talking and that I would only be reassembled in the morning.[1656]

One of Stephen Szára's subjects administered DMT in 1957 reported "a big place" full of "horrible" inhuman creatures whose sole motivation was to inflict pain.[1657] Insectoids feasted on the heart of Rex, one of Strassman's patients, "devouring the feelings of love and surrender."[1658] Another DMT user met comical surgeons which "casually" eviscerated and reassembled him with brand new, "shiny" parts.[1659]

I fall to pieces:

Alien abductions

In the modern era, the anomalous experience most closely associated with dismemberment is alien abduction (covered in further depth in Chapter 12). Abductees regularly describe surgeries, medical procedures, and invasive examinations. Some even feel dissolved "at the molecular level," though most experiences seem more clinical.[1660]

For instance, in August 1975 several airborne, luminous orbs descended towards Sandra Larson *en route* to Bismarck, North Dakota. Hypnosis revealed "a classic UFO abduction" where non-human entities put some type of instrument up her nose and separated her skull. They removed Larson's brain, then replaced it.[1661]

Alien abductees may even be devoured. One recurring experiencer remembered entering "a spaceship" in her youth where she met six beautiful, wispy-haired, alien children. She then realized her visit's purpose: she was on the menu. With "tiny sharp, pointed teeth... they began biting into my arms on either side of me; that's when I bolted... they were allowing me to escape, and if they wished I wouldn't be allowed to go."[1662]

Comparing alien abductions to psychedelic trips, Jeremy Knight wrote:

> Some people recall being torn limb for limb, dissolving away, having parts removed by alien doctors, being healed by elves, foreknowledge of a failing organ, and especially having implants inserted under the skin; usually including devices which make repeated abduction and communication easier. Another person using "acacia spice" reports reptiles implanting a communication device into his body….[1663]

The Ufological meme of "implants" forced into abductees reinvents faerie blasts, spirit darts, and, most congruently, objects installed by spirits during shamans' reassembly. Comparing the two phenomena, Bullard noted "especially striking" details: shamanic "dismemberment may take place in a cave with uniform lighting, two helping spirits may escort the initiate, rock crystals with special powers may be closed into his body, his head or brain may be removed, or his eyes torn out."[1664]

We can rebuild him

Returning to shamanic narratives, disassembled initiates are reborn "improved" following reassembly in the Otherworld. This reconstitution may include "implants" of some sort, especially in Australian traditions, where a variety of objects are inserted to enhance supernatural abilities. Aranda shamans receive *atnongara*, magical quartz fragments, into their bodies, while the Warramunga initiate, echoing kundalini awakening, is given "powers of a medicine man" by "a little snake inside his body."[1665] Elaborates Eliade:

> …parallels for the belief that spirits and initiators introduce rock crystals into the candidate's body are to be found elsewhere—among the Semang of the Malay Peninsula, for example. But it is one of the most striking characteristics of South American shamanism. "The Cóbeno shaman introduces rock crystals into the novice's head; these eat out his brain and his eyes, then take the place of those organs and become his 'strength.'" Elsewhere the rock crystals symbolize the shaman's helping spirits.[1666]

A possible analogue in western Europe might be "witches' marks" (a.k.a. "devil's marks" or "witches' teats"), blemishes allegedly manifesting upon those pledging fealty to the devil following nocturnal rites of initiation. This is admittedly a poor fit, as such marks were external, mostly natural features—

extra nipples, skin tags, moles, warts, etc.—presented as "proof" of guilt during witch trials.[1667]

Dismemberment themes perhaps originate in shared myths of the universe's creation from the scattered remains of an ancient god, giant, or monster. Odin and other Norse deities fashioned reality from the dismembered body of the giant *Ymir*. Pacific Islanders believe Tangaroa, distressed at the void, mutilated himself to fashion Creation.[1668]

One Indonesian origin myth describes how Hainuwele, "Coconut Girl," was buried alive, exhumed, and mutilated. "The buried pieces transformed themselves into things which had not previously existed on earth," Herzog wrote, "Particularly the bulbous fruits which have been the main food of the people ever since."[1669] Life requires death as down payment.

Petroglyphs from France's Pech Merle cave—up to 27,000 years old—depict not only alien figures with "teardrop-shaped heads" and "slanting eyes," but mysterious "wounded men": vaguely therianthropic, with "harsh slashes" bisecting their buttocks, chests, and torsos. A nearby cave in Cougnac shows other "wounded men," one of which is but a torso, legs, and feet.[1670] These may be among the earliest depictions of dismembered shamans.

Many religions encode shamanic dismemberment. Christ is crucified, his side pierced by a spear, before defeating death. A whale swallowed Jonah before his enlightenment, much as Satan devoured St. Margaret in the form of a dragon. Japanese Buddhist monks base their ecstatic journeys on Chiko, a mythical priest escorted by two messengers to the underworld, thrice "dismembered and reconstituted" before returning to earth.[1671] Xblanque, a Mayan psychopomp mentioned in Chapter 2, defeated death with his twin

Huhnapu through surrender, their bodies baked in an oven, their bones pulverized and tossed into the river.[1672]

Shamanic dismemberment also influenced Grecian and Egyptian mythology. Orpheus's attempted rescue of Eurydice from the underworld clearly resembles a failed shamanic soul retrieval.[1673] Metaphorically speaking, Orpheus failed his test of ego-death.

As Harpur notes, "In looking back at his wife Eurydice… Orpheus prematurely reflects ('looks back')—that is, he adopts an ego perspective which is inappropriate to the realm of soul, which separates itself from soul, driving it back and losing it (as Eurydice was lost)."[1674] Less famously, in some versions the hero "is torn to pieces by the Bacchantes, who then scatter his body parts."[1675]

Both Orpheus and Osiris inspired mystery schools like Eleusís.[1676] Egyptians associated Osiris not only with death but fertility and rebirth, evidenced by his green skin. He rules the netherworld, judging the dead.[1677]

In his most prominent myth, Osiris's brother, Seth, kills and dismembers him, scattering his remains across the world. Collecting these pieces, Osiris's wife, Isis, magically resurrects him in mummified form, and their posthumously-conceived, falcon-headed son Horus takes revenge for his father's murder. The god's dismemberment, death, rebirth, and transcendence symbolizes shamanic initiation (recall how dead Egyptians literally *became* Osiris).

One ayahuasca drinker encountered the ancient Egyptian goddess Sekhmet—"of which he had zero prior knowledge"—who bestowed "a death

rite of passage."[1678]

"I became Osiris in his tomb," he wrote in Metzner's collection of ayahuasca essays. "I began to experience dying. I knew that it was my ego dying and that my mind was emptying out, stilling. Soon there were no thoughts left, only consciousness." In becoming Osiris, he beheld "the Great Mystery, which I was now experiencing as a mystical nonboundary between life and death, the simultaneous coexistence of both the presence of death and the force of life."[1679]

Archaic techniques of ecstasy

Initiation marks but the first of many subsequent shamanic journeys, which come in the form of other ASCs—spontaneous visions, dreams, and meditation- or entheogen-induced trances. While few involve dismemberment, other aspects of initiation remain ever-present in later journeys, including supernatural lapses of time, the soul's separation, etc. By "releasing the inner god" and accessing what Ring dubbed "the imaginal world," all pathways open, all secrets are revealed.

"There is a division of opinion on the matter of whether 'narcotic' or, as I call it, 'hallucinogenic' shamanism is decadent or in fact primary," Terence McKenna mused. "Eliade took the position that hallucinogenic shamanism was decadent and Gordon Wasson, very rightly I believe, contravened this view and held that actually it was very probably the presence of the hallucinogenic drug experience in the life of early man that lay the very basis for the idea of the spirit."[1680]

Eliade unwisely confused the easy, efficient travel afforded by entheogens for "an imitation of a state that the shaman is no longer capable of attaining otherwise."[1681] It is an astounding oversight, overlooking the importance of entheogens to many cultures' shamanic experiences.

Psychedelics may cause seizures in some rare individuals, another form of shamanic journeying "interpreted as meetings with the gods." Eliade doubled down on his stance, claiming "the only difference between a shaman and an

epileptic is that the latter cannot deliberately enter into trance.˝ To him, epilepsy was central to shamanism, a rather reductive position.[1682]

This isn't to say that shamanism and epilepsy aren't closely associated. Certain cultures like Polynesia's Niue, Philippines's Subanun, Andaman Islanders, and some Samoans attribute shamanic authority to sufferers of epilepsy, suggesting seizures represent spontaneous Otherworld visits.[1683] In Abrahamic religions, seizures signified possession by demons or djinn.[1684]

Shamanic interpretations of epilepsy as divine intervention may stem from seizure-related catalepsy's "appearance of death," as Eliade phrased. Sufferers returning to consciousness might report apparitions, tunneling vision, and altered time perception, further reinforcing their status as shamans.[1685] Tantalizing clues also lie in dissociation's ability to instigate seizures and the work of Michael Persinger, covered in Chapter 9, who connected supernatural encounters and epilepsy. [1686]

These medical explanations skirt dangerously close to our key-room fallacy. Entertain the idea that *some* epileptic seizures may represent an altered state of consciousness accessing some place objectively *real*.

Anthony Peake examined the life of Myron Conan Dyal, a California artist and lifetime temporal lobe epilepsy experiencer. Dyal's seizures include packs of devouring wolves and visits to "his 'High Place.'" "One of the consistent themes of such experiences is flying on the back of a huge winged creature, usually a bird or a butterfly," Peake wrote. Dyal's seizures are sometimes triggered by sunlight, begging the question of pineal gland involvement. One of the recurring characters in his visions is the psychopomp Charon "in the guise of a tall old man with a white beard, dressed in a white robe."[1687]

In short, while epilepsy may be one vector for shamanic experience, it is far from requisite. In addition to entheogens, shamanic ASCs may also be achieved via ritual music and dancing, which induces "extreme dehydration and hyperventilation," as in trance dances of Africa's San people.[1688]

"After hours of stomping, some dancers start to slip into trance or half-trance," archaeologist David Lewis-Williams described. "In this altered state of consciousness many have out-of-body experiences. They describe traveling to the spirit realm. The shamans push themselves towards an altered state of consciousness; they enter 'half-death.'"[1689] No epilepsy here.

We are reminded of the dancing dead and gamboling faeries. "I repeat my suggestion that [dancing] feels like some sort of technology for jumping between worlds, and in particular for entering and leaving this one," Hancock said when writing about shaman dances.[1690]

Shamanimals

Beyond inducing ASCs, dancing often symbolizes Otherworld travels. The shamanic Yakut dance "represents the journey by dance movements and gestures imitating the flight of a bird," Eliade wrote, adding a quote from Waclaw Sieroszewski: "The dance always depicts a journey through the air in company with spirits... 'The drum is our horse,' the shamans say."[1691]

Here we see the pernicious psychopomp animal imagery and therianthropy alluded to in Chapter 2. Writes Eliade of horses:

> Pre-eminently the funerary animal and psychopomp, the "horse" is employed by the shaman, in various contexts, as a means of achieving ecstasy...
>
> The "horse"—that is, the horse-headed stick—is used by the Buryat shamans in their ecstatic dances... Among the Batak, in the course of the horse sacrifice in honor of the ancestors, four dancers dance on sticks carved in the shape of horses. In Java and Bali the horse is likewise associated with the ecstatic dance. Among the Garo the "horse" [effigy] forms part of the harvest ritual.[1692]

Dancing shamans may become eagles, jaguars, bears, wolves, elk, or other animals depending on the region.[1693] Shapeshifted shamans not only guide and retrieve souls in the Otherworld, but also reconnoiter in our realm.

Just as wise hunters behave, camouflage, or think like their quarry, "so the shaman may undertake a soul flight in order to locate game animals," wrote Vitebsky. "But the shaman may also go further and experience turning into an animal," living among them and "using this knowledge to encourage members of the species to give themselves up to the community's hunters, or to become the shaman's own spirit helper."[1694]

Lycanthropy—shapeshifting into canine form—appears worldwide. "Shamans, too, can turn themselves into wolves," Eliade wrote.[1695] European lycanthropy was inseparable from the quasi-shamanic discipline of witchcraft, often attained through topical psychoactive salves and animal skins (see Chapter 18 for more on werewolves).[1696] South American and African shamans or magicians practiced *gatanthropy*, shapeshifting into jaguars[1697] and leopards, respectively.[1698]

Other transformations were therianthropic in the more traditional sense, i.e. half-human half-animal amalgamations. Zoomorphic shamans in petroglyphs repeatedly display beaks, wings, claws, or other attributes. Features even appear mixed-and-matched, as in the "Sorcerer" art from France's Trois Freres cave: a human man with wolf's ears, owl's eyes, stag's antlers, horse's tail, and lion's claws.[1699] Ritual headdresses with feathers or horns may signify shamans' theriocephalic aspect.[1700]

Though mentioned throughout this book, the importance of birds in shamanism must be stressed once more. They are, bar none, the most common shamanic animal, inspired by disembodied flights of freedom. South American shamans are depicted with macaws' heads.[1701] Completely

unrelated—surely!—are avicephalic depictions of South Asian yoginis,[1702] or Australian beliefs where shamans transform into enormous birds.[1703]

The "ability to turn into a bird is the common property of all kinds of shamanism, not only the Turko-Mongol but also the Arctic, American, Indian, and Oceanian," Eliade emphasized.[1704]

Given shamanism's robust history in Eurasia, it is unsurprising the compassion with which Russian authorities handled witchcraft compared to their European and American counterparts. Explaining why the Soviet intelligence apparatus so readily incorporated psi phenomena, healer Eugene Kolessov told Ufologist Jacques Vallee in the 1990s: "When it was at the apex of its power the Western church killed over three million witches in the name of God... Many of those who died at the hands of your priests were young women who had not produced offspring. We have done many bad things in Russia, but we have never hunted down witches on such a scale. Our gene pool is still rich in psychic ability."[1705]

The shamanic impulse is ancient, primal, and universal. Yet, deprived of a framework by Materialism, modern Westerners have no idea how to react when the spirits come calling. Terrified, we cram them into preexisting cultural boxes: demonic possession, hauntings, faerie contact… alien abductions. What we perceive as trespassing in the ecology of souls may in fact be an invitation. The Otherworld, filled with our dead, seeks communion with us through diplomats straddling realities.

"The people who have these experiences are, many times rather unwillingly, being dragged into a shamanic apprenticeship," said author Joe Lewels, discussing alien abductions with Mike Clelland. "The people having

these experiences are being taught how to heal, their consciousness is being elevated, they are being given opportunities to help people... *We need shamans, and if society doesn't provide it, the universe will.*"[1706]

8

MOUNTAINS & MONUMENTS

OBJ



Shafts of morning sunlight probe a barricade of leaves shielding Georgia's Etowah River, furtively slipping past fissures in the canopy to kindle the air below. Mist, a child of liminality herself born of heat and cold, begins burning off in a slow, amber death above the water. Further up the bank, cobalt coils claw the land, lacing fingers through the grass.

Wispy kisses leave droplets clinging to the blades. The fog continues until its advance is arrested by degrees—not rising temperature, as down on the river, but a drastic incline. Unable to ascend, an ethereal ring coils, serpentine, around the base of a prehistoric, 63-foot-tall, three acre platform mound, emerging above the river like Avalon in Dixie.

One easily imagines the shiver felt by superstitious 19th century Irish settlers seeing what must surely be, to their eyes, a faerie mound in southeastern America. This largest structure, the Temple Mound, enjoys the company of five lesser siblings at the Etowah complex, but their family extends throughout the world, mirroring humanity's diaspora. Mankind has always altered our environment more dramatically than any other species, and the vast amount of monuments accompanying civilization—artificial hills and tumuli, human and animal effigies, menhirs and megaliths, temple and burial mounds, ringforts and hillforts, cairns and passage tombs—testify to this desire.

Lumping these structures together is problematic, as they served widely disparate purposes, taking numerous forms across equally divergent cultures. Some were erected for habitation, others rituals; some constructed from stone, others earth. Many, however, were sepulchral, and practically all find association today with paranormal phenomena.

"As formerly in their huts, so now in their graves, the dead would be regarded as the occupiers" of burial mounds, wrote Edwin Sydney Hartland in *The Science of Fairy Tales.* "Their spirits were still living… haunting the spot."

As a general rule, we find the richest faerie lore among populations living near such landmarks, especially where their original builders' identity is lost to indigenous memory. That these monuments were built by humans—instead of spirits—is not open for debate; but, as evidenced in previous chapters, such distinctions blur easily in the ecology of souls. Any attribution

to faeries, giants, etc. may well metaphorically signify monument builders' status as the dead.

Many esotericists, seizing upon this ambiguity, speculate a common origin for monuments throughout the world. Describing this lost civilization, some invoke Atlantis, or the lost continent of Lemuria; through an etymological coincidence connecting the latter to Madagascar, and by extension its lemur population, we find a link to the dead. The primates were named after Roman lemurs, a species of ghost. Maybe "Lemurians" *did* build these monuments, in a sense.

(As an aside, another tenuous connection are the "lemur-like creatures [i.e. the living dead]" seen by UFO abductee Beatty Andreasson in "the 'Green Realm,' a sunless land or island of fog and mist.")[1707]

While some of the evidence that proponents of this theory present is compelling—excavations of New World sites allegedly retrieve Old World artifacts and materiel—this possibility falls outside the focus of our discussion, to say nothing of its inherently racist quagmire.

Whether or not these sites share an origin, they suggest *universal human beliefs* in an Otherworld, either in their original purpose or their concomitant superstitions.

“At the mountains of madness”:

Cosmic mountains and axis mundi

To appreciate the international proliferation of *tumuli*—Latin for artificial “mounds” or “small hills” of earth or stone—we must first understand the *axis mundi*. Popularized in the 1950s by Eliade, the concept describes the central access point between earth and higher or lower realms.[1708]

Axis mundi analogues in comparative mythology include the ropes, ladders, and plants of shamanic ascension.[1709] Scholars like Lecouteux even see the emphasis placed upon chimneys and hearths in folklore as an extension of the axis mundi motif—we may perceive additional symbolism in the nesting of storks, legendary bringers of souls, atop chimneys.[1710] The concept of axis mundi naturally extends to “World Pillars,” “World Trees,” and “Cosmic Mountains.”

Cosmic Mountains are embedded in Mesopotamian, Asian, and European mythologies.[1711] The Greek pantheon surveys creation from Mount Olympus, Indra liberated the earth-mound from Varuna, Benin’s Batammariba deity Kuiye fashioned the earth from a sacred stone mound. To Egyptians, “the mound of earth at the beginning of creation opens the Uat, the waters. The land of the waters is the Ta-Uat, or Tuat. The land in the waters is the island in the sky, the mound in the sky, the mountain in the sky, the topmost part of the sky….”[1712]

This veneration inspired mythical and religious "Holy Mountains," often *axes mundi* themselves. Tibet's Mount Kailash houses Shiva and Parvati, sanctifying it in Buddhist, Hindu, Jainist, and Bon practice.[1713] Some Native American tribes consider *all* mountains holy.[1714] Such summits also house psychopomps: inscriptions indicate Anubis as "He who is upon his sacred mountain,"[1715] and "Yama's gate to the underworld is also on lofty mountains with watercourses."[1716]

Accordingly, mountains offer revelation. Yahweh dispatched the Ten Commandments to Moses atop Mount Sinai, just as shamanic initiates might climb mountains to obtain divine wisdom. In some Native American practices, "the tribal power mountain was always the first stop in a shamanic dream."[1717]

A 10th century Japanese ascetic bemoaned how "no sooner did the word go round that someone had climbed a mountain, than he or she was besieged by people wanting a cure," wrote Walter and Fridman. "Such traveling to holy mountains may not merely parallel, but may even replace, shamanic flights of the soul through the cosmos, particularly among contemporary practitioners."[1718]

Even when not sacred, mountains house portals to the Otherworld, their slopes infested with monsters, spirits, and lesser deities.[1719] Lonely peaks host solitary trolls in Norse folklore, elsewhere dragons, wild men, and other beasties… or the dead.[1720]

According to Caciola, medieval thought often "portrayed the dead as feasting, dancing, or simply living their (after)lives underneath mountains, conducting themselves in much the same way that the living did atop the

surface of the earth."[1721] Icelandic epics describe the dead continuing "second lives" on and within hills and mountains, which resemble burial mounds and medieval longhouses, respectively.[1722] According to Rudolf Simek, Swedish belief in mountains as repositories of the dead called *Vallhall* inspired the Norse afterlife (the *hǫll* of "Valhalla" signifying not a "hall," but perhaps derived from *hallr*, or "rock").[1723] Mythical mountains housing the pagan dead were widespread—even in the New World[1724]—and were easily reinvented as Christianity's hell.[1725]

Afterlife mountains span west to east, north to south. Slavs must climb a mountain to reach their afterlife; the Russian death euphemism *otpravit'sa na gorku* means "go to the hill."[1726] Ancient and medieval Japanese often disposed of corpses on summits, sometimes calling graves *yama* ("mountain").[1727] Following Buddhism's introduction from India, western Chinese mountains became "netherworld realms," particularly Mount T'ai, a sort of "'administrational' center of the dead, where souls were judged."[1728] The Sumerian word *kur* signifies both "mountains" and "netherworld."[1729] In Africa, Meru ancestors (*Nkoma*) shelter in forests along Kenya's ridges and hilltops,[1730] and Kalahari spirits shelter within hills.[1731] Mayan mountains also contain ancestral spirits.[1732]

Even smaller landmarks find veneration. Some Indians leave offerings at termite mounds associated with gods and goddesses who are "born of the anthill," the mounds and deities equivalent. These structures might house magical rainbow serpents[1733] or souls belonging to decaying bodies over which the insects built their homes.[1734]

The 14th century Welsh *Red Book of Hergest* contains a reference to "ghosts of the mountain who, just like fairies that live in the mountains, steal away men's reason when they *strike* them—in death which may appear natural, as in sickness, or in accident," wrote Evans Wentz. These ghosts also kidnapped individuals post-mortem.[1735]

Influenced by legends of the dead dwelling within hills and mountains, faeries became associated with natural summits. Knockfennel, rising above County Limerick's Lough Gur, and Scotland's Schiehallion and Doon Hill are examples of countless hollow fairy homes throughout Ireland and the British Isles.[1736] In the Herla legend, the hero meets the "huge-headed" dwarf king within a mountain,[1737] a figure resembling King Laurin, who rules dwarfs inside the Dolomites' Rosengarten massif in northern Italy.[1738] Even in America, faeries such as the nûñnë'hï live in and around landmarks like Georgia's Blood Mountain.[1739] So strong is this connection that the Irish faerie euphemism *aos sídhe*, "people of the mounds," is sometimes simply abbreviated to "sídhe," interchangeably meaning "faerie host of the Otherworld" or "Otherworld hill or mound."[1740]

Fae folk, the afterlife, and hills come together at Glastonbury Tor, regarded as an entrance to the land of the dead. It is also equated with the Arthurian Otherworld Avalon, and home to psychopomp faerie king Gwyn ap Nudd. In one famous legend, St. Collen ascended the Tor to parley with Gwyn, who offered a sumptuous banquet; Collen instead doused the scene in holy water, revealing an empty summit.[1741]

Today, the hill is still ascribed mystical powers, readily adapting to folklore of the modern era: it is now a UFO hotspot. From 2006-2011, police received

27 calls about unexplained aerial phenomena and suspected alien abductions in the area.[1742]

UFOs have displayed an alpine affinity since their first modern sighting, when Kenneth Arnold spotted nine craft skipping like "flying saucers" above the Cascade Range on June 24, 1947.[1743] Mountains make excellent sites for skywatching, attracting both ghost lights and structured craft in America, from North Carolina's infamous "Brown Mountain lights" to the extensive UFO history surrounding California's Mount Shasta, itself sacred to tribes like the Modoc.[1744]

The association is global. Alice Springs, just over 200 miles from the sacred sandstone rock formation Uluru—practically next door by Australian standards—sees regular UFO activity. UFO researcher Keith Douglass collected a 1998 account above the landmark from two astronomers who noted "a moving star" which abruptly sped into the southwest.[1745] In South Africa in 1978, two couples watched small, bright lights flit above a peak before exploding in a "sparkler" effect across the mountainside.[1746] On the Isle of Man, dogs and horses avoid a mountain cave called "The Devil's Den," infamous for ghastly sounds and peculiar aerial phenomenon: a pair of fiery globes, supposedly a dragon's eyes, were once seen diving into the cavern.[1747]

Persistent rumors of "extraterrestrial bases" within mountains clearly repurpose myths and legends surrounding the dead and faeries. Most notorious is the purported base inside Dulce, New Mexico's Archuleta Mesa, jointly operated by humans and Grey aliens—but believers claim dozens of others exist within peaks from Alaska (Mount Hayes), Australia (Mount Zeil),

Spain (Monte Perdido), and Zimbabwe (Mount Nyangani).[1748] In 2020, Scott C. Waring obtained video of "an alien spacecraft" entering Oregon's Mount Hood, explaining that "high mountains and volcanos are being used as entrances to underground alien bases, because the peaks of such places are rarely visited by humans."[1749]

These "bases" are best understood mythologically and shamanically. Jack Weiner (whose most famous encounter was the Allagash abduction mentioned in Chapter 11) described a 1995 UFO abduction beginning with an OBE which allowed him to rapidly soar over the landscape towards a dark fissure "within the shoulder of a gigantic mountain." Entering it, he met faceless, hooded figures in "a vast, intricately inlaid, stone courtyard"—depending on your perspective, an alien base, the Otherworld, or the DMT realm.[1750]

“Star-mounded graves”:

Monuments as axes mundi

Because indigenous populations so rarely believe mountains are “just” mountains, tumuli can be viewed as appropriated “divine technology,” attempts by mankind to reach the heavens. This drive manifests not only in the Biblical Tower of Babel story, but in cultures around the world which erected temples ever-higher. Summits were natural worship centers long before temples sprouted upon sites like Rome’s Capitoline Hill, dedicated to Jupiter, or the cairn of Queen Maeve’s grave appeared upon County Sligo’s Knocknarea. Christians—quick to syncretize pagan beliefs—adopted such locations for their own worship, like the Great Pyramid of Cholula, an overgrown, 2,000 year-old Aztec monument mistaken for a hill, surmounted by a church in 1594.[1751]

Sir Leonard Woolley, excavator of the Ziggurat of Ur, speculated Sumerians, finding themselves in a flat land, naturally sought closer proximity to the divine by erecting “a ziggurat whose name might be called ‘The Hill of Heaven’ or ‘The Mountain of God.’”[1752] Even modest structures raise worshippers closer to gods, to say nothing of temples or artificial mountains, which serve ritual functions across cultures on every inhabited continent. The international distribution of pyramids among unrelated cultures seems at least equally attributable to this “Cosmic Mountain” impulse as any extinct worldwide civilization.

Both artificial hills *and* caves, the tombs found within tumuli allow the dead to literally dwell within sepulchral mountains. These appear practically everywhere as burial mounds, *kurgans*, passage tombs, barrows, and even simple cairns. Larger tumuli may hold individuals of higher status with grave goods, while some purely symbolic structures, like Buddhist *stupas*, do not contain the dead. Others were sites of reverence or shamanic practice. Mausolea, derived of Greek, Persian, and Islamic construction, are variations on burial mounds, containing space for rituals and offerings.[1753]

Our broad "monument" category encompasses more modest structures which, while not stretching towards the heavens, enjoy similar reverence thanks to their age and oft-mysterious creators. These include ruins of human habitation, fortifications, and megaliths (immense menhirs, dolmen tombs, and stone circles). Many still embody the axis mundi. While not unanimously—plenty of stone circles, for instance, feature smaller rocks—megaliths resemble World Pillars, especially taller, vertically-oriented examples analogous to obelisks or church steeples. Similarly, many monuments in northwestern Europe are described as "hillforts" because of their elevation (while this presents clear strategic advantages, the connection nonetheless exists). We return to these "non-tumuli" monuments momentarily.

“A frightful gateway into forbidden spheres of dream”:

Window areas

Wiltshire boasts England’s most famous Neolithic monuments including Stonehenge, Avebury, and Silbury Hill, Europe’s largest prehistoric tumulus. Composed of chalk and clay, stretching 131 feet into the air, its purpose remains unknown. West Kennet Long Barrow is but a half-mile away, and other ancient burials are suspected in the immediate vicinity. Recent excavations have revealed sarsen stones within Silbury, rocks “potentially representing the spirits of dead ancestors,” leading archaeologists to suspect the tumulus was “built as a sort of spiritual tomb, filled with spirits rather than skeletons.”[1754]

Like Glastonbury Tor, Silbury Hill has its share of crop circles and UFO sightings, including a dramatic encounter from July 30, 1994. After midnight, five witnesses on the summit watched a dense fog engulf the fields, accompanied by dark, childlike shapes and the sound of footsteps ascending the hill. A distant, airborne orange orb drew the visitors’ attention, joined shortly by a second object.[1755]

The odor of burning rubber filled the air as both objects approached, revealing “tetrahedrons” beneath each. Inside both, “either kneeling or sitting cross-legged,” sat small figures, hands folded in their laps. The objects came within 15 feet, soaring above the summit and inducing an OBE in at

least one witness, who felt her consciousness "somewhere behind and to the side." All the while, another group atop the hill appeared artificially asleep.[1756]

A crescendo of crackling electricity and disembodied whispers culminated in a silent flash. Both objects withdrew to the hill's base, releasing their occupants, who floated in midair briefly before returning to their orbs. Beyond, several identical objects manifested, parading down the road. When one witness finally spoke, the distant lights condensed into a single, small, white orb, dipping into the roadside hedgerow. From Silbury's opposite slope, the witnesses then watched a string of "fairy lights" until the ambient sound of wind and birds returned. The entire enterprise—less than 15 minutes, surely—left them with two hours of missing time.[1757]

John Keel popularized the term "window areas" in 1970 to describe locations of high paranormal activity, from cryptids to UFOs and hauntings. In *Operation Trojan Horse*, he claimed each U.S. state supported "two to ten 'windows,'" with UFOs gathering "above the highest available hills" within each's roughly 200-mile diameter.[1758] Keel later noted these window areas typically centered around Native American archaeological sites, particularly ancient mounds.[1759]

The most striking window area is Mason County, West Virginia, home of both the 1966-1967 Mothman flap (a series of successive sightings; see Chapter 18) and numerous tumuli, including McCullough Mound, once standing 20 feet high.[1760] Elsewhere in America, upstate New York—UFO hotbed, Bigfoot habitat, birthplace of American Spiritualism, site of Whitley Strieber's *Communion* contacts, setting for Washington Irving's fictional paranormal adventures—is scattered with more modest burial mounds.[1761]

Window areas appear in the United Kingdom at places like Cannock Chase and Rendlesham Forest. Staffordshire's Chase is a paranormal playground boasting both a 5,000-grave German military cemetery *and* an Iron Age hillfort, while Rendlesham is home to a famous, if controversial, 1980 UFO sighting. Devil dogs, a faceless lady ghost, and an aquatic medieval wild man have all been reported in and around Rendlesham's six square-miles of woodland;[1762] just under five miles away lie the famous Sutton Hoo burial mounds, themselves haunted by Anglo-Saxon soldiers.[1763] Coincidence?

The window area concept predates Hollywood's "Indian burial ground" trope, which first appeared in 1979's *The Amityville Horror* (the cliché appeared much earlier in poetry: Philip Freneau's 1787 "The Indian Burying Ground" warned of restless native spirits around "the swelling turf.") If not representative of reality, window areas at least left an enduring and problematic mark on popular culture, obliquely vilifying indigenous spirituality.

There are further problems with Keel's hypothesis. The idea that monuments serve as "cosmic attractors" for the paranormal overlooks the existence of window areas lacking significant sites. Some sepulchral places seem supernaturally *inactive*.

Moreover, cemeteries exist in any inhabited region. 200 miles is a wide perimeter, particularly east of the Mississippi and in the U.K., where burial mounds form "daisy chains" coincidentally overlapping with heavily populated areas… areas whose population density alone engenders more paranormal encounters.

The window area concept also ignores how any land, especially post-colonial nations, *especially* the New World, is bathed in blood and pockmarked by graves. Calling America a "haunted house," occult author Peter Levenda wrote: "… this land of ours is haunted by the ghosts of races who lived and died on our land thousands of years before we came, and of races we ourselves exterminated with fire and sword and virus…."[1764]

"America itself is a housing development," he added, "built over a series of 'Indian' burial mounds, a development erected largely with the aid of African slaves, so it should come as no surprise when our children become deranged, violent, and possessed."[1765]

“A great mound of tumbled blocks”:

Monuments and window areas worldwide

Caveats aside, exploring the connection between ancient monuments and paranormal phenomena presents some utility. Northwestern European and U.S. window areas are addressed shortly; we first look at supernatural sightings and faerie associations around monuments elsewhere.

Sightings collected by Ufologist Keith Basterfield around Adelaide[1766] suggest nearby Gillman Mound (dated 850-1350 AD) might generate a South Australian window area.[1767] The Burragorang Valley, New South Wales, is another UFO hotspot.[1768] Roughly ten miles away, near Vanderville, the estate of one W.G. Hayes once contained a small complex of aboriginal graves.[1769]

In New Zealand, faerie-like wild men known to the Māori as *maeroero* played among hills (*puke-maeroero*), megaliths, and stone circles.[1770] H. Beattie wrote in 1918 of a farm near Owaka where “some stones stand up and the Maeroero used to come at night and sit on top of those stones….”[1771] Three young women camping by “a Māori burial mound” in the Waimata Valley heard strange noises, saw odd figures, and noted two hours of missing time early the morning of March 11, 1978. Hypnotic regression recalled an ascent along a shaft of light to a glowing disc, where they met silver-clad humanoids who communicated telepathically.[1772]

Across the Pacific to the north, Fiji's veli—hill-dwelling, ancestral elves—call "legendary earthworks" their property. "Pride of place was taken by a mound, about 2 metres high, surrounded by a shallow ditch or moat, which was presented as the installation mound of the veli chief," wrote anthropologist Allen Abramson.[1773]

Locating African window areas is rife with problems. Ufologists have long bemoaned the difficulty in procuring accounts from Africa and Asia, despite the best efforts of late South African researcher Cynthia Hind. Africans' general acceptance of magic and paranormal activity further confounds the issue, as fantastic events are simply not considered as anomalous as in narrow-minded Western thought. Nonetheless, comparing a map of the Maghreb's robust system of tumuli and necropolises shows some rough overlap with mid-20th century UFO sightings in Algeria, Morocco, and Tunisia.[1774] More rewarding are comparisons between European faerie lore and Madagascar's vazimba, mentioned in Chapter 4, whose tombs are worshipped during droughts and famines.[1775]

These themes continue into Asia, where a dwarf race supposedly erected megaliths throughout northern India.[1776] Traveling northeast, koropokkuru, also discussed in Chapter 4, supposedly built ancient structures in upper Japan.[1777] Stone circles and other megaliths are found throughout the island nation's interior, some of which, like Hokkaido's Oshoro stone circle, satisfy many of the requirements seen in western Europe and the Americas: astronomically-aligned megalithic sites which host burials, serving shamans as rumored portals to the Otherworld.[1778] Some Japanese burial mounds are the haunts of *yokai*, innumerable supernatural beings sharing many attributes with faeries. For example, the winged dog yokai known as *Hainu*

draw their name from a Fukuoka tumuli,[1779] and Kofun burial mounds are patrolled by goblin-like *kanazuchibō*.[1780]

In 1983, soldiers keeping watch overnight saw a sourceless, "cylindrical beam of soft pale white light" illuminating a hillside near the Korean Demilitarized Zone. Approaching, three more beams manifested before the entire area lit up in a flash. At dawn, the "soldiers went down to check the terrain the beams had hit. They found numerous burial mounds in that vicinity… undisturbed, being older graves, nicely grassed over," wrote MUFON investigator Tom Sheets.[1781]

Given their similarities to western European faeries, it is unsurprising that djinn "prefer isolated places, and in the Middle East live in deserts and abandoned places"[1782] like ruins[1783] or even cairns called *rudjm*.[1784] If our "monument" definition includes pyramids, we find no shortage of mysticism and UFO sightings throughout Egypt and around other ancient Middle Eastern monuments.

While accounts of paranormal phenomena around Göbekli Tepe are not readily available, the country is dotted with other archaeological sites. Turkish Ufologist Haktan Akdoğan considers his country "one of the top five UFO hotspots in the world" (of course, *every* Ufologist considers their area a hotspot).[1785]

Farther southeast in Afghanistan appear numerous tumuli like Tillya Tepe, circular forts like Yemshi Tepe, and even Buddhist stupas.[1786] Most dramatic are encounters from "Observation Post Rock" in Helmand Province. According to locals, the area—nexus of failed British, Soviet, and American excursions—is cursed. After military ordinance collapsed its tunnels in the 2000s, the 30

foot tall mound revealed itself as an ancient single-chambered passage tomb or fort. As U.S. armed forces came and went, bones—"centuries old"—kept surfacing. Further investigation revealed more recent burials, reminders of its use as an execution site during the Soviet-Afghan War. According to village folklore, the Soviet advance towards the nearby Amir Agha shrine had been miraculously halted near "the Rock" by mud, faulty ordinance, and a sinkhole where "several tanks went into the earth and disappeared"—but their occupants yet linger. From the October 31, 2020 *New York Times*:

> "It is a conduit" for paranormal activity, said Jose Herrera, then a lance corporal and one of the Marines that had spent time at the Rock in 2009. When he was there, Mr. Herrera said he saw mysterious lights, heard strange static on the radio and had the creeping feeling, much like several Marines who had spent time there, that someone, or something, was watching them.[1787]

Other phenomena include odors of decay and disembodied Russian whispers. "The area is full of dead bodies and haunted," a local warned.[1788]

Russia and former Eastern Bloc states have anomalies of their own. An archaeology student in August 1960 noticed a peculiar silence while investigating tumuli in Belarus. Her attention shifted to a ten-foot sphere—metallic, green, radiating heat waves—sitting amidst the burial mounds. The object's surface split, revealing a tall, helmeted humanoid in a loose coverall. It floated just above the grass before noticing the witness, who fled.[1789]

In 1979, children playing at a Romanian site named *Cripta Grofului* ("Count's Crypt") spotted two lights falling to earth near a tumulus. Approaching, they spied a pair of tiny humanoids in white suits standing alongside two three-foot-long craft, to which they retreated upon noticing the children. The objects departed. Additional witnesses noticed the lights, and soil depressions were discovered on the mound.[1790]

In August 1990, a camper near a dolmen on Karelia's Valaam island encountered a broad-nosed, goggle-eyed "little man" wearing trousers, a brown cap, and a jacket. He offered garbled responses to the witness's questions before "vanishing in plain sight."[1791]

Fourteen years later, researchers overnighting in November at Ukraine's Kamyana Mohyla—a Paleolithic burial mound perforated by chambers and tunnels—experienced something miraculous. They were allegedly surrounded by orbs and strange blue light, culminating in a meeting between the primary witness, Ufologist Yuriy Moskalyev, and six, tall, glowing humanoids. They telepathically communicated messages of peace and unity, leaving Moskalyev with residual RSPK.[1792]

Despite the less-common occurrence of famous burial mounds in Latin America, the entire region serves as one big window area for UFOs, ghosts, and cryptids; its populace, like Africa, largely remains open to supernatural phenomena. Latin America's ancient ruins enjoy a mysticism rivalling Egypt's pyramids, bolstered by decades of Western speculation that extraterrestrials built such sites.

While "ancient alien" theorists' logic is typically specious—misinterpreting artwork as depictions of alien technology, or citing engineering feats which,

while advanced, fall within the scope of human achievement—some monuments are attended by supernatural phenomena. In 2016, crowds beheld a silent, ghostlike orb above Pucyura, near Peru's Machu Picchu.[1793]

Native informants speak of "Sky People" occasionally visiting Mexican sites like Palenque and Chichén Itzá, recorded in the work of indigenous UFO folklorist Ardy Sixkiller Clarke. Two witnesses speaking with Clarke claimed that, while swimming in Chichén Itzá's Cenote Ik Kil, they watched an airborne craft blot out the sky, turning night to day as a smaller shape separated and gathered water.[1794] Other monuments are guarded by alux, faeries who ensure "visitors to the Maya mounds and archaeological sites do not desecrate them or steal any artifacts."[1795]

Among South America's most famous tumuli are *Cerritos de Indios*, over 3,000 burial mounds skirting the Uruguay-Brazil border near Rocha. The city itself has hosted multiple UFO sightings through the years. On August 9, 1964, hundreds of witnesses saw a bright light dancing above Rocha,[1796] and in 2006 an English professor claimed to have seen two Grey aliens looking through an open window into her Cabo Polonio home.[1797] A more recent encounter occurred in April 2013, when a large, glowing, aerial orb was caught on video.[1798]

Neighboring Brazil presents a rich history of both UFO sightings and alien abductions. A possible window area exists around Pinhal da Serra, Rio Grande do Sul, which features "a highly structured landscape" of the Jê people. The site was built "around funerary/ceremonial structures that began around AD 1000," including burial mounds.[1799]

127 miles away—within Keel's window area parameters—a retired policeman in Pinhal was compelled to an evening walk in November 1961, during which he came upon a landed, glowing disc. Two beings in headgear resembling football helmets approached him, leaving him with two hours of missing time, "his personality changed from stable to nervous and depressed."[1800] 126 miles away, a man in Montenegro reported a glowing object on June 3, 1985, inside which he could make out several humanoids.[1801]

“Nighted burial-place of the aeons”:

Burial mounds of northwestern Europe

Monuments of all shapes and sizes litter western Europe from Malta’s Ġgantija “giantess” complex to northern Iceland’s burial mounds, from Germany’s *Hügelgräber* to Portugal’s Anta do Silval dolmen. Their attendant myths and legends attest to Otherworldly engagement.

Faeries and deities inhabit megaliths everywhere. Giants built tombs in Malta housing the human dead and hosting rituals. Breton faeries dance and black dogs stalk through the burial mounds, tombs, and 3,000 standing stones of Carnac; further inland, faeries are credited with erecting the *Roche-aux-Fées* dolmen, “the Faeries’ Rock.” Another dolmen in Sønderholm, Denmark, 6,000 years old, is named *Troldkirken*—“the Trolls’ Church.”[1802]

These monuments often coincide with modern window areas. The infamous Wallonia 1989-1990 black triangle UFO wave (or “flap”) occurred over a region featuring Belgium’s best-preserved burial mound, the Glimes Tumulus.[1803]

Let us elaborate upon the faerie-burial site connections introduced in Chapter 4. The strongest continuity of faerie belief surrounding these sites arguably lies among Scandinavian and Celtic populations in northwestern Europe, where superstitions stubbornly endure into the modern era. In Scandinavia, fae folk like trolls and elves predominantly dwell within

sepulchral sites. Celtic faeries are linked to both these *and* the ruins of various human settlements, discussed shortly.

Today, Icelanders respect, if not outright believe in, huldufólk—a 2007 study determined 62% of the population is at least open to the possibility of the elves' existence.[1804] Belief is equally resilient in Ireland: as a twentysomething encountered in a Dublin pub quipped circa 2017, "'Course I don't believe in faeries… but I'm scared of 'em," confessing he couldn't be *paid* to overnight on a faerie hill or within a faerie fort.[1805]

"The conflation of hills, burial mounds, and fairy dwellings, although in many ways complex, is easily understandable in terms of power," wrote Richard P. Taylor. "The monolithic cairns and barrows of Europe" often held "great warriors, kings, and spiritual leaders who were to remain in human memory for many years." From the moment they were lain to rest, these sites were held as loci of political and spiritual power. "This power took on supernatural dimensions, and many magical beings came to be associated with such mounds and even certain natural hills."[1806]

A shining example of this conflation is Iceland's Hjörleifshöfði, a promontory surmounted by *Hjörleifshaugur,* resting place of Viking settler Hjörleifur Hróðmarsson, buried in 875 AD.[1807] Local folklorist Regína Hrönn Ragnarsdóttir translated at least two huldufólk sightings from Hjörleifshöfði, one involving a woman who emerged from the crags to empty a trough before "disappearing into what seemed like a door in the rock," another where the witness, blinded by a blizzard, found his way home by a light from the promontory attributed to elfin intervention.[1808]

Associations between Little People and cairns—often grave markers—manifest along Norway's coast, where indigenous Saami avoid "stones and the stone piles" along trails which house *hulder*.[1809] The howe of minor Norwegian king Olaf Geirstad-Alf, felled by plague, became a sacrificial site venerating "the Elf of Geirstad."[1810]

Pagan burial sites in England invited similar superstitions, encouraged by Christian conflation of heathenry with supernatural evil. In Dorset, faeries appear upon "great heapes of earth"—the barrows near Beaminster, or other faerie barrows around Abbotsbury, Bere Regis, Ryme Intrinseca, Cann, and Portesham. In the modern era, Reverend A.R.T. Bruce rested upon a barrow at Bottlebrush Down, only to meet "a crowd of little people in leather jerkins, who came and danced round him."[1811]

Yorkshire residents, hearing conversations emanating from within, believed faeries erected Pudding Pye Hill; an 1855 excavation revealed it as a burial mound.[1812] Scots rechristened Bronze Age burial cairns like the one on the northwestern slope of the Hill of Airthrey as "faerie knowes."[1813] In the north, Orkney Islanders supplicated *hogboon* faeries with milk poured on burial mounds.[1814]

Irish faeries' affinity for burial mounds cannot be overstated, attributed to the intervention of Manannán mac Lir. "In the Mythological cycle… it is Manannán who advises the Tuatha de Danann to take up residence in the sidhe, and he who assigned each new home," wrote Morgan Daimler.[1815]

"Irish mythology is really the story of the Sídhe," mused architectural mythologist Jack Roberts. It "has also been called 'the story of the mounds,' as it is impossible to talk about mythology without reference to the greatest

achievement of the Tuatha Dé Danann, the construction of the great temple mounds of the Brú na Bóinne," an access point to the Otherworld in County Meath.[1816] Built around 3200 BC, the "fairy dwelling" of Newgrange, most famous of the site's monuments, is an immense, circular passage tomb, accompanied by at least 20 other tumuli of various sizes, "the royal cemetery of the Tuatha Dé Danann kings and their Milesian successors."[1817]

"The megalith builders often built their burial-places close to, or even within, their sanctuaries, and rituals for the living surely gained in 'mana' [magical power] from the continuity ensured by the presence of the dead," wrote architectural historians Alastair Service and Jean Bradbery.[1818]

Throughout Ireland and the British Isles, sacred places arose upon earlier burial grounds, including Tara, Irish hilltop capital of the Tuatha.[1819] This overlap, as well as burials at sites not originally designed for interment—megaliths were often repurposed as infant cemeteries, for example —further blurs distinctions between funereal and non-funereal sites.[1820]

The discovery of burials at ringforts highlights this confusion. Despite their primary function as fortifications and settlements (or perhaps because of it, since every population needs a place to lay their dead), some forts yield extensive human remains. Exhumation of a Roscommon ringfort circa 2016 found 793 skeletons dating between the 6th and 11th centuries, some with jewelry, others beheaded.[1821]

“Imposing labyrinths of stone”:

Ringforts of northwestern Europe

As mentioned in Chapter 4, construction of “fairy forts”—herein collectively dubbed “ringforts” for ease of discussion—stretches from prehistory to around 1000 AD. This broad timeframe, coupled with their multitudinous names, shapes, sizes, orientations, locations, and functions, renders generalization difficult. Most, however, are circular and shelter faeries in Ireland and the British Isles.

Though ringforts exist in Scandinavia and within mainland Europe, they lack the strong paranormal associations enduring today in Ireland, perhaps as a function of density. For comparison, the Swedish island Öland is considered rich in ringforts, boating 19 ruins over 519-square-miles;[1822] by conservative estimates Ireland, only 62 times larger, hosts *at least* 40,000-50,000 ringforts.[1823]

English and Scottish ringfort distribution is also spottier than in Ireland. Around 80 Cornish ringforts called *rounds* are sometimes associated with faeries, like Penwith’s Caer Bran[1824] or the Iron Age settlement Trewardreva Fogou, a single underground passage known as the “Piskey’s Hall.”[1825] In Sussex, faeries gambol through ringforts at Torberry Hill and Cissbury Ring.[1826] One of Scotland’s largest hillforts sits atop the supposedly hollow Eildon Hill, where the Faerie Queen led Thomas the Rhymer to her realm.[1827]

Folklore connecting faeries to these sites is richest in Ireland, where ringforts are widely regarded as faerie homes. Souterrains, their subterranean tunnels, lead to Fairyland; the vegetation sprouting atop them are faerie bushes; their hilltop sites host dancing fae folk in the form of bobbing lights. Today, they stand alone, as trios, or spread across vast complexes, like the two-square-miles of Rathcroghan in County Roscommon. They keep watch upon Irish hills as *cashels*, lonely walls of stacked stone defying wintry gales. They persevere defiantly in otherwise treeless fields as untouched copses ominously littered with toppled masonry. They rise offshore in loughs as artificial islands called *crannogs*. They yield to time beneath the earth as *ráths*, forgotten gorse-crowned hillocks encircled by ditches, swathed in green, tolerating wooly tenants munching absent-mindedly till shearing season.[1828]

Above all, ringforts are respected. Overnighting within their confines means emerging mad—if one emerges at all. Manifold tales describe irreverent or careless farmers who, clearing fields, dismantle forts only to find their lives and livelihoods in shambles as well. Bravado is no match for faerie magic.

"You'd be surprised at the people who will not interfere with a fairy fort," chuckled folklorist Eddie Lenihan. "Fellahs you didn't think would care about anything. But when you put it to them, 'Go on, do it,' oh, they'll find an excuse. 'Mmm, another time, another time.'"[1829] For instance, 20 workers in County Mayo in 1958, discovering their fence line intersected a faerie fort, "promptly downed picks and shovels and folded their arms," much to the chagrin of their cynical foreman[1830] (Icelanders with similar dispositions divert roads around boulders belonging to huldufólk in examples as recent as

2014).[1831] Despite these superstitions, Irish monuments remain under threat from development, with estimated thousands destroyed in the past century alone.[1832]

What inspired this association? Discoveries of human remains certainly played a role—some are reputedly haunted by the dead, in addition to or instead of faeries—but why are unexcavated ringforts, or those without burials, considered faerie dwellings? There are numerous possibilities. For generations the Irish laity knew only of the miraculous megaliths, mounds, and ringforts their predecessors raised, not of the builders themselves, so they naturally credited supernatural races and beings. Others, understandably confusing earthen or overgrown ringforts with tumuli like burial mounds, imagined them as faerie hills, drawing upon mythologies describing mountains as homes of the dead. The elevation of hillforts, originally selected for strategic defense or heavenly proximity, likely contributed to this belief. There is also the connection of stones to spirits, as alluded to in the Silbury Hill excavations, and the underworld access souterrains imply.

If actual supernatural phenomena connected ringforts and faeries, perhaps on-site human remains are unnecessary—after all, plenty of dead souls haunting houses are buried off-property, with many ghosts simply reappearing where they lived or died, to say nothing of thought-forms generated by centuries of superstition, nature spirits reclaiming abandoned ruins, or lingering spirits summoned by ancient rituals. Perhaps human ghosts attached to ringforts *became* faeries, or faeries moved in afterward—as one witness said of Brú na Bóinne's residents, "The *good people* inherited

the *fort.*"[1833] Finally, such sites may actively draw in paranormal phenomena, an enticing possibility discussed later.

“Those old ones who carved them so reticently”: Window areas of Ireland and the British Isles

Even if not supernatural, northwestern Europe’s monuments are marvelous to behold. We know bits and pieces about who built them and why, but a wholistic picture remains elusive. Some ringforts probably represent dwellings, but this is based upon, as archaeology professor Tadhg O’Keefe put it, “the absence of any other settlement form of appropriate date in those landscapes. In other words, if the Gaelic-Irish did not live in ringforts, where did they live?”[1834] Others probably served as protective cattle corrals or literal fortifications—except many earthen ringforts are vulnerably positioned, their wartime use poorly documented.[1835] Some ancient monuments contain stones retrieved from vast distances—Stonehenge’s megaliths originate in a Pembrokeshire quarry 180 miles away, begging not only why, but *how* builders transported such massive blocks.[1836]

Others archaeologists explain monuments as vague “sacred spaces,” “ritually used and reused for as long as anyone could remember.”[1837] Hints of entheogens wend their way through the region’s history. Indo-Europeans’ use of psychoactive plants may well have influenced pagan religions in Ireland and the British Isles, a possibility obliquely supported by regional myths like the wisdom-granting hazelnuts consumed by Irish folk hero Fionn MacCumhaill.[1838] Megalithic art from Brú na Bóinne’s Knowth is even more compelling, with its recurring spirals, serpents, interlacing geometric patterns, concentric circles, and waving lines—all recognizable as *entoptic*

motifs (imagery seen during psychedelic trips originating within the eye).[1839] It would be surprising if at least *some* shamanic individuals didn't enter altered states of consciousness at *some* these monuments, whether or not entheogens were involved.

Unsurprisingly, generations of worship within ancient sites bolstered their reputation as portals to the Otherworld. Monuments became places of communion between humans and spirits, mundane spaces overlain by unseen realities where tumuli, megaliths, and ringforts simultaneously exist as repurposed physical spaces *and* subterranean palaces of deities, tombs of giants, pathways to Fairyland; these spaces exhibit a bipartite existence within the real and the imaginal, mirroring mankind's dual nature of body and soul.

Many sites facilitated an umbilical connection to the Otherworld by aligning closely with the observable but unreachable stellar realm. Besides symbolizing the spirit world, the stars keep pace with seasonal change, tracking the world's autumnal descent and vernal reemergence from darkness, signifying when to sow or reap—in other words, the heavens embody the annual death-rebirth cycle. This is famously evident at monuments like Stonehenge, where solstice sunlight dictated the megaliths' positions (Stonehenge's earliest purpose may have been as a burial ground).[1840] Similarly, the entrance to Newgrange "was built to align with the midwinter sunrise, with the sun shining directly into the chamber through a roof-box above the entrance, once closed with quartz blocks."[1841] At Ireland's largest stone circle, Lough Gur's Grange Stone Circle, 113 stones perfectly align with the summer solstice sunrise.[1842] Contemporary pagans still

seasonally participate in these events, connecting with traditions stretching across millennia.

"The evidence found at megalithic monuments often speaks to a cult of the dead or of 'ancestors' among the megalith builders and indicates that the sun and moon were worshipped as major deities, with the landscape also viewed as an 'otherworld' inhabited by supernatural forces," wrote Julian Heath.[1843] The expertise with which ancient peoples the world over precisely encoded astronomy into monuments is a vast topic more adequately covered elsewhere; the salient point is that these monuments link the movement of celestial bodies to the ecology of souls.

To this day, anomalies haunt burial mounds and other monuments throughout northwestern Europe. Besides faeries (already addressed extensively), consider this partial list of attendant phenomena at window areas in Ireland and the British Isles:

- **Ghosts.** "Ghosts are to be heard about the forths," a County Clare informant claimed. "They make a heavy noise, and there are creaks in their shoes."[1844] According to Cornish legend, a burial mound near the Hurlers Stone Circles housed the ghost of a druid who enticed visitors to drink from a golden cup—an 1818 excavation revealed remains and grave goods including an ornate golden chalice.[1845] Throughout Celtic countries, ghosts reside not only within burial mounds but around menhirs, cairns, and other tumuli.[1846] Phantom riders supposedly penetrate Avebury's stone circles, their steeds' hooves silent.[1847]

- **Black Dogs and Cats.** In England, Wales, and Scotland, cu sí manifest at sites like Gloucestershire's Longstone menhir, Cornwall's Whiteborough tumulus,

Scotland's Carn Moor cairn, and the Outer Hebrides's Dun Borbe fort—there is even a "Doghill Barrow" near Stonehenge in Wiltshire haunted by an anomalous black dog.[1848] Cat sí also display an affinity for monuments: for example, a panther-like feline allegedly stalks Bodmin Moor, a Cornish region replete with cairns, megaliths, and other stonework.[1849]

- **Lights.** Anomalous lights signify the most common phenomena around monuments; as such, any illumination around ringforts is attributed to faeries. A 19th century story collected by Dermot MacManus tells of a young woman who watched hundreds of small, white lights coalesce in the ringfort across the lough from her parents' farm, then travel to another fort on the opposite shore.[1850] Northern England's Pennine Hills exhibit regular "spook lights," often around Torside Castle, "a large prehistoric barrow" or hillfort.[1851]

In the early 1910s T. Sington and another witness, passing the stone circle of Castlerigg in Cumbria's Lake District, saw what they initially interpreted as a light on a bicycle. They realized something was amiss when numerous other lights—"globular, white, with a nucleus possibly six feet or so in diameter"—zipped toward the circle from the distance, including one which dissipated just before reaching them.[1852]

- **UFOs.** As noted, UFOs appear around all types of monuments, including those mentioned in Staffordshire and Wiltshire. One Wiltshire site boasting a hillfort and two bowl barrows, Cley Hill, is regarded as a minor UFO hotspot, with sightings allegedly stretching back into the 17th century of strange lights at high altitudes, orbs which separate and rejoin, and triangular craft.[1853]

- **Humanoids.** On November 21, 1980 Mario Luisi was searching for missing fishing tackle around a mound near Burneside, Cumbria when a rustling noise drew his attention to a beautiful man and woman wearing "wetsuits" in front of a 16'x8' craft. The wind never moved their hair as they told Luisi they hailed from "the sky," then boarded their craft and ascended, leaving behind a red glow in the clouds.[1854]

While approaching Scotland's Cairnpapple Hill in his car in summer 1985—a 4,000 year-old, cairn-adorned ritual site in Bathgate Hills—researcher Davy Colman and his family saw a tall, silver-suited humanoid flash across the road.[1855]

On a February afternoon in 1998, Paula Copestake, her husband, and their eight-year-old son summited Belas Knap (a Neolithic long barrow in the Cotswolds) where they saw a procession of five beings moving through the field below. They wore dark, hooded robes, possessed translucent faces, and multiplied from the shadows to at least a dozen, all following a shorter figure in front. Despite their purposeful gait, none made any progress towards the mound until, after glancing away, they vanished.[1856]

In addition to strange humanoids, cryptids appear in the vicinity of monuments in Ireland and the British Isles, elaborated in Chapter 18.

- **Miscellany.** Crop circles pop up around Old World monuments, especially on Avebury's Salisbury Plain. While many (if not most) are hoaxes, crop circles still exhibit anomalous activity, with strange lights accompanying their creation and hoaxers allegedly receiving psychic messages and divine inspiration.[1857]

Researchers like Terence Meaden speculated crop circles actually preceded these ancient monuments, anointing sites as "sacred" and inspiring the shapes and location of ringforts, stone circles, etc.[1858] Dubious assertions aside, even natural explanations like wind vortexes obliquely evoke the supernatural means by which fae folk travel, to say nothing of the circular dances so central to shamanic practice, the dancing dead, and faerie lore. Contemporary reports of "saucer nests,"[1859] circular depressions of vegetation, seem identical to "pisky beds" of yore[1860] or, frankly, the modern era: in May 1942 a Katie Richardson stumbled upon "a shallow, saucer-like depression in the ground" in Hampshire attended by "a group of very disgruntled-looking little men engaged in tidying-up."[1861]

Visitors to monuments also report missing time. In the mid-1990s, American tourist Linda Smith and her husband briefly visited the Nine Ladies, a Bronze Age stone circle

south of Manchester, but returned to their car to find seven hours had elapsed.[1862]

“Vast peaks rising on the west”:

Monuments of North America

The United States is a nation of contradictions. Despite being the fourth largest country by landmass, its population is tightly concentrated, with over 80% of Americans living in and around cities.[1863] Its indigenous inhabitants, once possibly numbering 18 million,[1864] now tragically comprise only 2% of America’s current population.[1865] We are left with a country where individuals could not be further removed from the land they inhabit, both in terms of lived experience and cultural heritage. Americans’ folklore overwhelmingly comes from other continents, their worldview gripped by modernity’s Materialist stranglehold. Anyone wise enough to leave the urban jungle quickly discovers a haunted land rich in indigenous history, despite early settlers’ best attempts to claim it as uninhabited.

“Around 1100 or 1200 AD, the largest city north of Mexico was Cahokia, sitting in what is now southern Illinois, across the Mississippi River from St. Louis,” wrote *Smithsonian Magazine*’s Sarah E. Baires. “Built around 1050 AD and occupied through 1400 AD, Cahokia had a peak population of between 25,000 and 50,000 people.” Composed of three boroughs over 20 square miles, “the city of Cahokia is one of many large earthen mound complexes that dot the landscapes of the Ohio and Mississippi River Valleys and across the Southeast.”[1866] Cahokia’s heyday is relatively recent; some place the earliest American mound construction over 6,500 years ago.[1867]

While not as dense as Ireland—New World indigenous populations simply had a more expansive canvas at their disposal—America nonetheless holds an impressive number and variety of monuments, including grand earthworks rivalling Old World structures. Official count circa 1894 was 100,000 sites, including complexes of two to a hundred mounds; researcher Gregory L. Little projects nearly 1,000,000 mounds once existed, with more discovered annually.[1868] These monuments assume a variety of forms, from immense ritual tumuli to small single burial mounds, from dwellings to effigy mounds in the stylized shape of humans, deities, and animals.

Burials predominate, however. America's largest conical burial mound, West Virginia's Grave Creek Mound—towering 69 feet into the air, its 295 foot-wide diameter surrounded by a moat long since destroyed—was constructed in multiple stages over the course of a century beginning around 250 BC, evident in multiple remains found within different strata.[1869] A few were erected at elevated sites, like Ohio's Miamisburg Mound (c. 800 BC, once 70 feet high and 877 feet in circumference), where the dead overlook the river from atop a 100 foot bluff.[1870] The number of burials can be staggering: Ontario's Taber Hill has produced over 500 Wyandot remains,[1871] one mound at Hopewell, Ohio 1,000 skeletons.[1872]

American burial mounds may have originated in a desire by relocated peoples to recreate knolls—themselves used for burials—in flat landscapes, or out of an aversion or inability to dig into hardpan. Burials in sufficiently dense soil would be shallower and thus subject to human or animal predation, while mounds allowed for customizable protection. This may account for their immense size, as "the higher the mound, the larger the area from which the top-soil would be stripped; so that a small mound would

increase in height by a double process," wrote E.F. Greenman in 1932. Greenman suggested a pragmatic origin for burial mounds: "the 'first mound builder,' exhausted from his labors in digging a deep grave, sat on the edge of his excavation and evolved the mound concept out of hand." From these humble beginnings, he suspected, a "bigger means better" mentality arose—but this practical explanation problematically overlooks the spiritual significance of the Cosmic Mountain archetype.[1873]

Encountering these cyclopean monuments, Europeans found some in use, others abandoned, varyingly ascribed by Native Americans to extant civilizations, ancestors, extinct races, or supernatural forces. Unable to reconcile racist conceptions of American savages with such sophisticated structures, early archaeologists suggested an Old World influence—Vikings, Welshmen, Hindus—anyone besides Native Americans.[1874] An unbroken line of speculation continues into esoteric circles to this day.

More charitably, anyone visiting both Old World and North American monuments notices eerie similarities. Pre-excavation photographs of American tumuli often show distinctly artificial mounds topped by trees, identical to many unexcavated ringforts in Ireland. Once cleared, these sites revealed further parallels: stone or earthen construction; stadium seating around ritual spaces; oft-concentric circular ditches, moats, and borrow pits; henges of wood; tumuli surrounding chambers for the dead, complete with grave goods; stacked stone cairns over remains; prehistoric fortifications on hills; sacrifices, especially at newer sites like Cahokia; and elaborate mounds reserved for prominent figures like chieftains and shamans. Their mixed function for both burial and ritual evokes sites in northwestern Europe, as

does the immense labor required for construction. The match isn't exact, but the broad strokes are consistent.

This neither excuses racist impulses nor endorses theories of "advanced" foreigners building these monuments. Rather, such similarities underscore how certain architectural techniques, forms, and functions (circular defenses, Cosmic Mountains, tumuli for the dead, etc.) signify archetypes embedded in the Collective Unconscious. The similarities *do* speak to a continuity of builders between Old and New World monuments—not shared culture, but shared *humanity*. For instance, archery arose worldwide not from a shared culture, but rather appeared independently across cultures because of its efficacy in hunting and warfare… perhaps these architectural features simply *work* when contacting the Otherworld.

The myth of Old World intervention was dispelled slowly and reluctantly, thanks to the archaeological pastimes of Presidents Thomas Jefferson and William Henry Harrison, as well as later work by Cyrus Thomas and Major John Wesley Powell, who successfully illustrated the mounds' native origin. Powell wrote:

> It is difficult to exaggerate the prevalence of this romantic fallacy, or the force with which the hypothetic "lost races" had taken possession of the imaginations of men. For more than a century the ghosts of a vanished nation have ambuscaded in the vast solitudes of the continent, and the forest-covered mounds have been usually regarded as the mysterious sepulchres of kings and nobles. It was an alluring conjecture….[1875]

While many indigenous tribes fashioned smaller tumuli, the largest and most numerous mound sites are today attributed to "Mound Builders," a term once denoting mysterious builders, since reclaimed to encompass various Native American cultures. These are primarily civilizations of the Archaic, Woodland (Hopewell, Adena, and Calusa), and Mississippian Periods (Coles Creek, Mississippian, Fort Ancient, and Plaquemine). Some of these people are forebears of the hunter-gatherer tribes so firmly ensconced in American identity.[1876]

Some are better understood than others. No one knows exactly from whence the Adena came, nor where they went.[1877] The archaeological terms can also be vague—the Hopewell, for instance, were not a culture but rather a tradition involving numerous populations.[1878] If the Gaelic-Irish are mysterious, some mound builders are downright inscrutable; they all, however, emphasized death.

"Perhaps nothing was quite so well celebrated as death among the mound builders," wrote Native American descendant and shamanic practitioner E. Barrie Kavasch. "After 4,000 years of mound builders' existence, we know more about their death than their life, especially the deaths of their elite, through their burials."[1879]

As in the Old World, even spaces not specifically designed for interment still feature burials. Tennessee's Pinson Mounds complex houses several such structures in addition to larger ceremonial tumuli like the flat-topped Ozier Mound and Sauls' Mound (standing 72 feet, reportedly the second highest surviving mound in the U.S. after the 100-foot-tall, 16 acre Monks Mound of Cahokia).[1880] Other platform mounds regarded as ritual spaces first and

foremost nonetheless occasionally contain burials, as do effigy mounds—about half feature remains buried at the center of the figures.[1881]

"That the ancient mound builders held some birdlike creatures in reverence is certain," Little wrote, noting the preponderance of avian imagery at archaeological sites.[1882] Pennsylvania's Sugar Run Mound, for example, began with the creation of two bird effigies under which cremations were placed. In Poverty Point, Louisiana, "an unknown group of people constructed a gigantic, semicircular, octagonal series of 10-15 foot tall ridges that were 50-100 feet in width," wrote Little. "Two bird effigy mounds were constructed" there as well.[1883] Hopewell sites in Scioto County, Ohio feature copper avian cutouts as grave goods,[1884] as do some Adena burials.[1885]

In addition to psychopomps like birds and turtles, vague parallels appear between effigy animals and cryptids: birds resemble Thunderbirds or Mothman, serpents lake monsters, panthers ABCs. The most notable absence is Bigfoot, although effigy mounds in the shape of bears and humanoids might *possibly* count.

"Recent studies undertaken on Adena mounds show that they were mostly ritualistic in nature; the difficulty in locating the remains of Adena living quarters and villages is directly related to this fact, as the Adena would keep the mound area clean of debris and non-sacramental artifacts and buildings," wrote Peter Levenda.[1886]

Despite so many clearly embodying a spiritual function, the exact nature of worship at the mounds remains largely unknown, except that it involved something recognizable as shamanism (unsurprising, given mound builders' treatment of death—where better to contact the spirits than at a burial

site?). Entheogens certainly played a role, either consumed orally like mushrooms or inhaled, evident from datura residue at Cahokia.[1887]

"The identification of shamans increases exponentially in Middle Woodland archaeology along with the appearance of effigy pipes that are believed to assist in the attainment of trances and perhaps to represent spirit helpers," explained archaeologist Thomas E. Emerson, further citing shamanic iconography in Mississippian petroglyphs. Pipes depicting figures in trance states have been excavated from sites as widely dispersed as Oklahoma's Craig and Louisiana's Gahagan Mounds, sometimes as grave goods.[1888]

As overseas, Native American mounds embody a stellar preoccupation. Numerous sites align with the rising and setting sun on solstices and equinoxes, also emphasizing stars like Orion. Elaborates Little:

> America's mound builders often carefully placed mounds at specific spots to allow for the observation of the rising and setting of stars on the horizon across the tops of mounds and the temples erected on them. Mound location and earthen pathways were determined by these ancient Native American tribes to delineate the exact time for conducting a death ritual. The ritual was designed to aid the souls of deceased tribal members in making the death journey to the "Path of Souls."[1889]

Little explains how some Mound Builder tribes believed the "'free soul' made a journey to the stars after death," passing into the West on the Winter Solstice where it lingered above "a body of water" until a "hand" (the constellation Orion) opened an *ogee* (sky portal). Via this gateway the soul

attained safe passage through the underworld to the Milky Way's Path of Souls, which eventually forked.

> At this split, the soul encountered a judge or mediator represented by a large raptor bird. The Constellation of Cygnus was the bird. If the soul passed the tests, the soul was allowed to make a final journey out of the sky dome… The Path of Souls alignments clearly show that many features at such ancient sites were purposely arranged to create alignments with the stars involved in the death ritual."[1890]

“The builders of the city were wise and old”: Builders and residents of American monuments

Faced with these tumuli so closely resembling the monuments of the Old World, some settlers *must* have identified them as faerie dwellings, yet comparisons are rare-to-nonexistent in the historical record. Blame may be partially lain upon the inconsistency with which European faerie beliefs were imported; while the indigenous population embraced their own, independently-derived Little People superstitions, few fragments of immigrants’ “fairy faith” survived the transatlantic voyage. Only in Atlantic Canada and bits of New England did these traditions endure—far from the Mound Builders’ most prominent sites.[1891]

It is remarkable how readily the imagination turns to supernatural innovation when confronted by such feats of engineering. Today this drive is satisfied by ancient alien theorists who—ever-tainted by the shadow of racism and a lack of faith in humanity’s ingenuity—staunchly credit extraterrestrials with erecting monuments worldwide.

But the more things change, the more they stay the same. Indigenous populations were not immune to this impulse. A 2014 survey by archaeologist Bradley T. Lepper found 13 of 38 tribes, if not crediting themselves, simply didn’t know who built the earthworks they lived alongside, or even occupied; 12 attributed them to their ancestors; six to spirits or foreign or supernatural races. The Delaware, for example, believed *Alligewi*—giants—built the mounds.[1892]

The Delaware's assertion is supported by manifold newspaper articles, typically from the late 19th and early 20th centuries, of gigantic remains exhumed from the mounds, accounts of varying credibility. Some were exceptionally tall, if not mythically proportioned—circa 1885, a mound near Gastersville, Pennsylvania held "a kind of vault… in which was discovered the skeleton of a giant measuring seven feet two inches." Another excavation near Toledo, Ohio, revealed jaws and teeth "twice as large as those of present day people."[1893]

Others finds were more alarming: in 1886, for instance, *The New York Times* reported thighbones allegedly recovered from Cartersville, Georgia's Tumlin Mound Field (Etowah) suggested their owners stood 14 feet tall.[1894] Claims of immense axes exceeding 38 lbs. and large skillets, as found in La Crescent, Minnesota, encouraged further speculation.[1895] The myth (if an appropriate pejorative) was so pernicious it arose in the speeches of President Abraham Lincoln, which referenced "that species of extinct giants, whose bones fill the mounds of America, have gazed on Niagara, as ours do now."[1896]

These narratives invariably find the remains destroyed or confiscated by the Smithsonian Institution, leaving conspiratorial Forteans to speculate whether or not they still molder in forgotten museum warehouses. While some reports of enormous skeletons clearly represent "Yellow Journalism," others, accompanied by photographs and ample documentation, are not so easily dismissed.

"It is true that the disarticulation of skeletons (i.e., the bones falling apart from the joints as the soft tissue decays) can make the deceased appear to

have been taller in death than s/he was in life, but disarticulation cannot account entirely for the size of the Mound Builders as consistently reported," wrote Barbara Mann in *Native Americans, Archaeologists, and the Mounds.* "It adds only an inch or two to height, whereas archaeologists who were familiar with the concept of disarticulation continually expressed surprise over the gigantic size of the Mound Builders."[1897]

Mann, who wrote her book "at the specific behest of elders of the Native American community of Ohio," is an academic, not a racist fringe conspiracy theorist. Even Cyrus Thomas, who dispelled many Mound Builder myths, "recorded 'graves inclosing skeletons of very large size' at the earthworks near Dublin in Franklin County, Ohio, and, on a dig in Coshocton County, Ohio, he marveled at 'a stone-box grave containing a skeleton seven feet long.'"[1898]

Similar remains surfaced in the Old World, where megaliths are often attributed to giants' hands. Enormous bones (likely bovine) allegedly surfaced at Ireland's many "giants' graves."[1899] Barrows at *Bryn-yr-ellyllon*, Wales's "hill of the goblins/faeries," were reputedly haunted by a giant's ghost in a coat of gold until an 1830 excavation found a golden cloak—displayed today at the British Museum—and a tall skeleton.[1900]

Giants are often, if not consistently, identified with the dead. The Norse *bergbúi,* "dweller in the mountain," can refer both to a giant or the dead.[1901] In Japan, anyone dying of starvation may become *gashadokuro*, a 15-foot tall giant who roams the land accompanied by a ringing noise.[1902] Giants also serve in other capacities related to death, providing the building blocks of creation with their corpses (discussed in Chapter 7), guarding Otherworld

bridges,[1903] fulfilling mythical "death devourer" roles,[1904] and even serving as psychopomps.

A 12th century text describes a giant, perhaps representing the Gaulish psychopomp Ogmios, joining a funeral procession alongside "dwarfs with huge barrel-shaped heads."[1905] This procession was the infamous Wild Hunt, the topic of our next chapter.

Giants were sometimes confusingly conflated with dwarfs, to the extent giants could be considered fae folk. The term "troll" is a good example straddling this distinction. Some western European cultures used "giant" to denote a variety of spirits great and small,[1906] and one informant told Evans Wentz some sídhe stood 14 feet tall, highly incongruent with our modern conception of tiny faeries.[1907] Wrote Waldemar Bogoras:

> …the megalithic builders in Sardinia, Germany, the British Islands, are considered as giants, but some traditions speak of them as dwarfs. Otherwise Giants and Dwarfs are represented as alternating with each other. Thus in Iceland according to the popular chronology the Giants are stated to be very early possessors of the land but to have been driven out by the Little People, who presumably held possession until the coming of the Danes.[1908]

The well-documented association of faeries with monuments in the Old World continues into America. Mound excavators regularly unearth effigies of dwarfs as statues or ceremonial pipes.[1909] Apocryphal stories speak of *small* bones recovered from the mounds—near Sparta, Tennessee, numerous 2'10'

’ skeletons were allegedly recovered,[1910] as were others from mounds near Ohio’s Conneaut Creek.[1911] In 1400, two dwarfs were purportedly disinterred at Moundville, Alabama exhibiting cranial deformation, a form of body modification practiced worldwide where infants’ growing skulls are bound. The resulting deformity gives the head an oblong orientation evocative both of “barrel-headed” dwarfs and modern alien Greys.[1912]

Tidbits from indigenous lore connect Little People to the mounds. Certain Native American tribes avoided the area around Macon, Georgia’s Ocmulgee Mounds, where spectral warriors could be heard singing and dancing nightly.[1913] A race of diminutive mound builders were sometimes credited with earthworks in Missouri,[1914] spurred by discoveries of an “ancient cemetery of pygmies” near St. Louis.[1915] Sightings of *puckwudgies* (Ojibwe faeries whose lore diffused into New England and the Midwest) prevail around Mounds State Park in Anderson, Indiana, a site containing ten Adena ceremonial burial tumuli.[1916] Ruins and earthworks in Hawaii like Kikiaola Ditch[1917] are sometimes cited as evidence of menehune.[1918] Sioux and Crow people speak of “the Little People of the Pryor Mountains,” large-headed “devils” in Montana, Wyoming, and South Dakota who fire long-distance arrows at anyone who transgresses near their capital of Spirit Mound—a natural Dakotan hill the Sioux *believed* was a burial mound.[1919]

North American beliefs connecting faeries to tumuli are most prevalent in the southeastern United States, where both burial and ceremonial mounds belong to nûñnë'hï. Cherokee residents of Georgia’s Nottely town, established near a mound, once claimed regular interactions with the nûñnë'hï. One folktale describes how hundreds of nûñnë'hï poured out of Nĭkwăsĭ’ mound near modern Franklin, North Carolina to repel an invading tribe alongside the

Cherokee.[1920] Centuries later during the Civil War, nûñnë'hï allegedly intervened again at Franklin, giving the impression the poorly-defended town was heavily guarded, discouraging an attack by Union forces.[1921]

A striking monument endures on Georgia's Fort Mountain. Littered with dozens of pits and a ruined gateway, no one is certain what purpose the 885-foot-long rock wall once served, nor its age, save it is at least 1,500 years old.[1922] Its builders are equally mysterious. Candidates include the Adena[1923] or —that old chestnut—an alleged Welsh traveler to the New World, Prince Madoc.[1924]

However, some Cherokee credit Fort Mountain's structure to "the Moon-Eyed People": advanced, sunlight-averse, "very small," and "perfectly white." These original inhabitants of the area lived near tumuli and burial mounds from northern Georgia up through McCreary County, Kentucky and far western North Carolina.[1925] Some speculate they were nûñnë'hï, but the Moon-Eyed People exhibited a more antagonistic relationship with the Cherokee. Conflicting accounts say they were expelled by the Cherokee or massacred by the Creek, or vice versa.[1926]

Eager to rekindle the trope of non-native Mound Builders, some identify the Moon-Eyed People as pre-Columbian European settlers or (as ever) extraterrestrials. Though not explicitly identified as such, their association with monuments, nocturnal inclination, implicitly larger eyes, small stature, and possible subterranean retreat speaks to them as faerie analogues. Their surrender of territory to the Cherokee even parallels the manner in which the Tuatha Dé Danann retreated into Irish mounds when faced with invasion.[1927]

To summarize: around the world, we erroneously attribute ancient monuments, clearly built by human hands, to races of supernatural, diminutive, subterranean beings associated with the dead. This impulse is strong—so strong, in fact, it appears among both colonizers and the colonized. We must either assume this tendency is inherent in human nature… or there is some objective truth behind these myths.

A middle road of interpretation allows us to treat both possibilities as true. Yes, these were built by humans who lived and died, just as we do; but those humans *changed* after they died. Over time, we remember them not as they were, but in their transformed state, as ancestors, ghosts, small souls. As fae folk. Rather than vanished global civilizations or extinct races, it seems possible the supernatural beings associated with these monuments are simply *us*, reaching through these outposts of the Otherworld from the ecology of souls.

"Gateway to secrets of the inner earth and vanished aeons":

Window areas of North America

It is impossible to collate an exhaustive list of window areas coinciding with American monuments. A cursory examination of the paranormal literature reveals dozens of candidates well within 200 miles of Native American burial sites and mounds exhibiting High Strangeness: the aforementioned destinations of upstate New York and Mason County, West Virginia; Cape Girardeau in mound-laden Missouri, which claims a 1941 UFO crash, Bigfoot activity, and Mothman sightings;[1928] Athens, Ohio, heart of Adena country, with Bigfoot sightings and an impressive display of 15-20 UFOs on April 26, 1954;[1929] Pennsylvania's Fayette County, a UFO-Bigfoot hotspot once boasting "Indian forts"[1930] (*Fayette* itself meaning "little faerie").[1931]

Before we continue, a quick aside. While acknowledging earlier caveats about their density, a certain numinous quality nonetheless pervades the areas surrounding Native American earthworks, even when not overtly paranormal. Perhaps speciously, Peter Levenda finds it curious cult leader Charles Manson's roots begin in the mound-heavy town of Ashland, Kentucky. Similarly, Joseph Smith founded the Latter Day Saint movement after receiving his golden plates at "the Hill Cumorah," another mound. Levenda also notes the incidence of major penitentiaries "located at or near Adena mound sites"—including Manson's prison at Chillicothe[1932]—as well as

nuclear testing facilities and, in a tangential UFO connection, the construction of Wright-Patterson Air Force Base, "built on the site of Indian burial grounds."[1933] It is almost as if the very institutions driving United States history draw influence from these monuments.

Setting aside Little People, consider a sample of unexplained phenomena surrounding Native American monuments and sepulchral sites:

- **Ghosts.** Many mounds feature hauntings, but separating rumor from fact is difficult. Ghost hunters claim Cahokia's Mound 72 features strange lights, noises, ghosts, and shadow figures.[1934] Visitors to Arkansas's Knapp Mounds "see lights, orbs, and even ghostly apparitions of ancient people. At night, footsteps have been heard around the existing mound site."[1935] In 1985, Lynne and Mark Wisner bought a home in Grovetown, Georgia, behind which sat a 20-foot-tall burial mound; after moving in, they were assaulted with disembodied drumming, anomalous lights, and "phantom figures dancing in the woods."[1936] Students at Athens's Ohio University, allegedly built over indigenous graves, report disembodied chanting and the sound of running water.[1937]

  Indigenous spirits comingle with more recent deaths. A Civil War skirmish at Ocmulgee left behind Confederate ghosts,[1938] and the University of Tennessee at Knoxville—whose grounds encompass at least two burial sites, one for Native Americans, the other for settlers—is haunted by both.[1939]

- **Black Dogs and Cats.** A "shadow wolf" appears in the vicinity of sacred Ho-Chunk mounds around Neillsville, Wisconsin.[1940] In the 1980s, one witness at a rental property in New York watched a silent, "enormous black dog… 300-400 lbs." trot across a dirt cul-de-sac during her childhood. Years later her father shared old maps of the area, revealing "the house was in a *direct line* between an ancient Native American burial ground and a 19th century church and cemetery," 1.41 miles

from each: "the *exact middle* of the aligned burial grounds."[1941] Somerset, Kentucky podcaster Nathan Isaac has spoken with "hundreds" of witnesses of large, black panthers. "The area where they're most seen in this county is up Highway 39 near where the Adena Mound is, where there is an earthwork," he said.[1942]

- **Lights.** "Imagine getting up in the middle of the night, looking out in the backyard and seeing this strange light going up and down just outside your window," Lynne Wisner said of her Georgia property.[1943] To the south, Florida's Old Connor Library in New Smyrna, built atop an indigenous shell mound, is haunted by poltergeist activity, "strange birdlike images," and, most significantly, "orbs of light" caught both in photos and on video.[1944] Further yet down the coast, the grounds of the Deering Estate include Cutler Burial Mound, alleged generator of all sorts of paranormal activity, including Native American ghosts, poltergeist activity, and orbs of light.[1945]

As ever, these phenomena overlap with UFOs. In December 1966, Rob McKinnon and his family watched a beam of light hang in the air, shining upon Alaska's Canyon Creek Burial Ground. "It was interested in this place," he said.[1946] A student of Jeffrey Kripal's perceived "three softball-sized, golden orbs made of light" rise from the ground in 2010 while interning at Big Sur's famed Esalen Institute—as Kripal noted, "the grounds upon which Esalen sits and out of which the beautiful balls of light emerged is a Native American burial site."[1947]

- **UFOs.** In addition to the window areas above, Washington's Yakima Indian Reservation, with "forty burial grounds on or adjacent,"[1948] is another paranormal hotspot. The area is rife with poltergeist activity, shadow people, Bigfoot sightings, sounds of underground machinery, and regular UFO sightings, from "Zeppelin-like craft" to enormous, fiery orange-red orbs shooting "spike-like rays of white light."[1949] UFOs and cryptids stalk southeastern Wisconsin from the Kettle Moraine State Forest and Bong State Recreation Area to Burlington, where 27 tumuli once stood before the business district arose.[1950]

- **Humanoids.** A child in Mound, Minnesota (named for local monuments) saw a short shadow figure with red eyes in the bedroom in 1968.[1951] Five years later, partiers three miles from Ohio's Serpent Mound noticed a bright light flooding the backyard, emanating from a green UFO which departed in the direction of the primary witness's house. Three days later, a trio of well-dressed men driving a black car, wearing sunglasses—quintessential Men-in-Black—took notes on her sighting, insisting she saw a weather balloon.[1952]

While cryptid sightings around burial mounds are mostly addressed in Chapter 18, a few are mentioned here. On June 18, 1997, Tennessee hunters allegedly opened fire on a tall, horned, hairy biped to no effect within two miles of a pair of burial sites, one of which is indigenous, near Johnson City.[1953]

A witness growing up in Rosepine, Louisiana (an area with multiple documented mounds)[1954] recalled finding indigenous artifacts near an earthwork when planting her spring garden as a child. Taking them to her room, she unwittingly invited a shadowy "half man, half dog" creature into her home. After its fourth nightly appearance, it telepathically demanded the objects be reburied, which ceased the apparitions (the young girl wisely didn't need to be told twice).[1955] Night watchman Mark Schackelman spotted another doglike cryptid at St. Coletta convent in Racine, Wisconsin in 1936. The stinking beast crept about the property's burial mounds, muttering the word, "Gadarrah."[1956]

- **Miscellany.** A crop circle, hoaxed or not, famously appeared in a soybean field opposite the entrance to Serpent Mound in 2003.[1957] The following year, another intricate design appeared in a Miamisburg, Ohio cornfield, Adena territory.[1958]

On December 28, 2016, a visitor to Serpent Mound reported his fully-charged phone turned off while taking pictures, the battery registering as dead—a return to his car showed its charge at 40%. A final trip to the mound shut his phone down once more, but it operated normally elsewhere the remainder of the day.[1959]

An unprovenanced account claims a paranormal "triangle" exists around Rhine, Georgia (home to minor mounds and 64 miles from Ocmulgee) where witnesses report Mothman, hairy hominids, ghosts, UFOs, and missing time: one Phyllis Newman claimed a 15 minute trip on State Route 117 took 90 minutes.[1960]

“Architecture much like that of the city above”:

Unidentified flying mounds

A pre-Removal legend describes how the nûñnë'hï told the Cherokee they planned to relocate one of their townhouses in a week’s time, inviting tribe members to accompany them if they fasted in silence during the interim.

“On the seventh day there was a sound from the distant mountains, and it came nearer and grew louder until a roar of thunder was all about the townhouse and they felt the ground shake under them,” wrote ethnographer James Mooney. The people shrieked in fright, and the nûñnë'hï “were startled by the cry and let a part of [the mound] fall to the earth, where now we see the mound of Sĕ’tsĭ. They steadied themselves again and bore the rest of the townhouse, with all the people in it, to the top of Tsuda’ye’lûñ’yĭ (Lone peak), near the head of Cheowa, where we can still see it, changed long ago to solid rock, but the people are invisible and immortal.”[1961]

The Sĕ’tsĭ myth speaks to a legion of connections between UFOs and monuments. The entoptic phenomena carved at Neolithic sites like Knowth resemble not only geometry from altered states of consciousness, but closely align with the shapes haunting our skies. Other icons like the *triskelion* also encode death in their spiral shapes—prehistoric labyrinths often signify passage into the Underworld.[1962] Even Knowth’s lesser-entoptic art, like a lengthy, winding serpent, speak to legends of the original UFO: dragons flying through the clouds.[1963]

The basic architecture shared between Old and New World monuments evokes flying saucers, their circular shape imitated in megalithic rings, henges, tumuli, ringforts, earthworks, medicine wheels—even indigenous burial patterns of some American mounds and Asian kurgans, where remains were lain in spokes.[1964] Both burial mounds and UFOs conceal labyrinthine interiors beneath domes leading circuitously to miraculous worlds, either Fairyland or another planet. Passage tombs' subterranean aspect closely mirrors McKenna's "sense of enormous mass surrounding you" in the DMT realm, their dank interiors some alien abductees' testimony. Their inhabitants are consistently Otherworldly, be they aliens, faeries, or the dead.

"As one approaches… one cannot help sympathizing with those who look to flying saucers for the origin of the megaliths," wrote Service and Bradbery of Brú na Bóinne. "In fact, if the hill of Newgrange floated away from its site it could be very similar to the flying objects so often reported."[1965]

Beyond the circular, practically every monument shape resembles a UFO sighting. Wessex's bell barrows are practically identical to classic discs topped with cupolas. Menhirs and long barrows look like cigar-shaped craft. Both Japan's Kawachi-Otsuka Tumulus[1966] and Poland's Kopiec Tatarski are roughly triangular (to say nothing of Egyptian and Mesoamerican pyramids).[1967] Bowl barrows approximate aerial orbs of light.[1968] Eye-shaped barrows share a likeness with UFOs like the one seen above Exeter, New Hampshire on March 21, 1966: "It would stop, bob, and then swing back and forth like a pendulum… It seemed to be football shaped."[1969] The shape of such monuments—coupled with the UFOs they attract and their stellar alignments—suggests a relationship.

Author F.W. Holiday noted these correlations in the early 1970s, connecting both UFOs and the Loch Ness Monster to tumuli in northwestern Europe (Chapter 18). To his mind, their circular construction indicated an ancient "Dragon - Tree of Life - Disc" cosmology: the disc nesting in the Tree of Life's crown, the serpent coiled about its roots, a fundamental divine-chthonic polarity.[1970]

Circles were indeed venerated among various cultures, evidenced in sun-moon worship, metallic disc grave goods, and ancient iconography, e.g. winged suns in Egypt, the Zoroastrian fravashi's winged disc-soul, the Norse god Odin's single eye, etc.[1971] (In this sense, Holiday echoed Jung's musings on the UFO as a symbol of totality or the Eye of God, covered in Chapter 15. We are equally reminded of the removal of eyes in shamanic dismemberment and alien abductions, and the pineal gland's status as a vestigial eye.)

"The sky-gods *Surya,* Djevs, Zeus, Jupiter and Taranis all seem to have been names for the same thing," Holiday wrote. "That thing was the phenomenon we now term U.F.O.s." Whether flying saucers inspired disc worship or vice versa is unclear and, to a certain degree, inconsequential: disc worship existed and UFO sightings persist.[1972]

Literal-minded researchers fall into the tired ancient alien trap to varying degrees of forgivability—some earnestly arrive at the conclusion based upon indigenous testimony. Midwestern mounds were "location markers" for "fire ships" according to some Michigan Anishinaabe,[1973] and a Susquehannock-descended shaman once claimed his people placed "healing crystals" inside mounds to guide "outer space craft"; even if describing "nuts-and-bolts" spaceships, neither testimony precludes UFOs' spiritual or psychic nature.[1974]

Even Keel lightly entertained the notion in the 1970s, citing Matest M. Agrest's speculation that "flat-topped mounds were intended as UFO airports."[1975]

But what of the Sĕ'tsĭ mound, neither inspired by nor inspiring a UFO sighting—but *an actual unidentified flying object itself?* Strangely, mobile monuments are not rare.

"Certain Druidical monuments called *pierres tournantes*, or *tourneresses*, are so termed because they are believed to move of themselves, and to *turn round* on Christmas Eve at midnight," wrote Amélie Bosquet.[1976] More dramatically, other megaliths dance or uproot themselves in search of water—UFOs today are regularly sighted around water, sometimes collecting it, as in the Cenote Ik Kil example.[1977] Sometimes "a fairy giant (such as the Gargantua of folk legends), or even a simple fairy (such as Melusine), transported megaliths for the building and founding of sacred sites."[1978]

That tumuli fly around as UFOs is absurd, but reserve judgment for a few paragraphs yet. Bullard long ago noted how folktales of "a fairy mound, on certain nights raised on pillars and brilliantly lighted… resemble[s] in remarkable degree a landed UFO."[1979] The same might be said of dolmens, their vertical pillars resembling landing struts topped by large, disclike rock slabs.

Moreover, UFOs and mounds blend in contemporary testimony. In 1983 a Missouri man watched through binoculars as several small humanoids "in broad daylight" levitated a cow into a cone-shaped craft—his wife, however, "saw the beings floating the cow up a black ramp and disappearing into a hill."[1980] The father of a New England family, dealing with UFOs and High

Strangeness on his property, told Ufologist Raymond Fowler in 1978 he saw an immense "boulder" by the roadside; closer examination revealed it as a landed craft, "rough, not shiny at all. Everything dull-like, just like a rock with moss on it." The craft came and went capriciously.[1981] During the infamous French UFO flap of 1954, a witness at Amiens caught sight of an oddly-colored "mound… like an unfinished haystack" in a distant field on September 7. The object swayed as they approached before ascending.[1982]

While accounts of flying ringforts and burial mounds are vanishingly scarce, tantalizing hints exist. Dragons—winged in European mythology, long conflated with comets and anomalous lights—found close association with barrows. A line from the 10th century *Exeter Book* reads *draca sceal on hlawe,* "'a dragon shall be in a barrow,' meaning that it is customary and right for a dragon to be in a burial mound."[1983]

A tale passed around Ballinalee, County Longford, describes one Mr. O'Brien who, driving cattle near a ringfort, saw a faerie emerge with a sack of treasure. The being laughed at him, and O'Brien gave pursuit, to no avail; upon returning one of his cows had disappeared. O'Brien fetched a priest who retrieved the cow, "and the fort disappeared."[1984] One Rathrush story sees a man passing a music-filled fort which transforms into a magnificent faerie castle but, upon approach, reverts to a deserted ráth.[1985] While not airborne, these folktales indicate ringforts were sometimes attributed powers of relocation or transformation.

Legends of sacred flying mountains are far more common, especially in the East. Japan holds several such myths, including Mount Ōmine, which arrived upon the sacred landscape accompanied by "thunder and tremors."[1986] In

Tibet, two sacred mountains flew from India,[1987] where the monkey god Hanuman once carried the massif Dronagiri and Nanda Devi. In India we find the flying mountain archetype embodied in *vimānas,* a term describing both the tallest structures of Hindu temples as well as mythical flying machines.[1988]

Flying mountains may originate in *Fata Morgana*, a natural phenomenon named after Arthurian antagonist Morgan le Fay ("Morgan the Fairy"). Bent rays of light passing through air strata of different temperatures produce the illusion of structures floating above the horizon. The effect—demonstrable with distant ships along the coast—is reported throughout history at sites like the faerie hill of Glastonbury Tor, which when accompanied by mist can appear quite uncanny.[1989]

Fata Morgana may also account for some mythical castles, cities, or islands in the sky like St. John's New Jerusalem or Hy Brasil, an Otherworld island appearing every seven years off the Irish coast (interestingly, the Rendlesham UFO encounter allegedly included a psychic "download" later speculated as coordinates for Hy Brasil).[1990] Seeing the island in 1885 off the coast of Sligo, W.G. Wood-Martin attributed Hy Brasil to natural phenomena reflecting a city elsewhere, referencing reports where mirages of Wales's Mount Snowdon sometimes appeared above Dublin Bay. A presumably similar phenomenon displacing Bristol to the skies above Alaska was recorded in Charles Fort's *New Lands.*[1991]

The "city in the clouds" motif endures into the modern day as Fata Morgana, sightings of massive UFO "motherships," or even floating buildings. Kentucky researcher Barton Nunnelly—a regular experiencer of High

Strangeness—saw "a brick castle complete with turrets and a red banner" in the clouds as a child in 1975, appearing entirely real until sight of it was lost behind tall trees.[1992] Natural explanations satisfy some flying saucer sightings, but not all. Fata Morgana cannot appear directly above your head, move dramatically across the sky, or land and disgorge occupants. Equally implausibly, tumuli cannot spin off into the sky.

If we adopt the position that ancient monuments represent "outposts of the Otherworld," perhaps their presence leaves an impression in another reality, often described as resembling, even reflecting, our reality. This magical thinking appears in the burial of grave goods like horses and even entire ships—objectively real objects meant to magically transition into Otherworldly modes of transport—or the ensouling of idols with the spirits of deities or the dead, seen throughout Africa.[1993]

Perhaps the interdimensional footprints of burial mounds manifest as supernal, quasi-holographic overlays of our landscape, skinned in shiny interplanetary chrome, embodying the Hermetic axiom of "as above, so below." If our souls are capable of flight, if animism's ensouled universe has some basis in reality, perhaps *buildings* possess souls equally capable of miraculous feats.

“Architectural marvels as yet unencountered”:

Constructing cosmic attractors

“Certainly there are spots which inevitably attach to themselves an atmosphere of holiness and goodness,” penned Shirley Jackson in *The Haunting of Hill House.* “It might not then be too fanciful to say that some houses are born bad.” In some sense, the ghost stories we tell today are actually architecture stories, the property’s layout as much a character as any revenant.

How do you ensoul buildings? You either imbue them with architectural features to “call in” the Otherworld, erect them upon sacred sites, or both. Such factors may explain why some houses are haunted and others are not. Refuting Levenda’s concept of “America as a haunted house,” perhaps it is the density of remains, the passion of deaths, which causes spirits to congregate. Monuments and ruins apparently excel at attracting the paranormal, evidenced by the regularity with which fae folk take over such spaces.

Indiana University’s William F. Romain wrote that Monks Mound, America’s largest pre-Columbian earthwork, “was not only a link between realms; it was also the equivalent of a cosmic attractor that drew into its sphere of influence the trajectories of peoples’ lives.”[1994]

Certain shapes may serve as cosmic attractors. In indigenous thought, this is certainly why mountains and caverns, close to the worlds above and below, were rife with supernatural beings. In Africa, the Lou, Dinka, and Nuer all fashion tumuli not to bury the dead, but "to pull the might of a divinity to Earth and empower the prophet who spoke for him or her."[1995]

That a structure's architecture can provide defense from the Otherworld is a widespread belief. The Iroquois felt their ancestors fashioned earthworks to repel supernatural monsters.[1996] The hengiform orientation of many ringforts in Ireland, on the other hand—with ditches *inside*, rather than outside their banks, as would be expected for defensive purposes—suggests an effort to *retain* the Otherworld. Retired curator of the Ulster Museum Richard B. Warner speculated upon the true purpose of "internally-ditched" sites:

> …within both the Tara and Navan internally-ditched enclosures (and possibly that at Knockaulin) rituals took place by means of which the king/priests contacted, and drew power and authority from, the Otherworld… It seems clear that the ritual was extremely dangerous. The opening of the door to the Otherworld allowed the Otherworld access to the Real-world, with potentially dire consequences. The gods and demi-gods were necessary, but were also capricious and potentially hostile. The importance of the king/priest undoubtedly lay in his ability to control that conduit, to act as the gatekeeper between the two worlds. One would guess that the danger of ingress by the Otherworld into these two most important ritual places, Tara and Navan, was also proportionately larger than for other, minor places of entry…
>
> The internally-ditched arrangement of the enclosures at Tara, Navan and Knockaulin is clearly incapable of being interpreted as defensive in the normal sense despite the fact that in all cases (particularly at Navan) the ditch is

extremely impressive. In fact both, were they turned round, would be spectacular defences, far stronger than any excavated hillfort in Ireland.

The Otherworld people obviously could not be prevented from entering the human world through the contact point—they were being invited to do so—so they had to be prevented from exiting from the sacred area around that point and into the secular human domain, the Real-world beyond. In other words the defenders were outside the sacred area and the enemy, or potential enemy, were within—the reverse of the normal defensive requirement.

This hypothesis would seem to require that the enclosure was constructed at the same time as the contact-point was constructed, or was first recognised to be an Otherworld entrance.[1997]

Warner's theory may explain not only the wrath incurred by destroying ringforts—their supernatural powers, no longer contained, contaminate our reality—but also why sites like Tara were built atop burials. Extrapolating further, were bodies interred at ceremonial mounds for the specific purpose of serving as paranormal attractors? Lest we think the hengiform orientation is solely Celtic, practically identical structures once stood at sites like Greenup County, Kentucky.[1998]

“This maze of stone-shadowed twilight”:

Circles and Labyrinths

While clearly an easily defendable shape for mounds and forts, circular designs may present additional ritual significance. Stone circles and henges regularly appear in the Old World, and circular burials, woodhenges, and medicine wheels—Native American structures with a stone at the center, from which radiate rows of rock spokes—dot the Americas. Circles for magical invocation and protection as “places between the worlds” are well-documented.[1999]

“Evil spirits cannot penetrate a circle drawn around him by one who invokes them” in European sorcery, wrote Hartland.[2000] Across the Atlantic, the Adena first utilized circular embankments “to offer protection from supernatural or other undesirable influences, either internal or external to the circle.”[2001]

Contemporary architecture can embody this belief as well. Longstanding superstition holds ghosts become “caught” and loiter in houses’ right angles; for this reason, spirit offerings are sometimes left in corners.[2002] The Bull Valley, Illinois police department now resides in the George Stickney House, built in 1865 by the Spiritualist parents of ten children, only three of whom survived.[2003] To enhance their séances and allow the free flow of spirits, the Stickneys insisted upon no right angles in the building, evident from the home’s curved exterior. In 2005, police chief Norbert Saunder admitted the

station remains haunted by strange noises and voices, opening doors, and moving objects. One officer even claimed to encounter a full-bodied apparition.[2004]

Returning to tumuli, we may also perceive power in the interior of passage tombs and ringforts' souterrains, which, even when not extensive, certainly impart the feeling of labyrinths. Some see a resemblance between Greek labyrinth coins and ringforts' concentric earthen circles when viewed from above.[2005] Other monuments are explicitly mazes, like the recent discovery of palisade enclosures near Stevns, Denmark.[2006] Symbolically speaking, labyrinths are spiritually potent, used in contemporary meditation and symbolizing a journey to the unconscious or the passage from life to death; the Bardo and Mayan afterlife path can be conceived of as mazes.[2007]

They are also notorious spirit traps, traced on doors to ensnare spirits of the dead, or manifesting in Native American culture as weblike dreamcatchers suspended over sleepers.[2008] This may originate in beliefs that spirits travel in straight lines, or that supernatural beings are arrested by complexity—Bavarian witch traps feature tangled thread,[2009] the devil can be distracted by counting sand,[2010] French lutins peas or grain,[2011] African-American *boo-hags* holes in colanders or straws on brooms.[2012] Could the tunnels and chambers beneath and within monuments function as spirit traps?

Subterranean spaces within monuments would also be highly conducive to shamanic altered states of consciousness. As noted, cavern-induced sensory deprivation encourages ASCs, countless ancient Mystery School rites occurred underground, and katabasis is a strong theme in shamanism. "As

day to the living, so night is conceded to the dead"—*Ut dies vivis, sic nox est concessa defunctis*, the Latin phrase goes. The ability to enter a darkened space during the day would represent an invaluable method for spirit contact on-demand.

Much to the chagrin of skeptics questioning why no ghosthunters operate in the daytime, darkness seems fundamental to spirit contact. After all, Terence McKenna's recipe for communication with the mushroom intelligence was consumption of a heroic dose of "five dried grams in silent darkness." Ancient Greeks believed the dead returned to Hades at dawn, but that "night free[d] the prisoned shades."[2013]

As to *why*, perhaps the supernatural is photophobic, suggested by ectoplasm's withdrawal from light during séances. Perhaps it is related to the pineal gland's photosensitivity. Perhaps it is because darkness is a death symbol, Thanatos being the child of *Nux*, Night. Or perhaps, as proposed by anthropologist Jack Hunter, darkness facilitates the imaginal realm, the "sham of shamanism."

"I think the darkness—as well as allowing for the *possibility* of fraud… which itself might enable genuine psi phenomena—the darkness also puts the rest of the sitters into an altered state of consciousness," he mused in 2018 on darkness's importance to séances.[2014] As extraterrestrial kidnappers told Ashland, Nebraska police officer Herbert Schirmer on December 3, 1967: "We want you to believe in us… but not too much."[2015]

"Whispered hill legends of the north":

Sounds & Stones

ASC-inducing darkness within certain monuments would be amplified not only by entheogens, but also acoustics. Many ancient sacred spaces include features which ring preternaturally when struck, or acoustics which amplify the resonance of certain vocalized pitches. For instance, large T-shaped pillars at Göbekli Tepe "vibrate like a tuning fork" when struck with an open palm.[2016] Acoustical analysis of Stonehenge reveals the structure not only amplifies sound within the circle, but dampens noise from without.[2017] Chambers within Giza's Great Pyramid resonate at specific frequencies, fueling speculation the monument may not be (solely?) a tomb, but a Near-Death Experience Simulator.[2018]

Sound is used to trigger ASCs or OBEs in consciousness research (recall the binaural beats Robert Monroe endorsed for facilitating out-of-body experiences). The connection suggests ancient monuments' acoustics were specifically designed to alter awareness, perhaps in conjunction with specific chants or drumming—an implication enriched by how often entity encounters and ASCs begin with buzzing, whistling, or humming noises.

The possibility is not new. All roads lead to John Keel, who hypothesized at length in *The Eight Tower* on the possible role of sound in paranormal encounters:

> Sound waves produce a variety of interesting effects on biological organisms, some of them similar to the effects of radio waves. A sound wave at just the right pitch can fill you with absolute terror even though you can't hear it. Ghosts, hairy monsters, and UFOs can apparently be accompanied by this kind of sound, creating unreasonable fear in humans and even stronger reactions in animals that can hear sounds that are beyond the range of human hearing. [2019]

These acoustic properties are not as yet widely documented at tumuli or ringforts, but we must ask if such sites once possessed infrastructure, since destroyed, enabling sound-induced ASCs. It seems reasonable that in some field somewhere, a farmer long ago laid the foundations of a pasture wall with the sonically-resonant stones of a long-demolished ringfort.

The stones within monuments might exhibit other attributes contributing to their paranormal reputation. As noted, some housed spirits of the dead or faeries, in addition to having their own souls in the animist perspective.[2020] That certain minerals facilitate window areas is the subject of longstanding conjecture—recall the "Stone Tape Theory" of hauntings—and to list every candidate is impossible. However, two materials warrant further consideration: quartz and limestone.

Quartz, long regarded as magical, may facilitate window areas via its *piezoelectrical* qualities, wherein energy is released under pressure. One theory is that quartz deposits underlying monuments generate bursts of energy or magnetism during tectonic stress, manifesting as ghost lights or even altering human perception (see Michael Persinger's work, discussed in

the next chapter). Quartz artifacts are regularly unearthed at Neolithic archaeological sites. Monuments like Cornwall's Duloe Stone Circle & the Nine Sisters[2021] and even Stonehenge contain high quartz content.[2022] The hewing of such stones may have amplified energies stored within. Rosemary Ellen Guiley speculated:

> The stones used in the construction of megalithic monuments, churches, holy wells, and temples were charged by handling and then fixed by being shaped with the blows of axes and chisels. The magnitude of the charge is thought to be related to the number of blows and the dimensions of the stones. Therefore, the charge of megaliths would be very great. Cremation pits and burials, such as those at Stonehenge; sacrificial pits and altars; and the burning of wood also fixed the charges.
>
> The very ground itself may be charged and fixed with blows. British folklore tells of the ancient custom of "beating the parish bounds," in which the church priest and choirboys would go around the parish perimeter beating the ground with rods. Most likely, this was believed to erect a protective energy barrier around the parish.[2023]

Many Old and New World monuments are built not from quartz but limestone, an underappreciated candidate for generating paranormal activity. Limestone appears extensively not only in ringfort construction but at American mounds as well, sometimes in layers. As a porous mineral, some suggest limestone "absorbs and releases electromagnetic and psychic energies."[2024] Illinois folklore even suggests limestone harvested from quarries in Lemont generates hauntings wherever it is used.[2025]

The mineral presents robust connections to faeries. Polynesian kakamora once rescued a sinking island with a limestone pillar,[2026] and oil from Welsh limestone is sometimes called "faerie butter."[2027] Its physical creation is its most intriguing aspect, however.

Limestone, which includes chalk, is primarily calcium carbonate, a compound appearing in living organisms as eggshells, snail shells, pearls, and seashells. In other words, *limestone is a dead medium*, perhaps bringing with it energy from dead organisms. Since limestone and seashells contain the same building blocks, American mounds layered with seashells—a common technique—might have the same paranormal qualities as more advanced structures built from limestone. This is certainly suggested by Florida's Old Connor Library, mentioned above.

In fact, this layering may be key in attracting paranormal phenomena. Time-and-again New World sites reveal symmetrical strata of soil, rock, and organic material, often brought from afar. Like Old World megaliths imported from distant quarries, these organic layers were sometimes obtained at great apparent effort, evidenced by seashells' appearance in mounds far inland.[2028] While ringforts are less deliberately layered, many nonetheless present levels of *humus*, or decomposed organic soil, sandwiched between their stonework.[2029] Other monuments like Silbury Hill are more clearly composed of alternating organic and inorganic strata.[2030]

In short, they resemble orgone accumulators.

“Primal crumpled strata”:

Orgone energy

The concept of “orgone” originates in the work of Austrian psychiatrist Wilhelm Reich, who claimed a “primordial cosmic energy” existed in all living things and could be harnessed via “orgone energy accumulators.” These devices supposedly concentrate life energy by trapping it within a metal box surrounded by organic material, holding a charge akin to Leyden jars. According to Reich, this controversial method displayed demonstrable physical and therapeutic benefit to his patients, but was met with strong criticism, further sullied by the sexual overtones in his work.[2031] Because of Reich’s research, the overlapping strata found within tumuli have been posited as a paranormal attractor, but—as with every paranormal theory—this fails to fully account for outliers, including non-layered sites or natural hills like Glastonbury Tor, which still draw in the supernatural.

Today, Reich’s champions contend his orgone theory presents some value, as well as its applied use in what Reich dubbed “cloudbusters,” a series of hollow metal tubes aimed into the air, grounded in a source of orgone energy such as a body of water. Reich claimed these devices encouraged rainfall in drought-stricken areas, but noted an unintended side effect: they allegedly attracted UFOs.[2032]

“Many Earth mysteries writers, including myself, have noted the similarity between the principles of Wilhelm Reich’s orgone energy and the

construction of prehistoric earthen mounds," wrote long-time researcher, historian, and author Andrew Collins. "Like the orgone accumulator, Bronze Age barrows are sometimes constructed from alternating layers of organic and inorganic materials, usually organically-rich soil and chalk. Could it be possible that the manifestation of mysterious lights in the vicinity of round barrows—such as those on Overton Hill just outside of Avebury—has something to do with their earthen composition?"[2033]

“This place could be no ordinary city”:

Siting monuments

The most potent factor in siting ancient monuments may be the old realtors’ adage: location, location, location. The tendency for UFOs to appear both around cloudbusters and bodies of water, coupled with the ubiquity of rivers, lakes, etc. in the proximity of tumuli, gives one pause.

As with mineral deposits, some point to water as a primary paranormal motivator, to varying degrees of persuasion. Like the defensibility afforded by hilltops and circular earthworks, practical reasons should not be overlooked—waterways were essential for ancient humans’ survival. That being said, a striking number of haunted locations and window areas feature bodies of water.

One oft-cited “correlation” claims underground rivers run beneath paranormal locales. We find Catholic cathedrals and holy sites like Lourdes arising near or atop springs once associated with faeries (which could “very often be considered as aquatic spirits,” Lecouteux noted).[2034] Silbury Hill is speculated as the holy site of a river cult,[2035] and Brú na Bóinne is named for the bend of the River Boyne in which it rests. New World mounds like Etowah and Ocmulgee share names with rivers a stone’s throw away. Tennessee’s Old Stone Fort juts out upon a peninsula.[2036]

Waterways at Native American sites typically lie east of their earthworks.[2037] If not for protection against humans, their proximity to water indicates which spirits were welcomed: while defenseless against sky or (obviously) water spirits, earth and human spirits were widely believed unable to cross water, like Old World faeries.[2038]

At Fort Center, Florida, the Woodland tradition dug a pond, above which a charnel platform was erected, "apparently to isolate the bodies of a group whose power was so strong that it was deemed necessary to utilize a water barrier for protection." Water's availability was also useful for purification rituals,[2039] and "facilitated the departure of Sky spirits, speeding them across the log bridge to the Milky Way Trail, as they crossed water in pursuit of the Fire in the Sky."[2040]

The astronomical position of ancient monuments bears repeating, if for no other reason than to counter "ancient alien" impulses. Long before outer space became a ripe target for Manifest Destiny 2.0, before science fiction appropriated mankind's magical thinking, the sky didn't simply represent the afterlife—it *was* the afterlife. Even today we cannot shake this conflation, treating the stars as a secular stand-in for heaven. We populate space with extraterrestrials just as we once did spirits. If employing actual contact as a metric for accurate interpretation, surely our ancient concepts, replete with spirit interactions through altered states of consciousness, present a more successful track record than our current methodology of blasting antiquated radio waves into an empty, unanswering void.

Herein lies the fundamental misinterpretation, so simply articulated by Jeffrey Kripal: "The gods were not ancient aliens. The aliens are modern

gods. This modern magic and these modern gods, of course, are likely not what they appear to be either."[2041]

That our astronauts find no evidence of spirits in orbit should be no more surprising than an archaeologist's failure to find nûñnë'hï at Nǐkwǎsĭ'—the wrong methodology is in place, the wrong questions asked.

"Prehistoric flights through cosmic space":

Reviving the Neolithic Space Program

Any one of these factors—architecture, materials, construction, location—may power these beacons or, alternatively, multiple factors may combine for additive effect. For instance, perhaps solely limestone deposits in significant concentration can draw in the paranormal; perhaps a lesser concentration, combined with burials, spirit-conducive architecture, stored orgone energy, and accurate stellar alignment can "break through" the threshold to the ecology of souls. The veil sufficiently thinned, souls could then transition to the afterlife, or shamans—prototypical psychonauts—could rocket into the Otherworld to commune with the divine, aided by labyrinthine darkness and aural stimuli, fueled by entheogen consumption.

Levenda wrote "… the orientation of the various Hopewell mounds… facilitated the transport of the souls of the dead to the Afterlife, which, in this case as in the case of ancient China, ancient Egypt, etc., meant outer space. In other words, the Hopewell mounds (and, perhaps the Adena mounds as well) were a type of machine, a technology for extraterrestrial travel. And the travel could go both ways."[2042] Spirits still send envoys, whether we do or not. Perhaps it is time to revive the Neolithic Space Program.[2043]

It is difficult to more elegantly eulogize ringforts, megaliths, stone circles, cairns, passage tombs, burial mounds, and other tumuli than Service and Bradbery, who concluded:

> …in their orientation—first on the rising of the new-born sun at the dead of winter, then on the other turning points of the year, and much longer cycles… recall us to the cyclical rhythms of life.
>
> These great structures were built to enhance very special places on the earth's surface, where a force or current works to make this expansion of consciousness more intense… They may encourage us in our labyrinthine journeys into darkness. Each of these journeys is a kind of death, and we can find in the megaliths reassurance of our coming back into the light, reborn, transformed, so that in ourselves we resolve and integrate light and dark, masculine and feminine, each of us the Axis Mundi, joining Heaven and Earth again.[2044]

One factor withheld from our discussion may have a greater impact upon window areas than any other. It is time to follow arcane paths—the death roads—wherever they lead.

9

DEATH ROADS

OBJ



Ancient monuments may not generate unexplained phenomena as much as they capitalize upon pre-existing supernatural tendencies embedded in the landscape. In other words, they are not erected randomly but rather at very specific locations; window areas precede them, rather than form around them, a useful perspective when considering zones of High Strangeness lacking significant archaeological sites.

Beyond their stellar orientation and proximity to water, historians long ago noticed sacred sites seem to align with one another. While straight lines can obviously be drawn between any two points, the incidence of three or more along a singular pathway raises profound implications. Western antiquarians noted the correlation as early as 1846, when Reverend Edward Duke observed the alignment of medieval churches and prehistoric monuments.[2045]

The idea appeared sporadically in England as well as Germany until 1921, when Alfred Watkins, a Herefordshire businessman, "conceived the notion of the Old Straight Track, a network of completely straight roads used by traders and travelers in early England and aligned through a variety of prehistoric, Roman and medieval monuments," wrote Ronald Hutton. "To these he gave, with some doubts, the name 'leys'" in his 1925 book *The Old Straight Track.*[2046]

Dead straight

Watkins's ley line concept—explored more later—is neither new, solely English, nor even exclusively Western. The 12th century Irish myth "The Drunkenness of the Ulstermen" implies a straight line connecting the Giant's Sconce (the fortress Dún Ceithirn), Navan, and Tara, an assertion confirmed by modern surveying techniques.[2047] Stone walls and long, linear earthworks called cursuses, some stretching six miles, dot Ireland and the British Isles, often within sight of other monuments.[2048]

Residents of modern Neman, Russia (once eastern Prussia) spoke of *Leichenflugbahn*, the "corpse flightpath" between cemeteries, upon which no home should be built.[2049] A Viking processional road at Rösaring, Sweden runs "dead straight" for a third of a mile, and atop the Wurmberg—Germany's "Dragon Mountain"—sits a monument known as the *Steinweg*, a straight cobbled road terminating in a *kist*, a series of stones arranged like a small coffin.[2050]

Predictably, Eastern cultures adopted similar ideas at immeasurable time-depths. The Chinese described *lung mei* or "dragon paths," geodetic grids of invisible power crisscrossing the Earth which dictated where buildings should be erected, lest they fall prey to ill luck.[2051] Similar thinking informed the position of one's possessions in the home through *feng shui,* or the curving of Chinese roofs and roads, since evil spirits fly in straight lines.[2052]

Equally old or older, legends of Australian creator deities tell how they narrated their journey across the new Earth with songs, leaving behind landmarks before becoming geographical features themselves after The Dreaming. The aborigines still refer to these routes as "songlines," to which they attribute their uncanny navigation skills and their shamans' ability to transfer information at great distances.[2053] Similar lines are crucial to Māori cosmology.[2054]

New World earthworks seem guided by similar principles. Paths in the Amazon Basin exhibit an almost inconvenient, "unusual straightness," leading archaeologist William Denevan to speculate they served a ritual significance, as ancient stone paths do among northern Colombia's Kogi. Mayan roads running "straight as arrows"—*sacbeob*, "white ways"—link sacred sites in areas of Guatemala, Belize, El Salvador, Honduras, and southeastern Mexico, interspersed with altars along the way. Similar roads, "almost airline in their directness… in spite of topographic obstacles," appear in the western United States. A "dead-straight" ancient road in Ohio connects the 60 miles between Hopewell sites at Newark and Chillicothe.[2055]

It is disingenuous to relegate these correlations to "coincidence" and simply move on, yet this is historically the position adopted by archaeologists. They scoff at modern "Earth Mysteries" researchers who speak of "earth currents," "rivers of energy," or "power lines." This stance displays a curious cognitive dissonance, as even conventional explanations for these roads require academics to engage with indigenous belief systems —namely shamanism, as explained later.

Instead, exploration of these anomalies falls upon esoteric researchers using both scientific tools and reliable folk methods such as dowsing. A number of plausible scenarios have emerged from decades of study, including the notion that ancient peoples erected sacred sites and straight roads after detecting natural currents within the Earth. Many researchers wisely abstain from declaring whether such natural phenomena merely generate hallucinations or actively draw in genuine paranormal activity.

Noting this trend, researchers have attempted several longitudinal studies of megaliths and the like, including Paul Devereux's Dragon Project. Beginning with scientific investigation in 1977, the project moved into more esoteric realms ten years later, monitoring dreams of volunteers at prehistoric sites. While tantalizing clues suggested natural anomalies at these locations, all appeared inconclusive… yet reports of High Strangeness endure.[2056]

Unashamedly following the data wherever it leads, Devereux is less shy about the Fortean application of his work than other researchers. Embodied within ley lines and straight pathways, he perceives an age-old, universal tradition: death roads.

Who roves there?

In his book *Haunted Land: Investigations into Ancient Mysteries and Modern Day Phenomena* (which, along with his *Spirit Roads*, constitutes essential reading) Devereux wrote:

> The concept of the death road in Indo-European cultures goes back at least to Anatolia (Turkey) of the second millennium BC, where a cuneiform inscription refers to 'the great road—the road that makes things disappear—'in a funerary context… The image of such a road was maintained in Indo-European tradition in varying forms right through to the mediaeval period. So the dead walking paths to the otherworld is a deeply embedded psychic motif, an archetype itself, and this could be why roads feature so prominently in the haunted land."[2057]

Like other archetypes, the road to the Otherworld emerges tangibly in our reality. Throughout Europe, funeral processions took the same roads for centuries from communities to burial sites, paths perhaps used even earlier by their ancestors. In England, these "corpse roads" may go by many names: bier roads, coffin lines, burial roads, lyke or lych ways (*liches* being "corpse" in Old English), or, stretching into Saxon times, *deada waeg*. Uniformly-straight *doodwegen* ("deathroads") transport the Dutch dead, "Mass roads" the Irish dead, a *kirchweg* or *kirkweg* ("church way") the German dead.[2058] In multiple European countries, moving corpses in anything

but straight lines was illegal, perhaps from whence we derived the phrase "dead straight."[2059]

Robust superstitions arose around death roads. In Germany, for instance, they were the same route the living took to church, avoiding farmers' fields and detouring across water to corral dead souls and prevent their contamination of crops. They were not to be obstructed for any reason.[2060]

Like Mayan sacbeob, European death roads often featured stations at which rituals were performed or coffins were rested. Souls not conveyed by these roads might return to haunt the living.[2061] We may therefore infer in their straightness—a tendency, not a rule—a desire to allow dead souls a degree of free passage, but many death roads throughout Europe were still regarded as haunted.[2062] Tangles of thread, "spirit traps," were sometimes strategically placed "to snare flitting phantoms."[2063] Recall how labyrinths hinder spirit movement; near the aforementioned straight Viking road at Rösaring, a maze intertwines the burial cairns.[2064]

When the dead did roam, they often followed such well-trodden pathways, sometimes gathering in their own Mass, described in texts from the 500s.[2065] Processions of the dead occur regularly in folklore as phantom armies marching across battlefields, especially in European Christian belief from around the 11th century, where they sometimes emerged from mountains.[2066] These were often sinners doomed to wander the land, seeking release from their mobile purgatory through the prayers of the living.[2067]

As ever, we find conflation between non-human spirits and the dead. By the 13th century the retinue was alternately accompanied by demons or the marchers were demons themselves, disguised as human souls, reflecting "an

ancient, pre-Christian, fear of the dead seen as mere objects of terror, as unrelenting maleficent entities without the possibility of any sort of expiation," as historian Carlo Ginzburg phrased it. In the 16th century, these processions became seasonal, "especially common in midwinter, or during the four annual sets of feasts called the Ember Days."[2068]

The trajectories taken by the dead are often as straight as the death roads themselves. German *Geisterwege*, the paths of ghosts, were "always in the same place," and ran "in a straight line over the mountains and valley and through marshes." Such travels were occasionally accompanied by a hissing sound.[2069] The motif of ghosts traveling straight lines is even seen in modern hauntings, where spirits' pathways are often "set" as they travel through obstacles like walls, or walk along nonexistent floors long-since removed.

These paths naturally recall faeries, the Breton ankou, and ghost lights, all of which travel death roads nightly, mirroring funeral processions and often presaging death (as demonstrated in Chapters 2 and 4). Yet daytime sightings of faeries also occur along these thoroughfares: a Dartmoor witness on her way to Haytor on "a hot day" rested upon a death road's coffin station, only to be resentfully observed at length by a short, elderly figure who eventually disappeared. Other funeral practices linking death roads and faeries include the circumambulation of faerie thorns on the way to cemeteries, or the lowering of crosses as processions pass faerie trees and bushes.[2070]

Other faerie pathways existed either above, below, or upon the countryside, often spanning between faerie forts or other monuments.[2071] So fond of roving were some that Yeats divided faeries into "solitary" and

"trooping" varieties, the latter including Chapter 4's faerie rades (Briggs later suggested "domesticated faeries," a third category for household spirits).

Witnesses might see grand parades of fae folk on horseback, a small band of diminutive marchers, or earthbound or aerial lights: a mid-20th century County Sligo witness bicycling the Backagh road beheld "a big light… high up in the sky… All the people that saw it say that it is the fairies moving from one fort to the other."[2072] Roving nocturnal faeries are also noted in New World belief, demonstrated by the close association between Hawaiian menehune and Nightmarchers (ghosts of revered ancient warriors), or tales of Cherokee Little People tromping noisily through southeastern American forests.[2073]

Like German death roads, the paths of trooping faeries are inviolable, evidenced by their unimpeded travel across uneven terrain or even through structures. Cumbria's steep and rocky Soutra Fell hosted several phantom parades in the mid-1700s, including horses impossibly sure-of-foot, unnaturally swift, carrying carriages up rockfaces yet leaving no impressions behind.[2074]

It remains unclear whether such faerie paths are straight or circuitous. Despite an account from Evans Wentz where faeries circle around bushes, Devereux favors the former, claiming "virtually all the (admittedly sparse) evidence suggests that fairy tracks were straight."[2075]

The Irish were more concerned about structures intersecting faerie paths. Before building anything, seers were consulted or sod was overturned—if tampered with the following morning, the site was along a faerie path, and

another location should be chosen.[2076] Anyone foolish enough to bypass or ignore such tests found their buildings cursed.

"It is considered unlucky to make noise, speak profanely, or to disturb these paths by littering or building on them," wrote Jenny Butler of Irish faerie routes. "Sickness and even the death of the occupants of a house built on such a path is believed to result, and similar explanations are given for a byre roof caving in or other mishaps with outhouses constructed on a fairy path."[2077]

In one example from 1935, Michael O'Hagan accidentally obstructed a path between two Irish ringforts with a house addition. All five of his children fell ill, one almost dying, without apparent cause. A consultation with a wise woman revealed the source of O'Hagan's misfortune, and "the new building was pulled down and the children straightaway recovered."[2078]

To appease the fae folk, builders could also remove the offending portion of a structure. Even today, flattened or rounded corners on Irish buildings can be seen where only a portion of a structure impeded faerie travel and was amended. Such simple corrections dispelled the bad luck and poltergeist phenomena caused by blocking trooping faeries.[2079] One half-wonders whether masons, down on their luck, fell in league with the Good Folk.

This gesture not only brings to mind the previous chapter's assertion that spirits can become caught in corners, but also appears in the Japanese *kimon*, or "demon gate," which allows evil spirits access to homes. Located on a structure's unlucky northeastern corner, belief in the kimon precludes the construction of doors and windows on its associated side, and bad luck befalls those disregarding tradition.[2080]

"Traditionally, many buildings in Japan have been erected with some sort of odd irregularity towards the northeast," explained Japanese folklorist Donny Kimball. "In many cases, this peculiarity takes the form of an L-shaped indentation that is said to keep out the *oni* and other spirits. If you look carefully, you can see that the Kyoto Imperial Palace has notched corners on the northeastern exterior."[2081]

Ghost riders in the sky

On the night of a full moon—or close to it—in autumn 1995, Barbara Fisher and her husband were snapped fully awake from the verge of sleep by the sound of multiple horses' hooves running through their Athens, Ohio yard. Who would be out riding so late? Both rushed to the window to survey the moonlit backyard, where they expected to see several horsemen.

"We could hear bridles jingling, we could hear the squeak of saddles, we could hear the horses' hooves, but we heard no human sounds," said Fisher, who hosts the *6 Degrees of John Keel* podcast. "We didn't see anything," despite excellent visibility and the proximity of the sounds "going right past the window." They even noted the Doppler effect as the phantom riders departed. Her husband was especially affected by the sound of the tack, having spent time with horses before. "He *knows* those sounds," Fisher added. "It was clearly riders." Upon investigating the next day, Fisher only found a solitary hoofprint surrounded by yards of untouched mud.[2082]

"Once upon a time there was a phenomenon that fueled local gossip continuously," wrote Lecouteux. "During the long winter nights a strange and unidentified troop could be heard passing outside, over the land or through the air. Anyone caught by surprise in the open fields or depths of the woods saw a bizarre procession of foot soldiers and knights, some covered in blood and others carrying their heads beneath their arms… This was the Wild or Infernal Hunt, the host of the damned…."[2083]

Folklore describes the Wild Hunt as a terrifying supernatural chase of spirits across northern Europe, particularly Germanic countries. As with so many legends, it remains generalizable only in broad strokes, answering to countless names: Germany's *Wilde Jagd,* Scandinavia's *Åsgårdsreia,* England's *Herlaþing,* Wales's *Cŵn Annwn*, the Slavic *divoký hon*. Depending upon the culture, it is composed of the dead, wandering souls of the living, Valkyries, fae folk, demons, spectral hounds, or any combination therein. Many lead this phantom army of the night, from historical figures and folk heroes to gods and psychopomps.

The Hunt presents a few universal consistencies, including its proclivity for abducting the living or the dead to the Otherworld. It is also boasts a consistent reputation as a harbinger of doom great and small, warning of plagues and war, or death and madness. Any encounter with the Hunt might leave an individual diseased, blinded, bedridden, or worse.[2084]

An Irish farmer told Lady Gregory he heard "in the air the sound of an army marching, and the drums beating" which hovered over the house of a sick girl who died that night. "They could see no one, but could hear the drums and the marching plain enough, and there were like little flames of lightning playing about it."[2085]

The appearance of light phenomena is another Hunt hallmark, drawing upon earlier conflations of ghost lights with evil spirits. For instance, bright lights seen above Germany circa 1850-1860 were regarded as "the Devil's Army."[2086] Sulpicius Severus's account of a monastery, invaded by "invisible demons" circa the late 4th century, described "numerous lights… glittering as

well as a dull sound of many people going to and fro, and the murmur of many voices." [2087]

These sounds, characteristic of a marching army, were another signifier of the Hunt. Witnesses reported "a rushing roar in which can be heard the neighing of horses, human cries and hunting horns."[2088] Other frequent noises included anomalous music, jingling bells or bridles, growling, or whistling, sometimes the only indication of the Hunt's invisible presence.[2089]

Scholars like Ronald Hutton have recently questioned whether the Wild Hunt as we know it today represents a continuation of actual pagan belief or instead a post-Christian pastiche. In 1835, folklorist Jacob Grimm described three variants: a supernatural woman leading female spirits, joined by the living; a solitary phantom huntsman, otherworldly, demonic, or cursed; and processions of the purgatorial dead. Only the first appears pre-Christian, Hutton argues, rendering erroneous any treatment of the Wild Hunt as primarily pagan.[2090]

Co-Creation Theory may render this controversy moot. For our purposes, we focus primarily upon the Wild Hunt's connections to the dead and their roads.

Hunters & the hunted

"In one way or another, the Wild Hunt fell into the vast complex of ancestor worship, the cult of the dead, who are the go-betweens between man and the gods," Lecouteux wrote.[2091] It is a tired story: a simple belief (the wandering, nocturnal dead) retrofitted with Christian baggage, transforming the entire concept into a highly dogmatized tradition of souls—unbaptized or unrepentant, killed violently or prematurely—desperately seeking expiation through the living's intercessory prayers.

If ever a pagan basis for the Wild Hunt as an army of the dead existed, it became, in essence, a mobile purgatory among Christians. A few examples:

- In one of the earliest recorded instances, a French priest named Walchelin allegedly saw an "Infernal Hunt" circa 1092 which included a club-wielding giant and "many of his fellow villagers who had died recently… lamenting the fact that they were in torment because of their sins." Among them was his deceased brother.[2092]

- Wrote Hutton, "the German chronicler Ekkehard von Aura recorded under the year 1123 a host of dead knights roaming the province of Worms, tortured for their sins by red-hot arms and armour, and needing prayers and alms to deliver them; while a monastic text from Alsace told of the apparition of two hordes of the dead, one destined for heaven but wandering awhile to atone for sins, and another bound for hell because they were knights who had died without penance."[2093]

- The Hunt sometimes appeared in conjunction with poltergeist activity, as in the 1135 case of a "knocking ghost" who revealed itself as a dead family member. He confessed to joining "a wicked throng," begging his relatives, "So that I may leave the pernicious road they travel and fully enjoy eternal rest, please celebrate a Mass for me tomorrow…."[2094]

- A tale of the mid 12th century describes "a crowd of people passing through the air," including the witness's father, "doomed to roam" until their earthly wrongs were righted.[2095]

- A 1508 sermon by Strasbourg preacher Johann Geiler alludes to the postmortem fate of France's King Charles V, who wandered with "the Wild Army" before finally finding redemption "thanks to the prayers of St. Denis."[2096]

- In 1516, historian Jacques Trausch described a phantom army of 50-200 members which "hastens through the fields" and towns of France, "playing drums and fifes," their wounds corresponding to "the manner in which each found his death in battle." They carried bright candles. "A man always preceded them, ceaselessly shouting, 'Make way, lest you suffer!'"[2097]

- In 1539 Nuremburg cobbler Hans Sachs heard distant horns, accompanied by "a loud and tempestuous wind" heralding the arrival of "the atrocious and horrible Furious Army," populated by more than three hundred dead miscreants. Sachs supposedly saw one of their number earlier that day executed at a hanging.[2098]

- Denmark's *knarkevognen*, an aerial ghost cart reminiscent of the ankou's wagon, was a death omen which became part of Wild Hunt tradition circa 1450. Elsewhere in Scandinavia, Christmas traditions supplicating nocturnal hosts of the dead with food were incorporated into the Hunt as well.[2099]

Like death roads and faerie paths, there was a degree of predictability to when—certain feast day evenings and old pagan holidays—and where the procession appeared, traversing "the same lines across the country, not always straight but often between ancient monuments and landmarks."[2100] Along the Swiss-German border, the Hunt always traveled 15 miles from Banholz Forest, ending at Veringenstadt.

Again, these ways were typically fixed, sometimes following ancient Roman roads, as seen in Stuttgart. "Definite paths" were used by the Hunt in Swabia.[2101] In Devon, a phantom hearse or coach piloted by none other than the ghost of privateer Sir Francis Drake "tears across the countryside from Tavistock to Plymouth in Devon, accompanied by demons and headless black dogs."[2102]

"So specific were the routes of the Hunt that some houses were known to stand in its way—a house in Crailsheim had this misfortune, for instance," wrote Devereux. "The only thing for the dweller to do in such circumstances was to open the doors and windows at the times the Hunt was due to pass through."[2103] Reports of broken and bent trees between castles Schnellert and Rodenstein were attributed to the Hunt as late as 1850.[2104]

There exists some disagreement on how often the Hunt was airborne. Some contend "the Hunt involves not incorporeal ghosts but revenants who possess actual bodies, and it travels more often over the ground than through the air."[2105] Yet the Hunt seems neither solely earthbound nor airborne, instead flying from destination to destination through the air "until its next touchdown."[2106]

In one tale circa 1570, a young girl encountered a "Furious Army" led by an evil huntsman who tried to capture her. "A lone soldier" thwarted the attempt by tracing a protective circle around the girl and striking her attacker with his sword, sending "the huntsman and his entire retinue… into the air with a great din of jangling and shouts."[2107]

Strong associations between violent weather and the Hunt's constituents further solidified aerial impressions. When not dead souls, it included Valkyries, demons, spirits, or faeries, all known for traveling on storms and wind.[2108]

Some more recent witnesses even explicitly saw the Hunt flying across the sky. A pair of Irish witnesses walking from Ballyallinan in 1884 "heard the cry, 'tally-ho'… to their surprise, it was the dead hunt, and they saw the huntsmen and hounds and horses, in the sky. They began to be afraid, so they separated."[2109]

"Complementing the male companies of embodied dead warriors who wandered the earth were companies of female spirits who flew through the skies," wrote Caciola. "The latter often were known as the 'good things' (*bonae res*). They were led by a feminine deity identified by a wide variety of names, depending upon the author and context of the report."[2110]

The leader of the pack

The Wild Hunt's iterations are best understood by their leaders. Despite the Christian overtones of its core element—the army of the unshriven dead—the Hunt is often led by pagan figures, further vilifying the Hunt in Christian eyes. If any truth lies behind these leaders' identities, it implies a phenomenon capable of reflecting cultural expectations.

Quite often, this spectral horde's leader was a generalized huntsman or noble, sometimes a man who had long ago sold his soul to the devil, or transgressed his faith by hunting on a Sunday. Truly, there is no rest for the wicked.

"In France there was Le Grand Veneur, who haunted the wood round Fontainebleau," wrote T.C. Croker. "In Germany, Hackelberg, who gave up his share of heaven for permission to hunt till doomsday; in Sleswick, king Abel; in the Danish islands, Græn Jette, who rides with his head under his arm; Palna Jager, and king Wolmar, or Waldemar: this last monarch also hunts in Jutland, where he may be heard continually crying out, *Hei! Hou! Lystig! Courage!* which are the names of his four hounds."[2111]

As Caciola notes, tradition sometimes specified the Wild Hunt as led by women. These figures often contrasted the evil, even demonic, masculine dead.

"As early as 1319 in the French Pyrenees, a local magician examined by an inquisitor claimed to have gained his knowledge by traveling with 'the good ladies and the souls of the dead', to visit clean and orderly homes with both," Hutton wrote. "A woman questioned by the same churchman asserted that the 'good ladies' who traveled by night were former rich and powerful women who were punished for their sins by being compelled to wander by demons."[2112]

The Hunt was sometimes headed by the goddess Diana: Hellenistic patroness of hunters, Faerie Queen, leader of witches, dancer among dead ladies.[2113] In German lands this might be Selga or Selda,[2114] also called Frau Saelde, equally associated with witchcraft. A Celtic crone figure, Nicnevin, "led the Hallowmas Rades" on Samhain. Variations of the Norse Hunt followed Reisarova on Yuletide storms, her company tossing saddles onto the roofs of those soon to die.[2115] Other characters include Bensozia, Satia, or variations on Perchta, discussed shortly.[2116] From Hutton:

> It seems as if two different earlier traditions, of women who joined night rides with a superhuman female, and superhuman females who visited houses to bless them, were now merging. Another famous French source of the thirteenth century, the courtly poem Roman de la Rose, cites the same tradition, concerning those who followed 'Lady Habonde'. It called her entourage 'the good ladies' and stated that it roved on three nights of each week, accompanied by humans whose spirits flew out to them while their bodies remained in bed: it was said that every third child born had this gift. The 'lady' and her companions were themselves spirits, who could get into and out of houses through any crack and so were never obstructed by locks or bars.[2117]

(Hutton believes this blending indicates outdated, romantic ideas that all pagan worship was fertility-driven. While the dead were tied to fertility in a general sense, connections between the Hunt and fertility appear poorly supported.)[2118]

Another female figure, Herodias, princess of the Herodian dynasty, led the Hunt in Guernsey and Spain as posthumous punishment. Her appearance alludes to the frequent attribution of negative Biblical figures driving the phantom army like Cain, King Herod Antipas, Pontius Pilate, the devil himself,[2119] or "the Wandering Jew" (a figure from a grotesque medieval legend condemned to wander until the Second Coming for denying Christ the chance to rest His cross on the way to Calvary).[2120]

On the other hand, legendary historic figures—a few cruel noblemen notwithstanding—were put in charge of the Hunt because they were well-regarded, driving the host with righteous fury. This trend appears in Denmark, where Valdemar IV Atterdag, 14th century king who restored the country from bankruptcy, led the Hunt.[2121] In Italy, the Hunt was led by Ostrogoth ruler Theodoric the Great.[2122] Adoration of King Arthur placed him at the front of the horde in Brittany and England.

On certain nights "the ghostly hoofbeats of Arthur and his knights can be heard galloping over the summit [of Glastonbury Tor] and out through the ancient southwest gateway," Devereux wrote. On the opposite side lay "traces of an ancient trackway… called Arthur's Lane or Hunting Causeway." In midwinter, "the sound of riders and hounds can be heard passing along it," with occasional sightings of "ghostly horsemen with small flames dancing around the tips of their upraised lances." Devereux sees a connection

between this myth and death roads: "Does this local legend of the Wild Hunt embody a deep memory of the journey of the dead to Avalon?"[2123]

When hailed, Arthur's company is more congenial than other Wild Hunt incarnations: "We are King Arthur and his kindred!" they shout.[2124] As an archetype, Arthur is well-suited to accompany a dead army. His reputation for defeating death enmeshes him in a continuity spanning from Osiris to Odin to Christ. His wife's name, Guinevere, means "White Phantom or White Apparition, in harmony with Arthur's line of descent from the region of phantoms and apparitions and fairy-folk." He was born of the Otherworld —"his own father, Uthr Bendragon [Uther Pendragon], was a king of Hades"—and to the Otherworld he returned.[2125] Some legends describe him as never dying, instead carried away by faeries "into some pleasant place, where he should remaine for a time, and then returne againe and reign in as great authority as ever."[2126]

A circuitous etymological path connects Arthur and the Wild Hunt with the harlequin archetype, *commedia dell'arte*'s checkered, masked clown. Walchelin's aforementioned sighting of the Infernal Hunt includes the remark, "Without a doubt, this is the retinue of Herlequin [familia Herlechini]," referring to the club-wielding giant leading the procession.[2127] Variations like "the Hellequin," *Herlething*, and *Mesnée d'Hellequin* became synonymous with the Wild Hunt.[2128]

As the Hunt was often filled with demons—mischievous trickster figures—these names found their way into the pens of medieval poets like Dante Alighieri. Dante derivatively dubbed a devil in his *Inferno* "Alichino," a corruption of the Italian word for "harlequin," *Arlecchino*. Dramatists followed

suit, including demonic tricksters in their plays, devils who in turn evolved into prankish humans, the harlequins and modern clowns of today. Coulrophobes take note: clowns not only display demonic roots but represent plague figures, their makeup forming rictus grins of the dead.[2129]

But why did Walchelin use the name "Herlequin" in the first place? "Herlechin or Hellequin likely derives from the Old High German *hari* ('troop, army') combined with *thing* (the assembly of arms-bearing free men in Germanic cultures)," Caciola wrote.[2130] The name also presents connections to King Herla, first mentioned in Chapter 4, who emerged from his parley with the dwarf king as a victim of missing time, doomed to remain in the saddle lest he crumble to dust, so riding with his army to this day.[2131]

"Though Herla is presented as the king of the Britons, his name is actually of Germanic origin, likely meaning 'war leader,' someone at the head of the *heer* or army," Caciola continues. "The relationship to Herlechin is evident." In both Arthur and Herla we see legendary British kings riding with their retinue between life and death after meeting the fae folk. As such, "Herla King"—harlequin—drives Herlaþing*,* "Herla's assembly," the Wild Hunt in Old English. [2132]

Herne the Hunter, another leader of the Wild Hunt, may also claim a similar origin. Besides resembling Herla in name, the Hunter, like Arthur, "is supposed to always appear in times of great national crisis, which he did in 1931 prior to the Depression and again before the start of World War II."[2133] Others suggest Herne is a Shakespearean fabrication from *The Merry Wives of Windsor,*[2134] or descends from another Wild Hunt leader: Odin.[2135]

Psychopomp & Circumstance

In early 1923, Carl Jung dreamed of a dark, primeval forest punctuated by "a piercing whistle" and "crashings in the underbrush," from which "a gigantic wolfhound with a fearful, gaping maw burst forth." The dream continued:

> …It tore past me, and I suddenly knew: the Wild Huntsman had commanded it to carry away a human soul. I awoke in deadly terror, and the next morning I received the news of my mother's passing… it was the Wild Huntsman… who hunted with his wolves that night—it was the season of Föhn storms in January. It was Wotan [Odin], the god of my Alemannic forefathers, who had gathered my mother to her ancestors…."[2136]

Jung's dream expresses the driving purpose behind many Wild Hunt legends: soul collection. Even the most genial invitation to ride with them was fraught with risk, their guests in danger of never returning. Those brave enough, as in the tale of "Wod, the Wild Huntsman," might meet the Hunt and find their cleverness rewarded with treasure.[2137]

"Conversely, offending the Wild Hunt might mean the person earning a more gruesome reward… other times the Hunt would turn on the individual and tear them to pieces," Daimler wrote.[2138] This death penalty is apparent in Dartmoor, where the Hunt rides about a crag called the Dewerstone.

One story from the area tells of an inebriated farmer who, encountering a hunter and hounds, engaged in playful conversation: "Had much luck—much sport? Give me a hare." The hunter tossed him a package. Unwrapping it by lantern near home, the farmer found inside "his own child dead." It immediately vanished as his servant approached, crying, "Sorry to tell you, farmer, but your poor little boy is dead."[2139]

In another regional tale, one of two children sleeping on a moor awoke to the sound of hooves. "Shall we take it?" a rider asked, receiving in response, "No, it will come of itself shortly." The sleeper was dead the next day.[2140]

Whether identified as the Wild Hunt or a faerie rade, these medieval rides primarily focused upon abduction and torment, typically targeting those the church considered wrongdoers, vulnerable, or "unsaved."[2141]

"Whilst humans found their sport in hunting animals, fairies would find their sport in claiming souls, denying them a place in heaven," wrote Pollyanna Jones. "Some believed that if an unbaptised child died they would be claimed by the fairies and become elves themselves."[2142]

Such unfortunate infants joined the riders forevermore or, more gruesomely, were collected by Hunt leaders like Herodias, "cut up into pieces, eaten, and gluttonously stuffed into the witches' stomachs" before being magically reconstituted and "returned to their cradles."[2143] In this, we might see shades of shamanic dismemberment, or Perchta's reputation as "belly-slitter," explored momentarily.

Fittingly, most leaders of the Wild Hunt were psychopomps. Some were literal giants, apparent in Walchelin's tale, or the testimony of Lady Gregory's Irish informant Thomas Brown, who described a friend's vision of "a great crowd" full of dead villagers and "one very big man, that seemed the master of them."[2144]

Other leaders appeared as gigantically-proportioned versions of established deities.[2145] The Breton ankou, whose death cart is essentially a proto-Wild Hunt, was strikingly tall and thin.[2146] Frau Perchta, the Teutonic soul collector mentioned briefly in Chapter 4, was a large beauty or crone in white, occasionally presenting oversized feet.[2147]

Perchta—also called *Percht, Bertha, Berta, Berchta, Holt, Holle, Hulda*, or (masculinized) *Berchtold* or *Berhtolt*—led the Wild Hunt at Christmastime in Germany. [2148] As Holda, she rode the beasts of the forest, over which she ruled.[2149] Like other female leaders of the Hunt, Perchta visited homes, collecting offerings left on *Perchten Tables*, a practice stretching into the early 20th century. These tables were named after her entourage, the Perchten—horned, hairy wild men[2150] related to *Krampus* and *Knecht Ruprecht*, another Wild Hunt leader.[2151] As noted earlier, Perchta was also attended by heimchin, the souls of unbaptized children turned into ghost lights.[2152]

"Frau Perchta bears another title, *The Christmas Belly Slitter*," wrote Timothy Renner, "for instead of leaving switches or coal to express her displeasure, Perchta would instead punish adults and children alike by ripping open their stomachs while they slept, filling them with dirt or refuse, and sewing them back up."[2153] These children, sometimes punished for not

completing their Christmas chores, would follow Perchta or her equivalent, Frau Holle, watering crops with their tears.[2154]

Grimm believed Frau Holle represented a "remembrance" of the wife of Odin, another psychopomp leader. Depending on the tradition, Odin led combinations of the dead, his ravens, his wolves, or his Valkyries on the Wild Hunt. Sometimes the winged warrior women crossed the sky leaderless in their search for slain heroes, attested in an Old Norse poem where a woman at sea watched as "lightning flashed above and the bolts struck their ships. They saw nine Valkyries riding in the sky…."[2155]

By far the Wild Hunt's most common leader was Odin, his manifestations displaying great variety. His attribution stretches from Germany (*de Wode tüt,* the Mecklenburg peasant whispers upon hearing the Hunt's dogs, "Odin drives") to Poland (*Wode jaget*, "Odin hunts") and Scandinavia (*Oden far forbi*, "Odin rides nearby").[2156] The retinue itself might be called Åsgårdsreia ("the Ride of Asgard") or *Oskoreia*, sometimes not led by Odin but rather the folk-hero Siegfried or a Percht-ish figure, Guro Rysserova.[2157]

In Småland it is believed when Odin's dogs tire he employs other psychopomp animals in the form of large birds. According to reports, he either rides on horseback or commands an ankou-like cart. The only real consistency of Odin's Hunts is their tendency to trace pre-determined, set paths which incinerate houses built upon them.[2158]

Odin's identity is equally fungible, referred to as Wotan, Woden, or Grutte Greybeard.[2159] In addition to his status as psychopomp, Odin can be viewed alternately as an archetypal wild man or huntsman, a perfect choice to sally forth and collect the dead. This quality likely inspired the litany of

"huntsmen" leading phantom armies, including Herne. Artistic depictions of Hunt leaders like Herne corroborate the connection, depicting him wearing stag's antlers, an animal closely associated with Odin, Diana, and death (see Chapter 2).[2160] We also live annually with a reminder of Odin's ride in the form of Santa Claus, supervisor of elves (the dead), his aerial pathway accompanied by deer and the Hunt's jingling bells.

Some contest Odin's status as a leader of the Wild Hunt. Hutton predictably cites this as another fallacy encouraged by Grimm,[2161] and even Lecouteux expresses doubt, as Odin was more often a solitary figure.[2162] In any case, if we are dealing with an actual, adaptable phenomenon, it is unsurprising the Hunt is more faithful to witness expectations than actual folklore.

In Wales, the leader of the Wild Hunt was either Herla or faerie psychopomp Gwyn ap Nudd. (Gwyn's service in the Wild Hunt should not be confused with *Gwydion fab Dōn*, another Welsh figure leading the army, perhaps identified with Odin.)[2163] In his capacity as huntsman, Gwyn "knows when and where all the great warriors fell," accompanied by his white, red-eared dogs, the cwn annwn, mentioned in Chapter 5.[2164]

The prevalence of dogs as death symbols, psychopomps, and faerie animals has been extensively established. In Wild Hunt testimony, their presence is often attested by barks and growls. These hounds either accompany a phantom army, a solitary huntsman, or rove on their own, seeking the recently deceased and those destined for death. More innocuously, they also signify impending storms. Some names, like "Wish

Hounds," hint at Odinic connections, *whist* being a Dartmoor word for "spooky," "derived from 'Wisc,' a regional name for Odin."[2165]

Another English iteration, "Gabriel Ratchets" or "Gabriel Hounds," alludes to the presence of the archangel—another psychopomp—leading the Wild Hunt.[2166] More often, the association was infernal, evidenced by the epithet "Devil's Dandy Dogs."[2167]

In 1127, English witnesses at a Peterborough monastery saw "a great number of huntsmen hunting. The huntsmen were black, huge, and hideous, and rode on black horses and on black he-goats, and their hounds were jet black, with eyes like saucers, and horrible… in the night the monks heard them sounding and winding their horns."[2168]

Both solitary spectral dogs and packs seem especially fond of congregating along death roads and, by extension, ley lines. In 1985's *Alien Animals*, Janet and Colin Bord provide 28 examples of monuments, churches, and landmarks along supposed leylines in Lincolnshire alone, each associated with black dogs.[2169] "Devon is said to harbour at least 50 Black Dog haunts" according to Devereux, many corresponding to roads and lanes. Richard Capel, a Cornish huntsman who supposedly sold his soul to the devil, was buried in 1677, yet roams on stormy nights with "phantom black hounds… out on the moor along the ancient Abbot's Way."[2170]

In Wales, these canines exhibited marvelous predictive capacities, as noted by Croker:

> One Thomas Phillips, of *Trelech* parish, heard those spiritual dogs, and the great dog sounding among them; and they went in a way which no corpse used to go; at which he wondered, as he knew they used to go only in the way in which the corpse was to go. Not long after, a woman, who came from another parish, that died at *Trelech*, was carried that way to her own parish-church to be buried, in the way in which those spiritual dogs seemed to hunt.[2171]

Other psychopomp animals are represented less prominently in Wild Hunt accounts. When not seeking human souls, the horde sometimes pursues animals, especially deer.[2172] Given the stag's psychopomp, faerie, and soul associations, it seems likely their quarry represents something more profound than venison; in some instances the German hunt seeks not animals, but *woodwives*, forest-dwelling fae folk.[2173]

On the other hand, horses, another psychopomp, occur with great frequency in Hunt narratives. When not astride beasts of the forest, riders appear on horseback, to the extent the equine-affiliated psychopomp goddess Epona is sometimes erroneously attributed as the original female leader of the Wild Hunt ("Epona is never shown with a retinue of followers," Hutton notes).[2174] The name of one Bavarian huntsman, *Rosswoderer*, may derive from *Ross* ("horse") and *Wotan* (Odin, anger, or the storm).[2175]

Faeries go a-hunting

While connections between faeries and the Wild Hunt have been noted, a few additional nuances are worth considering. Luminous phenomena, poltergeist activity, and detrimental side effects including death accompany both. Like Fairyland, Christianity deemed the Hunt a liminal purgatory zone for the unshriven dead, including unbaptized infants. Female Hunt leaders like Perchta were left offerings overnight reminiscent of those propitiating household faeries. As one sermon scolded, only "the foolish peasant women indeed believe that the ladies of the night and night-walking spirits visit their homes and they set a table for them."[2176]

In fact, it can be nigh-impossible to distinguish the Wild Hunt from faerie raids. The sound of an invisible army might indicate either, and both famously travel across the sky, often on storms. A striking specificity links the Hunt's jangling bridles to "the sound of bells" heard in some faerie sightings, to say nothing of bridles heard in invisible faerie processions.[2177] Music features in both phenomena, as well as whistling. Faeries near the Herefordshire border in Suckley make similar noises, "fly[ing] overhead at night… making whistling noises in the air."[2178]

The Hunt was sometimes explicitly composed of fae folk, to the degree that some believed "the faeries are announced by the messenger of the Mesnie Hellequin."[2179] The Scottish sluagh of Chapter 4—either malicious faeries, the unforgiven dead, or both—are, for all intents and purposes, a Wild Hunt.

The Orcadian Hunt was sometimes populated by their local faeries, the trow. In one tale, a man stepping out for fresh air was abducted by "a band of trows" flying on plant stems. The army alit upon the home of a woman in labor, intent upon abducting its residents if she went unblessed after sneezing three times; luckily, someone inside sained her and the plan was thwarted.[2180]

Perhaps the easiest way to differentiate faerie rades and cavalcades from Wild Hunts is to identify their leaders, but even this proves difficult. For instance, Perchta doesn't exhibit a strong faerie affiliation until one considers the links between her alias Hulda and Scandinavian faeries like huldufólk and *huldra*. The goddess *Abundia* (Diana), with whom Perchta is conflated, was also demoted to a faerie queen in the form of *Habundia*, Queen of White Ladies[2181] and Water Spirits.[2182] *Gurorysse*, another goddess leading the Norwegian Hunt, derives her name from the region's long-tailed, hooved *gurri* faerie.[2183] Regarding masculine leaders, some perceive a link between the harlequin and the *erlking*, the faerie king whose kidnapping exploits were immortalized in legend, poetry, and song.[2184]

Wild Hunts also display faeries' capricious morality. The razor's edge upon which their reward or punishment sits perfectly reflects the attitude of the fae folk. Compare the rough faerie division of the Scottish Seelie and Unseelie Courts to the dualism of the Wild Hunt's feminine, blessed host and its masculine, furious army.

Like faeries, the Hunt can exhibit a magnanimous fairness. Some versions, as attested by Jacques Trausch above, are preceded by a warning figure, the

Eckhart, an old Germanic spirit who advises the departure of those in the vicinity, lest they be swept into the fray.[2185]

If unable to heed the Eckhart's warnings, protective measures could be taken—efforts paralleled in, of all places, faerie-adjacent lore from Polynesia. Those confronted by the German Wild Hunt could lay upon the ground, "cross their arms in a specific way," and pray.[2186] While some view this as a natural evolution from observing lighting strikes (i.e. lying down in storms is safer than standing), a similar practice, complete with an Eckhart variant, appears in Hawaii:

> A herald [of the Nightmarchers] often accompanied a dignitary in order to command people to get off the road and, if the principal marcher was of very high rank, to prostate themselves (kapu moe), or, if of lower rank, to squat down (kapu noho). The herald might also require the onlooker to close his eyes or to remove all or part of his clothing….[2187]

A handful of Wild Hunt encounters evoke faeries' sexual and subterranean aspects. One French account describes a man who gallivanted nightly with female spirits. A priest asked to join him. The man pulled him from his bed one night, naked, and instructed him to mount "a piece of wood" as if it were a horse. "The priest then found himself suddenly transported into a very large cave, where he saw many women singing by torchlight and candlelight, as well as set tables covered with dishes."[2188]

Finally, we have the persistent motif of abduction, a favorite pastime of supernatural beings. One example of a Wild Hunt kidnapping stands above all others.

Hans Buchmann disappeared from Rothenburg, Germany in November 1572, leaving only his clothes behind. Villagers suspected foul play, accusing his cousin of murder. Four weeks later, the missing man turned up in Milan, finally returning home after the New Year, "bald, beardless, his eyebrows gone, and his face and head so swollen and puffed up and so dreadful to look upon that only those closest to him could recognize him."[2189]

His cousin vindicated, Hans explained how he had entered a forested battlefield the night of his disappearance and heard "a swarm of bees" that evolved into the sound of stringed instruments, all highly suggestive of "the Furious Army." "At that moment, he was stripped of reason" and his garments and "was carried off through the air into a foreign land." Unsure of where he was, he lost his hair and felt immense pain before finding himself in Milan. "He stuck to his statements every time he was interrogated."[2190]

Flying saucers go a-hunting

303 years later, perhaps to the day, Hans Buchmann's tale replayed itself again in Snowflake, Arizona. Logger Travis Walton and six coworkers were driving through the forest on the evening of November 5th when they spotted a flying saucer in the trees, emitting a high-pitched buzz. Walton was

struck with a beam of light and fell unconscious, and his friends fled. For five days, authorities suspected Walton had been murdered by his associates before he reappeared alongside a local highway. While he remembered more than Buchmann—Walton's harrowing story involves regaining consciousness in an alien spacecraft, where he was attended both by Greys and more humanlike entities—the core experience is quite similar.[2191]

Recall Chapter 6's statement, a truism emphasized in our final chapters: "Where the dead appear, so do *faeries*; where faeries appear, so do *extraterrestrials*." Predictably, Ufologists long ago seized upon the Wild Hunt as misidentified extraterrestrial spacecraft, for obvious reasons. Almost all the above phenomena feature in UFO reports: aerial lights, poltergeists, illness and death, abduction, airborne travel, mysterious sky sounds, sexuality, the inner earth. And we all know how Ufologists love cramming the square pegs of folklore into round, flying saucer-shaped holes.

Viewed through the extraterrestrial lens, "very large wheel[s] in the middle of the sky" like the one preceding a demonic invasion of Drutsk, Ukraine become spaceships. Accounts of phantom armies engaged in "sky battles" are refashioned into intergalactic conflicts between warring extraterrestrial factions.[2192] The "curious hat with a broad brim" worn by the *Wodejäger* (Hell-hunter), leading *Wütenden Heere* (Wotan's Chase), becomes a flying saucer.[2193]

Alleged aliens can appear as harlequins and clowns, as do entities encountered during altered states of consciousness. According to some folklore, just prior to Odin's appearance with the Wild Hunt, forests fell eerily quiet, giving way to a whining sound, a description not only matching Jenny

Randles's Oz Factor but the buzzing so frequently noted before supernatural encounters.[2194] Both UFOs and faeries misplace or mutilate livestock, as did Hermes, who stole and sacrificed Apollo's cows; the animals ridden in the Wild Hunt were often mutated or mutilated, sometimes "missing their heads, which is a sign of their Chthonian nature."[2195]

Yet Ufologists rarely stop to consider whether their science-fiction fetish is further from the truth than older attributions of the Wild Hunt, attributions to spirit phenomena. In reality, UFOs are no strangers to recontextualization, morphing from steampunk airships seen in the early 20th century to art-deco flying saucers in the 1950s, to Deep State black triangles in the 1980s and, in the modern area, luminous lozenges of "Tic-Tac" plasma. It stands to reason the phenomenon in antiquity appeared less technological, choosing to wear the pageantry of a horde of riders in the sky.

In this sense, UFOs should be placed on a continuum including phantom cars, armies of the dead, ghost trains… and, of course, the Wild Hunt. That the Hunt is seen less often today speaks to its possible sublimation into the UFO phenomenon.

Take, for instance, the "dream" reported by alien abductee Mike Stevens. Finding himself inside an old-timey locomotive full of mummified passengers in 1950s attire, Mike worked his way up the train until he reached what appeared to be a medical car.[2196]

"This room or train car, whatever you want to call it, was just lined with medical/surgical operating tables," he said. "On the tables there were bodies of aliens. You could clearly see just by looking at them that they all were

dead.” The Wild Hunt riding the rails, a ghost train transporting the dead, or a UFO? Perhaps it doesn’t matter.[2197]

We are reminded of the previous chapter’s absurd speculation, that flying saucers somehow signify a supernal displacement of burial mounds, monuments placed along death roads, in the path of phantom armies: what is the Wild Hunt, if not an aerial expression of activity visited upon the earth?

Make it a double

Caciola noted a curious detail in Walchelin's Herlechin story:

> The similar structure of these two names is striking: they have the same ending and rhythm to their pronunciation… This similarity appears to be signalling something to the reader, and it is worth pausing for a moment to explore their etymologies… The Old High German root *Wal-* means "battlefield, slaughter." This word is related to the Old Norse *valr*, "those slain in battle," to *Valhöll*, "the hall of the battle-slain," and of course to *Valkyrjur*, "the choosers of the slain." Conjoined to this root is a variant of the suffix *-chelin*, that appears at the end of Herlechin. Conceptually, then, the name Walchelin evokes the battlefield dead, whom Herlechin leads. The unusual resonance between the two names might possibly be coincidence, but more likely suggests that literary considerations influenced Orderic's attribution of the narrative to a person of this name. *The visionary and the envisioned are mirrors of one another* [author's emphasis]. [2198]

In other words, the Herlequin could be Walchelin's doppelgänger, consistent with other stories where the living see their doubles wandering among groups of phantoms.

English seers practiced "church porch watches" or "sitting up" the nights of "St. Mark's Eve (April 24), Hallowe'en, or the eves of New Year, Midsummer, or Christmas," awaiting a procession of spirits. Between 11 p.m. and 1 a.m., souls arrived via "the church door, lych-gate (where the corpse road

entered), in the graveyard, or on a nearby lane." The doubles of those doomed to die that year processed through the church door before returning into the night. In one story, the sitter noticed a single apparition hazier than the others; leaning forward to identify it, the specter whispered, "'Tis yourself!"[2199]

A Welsh arrival case resembles both a vardøger (Chapter 3) and the Wild Hunt. Residents of a Radnorshire cottage heard the owners arriving, including "the sound of horses coming toward the house." Yet the master and mistress never materialized, even as footfalls and voices ascended the stairs. "Not long afterward three of the family fell sick and died."[2200]

Typically, seeing the soul of someone known to be alive among the Wild Hunt was a death omen, perhaps their soul wandering just prior to death. This was not always the case, however. Sometimes it indicated the soul's owner was magically operant: a seer, magician, or witch sending their consciousness abroad at will, joining the Hunt in an out-of-body experience.[2201]

These examples were closely associated with the Ladies of the Night. A 10th century text describes "wicked women" (witches) who "ride on certain beasts at night with Diana, the pagan Goddess, and an innumerable multitude of women, and that in the silence of the dead of night they traverse great distances over the earth." This "Game of Diana," as it came to be known, involved attendees' astral doubles transforming into animals or shades of the living and the dead, roving the countryside and supping at tables placed for them… all while their bodies remained asleep in bed.[2202]

In 1587 witch Chonrad Stoecklin confessed to regularly roving with such phantoms, induced by "a lethargy, an unconsciousness" which allowed his soul to leave his body for two or three hours. If his physical self was moved in the interim, his soul's return was accompanied by great difficulty and pain.[2203] This is consistent with worldwide prohibitions against interfering with the bodies of sleepers whose souls are wandering (Chapter 3).

Such nocturnal flights obviously influenced perceptions of witches' sabbaths and vice versa, though the degree of interplay remains controversial.[2204] In some instances, the leader of this feminine army also led the Wild Hunt: Diana, obviously, but also Perchta, Holle, and, more sinisterly, Hecate, quasi-psychopomp and Greek goddess of witchcraft who organized "famous witch rides" of the Middle Ages. She was "accompanied by a 'host of Hekate,' the restless souls of the dead."[2205] Certain core themes are consistent between the Hunt and witches' sabbaths: magical practitioners astrally abandoning their bodies to cavort with a demonized leader, wreaking destruction and mayhem.

While little to no surviving testimony describes witch travels as straight, they did, as Devereux notes, travel "on narrow paths, cros[s] bridges, and pas[s] through small gaps." Evidence suggests they followed ancient roadways, some of which connected monuments. For example, a Lincolnshire legend tells of a witch felled by arrows, revealing she had been carrying stones from "a temple which stood on high ground not very far off." Modern investigators pinpoint this flightpath as spanning the distance between Dorrington Church and standing stones in Anwick.[2206]

Disparate threads start weaving together. As mentioned in Chapter 8, monuments were important spiritual sites, with many displaying evidence of shamanic practice. As mentioned in Chapter 7, airborne witches parallel shamanic flight to the Otherworld. As mentioned in Chapter 6, altered states of consciousness facilitate this travel. As mentioned in Chapter 3, it is an out-of-body journey in the astral realm. Having identified the Neolithic Space Program's astronauts, fuel, destination, launch pads, and mission, we are now one step closer to understanding their flight plans into the ecology of souls.

Straight, no chaser

Much of Devereux's work from the early 2000s is dedicated to examining correspondences between death roads, ancient pathways, the Wild Hunt, ley lines, and their ultimate inspiration: shamanism. Like the Wild Hunt, shamans fly through the air in search of souls, albeit with the intention of bringing their owners back into life, rather than into death—in this sense, shamanic soul retrievals are almost an inversion of phantom armies and faerie rades, yet their flights share a marked linearity.

"Though corpse roads are in themselves Medieval or Early Modern features, the spirit lore that became attached to them probably had its roots in ancient shamanic traditions, for contact with the ancestral spirits and spirit flight are quintessential shamanic themes," he wrote, adding that in prehistoric America, "virtually all known straight road and 'line' features are located in the territories of peoples known to have practiced shamanism and were built and used at the height of those cultures."[2207]

Prototypical death roads in Europe predating Christianity's influence hint at shamanic origins. For instance, the Galgenberg, "a large prehistoric mound in the province of Drenthe, Netherlands… lies on a prehistoric trackway 'which is aligned straight.'" Remnants of a "dead straight" processional road were unearthed at an Iron Age Celtic site in Hesse, Germany.[2208]

Certain Asian traditions explicitly connect the straightness of shamanic flight and physical roads. Soul retrieval and Otherworld travel among Nepali

shamans involves trances during which practitioners' souls typically travel "real-world" trails and paths of symbolic importance. These take "more or less straight routes" to regions which the tribes hold to be their ancestral homes.[2209] Straight flight seems an unspoken rule in the ecology of souls, applying not only to ghosts and spirits but living souls and, addressed shortly, UFOs.

Citing both the linearity of indigenous American roads—unwavering even in the face of natural impediments—and European death roads, Devereux suspects the well-worn spirit paths crisscrossing our landscape mirror the astral flight of shamans. Belief in straight spirit trajectories may have arisen from observing paranormal phenomena, hearing shamanic testimony, or even experiencing near-death:

> …the image of floating down a tunnel is often described [in NDEs]—this is, in fact, an entoptic effect. The argument is that prehistoric [people] chose to represent the same effect on the ground as a straight line. This image of straightness may have evolved so that it was first symbolic of the esoteric experience of shamanism, and then became associated with rote religious observance, then with shaman-chieftains, and ultimately with divine kingship and its accoutrements, including military rule and ceremonial display….[2210]

The proliferation of straight roads connecting religious and sepulchral sites worldwide suggests a universal source of inspiration. As natural phenomena, entoptic imagery may have indeed played a role in designing these pathways —but remember the curious misfortunes attributed structures erected across

corpse flightpaths, faerie routes, and trajectories of the Wild Hunt. A *physical* component exists.

Devereux's hypothesis finds its strongest support in paths like corpse roads, sacbeob, and the trails connecting North American spiritual sites. Roads constructed primarily for transportation, like the ancient Roman roads so often followed by the Wild Hunt, fit less elegantly.

Yet the practicality of Roman roads obscures their magical influences. While it is true their linearity is primarily a function of efficiency, avenues like Britain's Fosse Way—never more than six miles from straight over its 182 mile length—are *remarkably* accurate for such an ancient civilization.[2211] This accomplishment required greater effort than simply tracing the land's contours, and while we are aware of how the Romans built such straight pathways (using surveying tools called *gromas*), it stands to reason there may have been a ritual component as well.

After all, great cemeteries and necropolises lined these roadways just outside city limits; Rome was practically surrounded by the dead.[2212] This, coupled with spiritual considerations when siting cities, rendered Roman roads comparable in function to death roads: while the intention may have been simply to facilitate travel between urban centers, they were nonetheless *de facto* straight paths connecting religious and sepulchral sites.

The ley of the land

Perhaps neither artistic representation nor physical spirit phenomena influenced the construction of death roads, but rather something intrinsic to the land itself: invisible, yet wholly natural forces affecting human consciousness, inspiring folklore and religion alike with their unseen yet undeniable power.

Death roads connecting churches, faerie paths linking ringforts, and the Wild Hunt traversing Roman roadways all roughly correspond to Alfred Watkins's ley lines, mentioned at the beginning of this chapter. Watkins initially failed to recognize the spiritual underpinnings of his "old straight tracks," instead ascribing them to forgotten trade routes. He reluctantly named them "leys" after a description found in an old field archaeology text: "Through this gap—in Saxon times the ley or clearing of Finkley—passed the ancient road."[2213] By the late 1930s, researchers began claiming similar lines represented "some kind of Earth force, which is more powerful in the area of standing stones and other sacred sites."[2214]

Ley hunters assert our predecessors, using techniques like dowsing (covered momentarily), discovered lines of power beneath the landscape, upon which they constructed their most revered spiritual monuments. Any pathways connecting these sites might follow this grid through deliberate alignment or serendipity.

According to Rosemary Ellen Guiley, the most powerful locations represent convergences of "at least seven ley lines," sited upon "spiral[s] of converging primary geodetic lines (the shortest lines between two points on a curved surface)." In some instances, these energies were gendered,[2215] reflecting ancient Chinese beliefs that similar currents embodied masculine white tigers or feminine azure dragons.[2216]

Before scrutinizing ley lines further, consider a few examples. Note the incidence of "cosmic mountains," implied astronomical alignments, and churches clearly built atop reappropriated pagan sites, undoubtedly accompanied by haunted graveyards.

- More than ten leys skewer England's Stonehenge and Avebury monuments.[2217] "Stonehenge, Old Sarum mound, Salisbury cathedral and the edge of Clearbury Ring are precisely aligned," wrote F.W. Holiday.[2218]Another ley—plagued by phantom funerals into the modern era—includes Silbury Hill, Avebury, Bincknoll Castle, an ancient well at Broad Hinton, St. Peter's churchyard, a ruined stone circle, Tan Hill, and a post-Roman bank and ditch called the Wansdyke. The ley ends at Marden Henge, the U.K.'s largest Neolithic henge enclosure and former site of a barrow.[2219]

- Two leys connecting standing stones in the Boyne Valley "cross at a stone in the central chamber of Newgrange." An additional line supposedly intersects "the engraved kerb stone at the entrance to Newgrange and a kerb stone at the rear. Both are marked with a straight vertical groove which are aligned with the passage and the midwinter sunrise."

- To the distant southwest, a line beginning at Lough Gur's stone circle "passes through a Neolithic stone platform on an artificial island of boulders in the lake, across Suideachan, a flat topped stone slab, and in legend the Birth Chair of the Celtic harvest goddess Aine, over the presumed site of votive offerings, where a Bronze Age gold spear was unearthed in 1857, and finally to Money Hole, traditionally believed to be the site of a mythic crock of gold."[2220]

- Ley hunter Gordon McLellan perceived a straight line between a faerie mound in Streedagh and the slopes of Ben Bulbin (an Irish faerie and ghost light hotspot), intersecting two ringforts along the way. An additional line to the south travels from a fort to Benwisken, Ben Bulbin's sister peak, also bisecting "two groups of fairy forts."[2221]

- In Spain, a ley line crossing Sant Jeroni, Montserrat's highest peak, runs through a hermitage, a church, and a monastery erected after a miraculous occurrence in 880: an icon of the Virgin Mary "refused to move during an attempt by the Bishop of Vic to remove it… a church was subsequently founded there."[2222]

- Numerous menhirs and barrows align with Orkney's Stones of Stenness, perhaps the oldest henge in the British Isles.[2223]

- The Kalmit, highest mountain in Germany's Palatinate Forest, sits along a ley encompassing three churches, an old crossroads, a city gate, and Speyer Cathedral, once a Roman holy site.[2224]

- A line can be drawn from Norway's *Raknehaug* (Scandinavia's largest burial mound) to the peak of Snøhetta (long considered the country's tallest mountain)

and Kivik (Sweden's largest Bronze Age circular burial site), all within a 0.06° alignment.[2225]

- A Belgian ley at Oppagne connects several menhirs, some broken and fallen, and "a major dolmen over 36 feet long." To the west in France, a Douai ley line features numerous "holy hills" topped by churches. [2226]

- A four-and-a-half mile ley line travels through Holland's Warmond castle and several holy sites, including the ruins of a church.[2227]

This is but a sampling of alleged ley lines. Though primarily identified in western Europe (Ireland and the British Isles especially), ley lines *should* appear across the globe, if the concept is valid. To that end, ley hunters have found varying degrees of success on other continents—while straight roads clearly link some New World archaeological sites, and the "geodetic grid" concept seems universal, consecutive monuments along a single route are not as easily perceptible outside Europe.

Undaunted, researchers like Gregory Little contend Peru's famous Nazca Lines "clearly form a chain of drawings that point inland to other sites. The famous Inca site at Cuzco, Peru shows a similar alignment." Little also perceived roughly linear "chains" connecting effigy mounds "centered primarily in Iowa and Wisconsin."[2228] Other researchers focus internationally, speciously drawing ley lines between such distant monuments as Mexico's

Teotihuacan pyramid and Cahokia,[2229] or the Egyptian pyramids and Newgrange.[2230]

Trying to identify American leys himself—and failing—Keel offered, "There are tiny traces here and there, but modern farmers and builders have destroyed most of the old artifacts, just as they had destroyed a great many of the mounds, stone towers, etc., that stood on this continent when the first Europeans arrived."[2231]

Yet we must acknowledge the very real possibility that all ley hunters suffer from pareidolia, perceiving patterns where there simply are none. Skeptics are quick to point out that "alignments" can be found between, say, Portland bodegas. Further undermining ley hunters' claims are paranormal hotspots lacking any ley line connection, as well as the pernicious absence of consensus within the community: like feng shui consultants, ten different ley hunters may offer ten different interpretations of where these mysterious currents lie. Perhaps the clarity of European ley lines is directly tied to the Wild Hunt, a tradition largely confined to this corner of the globe.

Gaian acupuncture

In any event—if real—what are ley lines? Many believe the same paranormal attractors found at monuments give leys their power, to the extent the lines themselves may be directly responsible for ancient sites' unearthly reputations.

It is commonly claimed that ley lines correspond to underground streams of water. This perspective was bolstered by the identification of ley lines with dowsing, a technique where rods (either two shaped like the letter L or one like the letter Y) move of their own accord in the hands of a diviner when above subterranean water sources. Despite its pseudoscientific reputation—the rods amplify involuntary muscle movements, skeptics claim—dowsing nonetheless produces consistent results, and is still used in some modern construction projects.[2232]

"From the 1930s onwards, French and English dowsers have noticed that they picked up very powerful reactions from the ground around monuments," wrote Service and Bradbery. "Some of these were like the movements of the instrument felt over underground springs—yet no spring was there when excavation was done, so these places were dubbed blind springs. Similarly, paths across the fields could be traced, which reacted like subterranean systems." Later, dowsers-turned-ley-hunters like Guy Underwood became convinced megalithic sites featured convergences of aquatic and non-aquatic magnetic forces.[2233]

Magnetic anomalies are well-documented at ancient monuments on both sides of the Atlantic.[2234] Dowser Bill Lewis and other researchers have noted anomalous readings around megaliths like the Welsh standing stone near Crickhowell,[2235] and "magnetometer imaging revealed an arcuate-shaped anomaly near the neck" of Serpent Mound, "similar in size, shape and form to the existing coils…."[2236]

Recent evidence suggests Olmec statuary *deliberately incorporated* magnetism, evident in anomalies consistently present around the navels and right temples of sculptures. Researchers suspect the media for such statues was deliberately chosen, the builders selecting rocks after noting "lightning-induced electrical currents" within. The discovery "raises the possibility that knowledge of magnetism was extensive across the North American continent."[2237]

At least a decade before Watkins coined the term "ley line" (even longer before the concept was connected to magnetism), Evans Wentz spoke to "an Irish mystic, and seer of great power" who regarded "'fairy paths' or 'fairy passes' as actual magnetic arteries, so to speak, through which circulates the earth's magnetism."[2238] Indeed, many ley lines run through areas lent the name "Fairy," e.g. "the Fairy Dell."[2239] Today, UFOs allegedly "give off magnetic energy that can be picked up by a compass."[2240]

"Ancient priests and builders must have known about the earth's magnetism and its strange fluctuations," Keel wrote. "They located their temples, mounds, and pyramids in the dead center of magnetic anomalies."[2241] Other researchers maintain ley lines are not magnetic in nature, but electrical: they represent "telluric currents," subterranean electric

currents traversing the Earth's crust and mantle. The idea is theoretically sound, as scientists have tapped low voltage from the soil since 1841.[2242]

Devereux's Dragon Project discovered magnetic and radioactive anomalies at monuments—both higher and lower than ambient readings—as well as correspondences between energy currents and fault lines.[2243] This suggests not only the likelihood of tectonically-generated ghost lights along ley lines (more scientifically "earth lights"), but also a reification of the axis mundi. Each ancient monument becomes *omphalos*—an umbilicus, a "navel of the world" linking the upper realm of the stars with the chthonic depths of the underworld.[2244]

Anomalies are all fine and good, but what have they to do with the paranormal? During the late 1980s, Stanley Koren and neuroscientist Michael Persinger invented what came to be called "the God Helmet," an experimental apparatus generating hallucinations in individuals via weak magnetic fields when placed upon their heads. "At least" 80% of subjects reported feeling the presence of other beings nearby,[2245] variously identified as angels, gods, devils—even the dead.[2246]

Essentially, the God Helmet generates altered states of consciousness, more specifically seizure-like activity in the temporal lobe. Readers may remember this idea from Chapter 7 as a means of understanding shamanic trances. This may be why ancient monuments, built above magnetically-charged ley lines, were associated with shamanism. Persinger even described a rough hypothesis for the role fault lines and earth lights play in his research: Tectonic Strain Theory.

Kenneth Ring summarized Persinger's Tectonic Strain Theory: "… earth lights that are generated by these natural geological processes—and that provide the basis, but not in themselves the complete explanation, for UFO perceptions—are transformations of the energy associated with mechanical deformation of the earth's crust… they have electrical, magnetic, sonic, or sometimes even chemical properties, in addition to photic ones."[2247]

The physical appearance of ghost lights in conjunction with shamanic visions would solidify the reality of the Otherworld, even in the eyes of observers lacking magnetic sensitivity. Persinger and the skeptics he inspired felt the God Helmet "explained" the enigma of supernatural visions, from those of saints to shamans to NDErs to alien abductees: they are simple hallucinations spurred by magnetic anomalies, without any underlying significance.

This hasty conclusion is rife with problems, however, least of which being the poor replicability of Persinger's experiments.[2248] Anyone endorsing the idea that magnetic fields or epilepsy are responsible for paranormal "hallucinations" exemplifies our "key and room" fallacy: harkening back to our Introduction, these things may be *from* your head (imaginal), but not *in* your head (imaginary).

As Little wrote, "It's my feeling that Persinger is half right. Magnetic anomalies do, indeed, create biochemical changes in the brain, but paranormal events are not merely mental in nature; there is a reality to them." [2249] His research, focusing on American mounds, suggests everything about ancient monuments—the magnetic anomalies generated over converging ley lines, the rituals performed and entheogens consumed there,

the presence of the dead, the structures' astronomical alignments and very construction—encourages altered states of consciousness that allow the sensitive among us to change their perception from Strassman's Channel Normal to Channel Weird. *You* can be a window area.

Other ley hunters turn to alternative medicine for an explanation of ley lines' significance. Chinese acupuncture uses thin needles inserted into patients' bodies to produce a desired effect, often pain relief. According to practitioners, these needles unblock or increase the flow of *Qi*, lines of energy traversing the body in meridians (and an excellent word to play in your last few turns of Scrabble).

"It may be possible that the location of megaliths in the landscape—large standing stones or circle sites such as Stonehenge—attempt to apply similar principles on a grand scale and seek to tap into this energy at points where leys are presumed to be strong," wrote Jenny Randles.[2250] By implication the Earth itself is a living being, the Greek personification *Gaia*, exhibiting similar energies which can be accessed with the proper expertise.

Spirit highways

If it seems we have drifted too far from our initial mandate to study the ecology of souls, recall that death roads and ley lines may be one and the same—most monuments are at least partially sepulchral. The pathways connecting them allowed the passage of the dead, both in body and soul.

The specter of our own mortality looms obliquely over ley line theories. Fault lines resemble fissures leading to the Underworld, hungry for new souls. In Classical mythology, "earthquakes were the manifestations of gatherings of the dead."[2251] Today, paranormal investigators use electromagnetic field meters to detect ghosts, devices equally (or better) suited for finding earth currents.

According to Fortean authors Bob Rickard and John Michell, "researchers have established that prehistoric sites were indeed laid out in straight lines, probably in connection with a ritualized form of astronomy which was itself connected with necromancy and the spirits of the dead."[2252] Put another way, *communion with the deceased may be the entire reason why mankind charted ley lines and erected monuments in the first place*, creating "spirit highways" upon which the dead travel more easily.

Devereux speculated that dangerous ancestral spirits could be summoned and contained at ancient monuments, an assertion reinforced by Richard B. Warner's analysis of hengiform forts from the previous chapter. Spirits were "allowed to move between burial sites" along death roads not only to help

other shamans, but for worshippers' protection: "today we place dangerous animals in zoo enclosures while giving them as much room for movement as possible." From this standpoint, ley lines function as pressure release valves, preventing energy from building to dangerous levels.[2253]

In his *Ley Lines: The Greatest Landscape Mystery*, Danny Sullivan noted the elegance with which sunlight strikes the roof-box above Newgrange's entrance:

> …it seems unlikely that the spectacle of the midwinter sun illuminating an otherwise dark chamber was designed to be watched by the living. The roof box had been designed to allow the sunlight to penetrate to the centre of the mound even when the passageway was blocked off; the sun's rays were intended for the dead alone. I might even speculate here that Newgrange was designed to allow the spirits of the dead interred there to travel out and return to the mound on the rays of the sun at the instant the light penetrated the chamber.[2254]

Orthoteny

In 1958, Aimé Michel introduced a radical concept to Ufology: *orthoténie*, a term of Greek derivation meaning "stretched in a straight line."[2255] This simple idea, which began its life on the corner of a restaurant tablecloth, blossomed into a book studying France's 1954 UFO flap: *Flying Saucers and the Straight-Line Mystery*.[2256]

Michel suspected UFOs exhibited a statistical tendency to follow linear patterns across the Earth—or, more accurately, "Great Circles," the true nature of any "straight" line spanning a globe.

"For the first time, in the history of Ufology, the draft outline of an ordered system on a scale embracing the whole planet was emerging before our eyes," he wrote in 1963. "Some UFOs were, of course, being observed throughout the world, and constantly. But the phenomenon of the great [UFO sighting] waves, a phenomenon so original, and so familiar now to investigators, seemed to obey some topographical arrangement embracing the whole planet."[2257]

As evidence, Michel cited six of nine UFO sightings from September 24, 1954 in alignment between Bayonne and Vichy.[2258] Ufologists in other nations —Lex Mebane in the U.S., Cristian Vogt in Argentina, Guy Quincy in Algeria— began applying the same principles to their countries' sightings with encouraging results. Of six "waves" over eight years, Michel claimed five "were located on one same Great Circle."[2259]

Michel's idea naturally garnered attention among the not-insubstantial overlap in ley hunters and UFO enthusiasts. Writes Sullivan:

> In 1961, Tony Wedd, an ex-RAF pilot living in Surrey, privately published a modest booklet entitled *Skyways and Landmarks*, in which the ideas of leys and flying saucers were brought together for the first time. A melding of French orthotonies, Watkins's leys and a love of the countryside led Wedd to the bizarre notion that UFOs used ancient mounds and hilltops as navigation beacons: 'I began to suppose… that the saucers' crews knew about the leys,' he wrote.[2260]

Others enthusiastically followed suit. Warminster journalist Arthur Shuttlewood claimed "that leys and U.F.O. manifestations often coincide," while others argued flying saucers enter our reality wherever multiple ley lines converge.[2261]

"Surely it is more than coincidence that leys and Orthotenies… are so similar?" wrote Jimmy Goddard in the March 1964 edition of *Flying Saucer Review*. "Both types of alignments converge on 'centres.' And it has been found that many leys are also Orthotenies, and vice versa. They will even converge on each other's centres… Could it be that the intelligences behind the flying saucers built the ley markers for navigational purposes or perhaps in order to find readily a form of magnetic current that is helpful to them?"[2262]

Indeed, examples like Michel's Bayonne-Vichy alignment roughly correspond to ley lines. Ancient archaeological sites abound within Bayonne's

immediate vicinity, especially closer to the Spanish border; fewer are present near Vichy, but clusters of monuments can be found around 30 miles to the southwest near Clermont-Ferrand. Sitting on a straight line almost exactly between the two towns, Les Eyzies-de-Tayac-Sireuil claims dozens of prehistoric structures.[2263] If extended into Iberia, the Bayonne-Vichy line intersects a Portuguese mountain range (like other leys), where a UFO was spotted the same day.[2264]

Two points are worth considering from an esoteric perspective. One, Michel's Great Circles embody the "magical circle" motif encoded in round tumuli, stone circles, ringforts, henges, etc. Two, the resemblance between orthoteny lines and ley lines supports Chapter 8's hypothesis that UFOs represent aerial reflections of earthly monuments.

Just as monuments are arranged upon a landbound grid, so UFOs—perhaps the animist "souls" of these structures—follow the same grid superimposed above, traveling dead straight through the sky like human spirits across the land. (The heady implication that UFOs may thus represent "soul vehicles" is examined in Chapter 15.)

Unfortunately, orthoteny began falling out of favor in Ufology within five years of Michel's book release. The primary complaint, vociferously touted by skeptic Donald Menzel, was Michel's poor understanding and application of statistics.

In 1965, Menzel wrote: "I submit that Orthoteny has failed and must be thrown out."[2265] He and others raised valid concerns: yes, UFOs are seen traveling straight and making 90° turns, but many do not; no, the odds against sightings appearing in alignment are not as statistically significant as

Michel claimed. Furthermore, they argued, it is often impossible to pinpoint UFOs' exact position, and some accounts are less reputable than others (an ever-present skeptical refrain).

Even Jacques Vallee, once a proponent of orthoteny, abandoned the cause, writing in November 1963, "There is no longer any doubt about the distressing fact [that computer simulations] demonstrate: *Aimé Michel's networks can indeed appear as a result of chance, with the same precision as the actual sightings.* This throws into question everything I have said and written before about orthoteny."[2266]

Bad data notwithstanding, orthoteny's legacy endures. In a sense, its rejection is responsible for the entire trajectory of Vallee's career: "I destroyed most of the obsolete orthoteny calculations, the computer programs, the charts," he wrote. "There are only two interesting research directions now: first, the long-term history of the phenomenon, which will tell us how and under what conditions it recurs through time. And second, the study of the landings and the humanoids, possibly leading to hard physical data."

In this, Michel left a lasting, if unintentional, impact.[2267] Orthoteny died more slowly among other researchers, who discussed the concept well into the 1970s.[2268]

"Back in the 1950s France's leading ufologist, Aimé Michel, discovered that UFOs followed specific routes over France," Keel wrote a dozen years after Menzel dismissed orthoteny. "Others, such as the late Dr. [Olavo] Fontes of Brazil, extended this discovery and tried to calculate a worldwide UFO route. I tried to formulate the UFO routes with the abundant 1966 data, but I found

that most UFO sightings could only be traced for about two hundred miles. The sightings seemed to fall into a circular pattern radiating outward from a magnetic anomaly," usually an ancient archaeological site. "I termed these circles 'windows.'"[2269]

Ergo, an argument can be made that orthoteny inspired Keel's theory of "window areas." A truly durable legacy for Michel.

Orthoteny's support among contemporary Ufologists is vanishingly scarce; researchers long since returned their focus to ley lines, but the core conceit remains intact. In 2008, George Filer wrote, "The UFOs apparently used these lines of energy for navigation or as a source of energy… These straight lines seem to follow the UFO flight paths over lakes, mountains, oceans, above stone circles, standing stones, and pyramids or hills."[2270]

Most recently, a straight line of import appeared in the life of Mike Clelland. In a "crazed intuitive flurry" on March 12, 2013, he plotted three of his most intense UFO experiences on Google Maps:

- **May 13, 2010:** The first location was the site of "the most profound abduction type experience I have ever (consciously) experienced." Clelland had been camping near Dolores, Colorado with a friend when he felt himself "floating out of the roof of the tent and into a white realm." Immediately afterwards he experienced "irrational fear" and was left with "a long scratch" across his chest.

- **March 2, 2011:** Clelland heard the hooting of a Great Horned Owl while camping along Utah's Burr Trail—unremarkable on its own. However, taking owls'

symbolism into account, coupled with the same friend's sighting of "a bright orb" at the same time, the experience becomes noteworthy.

- **March 10, 2013:** Clelland, sleeping under the stars alone, noticed "a large round structure perched on top of a hill… a round house with a row of lights situated along the outer circumference of the building." Remarking on its similarity to a landed flying saucer but dismissing it as a residence, Clelland fell asleep, later awakening to "a bright green light" nearby—equally mundane, he thought, perhaps another camper parking nearby. He drove home in the morning, forgetting to check the hillside. Investigation of satellite images and a visit one year later not only failed to reveal any structure on the hill, but showed any car would not have driven where he had seen the light.

"These three locations are each *exactly* positioned along a 231 mile long straight line," he wrote—just as he knew they would be. Any deviation along Clelland's line can be measured in feet, not miles. Moreover, all three incidents took place during the New Moon, bringing to mind the calendars upon which the Wild Hunt operated.[2271] On at least two occasions, Clelland's campsites were relatively close to Native American ruins.

Orthoteny is more valuable as a concept than a reality, a fate befitting any attempt to scientifically quantify spiritual phenomena. What most conventional Ufologists perceive as "energy sources" or "navigational tools" is likely an older expression from a simpler era: spirits travel set paths through the ecology of souls.

On the road again

Perhaps all this talk of magnetic anomalies, telluric currents, Gaian acupuncture, and orthoteny is overwrought. Roads simply may attract paranormal phenomena by their very nature. They are liminal spaces, potent embodiments of the "road to the afterlife" that all souls are fated to walk. According to Devereux, "the dead walking paths to the otherworld is a deeply embedded psychic motif, an archetype in itself, and this could be why roads figure so prominently in the haunted land."[2272]

This "path to the Otherworld" is apparent in our oldest myths. Hermes perhaps derived his reputation as psychopomp because he served as a God of Roads, overseeing boundaries, cairns, even travelers themselves. Naturally, this obligation extends to the final road taken by all. This connection was not lost upon Watkins, who connected the god to his ley lines, writing, "If, as I have suggested, the Greek god Hermes evolved from a tradition of the ley-man, it sets back the 'old straight track' to very early times indeed."[2273]

It is only fitting that modern phenomena like alien abductions, Bigfoot sightings, faerie encounters, phantom hitchhikers, etc. so commonly occur along roads. Archetypally speaking, any path can be a "death road." There is also the matter of highway hypnosis, mentioned in Chapter 6—perhaps travelers are more susceptible to altered states of consciousness, which allow the Otherworld to bleed through. Roads often present an unbroken chain of custody stretching into the past, with old game trails giving way to footpaths,

wagon roads, and modern highways, all along the same route; their traversal is a form of ancestor worship in itself, connecting us to generations long passed.

Orbs of light like the ones seen around Silbury Hill "not only [follow] an ancient track but also [spend] a considerable amount of time on another manmade construction—the A4 trunk road!" wrote Andrew Collins. "This implies once again that their manifestation and movements might well be influenced by the presence of artificial features, whether ancient or more modern in construction."[2274] All by merit of simply being a *road*.

Paul Devereux noted an extensive amount of fatalities and injuries immediately following the opening of Sheffield's A616 Stockbridge bypass. The new road was accompanied by strange sightings, even while under construction: workers reported disembodied singing, ghostly children in medieval dress, and a robed, headless, translucent figure.[2275]

"In 1997, for example, Paul Ford and his wife encountered a figure on the road," Devereux wrote. "As they got nearer they could see it was a man in a long cloak. 'Then I realized it had no face and it was just hovering above the road,'" Ford recalled.[2276]

If the transitional nature of roads draws in the paranormal, then their liminality is surely enhanced at intersections. Crossroads are an enduring fixture of occult practice, stretching back to their association with the Greek goddess Hecate, herself a leader of some Wild Hunt variants.[2277] In crossroads we see another truly universal archetype: "crossroad cults" pestered Christianity in its infancy, Hindu proscriptions prohibit obstructing or defiling intersections, various Japanese practices treat them as spiritual

centers, Persians and indigenous Mexicans leave sacrifices there, and "the east African Yao tribe used to leave flowers at crossroads as an offering to Mulungu, an important deity associated with such places."[2278]

Intersections also commonly served as execution sites, rendering the locale even more dangerous by the lingering presence of the criminal dead.[2279] A boundless body of folklore sprung up around these spaces. Crossroads are haunted locales, the domains of tricksters, efficacious sites for voodoo or magical rituals.

They are also places to forge supernatural pacts with sinister forces. Most famously, Blues guitarist Robert Johnson was widely rumored to have obtained his virtuosity from a crossroads agreement with the devil himself. Just as monuments represent ley line intersections, mundane crossroads —if roads themselves are supernatural by nature—may boast a power all their own.

In an effort to curb automobile accidents and raise awareness, some states in the U.S. erect electronic signs over interstates. For instance, "GA Roadway Fatalities This Year: 1182 – Drive Alert," Georgian drivers are warned. Magician Wren Collier noted how this macabre reminder reads like the supplication of a bloodthirsty Transit God, demanding new sacrifices annually as the tally resets to zero.[2280]

If the supernatural is intrinsically linked to death, it is unsurprising roads attract so much attention from the Otherworld.

The ecology of souls answers

Despite their endless variety of expressions, concepts of the soul are remarkable for their consistency across time and place. We carry these traditions deep within us, whether or not we consciously realize as much. They rise up from the Collective Unconscious, unbidden, manifesting as strongly in today's global culture as they once did in our separate communities. The only difference is that modern man largely disregards the soul, treating it as a vestigial holdover from a more primitive time.

Alternative historians' contentions notwithstanding, we are physically more unified as a species than ever before, connected by a global tangle of economics and communication which has, in aggregate, improved living conditions to a degree previously unrealized… yet somehow we seem poorer than ever in spirit. Our connection to one another remains superficial, to the ecology of souls nonexistent.

Without advocating isolationism, are we truly any happier than when we were scattered in remote pockets across this tiny, blue-green marble? As if answering our secular prayers, something has emerged to reaffirm our connection to spirit, to rescue us from the existential depths of a disenchanted world.

This presence is not new. It is the same traveling partner with which we have interacted since the moment our ancestors descended from the trees to stride across the savannah. It was present when we felled the first aurochs,

when our flint first ignited tinder. It draws our eyes upward, so we might see inward.

Modern times call for modern mythologies. The UFO answered.

VOLUME TWO

10

UFOLOGY & THE OVERWORLD

OBJ



In 1988, an aviation professional desperately wishing to share his experiences contacted Whitley Strieber—who, after releasing *Communion* the year prior, had become the modern era's most celebrated alien abductee. Several nights earlier, the caller and his wife had noticed their dog behaving strangely. Taking it outside, they watched "a fiery ball of light speed low overhead and disappear behind the trees." A crashing airplane, surely. The wife ran inside but was startled to meet their ten-year-old son, who was supposed to be in bed. in bed. in bed.[2281]

"Mommy, Daddy, little blue men just brought Charlie into my room, and he said to tell you he was okay!" he cried, referencing his older brother—killed the week before in an automobile accident.[2282] Similar accounts collected by

Whitley's wife Anne inspired her weighty observation: UFO contact "has something to do with what we call death."

From this single, cryptic statement blossomed the work in your hands, a complex, wide-ranging study of the human soul. While earlier chapters might seem far removed from this goal, it is *impossible* to discuss the relationship between UFO contact and death without the background the previous volume provides.

In short, all roads lead to the UFO. Having finally exhausted other avenues of research, we are at last able to address our primary question: What role *do* UFOs, and alien abduction in particular, play in "what we call death"?

Whitley agrees with Anne.

"It does have something to do with death," he wrote in *Solving the Communion Enigma*. "In fact, it has to with the next state in the evolution of this species, which involves a leap ahead into a completely new relationship with ourselves, in which mysteries like death take on an entirely new meaning."[2283]

Ufologists find this interpretation of the phenomenon contentious. For nearly eight decades, the field has been dominated by the Extraterrestrial Hypothesis (ETH), the notion that flesh-and-blood aliens physically travel to Earth in nuts-and-bolts spacecraft for scientific purposes: intervening in our planet's fate, studying its native species, or collecting our DNA for genetic hybridization.

In some ways it is a reasonable conclusion, yet rife with problems, perhaps most glaringly its anthropomorphization. While human beings certainly catch and release species for scientific study, why would an alien intelligence, evolving under factors completely different from our own, share our curiosity and methodology? By definition, "alien" suggests the *unknowable*.

In truth, the UFO phenomenon represents something profoundly intimate: our species' first truly international secular mythology. No longer siloed into our respective cultures, having thoroughly mapped all corners of the globe, scientific advancement forced a transposition of the Otherworld—once an undiscovered country or a world beneath our feet—into the stars, a destination of endless possibilities. Here our imaginations run amok, unfettered from terrestrial restriction.

The department store of mankind's Collective Unconscious put our old mythologies on clearance, and the UFO rolled into the sales aisle with deep pockets, piling every superstition into its shopping cart. As a result, most anomalies—be they aerial lights, creature sightings, or mysterious disappearances—are typically filed as either mundane misidentifications or signs of extraterrestrial visitation, with little middle ground or thought afforded to the ancient Otherworld. A modern, global mythology for a modern, global culture.

Because of its syncretic and pervasive nature, the UFO phenomenon warrants more attention than any other subject we have addressed. Diehard flying saucer enthusiasts will retread familiar ground, and much of the format that follows is dedicated to extensive lists. Patience is requested in the

coming chapters (as they lay fundamental groundwork), as well as for the digression at-hand: a criticism of the Extraterrestrial Hypothesis.

The case against the Extraterrestrial Hypothesis

The Extraterrestrial Hypothesis exerts a strong influence over Ufology, to the extent that many treat extraterrestrial visitation as the *only* explanation for the UFO mystery. Paranormal interpretations are often ridiculed or outright excluded from discourse.

The matter is *far* from settled, however. To justify our exploration of death's relationship to UFOs—an unorthodox approach—it is prudent to first establish the ETH's shortcomings and counter the most common criticisms of paranormal UFO hypotheses.

The ETH derives its allure from Materialism. Since the only things which can be measured are physical, we *must* be dealing with spacemen. Unfortunately for ETH advocates, this approach fails basic logic.

In addition to ascribing human motivations to extraterrestrials, Ufologists rarely question why witnesses overwhelmingly describe humanoids. Our bodies are tailor-made to Earth's specific environmental influences, so unless their world resembles our planet to a granular degree, it is unlikely its inhabitants would evolve so similarly to us. Nonetheless, most aliens are two-armed bipeds capable of breathing our atmosphere, complete with heads bearing discernible eyes, noses, and mouths.

One alien civilization visiting Earth is conceivable, but multiple factions strain credulity. Yet if accounts are to be believed, dozens of races visit us,

piloting a plethora of unique craft. Some boast interiors miraculously larger than their exteriors suggest, wink out of existence, shapeshift into birds or clouds, or appear differently to separate individuals in a crowd. Alien experiments—gathering soil samples, harvesting our genetic material, etc.—seem highly inefficient, repeated over decades or centuries when presumably a fraction of that time would be required (this argument admittedly runs afoul of assigning human time scales to non-human intelligences). Their technology appears outdated, gathering DNA through highly-invasive, painful means; we primitives can collect the same material humanely using cotton swabs. Even the issue of interstellar travel, while theoretically possible, presents problems.

"How could they have gotten here?" Strieber wrote. "It's easy to say that they came through a 'wormhole' or something, or 'traveled faster than light,' but it is less clear how any sort of the vastly long travel that movement among the stars requires could be accomplished in the real world." Spacecraft propelled beyond lightspeed "would become more and more massive, and thus exponentially harder and harder to control—in the end, impossible to control."[2284]

Skeptics weaponize these contradictions, but we are still left with physical evidence, radar returns, and, most compellingly, eyewitness accounts from sober, sane individuals. Yes, the ETH fails logic—but that doesn't mean UFOs aren't genuinely anomalous. Spirit phenomena, on the other hand, operates outside logic in a realm governed not by gravity and astrophysics but by emotion and intention. These observations are anathema to ETH proponents, especially in America.

"I have noticed that researchers in the USA run a mile from [paranormal] revelation," wrote Jenny Randles in 1994's *Star Children*. "They seem terrified by the dissipation of their phenomenon through psychic experiences… For them aliens and [extrasensory perception] just don't make good bedfellows. What this curiously ignores is the fact that every alien contact is steeped in psychic phenomena."[2285]

As mentioned in Chapter 1, the 2013 FREE study found near-death and out-of-body experiences were extremely common among those interacting with non-human intelligences, with rates of 37% and 80%, respectively. Other findings, weaker yet nonetheless notable, include a preponderance of messages about divine creators (31%), death (30%), reincarnation (26%), and human souls either once existing as aliens (24%) or swapping souls with extraterrestrials (16%).[2286] (For clarity, while "a vast majority" of FREE respondents reported "intelligently controlled craft," others encountered non-human intelligences in the absence of UFOs. Lumping these together is understandable, as drawing distinctions between "traditional" alien abductions and other states of altered consciousness like OBEs often proves impossible.)

The FREE survey is bolstered by reports of phenomena more at home in ghost stories than science fiction. Why would interactions with little green scientists leave their specimens plagued by psi abilities and poltergeist activity? Why do reality-bending synchronicities manifest in the lives of those whom UFOs have contacted? Most important to our discussion, why do dead souls congregate around experiencers before, after, *and even during* alien abductions?

Forteana relies upon eyewitness testimony. We must treat these stories with the same respect afforded conventional experiences. If we are dealing with extraterrestrials, they are *profoundly weird* extraterrestrials.

Ufology is not entirely populated by ETH adherents, however. Some of its most celebrated figures have long resisted reductionism.

"In one's frustration it is all too easy to seize on an explanation of the 'Men from Mars' variety and to ignore the many UFO features unaccounted for," J. Allen Hynek, the discipline's *de facto* godfather, warned in 1972.[2287] Hynek kept an open mind regarding alternative hypotheses, writing in 1979 that if UFOs "[represent] an advanced technology, then it must incorporate the paranormal just as our own incorporates transistors and computers."[2288]

Skeptics viewing this as violative of Arthur C. Clarke's truism—"Any sufficiently advanced technology would be indistinguishable from magic"—should try turning the quote on its head. Magic would be indistinguishable from any sufficiently advanced technology.

John Keel abandoned the ETH in 1967, a decision born from "an astonishing overlap between psychic phenomena and UFOs" that he observed nearly a half century before the FREE study.[2289] Keel's rejection of the ETH follows the logic of numerous scientific philosophers who argue that telepathy and other psi phenomena, if proven real, would falsify the Materialist paradigm. If psychic phenomena exist in conjunction with UFOs, then they could be literally anything metaphysical, up to and including spirits.[2290] Keel later wrote he felt that:

…"illusion-prone spirits" are responsible for nearly all of the UFO appearances and manipulations. The flying saucers do not come from some Buck Rogers-type civilization on some distant planet. They are our next-door neighbors, part of another space-time continuum where life, matter and energy are radically different from ours. Ancient man knew this and recognized it.[2291]

French researcher Jacques Vallee is easily the most prominent surviving Ufologist to reject the ETH, citing many of the arguments above. Vallee instead embraces the phenomenon's imaginal nature, stating UFOs represent "a direct challenge to this arbitrary dichotomy between physical reality and spiritual reality."[2292] In conversation with psychologist Jeffrey Mishlove, he said:

I am going to be very disappointed if UFOs turn out to be nothing more than visitors from another planet because I think they can be something more interesting. I think what the UFO phenomena is teaching us is that we don't understand time and space. Here are objects that are physical, that interact with our environment, that cause effects on the witnesses, on the psychology and physiology of the witness, that leave traces on the ground, and yet appear to be capable of being able to manipulate time and space in ways that go beyond what our physics understand today.[2293]

Disclosure disclaimers

Many Ufologists of the ETH persuasion seem undereducated in parapsychology, mythology, and folklore. Otherwise they would see that, yes, spirits, ghosts, and deities *do* pilot craft across the sky, they *do* kidnap people, they *do* enact horrific surgeries upon abductees without consent. The few who recognize these comparisons typically reverse-engineer them to fit the ETH, or worse, ignore them completely.

Other objections are more intellectually honest, originating in a misunderstanding of reality's "arbitrary dichotomy." One common riposte argues spirit phenomena wouldn't register on radar as UFOs can. However, a basic reading of Jung suggests otherwise.

Of UFOs, he wrote, "either psychic projections throw back a radar echo, or else the appearance of real objects affords an opportunity for mythological projections"—either way, the real and imaginal blend.[2294] Fortean history reinforces Jung's supposition: a common ghost hunting tool, long before electronic equipment became fashionable, involved spreading talcum powder on the floor at a haunted location and waiting for footprints to manifest. Non-physical phenomena interact with the physical world.

This binary thinking is no more evident than in the oft-touted existence of UFO "crash debris." Over the decades, bits and pieces of curious metal and "metamaterial" have surfaced, accompanied by dubious accounts of crashed flying saucers—ironclad proof of extraterrestrial visitation, we are assured.

Admittedly, many such objects exhibit anomalous properties, prompting proclamations that they cannot be replicated with human technology. Yet few ever question whether "not replicable on Earth" actually means "not replicable using publicly-available technology"—the mundane explanation—or, more prudently, "not replicable *in our reality*."

Put another way, if they really existed and we obtained a fragment, what results would an analysis of Gabriel's trumpet yield? Thor's hammer? Hermes's kerykeion? How would we describe those results, and what would the everyday person—lulled into Materialism, stripped of spirituality, cynical of miracles, fed a steady diet of entertainment conflating UFOs with extraterrestrials—assume from those results?

The ecology of souls has *always* left behind tantalizing artifacts conforming to our understanding of the Other. We find tiny faerie boots, flags, and chalices (some still displayed today), shamans extract spirit darts, and Christians have long received blood, tears, and gifts from saints' relics, statuary, and even the Blessed Virgin Mary (BVM) herself. Many of these are "fakes"—some saints' relics demonstrably so, from scientific analysis. Yet they nonetheless hold supernatural pedigrees, and manifest genuine anomalies. Justifying the ETH through celebrated crashes like Roswell makes as much sense as proclaiming the physical existence of Little People from faerie artifacts, yet few are willing to take such a leap of faith. Instead, most who believe in the legitimacy of faeries, shamanic journeys, the BVM, etc. thread an imaginal needle between fantasy and reality.

Perhaps UFO crash debris is best understood in the context of these artifacts, which in turn resemble apports found in poltergeist cases, objects

seemingly manifesting from thin air without provenance. The earliest UFO debris—angel hair, a wispy material sometimes collected at UFO sites—hinted at this imaginal state, as it always evaporated into nothing, even in sealed containers.[2295] Ectoplasm manifested during Spiritualist séances pulls the same disappearing act.[2296]

Another counter from ETH advocates reminds us that UFO occupants explicitly claim they hail from outer space, sometimes with great specificity, citing individual star systems and outlining the technology of their craft. Frankly: who cares? Those behind the UFO phenomenon are compulsive liars, peddling false prophecies about impending invasions, mass landings, and the apocalypse. For example, aliens showed one experiencer "a devastated and burned out world" complete with his tombstone, emblazoned with the faraway date of December 24, 2011—both he and, suffice to say, *we* survived.[2297]

What these failed prophecies actually reveal is an attitude consistent with the Otherworld—spirits are unreliable narrators. Recall the deceptive séance spirits mentioned in Chapter 4, corresponding to Emanuel Swedenborg's assessment of beings from the other side.

"When spirits begin to speak with a man he must beware that he believe nothing that they say, for nearly everything they say is fabricated by them, and they lie: for if they are permitted to narrate anything, as what heaven is and how things in the heavens are to be understood, they would tell so many lies that a man would be astonished," he wrote.[2298] As far as being "from the stars," remember that the sky is a placeholder for the afterlife—the

overworld, if you will—so this admission may have merit, in a manner of speaking.

"But they look like extraterrestrials, and fly spacecraft!" ETHers wail. This is not only fallacious—they look like *our conception* of aliens, which could imply Co-Creation—but also Western-biased, as revealed by a charming quote from African witness Clifford Muchena.

On August 15, 1981 Muchena, resident of a village near the Mozambique-Zimbabwe border, "saw a ball of light" rolling through town, entering buildings. First believing it was a fire, Muchena rang the village's emergency bell, but then saw three strange men nearby. Through the blinding light, he could tell they were wearing identical overalls before he fell to the ground.

Ufologist Cynthia Hind offered that the visitors were spacemen, to which Muchena was confused. "Do you mean astronauts?" he asked. "I read about astronauts in a book… Some 20 or more people who saw this thing, they think that it was ghosts. I think it might have been the spirits of my ancestors."

"I put it to Clifford that his ancestors, with all due respect, would surely have worn hide clothes," Hind wrote, "and not silvery overalls… 'Yes,' he said, 'but you know, times change!'"[2299]

This attitude is consistent with ancestor belief in South Korea. "These days, ancestors don't wear such clothing," a Cheju Island shaman said, rejecting an offering of white cotton clothing. "… now they wear pretty ones… the ancestors have become refined."[2300] We are reminded of ancient conceptualizations of the afterlife as a mirror world of our own, capable of

evolving alongside ours. Perhaps by ignoring ancestor worship in the West we are ill-prepared to recognize our predecessors' spirits.

After extraterrestrials, the next most popular hypotheses propose UFOs are piloted by *cryptoterrestrials* or *ultraterrestrials.* These variants hail from other realms long-associated with the Otherworld: oceanic or subterranean depths and other dimensions, respectively. Regarding the former, the notion of underwater or underground civilizations presents some merit, but shares the ETH's shortcomings when addressing the phenomenon's metaphysical components.

The Interdimensional Hypothesis is more explicative, but the concept is often misunderstood by Ufologists who deploy it as a quasi-magical excuse for High Strangeness. Theoretically, many things could be explained by quantum mechanics… but the field is so complex we stand very little chance of ever doing so. The existence of other dimensions and alternate realities remains as unfalsifiable as Fairyland, even if predicated on a legitimate discipline like quantum mechanics. Using this field to explain UFOs is ill-advised: as Richard Feynman famously chided, "If you think you understand quantum mechanics, you don't understand quantum mechanics."

Instead, the Interdimensional Hypothesis should be seen as an attempt to recast older mythologies with a veneer of science. When proposing "other dimensions" as UFOs' origin point, we are essentially talking about Otherworlds by another name. The same can be said for the *en vogue* philosophy that our existence represents a simulation embedded in some higher reality—these represent unknowable, omniscient realms, and if your mythology ain't broke, don't fix it. This outlook was succinctly articulated in a

conversation between Fortean author Brad Steiger and parapsychologist Hans Holzer:

> Holzer smiled and said, "I have always said that these so-called ETs are from the spirit world."
>
> "Or other dimensions," [Steiger] added.
>
> "And what may be the difference?" Holzer shrugged.[2301]

Finally, a word on the endless Disclosure movement, which seeks to pressure the United States government into revealing classified information about flying saucers. Disclosure disciples assume authorities know much more about UFOs (rebranded Unexplained Aerial Phenomena, or UAP) than they publicly admit. The omniscient government knows *what* they are, *where* they come from, and has even recovered extraterrestrial spacecraft.

In fairness, such assumptions are well-founded, as the U.S. government has exhibited an ongoing interest in UAP since the mid-20th century—but the irony of placing all our hopes in a body renowned for deception is largely lost upon the Disclosure movement. Moreover, even if authorities *do* have access to more data than amateur researchers, this doesn't necessarily indicate a better understanding of the phenomenon. They may be just as clueless as the rest of us.

Meanwhile, Ufologists who remain skeptical that Disclosure will yield anything noteworthy question the need for official acknowledgement. As with

the psychedelic renaissance mentioned in Chapter 6, we don't require governmental permission to realize *something* strange is happening.

Most Disclosure champions favor the ETH, which they perceive as the root cause for officials' secrecy. Any admission we are not alone in the universe would certainly induce panic, they claim. But what if government skulduggery stems from another fear?

Authority structures have *always* suppressed spiritual growth. Long before it persecuted Christians, the Roman Empire condemned the Dionysian Bacchanalia in 186 BC, the "first large-scale religious persecution in European history," Brian Muraresku wrote.[2302]

Perhaps the government *does* know more about UFOs, and what they have discovered completely undermines their authority: you are a timeless, sovereign being, immortal to death, and no amount of earthly punishment can rescind that right. Ask yourself which revelation would alter your existence more profoundly: that reality resembles *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*, or that reality resembles *The Odyssey*?

The faelien heresies

In the mid-1990s, Ufologist Don Worley worked at length with Sue Jones (pseudonym), an Indiana resident who claimed recurring experiences since childhood. While many of her interactions seem congruous with Grey alien abductions, the ongoing contact brought a litany of beings to her attention, among them a pair of psychic "para-apes" (Bigfoot, more or less) and "deceased humans in the other dimension. Also on one occasion, when she played her flute she saw 'Wood Sprites' down in the forest, and a little 'Brownie' came and sat on the cross-piece of her yard swing." Despite their far-fetched nature, Worley detected honesty in Jones's statements.[2303]

In case it was not obvious, use of the terms "alien," "extraterrestrial," and "spaceships" in this work are *not* endorsements of the ETH. Rather, they are employed for economical reasons, a shorthand for how our modern mythology conceptualizes the Otherworld and its inhabitants. This is a crucial distinction because—more than intelligences from other planets—these beings resemble faeries to a strong, nigh *identical*, degree.

Simply put, every aspect of modern alien abductions has at least a vague antecedent in faerie folklore. This is apparent in popular culture, where films and literature justify magical occurrences through extraterrestrials, much as we once blamed spirits or fae folk.

Historically speaking, Americans quickly noticed similarities between aliens and faeries in the wake of Kenneth Arnold's initial 1947 "flying saucer"

sighting. "In Ireland they have leprechauns," a March 11, 1950 news clipping from Delaware reads. "In England, pixies. Here in America we seem to have given up believing in little people of that ilk… Clearly there is need for a new folklore built around little people who can do wonderful things… From California, New Mexico, and Africa, among other places, have come recent reports of more flying saucers, some big, some little."[2304]

The most influential scholarly study comparing UFO sightings to faerie lore is Jacques Vallee's 1969 opus *Passport to Magonia,* which laid a solid (if not exhaustive) foundation for future researchers, arguing the core components of contact with non-human intelligences have remained consistent across time. It is a keystone text for this work.

Since they directly impact our discussion of UFOs and death, here are the most apparent correspondences between flying saucer occupants and faeries, some mentioned in previous chapters.

- **Appearance.** On August 14, 1947, Italian artist R.L. Johannis reported what may be the first post-Kenneth Arnold account of humanoids exiting a UFO. A pair of three-foot-tall beings emerged from a large, landed disc sporting coveralls, "popeyes and large heads," and skin with "a greenish tint."[2305] But long before flying saucers gave us "little green men," we had little men in green—faeries. Some fae folk have oversized eyes and heads (Chapter 4), exactly like Grey aliens today.

  Not all faeries are short, of course. Some, especially faerie kings and queens, are reported as human-sized. They tower over their diminutive subjects, just as modern eyewitnesses describe taller "supervising" Greys directing the actions of shorter aliens.

"Researchers now know that the taller alien, whom abductees sometimes call the 'doctor' or the 'specialist'… often joins the abduction after the shorter aliens have performed an examination of the abductee," wrote David Jacobs. (A quick note: though alien abduction researchers like Jacobs and Budd Hopkins exhibited ethically problematic behavior, they have nonetheless influenced our concepts of contact a great deal, and are cited throughout the coming chapters. *Caveat emptor.*)[2306]

- **Anomalous lights.** Whether one deems orbs of light extraterrestrial or faerie in origin is entirely dependent upon the circumstances. In the sky, it is the former; inside an ancient monument, the latter. Even this, of course, is subject to cultural norms.

- **Wands.** These faerie accessories (Chapter 5) repeatedly appear in UFO reports. Wands regularly facilitate the **paralysis** or **levitation** of UFO witnesses, powers consistently ascribed to faeries.[2307]

In one case exemplifying High Strangeness, a Belgian farmer approached a landed UFO, only to have a small alien ask him the time. After his response, the being told him he was incorrect "and pointed a wand at him which paralyzed him until the alien had departed in his craft," leaving circular burn marks on the ground.[2308]

- **Pixie led.** Just as faeries lead unsuspecting farmers into unfamiliar territory or render familiar territory unrecognizable (Chapter 4), modern alien abductees find themselves compelled to visit deserted locations, only to be taken aboard UFOs. These kidnappings often take place on **roads**, symbols of **liminality** (Chapter 9).

Laura, one of Budd Hopkins's case studies, was on her way home late one afternoon when an urge to pull into a church parking lot suddenly seized her. She was noting the absence of cars ("strange for a Sunday afternoon in that busy area") when a silver UFO appeared above. The craft took off, and suddenly it was nighttime.[2309]

According to Hopkins, such decisions are "remembered as odd—even irrational—and frequently a witness will say something like 'I didn't even know there was a road there, but I found myself turning off the main route to drive down it. I stopped next to this field, and there was a UFO hovering above the trees.'"[2310] As we see later in Hopkins's work, some abductees even report following **faerie animals** like deer into forests where their abductions occur.

- **Faerie-rings.** These anomalies are roughly analogous to modern crop circles and saucer nests (Chapters 4 and 8).

- **Dwellings.** Faeries find association with subterranean spaces, mountains, and ancient monuments (Chapter 8), connections alleged in contemporary UFO sightings.

- **Livestock mutilation.** Mutilated or missing livestock, once understood as faerie harvests, have become evidence of UFO interference.[2311]

- **Missing time**. "A close encounter with fairies is perilous business," wrote Eddie Bullard. "Any human who spends an hour or so in their company may return home to find that fifty or one hundred years have passed—a motif called the 'supernatural lapse of time in Fairyland,' with hints of the time-lapse phenomenon in abductions."[2312] This attribute, shared across all visits to the Otherworld, is explored in the next chapter, as is **vehicular and electronic interference.**

- **Elaborate taxonomies.** Faeries appear in a wide variety of shapes and sizes not only worldwide, but even within region-specific folklore (e.g. Germans believed not only in elves, but nixen, dwarfs, giants, etc.). Today, aliens take the guise of Greys, Reptilians, Mantids, tall blond Nordic humans, short hairy dwarfs, and more.

"The extreme diversity of aliens is more plausibly compared to the plethora of folklore entities than to thousands of different extraterrestrial species," Patrick Harpur wrote.[2313]

- **Implants.** *Blast, blustery,* and *blister* share etymological roots.[2314] Appropriately, angry fae folk used blustery gusts of wind to unleash "faerie blasts" upon victims, afflictions manifesting as lesions, bumps, or blisters. When lanced, these blemishes yielded all manner of detritus: splinters, grass, bones, moths, teeth, rags, rusty nails, bits of porcelain, or rocks.[2315]

Today, alien abductees commonly claim devices to locate, monitor, or communicate with them are implanted in their bodies. When surgically removed, these normally appear mundane—just like objects excised from faerie blasts. Alien implants are covered in later chapters.

Other abductees claim alien genetic tampering causes Morgellons, a controversial condition manifesting skin lesions which produce peculiar string or fiber-like protrusions. Again, we find antecedent in faerie lore: one man offending the faeries received a blast on his leg. When the boil was "let," "a long white string came out and continued to fall in a pile to the floor."[2316]

- **Glamour and shapeshifting.** Glamour, faeries' ability to alter the appearance of objects and themselves, is shared with modern aliens (including invisibility). Ufologists attribute this to "screen memories," imagery projected telepathically or technologically into experiencers' minds to obscure their accurate recall—but they are functionally identical to glamour. Like faeries, aliens are often seen **phasing** through solid objects. [2317]

- **Defects.** Much as faeries might appear perfectly-formed save one flaw, aliens often appear human, albeit with a telling difference like slightly oversized eyes or misnumbered digits. In an echo of hollow-backed huldren (Chapter 4), some aliens

like the entity in Carl Higdon's encounter never allow themselves to be seen from the rear (Chapter 12).[2318]

Moreover, **rear-facing feet**—occasionally found in faeries, or psychopomps like Xolotl—resemble how some aliens allegedly turn their heads 180°.

"The craft landed, and I saw a giant creature get out," said a witness in Belize. "At first it walked forward, and then all of a sudden, it began to walk backward. Its knees actually reversed, its head pivoted and it walked backward. It is difficult to describe. It rotated its head around so it looked like it was going forward even though it was walking backward."[2319]

- **Abilities and body composition.** Aliens can levitate, glow, disappear/appear at will, etc. just as faeries can, and witnesses who touch them often describe their bodies as soft, frail and yielding to the touch (Chapter 13). Robert Kirk described faerie bodies as "spongious, thin, and delicate," consuming *foyson*, or the essence of food offerings, via osmosis. In the modern era, we find allusions to aliens gaining nutrients through their skin.[2320]

- **Power over sleep.** All residents of the Otherworld, including faeries and aliens, can induce sleep (Chapter 4).

- **Euphemisms.** Just as anyone speaking of faeries utilized flattering synonyms, some alien abductees are so frightened by their experiences that they simply call extraterrestrials "them." As at the core of faerie euphemisms, there is a belief aliens are "always listening." For example, Strieber claims his Visitors become quite angry should he lie about them, verbally or in writing.[2321]

Penalties for speaking ill of or too frequently about aliens mirror those of the faeries. Following a dramatic encounter with a nine-foot-tall, white-suited humanoid in her Merseyside garden in 1977, Barbara Street was warned by a neighbor

experiencing similar contact, "The aliens are watching you and, if you continue telling people about your sighting, something would happen to you or your son may be abducted."[2322]

- **Abduction.** Faeries and aliens both kidnap human beings, sometimes accompanied by inclement weather (Chapter 13). Both often, though not exclusively, target similar demographics: women, children, and artists. They even share **motivations**: just as faeries wish to incorporate humans into their diminishing bloodlines, modern aliens claim their race is dying and in dire need of human genetic material. Both exhibit a **preoccupation with sexuality and reproduction**, their unions generating half-human **hybrids** which resemble changelings (Chapter 17).[2323]

- **Psi phenomena.** Faeries and aliens alike exhibit telepathy and knowledge of the future, talents sometimes passed on to their abductees.[2324] UFO contact also causes **poltergeist activity**, a phenomenon once blamed upon fae folk (Chapter 12).

- **Dancing.** The faeries' favorite pastime sometimes pops up in alien abductions. As with faerie sightings, alien dances may include indescribable **music**, as in Suzy Hansen's experiences (Chapters 6, 11, and 17).

Dancing aliens typify High Strangeness. Such frivolous behavior fits incongruously within these otherwise upsetting narratives. For example, one experience from abductee-cum-researcher Beverly Trout featured Grey aliens line dancing in cowboy costumes.[2325]

- **Surgeries.** Medical procedures are a staple of alien abductions (Chapter 12), altered states of consciousness, and shamanic initiation, with rough analogues in faerie folklore (Chapter 7). The ailments reported by UFO witnesses resemble faerie curses (Chapter 16).

- **Inverted clothing.** A common way to dispel faerie enchantment involves inverted clothing (Chapter 4); alien abductees find their clothes on inside-out, backwards, or otherwise worn incorrectly following encounters. For instance, alleged abductee Linda Cortile "once awoke from an experience wearing her pajama tops on her legs, and when she got out of bed and tried to walk, she tripped on the sleeves and fell."[2326] While it is rarely implied this is done by the abductee, the result is the same: expulsion from the Otherworld.

Faced with so many correspondences, an argument could be made that it is easier to list *dissimilarities* between faerie folklore and alien abduction reports than *similarities*. Perhaps the incongruency most-cited by ETH proponents are the UFOs themselves, which regularly appear as structured craft, rather than faerie lights; yet there is no shortage of spirits piloting ships through the heavens. Wrote Patrick Harpur:

> ...the *ihk'al* of the Tzeltal Indians in Mexico fly about with a kind of rocket attached to their backs. They are described as three-foot-tall, hairy humanoids who occasionally use their means of propulsion to carry people off. Flying vehicles of a technology appropriate to the culture in which they appear are not uncommon. A native American myth tells of Algon, a Chippewa hunter who stumbled across a circular pathway worn by many feet in the grass. To find out who made it. he hid and waited, eventually hearing music. As it grew louder. he saw in the air an osier (willow) car carrying four pretty women who landed and danced beautifully in a circle. When Algon approached, they fled to their car and soared away.[2327]

Note that the *ihk'al* is sometimes considered an avatar of the god of death, sporting a wide-brimmed hat.[2328] In Europe, the Wodejäger and Odin lead the Wild Hunt in similar headwear, traveling on storms.

Though rarer than on winds, horseback, or on foot, faeries traveled in aerial vehicles as well. In the 16th century Reginald Scot wrote of people "taken away by the sayd Spirits, for a fortnight, or month together, being carryed with them in Chariots through the Air…."[2329]

At other times it seems orbs of light are the most fundamental version of aerial phenomena, onto which we graft our cultural expectations. This is evident in a traditional Galloway tale where "a blue light moving swiftly over the waves some distance from shore" revealed not a flying saucer, "but a tiny carriage" inside, "drawn by six white horses… 'crowded with elfin figures….'" The carriage, illuminated by blue coach lamps, sounded "a clear fairy horn" upon landfall, where it raced across the moors.[2330]

"I have pointed out that aerial phenomena very similar to our UFOs had been reported in the 9th century in the form of vessels in the sky, as airships in the days of Jules Verne, as ghost rockets in 1946 and as spacecraft in more recent times, as if they mimicked human expectations," Vallee wrote. "Everything works as if the UFO phenomenon remained consistently one step ahead of human technology."[2331]

None of these similarities are to suggest that aliens are faeries, or vice versa. There is no supreme "true" mythology (although faerie and spirit folklore may be closer than our modern interpretation). Rather, the point is that these belief systems are byproducts of their respective societies, both

grasping at an inherently universal, if unknowable, experience. Aliens and faeries may be identical, or only closely related, *but the connections exist.* For these reasons, it seems more appropriate to call these beings *faeliens* than either culture-bound definition.

Why impede our discussion with this exhaustive list of similarities? Primarily because it supports an undeniable, bedrock connection between UFOs and death. If aliens and faeries represent the same phenomenon, and faeries are strongly tied to the dead, then by the transitive property, aliens find the same association.

Ashes to ashes, stardust to stardust

To fully appreciate the history between UFOs and death, we must place it within the context of our relationship with the overworld, the afterlife above. While the skies were, and still are, named the final destination of our souls, few cultures conceived of heavenly bodies in the way our modern astronomy has revealed them, as physical planets.

One notable exception appears to be Africa's Dogon people, who long ago incorporated "the movements and certain characteristics of virtually invisible stars" into their religion, all in the apparent absence of advanced instrumentation or Western contamination. From a world circling the "Dog Star" Sirius, the Dogon claim, hailed the Nommo, amphibious deities central to their cosmology.[2332]

While the Dogon's interpretation favors modern astronomy, cosmic pluralism in the Classical tradition more closely resembled what we would call "parallel universes." Democritus claimed worlds existed "infinite in number and differing in size. In some there is neither Sun nor Moon, in others there are more than one." These were not duplicates of Earth—our world was held unique—but rather infinite alternate realities, some growing, others declining, destroyed "through collision with one another."[2333]

Instead, mankind conceived of space as an Otherworld, an outlook undoubtedly informed by staring into the night sky after consuming entheogens (a habitual practice of psychonauts to this day). In Plato's

Cosmology, planetary bodies were beings, heroes, gods, and the souls of virtuous men who rejoined their companion stars at death.[2334] Similarly, Hindu texts explain "the stars are the lights of righteous men." The Aztec dead became "beings of light (often as stars)," and stellar iconography litters Egyptian afterlife belief. Only in Mesopotamia did the dead fail to become stars, though themes of ascent still present themselves.[2335]

Secular folklore inverted these notions, adding the belief that new *births* on Earth are accompanied by the appearance of corresponding stars, which wane with their owners' passing (perhaps reflecting how the Star of Bethlehem appeared in conjunction with Christ's birth). Most cultures treated stars as symbols of "divine guidance" or "highest attainment."[2336]

Overworlds are pervasive, appearing in cosmologies far removed from one another. Icelander Eiríkur Laxdal's late 18th century *Ólands saga* recorded that "the dead live on in the stars."[2337] In Chuukese mythology from Micronesia, the dead ascend several layers of heaven above Earth before settling just beneath the gods themselves.[2338] In Polynesia, Iran, and India, souls sometimes traveled "underground" each morning with the moon, itself linked to chthonic Greek deities like Persephone and Hecate.[2339] Dante placed the lowest of the seven planetary heavens on the moon, "where inconstant souls manifested on ascent to paradise."[2340]

"In Iran, a very important source of the whole idea [of dead leaving to the sky], and in Spain, where the lunar symbolism is prominent on the least Romanized tombs, the dead were exposed in the air to be eaten by birds, instead of being interred," wrote folklorist W.M.S. Russell. "Heracles, who

rose directly to Olympus from his pyre, also figures in tomb imagery, leading the way to the skies."[2341]

We often see Chapter 2's psychopomps leading the dead through these supernal realms. Stars represent both Yama's dogs and Zoroastrianism's yellow dogs, which guard the Chinvat Bridge.[2342] The planet Venus, itself dubbed the Morning/Evening Star, represents the Aztec hound Xolotl[2343] and Australia's Barnumbir.[2344]

Wandering the Milky Way

Another consistent motif renders the Milky Way a path to the afterlife, present in Polynesia and overwhelmingly popular in the New World. This is abundantly clear from the orientation of Native American monuments (Chapter 8).[2345]

The *Camino de Santiago* tracing the Iberian peninsula indicates similar belief may have arisen in Europe. Prior to its 8th century attribution to Christianity's St. James, pilgrims walked these pathways to follow the Milky Way to Spain's westernmost point: *Finisterrae*, "the end of the world," the border "closest to the land of death, to the 'other world.'"[2346]

Even when cultures sent their dead to the underworld, their souls might counterintuitively reach it not by descending but *ascending*, going into the sky and traveling along the Milky Way.[2347] In many mystical traditions, "the voyage to the underworld is the night sky below the ecliptic," or path of the sun, according to Christopher Knowles. Students could practice this journey throughout their lives in preparation for their final moments, moving upward by turning inward and traveling astrally to the beyond.[2348]

Citing Mayan, Hindu, and Egyptian mythologies, ancient mysteries writer Bibhu Dev Misra suggested placement of the underworld in the sky may be partially due to the symbolic resonance between caves and black holes. Sure enough, scientists discovered "a supermassive black hole at the center of our

galaxy" in 1998. The presence of similarly-placed "wormholes" in other spiral galaxies like the Milky Way has been postulated.[2349]

Barring coincidence, how ancient people were able to symbolize these realities before modern astronomy remains a mystery. Profound questions arise: did the Mound Builders' ogee portal represent a black hole at the center of the Milky Way? If so, do black holes lead to other dimensions—perhaps the afterlife?

The constellation Cygnus (the "Swan," another psychopomp) marks the beginning of the Milky Way's "Great Rift, Dark Rift or Dark River." A brilliant entry from the European mythology blog "The Soul of Bones" brings together many of our usual suspects:

> In the case where the Milky Way is perceived as the body of a goddess, Cygnus would be roughly where her two legs part—in some sense, perhaps her womb. Where it is the World Tree, it would be situated where its roots begin to split from the trunk. It is interesting to think that in Norse myth, two swans (from which all other swans descend) are depicted as swimming upon the lake or pool —the Well of Origin—at the base of the Tree. Since Cygnus is found beside the constellation Lyra, it was said by the Greeks that Cygnus represented Orpheus who was transformed into a swan following his death at the hands of the Maenads and placed in the sky next to his beloved lyre...
>
> Some have also suggested that for many early peoples, who orientated temples, great earthworks, megaliths and graves towards the north, their belief was that the realm of the dead lay in the direction of the north. For several cultures, the Milky Way was thought of as a path to the otherworld, a 'ghost road' of sorts, which gods, shamans and the spirits of the dead would travel. Considering this, alongside Cygnus as the celestial bird of cosmic creation,

resting in the uppermost branches of the World Tree or else swimming upon the Well of Origin, combined with Deneb as the Pole Star and cosmic axis at the time this mythic imagery may have originated, provides us with a powerful analogy. They may have thought that Cygnus or other places in the stars served as gateways to the celestial otherworld.[2350]

Goin' up to the spirit(s) in the sky

Why did the sky capture our imagination in the first place? In addition to being unreachable—as it remains, in any meaningful way—space was simply the only visible arena large enough to contain the multitudinous dead.[2351] The psychopompic sun and moon probably influenced this assumption.

Hegemonius's *Acta Archelai* (4th c.) suggested the sun collects departed souls from the Earth in 12 urns for purification. As the sun deposits them on the lunar surface, the moon waxes until full, then "ferries its passengers across toward the east wind, and thereby effects its own waning in getting itself delivered of its freight. And in this manner it goes on making the passage across, and again discharging its freight of souls drawn up by the urns, until it saves its own proper portion of the souls."[2352]

The overworld impulse seems pernicious, even infecting early astronomers, according to H. Percy Wilkins. Observable features on the moon "were named after actual personages, living or dead," he wrote in 1957. Following their deaths, "*the spirits or ghosts of the personages concerned entered into formal possession and took up residence within their respective craters!*"[2353] Wilkins continues:

> Discussion actually took place as to whether or not within the crater named after Plato there resided the spirit of the famous Greek Philosopher, together with other and numerous spirits who were continually studying the academic philosophy!... In

> such follies our ancestors allowed their imaginations to populate the moon… this [belief] was followed by animals and trees, afterwards moved to the other side, whereas nowadays this mysterious region has become a flying saucer base.

Today, we rightly dismiss such ideas as fantasy. Yet we must entertain the possibility that genuinely anomalous experiences may have inspired such beliefs. Psychedelic trips regularly send the user's consciousness into orbit, and the NDE literature is filled not only with stories of ascent, but overt travel into outer space.

For instance, Durdana Khan, diagnosed with viral encephalitis in 1968, died for around 15 minutes during childhood. Upon returning, she claimed to have visited "a beautiful garden among the stars" filled with delectable fruit where she met her grandfather and his mother, whom she correctly identified from a photograph: "I met her in the stars," she said, despite having never seen the picture before.[2354]

In one tragic 1978 NDE, a mother miscarried her child at five months, losing six pints of blood. During her clinical death, she "reeled backwards" into space, flying "through the rings of Saturn" and "seeing massive rocks and dust particles right before my eyes… I was an astronaut, a fabulous free spirit of joy!"[2355]

A pair of more recent examples comes from 2017 and 2015. After she stopped breathing on December 17, Sharon ascended through the hospital roof into "the vast dark universe… I could see brilliant stars and planets all around me."[2356] Two years earlier, another NDEr found himself in space,

where he "could see planets, stars, and galaxies… I can feel the earth far behind me. I'm traveling deeper and deeper through the universe."[2357] Other NDEs, where people *literally go to spaceships*, are covered in the next chapter.

The overworld also arose from what can best be described as legitimate spirit contact. Long before the stars birthed modern UFOs, we associated them with deities, spirits, and, intermittently, faeries. The "Selena Moor" story described the fae folk as "star worshippers," perhaps referring to "when they lived as mortals—maybe thousands of years ago."[2358] One informant told Evans Wentz in 1911 he believed the *gentry* "came from the planets—according to my idea."[2359]

One modern story describes a night watchman who, patrolling an undeveloped valley near a Hawaiian resort, saw "a tiny person maybe only two feet tall"—possibly a menehune—scouring the ground as if it had misplaced something. A rooster crowed, drawing the being's attention to the witness. Its purple, glowing eyes held the watchman's gaze until it looked upwards, prompting the witness to follow suit. A "bright star" then broke in two "and both new dimmer stars floated in opposite directions but in a straight line away from each other." Looking back, the being had disappeared. The watchman refused to report the encounter to the resort, instead sharing it with a friend.[2360]

"Certainly, fairies are known to move from stone circles and raths when we reach particular points in the year such as Samhain, Bealtaine or during the zenith of certain constellation or star rises," noted David Halpin. "It would be

a nice project to try to determine just how encounters and sightings rise and fall before and during these yearly points."[2361]

Ancient alien theorists would seize upon such analysis as *astronomical* truth, when perhaps it is better looked at from an *astrological* perspective, where "the planets" represent not discrete, physical "islands," but rather inviolable forces defined by their relationship to Earth—and, by extension, to humanity.

In search of *prisca ufologia*:

Ancient cosmologies, fictions, and stellar religions

Given the overworld's ubiquity, UFOs as a means to reach the afterlife make perfect sense. Yet in numerous cosmologies mankind itself originated in the stars, rendering such trips not departures, but rather returns home. Cheyenne priest White Eagle told Gregory Little that the dead return to the stars at death, and implied that—much to his surprise—this "happy hunting ground" was none other than Sirius, the Dogon "source of souls."[2362]

Indigenous testimony often confuses modern researchers. When describing visits from their interstellar "ancestors," New World tribes use the term interchangeably to reference human spirits of the ancestral dead *and* physical, living members of a progenitor race appearing either human or non-human. These definitions are further subject to regional and individual interpretation. Ghosts or aliens, take your pick.

Few have navigated these tricky waters more sensitively than Ardy Sixkiller Clarke, who has spoken to numerous tribespeople about ancestral visits from the stars. Many of the accounts she has gathered roughly correspond to ancient alien tropes. A Navajo informant, for example, said his grandfather described their ancestor race as interstellar "seed layers" who populated the planet with lifeforms and regularly "come back to check on them."[2363] Mayan descendants, on the other hand, reject the notion we were civilized by or

somehow subservient to these beings: "… the highly intellectual race is our ancestors. We are the same."[2364]

Among other tribes, the boundaries between physical and spirit elide effortlessly. Indigenous beliefs from around the world sometimes place mankind's origins in Otherworld locales like the sky or underground, perhaps not literal truths but rather indicators of our fundamental spiritual nature. The Cree, for example, "claimed they came from the stars in spirit form and then became flesh and blood."[2365] In short, indigenous testimony commonly rejects "either/or" thinking in favor of the "both/and" imaginal interpretation of UFOs. Clarke's work is highly recommended for anyone seeking deeper analysis of these modalities.

Such traditions render it altogether impossible to separate "spirit ships" from flying saucers. Ergo, the question at hand becomes which mythologies describe explicit *planetary* (not interdimensional) *extraterrestrials* (not gods or spirits) *receiving* (not dispensing) human souls.

In answering this, we find that Ufology has *always* been a spiritual discipline, only recently usurped by Materialism. If an original Ufology exists, a *prisca ufologia* if you will, it is a paranormal, rather than extraterrestrial, hypothesis.

First, a brief digression into fiction where, in the Old World, we find the earliest recorded spiritual extraterrestrials—indeed, these works are often cited as the first appearances of "aliens" in popular culture. In the humorously-named *True History* (2nd c.), Greek satirist Lucian claimed he sailed to the moon, populated by warring factions. There he met Endymion, a visitor "rapt up long since from the earth as he was asleep, and brought

hither, where he was made king of the country," clearly referencing a sleep-induced OBE.[2366]

In *The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter*, a 10th century Japanese story, the eponymous hero finds a thumb-sized girl in a shining bamboo stalk and raises her as his own (shades of Theosophic faeries) until, accompanied by a blinding light, she returns to her home on the moon. The Emperor, who has fallen in love with her, dispatches his men to Mount Fuji, the mountain closest to Heaven, hoping to contact her (recall Japanese conflation of graves and mountains from Chapter 8).[2367]

Finally, *The Adventures of Bulukiya* from *One Thousand and One Nights*, collected in English in the early 1700s but told much earlier, sees the protagonist traversing various cosmic realms. Scholars contend this represents a precursor to modern science fiction; being heavily influenced by Islam, the text is replete with spiritual references.[2368]

But fiction is not belief. At this juncture, it would be easy to digress into an endless history of UFO religions. Dozens exist, so a brief overview must suffice.

To be clear, we are not discussing ancient alien reworkings of Sumerian religions or Christianity, but rather worship with an overtly interstellar flavor embedded from its founding. An argument can be made, as championed by Christopher Knowles via Kripal, that Christian Gnosticism was "history's first flying saucer cult." It presents many of the trappings, speaking of "our true home among the stars, about the secret spark of divinity that sleeps in us all, about the stellar nature of the soul, and about the savior who descended from the stars in order to teach us how to get back home."[2369]

Turning to the modern era—when UFO religions truly came into their own—the Latter Day Saint movement begun in the early 1800s espouses cosmic pluralism. The planetary body Kolob serves as the nearest throne of God.[2370]

As with contemporary faerie folklore, modern Ufology owes much to late 19th century Theosophy. The idea that those in trance can contact beings identifying as extraterrestrials first appeared in Emanuel Swedenborg's 1758 *De Telluribus in Mundo nostro Solari*, in which he communicated telepathically not only with aliens, but extraterrestrial spirits *in the afterlife*.[2371]

> In a state of wakefulness, I was led as to the spirit by the Lord through angels to a certain earth in the universe, accompanied by some spirits from this globe… Near the boundary of our solar system, there appeared first a whitish but dense cloud, and after it a fiery smoke ascending from a great gulf: this was an immense chasm, separating our solar system on that side from certain systems of the starry heaven... I was conveyed across the midst of it, and then there appeared beneath in that gulf or chasm very many men, who were spirits (for all spirits appear in the human form, and are actually men)... One of them, however, told me that they were guards to prevent spirits passing without permission from this into any other system in the universe. That this was the case, was also confirmed; for when some spirits who were in the company, and who had not received permission to pass, came to that great interstice, they began to cry out wildly that they were perishing, for they were like persons struggling in the agony of death; wherefore they stopped on this side of the chasm, and could not be conveyed any further; for the fiery smoke which exhaled from the chasm attacked them, and tortured them in this manner.[2372]

Swedenborg profoundly influenced Helena Blavatsky, and by the 1870s these ideas had diffused into Theosophy. Adherents often spoke of mystical powers from other worlds or star systems. Blavatsky herself claimed contact with spirit guides from planets like Venus.[2373]

Spiritualism, the era's other predominant esoteric school, adopted similar concepts. Encouraged by his own "spirit messages," American dentist John Ballou Newbrough published *Oahspe: A New Bible* in 1882, asserting within that luminous, intergalactic "soul-ships" travel the skies, scooping up the newly deceased.[2374] By 1894, Hungarian Spiritualist Hélène Smith claimed she astrally visited Mars, providing detailed drawings of the planet's architecture and learning to read and write their language (conveniently similar to French).[2375]

These notions also took root in the nascent genre of science fiction. The same year as Smith's Martian journey, John Jacob Astor IV's *A Journey in Other Worlds* depicted Saturn as "an abode of departed spirits."[2376]

In search of *prisca ufologia*:

The contactees

In a sense, early UFO *contactees*—recipients of messages from "Space Brothers," beautiful, semi-divine, humanlike extraterrestrials—were literal Spiritualists, using mediumship as their primary tool to interact with alien intelligences. A direct lineage be traced from Theosophy and séances to organizations like the Borderland Sciences Research Associates of the mid-1940s, which channeled extraterrestrials with help from medium Mark Probert.[2377]

Among the many messages he received, Probert claimed all "skycraft" came from other planets' "etheric regions," the "waiting halls" of death. The "disc ships" came from the etheric region of Venus, specifically.[2378] Fortean researcher Jerome Clark refers to Probert as the first modern contactee, notable because he predates the modern UFO era, demarked by Kenneth Arnold's 1947 sighting of nine shining objects soaring past Washington's Mount Rainier.

Arnold's testimony may have spawned decades of speculation linking flying saucers to extraterrestrials, but he himself remained circumspect, recalling a childhood sighting of a light orb in the presence of his great-grandmother as she lay in repose. Later in his life operating search and rescue missions, Arnold saw "similar mysterious lights at airplane crash sites where there had been fatalities," wrote Brent Raynes. "He described one case in which a

family at a ranch in California had sighted two basketball sized balls of light soon after a nearby fatal small plane crash claimed the lives of two young men who had been onboard."[2379] According to his daughter, by the end of Arnold's life he suspected "the flying saucers were the connection between the living and the dead."[2380]

Spiritual interpretations of the phenomenon thrived in the early days of Ufology. The topic appeared regularly in the earliest issues of Britain's *Flying Saucer Review*.

"I believe that a *prima facie* case has been made out for the non-physical nature of the beings who manipulate the u.f.o.s," wrote Arthur Constance in 1956, adding "that beings in other dimensions—dimensions of the spiritual cosmos—may regard a man's belief (his attitude to the cosmos) as of far greater importance than the time of his death or the way of his death."[2381]

The post-Arnold decade saw numerous colorful characters connecting UFOs and death, typically involving Space Brothers (who, it must be noted, not only resemble Theosophy's "ascended masters" but beautiful elves as well). A few figures of note:

- Just one year after Arnold's sighting, **Wayne Aho** claimed flying saucer occupants contacted him telepathically while he was logging. Having recently read about a fatal plane crash around which UFOs had been spotted for three days afterward, he wondered who these beings were and received an answer: "We are caretakers of the souls of the dead!"[2382]

- **George Adamski,** perhaps the most famous of all contactees, supposedly first encountered the Venusian Orthon on November 20, 1952, from which sprouted a cult following. Many of Adamski's conversations with the Space Brothers involved spirituality.[2383]

In one instance he was told, "We cannot take our houses with us when we go from one place to another. Neither can we take a body, which is the house, from one world to another in death. The material of your Earthly bodies belongs to Earth, and must remain there to maintain your world. But when you move from Earth to another planet, that world will lend you of its materials to build a house according to the needs and conditions that exist there."[2384]

Adamski supposedly returned to Earth the day after his death. A Devonshire man named Ernest Bryant dubiously claimed to have met three beings from a landed flying saucer, one of which was a teenager who identified himself as "Yamski," Adamski's reincarnation.[2385]

- The same year that Adamski encountered Orthon, **George Van Tassel** began receiving messages from what he believed were aliens, the most prominent of which was Ashtar.[2386]

"I know now that angels are people that come out of space," he wrote after encountering Solgonda, an "angel of space" who took him aboard his spacecraft. "They not only colonize planets and communicate by thought, but they spend their time helping other people to understand Life."[2387]

Drawing upon imagery of the Christian rapture, Van Tassel asserted the onus lies upon each of us to justify our ascent with the Space Brothers through actions which increase our "vibratory body auras." "Your aura, or the frequency of the body force field, will determine whether you are taken or left… If your body aura or force field conforms with, or exceeds, the established level of the spacecraft force field, then you can enter the ships."[2388]

- Having read Adamski's book, **Howard Menger** allegedly rekindled his childhood contact with extraterrestrials and traveled aboard a "Venusian Scout Ship" in 1956.[2389] In *From Outer Space to You,* he wrote, "Those who die on this planet without knowing the truth or having the gifts of awareness are prisoners of this planet and do not leave it... Those, however, who die knowing the truth are not afraid to die. They know there is no death in Truth, and that they may be reborn on another planet, Venus, for example: a veritable heaven compared to Earth. Heaven is not an isolated place; instead there are degrees of heavens." Menger also claimed Earth was the battlefield "for men's minds and souls."[2390]

- **Orfeo Angelucci** also first encountered the Space Brothers in 1952. In subsequent trips, he "seemed to see all his previous incarnations, and understood the mysteries of life," at one point thinking "he was about to die" before returning to Earth.[2391]

Angelucci's books *Son of the Sun* and *Secret of the Saucers* cover a great deal of spiritual ground. Lyra, one of his spiritual contacts, explained their "disks, or saucers… are in your space-time frame as harbingers of mankind's coming resurrection from the living death. Although our disks are essentially etheric; that is, non-material… they can almost instantaneously attract substance to take on any degree of material density necessary… These are from other worlds and also space islands of various densities of matter. Some are on the borderline between materiality and non-materiality."[2392]

That Orfeo (Orpheus) should receive this information from Lyra (the lyre) speaks to the shamanic reification seen in so many contacts.

- In November 1957, Shropshire newsagent **Hubert Lewis** was collecting newspapers in an ill-mood when all ambient noise ceased and "a tall figure appeared in the road in front of him," accompanied by "a large object of 'a dull lightness', which seemed to rotate, although part of it was still." The being knew every intimate detail of Lewis's life. He said the stranger "promised I should be looked after and guided along the right path if I kept faith. My [deceased] sons and

my wife were still with me in spirit, as were my friends (he mentioned one whom I had forgotten, of forty years ago)... He wished me well, then suddenly vanished, just like that."[2393]

- Over the course of several books, **Dana Howard** detailed her interactions with Diane, a beautiful space woman (no relation to the Greek goddess Diana, apparently). Her Venusian contact allegedly told her they sought to "raise Earth's density an entire octave," and that "workers are needed, both on the manifest side of the earth's surface and in the tenuous regions across the vale of death. In the interim, physical bodies will be regenerated and made ready for habitation on the higher planes." Some of these bodies would incarnate on other planets.[2394]

In a 1958 *Flying Saucer Review* article, Howard clearly articulated Jung's imaginal outlook: "The conventionalist believes the abstract world is for the dreamers. The concrete world is for the doers. They do not know there is a subjective-objective, a concrete-abstract… those on a higher dimension… would be *both* objective and *subjective*…."[2395]

- Following his wife's death in 1970, **Gabriel Green** "spent the remainder of his life attempting to establish interplanetary contact with his dearly departed," believing she had joined a mothership orbiting the Earth, piloted by beings he met 13 years earlier.[2396]

These and other contactees spoke often of flying saucers' spiritual dimensions, their language as inscrutable as any Spiritualist's or Theosophist's. For more on these figures, few resources come more highly recommended than Adam Gorightly's and Greg Bishop's *"A" is For Adamski: The Golden Age of UFO Contactees.*

In search of *prisca ufologia*:

Space programs, UFO cults, and Disclosure

The overworld even touches scientists. In the early days of the space station, rumors arose that Russian kosmonauts saw "angels" in 1986 which followed them for ten minutes. First only three beheld the apparition, but an additional six witnessed these glowing figures 12 days later.[2397] This is to say nothing of the heavy occult symbolism some see in rocket launches, timed to esoteric dates and christened with the names of pagan deities: as Christopher Knowles contends, "space is an altar."[2398]

The UFO religion most firmly ensconced in recent memory is the Heaven's Gate cult. Founded in 1974, the group came to national attention when 39 members, at the direction of leaders Marshall Applewhite and Bonnie Lu Nettles, committed mass suicide with phenobarbital and plastic bags in March 1997. The victims saw this as a way to evacuate their "earthly vehicles" and join a spacecraft traveling in the wake of Hale-Bopp, one of the brightest comets in decades. Though both tragic and foolish—nothing indicated Hale-Bopp's appearance was anomalous—there is detectable irony that Heaven's Gate's misguided interpretation may have been closer to the truth behind UFOs than those found in mainstream Ufology.[2399]

Nuts-and-bolts Ufologists believe themselves immune to quasi-religious advocacy, but the impulse manifests in more insidious ways. Advocates await

Disclosure with a fervor equally at home among Christians anticipating the Second Coming.

In 1980, Ufologist Mark L. Moravec noted how beliefs among contactees and abductees share elements with prophetic religious movements. Both exhibit dissatisfaction with existing social conditions; rejection of authority; prophetic revelations from higher beings; promises of a reborn, enlightened world; and catalyzation of self-identified leaders.[2400]

This doesn't mean UFOs are fantasy. If people are really meeting extraterrestrials (and not interacting with spirits), we may be seeing an expression of the "cargo cult" mentality, when Western trade with pre-industrial island cultures was revered by their populations as spiritual intervention. UFO contact might constitute a cargo cult writ large on a global scale.[2401]

In any case, Moravec's observations can easily be grafted onto the Disclosure movement. We are not being told the whole story, they claim. Disclosure will bring about peace—some even offensively deem it a human rights issue—or herald technology used to humanitarian ends. Disclosure advocates reject scientific consensus, even when offered by reasonable, open-minded skeptics. They hang on every word from self-appointed celebrities and documentarians—in it for *the truth,* we are assured, the money is a mere afterthought—who claim soon, any day now, Disclosure is nigh.

If this seems unduly harsh, it is only because the Disclosure movement seems to lack awareness (of UFO history, of themselves, of the foundations of Ufology) all while largely asserting the supremacy of the Extraterrestrial

Hypothesis and demeaning other approaches. In reality, spirituality and death have been traveling companions with Ufology from its inception.

The *prisca ufologia* is paranormal, and we have every right to explore it in those terms.

11

ALIEN ABDUCTIONS

OBJ



Are ghosts really UFOs and UFO entities, or are UFOs really ghosts?" John Keel asked. "Take your choice."[2402]

Comparisons of alien abductions to other contact modalities are not new. We have noted Kenneth Ring's observations regarding alien abductions and NDEs at length, and will continue to do so. Eddie Bullard outlined extensive similarities between abductions and shamanism which inform the next chapter. Finally, a handful of researchers like Keel have approached UFOs with a folklorist's knowledge of death, but few to the extent covered in this book.

Another, less celebrated, early proponent of the spirit connection was Ivar Mackay, who penned a series of *Flying Saucer Review* articles in 1970

matching UFOs with the occult. Mackay noted both UFO sightings and hauntings share numerous phenomena:

- Noxious odors, often of decay;
- an aversion to light;
- precipitation and apports like angel hair or the sensation of spirit "hairs" during séances;
- lowered ambient temperature;
- psi effects like telepathy, teleportation, telekinesis, and levitation;
- "shadowy, quasi-solid and solid figures";
- exploding orbs of light;
- violent noises like explosions, raps, and bangs;
- buzzing sounds;

- expanding objects, like lights or ectoplasmic appendages seen during séances;
- a dearth of photographic evidence;
- physical effects in witnesses;
- and poltergeist activity.[2403]

"Only *time* will tell," he wrote of these connections, many of which we explore, "but there is evidence to suggest that it is time we broke free from the fetters of the 'Rational' and the 'Traditional'—and pondered on these things."[2404]

F.W. Holiday drew similar comparisons three years later, writing that, like ghosts, UFOs seem capable of shifts from great mass to nil, appear and disappear from observation, and "embody an intelligent principle not derived from people living on earth… Science has been studying a parallel set of phenomena for well over a century. These are the apparitions and simulcrae generally termed 'ghosts.'"[2405]

Subsequent authors like Michael Grosso quipped in 2004 that "maddeningly elusive and surreal" UFOs and their occupants seem more akin to "antics of ghosts than machines from outer space."[2406] While not dismissing the ETH completely, Brad Steiger agreed:

> After almost 50 years of investigating the mysteries of the paranormal and the UFO, I have become convinced that in so many areas of human experience the two phenomena are one. And yet so many of my fellow researchers maintain that the accounts of hooded beings and greenish balls of light in people's homes are not evidence of ghostly phenomena but are really reports of extraterrestrial aliens who have crossed millions of light years to come to Earth to frighten people. The poltergeistic energy that tosses books from shelves and upsets furniture is the work of ETs, not the explosion of psychokinesis from someone entering puberty or undergoing emotional stress. The nightmarish horror of aliens who invade people's bedrooms and abduct them by going right through walls is not an experience of the astral body or a projection of the psyche, but an actual physical happening by extraterrestrials who can never get enough of examining human sexuality. And all those ghosts that materialize before humans in dark and lonely places or in creepy castles and moldering mansions are merely extraterrestrials who have explored the universe to find victims for their pranks.
>
> ...I believe so much of the UFO mystery to be the activity of ghosts, spirits, multidimensional beings—call them what you like—rather than the machinations of aliens from other planets.[2407]

Approaching the phenomenon from a psychological angle, skeptics and academics alike invoke our final hours when discussing flying saucers. UFOs, some contend, represent an "unconscious concern with death and immortality" borne of "a denial of the finite nature of life."

"*Death*—the ultimate alien and at the same time the most intimate alien that can be imagined," University of North Carolina professor David J. Halperin mused. "*Death*—bone of my bone and flesh of my flesh, born with

me at the moment of my birth and growing with me from babyhood onward."[2408]

Repeaters & Hauntings

Most Ufologists believe alien abductions are more widespread than we appreciate—reasonable, if they somehow relate to death, one of few guaranteed universals. Yet for whatever reason, some individuals consciously recall ongoing interactions with the Other, not once, not twice, but dozens of times throughout their lives, encompassing not only UFOs but ghosts, Bigfoot, and faeries. If these phenomena are separate, why do some of us seem encounter-prone across our lives, across distinct modalities, when many of us go our entire lives recalling few if any experiences?

Researchers once vilified anyone reporting recurring contact, derogatorily referring to them as untrustworthy, attention-seeking "repeaters." This attitude shifted significantly in recent decades, to the extent that those experiencing ongoing contact are in some ways regarded as *more* credible. Yes, a witness may have one UFO sighting in their life… but alien abductions are rarely standalone events. They seem to target "encounter-prone personalities," as Ring termed them.[2409]

The FREE data bear this out. In addition to a preponderance of OBEs and NDEs, 76% of experiencers had "seen what can be described as a ghost or spirit."[2410]

Indiana resident Charles Jones is one such witness. Jones saw UFOs "fairly frequently," including dramatic sightings where his home was buzzed by bright lights in 1966-1967. While driving home in '65, he saw "a small white

light" in a patch of fog harboring a small cylindrical ship with a large-eyed, large-nosed occupant. Jones described himself as partially psychic, often hearing raps and seeing the dead haunting his home, including his deceased sister-in-law, who passed through his bedroom one night. In another instance following his father's death, Jones saw a brilliant, bluish-green light appear over the body's eyes, which he interpreted as his father's soul. He acknowledged it, and the light dissipated.[2411]

Paranormal experiences beyond UFOs surround many abductees. "My life has been a case history of paranormal potpourri," Gina Willoughby told Ring, citing prebirth memories, numerous OBEs, and meetings with Bigfoot, nonphysical faeries, and her "true parents"—beings from a place called "Zenith."[2412] Keith Daniel ("a walking dictionary of the paranormal," Jenny Randles called him) related a childhood of psi-events, ghosts, UFOs, premonitions, and "timeslips," wherein he felt temporarily transported to another era.[2413] In a letter to the Striebers, another experiencer said they "could write a book, so many paranormal things have happened to me," including UFO sightings, OBEs, and hearing raps throughout their home.[2414]

Chapter 12 addresses psi phenomena in the lives of abductees (RSPK/poltergeist activity, telepathy, precognition, etc.). Despite the obvious overlap between psi and ghosts, we focus for the moment on the incidence of traditional hauntings and ghost encounters *before* versus *after* alien abductions.

Plenty of abductees fall into both categories. What emerges is a "chicken-or-the-egg?" conundrum: which comes first, paranormal activity or alien abductions?

Repeaters & Hauntings:

spirit precursors

In one camp, we find individuals describing communication with the Otherworld in childhood long before their alien abductions. Many inciting incidents are familiar from Chapter 7: illnesses, abuse, dissociation, etc., all consistent with spirits' selection of future shamans.

It should be noted that recall of such events can be incomplete or fragmentary. One abductee described their initial experience as "being brought back to my bedroom and landing on the bed with rather a large thump and then being aware of the craft outside. I forgot a lot of memories as a child until probably three or four years ago and then they started really coming back to me... I kind of had a child's naïveté in as much as I was fairly open and experiencing a lot of spiritual things as a child myself…."[2415]

Some of the most celebrated alien abductees claim paranormal activity at an early age. Twins Jack and Jim Weiner of Maine's famed 1976 "Allagash Abduction"—taken from their canoe by a bright light while fishing and later reporting alien medical procedures under hypnosis —remembered "visions of ghosts as children" which sat on their bed, sometimes pressing it down as they visited.[2416]

Another notable example comes from none other than Betty Hill. She and her husband Barney are widely known for their harrowing 1961 alien

abduction in New Hampshire, but Betty experienced plenty of supernatural occurrences both before and after the experience. In high school, her dreams accurately predicted the deaths of two friends in fatal automobile accidents, one of "many other dreams like that."[2417]

Betty believed she inherited this ability from her maternal grandmother and paternal great aunt. Her parents' second date while courting was to a Spiritualist meeting (how romantic!) where their marriage and number of children were accurately predicted. In 1954, her sisters saw "a large glowing green football-shaped object" in the sky, and later one of them owned a home haunted by the spirit of a small child, who impishly tipped over waste bins in the kitchen and tossed clothes about.[2418] (Unfortunately, Betty's habit of misidentifying recognizable aircraft as UFOs later earned her a reputation as a "repeater" in the negative sense—despite the other, legitimate phenomena which appear to have permeated her life in equal measure.)[2419]

The experiences of Betty Hill's family suggests a hereditary component, equally apparent in the bloodline of Ufologist Raymond E. Fowler. Fowler's own experiences are addressed later, but his wife, mother-in-law, brothers, daughters, sons, mother, and father all variously reported UFO experiences and ghost encounters, often involving deceased loved ones. Notably, his father claimed an OBE, NDE, timeslip, and a meeting with a deceased friend from his Navy service who told him "they would be together again and then disappeared." Fowler's father also presented scoop marks on his body—an alien abduction hallmark—and vaguely recalled meeting "tall robed entities" bathed in light. [2420]

Other alien abductees report similar paranormal precursors, often involving ghosts:

- During his research on the intersection of alien abductions and shamanism, Simon Harvey-Wilson spoke to several experiencers who "described paranormal events in their teenage years." The psychic abilities Patricia exhibited in her youth were "heightened" following her abductions. Angela saw premonitions and a Victorian ghost prior to her contact. Another future abductee, Michael, accurately called coin tosses and lived with "the feeling of ghosts in the house."[2421]

- Keith Daniel, mentioned earlier, grew up in a haunted house in Merseyside. "Many odd happenings took place here, including what we might call poltergeist making noises and moving objects," Randles wrote. "The noises included crying sounds, lights turning on and off on their own, and his father being flung across the landing by an unseen force."[2422]

In one instance, Daniel's father saw a friendly apparition wearing a habit and holding a book or box. During that time, his mother and sister saw UFOs, and his own experiences began in 1967 with dreams of being "abducted aboard a UFO by little men." Shortly thereafter he had his first daylight encounter involving "the most incredible rushing noise overhead." By the time he saw UFOs while camping in 1981—silent red and yellow/white lights hovering and zooming impossibly fast through the sky—such sightings were routine.[2423]

- On Independence Day 1970, Mrs. D.J. awoke from sleep to find a large, glowing orb bouncing across the meadows of Port Monmouth, New Jersey. Impressions in the grass were discovered, and her family saw additional light phenomena soon afterward. Events escalated when the television malfunctioned and foul odors filled the home, sending D.J. into a coma-like sleep filled with peculiar dreams.[2424]

Writing of the experience in the May/June 1971 edition of *Flying Saucer Review*, researcher Berthold Schwarz nearly glosses over the High Strangeness preceding her sighting: "Mrs. D.J. then described some highly personal possible precognitive experiences that pertained to the death of her baby years ago, an episode where she unexpectedly received a minor windfall of money, and several unusual childhood episodes when she lived in her maternal grandmother's haunted house."[2425]

- Cheshire witness Karen lived a life filled with ghosts and poltergeist phenomena before hearing a humming sound on a country lane in the summer of 1979, announcing a "blinding light" which shot into the sky from a nearby field. She was thereafter plagued by dreams of birthing horrific children—predictions of a later miscarriage, she believed.[2426]

Five years later, Karen saw the light again from her bedroom window. A six-foot-tall, white-skinned "woman" with slanted eyes appeared in the doorway, inviting her into the light. The last thing she remembered before awakening in bed was intense cold. Months later, the feeling of a little child's finger on her hands roused Karen from sleep. According to Randles, her husband flicked on the light and they "noticed a tiny light floating upwards and disappearing through the ceiling."[2427]

- Randles also met Gwyneth who, as early as she could recall, saw specters "passing through my bedroom or just standing and watching me." By age five, she was seeing "countless people" in public floating above the ground, perhaps "spirits of the dead in some unknown afterlife." After an epilepsy diagnosis later in life, "she frequently began to see and to dream about UFOs and aliens," identifying as an abductee.[2428]

- "Ghosts played an important part of my childhood," said Peter Gregory, whose psychic track record included locating two missing children in Scotland. Later, through remote viewing—psychic visualization at a distance—he contacted "Oona," an alien hybrid who claimed he had been put on Earth "as a direct result of alien genetic engineering in the early 1970s."[2429]

- Long before her extraterrestrial contact, Caryl Dennis grew up in a haunted house complete with mysterious footfalls, lights turning on and off of their own accord, scratching noises, and apparitions. These events constitute Dennis's "earliest conscious recall of paranormal activity—except, perhaps, for the vivid, recurring dream" of "pirates" dragging her from bed.[2430]

- A Florida housewife interviewed by Berthold Schwarz in 1984 claimed "a spectacular array of psychic talents," some documented on video: germinating seeds in her hands, bending metal in sealed jars, healing, teleporting, automatic writing in foreign languages, successful assistance with police investigations, and stigmata (including a Viking longship drawn on her abdomen).[2431]

It wasn't until later in life that she and her son watched "orange globes the size of a basketball in the orchard in the backyard." The talent seems familial, as her son manifested apports examined by Schwarz, and her mother, part Cherokee, recalled a vision of "two suns, then three suns, three moons, three rainbows and stars" on a hazy day after the end of World War I.[2432]

- Sara, whom researcher John Mack interviewed, claimed "small beings [began] communicating with [her] telepathically" after a medical massage to alleviate "pain at the base of her skull." Though right-handed, she began drawing channeled images of aliens with her left. She experienced extrasensory perception, synchronicities, and sensitivity to spirits.[2433]

Yet Sara also recalled being examined by some sort of presence at "six weeks old or less." As a child, she held faux séances. "Experiences related to ghosts 'were a permanent fixture of my whole childhood,' beginning at least as early as age four," Mack related. "'I became a premier ghost story teller.'"[2434]

Alongside these accounts, perhaps more frequently, we find abductees reporting hauntings *after* initial UFO contact.

Repeaters & Hauntings:

UFO precursors

A 2012 study by Denise Stoner and Kathleen Marden—herself Betty Hill's niece—found 88% of subjects reported increased paranormal activity at home following abductions, with over half claiming its absence prior.[2435]

Marden's findings seem to confirm her own suspicion that UFO contact occurs first and the supernatural follows: according to Brent Raynes, Marden felt her childhood experiences were "related to the UFOs, because just when that haunting started… she and her mother had an experience with a craft that landed across the road and they both felt that they had been abducted, and then all this—doors opening and closing by themselves," etc. began. Incidents at the Marden household also included floating orbs of light and poltergeist activity, as when coat hangers flew from a closet.[2436]

Bret Oldham's first anomalous memory comes from age five, when a Grey alien beckoned to him from outside the window of his Illinois home. His next recollection before losing consciousness was awakening on an brightly-lit examination table, the aliens transforming into human doctors.[2437]

Around age eight, Oldham's interest in the supernatural was fully kindled. Distinctly less-alien encounters began the following year after the grey-haired

ghost of an old lady appeared in the attic window next door, then vanished before his eyes. More traditional alien abductions continued alongside ghost sightings throughout his childhood, trailing into the present day: nightly visits from spirits, disembodied voices, faucets turning on, poltergeist activity, footsteps in the house, communication with a dead uncle, etc.[2438]

"… it was like a floodgate from another dimension had been opened," he wrote. Oldham eventually honed his psychic abilities, which he directly attributed to aliens. "I believe without a doubt that these increased paranormal experiences are a direct result from my alien abductions… there is a direct correlation between these events." Oldham believes these interdimensional beings, which transcend time and space, raised "the vibration rate of energy in my body" by "taking me through these dimensional portals and that this increase results in ghosts/spirits being able to more easily see me or sense my presence more than the average person… I am a paranormal magnet."[2439] In another time and place, Oldham would be a seer granted second sight by the fae folk.

Setting aside psi phenomena and poltergeist activity for the time being, we instead focus on alien abductees who see ghosts after meeting extraterrestrials.

- Many correspondents with the Striebers saw dead loved ones in the wake of their UFO experiences. One described psychic abilities entering her life after a May 1933 abduction at five years old, where four entities ushered her into a landed UFO on a hilltop, lowering "the top half of a coffin" over her to perform an examination. Subsequent experiences included a "visit to the moon," several OBEs, and regular

sightings of ghosts. She sometimes delivered entire sermons given to her by spirits.[2440]

- Another letter writer experiencing alien abductions from 1983-1993 reported seeing the dead during this timeframe. One day in 1986, an old truck pulled up to the curb and out stepped her father, who passed away in 1969. He pulled some fruit from the pickup's bed and rang the doorbell. The witness barely mustered a reply as he began his sales pitch, but for some reason she could not engage him any further than to say, "I'm sorry, I'm not interested." Dejected, the man turned and left. She remained convinced she had met her father, as he had also been a salesman and drove an identical truck.[2441]

- "It all started when I saw a flying saucer!" proclaimed psychic Betty Shine. Though she experienced weak psychic events after fleeing London in World War II, Shine's career was instigated by a structured craft she and her husband saw "going round and round in circles" years later above Spain. "I believe that [my] power has got something to do with the Space machine," she claimed. One afternoon shortly after the sighting, Shine's "mother appeared—she had been dead for seven years."[2442]

- After a beam of light entering her New England home temporarily paralyzed her, Linda regularly "felt the presence of people who had passed on including her deceased father," sometimes in the form of misty apparitions, "and was able to communicate with them." She also saw her double. Hypnotic regression with investigator David Webb suggests she was abducted that morning in 1968: she recalled her body lifting off the bed, followed by memories of pain while lying on a flat surface in a circular room accompanied by short, eggheaded beings with slanted eyes.[2443]

- Two witnesses outside a restaurant in Sheffield in March 1979 saw a grey flying saucer complete with a cupola, which housed two people inside bearing long, blond hair. The surrounding area seemed dead the entire time the object was present. "Following the UFO sighting the woman began to experience psychic phenomena, including noises and objects moving about in her house on their own, and saw an apparition of her dead husband," Randles reported.[2444]

- On June 30, 1983, Debra Kauble of Indiana sensed an intruder in her house, after which intense heat seized her and she was paralyzed, her entire body vibrating. The source was a white orb of light outside accompanied by five or six child-sized beings. The entities entered an egg-shaped craft—too small to hold them, Kauble thought—and departed. Her mother called to her, breaking the spell, and later revealed she too had seen the UFO. Following a deep depression, Kauble began communicating with ghosts and spirits.[2445]

- Harvey-Wilson's interviews with a man named Arthur indicated "the first [childhood] encounters that I had with an alien being really rocked my foundation of belief and then I started having these other abilities." These included seeing several days into the future, apports, predicting neighbors' deaths, and sightings of ghosts in his house.[2446]

UFO sightings even appear as antecedents to NDEs. In 1965 four-year-old Ron saw his first flying saucer: four Greys entered his bedroom "and floated [him] through the wall of the house" into a round room within a "space ship overhead," performing surgery on him and inserting a probe into his nose. Eight months later he drowned in the family swimming pool. Two angels escorted him "into a bright cloud" to meet his family in heaven where he

received a life review before returning to watch his resuscitation from a third-person perspective.[2447]

Conclusions are impossible with such contradictory data. Our question —"Which comes first, alien abductions or supernatural sensitivity?"—remains unanswered. Perhaps all experiencers possess psychic talents, some more latently than others. Like musical prodigies, you can either be born with these abilities or, with discipline and tutelage, learn them to equal proficiency. We return to these issues in Chapter 12.

From Harvey-Wilson:

> This introduces ideas about a possible interest in genetics by both aliens and shamans, which in turn leads to a discussion of heredity and relationships, either spiritual, alien or human. For example, some shamans inherit their vocation, which might imply that shamanic or paranormal abilities are genetically based, and which makes an interesting comparison with the fact that some alien abductions appear to run in families. However, an alternative suggestion is that the reported alien interest in genetics is a symbolic way of communicating to abductees that aliens and hybrid children are perhaps spiritual or imaginal beings, who are nevertheless 'related' to us in some sense that we have yet to comprehend.[2448]

Those from psychically-inclined families note these phenomena before alien contact, much as some shamans' bloodlines are naturally affiliated with the Otherworld. Those solely reporting paranormal activity after their initial experience required "formal training," as it were: alien abductions or, as seen momentarily, NDEs.

OBE to the UFO

One of the strongest indicators of their imaginal nature appears at the beginning of each alien abduction. While there is no shortage of people walking, climbing, or even being dragged inside, many if not most experiencers recall *levitating* into waiting UFOs.

Conventional Ufologists believe extraterrestrials possess technology akin to the "tractor beams" found in science-fiction franchises, physically lifting targets into the air. There is some truth in this interpretation. Abductees might report the feeling of wind rushing over their bodies as they ascend skyward, and quite a few roadside abductions feature not just people, but entire cars being drawn into UFOs. Both imply physicality.

That being said, apparently nothing can obstruct the paths of those caught by flying saucers, as many experiencers report phasing through solid objects —ceilings, walls, windowpanes, car roofs, the exteriors of the craft themselves. To explain this miraculous quality, Ufologists again draw upon science fiction, particularly the transporter technology of the *Star Trek* series, wherein solid objects are atomized into their fundamental components, then reassembled elsewhere.

Indeed, some abductees mention "dematerialization" as they are taken, their "level of vibration decreasing," or traveling via "boom tubes," appropriating an interplanetary travel device from DC Comics.[2449] Mack said many of his subjects felt "an intense energy… separating every cell, or even

every molecule, of their bodies" during experiences. "So powerful is this feeling that experiencers often find it remarkable that they 'come back together' whole on the other side of the wall."[2450]

Nearly every explanation stirs New Age terminology into quantum mechanics, creating a pseudoscientific soup. The method outlined by UFO channeler Laura Knight-Jadczyk is a prime example, as described by Lex Nover:

> Most alien abductions... take place in fourth density, a realm not visible to the naked eye and undetectable by current scientific methods. The Greys use a technology called *transdimensional atomic rearrangement* to pass through solid matter and make "soul imprints."
>
> The abductees, they explain, most often are not physically removed from third density [humanity's current state]. Instead, they are put in a kind of stasis, while "a soul imprint occupying... that particular host body is removed forcibly, transported to another locator, and remolecularized as a separate physical entity body for purpose of examination, implantation, and other." Changes in the fourth-density "clone" are seamlessly matched in the third-density being "whenever and wherever desired."[2451]

Note the changes to the "clone" mirrored on the physical self. This is exactly how medieval cultures described injuries to wandering souls or werewolves manifesting on their owners' bodies.

Only in a handful of cases do UFO occupants reveal their fallibility. Despite his lifetime of harrowing abductions, a moment of levity can be found in John

DeSouza's book *The Extra-Dimensionals: True Tales and Concepts of Alien Visitors.*

During an abduction at age nine, the author found himself paralyzed in bed and surrounded by diminutive beings before floating toward—and hitting—the ceiling. The beings, floating around him, exuded frustration as they kept tugging his body towards the ceiling. "There were more thuds as they kept trying to push, pull, and force my body through the ceiling that they themselves were easily passing through," he wrote. The aliens' incompetency reached a climax as they debated among themselves before sending him crashing back to bed.[2452]

Though it is technically conceivable sufficiently advanced technology would be capable of doing so, phasing implies a technique more congruous with spiritual interpretations. A hint comes in DeSouza's aliens' exchange.

"What's the delay?" one asked; "Something's wrong, he's awake," came the reply.

This, alongside their conflation with dreams, implies that alien abductions require *sleep*. Abductee Karin confirmed as much in conversation with John Mack: "I can't see them until I get in that altered state of consciousness," she said. "The easiest way to get into that altered state is just to go to sleep."[2453]

If not sleep, these experiences seem to at least require a state of consciousness other than alert wakefulness. The sensation of the self or one's surroundings dematerializing is a hallmark of psychedelic trips. In

short, the levitation of abductees resembles an OBE or shamanic flight more than a bodily kidnapping.

"Over the past twenty years or so I have frequently discussed the question of whether or not there are alien beings that can pass a human through what we term 'solid matter,'" wrote Ufologist Gordon Creighton in 1993. "But is it our physical body that is passed through doors and walls and glass windows, or is our 'other body,' postulated by many writers and investigators over the past two thousand years and known variously as the '*Augoeides*' or the 'radiant body,' or the 'spiritual body,' or the 'astral body,' or the 'etheric body,' or the 'double'?"[2454]

Many experiences go beyond the mere implication of OBEs and include alien abductees observing their physical bodies from third-person perspectives. In the case of Betty Andreasson and her husband Bob Luca, both described being taken out of their bodies. In one instance, Betty transformed, along with the aliens, into orbs of light. In another, an alien appeared and laid a box beside the couch she was on, allowing her to perceive herself from outside her body; when she reached out, her hand "went right through" her physical self.[2455]

Hundreds of similar accounts exist. One Belgian mother mentioned her August 21, 1976 UFO sighting to her son, but he already knew: his body had remained at home while his "second body" had visited robotic aliens aboard their craft.[2456] A correspondent with Strieber described the sensation of "something invisible" tugging at his chest, accompanied by the sensation of "my soul, not my body… being pulled vertically."[2457] Another remembered floating into the astral realm at the verge of sleep, then being "lightly

tossed," losing control of her movements as she was dragged into the basement where an almond-eyed entity awaited. "I have no memory of returning to the physical, which is another first for me [in my OBEs]," she wrote.[2458]

While most abductions occur in isolation without any observers, third-party corroboration of astral alien abduction exists. Following a childhood of OBEs and psychic experiences, John Evans spotted his first UFO in 1944, and in 1986 encountered "a tall being dressed in a shiny suit" on his way to the operating theater for hip surgery. The being allegedly "sucked" him into a "strange room where [it] administered healing," Randles wrote.[2459]

"As he floated over his body on return, he saw the doctors talking to one another, saying 'this man has healed himself,'" at least partially. A reluctant nurse later confided to Evans she "had seen a double ethereal form of John rise from his operating trolley and float through the ceiling… after the surgery, she saw the same ethereal form float back into his body."[2460]

A cursory survey of the literature reveals hundreds of abductees asking themselves as they levitate, "Am I dying? Am I dead?" Calvin Parker—abducted by tall, crab-pincered entities in 1973 alongside Charles Hickson in Pascagoula, Mississippi—recalled under hypnosis with Budd Hopkins:

> I feel a real warm sensation, the best feeling I ever had in my life. Thank God I'm finally dead, I'm dead. And my soul is leaving my body. She's actually killed me; my soul's leaving my body. In this light, this strong light, I'm glad it's all over now; I'll finally get some peace. And then I see angels, nothing like I've ever seen before. Oh, oh. I'm being pulled back down now; I'm being pulled back into my body.[2461]

Jenny Randles endorsed calling such states "UFO consciousness," a term coined by Ian Watson.[2462] We might as accurately call it "astral traveling" or "shamanic journeying to the Otherworld."

Our alien kidnappers themselves frequently admit that these techniques incorporate astral travel, if we can trust their dubious testimony. Pat Brown of Panorama City, California endured a series of abductions in 1992 during which a Grey alien took her out of her body and demonstrated "what her astral body looked like." "That is your soul," the Grey said.[2463]

The year prior, a tall, robed figure paralyzed a New York resident in the hallway of his Queens apartment, telling him "he could not be taken in physical form." Instead, the aliens would "carry his 'psychic' body or soul" into a silvery craft before returning him to his body.[2464]

The aliens use this same technology on themselves—*or inhabit the same astral realm as our souls*, depending on one's interpretation. They penetrate bedrooms by gliding through shut doors or walls with ease. DeSouza's aliens found no difficulty floating through the ceiling. Keel noted how "sober and baffled witnesses have described how the UFO occupants seemed to fly from the ground to their waiting saucers. Still others have claimed that the ufonauts simply walked through the sides of their craft like ghosts."[2465]

UFO occupants even phase outdoors. A witness pursuing a pair of child-sized, goggle-eyed spacemen during a 1969 Brazilian UFO flap remarked how

the heavy brush which held him back "strangely didn't seem to impede the two ahead of him, which in fact puzzled him."[2466]

David Jacobs felt his research indicated that "the beings appear to seek out a window" when taking people from their homes. "Sometimes the aliens will take the abductees out of their bedrooms and into another room and then out through a window there," open or closed.[2467] This obsession seems nonsensical—if they can phase abductees through solid objects, why bother?—until one considers European folklore.

"The window is… a magical location," Lecouteux wrote. "This aperture is closely linked to misfortunate and death, either because it allows such forces to enter or to escape, or because it is an alternate opening used when there is a desire to avoid contaminating the threshold."[2468]

OBE to the UFO: Physical contradictions

Despite their consistencies with OBEs, alien abductions feature ample physical components. Injuries and wounds are easy enough to reconcile—recall our examination of stigmata and dream injuries in the Introduction—but other aspects, like abductees' bodily absence, are confounding.

"An OBE abduction would have shown that [the Weiners] were returning to and seeing their physical bodies," Fowler argued regarding the Allagash abduction. "This was not the case. Just prior to being returned by the same transporting light that brought them aboard the UFO, Chuck, one of the [friends accompanying them on the trip,] could see the empty canoe below the hovering craft."[2469]

Though a poor fit for the Weiners, some abductees' bodies wander autonomously during OBEs. Researcher Caryl Dennis interviewed an eight-year-old experiencer who claimed her body disappeared while she traveled astrally to a UFO: "I went to go get back in my body and I couldn't find it!... I saw my body hiding in the closet, and so I went and I, I jumped back in it."[2470]

It seems reasonable that experiences like Travis Walton's, where abductees disappear bodily only to be found wandering days later, could represent the physical self rambling autonomously during the soul's absence in another realm. Medical precedent exists in the form of *fugue states*, a rare

dissociative disorder manifesting in lengthy periods of amnesia and characterized by unplanned wandering or travel.

Folklore suggests another, more magical answer for physical disappearances. "Not only do fairies render themselves invisible, but they also render people, animate and inanimate things invisible," wrote scholar Peter Rojcewicz.[2471] Something similar may have occurred to abductee Katharina Wilson who claimed that, just prior to being taken from a busy airport terminal, she entered a restroom yet could not see herself in any mirrors, "only the reflection of a dark-haired woman using the sink to her left."[2472]

Another of Wilson's experiences includes an OBE *after* being physically taken aboard a flying saucer. She recalls lying on a table as two Greys on either side performed an intensely painful procedure on her chest. "Suddenly, I'm out of my body—I'm above my body and I'm looking down at them and they're still working on me." After a time she returned to her physical self, still in pain.[2473] Short of multiple souls nesting within us like a Russian doll—a possibility, if we adopt Egyptian or Norse polypsychism—Wilson's encounter suggests alien abductions are not *always* astral.

The movement of automobiles in abductions, noted earlier, also alludes to their physical component. A lengthy example from Rhodesia suggests this possibility.

Peter and Frances were traveling in the wee hours of the morning on May 31, 1974 when they spotted two bright lights in the sky. As the UFOs approached their automobile, the interior grew intensely cold and Peter lost control over the steering, brakes, and accelerator, as if the car was on

autopilot. The pair passed two abandoned buses in the road—odd, they thought—before the UFOs disappeared. The car then operated normally. Peter stopped to refuel shortly thereafter, where they met an attendant who had also seen the lights.[2474]

Back on the road, the encounter played out again, minus the buses, and the couple found themselves in a swamp ("there are no swamps in that part of Rhodesia"). Frances drifted to sleep, and Peter felt hypnotized. The next thing they knew, the pair arrived at their destination an hour early, the gas tank nearly full.[2475]

Despite the account's inherent physicality—*the car was moved*—Peter described his altered state of consciousness in unambiguous OBE terms: it was "like the initial stages when one prepares himself for astro travel," he said, a talent he had displayed since 14. "It was exactly the same sensation as when one is parting from one's own soul." Aftereffects included prophetic dreams from Frances, increased durability of the car's "cheap recap" tires, and no need for oil changes.[2476] (Please abduct my car, Mr. Spaceman.)

Under hypnosis, Peter remembered communicating with a being in the car's backseat. It told him its people could appear however they pleased and were immune to death. Peter believed the couple's entire journey represented a screen memory, obscuring a shamanic flight through the air: "We went in a *dead straight line* [author's emphasis]. We were not on the road at all."[2477]

Though animism ensouls everything in our world, these are typically natural features. We don't normally think of our cars having souls… though,

like Chapter 8's flying monuments, perhaps this stance should be reconsidered. Maybe vehicles leave astral impressions as well.

OBE to the UFO: Out-of-body aftermath

Peter's preexisting penchant for "astro travel" establishes another Ufological "chicken-or-the-egg?" scenario. OBEs are among the most common prerequisites for alien abduction, but there is no shortage of experiencers reporting these abilities solely in the aftermath of encounters.

Authorities seem to have noticed this trend. After nearly colliding with a red light which revealed itself as a domed, cigar-shaped UFO on October 18, 1973, U.S. Army Reserve pilot Lawrence J. Coyne found his helicopter and crew pulled precipitously upward by a green "pyramid shaped" light shaft. Like Peter and Frances, they eventually regained control.[2478]

"On several occasions in the immediate aftermath of their encounter, Captain Coyne received telephone calls from people identifying themselves as representatives of the Department of the Army, Surgeon General's Office, asking if he, Coyne, had experienced any 'unusual dreams' subsequent to the UFO incident," wrote researcher Nick Redfern. "As it happened, not long before the Army's call, Coyne had undergone a very vivid out-of-body-experience." Another crewmember received similar calls inquiring about dreams of "body separation"—indeed, after the sighting he recalled his "spirit… floating, looking down at me lying dead in bed."[2479]

Do OBEs lead to alien abductions, or vice versa? Are abductions physical or nonphysical? Sweeping proclamations fail again in the face of conflicting

stories; we can only retreat back to the imaginal realm, claim "all of the above," and turn to folklore for support.

Previous chapters illustrate strong correspondences between OBEs and alien abductions. These were both holy and horrible—*raptus in spiritu* with the Lord, or frightening flights with demons—a dichotomy present in modern stories. Contactees enjoy consensual travels with amicable Space Brothers, while unfortunate abductees are kidnapped under duress by impersonal Greys.

Our souls have always wandered in the company of such beings, joining witches' sabbaths, riding among the Wild Hunt, weathering the trials of shamanic initiation, visiting Fairyland, and, most importantly, penetrating the border between life and death.

Near-death abductions

S. Ann Canary was only four years old when she saw a peculiar "star" hovering above the trees in 1947. When she later spoke to her conservative parents about meeting "a moon man," she received a stern reprimand, but the contact continued. Nearly two decades later, an NDE left Canary feeling her soul had been "transported to another dimension" where "compassionate beings" gave her "a special mission," before retuning her to her body.[2480]

Following a 1978 sports injury, Mik Burley of Middlesborough, England found himself in a hospital. Yet something wasn't right. Bright lights surrounded him, yes; he could feel a hard surface beneath his prone body; but the doctors were wearing *brown robes*. Without warning, Burley regained consciousness on the field, where mere moments had passed. Peculiarities stacked up following his recovery: a scar manifested on his side, he started experiencing precognitive visions, and a little redheaded girl began visiting his bedroom. It wasn't until later that he discovered a child fitting her description had died in the house years earlier.[2481]

Alien abductions? Near-death experiences? It is difficult to say, as their pageantry elides effortlessly. As Randles confessed in 1999, "I have investigated a half a dozen cases in the U.K. where it is almost impossible to make a choice between whether the witness is describing an NDE or an abduction."[2482]

As first mentioned in Chapter 1, comparisons of the two experiences yield plentiful similarities, stretching back to Keel's 1972 examination of "death dreams." Since then, researchers like Randles, Mack, Fowler, Bullard, and, of course, Kenneth Ring have found further correlations. It was his editor who first brought the alien abduction experience to Ring's attention with Whitley Strieber's *Communion*.

"Read this at once, advised Ring's editor, because it's relevant to your work," wrote Jim Schnabel. "Ring thought so, too, when he saw in the narrative that Strieber, despite all of the brain-zapping blue-meanie trauma of his experiences, was concerned about the ozone layer and nuclear winter and his own spiritual transformation."[2483]

Following this line of inquiry, Ring discovered that both NDErs and alien abductees often consider themselves psychic. Both regularly claim encounters with supernatural beings in childhood, and grow up in the presence of child abuse.[2484] (Though as Strieber rightly noted in 1997, "I do not think [abusive trauma] is the only kind that sensitizes a person to the unusual.")[2485] Continues Schnabel:

> According to [Ring's] respondents, their respective experiences wrought remarkable physical and mental changes… they became more sensitive to light, noise, and humidity. Their metabolic rates, body temperatures, and blood pressures decreased. They needed less sleep at night. They experienced occasional ecstatic surges of energy through their bodies, as well as mood swings. They sensed structural changes in their brains. Their mental awareness expanded and their paranormal abilities increased. They developed the gift of healing. Electrical equipment tended to malfunction when they were nearby. They developed allergies and migraines. They became altruistic and spiritual, appreciating all forms of life, and developed

> passionate concerns for the fate of the planet. They believed—with the possible exception of Budd Hopkins's abductees—that mankind was being nudged by some higher intelligence towards a glorious New Age.[2486]

Researchers accepting Ring's data began viewing alien abductions as but one point on a broad spectrum of related phenomena including trips to the Otherworld and altered states of consciousness. "I have come to regard the alien abduction phenomenon as one among a number of occurrences currently confronting human consciousness, like near-death and out-of-body experiences," wrote John Mack, further adding livestock mutilation, crop circles, BVM apparitions, "and spontaneous shamanic experiences, which might be described as crossover phenomena (events of various sorts that appear to manifest *in* the material world but seem not to be *of* it)."[2487]

Whereas Ring approached alien abductions as an NDE researcher, the FREE study tackled NDEs from a UFO contact perspective. "Interestingly, our findings were similar to those reported by Ring's historic study and support his conclusion that contact experiences with [non-human intelligences] 'tend to initiate some profound alterations in one's personal values and belief system,'" wrote the FREE organizers in 2018.[2488]

The FREE survey determined "the vast majority (73%) of subjects regarded [the effects of the contact experience on their lives] as either 'highly' or 'slightly' positive, with only 10% reporting it as 'highly' or 'slightly' negative." Experiences initially viewed as negative often took on a positive light given time.[2489]

We have already alluded to FREE's findings cross-referencing the incidence of NDEs among UFO experiencers. The core phenomena, and the messages delivered, remain broadly consistent. So powerful are these congruences that physical-minded researchers often "convert" to more comprehensive interpretations.

Raymond Fowler—who once "would throw UFO reports that contained paranormal phenomena in the proverbial wastebasket"—finally grew to embrace the metaphysical perspective, stopping just short of interpreting aliens as psychopomps. This was due in part to his work with Betty Andreasson, whose extensive experiences from the 1960s-1970s closely modeled NDEs, albeit with a decidedly extraterrestrial flavor.[2490]

In 2020 Fowler wrote that, for him, alien abductions and NDEs represent a "proverbial two-sided coin with two different but still connected functions": the former analogous to farmers tending their crops, the latter "the beginning of the harvesting of what the abductee will become after death."[2491]

Before we continue, a quick note on formatting. Other chapters compare their experiences to NDEs using bullet points, but what follows abandons this approach. The correspondences between NDEs and alien abductions are simply too robust to restrain this way. Therefore, dedicated sections discuss each connection, giving them ample room to breathe.

Near-death abductions: Sounds

Mack's subjects reported "an odd buzzing or humming sound" whenever "an abduction [was] about to occur."[2492] This "trilling"[2493] has been compared to flies, bees,[2494] beehives,[2495] thrumming generators,[2496] electronic buzzers, or manufacturing plants.[2497] The sensation may even extend to abductees' entire bodies, feeling like electric shocks or as if "their whole beings are vibrating."[2498] As noted throughout this book, other UFO witnesses succumb to the Oz Factor and are wrapped in an unnatural silence, a feature first connected to NDEs in Chapter 4.

Buzzing noises may even persist after encounters, as in one 1957 incident. The wife in a couple plagued by abduction "nightmares" awoke from a dream about a UFO which "gave out a pulsating, humming noise… At that point, [she] awoke with a start *but the humming noise still persisted*" for several minutes.[2499]

This account alludes to the difficulty in pinpointing the sound's origin: does it come from inside the mind, as some abductees claim, or does it originate from the craft themselves, as noted in a 1973 Mount Airy, North Carolina encounter where a "UFO made a sound 'like a huge swam of bees'"?[2500]

"It is a tradition in Occultism that the sound of buzzing like a swarm of bees, humming noises, bell-like notes, a whine like a generator, indicate the advent of a Teacher or a Higher Intelligence—all remarkably suggestive of the sounds that UFOs have been heard to emit," Ivar Mackay wrote.[2501]

Witnesses also report buzzing at crop circles or in spirit encounters, like interactions with Japan's *shito dama.*[2502] Finally, identical noises occur during sleep paralysis, a condition commonly cited by skeptics dismissing alien abductions (explored at the end of this chapter).[2503]

Near-death abductions:

Sense of peace, inaccessible knowledge, and levitation

Though many alien abductions are existentially terrifying, an equal number are peaceful. Betty Andreasson's encounters included a revelation "that everything is *One.* Everything fits together."[2504] Another abductee said, "I felt all the tension go from me and I felt a sense of peace I have never felt since."[2505]

In one of the weakest congruences with NDEs, aliens leave abductees with predictions revealed as partially true at best. Nonetheless, many come away from their experiences with a sense of "all-knowing."[2506] NDEs just seem to be a better source of inaccessible knowledge, whatever the reason (for more on UFOs predicting death, see Chapters 13 and 16).

As covered extensively, levitation during alien abductions closely resembles the out-of-body sensation NDErs report.

Near-death abductions:

Tunnel experience

Andreasson's encounters involved a tunnel-like cylinder: "It looks like a silvery tube… slowly lowering down."[2507] Andrea (no relation) told Mack she traveled through a tunnel where she "lost all conception of time."[2508]

Other alien abductees describe not literal tunnels, but rather the *impression* of such spaces, much like NDErs. The tunnel motif also vaguely manifests in the labyrinthine interior of some flying saucers. Near-death tunnels can also sound curiously Ufological. Following a car crash, one victim traversed a tunnel "made of polished metal jointed and held together with something like rivets."[2509]

The beams of light into which abductees float resemble tunnels. "I remember wondering whether 'eternity' might be a loose term for [time stopping] at the speed of light, and whether the classic 'speeding tunnel' effect and sense of eternity 'in the Light' of near-death experiences might be how the imagination translates a ride on (or as) a beam of light," Kripal mused. "Is there a mystical 'inside' to light itself that is related to but not captured by the 'outside' of light modeled by physics?"[2510]

Near-death abductions:

Bright light

"Abductees observe or feel intense light and vibrational energies during their experiences, which have a lasting effect," Mack wrote. "Light and energy seem to be at the core of or *are* everything, they try to explain."[2511]

Andreasson was commanded to enter *the Door* in one of her experiences, "the entrance into the *other world*. The world where light is," where *the One* resides. "In order to visit the *One*, Betty had to leave her body behind to enter the *Great Door*," Fowler wrote. "The place where the *One* resided was called *home*… Betty was told specifically that *everybody* would share this experience. In retrospect, there are only two things that we know for a fact that *everybody* on earth experiences: *birth* and *death*!"[2512]

Like all paranormal phenomena, UFOs and their occupants are accompanied by bright light, to the extent both can appear as nothing more than luminous orbs. These often exhibit indescribable qualities, as do NDE lights.

Strieber wrote that alien abductees "see light, 'blinding light,' 'pale light,' 'green light,' 'white, chalky light,' 'light I think was alive,' 'a blue white light that was scary, like it could see me somehow, see my soul,' 'black light that made everything seem very pale,' and, most often, 'blue light,' which,

incidentally, is also the color traditionally associated with ghosts and the return of the dead."[2513]

Bright light accompanies alien abductions to a nearly universal degree. In conjunction with levitation, it can give abductees the initial impression they have died. One person Budd Hopkins interviewed was approached by a bright "star" which illuminated them and the surrounding area: "When this light came down and shone on us, I can only tell you the feeling that you get is that you really are… dead," she said.[2514]

We have always made such assumptions. A Cornish seaman told Evans Wentz he dreamt of a boy who came to him and asked, "How many lights does Death put up?" A bright light appeared in the dream "as I never saw in my life; and when I woke up another light like it was in the room. Within three months afterwards we buried two grand-daughters out of this house."[2515]

Near-death abductions:

Landscapes

While most stay onboard what they perceive as spaceships, some alien abductees are lucky enough to be taken to other "planets," described as beautiful "worlds of light" complete with miraculous, futuristic cities and lush landscapes.[2516] Abductee Sharon Delarose claimed to have glimpsed "glowing golden sea oats" and "shimmering gold" bushes, trees, and grass in her encounters.[2517] Some experiencers explicitly regard these locations as spiritual, rather than physical worlds.

But appearances can be deceiving. Oldham recalled one abduction where his surroundings transformed into "a beautiful sunny day" complete with a clear blue sky, wispy clouds, vibrantly green grass, large trees, and singing birds. "I turned around and was shocked to see my little dog Sam," he said. The pup was long since dead. Unsettlingly, the image evaporated as he knelt to pet the dog. "I once again found myself in the empty room," he wrote, his kidnappers watching with detachment.[2518]

In 1990, an elderly Russian man watched a cloud descend to the ground, revealing a trio of humanoids who accepted his request to enter their spherical spacecraft. They discussed death and reincarnation, after which his son—deceased a dozen years—emerged from a door. As the two embraced, the witness could see in the room beyond "a verdant meadow with grazing horses." He was summarily returned to Earth.[2519]

Contactees almost unanimously described the Space Brothers' planets as pastoral paradises. In a parallel to the marvelous palaces of Fairyland, the beings who contacted Truman Bethurum inhabited literal "castles in a faraway land." Paul Mayo, who was allegedly healed by similar entities, described being carried through a "portal" into a bright light; within lay a vast field akin to the English countryside.[2520] In 1954, Calvin C. Girvin saw a distant planet full of exotic flowers and babbling brooks.[2521] On one of his own offworld excursions, George Adamski claimed to behold Saturn's "exquisite" architecture, including magical fountains, all accompanied by harmonious music permeating every space.[2522]

Others report crystalline realms. Fred Bell saw "a crystal/diamond planet, reflecting and refracting the purest, most brilliant colors."[2523] According to contactee Ralph Lael, Venus was constructed entirely from pure crystal.[2524] Andreasson claimed to be "taken through a glass-like forest with trees and life-forms composed of clear crystal."[2525]

This exhibits a striking consistency not only with the afterlife—"I saw these vivid colors of what I believe to be crystal," one NDEr exclaimed[2526]—but also the fractal geometry of psychedelic trips and even older conceptions of the Otherworld. For example, the Middle High German Arthurian romance *Diu Crône* depicts both "a crystal mountain, slippery and sharp" and a magician who builds "a glass castle that turns on its axis and is surrounded by a deep moat."[2527]

Not all NDE locations are peaceful, however, and neither are all the places to which alien abductees are whisked away. Some are overtly negative.

During a 1983 abduction, Patti Layne felt she was *literally in Hell* after seeing "a lot of fire and stuff like that."[2528]

In a 1970 NDE, Paul Garratt traversed a tunnel before landing in "some hellish realm": an endless blue, sandy plain "dominated by a writhing mass of an untold number of naked human beings, screaming in what sounded like torturous agony." Flying saucers crisscrossed the purple sky by the dozens, intermittently pausing to "suck up" small balls of light from the bodies, presumably souls.[2529]

In 1962, a Russian witness beheld a similar landscape—flat, empty save for mountains of corpses—yet these were short Grey aliens, not humans. She was somehow forced to carve out one of their hearts, and warned by a human woman that Earth would befall the same fate as this realm, should we not "change our minds and hearts."[2530]

By far the most infamous alien hellscape comes from Michael Cecil's *Round Trip to Hell in a Flying Saucer* (1955). Following several daytime sightings, two hooded, moccasin-wearing beings appeared at Cecil's auto shop to take him on an astral journey… to Hell![2531]

"Planet Hell, it turns out, lived up to its reputation, featuring a burning lake in which the dead in their coffins were cast, only to emerge as tormented souls on fire, screaming in flesh-searing agony," wrote Gorightly and Bishop. "Cecil figured he was doomed to this same fiery fate until Jesus miraculously appeared in a white beam of light and delivered him back to his auto shop, a round trip that apparently transpired over the course of four days, although the clock on his wall indicated he'd been gone for only four hours."[2532]

These tales reveal humanity's ongoing obsession with the overworld as afterlife. In the early 7th century, Isidore of Seville drew etymological connections between "death" (*mort*) and "Mars" (*a Marte dicitur*); although referring to the Roman god, it seems peculiar that a planet of the same name would later dominate popular imagination as the world most likely to harbor extraterrestrial life.[2533]

Modern alien abductees continue the overworld tradition. Carlos told Mack his abductions took him to "a divine Light or energy" he called "Home," but described his destination not as a place, but a *state*, "a pure soul experience."[2534]

Oldham seems more literal-minded. "I had recorded EVPs stating [ghosts] had seen me on their side. I had not died or had an NDE," he wrote. "Perhaps, the spirits had witnessed me being taken through their dimension by my alien abductors."[2535]

Near-death abductions:

Enhanced perception

When meeting his dead dog, Oldham said the environment's "vivid, radiant colors… almost overwhelmed [his] senses."[2536]

"You become very sharp, very clear" during experiences, another abductee explained. "You hear very well... it's like you become this super person...."[2537]

"Another thing that gets repeated is that the experience was *more real than real*," wrote Mike Clelland. "[Experiencers] perceive reality with a heightened clarity, a hyper-vividness and an eerie silence." This quality distinguishes some of Clelland's own experiences from dreams, echoing a refrain from the letters the Striebers received: "*I had a dream that wasn't a dream*."[2538]

Near-death abductions:

Interiors

While sterile spaceship interiors seem far removed from Fairyland or pastoral afterlife realms, similarities are nonetheless evident. "Round rooms" are a recurring feature of alien abductions, echoing innumerable burial mounds worldwide or the "round huts" commonly used for shamanic séances.[2539]

Moreover, "the shaman's initiation may take him to a rounded or domed chamber filled with light," Bullard wrote.[2540] Conversely, some interiors reported in alien abductions are filled with dim, "grey," or indirect light, evoking Fairyland's perpetual twilight, or the caves and caverns which NDErs, psychonauts, and shamanic initiates enter.

No shortage of abductions feature actual subterranean spaces, sometimes identified as underground bases.[2541] These realms can resemble the underworld: dark, dank, and unpleasant, but not necessarily negative. One young girl claimed regular interactions with short, "wet" beings who took not her body, but her "soul and mind" to their "damp" planet. "We might think it has dirty air, but it's really clean air."[2542]

Unexpectedly (if these represent separate phenomena), NDErs regularly travel to flying saucers. One reported seeing Earth "as if viewing it from a

porthole of a spaceship,"[2543] and another felt "as if I was traveling in a spacecraft made by God Himself, not by the astronauts."[2544]

"I found myself in an enormous silver great place, rather like a hangar for airplanes, but going on for ever," said one woman of her NDE during bypass surgery. "Miles away there were some tiny figures… My hangar was ghastly, a real Hell if there is such a thing." Yet the experience made her "much less anxious to die."[2545]

While having a lump removed from her breast in 1975, another experiencer found herself in a void where she met Jesus. The duo snapped into "what seemed to be a spaceship… a room full of lights… several men were sitting at their posts getting the controls ready to take off." Jesus telepathically introduced her to the beings, who "were dressed in astronauts' clothes, light and bright too, but very sophisticated, futuristic, far from the way Jesus was dressed." As she settled in for the journey, Jesus unceremoniously sent her back to her body.[2546]

To digress for a moment, Jesus also appears within overtly Ufological scenarios, including alien abductions. Beings resembling Christ feature in reports of varying credibility throughout researcher Albert Rosales's humanoid database, with cases stretching from the 1950s through the present day.

In July 1971 in Scotland, Eleanor Harvey heard the sound of something with an engine land on her roof. A light struck her between the eyes and a "beautiful and sad" face appeared. By all descriptions the being resembled Jesus Christ. Presenting its palms in "a sign of peace," the presence abruptly departed as the engine noise started again. Harvey could hear a voice say, "I

am the light of the world. He that believeth in me shall have everlasting life."[2547]

In another example collected by Karla Turner, Pat from Indiana encountered a blonde-haired, blue-eyed figure at the onset of an abduction. From within the sparkling light he calmed her: "Do not be afraid, my child. These are mine," he said, referring to the aliens. "The Jesus figure looked at Pat and said, 'I am the light of the world.' Then he was again surrounded by the sparkling shaft of light, which ascended back into the ceiling and took him with it."[2548]

Near-death abductions:

Supernatural lapses of time

"Missing time" is the most common side effect of alien abductions, as seen throughout this book. As such, further examples are unnecessary. Instead, we focus on what missing time represents.

Individuals in these narratives discover that tasks—traveling in a car, walking home, playing in the backyard—far exceed the estimated time expected, often by a magnitude of hours. Nothing strange can be recalled, or there are small, tantalizing hints: "I saw a light in the sky and suddenly it was three hours later," "I came home in the dark with a nosebleed," etc. The assumption is that an abduction occurred during the interim, often "confirmed" by hypnotic regression.

Yet aliens themselves seem to experience time differently as well: "Time to them is not like our time, but they know about our time," said Betty Luca (née Andreasson). Her husband Bob reiterated this: "There's no time up there… nothing changes. They said [it is] beyond my understanding."[2549] (This temporal unmooring, coupled with persistent claims that aliens live long "lives," speaks to the possibility they might actually be dead.)

Further alien testimony appears in a 1989 Ukrainian incident. Tall "Nordic" aliens escorted a witness underground to show him a portal to their realm, warning that an hour in their dimension would equal five years passing on

Earth. "His friends described [the witness] as a very secretive individual that periodically 'appeared and disappeared,'" wrote Rosales.[2550]

Given the frequency of amnesia among experiencers, some researchers presume extraterrestrials erase abductees' memories before returning them to normal life. While not an ETH-adherent, this is the primary criticism Jerome Clark leveled at comparisons between faerie lore and UFO abductions.

"Vallee notes the belief that time is different in fairyland and tries to link this idea with missing-time episodes in the UFO abduction phenomenon," Clark wrote. "The latter, however, have to do with amnesia (a memory anomaly), not with time supernaturally expanded or compressed."[2551]

It is true, in examples covered shortly, that abductees are sometimes administered substances explicitly erasing their memories. Amnesia certainly seems at play in an 1897 case from St. Louis, Missouri. Noticing a large, peculiar object on the ground, Joseph Joslin claimed to have met a small humanoid entity who "hypnotized him and seemingly abducted him." Joslin disappeared for *three weeks* before returning without any memory of what occurred.[2552]

However, the complexity of other cases refutes the assumption of mere amnesia. While playing hooky in 1957, Rae Fountain followed a set of footprints through the Bedfordshire heath to a pair of oddly-dressed people who disappeared into a "metallic and roughly bell-shaped" craft; the headmaster, catching up with him, castigated the boy. "Do you realize it's 10:30 p.m. and we've had the whole school out searching for you?" he scolded. The boy's brand-new watch still read 3:30 p.m.[2553]

After witnessing a UFO with his wife in 1963, Gerry Armstrong remembered an odd incident from a decade prior. He was skipping school as well, smoking a cigarette, when a sudden darkness fell—yet the cigarette still burned, implying a temporal anomaly. As with Fountain, Armstrong was discovered by his teacher, who chided him for the alarm his disappearance had caused in the intervening hours. Hypnotic regression administered by the late Leo Sprinkle revealed he had met with short alien beings in a landed craft during the interim. Armstrong went on to experience extraterrestrial-guided automatic writing, revealing that "Heaven is somewhere between here and Andromeda," existing as a solid planet.[2554]

Cases where time is *gained* (where lengthy experiences unfold in *less* time that estimated) further undermine Clark's assertion, as in the May 16, 2013 experience of Reinerio Hernandez. Hernandez, who claims other experiences, received a detailed message in his mind while sitting in Miami's morning rush hour traffic: "You need to undertake a project that presents to the public the relationship between the ETs, the Spirit World, and Quantum Physics," it began. A many-spoked, spinning wheel—like an enormous Ferris Wheel or, we might add, a Native American medicine wheel—appeared in Hernandez's mind, with him inside the fulcrum.[2555]

"It had spokes which contained the following topic areas: ETs, Contactees, various paranormal phenomena (NDEs, Out of Body Experiences, pre-death visions, the Spirit World, etc.), Quantum Physics, Consciousness Studies, and God/Religion," he wrote. "I was in the middle of this wheel looking out at these spokes spinning around me." [2556] Hernandez went on to become one of the driving forces behind the FREE study—all from an instantaneous vision in

the middle of stop-and-go traffic which, to his estimation, should have taken at least 15-20 minutes.[2557]

As first mentioned in previous chapters, missing or gained time seems primarily a hallmark of *travel* to the Otherworld—in other words, merely meeting an entity appears less likely to exert temporal distortions. This may be useful in differentiating simple sightings from possible abductions; when missing time is present, travel is implied. If aliens, faeries, and the dead all represent similar phenomena (or the same *phenomenon*), this might explain missing time's absence in your standard haunting, versus timeslips like the one experienced at Merry Hall (Chapter 4).

Near-death abductions:

Love

Feelings of love go hand-in-hand with sensations of peace and oneness, strongly represented in positive alien abductions. "All things… All is one," Armstrong revealed under regression.[2558] Experiences include not only sensations of acceptance and affection, but lessons as well: one kidnapper said "love is the greatest of all… because of great love [we] cannot let man continue in the footsteps that he is going."[2559] 54% of FREE respondents indicated similar messages.[2560] Andreasson, like others, equated love with extraterrestrial light: "It is a light of perfect understanding and love."[2561]

Though love and sexual intercourse are by no means synonymous—plenty of negative interactions feature non-consensual acts performed on abductees, from physical rape to dispassionate harvesting of egg and sperm (Chapter 17)—alien abductions, like all spirit interactions, also manifest erotic components.

One of earliest incidents, a 1957 Minas Gerais abduction, saw Brazilian farmer Antônio Villas Boas taken into a landed craft by short, "barking" humanoids who rubbed a (possibly aphrodisiac) salve all over his body. He became overwhelmingly aroused and, upon their introduction, had intercourse with a peculiar woman.

"Her body was much more beautiful than that of any woman I have ever known," he recalled. Afterwards, she rubbed her belly and gestured upwards, implying they had conceived a child who would live in the stars—either one of the earliest human-alien hybrid pairings or one of the latest human-faerie pairings, depending on one's perspective.[2562]

Among the multiple experiences she confided to Mack, alien abductee Isabel recalled being awoken by her partner's sexual advances. Within moments she realized he was still asleep beside her. "After 'that initial shock,' she felt 'really good,'" Mack wrote. The act seemed transcendent beyond the physical, "like having spiritual sex," emotionally connected and leaving her with a sense of peace.[2563]

A disconcerting thread runs through many abduction narratives suggesting this "love" is at best a version of Stockholm Syndrome (wherein victims romanticize their kidnappers) or at worst artificially-induced. David Jacobs noted the propensity for alien "mindscans"—a telepathic exchange between abductor and abductee—to transform revulsion into love.

"Often ['male' aliens] will create an instant rush of pleasurable emotions in the abductee that 'bonds' her to him," he wrote. "As he stares deeply into her eyes, she may feel that the Taller Being is really a 'good' individual. She wants to help him. She wants to be with him. She wants to give herself to the Beings' 'program,' to help in any way she can. She does not want to leave. Sometimes there is a romantic and even sexual quality to these thoughts. Some women say that they 'love' the Taller Being. They want to give themselves to him fully and completely. Men have similar feelings,

especially if they perceive the alien to be 'female.' Bonding can be a totally overwhelming experience."[2564]

In truth, consensuality and coercion in experiences seems largely dependent on both the experiencer's outlook and, tellingly, the outlook of their Ufologist handlers. Jacobs perceives the whole of abductions as negative, raising questions as to whether these experiences can be viewed objectively at all. Perhaps they are more akin to the frame of mind, or "set and setting," which psychonauts claim distinguishes "good trips" from "bad trips."

Near-death abductions:

Music

We find descriptions of otherworldly music early in the UFO era, attested in George Adamski's Saturnian trip and the accounts of Howard Menger: "I heard the strains of the most inspiring, soul-tingling music I have ever heard," he said, played on "a piano-like instrument."[2565]

"I listened intently to music such as I had never heard or could imagine," Orfeo Angelucci wrote, describing it just as countless NDErs and faerie witnesses did before him. "It is beyond description, for it was not music as we know it, nor was it played to our musical scale."[2566]

Singing is common. In October 1995, a recurring abductee's visitors entered her bedroom ("two shorter ones in front of a taller one") and "began to 'sing,' making a high-pitched, lilting little noise, with their voices weaving together. It was beautiful!"[2567] Suzy Hansen, first mentioned in Chapter 6, heard distinctly "non-Western" music: "Nevertheless she described it as indescribably beautiful, especially in combination with visual spiraling energy waveforms," wrote Harvard-Smithsonian astrophysicist Rudolph Schild. Schild suspects this sensorial marvel, along with the dance it induces, somehow controls the beings' "semi-alive" craft, which responds to consciousness.[2568]

Hansen also noted her aliens speaking in a singsong cadence, as reported elsewhere. Conflating aliens and angels, a "New Age mystic and contactee"

told Brad Steiger her visitors' voices "kept rising and falling in tone, as one would sing and talk at the same time" when she first met them as a child. When she called to her mother, the pleasant intonation ceased: "Do not tell your parents," the being mechanically scolded in "a low, harsh monotone."[2569]

Another phenomenon, perhaps better filed above under "Sounds," entails metallic chiming or pinging. Fowler noted many such examples over his career: "I heard a pinging sound," a "*ping, ping, ping* that was on the outside of the roof," etc. Many of Fowler's own "OBE abductions" were instigated by the sound of bells or windchimes.[2570]

An experiencer's first incident at 13 began when "jingle bells" were heard in the middle of the night. Upon investigating, a flying saucer had landed in the backyard, accompanied by four or five childlike beings. The entities raised "a rope ladder with metal hooks" to the window—incongruously primitive, evoking shamanic ladders of ascent to the Otherworld—and began climbing. Their faces were hairless, wrinkled, colored like "a dead person," and the witness fled from the room.[2571]

We are reminded of jangling reins in the Wild Hunt and faerie rades, or other spirit phenomena like *eloko,* Nkundo ghosts of the unfortunate dead who paralyze victims in Africa with "magical bells."[2572] Even in the modern era, similar noises announce the arrival of faeries. A Devon witness aged 12 in the 1970s "heard a loud metallic ping like a triangle being struck," followed by an orb of light which drifted into the room. "Inside was a female form, with long hair with beautiful wings" who acknowledged her before the orb "popped like a bubble."[2573]

Near-death abductions:

Life review

Wrote Bullard of alien abductions:

> Even the aspect of a formal meeting and discussion has parallels in religious and folk belief: Conversations between a dead person and the gods who judge his soul reach elaborate proportions in ancient Egyptian and Zoroastrian religion, though in these cases the well-structured conference was more a theological overlay than spontaneous psychological content. An accounting with St. Peter at the gates of Heaven has a more familiar place in popular Christian tradition. A clue to the origin of conferences in both abductions and religion may lie in an episode of the near-death experience known as 'life review,' where the witness relives his past and glimpses his future. Here a spontaneous and apparently psychological experience may include a formal scene of introspection and prophecy akin at least as cousin once removed to abduction conferences.[2574]

Why (or how) would extraterrestrial scientists review abductees' entire lives? These interactions occur too frequently to ignore, even if they do not represent a staple of the genre (life reviews are also absent from many NDEs, as noted in Chapter 1).

Armstrong saw a screen with pictures of his life.[2575] Another experiencer found a "grapefruit-sized ball of light" in his car and was pulled through the

roof, arriving bodiless in a room of light to watch "his whole life, like an NDE life review."[2576] Andreasson was shown a TV-like screen with images of her past, specifically a church service that was so lifelike it seemed to be "happening right now."[2577]

In October 1978, Hideichi Amano was on a Japanese mountain when his car filled with light, killing the engine and battery. An orange beam hit his daughter's abdomen as his "right forehead" filled with immense pressure and a large-eared being stared at him from outside. High-pitched noises and a slideshow of images "similar to the [NDE] 'life review'" filled his head before both he and his daughter regained consciousness some time later. The car worked fine.[2578]

As addressed in the following chapter, disclosures about Earth's future almost constitute a "Gaian life preview."

Near-death abductions:

Ultimatum

Ultimatums to "stay or leave" with these beings also appear less often in alien abductions than in NDEs. In fact, it can be argued most abductees have *no* choice, perhaps another indication of inversion signifying representation.

At least one exception occurred during a "dream" Kelly Cahill experienced following a 1993 abduction from her car with her husband near Belgrave South, Australia. She recalled meeting several beings, including one who seemed oddly familiar. On a table was her Bible, which had disappeared from home several days earlier.[2579]

"The being told her that she could come with him, but she had to leave the Bible behind, or she could just leave with the Bible," wrote Dwight Connelly. Kelly, who was deeply religious, chose the latter, and said the entity seemed saddened as it handed her the book. She then awoke. Two days later, her husband found the Bible in their car.[2580]

Just as life reviews become Gaian life previews, ultimatums generally take on a scope beyond the individual, becoming dire warnings regarding humanity's future. In interviews with Mack, abductee Sue said, "I have to do something" regarding the environment. "I knew it on a very deep level… I had a choice, but I didn't have a choice."[2581]

Ultimatums may more clearly appear in choices to reincarnate on Earth as part of "prebirth agreements," a controversial topic covered in Chapter 17.

Near-death abductions:

Beings

Large-headed, big-eyed, short, spindly Grey aliens obviously appear in abductions but also pop up in NDEs, as mentioned in Chapter 1. More commonly, NDEs feature beings who, in a UFO context, would be interpreted as Space Brothers: tall, beautiful, bright, healthy, and more-or-less human. Other entities shared across contact modalities to a lesser degree include reptilians and mantids. Chapter 13 addresses the resemblance of all UFO occupants to the dead, while Chapter 16 compares them to psychopomps.

When looking at UFO encounters and NDEs, the urge to draw comparisons between "Greys and demons" or "Space Brothers and angels" is tempting, but flawed. Negative abductions from Greys may hold positive value (see the next chapter), and the magnanimity of Space Brothers may hide nefarious motives. Chapter 16 discusses these angelic and demonic connections.

One of the strongest trends finds the "light beings" of NDEs time-and-again aboard spaceships. In fact, FREE stats suggest they and humanlike entities are seen slightly more often than Greys.[2582] One of Mack's subjects, Jean, claimed "hundreds" of visits, always to the same craft, always accompanied by "very refined energy presences. They were literally beings of light."[2583] In other examples, UFO occupants begin as light beings before assuming more conventional forms or vice versa, as when Bob Luca saw a Grey transform into a being of light.[2584]

When not clad in futuristic space suits, jumpsuits, or coveralls, UFO occupants wear robes or hoods, consistent with near-death attire and ghost garments. For instance, Fowler's father encountered "beautiful, noble-looking" entities wearing "robes in golden-white rays of light."[2585] With few exceptions UFO occupants are humanoid and communicate telepathically, like beings met by NDErs. Alien abductees might identify more humanlike entities as dead loved ones (Chapter 13) or religious figures.

After his capture by short trolls in Brazil in 1969, José Antônio da Silva entered a craft resembling "a vertical gray cylinder." Seeking solace, he fingered his rosary, "an act which angered" the creatures' leader. "Unseen by the talking aliens, the vision of a saintly human appeared to the witness and spoke a message of comfort in Portuguese," the contents of which da Silva never shared.[2586]

Some abductees see God, or at least think they do. Andreasson's "the One" is clearly analogous to the Almighty.[2587] A couple on a Florida beach in 1993 thought nothing of the "children" scouring the dunes with flashlights until, while making love, they were compelled to stop and follow a shooting star in the sky. The coastline illuminated as "a dead ringer for the Biblical picture of God" came through the clouds, then transformed into a light, which further morphed into an enormous, triangular craft—in reality, three separate ships functioning as one. In a snap, everything returned to normal.[2588]

These presences may go one step further and even *identify* themselves as God. In December 1994, a trio of Chilean boys were "sucked up" into a UFO by a blue beam of light, corroborated by six other witnesses. Over the next

three days they traveled the cosmos with God Himself, a silver-haired, shining being who called himself "Lalar" and "scraped [their] faces with a white stick and stuck [them] in the back with a needle."[2589]

The Raëlien UFO religion began in France in 1974, one year after Claude Vorilhon encountered a small, bearded being from a landed craft who identified himself as "Yahweh." Yahweh explained how his race, the "Elohim," created humanity 25,000 years ago. (This message is emblematic of another trend, wherein quasi-atheistic messages supporting panspermia are imparted to experiencers, confirming ancient alien tropes.)[2590]

Other visions of God are more esoteric. Amy, an abductee who worked with Karla Turner, recalled an experience where, in the presence of other humans, she was shown "God" in the form of a "ball of light that looked like a little sun."[2591] In the famous 1974 Avis/Day abduction, the husband "saw a city and an aged being [who] held a glowing sphere, seemingly sacred to the beings, which [the witness] touched and felt a sensation he interpreted as the energy ebbing from that planet."[2592]

This may be similar to what an Ohio abductee described to Brent Raynes. Among other experiences, Al claimed to have met tall, robed, large-headed aliens in 1958 who escorted him to a planet of simply-constructed gold and silver buildings, one of which housed "a seething red sphere." "That is God energy," they told him, "God and energy are one and we know how to use it."[2593]

As with NDEs, separating apparitions of the Blessed Virgin Mary (BVM) from UFO sightings, altered states of consciousness, and faerie encounters proves difficult. This is famously evident with 1917's Our Lady of Fátima,

whose interactions with three Portuguese children culminated in the Miracle of the Sun, an event witnessed by 30,000-100,000 people where the sun spun, danced, and emitted beams of multicolored light into the sky.[2594] Notably, some of the Fátima apparitions involved buzzing noises, and the faerie-like BVM Herself spoke in singsong,[2595] by some accounts standing only three feet tall and appearing bald.[2596]

Nearly 73 years after the Miracle of the Sun, Mary appeared again at Fátima to Giorgio Bongiovanni, this time accompanied by a "mercury colored sphere." She talked to Bongiovanni for a time before beams of light from her breast pierced his hands, leaving stigmata behind.[2597]

Take note that UFO experiences also feature figures from other religions besides Christianity. Many resemble pagan psychopomps, and a few display a Hindu flavor.

In 1977 Lalit Chawla and his family were enjoying an evening walk through Bombay when a flying saucer engulfed them in a blue beam of light. At a birthday party shortly thereafter, a "blue man with four arms"—Vishnu—appeared in the doorway, later visiting Chawla's daughter's bedroom alongside *Lakshmi, Ganesha*, and several other deities.[2598]

Ganesha appeared again in conjunction with a UFO in January 2001 in Cape Town, South Africa. The witness, who had seen a bright light in the sky days earlier, lapsed into an altered state of consciousness in a field during a festival, seeing reptilians, robots, short grey humanoids, and the elephantine deity himself.[2599]

Even when divine beings fail to appear, extraterrestrials regularly litter their lectures with soulcraft, peppering contactee channelings with discussions of God, sharing insights with abductees, and generally evangelizing—recall the unsolicited religious commentary Jean Hingley reported from her visitors in Chapter 3.

Alien abductees typically interpret this information as *spiritual*, rather than overtly *religious*.[2600] 31% of FREE respondents admitted UFO entities delivered "messages about God or a Creator." These oft-contradictory narratives are too plentiful to enumerate—suffice to say, aliens are at least partially preoccupied with spirituality.[2601]

But what do extraterrestrials worship? After stopping his car to overnight in the Dolomite Mountains in 1968, Walter Rizzi was awakened by a burning odor and met several helmeted spacemen who arrived in an enormous, silver UFO. Over the course of their conversation, Rizzi asked if they believed in God, and received a rather animist response: "*everything* is God—we, Nature, the Planets, rocks, grass—in fact everything that exists."[2602]

Six years later, a Brazilian abductee had the presence of mind to ask his captors the same question, earning a similar reply. "Clearly so," they said. "Of course. [God] is everywhere. Everybody knows about Him."[2603]

Near-death abductions:

Amnesia

As alluded earlier, amnesia is a hallmark of alien abductions. There is obviously an overlap between forgotten memories and missing time, yet sometimes the former appear in the absence of the latter. Like sleepers trying to remember dreams or psychonauts "coming down," UFO experiencers may find the passage of time completely reasonable and remember *something* noteworthy happened, but their recall, including the sequence and logic of events, remains spotty. Memories are either completely absent or composed of fleeting images and sensations.

Amnesia manifests at different points across experiences. Sometimes the entire ordeal is forgotten. Faced with missing time, abductee Tony "was shocked" by the implication: "He remembered the trip well, but he had never realized that his journey had been interrupted." Eventually, he recalled being onboard some sort of craft, but memories of his departure and return remained blank.[2604]

Others forget bits and pieces. A fellow experiencer said of the time between their medical examination and waking in bed, "This is a gap that I quickly forgot and still now cannot remember."[2605]

"I honestly think nearly everybody is abducted," said experiencer Gary to Ufologist Preston Dennett. "The difference is, most people simply have no

idea, don't remember and never will. It's just the odd unlucky person (or lucky, I suppose, depending on your outlook) like myself that occasionally does, for whatever reason."[2606] Gary's suspicion categorizes the alien abduction as a *human universal* alongside sleep, birth, and death.

Even passive UFO witnesses experience amnesia. Actor Kurt Russell completely forgot his UFO sighting until watching a ten-year retrospective of 1997's famous Phoenix Lights incident, which mentioned a civilian pilot who reported lights in the Arizona sky. He was shocked to remember that *he* was that pilot, but had thought little of it in the intervening decade.[2607]

A UFO seemed to exert similar mental power over author, researcher, and aviator Greg Bishop, who completely brushed off "an eight-armed three dimensional thing" hovering 100-200 feet in the sky above the Santa Barbara Municipal Airport. Despite his passion for UFOs, Bishop "was in a hurry to get back to L.A., and didn't drive the extra distance to take a look at the strange object," which he later regretted.[2608]

Extraterrestrials convey important, dire, life-or-death spiritual or environmental missions to abductees… who often forget their content. According to the FREE study, 29% of experiencers receive missions during their encounters,[2609] but many are left only with a lingering sense of purpose.

"Not infrequently they come to regard themselves as people with a mission," Mack wrote. "I'm not the chosen one, I am a messenger," Carlos told him. Another abductee, Gary (no relation to Dennett's contact), "attributed his mission as a healer who 'awaken[s] ancient Source in other humans' to [an] early experience 'of all-knowing in the craft'…."[2610]

Gary is fortunate. Most missions remain vague to abductees or feature impenetrable Theosophical word salad. Angela, who spoke with Harvey-Wilson, only claimed to understand "most of" the telepathic information aliens relayed, because "the concepts are really difficult to comprehend." Another echoed this sentiment, saying the messages came in "universal soul language," impossible to grasp "on a conscious level."[2611] An Ontario witness who met four-foot-tall humanoids in 1961 hit "a mental block" under hypnotic regression because he was deemed unfit for some ill-defined task.[2612]

Eva told Mack she was "'an energy form given a body to carry out a certain mission,' which has to do with some sort of full experience of 'life in earthly terms.'" Another abductee, lamenting our finite lifespans, said he had "some sort of mission": "I know that I've just got to keep doing what [my alien spirit guide] wants me to do."[2613]

Alien abductees may detect conflict spilling into their lives. "The big guy with the big eyes looked right at me and told me I have free choice," Andrea told Mack. "I feel like there's two of me. One is very, very committed to this mission, whatever it is, and the other one is sitting here wondering 'what am I doing'… and 'if it isn't real, it's screwing up my life.'"[2614] While possibly a metaphor, Andrea hints at the physical/spiritual dichotomy within us all, represented by the double (see Chapter 17 for more on aliens as doubles).

Amnesia is sometimes a casualty of memory, other times directly caused by the entities. Liquids strongly resembling the lethe of Greek mythology appear throughout the work of Whitley Strieber and in another case from Canada.

While out cycling in 1987, Kevin was momentarily paralyzed after a UFO and a pair of short insectoids materialized during a pitstop on North Canol Road near Macpass. The presences then disappeared, and he could move once more. Kevin hopped on his bike and returned home, unsettled. That night, strange noises surrounded his trailer, and he awoke in the company of a Grey aboard a spaceship.[2615]

The entity offered to take Kevin "on a trip," but he declined and instead received a clear glass "full with a yellow liquid" to erase his memory. "I was told it was for my own good that I forget," Kevin later said. He took three sips and the next thing he remembered was being back on Earth with strange scoop marks on his palms. Only some time later was he able to consciously recall the memory.[2616]

For fellow Canadian Steve Boucher, amnesia was administered not by substances, but by the aliens' mental abilities in the form of repeated telepathic messages urging him to forget. On one occasion Boucher was able to record his encounter in a journal just before his memory faded—a technique employed by dreamers and psychonauts who wish to preserve an accurate account of their altered states of consciousness.[2617]

"I tore the page off and put it in the top drawer of my dresser and went to bed," he wrote in 2020. "The next morning, I had forgotten the whole incident, and I didn't find that paper again until several years later."[2618]

Memory suppression also manifests as simple secrecy. "Why do you do this to people?" Dennett's contact Gary telepathically asked his Grey handler.

"We are not allowed to tell you," nor let abductees remember their experiences, the being responded sadly.[2619]

Tellingly, the Greys also asked Gary, "What do you want to do with your life?"[2620] Another experiencer said the information aliens imparted was "primarily" for "personal development."[2621] Abductees' missions—vague yet important, immense yet intimate—sound less like extraterrestrial assignments and more like journeys of self-discovery wrestling with the meaning of life, what each of us is put on Earth to do.

Contact is contact is contact

At its fundamental level, the alien abduction is practically identical in form and function to NDEs and most other contact modalities. From the lists assembled in Chapters 1, 4, 6, and 7, it seems reasonable to assume we are dealing with the same phenomenon, or at least closely related *phenomena*, the only salient differences being their instigating factors and attendant pageantry.

This should give even the staunchest ETH proponent pause. It would be more surprising if these experiences are *not* connected. Whether by accident or by choice, denying these similarities is ignorant.

Contact is contact is contact. What we see over-and-over across NDEs, OBEs, visits to Fairyland, ASCs, dreams, shamanic initiations and journeys, and alien abductions are trips to the Otherworld culminating in communion with the ecology of souls. Only by Co-Creating with our expectations and cultural conditioning do these travels differentiate.

The similarities do not end here, however. Because of their profundity, the aftereffects of UFO contact—spontaneous healing, supernatural abilities, spiritual awakenings, and poltergeist phenomena—are saved for the next chapter. A case can be made that these subsequent experiences are the entire reason for alien abductions in the first place.

Dismissals

As with NDEs, no shortage of Materialist "explanations" reduce alien abductions to misunderstood medical conditions. These dismissals unfortunately gain reinforcement in the broad application of hypnotic regression which, as discussed in Chapter 6, remains a problematic tool in abduction research.

For all its problems, hypnotic regression remains an unsatisfactory reason to ignore the abduction phenomenon. As with other reductionist solutions, it overlooks the "key-and-room" fallacy, and never stops to ask whether hypnosis accesses authentic realities beyond our own.

This was inadvertently illustrated during a regression of one of Budd Hopkins's abductees. Though Hopkins held regression as a useful tool for memory retrieval, he seemed to be pushing the experiencer towards the border of life and death *during* hypnosis, her hands growing "very cold," her breathing "agitated":

> I just couldn't go on. My head would start to hurt and I would think I can't go any further or I'm going to die. I just... my body… my body felt like it was going to die. I don't even know what I was afraid of. I just felt like my body was going to die if I remembered any more, so I had to wake up.[2622]

As mentioned in Chapter 9, Michael Persinger's compelling-if-unreplicated research brought magnetism into the discussion as a mundane explanation for alien abductions. Certainly some UFOs represent earth lights rather than elaborately structured craft, bringing with them magnetic anomalies—but this explanation neither suits all sightings, nor explains the litany of aftereffects discussed shortly.

Even if these are "natural" phenomena, where does one distinguish between them and the *super*natural? If nonphysical phenomena can leave physical impacts, it stands to reason the opposite happens, that the physical can cause nonphysical manifestations. Measurable powers like magnetism can physically affect the temporal lobe while still instigating immeasurable, numinous—dare we say *paranormal*—changes in experiencers. To that end, Persinger's research remains useful for highlighting the incidence of epilepsy among witnesses.

"Keel had noted symptoms characteristic of epilepsy in his studies of experiencers," Brent Raynes wrote. Even so, he refused to chalk the entirety of encounters up to such afflictions, instead positing external sources. "Keel speculated that UFO experiencers were being radiated by 'electro-magnetic waves,' resulting in a 'pseudo-epileptic effect."[2623] It remains possible that, instead of epilepsy generating false experiences of the anomalous, truly anomalous experiences generate epilepsy.

"After my 1985 encounter, high on the list of possibilities in my mind was temporal lobe dysfunction, either a tumor or temporal lobe epilepsy," Strieber admitted. "Tests for both proved negative. In fact, a very aggressive test for

temporal lobe epilepsy revealed that I have an unusually stable brain. Not, however, one would assume, when in the presence of 'UAP radiation.'"[2624]

Two remaining candidates for why some of us experience alien abductions are dissociative personalities (covered again in the next chapter) and, as mentioned earlier, sleep paralysis. This nocturnal condition occurs on the brink between sleep and wakefulness, where our brains are alert but our bodies remain at rest, characterized by partial or full immobility. Sleep paralysis often features buzzing noises and felt or seen presences, typically negative, manifesting in a broad spectrum of forms: sentient shadows, arachnids, Greys, and, quite commonly, hideous old crones (hence the folk designation "Old Hag Syndrome"). Victims commonly report these entities bearing down upon their chests.

Some experience sleep paralysis regularly, others once or not at all. Estimates place its incidence around 25%-40% of the population, depending on whether or not individuals live in a culture openly acknowledging its existence.[2625]

Despite not fully understanding it, medical professionals generally regard sleep paralysis as an altogether natural experience, though it was historically regarded as an actual attack from the Otherworld. Sleep paralysis appears more often in societies retaining this belief, as among the Hmong of southeast Asia, who believe attacks can cause actual deaths.[2626] Old World beliefs provide a proto-template for modern alien abduction mythology in the form of incubi and succubi who raped sleepers, collecting egg and seed for their demonic progeny.

Given these similarities, *some* connection exists between alien abductions and sleep paralysis, but simply dismissing the former with the latter only moves the goalposts of discussion, cramming the anomalous into the mundane. Furthermore, sleep paralysis is a poor fit for alien abduction narratives as the out-of-body component is largely absent, occurring in only 11% of sleep paralysis attacks; to the contrary, sleep paralysis is a terrifyingly *embodied* affair, anchored in the physical.[2627] Victims uniformly report being *pressed down*, not *lifted up* as in abductions.

According to Michael N. Marsh, researchers found "low amplitude electrical stimuli applied to the 'vestibular cortex' of the brain… evoked sensations of sinking or falling, while with higher currents, autoscopy [seeing one's double] and OBE were elicited."[2628]

When differentiating entities, New Agers constantly reference "vibrational frequencies," with negative presences corresponding to "lower vibrations" and positive presences corresponding to "higher vibrations." These roughly mirror the character of beings encountered during sleep paralysis and OBEs: sleep paralysis entities tend to be negative, OBE entities positive.

Applying Marsh's data, we see *low amplitude stimuli : sleep paralysis : lower vibration beings :: high amplitude stimuli : OBE : higher vibration beings*. Is the lower/higher frequency meme actually true? Are New Age vibrational concepts based upon the amplitude of electrical stimuli?

There exists another possibility. If sleep paralysis and OBEs sit upon a spectrum, as this research suggests, perhaps they indicate *different stages of a journey*. Sleep paralysis may represent the soul's arrival back into embodiment. This is consistent not only with sensations of being pulled

downward (i.e. back into physicality), but also with sleep paralysis's tendency to occur when emerging *from* sleep, rather than falling *to* sleep.

Theoretically, our souls nightly leave our bodies (OBE), traveling astrally (dreams, abductions), before returning, during which sleep paralysis may occur. From a Fortean perspective, sleep paralysis may be akin to one's car breaking down in a bad neighborhood just before reaching home. Sometimes we arrive without difficulty, while other nights our astral vehicles stall, half-returned to our bodies, in this liminal zone where the Otherworld's ne'er-do-wells congregate.

Medical dismissals of alien abductions require us to treat these conditions in a vacuum, ignoring the other phenomena surrounding sufferers, phenomena which bleed into their waking lives. Epilepsy and sleep paralysis —as we currently understand them—do not create burn marks in the ground, tamp down saucer nests, or leave behind crash debris. Sufferers of epilepsy and sleep paralysis do not exhibit scoop marks in their hands, foretell the future, endure poltergeist activity, or swim in synchronicities.

… unless the medical establishment wishes to jump on our imaginal bandwagon.

12

STAR SHAMANS

OBJ



Unlike the near-death experience… the 'alien abduction' perception has been subjected to ruthless tabloidization and pushed aside by medical and scientific communities eager to distance themselves from the more absurd excesses attached to the experience," Whitley Strieber wrote in his 1992 foreword to Kenneth Ring's *The Omega Project*. "What I have claimed, and what Dr. Ring's study has found, is that the perceptions that are popularly referred to as 'alien abduction' have some readily identifiable and highly unusual aftereffects in the lives of the people reporting them."[2629]

Alien abductions and NDEs are intimate. They seem tailor-made for the experiencer's benefit, leaving third party observers at a loss for how to integrate them; we should neither deride these personal communions, nor

should we accept every account on face value. Instead, our best approach towards validating these phenomena remains in their reported aftereffects, events which, even when not scientifically verifiable, are observable with an immediacy in the "real" world. Neither radically-altered personalities nor newfound spiritual enlightenment will weather scientific scrutiny, but they nonetheless represent significant changes each of us easily recognizes on a human level.

We are reminded of the rule of thumb for discerning true prophets from Matthew 7:20: "Therefore by their fruits you will know them."

Synchronicities

Many aftereffects of UFO contact remain wholly internal, marked by spiritual transformation. For the moment, our focus falls upon external effects manifesting in the lives of experiencers.

In addition to being authoritative texts on UFOs and owls, Mike Clelland's *The Messengers* and its follow-up books, *Stories from the Messengers* and *Hidden Experience*, are also repositories of synchronicities involving owls, UFOs, and death. These acausal "meaningful coincidences," brought into popular awareness by Jung himself, often feature events unfolding with a serendipity that beggars belief.

One of the many examples Clelland details in his second book comes from Allison (pseudonym), a server at Boone, North Carolina's Green Jade diner. An experiencer herself of UFOs in connection with owls, she was intrigued to find a printed copy of Clelland's essay—an early draft of *The Messengers*—beside a coffee urn. Another co-worker planned on reading it, but Allison took it first, reaching out to Clelland under the assumption he had left it there. While Clelland had visited the diner once before, it was a month earlier, "so I couldn't have left it there," he wrote. He had eaten at the diner June 2, 2013, the essay was posted online July 3, and Allison's message arrived August 2. Who left the essay behind, why Allison assumed Clelland had done so, and how it conveniently fell into the hands of a UFO experiencer—*a UFO-owl experiencer*, no less—remains a mystery. Clelland's

mother passed away two days before Allison's email, lending the synchronicity emotional weight.[2630]

Prevailing wisdom among the spiritually-minded suggests synchronicities represent affirmations from higher powers that one is following life's correct path. Unsurprisingly, their incidence increases in the wake of psychedelic use[2631] and NDEs as well. According to P.M.H. Atwater, NDErs enjoy "an immense sense of confidence and peace [which] often leads to frequent incidences of synchronicity… as if [their lives are] caught up in some kind of 'flow.'"[2632]

Sometimes the accidents causing NDEs are mired in synchronicities themselves. Enocia was struck by a car as a child, causing an OBE and visions of "a clearly mystical or unearthly realm." Luckily, an ambulance was several cars behind the accident. The driver who had hit Enocia was a relative of her cousin's boyfriend who worked at the hospital where she was taken.[2633]

Death seems to draw synchronicities into its wake. In one tragic example, a drunk driver lost control of his car and hit a tree at 2:02 a.m. on April 13, 1970. Despite extensive injuries, broken bones, and being placed on a respirator, he fully recovered and raised a son until, returning from the same bar, he crashed and died—two years later to the minute, according to his broken car clock.[2634]

On a more positive note, those who have passed on often use synchronicities to communicate. "The dead speak to us in many ways, including synchronicities," wrote researchers Trish and Rob MacGregor. "Any time you feel you are experiencing spirit contact, look for the synchronicities

—as guidance and confirmation that the universe really is far more mysterious and complex than we have been led to believe."[2635]

The MacGregors also recorded synchronicities unfolding in the lives of UFO experiencers, like suspected alien abductee Charles Fontaine of Quebec. Disturbed by missing memories and sightings of strange lights, Charles reluctantly confided in his neighbor, who hadn't seen anything—but his wife's cousin, Henri, was a medium who predicted they might see flying saucers in the near future. Henri and Charles began corresponding.[2636]

> Henri's appearance in the scheme of things also triggered a series of synchronicities. He had entered Charles' life through neighbors, a couple he and [his wife] didn't know very well and didn't see very often. Yet, in the weeks following the UFO encounter, their paths often crossed. It seemed that they were linked in a way that he didn't understand, and neither did they. He would notice them in places where it was unlikely to see them. For example, he would be at a shopping center or in a restaurant 20 miles from home, and there the neighbors would be.[2637]

Charles insisted they weren't following him, as they "were just as surprised to see me as I was seeing them." Both he and his wife also began having complete strangers initiate conversations about UFOs.[2638]

Synchronicities may be contagious. While corresponding with an alien abductee named Connie with an experience from Warner Robins Air Force Base, the MacGregors' website was visited by "someone from Warner Robins, Georgia… In the more than three years we've had the blog, we had never

noticed a hit from Warner Robins, Georgia. What are the odds that someone dropped by… just as we were writing Connie's story?"[2639]

You are forgiven if such coincidences seem underwhelming. As with dreams, the details experiencers find profound within synchronicities can seem mundane, even boring, to others. Among these are recurring patterns which may represent genuine synchronicities—"I see the numbers of my birth date 8 [and] 24 everywhere," one NDEr remarked—but seem as likely a product of observational bias.[2640]

On the other hand, should we take experiencers at their word and synchronicities *are* significant, they indicate flying saucers operate on a metaphysical level, despite being imbued with an undeniable physicality. They are imaginal, hinting a broader, more mysterious relationship to the fundamental arrangement of reality, moving us into position on the chessboard that is the ecology of souls, checkmating Materialism.

Poltergeist activity

Whereas synchronicities may not be very dramatic to outside observers, light phenomena is a whole other story. The late Jeff Ritzmann, whose UFO interactions were legion, commonly heard voices, glimpsed beings, and saw strange flashes of light and luminous orbs at his residence. These manifestations were sometimes so unsettling that guests to his home left upon witnessing them.

"For a number of years my life, my wife's life, our life together was a three-ring circus of really bizarre stuff," he confessed. "We lost a lot of friends that didn't want to come over because they saw things they didn't want to be around."[2641]

Kathleen Marden, part of Betty Hill's bloodline, shared with Brent Raynes the experience of seeing a light in her mother's home circa 1983. Upon investigating "a ruckus" from the room where her son slept, Marden saw him trying to swat a "light orb" out of the air. He slept with her the remainder of the night.[2642]

Light phenomena represents but one facet in a suite of poltergeist activity alien abductees might experience. Such reports are so common that Vallee wrote, "It is the rule, rather than the exception, to find significant UFO sightings preceded or followed by other anomalies, notably of the poltergeist variety."[2643] FREE stats support this assertion, with 25% of experiencers

reporting apports, and a whopping 61% claiming objects fell or moved suddenly in their presence "without any reasonable explanations."[2644]

Discussing these aftereffects runs the ironic risk of repeating our "Repeater" section, so we remain relatively brief. UFO witnesses, especially abductees, regularly tick every box on a list of poltergeist phenomena… lights, yes, but also doors slamming and objects apporting, disapporting or levitating.

"We began to lose so much silverware that it became very noticeable that we simply hadn't misplaced our eating utensils," Oldham said.[2645] In another case from Brazil, doctors treating an alien abduction-related rash on a house call were faced with "poltergeist effects around the house (including saucepans rising into the air on their own)"—literal flying saucers![2646]

Sourceless noises can plague alien abductees' residences: knocks, disembodied voices, growls, whistles, breathing, or ownerless footsteps inside or on roofs.[2647] One abductee told Karla Turner they "heard several unusual sounds in the house" nightly, "including a distinct knocking, and I also remember hearing another voice, saying a single word that began with a 'K' sound but which was unfamiliar."[2648]

Other poltergeist phenomena occur less frequently, but are by no means absent from the UFO literature. Experiencers' homes might fill with peculiar odors, pleasant or unpleasant, sweet or sickly.[2649] Lithoboly—stones thrown by invisible assailants or showering from above—figures in historical accounts of lights in the sky.[2650] One time at church, Fowler felt disembodied hands grasping his shoulders from behind.[2651]

In fact, the only poltergeist hallmarks absent in UFO contact are spontaneous fires and anomalous writing on mirrors and walls—though outliers can be found. John Keel claimed in 1970 that "fires of undetermined origin erupt suddenly throughout UFO flap areas." UFOs can certainly leave behind scorch marks at landing sites.[2652]

Regarding writing on mirrors, on one occasion Ritzmann awoke to find "on the left-hand-side… about 16 inches tall—this symbol that looked like it was scrawled into the mirror." The glyph was "comprised of four pieces. It looked like it was scraped into the glass," leaving behind "a waxy substance of some kind."[2653]

Other indicators of poltergeist activity include liquid materializing out of nowhere. We are all familiar with the horror film trope of walls weeping blood, but alien abductees generally find something less sinister. As one experiencer interviewed by Jenny Randles claimed, water may flood alien abductees' homes without an apparent source.[2654] Said another, "Water has fallen from mid air in my home and is falling on my head."[2655]

An abductee whom Simon Harvey-Wilson spoke with "went into the kitchen one day and the whole dining table was covered and brimming, like falling over the sides with water... If someone had dumped water on it, it would have washed off more quickly. This was like oozing out of the table. And the stove that was a big, old, heavy stove, was sitting in the middle of the kitchen."[2656]

Betty Hill's life was a case study in post-contact poltergeist activity. One day, she found "a strange piece of ice in the kitchen" just weeks after misplaced earrings—the ones worn during her abduction—reappeared within

a pile of leaves on her countertop.[2657] Following Barney's death, such activity ramped up so intensely that Marden moved in with Betty, just to keep an eye on things. This activity also contaminated those outside Hill's lineage: Barney's son from a prior marriage met a mysterious stranger identifying as a "Mr. Geist" (a little on-the-nose) who grilled him about his father's abduction.[2658]

Several of Betty's appliances also behaved erratically. Her refrigerator, clocks, toasters, irons, radios, and televisions stopped or died randomly, then fixed themselves on their own.[2659] This aftereffect appears throughout all contact modalities, but is especially pronounced in UFO cases, with both the craft themselves and witnesses causing electrical interference long afterward. This occurred among 52% of FREE respondents.[2660]

Many alien abductees from the previous chapter regularly reported electrical interference: Betty and Bob Luca caused lamps to malfunction in their presence,[2661] Bret Oldham battles capricious thermostats,[2662] Mike Clelland dims streetlights,[2663] Fowler watches computers and printers activate of their own volition,[2664] and Patricia, whom Harvey-Wilson interviewed, "would have enormous electrical activity in the house, so much so that it would blow. It would actually trigger my alarm system or trigger things to come on. The television came on one night [and] the stereo turned off one night."[2665]

Of this enduring mystery, Kenneth Ring wrote that the journeys of NDErs and abductees toward becoming "electrical sensitives" represents "a definite part" of their "psychophysical transformation":

> Why should this be? One can only speculate, of course, but for starters, we might recall that NDEs often involve powerful episodes "in the light." And light is, after all, an electromagnetic phenomenon. Likewise, the UFO literature is replete with instances of apparent electromagnetic effects (e.g., automobile engines stopping in the presence of a UFO, but afterward inexplicably starting up again). One therefore begins to wonder to what extent the pattern of psychophysical changes we have found to be characteristic of our experiencers might be mediated by subtle electromagnetic effects, possibly causing a direct change in the respondent's electrical field.[2666]

It is difficult to overstate how much more "contagious" UFOs appear to be compared to other phenomena. Simply interacting with alien abductees can manifest synchronicities and poltergeist phenomena in the lives of researchers. While this is equally true of those in close proximity to NDErs, the level of contact required firsthand to become "contaminated" by UFOs is shockingly minimal.[2667]

For instance, on July 2, 1968, Fred and Wayne Coulthard watched a UFO with rotating red lights in the skies above Wooler, Ontario. No abduction was reported, but the family's cats and horses became agitated. "Less than 2 hours later, poltergeist disturbances began in the house and continued for several days," Mark Moravec wrote. "A window shattered; cards, spoons, and a glass were thrown around; and a strong odor of roses was detected in the kitchen."[2668]

Suffice to say, *none* of these phenomena conform to our understanding of what extraterrestrial contact would constitute in a Materialist paradigm.

Poltergeist activity and psi abilities cannot exist in such a restrictive worldview.

If, on the other hand, we turn to older cosmologies, we at least can begin to grapple with this High Strangeness. Poltergeist activity once blamed upon fae folk and spirits, commonplace in the lives of mystics, nests into the bigger picture like a missing puzzle piece. It is no longer an outlier; it is expected. "High Normalness."

The precise significance of poltergeist activity regarding UFO contact remains up for debate. Paranormalist Colin Wilson suspected "poltergeists had nothing to do with the aliens, but that the experience had somehow 'opened up' [experiencers], weakening the divide that seems to separate human beings from other realms of reality… and making them vulnerable to attack."[2669]

Even if our perspective broadens, we nonetheless face profound questions about the nature of these encounters. Is increased poltergeist activity among experiencers induced by dead souls traveling in the wake of flying saucers? Or does it signify an awakening in the experiencer, a shamanic initiation opening the floodgates of latent RSPK and other psi abilities? Or both?

Internal changes & psi abilities

Less verifiable but no less remarkable, alien abductees also report considerable internal changes identical to those seen in NDErs. Some aspects are more measurable than others, like increased intelligence, evidenced by higher IQ scores. One abductee with only a high school education allegedly performed poorly on tests prior to his experience; debates aside on whether they indicate intelligence, he allegedly scored 134 on an IQ test administered afterward.[2670] Similar increases are noted among NDErs.[2671] Perhaps something about these experiences unmoors rigid thinking.

In addition to RSPK, lingering psi effects appear following UFO contact. Marden and Stoner's study, perhaps the largest of its kind before FREE, found 51% of experiencers directly attributed psi phenomena to their abductions, with 72% "more sensitive or intuitive than they were prior to contact" and 79% describing newfound psychic abilities.[2672] Six years later, FREE statistics bolstered their findings: 74% of respondents could "see or feel energy or auras around people" and 58% "became more psychic."[2673]

Psi phenomena are "both perplexing and troubling to investigators," Marden wrote of the American Ufological establishment. "Many are not inclined to investigate reports of events that seem more like imagination than reality… Some consider it an embarrassment to the scientific study of UFOs and would prefer to sweep it under the rug. Others feel that they are not equipped to investigate psi phenomena."[2674]

Telepathy occurs regularly not only in dramatic encounters, but even in mundane sightings. Images are beamed into witnesses' heads, or lights in the sky react to viewers' thoughts on the ground.

"Regarding UFO contact, we would do well to recall that most contactees and abductees have claimed some form of telepathic connection with these other beings," Ufologist Richard Dolan admitted, despite favoring the ETH. "In fact, such connections are often felt by people who have UFO sightings, without even experiencing the extra level of abduction or contact. In other words, these beings appear, somehow, to connect to us telepathically."[2675]

(The manner in which this aspect of contact undermines Materialism is unfortunately lost upon many ETH proponents, who insist telepathy can exist in a physicalist paradigm. Skeptics and scientific philosophers like Mario Bunge[2676] or H.H. Price would say otherwise, the latter of whom wrote, "... the implications of telepathy are... incompatible with the materialistic conception of human personality... telepathy is something that ought not to happen at all, if the Materialist theory were true.")[2677]

Something about UFO contact unlocks this ability in experiencers afterward, allowing them to convey or receive thoughts with others in waking life. One abductee described this as a "perpetual bombardment," likening it to being "blind from birth, only to suddenly gain her vision late in life."[2678]

Recalling the UFO sighting of a childhood friend, Fowler wished to rekindle communication to discuss the incident, but had long since lost contact. He visualized getting in touch, to no avail. Shortly after giving up, Fowler "received a telephone call from him. He was having a personal problem and said that he began thinking of me a few days ago!" The conversation

revealed Fowler's friend also started thinking of his UFO sighting for no apparent reason.[2679]

Among FREE respondents, 64% also reported increased precognition following UFO contact, sometimes mundane, other times dramatic.[2680] Strieber listed several examples in 1995's *Breakthrough:* "I dreamed that my husband died. But when we got up, we found out my cousin had died." "They showed me my life as it would be and I have been in a constant state of déjà vu for thirty years." "I have total déjà vu after my experiences. I feel like my life is running on rails."[2681]

Precognition is, of course, prefigured in spirit contact. Ancestors and gods in ancient China delivered messages to diviners regarding the future.[2682] Our Higher Selves, their perspectives unmoored from time and space, allegedly possess awareness of our eventual demise.[2683] As noted throughout earlier chapters, necromancers sought council from the dead because of their omniscience regarding future events.

"The divination of death was the sort of prediction to which necromancy above all lent itself," wrote Daniel Ogden of Greco-Roman practice, adding that "such inquiries of ghosts could in itself, paradoxically, hasten the point of [one's] death."[2684]

The imprecision of extraterrestrial prophecies has been alluded to several times in previous chapters. Curiously, their predictions of death enjoy a marginally more successful track record. Fowler recorded several such instances: Betty Andreasson learned of her sons' impending deaths from her alien handlers. When she awoke afterward on October 20, 1977, however, the message was not consciously remembered, only felt as a "deep

depression" and "sense of impending death" that she confided to Fowler and her then-boyfriend Bob Luca. Twenty-four hours later both of her sons suffered a fatal automobile accident.[2685]

Fowler also spoke with Rita Malley, who, pulling over for emergency vehicles, discovered the lights behind her car came from a flying saucer. Her child entered a daze, and a humming sound filled the car before transforming into a message about the brother of an acquaintance. According to Malley, her sister phoned the following day with news of his demise.[2686]

Those with UFO contact also claim controlled psychokinesis. A good example is Israeli psychic Uri Geller, who popularized "spoon bending," the supposed deformation of metal objects using only the mind. Accusations of fraud aside, it is worth pointing out that Geller's psychic abilities apparently stem from an encounter with a flying saucer just after his third birthday in 1949.[2687] Twenty-four years later, Calvin Parker claimed psychokinetic talents within a month of his abduction: he could warp paper clips and other metal objects in sealed jars "just like Uri Geller."[2688]

This is by no means a complete list of the psi abilities alien abductees report. As noted in the previous chapter, experiencers also describe psychic sensitivity or second sight, i.e. seeing ghosts and spirits which no one else can see... or flying saucers no one else can see.

Speaking with a psychic named Anne, Craig Lang learned of a power outage in Minneapolis circa 1995 during which a UFO appeared. "When Anne looked out the window, to her surprise she observed an extremely large UFO hovering only a few hundred feet above the building tops, only a few blocks

away from her building," he wrote. "The object was positioned in such a way that everyone should have seen it. Yet Anne seemed to be the only one aware of it." Lang claimed to have collected "many such cases."[2689]

Note how all these attributes—from RSPK to light phenomena to psi effects—appear during UFO encounters themselves, even in cases that fail to cause aftereffects among witnesses. Items levitate, UFOs appear as light orbs, aliens communicate telepathically, predict the future, and warp their surroundings.

In some sense, it is almost as if alien abductees "inherit" these abilities from whatever intelligence lies behind the UFOs. Certain abilities may also exhibit a sort of "half life." One experiencer who could allegedly detect other paranormal witnesses found their "gift" waned after about a month, "and thereafter gradually began to dissipate."[2690]

As in earlier discussion, we again face our "chicken-or-the-egg?" question. Researchers like Jenny Randles view the psychic component as inextricable from UFO contact, a prerequisite enhanced by visitation.

> Abductees tend to be psychic... the extent of these claims about psychic phenomena in the history of a witness simply cannot be evaded... this correlation between abduction witnesses and their previous strange encounters does exist...
>
> … I believe this superior imaging ability, coupled with the high ESP scores in other experiments, and the very clear incidence of paranormal experiences in abductees' lives, will prove to be the key to the entire mystery, for these seem to be the only things that make them in any way different from everyone else.[2691]

Given their remarkable talents, some experiencers run the risk of believing they are "special," succumbing to delusional impulses that they were somehow selected for a special task the unwashed masses will never know. Though the election of select individuals shows a precedent in shamanism, paranormal contact seems available to *all* humankind. Some simply show a greater aptitude, but this should not be construed as a monopoly. As suggested in the previous chapter, these abilities may be natural talents, or they may be learned.

We are all capable of contacting the ecology of souls. Those doing so with an open heart more often find themselves humbled, their egos shattered.

Sleepers awake

Ring noted a high incidence of "disappointment, regret, sorrow," and "resentment" after both NDEs and alien abductions.[2692] This may occur for several reasons. The absence of a suitable metaphysical framework might play a role. When integrating the numinous, modern Westerners are at a disadvantage not found in animist cultures. Many ascribe to Materialism, and those who don't must face the incongruity of their firsthand experience with their preexisting religious beliefs. (FREE respondents indicated their interest in organized religion *decreased* by nearly 52%.)[2693]

Fortunately, this depression typically gives way to enlightenment, a longstanding trend seen across all spiritual disciplines. It may seem cliché, but it truly is always darkest before dawn—hitting "rock bottom" spawns growth or, put another way, spiritual death leads to spiritual rebirth.

On their most basic level, even simple sightings engender wonder and reenchant our mundane existence. Witnesses realize we have *not* catalogued every corner of reality. In more dramatic contact, we find that UFO occupants are not Arthur C. Clarke-esque emissaries of atheism, but rather beings whose concerns hew towards the spiritual.

S. Ann Canary, first mentioned in the previous chapter, enumerated a handful of changes brought about by her contact. Taken in aggregate, they indicate a divorce from worldly constructs like organized political, economic, social, and religious structures, with a shifted emphasis on self-responsibility,

enlightenment, and universal oneness.[2694] Such spiritual awakenings even appear after fleeting UFO contact, or in the absence of psi abilities.

Experiencers undergo "a sudden change in spiritual and social outlook," Lang explained. Their viewpoints often become "Eastern or mystical in nature" with highly personal overtones. Many take up meditation and other spiritual disciplines, reporting higher levels of empathy and, "in the words of one abductee, 'becoming closer to God.'"[2695]

This is consistent with Ring's findings, summarized by the organizers of FREE:The following psychological attributes increased significantly in both the [contact] with UAP [Unexplained Aerial Phenomena] and NDE groups: concern with spiritual matters, desire to help others, compassion for others, ability to love others, concern for the welfare of the planet, conviction that there is life after death, tolerance of others, and insight into the problems of others, among other characteristics. The following profiles decreased significantly: concern with material things in life, interest in organized religion, fear of death, and desire to become well known, among other attributes.[2696]

By their own admission, those in contact with non-human intelligences become more conscientious. FREE found a "desire to help others" increased after contact by over 50%; compassion by nearly 55%; sensitivity to others' suffering 53%; and "acceptance of others" 33%. The ability of UFO contact to reenchant experiencers' waking hours is apparent in the 52% increase in "appreciation of the 'ordinary things of life.'"[2697]

It is conceivable that contact with more advanced lifeforms could prompt spiritual awakenings, but what insect would be compelled by a sermon? More directly, why would a vicar care about an ant's salvation? A more parsimonious interpretation suggests these encounters are spiritual by nature, that the point of UFO contact is to convey the existence of other realities and, perhaps, the nature of our immortal souls.

Many come to accept this possibility. "I have grown spiritually in the last eight months," one abductee told Strieber. "I now call the experiences a spiritual awakening."[2698] Some realize this from the start: in 1999's *Passport to the Cosmos,* Isabel told John Mack she "always knew that what [she] was dealing with was on a spiritual level."[2699]

Others need encouragement. Like a Zen master striking myopic novices upside the head with his *keisaku* stick, they require help bringing the phenomenon's spiritual aspect into focus. Wrote Clelland of one formative discussion:

> I spoke about this to a close friend, rather pompously declaring that UFO abductees attract far more synchronicities than the rest of the population.
>
> She rolled her eyes and wisely replied: "But that's true of *anyone* on a spiritual path."
>
> I instantly realized she was right, and I saw my own narrow-minded focus. Her astute reply forced me to look at the bigger picture. Following that line of thought, I concluded that *UFO abduction is a spiritual path*.[2700]

While it's true that alien abductees' newfound spirituality often has an Eastern or mystical bent, this is by no means universal. Quite a few find themselves drawn into New Age groups, metaphysical study, paranormal research, or UFO religions.

Brad Steiger discussed five college students who, after seeing UFOs while sky watching, were beset by poltergeist activity in their homes. Their reactions varied: one slept with a gun under his pillow, living in fear, another "began running with a group that offered sacrifices to Odin," and "a third was 'born again' into fundamental Christianity." The other two, who were honor students, dropped out of college. In each instance, their worlds irrevocably changed.[2701]

Lifestyle changes

As among NDErs, internal changes can manifest in other, more tangible ways, like significant lifestyle changes. This is no more apparent than in the 1974 abduction at Aveley, Essex.

John and Sue Day and their three children were driving home when the middle child noticed a light in the sky. After passing into a green fog, their engine died. Moments later they were driving home, but arrived with two hours of missing time. Hypnotic regression of John suggested the family had been taken into a flying saucer by two taller beings accompanied by shorter, goblin-like entities with beaked noses and gigantic ears. Sue, on the other hand, recalled snippets of the abduction on her own.[2702]

"After this odd experience, the Days showed personality changes," Colin Wilson wrote. "John became more self-confident, more creative, and began writing 'poems about life.' Sue also became more self-confident. And the ten-year-old, who had been backward at reading, suddenly improved. They became vegetarians and almost gave up drinking. John, who had been a heavy smoker, gave up smoking." Simultaneously, the household was wracked by poltergeist activity, causing John to suffer a nervous breakdown; however, this led him to pursue a more "artistic" career, another recurring theme across contact modalities.[2703]

Similar changes appear in ways both large and small throughout alien abductees' lives. Clelland noted "that after seeing a UFO, people's lives will

change. Some people will start acting more altruistic, they'll become vegetarians, stop swatting bugs, or volunteer at the local animal adoption center."[2704]

The Days also became more interested in the health of the planet. How often this sentiment arises cannot be overstated, and its significance is examined shortly.

Physical death, ego death

Most importantly, *alien abductees die to death*, just as NDErs, psychedelic users, and participants in the Eleusinian Mysteries once did. FREE determined that respondents experienced a 55% increase in belief of the afterlife's existence following contact, resulting in an 81% total belief in life after death.[2705] A choir of individuals who have met non-human intelligences repeat the refrain *ad nauseum*: "No fear of death." "I now know that we never die." "I don't fear death knowing other beings don't."[2706]

"I have no fear of death," Canary said. "Death is the laying aside of one's physical body. Life is eternal—mind is eternal."[2707] Mack's subjects reiterated this:

> When they no longer deny their experiences and confront them honestly, abductees tend to lose their fear of death. "There is no death," Isabel said after an experience in which she felt she made contact with her son, who had been killed in an automobile accident a year before. Physical death "is just a transition. You change from one thing to another, from one form into another, but there is no end and there is no beginning. It just is." Similarly Karin has come to believe that "death is nothing more than the death-of-the-flesh thing. It's of the shell… To me death is an irrelevant term, because there is no death. It's just the body terminates itself."[2708]

In some instances, this is clearly the result of ego death, equally apparent in Mack's work. "My ego rebels against" abductions, Karin added, but "in my higher self-consciousness, I'm in complete agreement." Another, Greg, explained his experiences "destroyed the 'imprisoning and limited' structure of his egoistic beliefs"—an ongoing project, as he still battled his "own ego structures."[2709] Describing his own UFO contact, Reverend Michael Carter said, "In short, what I had experienced was nothing short of a type of ego death."[2710]

If today's alien abductions and yesteryear's religious experiences represent the same phenomenon, this facet of the experience has been with us since time immemorial. Ego death even features among the earliest proto-UFO contacts. As chronicled by his son, on August 13, 1491, Facius Cardan met seven peculiar visitors. Many of the entities' aspects prefigure those of faeries or aliens, and when "questioned on the immortality of our soul, they affirmed that nothing survives [death] which is peculiar to the individual…."[2711]

Spiritual guides often emphasize ego death and "dying to death" as forms of transcendence. German spiritual teacher Eckhart Tolle teaches that "death is a stripping away of all that is not you. The secret of life is to 'die before you die'—and find that there is no death."[2712]

Both Tolle[2713] and, to a greater degree, Whitley Strieber are influenced by Russian mystic George Gurdjieff. In the words of Ufologist Michael Swords, Gurdjieff's work focused upon "gradually stripping away the masks of the self, and exposing (often painfully) the naked but true 'I am' beneath"—the self, devoid of ego.[2714]

"For some abductees this boundary-shattering or ego death leaves them with a sense that they are ensouled, even eternal, beings whose existence will survive the death of the body," Mack wrote.[2715]

Again, these revelations are available to *all of us*, if we know where to look. The simple act of encountering intelligences beyond consensus reality is enough for experiencers to realize they are embedded in a bigger, stranger existence than previously thought. It serves the same function as magical or shamanic initiation—it is impossible to put the "toothpaste" of one's belief "back in the tube." By enduring these experiences, alien abductees realize they are immortal.[2716]

So profound are these internal, spiritual changes that they seem to represent the entire reason behind alien abductions—the experience is primarily for *personal* development, as an abductee emphasized in the previous chapter. Group interactions like the Day family abduction are rare, and even in such cases the beings tend to focus on a single individual. More often than not, interactions with aliens are one-on-one affairs. No one can walk the path for you.

Pulling back

At the same time, UFOs' impact simultaneously unfolds at a global level. In 1999, researcher Leo Sprinkle wrote he "believe[d] that UFO activity is serving both as individual initiation and social stimulus, so that Earth governments minimize their tendency to act like armed and lawless gangs, and begin to cooperate as a planetary community."[2717]

This echoes Jacques Vallee's speculation that UFOs represent a sort of "control system" designed to adjust human expectations. While this sounds nefarious, Vallee likened the concept to a household thermostat, a force which "may serve to stabilize the relationship between man's consciousness needs and the evolving complexities of the world which he must understand." By presenting mankind with absurdity and separating us from consensus reality, UFOs move us into a new consciousness, or keep overly restrictive paradigms—like Materialism—in check.[2718]

Whatever lies behind the UFOs does not wish to intervene directly, but instead has apparently concluded massive consciousness shifts are best accomplished at the grassroots level, with personal experience facilitating broader social change. As gardeners within the ecology of souls, UFOs fertilize the soil with cultural acceptance, but realize the field will remain fallow unless individual seeds are planted. To what end, though?

One line of thinking holds UFO contact seeks to jump start human evolution. Proponents of this hypothesis typically believe this evolution is

directed towards spiritual ascension. As such, it finds a welcome home in the New Age movement, where followers commonly speak of UFOs raising mankind's "vibrations."

This approach brings alien abductions into alignment with Ring's Omega Point, discussed in Chapter 1. Ring perceived NDEs as "a kind of experiential catalyst for human evolution, that potentially, at least, these experiences that we now know have occurred to many millions of persons across the globe are serving the purpose of jump-stepping the human race to a higher level of spiritual awareness and psychophysical functioning."[2719]

Pontificating on his Visitors' imaginal nature, Strieber astutely mused, "I have even thought that it may simply be what the force of evolution looks like when it acts upon conscious creatures."[2720] Taking this observation one step beyond, Jeffrey Kripal wrote:

> I want to propose the idea that *a rare but real form of the imagination may be what the conscious force of evolution looks like*. And by "looks like," I mean two things: *how the evolutionary force appears* to a human mind in a particular culture; and, with a bit of a trippy twist now, *how the evolutionary force itself "sees."* I mean both sides of the two-way mirror. I mean both the *reflecting back* and the *seeing through*.[2721]

The term "evolution," however, is problematic, as it implies a forward direction towards a new goal; the word itself flirts with Materialism and scientifically-measurable qualities. While this may be the case, consider the

possibility that contact modalities like NDEs and alien abductions are not a *push forward*, but rather a *pull back* to ancient experiences once held commonplace.

Recall Terence McKenna's pointed observation from Chapter 6: "the human soul is so alienated from us in our present culture that we treat it as an extraterrestrial." Instead of propelling us to a New Age, perhaps the Otherworld is calling the prodigal sons and daughters of humanity back into the Otherworld's open arms, to the Old Age. A call back to shamanism.

Star shamans

As mentioned earlier, Eddie Bullard was among the first researchers to perceive similarities between alien abductions and shamanic initiation. Five years before Ring's *The Omega Project*, Bullard wrote that the "same transformations" seen among abductees "accompany the broader phenomenon of mystical experience in all cultures and ages. After he learns his craft in the otherworld, the newly initiated shaman returns with special powers and skills to live an individual apart from the rest of his society, and to serve his people through his occult knowledge and contacts with spiritual beings."[2722]

These transformations are not exclusively relegated to shamanism. We find similar motifs of ascent and revelation in Abrahamic religions, from saints to their founding figures themselves: most Westerners are familiar with Moses's acquisition of the Ten Commandments atop Mount Sinai, but the journey of the Prophet Mohammad to the heavens astride a human-faced, quadrupedal, winged creature called *buraq* is less famous outside Islam.

Nona spoke to Mack about the dawning realization that she was caught up in a shamanic narrative, despite having never studied the tradition until after her abductions began. "When you become a shaman, initiation brings you to the edge to meet death," she explained, claiming that each meeting with her alien contacts was "like meeting death."[2723] Given the strong similarities between NDEs and alien abductions, her assumption appears well-founded.

Several of Mack's subjects were practicing shamans themselves, or took up the mantle in the aftermath of their contact. This is true of South African sangoma Vusamazulu Credo Mutwa, Brazilian shaman Bernardo Peixoto, and Native American medicine man Sequoyah Trueblood.[2724] Their experiences alone make *Passport to the Cosmos* well worth reading.

Mack asked Trueblood, affiliated with the Choctaw, Cherokee, and Chickasaw people, how many of the 150 medicine men he knew had experienced encounters resembling alien abductions. "All of them," Trueblood replied.[2725]

This is not to imply shamanic experience is extraterrestrial—some will certainly argue as much—but rather that these phenomena, whatever they indicate, are functionally the same.

Building off Bullard's work, Harvey-Wilson concluded:

> These numerous similarities are not superficial or coincidental... The differences between the experiences of the abductees and shamanism seem largely to result from their different cultural and technological context. In comparison to traditional societies, people in the West have a more secular and pluralistic culture and education system... This means that, as some of the abductees mention, they generally feel that their paranormal abilities, spirituality and otherworld perspectives are ignored, ridiculed or marginalized, whereas in a traditional society they would be honored or at least regarded as useful.[2726]

Cultural constructs define everything about the paranormal, from its very appearance to the roles experiencers play within a society. Animists know exactly where shamans fit into the tribe; on the other hand, we simply don't know *what* to do with alien abductees, so we ridicule them.

Much of what follows is familiar from Chapter 7, albeit informed by the trends noted in Chapter 11. Before outlining similarities between shamans and alien abductees, now may be a good opportunity to devote more attention to the topic of dissociation, briefly touched upon in previous chapters.

Star shamans: Dissociation

Predictably, skeptics use connections between dissociative personalities and paranormal encounters to dismiss their validity. While it is true there exists a psychological link between dissociation and fantasy-prone individuals, reductionists never stop to question whether they are misidentifying "fantasy." A fascinating rejection of this interpretation can be seen in the emerging practice among some psychiatrists, who treat schizophrenia in patients by encouraging them to engage with the voices they hear, as opposed to ignoring or attempting to silence them.

Recall Credo Mutwa's Chapter 7 comments on dissociative states. Unfortunately, many future experiencers first encounter dissociation in childhood as a result of abuse, a controversial claim among alien abduction researchers. FREE organizer Reinerio Hernandez emphasizes the *lack* of child abuse among experiencers, since 80% of survey respondents stated they did *not* suffer trauma in adolescence.[2727]

Yet FREE's findings imply that 20% of experiencers *did* report child abuse. This is still grossly disproportionate compared to estimates in the U.S., which place the incidence of abuse among minors around 12.5% circa 2011.[2728] (A debate has long raged whether or not recollections of "alien abductions" are actually repressed memories of wholly earthly trauma—likely in some cases but less so in others, especially when accompanied by physical evidence and UFO sightings.)

Coupled with the possible suppression of memories, the incidence with which victims fail to recognize their own mistreatment, and the shame some feel in self-reporting, there is a clear suggestion that experiencers are abused more often in childhood. To reiterate, we may perceive a connection to Chapter 5's changeling abuse.

The primary point of contention arises when researchers argue that abuse, or even trauma, are inviolable prerequisites for paranormal encounters. They are patently *not*, but altered states of consciousness broadly, dissociation specifically, may be. Whether that is spurred on by trauma, illness, entheogens, sleep, spiritual practice, sheer spontaneity, or other yet-unrealized factors remains unclear.

Ergo, child abuse appears but one avenue of many providing contact with the Otherworld. Even when abuse is not claimed, abductees might grow up in toxic households. Looking back on her childhood, abductee Sara recalled her father's abusive ways, lashing out both verbally and physically against her mother. She often retreated to her room to avoid his anger.[2729]

The initiatory experience itself also facilitates dissociation, apparent in shamanic practices involving traumatic ordeals like pain and burials alive (this may explain negative abductions, discussed at the end of this chapter). For example, one correspondent with the Striebers suffered a bicycle accident in his youth which nearly handicapped him for life. He believed the subsequent NDE allowed him to contact "beings of light" which he channeled for years afterward.[2730] This case exemplifies how difficult separating trauma from initiation becomes—was the crash itself initiatory, or his NDE? Do alien abductions simply represent NDEs in the absence of physical trauma?

Like Credo Mutwa, Sequoyah Trueblood—an equally controversial figure—experienced a life of hardship, including addiction, imprisonment, war, and physical, mental, sexual, and spiritual child abuse. Though he did not discover shamanic practice until later in life, Trueblood's path seems preordained: as she was experiencing contractions, his teenage mother "heard a barn owl hoot four times," then crossed snowy fields barefoot to deliver him at a friend's house, an origin befitting any culture hero complete with a spirit guide.[2731]

In one dramatic incident, a duck blind capsized while hunting and Trueblood found himself trapped underwater; a voice reassured him he would go on to do great things, emphasizing how he would "go beyond this thing called death." A similar presence appeared throughout his service in Vietnam, rescuing him from impossible situations: "He was becoming acquainted with death, the being said, for there were things he had to experience so he could understand life." [2732]

Trueblood's overt UFO contact occurred on July 4, 1970, when, while resting, he was lifted by a rainbow-colored vortex into "a beautiful garden surrounded by hedges." A Grey appeared and invited him into a flying saucer, in which they whisked away to a city of light populated by robed beings. The presence revealed it had been with him throughout the war, and had "guided him through the hallways of death." Later in life, Trueblood dedicated himself to improving communities throughout North America, propelled by the belief that "time on Earth is running out."[2733]

Though absent in Trueblood's narrative, shamanic "initiatory illnesses" commonly figure in the childhoods of alien abductees. For instance, Harvey-

Wilson's interviewee "Karen remembers that after her initial abduction experiences, 'I did get quite sick and... I was incredibly nauseous, sick in the stomach, and that went on for weeks, and my parents took me to several doctors who couldn't find anything wrong with me.'"[2734]

In another example, a Mrs. M. interviewed by Ted Bloecher suffered a debilitating asthma attack resulting from bronchial pneumonia, which spurred an OBE at age 15. Ascending, she met her deceased grandfather, robed and bathed in light, accompanied by "music, such as I had never heard in all my life." She was issued an ultimatum and chose to return, albeit painfully. Five years later she watched as a pair of UFOs landed near New Berlin, New York, accompanied by dark-suited "Nordic" aliens. Her house was haunted afterward.[2735]

Bret Oldham suffered a sickness resembling Strieber's transformative fever (Chapter 7). "When I was a sophomore in high school something changed from the norm," he wrote, alluding to his preceding years of good health. "I got sick; very sick. I suddenly started losing weight and running high fevers." No one could deduce the cause until aliens came to him in a dream and told him he would recover, which he did—with a mysterious scar on his lower back.[2736]

Frustratingly for researchers, however, Oldham's contact predates his illness. More chickens and eggs. Perhaps Oldham's earlier experiences were simply preparation—shamanic preschool—before emerging into full-fledged shamanhood as an adult. This interpretation finds support in his newfound interest in metaphysics shortly thereafter.

"Something had happened to me during the time I was sick that had changed my whole belief system and how and what I perceived as the truth," he wrote. This was followed by bouts of depression, newfound artistic expression, and, as seen shortly, service as a psychopomp later in life.[2737]

Given the previous chapter's list of trends seen across all contact modalities, as well as those noted in Chapter 7, consider a brief summary of attributes particular to shamanism shared with alien abductions:

Star shamans:

Emergent motifs

- While levitation and simply walking aboard are the most common means of entry into flying saucers, other stories feature **shamanic means of ascent**. Noting the appearance of "ropes, wires, strings, or threads of light" in alien abductions, Graham Hancock made the comparison to similar devices "found in accounts of shamans' sky journeys. In north-western Australia, for instance, shamans say that they reach the sky on 'ropes of air,' while the shamans of the Kulin and Kurnai tribes hallucinate a fine thread emerging from their bodies: 'It comes out of their mouths like a spider's web and they climb to heaven on it.'"[2738] We also see ladders in abductions, which some shamans climb to the overworld.

- In encounters where ascent is non-physical, the shamanic staple of **separable souls** is evident. Like shamans, abductees may find their souls projecting elsewhere after initiation.

In 1974, a yellow entity with antennae paralyzed Carl Higdon while hunting in Medicine Bow-Routt National Forest. After it administered a mysterious pill, the being floated Higdon into a cube-shaped space accompanied by another alien and five elk. Sometime afterward he was "aware of his consciousness in three separate locations": in bed at home, in the forest several miles south watching a deer, and on the prairie several miles north watching a pronghorn antelope. In another culture, Higdon would have been an excellent candidate for fulfilling the shamanic task of tracking game migration.[2739]

- Beings resembling **spirit helpers** are actually quite common in alien abductions, with experiencers assigned familiar, recurring alien "handlers" who explain their

predicament. Like shamanic spirit helpers, they guide, confide, and reassure abductees throughout sequential experiences, sometimes providing useful information about the Otherworld.

Ted Rice's UFO experiences, detailed in Karla Turner's *Masquerade of Angels* (1994), feature a variety of entities explicitly identified as spirit helpers.[2740] Harvey-Wilson found that, like possessed shamans, abductees slowly gained greater autonomy through subsequent experiences.[2741] Like spirit helpers, aliens present the ability to shapeshift into animals, whether literally or through screen memories.

- Though rare, alien abductees sometimes exhibit **therianthropy**, evidenced by the Chapter 7 Australian case from 1974, where the experiencer became a fox. More often, therianthropy in abductions manifests as birdlike flight to or within flying saucers. When neither Greys nor humans, UFO occupants themselves are almost uniformly therianthropic, explored in the next chapter. Because of its significant bearing on psychopomp roles, we return to therianthropy in Chapters 16 and 17.

- Today's abductees, labeled **insane** by society at large—sometimes feeling the same themselves—are in good company. Tribal shamans often return from initiation insane, though these mental discontinuities, like those in abductees, prove temporary if properly integrated.[2742] "We treat our shamans like misguided idiots and I suspect we are all the poorer for it," lamented Randles.[2743]

- As addressed at length, UFO witnesses also see ghosts and spirits more often than ordinary folk. Fully-developed shamans receive regular **spirit communication**, reflected in the UFO contact experience by channeling and psychic downloads.

In 1942, Eileen Arnold was compelled to look across the street of her Cheltenham home and saw a flying saucer, while at the same time traffic and people on the road seemed to vanish. Just as quickly, the UFO disappeared, and she forgot about it completely—until she started experiencing "impressions dictation," i.e. automatic writing.[2744] While this tradition does not feature extensively in shamanic literature, it is identical in function to spirit communication.

"Through automatic writing, mediums have claimed to produce messages from famous persons in history," wrote Rosemary Ellen Guiley. "In the 1850s, Judge John Worth Edmonds, an American Spiritualist, incited a spate of automatic writing with his alleged messages from Francis Bacon and Emanuel Swedenborg; curiously, the latter always misspelled his name 'Sweedenborg.' The material produced sounded nothing like the work of either famous man, but it nonetheless inspired others to communicate with more famous deceased persons, including Christ himself."[2745]

- **Healing abilities** are overwhelmingly reported following alien abductions, a duty shamans fulfill in animist cultures. Harvey-Wilson noted how "in a traditional society a person may be propelled into the spirit realm during a near-death experience as a result of becoming ill, being wounded or from a worsening congenital condition. Once there, he or she may experience some form of otherworld encounter or initiation which may result, firstly, in their own ailment or injury being healed, and secondly, in their becoming a shaman who is now able to use that same spiritual power to heal others."[2746]

As with NDErs, alien abductees find wounds and chronic illnesses resolved by contact with alarming regularity, quite often confirmed by healthcare providers. One celebrated case involves a French doctor who, after observing a pair of glowing flying saucers on November 2, 1968, found an axe wound inflicted three days earlier miraculously mended, as well as "a 10-year-old Algerian War wound" healed.[2747]

In another case, Licia Davidson of Los Angeles was diagnosed with inoperable colon cancer and given three months to live. Shortly thereafter, she found herself on an extraterrestrial surgical table: "I was abducted. They told me I had cancer. They said, relax. And they did a cure. It was excruciating." At her follow-up appointment,

Davidson's doctor found "all traces of her cancer were gone," verified by medical records.[2748]

Others might have unknown conditions brought to their attention by UFO intelligences. One experiencer learned that they suffered from a severe liver condition, confirmed and fortunately remedied by a doctor's visit.[2749]

Some even heal others, as collected extensively by Preston Dennett and Harvey-Wilson. Many claim these abilities are not their own, but rather channeled from aliens *à la* shamanic spirit helpers.[2750] Stoner and Marden found 50% of individuals "were able to heal others for at least a short period following an abduction experience,"[2751] while FREE found an equal number had their family members or themselves healed.[2752] One respondent claimed their sister's terminal leukemia was cured by non-human intelligences.[2753]

- The art of physical healing is paralleled by **psychopomp roles** and healing on the spiritual level. Though less verifiable than traditional medicine, abductees regularly find themselves drawn to energy healing practices like Reiki.[2754]

The psychopomp role appears no more explicitly than in the life of Bret Oldham, who—in addition to dramatically healing his brother's head injury by laying hands upon him and having a possibly-cancerous mole miraculously disappear—regularly uses his gifts to assist ghosts "seeking me out for help." Oldham views this as a "responsibility to the spirit world."[2755]

"We try and use what the spirits/ghosts tell us to help them," he wrote. "We pray for them when they ask us to. We explain to them what has happened to them. We try to comfort them and explain to them what we feel they should do in order to progress. We use our paranormal work and spirit communication efforts to help both the living and the dead."[2756]

Another shamanic motif obliquely appearing in alien abductions resembles burials alive, reifying rebirth symbolism. The very image of lying on an alien operating table, faces gazing down from above, resembles a corpse's perspective at burial. Connections are explicit in "the top half of a coffin" used in a 1933 abduction from Chapter 11, as well as an experience reported by Andreasson: "To visit *The One*, she was made to lie in a coffin-like device which transported her to a place that had a huge glass door."[2757]

Another incident from Colonia Cella, Brazil in late 1983 found a motorist compelled to stop and walk towards a landed object shaped like a bus before he was sucked inside, losing consciousness. When he revived, the witness immediately noted darkness, claustrophobia, and a lack of air, leading him to reflexively assume he had been buried alive before "a very beautiful small woman" came to his rescue. She telepathically relayed an environmental warning.[2758]

By far the clearest parallels between alien abductions and shamanic initiation come in the form of dismemberment, covered in the next two sections, and animist messages, the section following.

A night to dismember

"When I was young they had playful personalities and were kind, but as I got older the things they did became more painful and they were very clinical in behavior towards me," alleged one FREE respondent. "They'd tell me that it wasn't going to hurt and to relax and it would be over with soon, but it did hurt…."[2759] She continued:

> I was paired with beings for sexual experiments. They would remove an egg from me and sperm from the creature and then combine them in a tube. Other times they also did things to my heart and my brain. I recall laying on a table surrounded by light and then one being removing my heart and replacing it with another one from a human laying next to me… Another time I was laying on an elevated table and with this light I was split open and inspected internally. Then I was closed up. I was awake for the whole thing, it was quite scary but I was assisted throughout the whole thing by a smaller being.[2760]

Surgical procedures have emerged as one of the most persistent motifs in alien abductions, resembling shamanic dismemberment to a startling degree. This is not to imply all such encounters are invasive, as plenty resemble superficial "check ups," and others seem relatively painless. Abductees are usually told or intuit that their kidnappers are healing them, harvesting human DNA, gathering reproductive material, or implanting devices to monitor or communicate with them.

Nonetheless, as noted in Chapter 10, many procedures are shockingly dramatic and primitive. Alongside devices bordering on the magical, abductees describe comically ominous drills, syringes, and saws, begging the question whether or not some procedures are purely theatrical, a means of inflicting fear and pain—both long-recognized catalysts of dissociation and spiritual growth.

For all their primitive trappings, these surgeries often feature the removal and replacement of vital organs only recently possible, or yet unrealized, in terrestrial medicine. Following her meeting with *The One*, Andreasson was returned to her "coffin" and endured a "very traumatic" surgery where the aliens removed her eye, inserting an implant inside the empty socket before replacing it.[2761] There are even stories, focused upon in our epilogue, of abductees' *heads* being removed.

On one occasion, Karin found herself in a spaceship filled with repulsive spiders shortly after falling asleep. As she questioned the image's reality, "they opened up my chest and took out my heart." (Notably, this ordeal occurred after a customer at the pub where Karin worked handed her a bag of chicken hearts as a prank—drawing into question whether her experience was an abduction, "just" a dream, or something in-between.)[2762]

Others die and are brought back to life during abductions. Some Ufologists speculate this was the motivation behind Travis Walton's abduction, that the beings had accidentally killed or injured him with a plasma discharge and felt a duty to revive him.

While under hypnosis, abductee Angie claimed to watch from a third-person perspective aboard a cigar-shaped UFO while "several men and women in white coats" operated on her. She was four years old, and her father's van had been overtaken by a bright flash of light.[2763] Karla Turner documented her reaction under hypnotic regression:

This bears some resemblance to a 1994 Georgia case where abductee David was taken by short "monks" and shown "images of myself… dead with blood coming out of my mouth." The beings "pulled him open" with a dull pain and returned him home, ostensibly saving his life. The entities were not "allowed" to share their motives with patients, David claimed.[2764]

In yet another incident from Brazil in 1979, two witnesses were abducted in a UFO "shaped like a hunter's hat" piloted by "repellent bipeds with rat-faces." Under regression, one witness described the other as "look[ing] as though he's dead!" during the encounter. He lay on a marble slab while "the beings examined him," but was alive and well afterwards.[2765]

Not all dismemberment is mired in surgical pageantry. Descriptions from Harvey-Wilson's abductees display the distinctly shamanic flavor of cannibalism. "I saw myself in this dark humid web," one said. "I was dead, lying on this coffin thing and there were all these dark beings coming in and [they] were eating my physical body and I felt that I had died and came back to life." Another remembered the sensation of being chased by beings with knives, who caught her and diced her "into little pieces," consuming her flesh.[2766]

While documenting the experiences of Ted Rice, Turner uncovered an overtly metaphysical procedure involving a "small soul" (Chapter 3). In the

company of a red-headed woman and several Greys, Rice was told he could only return home if he drank a green, glowing liquid. Consuming it induced waves of nausea, vomiting, and pain, culminating in an OBE. Wondering whether he was dead, he watched a "miniature image" of himself leave his body, identified as his soul. The strange woman then produced a black box which vacuumed up his homunculus before decapitating his body with a drill. As in a dream, his perspective suddenly shifted to another part of the craft filled with human-alien hybrid babies in tubs.[2767]

> "I can see my hands twitching," she said. "The wristbands are making my fingers twitch and jerk. I'm lying there with the headband on, and my eyes are open. The pupils are dilated like I'm dead."
>
> She then described a procedure in which a clear tube was inserted vaginally and filled with "a pinkish liquid" as one of the women pressed on Angie's abdomen. When she was revived, the blond man tried to "jolly" her out of her terrified state, and she was returned to the van, which exited the cigar-shaped craft by flying out of the opening "on its own"....[2768]

Such High Strangeness aligns incongruously with the ETH, but is perfectly understandable when viewed shamanically. Extraterrestrial "surgeries"—more often arbitrary dismemberment and reassembly—echo shamanic experiences where initiates' bodies are torn asunder only to be repaired with enhanced abilities. Alien surgeons tend to focus on the head or heart, both long-regarded as seats of the soul, or upon the genitals, the font of life itself. Even non-invasive procedures where substances are administered orally reflect ancient concepts regarding mouths as the soul's primary point of

egress; recall Chapter 3's examination of the soul as *pneuma,* breath. Following their reassembly, abductees regularly find themselves better off, sometimes enjoying health improvements as mentioned in the previous section.

Hancock noted how Karin's heart removal, whether imaginary or imaginal, is a dead ringer for the initiation of the Avam Samoyed shaman afflicted with smallpox mentioned in Chapter 7: "He told of how he had left his body and made a journey in the company of two spirit guides (in the form of an ermine and a mouse), who led him to the underworld. There his heart was torn out and thrown into a pot... Then, to complete the familiar sequence of shamanic surgery, his head was cut off, his body dismembered, and his bones counted."[2769]

In another culture—ancient Egypt, perhaps—Karin's experience might have been interpreted as an immortal judgment, the heart measured for sins against the weight of a feather. What is initiation if not a journey to death's door?

Implants

Compare Andreasson's ocular surgery to Eliade's Chapter 7 description of Cóbeno shaman initiations: spirits place "rock crystals" in novices' heads, which burrow through their brains and eyes before becoming sources of mystical strength.[2770] These accounts of crystals seem as close to describing "alien implants" as could be expected from an animist society—they may in fact be closer to the truth than orthodox Ufology's model of little green scientists playing "catch and release" with technological tracking devices.

Alien implants sometimes explicitly appear *as* crystals. One correspondent with the Striebers watched "two little people" enter the bedroom during a 1972 OBE while their physical self lay in bed. "My scalp was simply laid open and moved over my head, and the other person took tweezers and began implanting what appeared like rubies and sapphires into various portions of my exposed brain" before closing it up, bowing to one another, and departing.[2771]

52% of FREE respondents believed their contacts "placed a permanent foreign object in their body," while 53% found anomalous puncture or scoop marks on their skin following encounters.[2772] In the event that implants aren't embedded deep within their bodies, alien abductees typically notice lesions or bumps on the skin which strike them as strange. After consulting physicians, these are sometimes opened up and yield what generally appear to be mineral deposits, often iron.

Occasionally, analysis of these "implants" reveals them as anomalous; otherwise, while very real, they appear unremarkable. To skeptics, these are simply the accretion of trace minerals or debris embedded under the skin during an unremembered accident. To UFO believers, they represent an advanced technology (so advanced it doesn't even appear to *be* technology!) used to control or track abductees.

In this regard, shamanic crystals, alien implants, faerie blasts, and spirit darts all loosely resemble one another—foreign objects from the Otherworld which, if removed, appear mundane. Unlike spirit or faerie afflictions, however, crystals and implants seem to improve experiencers' abilities, if testimony is to be believed. Speaking to Harvey-Wilson, Patricia claimed implants in abductees "enable us to… have these abilities heightened to the point of seeing these other realities."[2773] As seen in Chapter 14, Whitley Strieber's implant often yields communication not only with his Visitors, but with Anne from beyond the grave… though, if Strieber's suspicions regarding its origins are correct, his implant represents something far stranger than extraterrestrial technology.

Its the end of the world as we know it

As alluded in the previous chapter, life reviews of the NDE type occur less often during alien abductions. Instead, the most common messages imparted by aliens involve warnings of impending environmental disasters —"Gaian life *previews*," if you will. In this sense, inversion equals representation again: these don't look at *an individual's past*, but rather *the collective's future.*

"An apocalyptic thread runs through a great many of these messages—war is coming, the earth is in danger, humans misuse their knowledge, evil enemies threaten humankind," Bullard wrote of such visions in alien abductions. "The 'museum of time' on the otherworld may echo this warning by showing violence in human history. Alongside this danger theme the beings express a salvation theme—they have come to warn and prepare, they will intervene to help, good times will follow the approaching troubles."[2774]

These predictions unsurprisingly correspond to the overall quality of contact. Space Brothers and Greys—who roughly correspond to the Seelie and Unseelie Courts of the fae—both provide visions of a calamitous future, the former generally hopeful, the latter more fatalistic. The reasons behind Earth's doom are almost always mankind's fault, echoing the concerns of a given era: visions of our future in mid-20th century contactee encounters focus on nuclear holocaust and the dangers of atomic energy, while the modern abduction experience—which firmly took hold in its current

incarnation in the late 1970s or '80s—regularly addresses pollution and climate change.

Noted Ring regarding similar visions from NDEs:

> I couldn't help seeing that there appeared to be a fairly obvious connection between the moral injunctions of [UFO contact] and the dominant social issues of the times. And likewise, from my background research on NDEs, it was impossible for me not to notice that today's ecological and planetary concerns were also matters to which many NDErs were at pains to stress that their own encounters with death had led them to become more sensitized. Indeed, a small subset of NDErs have even described to me (and other researchers have reported similar findings) that as a part of their experience or in its immediate aftermath, they have had a terrifying vision of global cataclysm."[2775]

For example, one NDEr returned from death with a vision that the Earth's temperature would rise precipitously, rendering the surface uninhabitable to humans. Another predicted a meteor would send Australia into the sea.[2776]

Gaian life previews in alien abductions reveal the phenomenon's abiding preoccupation with death, albeit writ large. Though UFO contact often emphasizes mortality on the individual level, even encounters without personal implications convey our fragility as a species through dire prophecies. As clarified in previous chapters, specific dates for Earth's demise unfailingly pass without incident, yet the specter of the apocalypse endures. In this sense, Gaian life previews serve as *memento mori* for our species: remember that you die, that the thread of life is tenuous. Just as your own

death is inevitable—you might pass tomorrow, in four years, or in 40 years—mankind's demise is *fait accompli*, whether from the heat death of the universe or by our own hubris.

On the other hand, David Jacobs noted that, when shown something other than a Gaian life preview—"death and destruction, calamity and war, atomic explosions, the end of the world, and so forth"—abductees were presented instead with "sexually charged" imagery or something "mundane and commonplace, such as a scene of a pretty garden with a fountain." Even in these exceptions, we see aliens' focus on the cycle of life through the ecology of souls.[2777]

Apocalyptic warnings wend their way through all of Mack's work. In 1994's *Abduction: Human Encounters with Aliens*, he explained:

> Sara and Arthur, for example, were shown great black clouds or "blobs" suffocating the earth's living systems, the effect presumably of environmental catastrophe. A number of abductees have been shown apocalyptic images of the earth itself literally cracked open or broken up, followed by elaborate triage scenes in which some people will die, others will survive in some way on Earth, and still others will be transported to some other place where human life will continue in a new way.[2778]

Mack was warned through his research subjects that "civilization is eating itself up…*This planet, our home, is dying*." "Cities are going to be lost in the blink of an eye" from meteor showers. A "cleansing… will occur," devastating the Earth.[2779] Carlos proclaimed that humans are faced with "an apocalyptic

final hour" which must be "met and challenged… We experiencers of this spiritual apocalypse constitute a paradigm of initiation. We are being initiated, but we initiate."[2780] Warnings from aliens sometimes resemble eschatological theology: "… there are going to be a lot of ships that are going to come here, and I think that they're going to take us and remove us first."[2781]

A few additional examples of apocalyptic warnings and Gaian life previews from UFO contact:

- In his 1952 meeting with Orthon, George Adamski was told via "hand signals and telepathy" that the Space Brothers had traveled to Earth because of their concerns about atomic weapons. "To emphasize his point, Orthon said, 'Boom! Boom!'"[2782]

- Circa 1953, Orfeo Angelucci received an image of a comet hurtling towards Earth in the distant year of 1986. "I shuddered and waited anxiously, but the portentous scene slowly faded from the screen," he wrote. "I turned excitedly to [my companion] Orion. 'But what happens to Earth?'" Angelucci's Space Brothers told him the planet's fate "depends entirely upon your brothers of Earth and their progress in unity, understanding and brotherly love during the time period left them between the so-called now and the year 1986."[2783]

- Frances Swan, an Eliot, Maine housewife, claimed to have obtained communication from extraterrestrials "Affa" and "Ponnar" via automatic writing since May 27, 1954. Among their messages, these aliens from "Hatann" warned that Earth's fault lines were in danger of irrevocably breaking, and that the planet would die just "as stated in the Holy Bible" around 1956.[2784]

- Peter Gregory, mentioned in Chapter 11, told Randles the entities he had been in contact with "showed him scenes of ecological catastrophe in the earth's future, where no life remains on the planet."[2785]

- Johnny Sands shared with Brent Raynes a 1976 sighting of a humanoid whose left hand issued a grapefruit-sized light orb. Sands was given a message that nuclear detonations were affecting life throughout outer space, "upset[ting] the balance of everything that we intend for the future."[2786]

- Lucy Sanders, whom Jacobs interviewed, described a screen playing images of the future including "a bomb going off. I see a crack in the world. There's lava coming out... And black clouds everywhere and bad wind... I see dead bodies everywhere." Her kidnappers added that the catastrophe *must* be averted, because, "Your good is our good."[2787]

- Mirroring this sentiment, Oldham's alien handlers informed him, "It is not in our best interest to let your kind destroy itself and your planet." This was immediately after showing him "horrific doomsday scenes" of dark skies, fiery cities, and "great floods and tsunamis wiping out everything in their path."[2788]

- Many FREE respondents described similar messages. "I was shown downloads of destruction and death." "They said that the human race on earth is overpopulated…." "We are destroying the planet…." "The [ET] messages all were consistent with warnings about pollution, global warming, self-destruction, human wars, how humans treat each other, and similar human behaviors."[2789]

One dramatic case of High Strangeness comes from the files of researcher Stan Gordon. To quickly summarize a complex series of events, 15 people watched a red, barn-sized UFO fly above Fayette County, Pennsylvania in October 1973 before it alit on a farm. George Kowalczyk and his sons investigated, encountering—and firing upon, to no effect—two Bigfoot with glowing green eyes. The creatures shuffled into the forest as the UFO snapped out of existence.

Kowalczyk contacted Gordon and they met that evening.[2790] During their conversation, Kowalczyk suffered a fit and, upon recovery, described visions of a figure "in a black hat and cloak, carrying a sickle." The being told Kowalczyk, "If Man doesn't straighten up, the end will come soon… There is a man here now, who can save the world."[2791]

Following that night, Kowalczyk experienced all the attendant phenomena found in alien abductees, including psi abilities like low-level precognition and visitations from the dead. A pair of men in military garb—akin to Men-in-Black—eventually visited his home and shared photographs of Bigfoot and UFOs before hypnotizing Kowalczyk, assuring him they would be in touch. They never contacted him.[2792]

The allusion to "a man who can save the world" in Kowalcyzk's vision clearly continues another theme seen throughout UFO contact, that abductees are somehow specially chosen for missions to rescue mankind. In Lucy Sanders's abduction from above, she was assured, "This will not happen... This must not happen. Only you can do something about it…."[2793]

In response to such experiences, abductees find themselves compelled to enact the internal changes they have undergone upon the external world.

"… the witness finds hope when the beings hint that their abduction operation is widespread and integral to a plan to save the world," Bullard explained. "The witness has a mission in that plan… He will learn and teach, become better for others, grow into a new and different person with enlarged abilities and important though indefinite work to do… Who could resist the promise of a leading role in saving the whole earth from impending catastrophe?"[2794]

Both Bullard[2795] and Mack[2796] noted how extraterrestrials occasionally claim firsthand knowledge of environmental cataclysm, their own worlds wracked by irresponsible stewardship. This damage even extends to the species themselves, who in many narratives have rendered their race incapable of procreating on their own, thus the need for human reproductive material (Chapter 17).

The question remains why extraterrestrials from a distant star system would be so interested in our fate—especially when we can't even be bothered to care for the planet ourselves, or love those with whom we share it. Altruism doesn't seem to be a constant in the physical universe. The amount of investment UFO entities display in Earth's future strongly suggests their fate is intertwined with ours—perhaps as cryptoterrestrial cohabitants, our ancestors (explored in the next chapter), or as our *descendants*.

Given UFO occupants' peculiar relationship to time, it seems possible that the ecological catastrophes of *their* past represent events yet to unfold in *our* future. This was the stance adopted by Credo Mutwa, who told Mack:

> …these creatures come from the future. There are terrible prophecies that you find throughout Africa to the effect that as a result of the dirtying of the Earth by human beings, as a result of human beings practicing very bad magic, the sky will become dirty, the animals will vanish, the seas will turn into poisonous mud, water will be even more precious than gold to human beings at that time. Then human beings will change, we are told. They will become smaller….[2797]

While outside the scope of our discussion, this implies "extraterrestrials" may actually be human time travelers ravaged by technological excess, reaching back across the centuries to cancel the apocalypse. More germane to our topic is the intersection of Gaian life previews with psychedelics, folklore, and animism.

Missionaries of animism

Chapter 6 briefly described environmental messages imparted to psychonauts under the influence of entheogens. Almost to a person, they describe substances like ayahuasca emphasizing our beautiful, interconnected, harmonious relationship with the planet, which we must look after. Recall Graham Hancock's sense of Mother Ayahuasca: "Her business is the planet, but she has time for *me.*"[2798]

Psilocybin, on the other hand, evokes similar ecological concerns, but is much more proscriptive. In one of his lectures, an audience member chided Terence McKenna for pontificating on Earth's doom without providing any solutions. In his very-Terence way, McKenna decided to ask the mushroom while under its influence: "So how can we save the world?"

"It hesitated roughly a third of a second and said, 'Every woman should bear only one natural child,'" he relayed later. "I thought about this for a long time before I ever publicly mentioned it to anyone, and I realized… an uncontrolled rise in population… wipes out every good intention, every social program. Every expansion of agriculture succumbs to expanded population. This is destroying us."[2799]

Reflecting upon the divergent characters of psilocybin and ayahuasca, McKenna added:

> It's interesting that they have these personalities. Psilocybin is kind of megalomanic. It says, "History is ending, prepare for the departure, the crisis of the species is upon us, cosmic forces are intersecting, machines the size of Manitoba will be involved," and it's all about, "Mankind, prepare to depart for the Higher Orders of the Galactarian Hegemony…
>
> And ayahuasca is all about how rivers flow, and family lines intersect, and what is in the river, and what is in the mind of the woman… [It] brings you into connection with everything….[2800]

In short, mushrooms are apocalyptic, whereas ayahuasca is hopeful —we again see a rough Unseelie-Grey versus Seelie-Space Brother character emerging from these disparate narratives (coincidentally, Greys' rubbery skin and silhouette bear a passing resemblance to mushrooms). Entheogen use, like NDEs and alien abductions, is a catalyst for profoundly empathetic internal change, often with environmental overtones.

Turning to folklore, we see environmental themes rendered explicit in Theosophic interpretations of faeries as nature elementals, who care about our stewardship of the wilderness. Said one contemporary faerie witness, "I suspect that the environmental crisis is perhaps pushing these Intelligences to reconnect with humankind in the way that they perhaps used to on a regular basis, in an attempt to work together and address the damage that has been caused since the separation."[2801]

Communication with Bigfoot via telepathic "mindspeak" often involves environmental concerns (Chapter 18). Muut, psychopomp owl of the Cahuilla, received his role from the deity *Mukat*, "who argued that death was a

necessary factor in the Cahuilla universe lest overcrowding would result."[2802] Apocalyptic warnings are even found in modern religious experience, as Keel noted after studying Brad Steiger's work.

"He found that people claiming to be in communication with *God*, angels, spirits of the dead, and spacemen from other planets were all receiving essentially the same information," Keel wrote. "All spoke of an impending disaster… 'The time for your planet is crucial.' But the prophets and seers of the last century were getting the same spiel."[2803]

Taken together, these messages—whether coming from deities, plants, spirits, or aliens—implore experiencers back into right relation with the environment. If this is indeed their aim, the initiative appears resoundingly successful: 62% of FREE respondents indicated an increase in "concern with the welfare of the planet Earth," while 49% exhibited greater "concern with ecological matters."[2804]

Incorporating these truths, abductees often place greater focus on animal and spirit allies—in other words, they become star shamans, invested in the well-being of all Earth's inhabitants, both physical and non-physical. Andreasson learned that her alien contacts "watch the spirit in all things" and was instructed "not to trap and hurt any more animals" as she had in her youth—a sentiment shedding light on the curious inclusion of animal collections aboard some UFOs (consider the Higdon abduction from earlier).[2805] One NDE survivor also claiming a UFO experience found themselves "'salut[ing]' animals I would meet, recognizing their individual worth, and of course, my recognition of human individual worth began to grow."[2806]

Another claimed the aliens they met directed them to "listen to the earth. You can hear the earth. You can hear the anguish of the spirits. You can hear the wailing cries of the imbalances."[2807] Such instructions would find a welcome home among animist shamans.

"In addition to their ability to sense various spiritual or alien entities, another reported consequence of the abductees' experiences is the degree to which their sensitivity towards animals, nature and the environment has increased," Harvey-Wilson concluded. "This effect could perhaps be summarised by saying that the abductees *have now adopted a more animistic or pantheistic view of reality* [author's emphasis]."[2808]

To build on a metaphor from Chapter 8, ancient monuments may indeed be "outposts of the Otherworld" within our reality… or, in other words, they are *missions* in the religious expansionist sense, staffed by an animist priesthood of spirits converting Materialists much as modern faiths evangelized indigenous populations. As Mack put it, alien abductors might be "intermediaries of the world soul or anima mundi"[2809] conducting "a kind of spiritual outreach program from the cosmos for the spiritually impaired."[2810]

A tantalizing question arises: if we visit *their* realm in NDEs, psychedelic trips, shamanic initiations, and alien abductions, what is happening when they appear in *our* world? Are faerie, alien, and spirit shamans ingesting entheogens in the Otherworld? Are they having brushes with death on the other side and suddenly popping up, bewildered, in the alien environment that is Earth? Our perception of this reality as "normal" may amount to simple conditioning—to an alien intelligence, our world may look as foreign as any psychedelic landscape.

The true nature of these intelligences remains a mystery. They may be deities, spirits, psychopomps, or our ancestors. In any case, we at least know how they appeared to us: first as gods, then faeries, now today as aliens piloting flying saucers; not "little green scientists," but "little green priests," changing our culture by changing individuals. Their end goal appears consistent across the eons: to spread a Gaian gospel in the hope that successful converts—alien abductees, star shamans, these "reluctant missionaries" of animism, as Randles dubbed them[2811]—will draw humanity back to meaningful communion with the ecology of souls.

Round trips to Hell in flying saucers

"One thing is undeniable: Contact can leave witnesses in a fruitful if uneasy state, filled with questions too provocative to ignore and too bizarre to answer," Strieber wrote. "Like the paradoxes of philosophy and the unanswerable koans of Zen, the very impossibility of their memories urges the minds of the witnesses toward change, with the result that those who do not become locked in fear report spiritual awakening."[2812]

What about those poor souls who *do* become locked in fear? Victims of unpleasant alien abductions justifiably find hopeful interpretations of the phenomenon downright offensive. Alien abductions are often torturous and overwhelmingly non-consensual, even performed upon children. How do we reconcile this terrifying reality with loftier goals of spiritual ascension?

First, a word on victim-blaming. Despite great societal strides to reject blaming victims for their tragic circumstances—poverty, rape, abuse, etc.—it remains culturally acceptable to shame victims of paranormal encounters. Any enlightened society should find this reprehensible. Whether or not things like alien abductions are real, anyone seeking comfort or counsel should be granted as much. Compassion should not depend upon whether or not paranormal experiences objectively exist. The *trauma* is real regardless.

Even if all these stories are purely imaginary—unlikely—they indicate mental illness, a factor entirely out of witnesses' control. In short, making fun of victims like alien abductees either dismisses legitimate experiences, or

shames those suffering from untreated medical conditions. (Yes, frauds and liars exist—but better to hear a hundred hoaxes with kindness than ruin one victim's life. We can be compassionate *and* skeptical.)

Returning to the incidence of "bad abductions," their frequency is difficult to determine. Though perceiving an overall positive trend, Mack admitted alien abductions were a mixed bag; David Jacobs, who holds a negative view, asserts any beneficial aspects are deceptive. Such disparate perspectives placed the two at loggerheads, with Mack embracing the metaphysical and Jacobs, while grudgingly acknowledging things like psi phenomena in abductions, never escaping the Materialist trappings of the ETH.[2813]

There is no clear answer. However, we may infer from the massive amount of evidence presented in previous chapters that a spiritual component *is* at play in alien abductions, consistent with ancient traditions. If so, Mack's assessment may have been *more* correct.

This is borne out in the FREE survey, which overwhelmingly emphasizes the phenomenon's positive aspects. Merely 9% of respondents felt the entities behind their encounters were "bad, malevolent, or evil," and only 16% would stop ongoing contact if given a choice. As noted in Chapter 11, negative perceptions tend to improve over time.[2814] It seems the fear felt by so many first-time alien abductees is largely fear of the unknown, rather than an actual existential threat.

Wayne Heald, whom Ring interviewed, described how his first UFO encounter at age nine mellowed over time:

> Sitting up in bed, I turned to my right and saw a smallish, bell-shaped craft on the ground no more than 25 feet away. A strobelike series of lights flashed… red, green, yellow, white. I was absolutely terrified. I was certain my face had been seen through the screen mesh [of the window]. Covering my head with the bedsheet I forced myself to remain as still as stone for fear that if I moved one muscle they would hear it and "capture" me. Although I did not once see any being or intelligence, I was apprehended by an overwhelming sense of presence—one which seemed malevolent at the time but in retrospect was probably a nine-year-old's natural reaction.[2815]

However, if UFOs come from the ecology of souls, we can assume that, like any ecology, there are predators… and there are prey. The religiously-inclined speculate that bad abductions are carried out by dark, even demonic forces like those seen in negative NDEs.

A more charitable interpretation suggests these entities are akin to apex predators fulfilling a higher niche on the spiritual "food chain"; a shark isn't evil, but it certainly behaves with its own interests in mind. The possibility that some alien abductions are the product of negative, parasitic, or maliciously indifferent spirits should not be dismissed out of hand, and therefore receives attention in Chapter 16.

Negative paranormal experiences are not uncommon across contact modalities. As shown in Chapters 4 and 5, faerie encounters were often perilous, frightful enterprises incurring all variety of maladies. Every recreational user of psychedelics speaks of terrifying "bad trips," with some emerging mentally broken afterward. Shamanic initiations, while exhibiting a

certain beauty and clearly benefitting the larger tribe, are far from pleasant ordeals. NDEs can feature demonic creatures.

Yet even negative NDEs impart positive outcomes. Recall the positive aftermath of Howard Storm's descent into hell (Chapter 1). This exemplifies a theme seen throughout this book: that by traversing the lowest depths, we can ascend the highest heights. Odin, Osiris, and Christ suffered before reaching the godhead. Saints and shamans are forged through torture and affliction. Addicts find meaning in recovery, and most who pull through into spiritual awakening wouldn't trade their "rock bottom" for the world. Initiation is painful by nature.

We might extrapolate that death and suffering—things we are taught to avoid—are not to be feared at all, perhaps signifying initiations in their own right. This is the logical fallacy running through atheist criticism of spirituality: citing carefree pop-culture interpretations of religion, especially Christianity, atheists argue that a loving deity would not tolerate the suffering of innocents, while never stopping to think that suffering *might serve a purpose* on a higher metaphysical level. This is broadly accepted not only in Eastern and indigenous traditions, but even scripturally-focused Abrahamic practice. Acceptance of death and suffering are obvious from close readings of the Bible, Qur'an, and Jewish texts; it is only in our modern world, where comfort is placed above all else, that these religions have been stripped of nuance.

The purpose of suffering has long preoccupied religious thought. Citing 2nd century Greek bishop Irenaeus, John Hick wrote in *Evil and the God of Love*: "Instead of the Augustinian view of life's trials as a divine punishment for

Adam's sin, Irenaeus sees our world of mingled good and evil as a divinely appointed environment for man's development towards the perfection that represents the fulfillment of God's good purpose for him."[2816]

Difficulty, even pain, is necessary for gratitude and progress. It may seem trite, but without opposition, without friction, the tires on our cars would simply spin in place. We live this each day in our lives. The drudgery of work helps us appreciate free time, absence makes the heart grow fonder, etc.

To this end, perhaps the intense fear and pain of negative alien abductions is the initiatory act itself, promoting dissociative states by which we realize our immortality. Their surgeries are emotional, not medical.

"Any trauma may carry with it the possibility of personal transformation and growth," Mack found. "My sense is that when abductees accept the pain and trauma, it is because at some level they are aware that they are participating in an as-yet-unfathomable process that involves not only their own growth and transformation but an awakening of consciousness for humankind more generally."[2817]

Again, this is not to imply that all alien abductions are beneficial, but rather to rebuke the equally reductive perspective put forth by Jacobs and others. Critics of the positive perspective often cite legitimate issues of consent, Stockholm Syndrome, and the fact that bad abductions are so traumatic they could never come from a positive force.

"Fundamentally, whatever this is, it's in it for itself," Michael S. Heiser told Nick Redfern regarding consent in alien abductions. "This is not altruistic. I look at it demonically because of the human-rights issues: people being

taken against their will, nasty things done to them. Or even if things are not literally done, they're implanted in their minds; they're mentally tormented." Heiser says, despite being "perfectly capable of communicating with us," aliens rarely disclose their motivations and offer little comfort to victims. "I view it in terms of it being unethical by whatever is doing it."[2818]

Yet consent is regularly circumvented by parents at the pediatrician's office, or pet owners at the animal hospital. Children and pets fear these environments and the invasive, painful procedures which occur there, but they are necessary for survival. Perhaps spirits—in whatever guise, operating with knowledge we cannot access—are acting in our benefit by inflicting pain, and we simply lack the capacity to comprehend.

Claims that abductees suffer from Stockholm Syndrome are entirely reasonable, as the phenomenon regularly exhibits manipulative tendencies. Some believe aliens exert mind control over their subjects, essentially brainwashing them to believe their captors' motives are pure. Even Mack considered this possibility before rejecting it in favor of his initiatory model.

"While this remains a valid hypothesis, in my experience… abductees seem to come to feel a more authentic identification with the purpose of the whole phenomenon," he wrote, adding that such comparisons "do not take into account the subtleties of these encounters."[2819]

Seeking to distance NDEs from alien abductions, author John White wrote in the Summer 1992 issue of *Flying Saucer Review*, "Abducting aliens induce fear and long-lasting anxiety, discomforting dreams, intellectual confusion and a disturbed personality in their victims; NDE Light-Beings have an after effect which brings people a sense of ultimate peace, cosmic goodness,

reverence for life, deepened spirituality, concern for fellow humans and the environment—a general revaluing of a materialistic, egotistic life-style in the name of God and Love."[2820]

White's criticism is true to an extent, but fails to entertain the possibility that the widely variable character of contact from positive to negative may not indicate "good" and "bad" factions with diametrically-opposed goals, but instead aspects of a shared phenomenon which adopts an approach tailor-made to resonate with the experiencer. You can either be coddled or given "tough love," tactics that any parent immediately recognizes may or may not work, given the child or the situation. There is also the uncomfortable possibility that some alien abductions are negative because they reflect some karmic debt, perhaps incurred in an individual's past life—though this skirts dangerously close to victim-blaming.

A 1994 MUFON Symposium paper by Karla Turner suggested Ufologists should treat the positivity of spiritual awakenings separately from UFO contact.

> …such growth seems to come to abductees only after they are aware of their experiences. If indeed this growth is produced by the aliens, then it should have been there long before the abductees were conscious of their encounters, since in almost every reported case there is evidence of alien involvement since early childhood. The psychic increase and growth of perceptive abilities indicate a different genesis—an internal evolution of consciousness—stemming from our need to know what is and has been done to us and what we can do to meet the situation in a more empowered state... Given the vast intrusive activities of the abduction scenario, our species may well feel such a threat or stress that a mutational or evolutionary leap is occurring today... If this is indeed the case, then any spiritual

> growth is the abductee's own doing at a deep level of consciousness and is not coming from an abducting entity.[2821]

Another cogent argument, but the question remains whether or not alien abductees would have retained memories of their experiences more readily had they taken place in a shamanic society. Instead, the talents of abductees—shamans with no nation—lie dormant because there is no place for them in our culture. From another perspective, the fact that growth only occurs after experiences are recalled speaks to the importance of alien contact—in most other aspects of our lives, lessons are only useful if remembered.

In conclusion, we may never know why negative UFO experiences occur, but it is disingenuous to paint them universally as "good" or "bad." The fault may lie within our own desire to reduce good and evil into tidy boxes. Tragedies can arise from blessings, and blessings can arise from tragedies. Sinners can be moved to saintliness, saints to sinfulness.

Whether for good or ill, it seems obvious that alien abductions are shamanic experiences, or at least modern variations on these ancient paths of enlightenment. If this is indeed true, by implication we inhabit an animist universe, and to assume shamanic initiations exist but soul theft does not—when it is a cornerstone of animist belief—would be not only presumptuous, but arrogant.

Ergo, "good" abductions may be initiatory, while "bad" abductions represent spiritual attacks which, outside the West, may best be served by shamanic retaliation or soul retrieval. Few if any victims receive the spiritual

care they need, however, and this may represent one reason why those unable to process the fear of negative experiences seem more likely to descend into paranoia and madness. They succumb to the spiritual attack, rather than rise above it, and it is up to us to help them.

As outlined in Chapter 7, shamanism is a death discipline, focused upon rebuilding relationships not only with our ancestors, but the broader ecology of souls. In light of this correlation, it seems only natural that the quasi-shamanic figure of the alien abductee should encounter the dead during their travels to the aliens' Otherworld.

13

ALIENS & THE DEAD

OBJ



It was September 6, 1978. The fog lay unusually dense as 12-year-old Juan Pérez rode into a field near Venado Tuerto, Argentina to round up his family's horses. Without warning, several silvery objects appeared overhead, firing beams of various colors and startling his horse. Pérez managed to calm his steed and return home, but his father demanded he finish his chores.

A reluctant Pérez reached the field again, where he was surprised to find one of the flying saucers landed. An opening parted on its shiny surface, releasing a ladder and a seven-foot-tall entity wearing something resembling a HazMat suit, attached to the craft's interior by a tube. Compelled inside, Pérez found a scene straight out of science fiction, including blinking panels, an invisible force field, and a being dissecting or cooking livestock. [2822]

Frightened, Pérez retreated to the field, but his horse had somehow been injured. He asked one of the beings to heal it, which it did before grabbing his arm and sending Pérez into a daze. Visions of stars flew past, culminating in the appearance of his dead grandfather.[2823]

"My grandpa's there," he recalled. "They took me where my grandpa is… He's doing his thing… He was the person I leaned on… And they showed me a black zone, a black place… over there. I'm not sure if it's the horizon, if it was up or down, or if it was on Earth… something black that was coming… like a storm. It was coming and destroying."[2824]

Returning to normal consciousness, Pérez was given one of the beings' gloves as proof of his encounter. With its exposed claws, the entity pricked his right arm near the shoulder, documented afterward. Pérez was permitted to leave, but on his journey home two of the craft returned and levitated the glove from his grasp.[2825]

Empty-handed and traumatized, Pérez lived a solitary life for decades, his only solace coming from his animal companions, whom he believed could understand him. Pérez's despondency found some alleviation during the production of the 2019 documentary *Witness of Another World*, during which he incorporated his experience into the shamanic practice of his Guaraní ancestors.[2826]

UFO contact closely mirrors near-death experiences, altered states of consciousness, and shamanic initiations in both form and function. Anyone compiling a list of similarities and differences will find the former much longer than the latter. We are left asking exactly what intelligences populate these spaces. In all other contact modalities, they are almost exclusively

spiritual presences, yet Ufologists insist the entities encountered during alien abductions are flesh-and-blood extraterrestrials. A minority disagrees.

"One reason that I doubt aliens have flown here from someplace like Zeta Reticuli to study us is that the contact experience includes two seemingly disparate aspects: encounters with the dead and encounters with nonhuman beings," Whitley Strieber wrote. "What possible connection could there be between alien scientists from another planet and ectoplasmic manifestations of dear aunt Ethel?"[2827]

A shocking number of UFO contacts include appearances by the dead, from complete strangers to instantly-recognizable loved ones who have already passed on. Because mainstream Ufology so often downplays these encounters (or willfully ignores them), two extensive lists have been compiled to illustrate their frequency. Their length necessitates their presentation as appendices in a supplemental volume (for more information, consult the back of this book).

Appendix A features general or unrelated human dead, while Appendix B lists individuals personally known to UFO experiencers. Some meet the dead aboard flying saucers, while others only meet them on Earth during periods of heavy UFO contact.

At last, we see the overwhelming data which inspired Anne Strieber: *This has something to do with what we call death.* As the appendices indicate, she was ahead of her time. Alien abductions feature the dead often enough to demand further scrutiny, yet the topic remains taboo within orthodox Ufology. It is an understandable impulse. Both lists showcase how deeply such accounts are mired in High Strangeness, combining elements which—

even if the dead *weren't* involved—seem patently ridiculous, but persevere nonetheless.

The screen memory scam

A few things become apparent from the appendices which, while by no means comprehensive, provide a sufficient overview of UFO encounters featuring the dead. For one, when experiencers see physical corpses, these are invariably those of strangers. The dead whom they knew personally always appear quite healthy, even corporeal or physically *alive*. They are rarely wispy ghosts, placing them much more in alignment with ancient conceptualizations of souls and spirits.

Absent from the appendices are appearances of dead pets, like Oldham's dog Sam (Chapter 11). Their omission does not indicate they appear infrequently, but is rather a deliberate decision to narrow our focus.

It may be recalled that Sam and the surrounding pastoral scene Oldham found himself in were illusory, dissolving into a clinical setting from which his alien abductors monitored his reaction. ETH adherents insist experiences like Oldham's represent "screen memories," a Co-Creative theory wherein aliens apply otherwise mundane, even sentimental imagery to obscure their true nature. Whether achieved mentally or technologically, this ability is faerie glamour in all but name, and certainly *seems* magical.

There are clear examples in the UFO literature where aliens use screen memories to imitate the dead. A disturbing example comes from the childhood of Ted Rice who, while sharing a bedroom with his grandmother, remembered his dead grandfather appearing one evening. The apparition

raped her before revealing itself as a reptilian alien. Another creature raped Rice. His grandmother, who had been something of a cunning woman, passed away two days later from a massive stroke.[2828]

More ambiguously, alien abductee Lily Martinson recalled seeing her dead brother at the foot of her bed while vacationing in the Virgin Islands in 1987. Under hypnosis, she recalled the figure looked not like a human, but like a Grey alien.[2829]

The idea that aliens can assume the form of dead loved ones originates in occultism, where spirits assume any guise they choose, sometimes to deceptive ends. For instance, it is widely accepted that, should one communicate with an authentic spirit via a Ouija board, their self-identification should be approached cautiously; manifold tales describe spirits claiming to be dead relatives who are welcomed with open arms, but eventually unleash horrific supernatural torment.

We see similar behavior among faeries, who assume the features of family members to deceive others, particularly children. A Norwegian account from 1720 finds a girl taken by little men in "black round caps" who changed into her aunt and uncle, attempting to cajole her into feasting with them.[2830] According to some accounts, South American duendes "can appear as a parent or friend of children they steal, or as a handsome suitor of women they seduce."[2831]

Oldham himself, perhaps soured by his false reunion with Sam, adopted a screen memory stance when aliens presented him with his dead stepfather. The telling fault was how the apparition hugged him and couldn't stop smiling, taking Oldham by surprise—"My Step Dad was a very kind and

caring man, but he was never a very affectionate man, and that isn't something that he normally would have done." He began shouting at his stepfather, insisting he was dead and the whole thing was an illusion, and "the whole scene vanish[ed]."[2832]

Without undermining Oldham's interpretation—he was there, we weren't—it seems equally possible that his stepfather's appearance was authentic, but that something about the transition to the afterlife softened his demeanor. The assumption that souls in the afterlife remain unchanged by the journey, when so many NDErs return more compassionate, seems hasty.

Returning to the appendices, their disparate lengths reveal another trend: when meeting the dead, it is *far* more likely for experiencers to interact with people they knew, rather than complete strangers. Individuals encountering dead people they did *not* know in life either learn their status from the dead's direct testimony or see unfamiliar corpses. If you didn't know someone before their death, why would you recognize them afterward? Therefore, the question arises as to how often the dead go unidentified in UFO contact.

The appendices suggest appearances of the dead in conjunction with flying saucers could be more common than we realize. Maybe Space Brothers or other humans aboard UFOs are simply dead strangers. Given the fluidity of the dead's appearance in folklore, Greys and other nonhuman beings might actually be human souls *appearing* alien. It is only when recognized by someone they knew in life that their true nature is revealed. In short, perhaps *all* entities seen in the company of UFOs represent our dead… a shocking implication.

Alien ancestors

Clearly, there appears to be a relationship between UFO contact and death, but what is the nature of this affiliation? Are aliens—even nonhumans—actually the dead souls of humankind?

Before unpacking these questions, it is important to abandon either/or thinking. Yes, as illustrated shortly, aliens may be the dead. They may not. They may only be involved in the process of death, or may be entirely unrelated, simply fulfilling another niche in the ecology of souls *alongside* the dead (see Chapters 16 and 17).

For example, Robin Foy (who organized The Scole Experiment, the gold standard of longitudinal psi research projects) claimed his group contacted both extraterrestrials and the dead, sometimes in the same room. "We got the impression, really, that there's—not quite what you'd call a partnership between the spirit world and ETs—but certainly there's an understanding between them, and they work together on many projects," he said.[2833]

Caveats aside, clues suggesting aliens are dead humans pepper UFO encounters, often by the entities' own admission. For instance, a witness in a 1997 Russian case was warned by a tall humanoid who appeared in his bedroom not to "interfere in the alien or UFO business, or death will await you. *You will belong to my race* [author's emphasis]."[2834]

Lorie Barnes, with whom Strieber regularly corresponded, encountered his short, blue dwarfs sometime in the 1950s. Barnes was pregnant, reading in bed, when their arrival startled her. One of them laid its hand on hers and intoned:

> "Do not fear. We are not here for you. We are interested in the girl child you are carrying."
>
> …Lorie then cried out, "You're so ugly!" The leader spoke again. He said, "One day, my dear, you will look just like us."2835

The shared identity seen in Barnes's anecdote is echoed in other encounters stretching back to the legend of King Herla, where a dwarf monarch proclaimed he and his human counterpart were kin.[2836] More recently, aliens informed an Australian abductee, "You're one of us."[2837] "You are our children," the Day family was told.[2838] "… You are one of us," another being informed Filiberto Cardenas during his 1979 abduction.[2839] As addressed in Chapter 17, many believe such statements indicate alien abductees are half-alien hybrids, or that we somehow possess alien souls.

A more direct reading suggests these intelligences are telling us that they represent our human predecessors. This is consistent with recurring messages that the aliens' fate is somehow intertwined with ours, that, as seen in the previous chapter, any environmental catastrophe befalling *us* somehow affects *them.*

While wholly unpalatable to most Westerners, other cultures integrated UFOs into their ancestral cosmologies long ago. Some Hopi contend part of their spiritual belief includes calling down aerial lights, sometimes piloted by *kachinas*, spirits embodying both revered ancestors and natural elements.[2840] Interviewing an experiencer at Copán, Honduras—site of pre-Columbian ruins—Ardy Sixkiller Clarke was told tribal belief held anomalous lights in the sky "were the spirits of the ancestors."[2841]

Medicine man Grizzlybear Lake consulted a Seneca colleague after experiencing peculiar dreams. The Seneca mystic told him his vision signified he would see a flying saucer piloted by "the ancient ones." Lake scoffed, but later found himself aboard a UFO where he met its operators. "Native Americans were piloting the saucer!" he later exclaimed.[2842]

This conflation of UFOs with the ancestral dead is extremely prevalent in African societies, exemplified by Clifford Muchena's Chapter 10 interpretation. Much of our Ufological knowledge from Africa comes from the tireless work of Cynthia Hind, who quickly discovered that many sightings throughout the continent are rarely reported because they are considered commonplace. Attempts by Ufologists—even those of indigenous descent—to convey Western interpretations of UFOs are typically met with extreme skepticism, with most witnesses insisting their sightings were "either a spirit or some magic."[2843]

In fact, "none of the [native Africans] interviewed treated their experiences as unusual," Hind wrote. "It was always something they associated with the spirits of their ancestors, a tribal anomaly which did not surprise or confuse them. Although they were often frightened by it, as the

spirits were not always friendly, they could always run away and hide, or make some attempt to avoid contact."[2844]

Armed with this knowledge, Hind began asking the right questions, as it were, and found a broad spectrum of cultures with a rich history of flying saucer sightings. In Hind's research, which focused on Zimbabwe, there is little distinction between humanoids and the "craft" themselves—both represent spirits.

- On November 20, 1976, multiple witnesses watched an orange orb flying over Rhodesia's [Zimbabwe's] Dindingwe Farm. The indigenous population attributed the light to "a spirit from the dead," going so far as to claim recurring contact. "They told me that they had met up with this 'spirit' before—and that the last time this happened—some two years previously—it had given off a strange smell like two stones rubbed together," said fellow witness John Butcher.[2845]

- From 1982-1984, workers at a Zimbabwe dairy farm often saw an aerial light hovering nightly above a nearby hill. When requested that the object move closer, it seemed to comply. The workers never conceptualized the light as extraterrestrial, instead believing it was a ghost.[2846]

- In 1983, four men in Zimbabwe walking to their village spotted a brilliant light descending from the sky. Convinced it was an ancestral spirit, they watched the object—clearly a machine—settle to the ground, open, and release two light-skinned beings. The witnesses fled the scene.[2847]

Alien-ancestor belief cannot be applied universally. For instance, while Australia's Warlpiri recognize both ancestral *warnayarra* and UFOs are capable of similar feats like draining billabongs, there is no indication that they are viewed as the same, nor that they interact with one another.[2848] Shaman Bernardo Peixoto told Mack his Brazilian tribe distinguished between ancestor spirits and *ikuyas* (Greys), which "possess a different energy and a higher standard of knowledge" than human predecessors. Credo Mutwa expressed similar misgivings, claiming spirits appearing as his African ancestors could in fact represent "parasites from other dimensions."[2849]

Even when witnesses describe UFOs as machines as in the 1983 case above, there is little cognitive dissonance between ancestral spirits and technology in indigenous thought. This may be due to the fact that, as noted elsewhere, the afterlife in non-Western cosmologies often continues to evolve just as in the living world. In fact, one could easily argue that the idea of a static afterlife is the true outlier across cultures, primarily the domain of Classical, Abrahamic, and contemporary theology. Modern ghost stories hint at the mundanity of the other side, depicting restless spirits compulsively engaging in the same activities which preoccupied their lives on Earth.

"In many cultures, the otherworld is a lively copy of the present world," wrote James R. Lewis. Most explicitly, the Egyptian afterlife was a mirror of our own, full of canals, dams, farms, and mortal activities like worship, work, eating, and sleeping.[2850] Variations on the Chinese afterlife were often quite "earthly:"[2851] "The world of spirits is an exact counterpart of the Chinese Empire, or, as has been remarked, it is 'China ploughed under,'" quipped one

scholar.[2852] We see similarities to Native American concepts of stereotypical "happy hunting grounds," full of plentiful game.[2853]

The dead in UFO encounters often seem engaged in personal and societal progress on the other side. Recall Muchena's explanation for his ancestors' garb: "Times change." Referring to Appendix B, we see similar implications in cases from Ufa, Russia (a dead son starts an afterlife family), Donetsk, Ukraine (a deceased neighbor appears with construction supplies), and Makhachkala, Dagestan (a departed friend has "a lot of work" to do). These examples suggest there is literal *life* after death, and it seems possible, if fantastic, that technology could progress far beyond ours in the next realm.

(Some researchers speculate UFOs originate in "breakaway civilizations," human societies operating parallel to ours on Earth possessing advanced technology. A technologically-advanced afterlife certainly fits this description. The idea that UFOs constitute "soul vehicles" is explored in Chapter 15.)

An ancestral model can render even the most absurd UFO encounters understandable, at least symbolically. As an example, consider the June 19, 1978 encounter of a family driving home in Gloucestershire who saw a hovering flying saucer and experienced missing time. Spurred by recurring dreams, the family volunteered for hypnotic regression, revealing supposed interactions with beings hailing from the planet Janos, a world long since destroyed.[2854]

The family's story, detailed in Frank Johnson's *The Janos People*, contains many far-fetched elements which make a great deal more sense when approached as a parable of ancestors dying in the distant past. Foremost, the Janos people claimed to explicitly come from Earth, having long ago fled

to another star system (or, from another perspective, they died): "You are our people, because you are the same as us." By their own admission they were our ancestors.[2855]

Upon reaching Janos, they found a pastoral utopia, nearly identical to the afterlife realms seen in NDEs. Here they prospered, though they continued wearing clothes resembling those of Ancient Greeks, their names bearing a Hellenistic quality: Saunus, Vonason, Faun, Phusantheas, etc. (even "Janos" resembles *Janus*, a liminal Roman deity). When their moon, Saton (Satan?) collided with their planet in a fiery apocalypse, they fled underground, where some withered to the point of appearing dead (shades of the fae folk).[2856]

Eventually, the Janos people scattered amongst the stars like a futuristic lost tribe of Israel, winding their way back to our solar system in anticipation of homecoming. Keeping with our death theme, the family was returning home *from a funeral*, and before returning to their car, consumed a liquid causing amnesia, much as Greeks drank lethe when leaving the afterlife.[2857]

If this narrative sounds familiar, consider that while *Battlestar Galactica* didn't debut on television until four months after the family's encounter, Johnson's interviews occurred after the show first aired. In some ways, this damning detail is inconsequential: the Janos People story sits at the nexus of fact and fiction, reality and dreams, UFOs and death, simultaneously drawing upon and contributing to the flying saucers of our Collective Unconscious.

Over hill and under hill

As mentioned in Chapter 11, extraterrestrial homeworlds invariably resemble the afterlife, be they paradisical or hellish. Even earthbound UFO sightings cluster around locales long associated with faeries and the dead: mountains, caves and caverns, monuments, bodies of water, the wilderness, even graveyards and cemeteries.

As Chapter 8 illustrated, both UFOs and the dead are closely associated with mountains. Today, many believe flying saucers retreat to bases inside hills and mountains, and alien abductees are taken to subterranean spaces within.

One of Katharina Wilson's many abductions included transportation into "an old structure that has been built into the side of a hill" where she met other abductees loitering in its musty labyrinth—by all appearances, a burial mound. The experience left her unable to shake the feeling that she had somehow died. During another abduction, she recalled "seeing a stone structure off in the distance… some old bricks and stones. Something was once here… ancient…."[2858]

Wilson's descent closely resembles a 1992 abduction where a woman was compelled to drive into the Blue Ridge Mountains, only to find herself and "a field full of people" in sleepwear floated "into the side of the hill where there was an opening."[2859] On July 24 of that same year, the U.S. military—

apparently in collusion with aliens—allegedly dragged alien abductee Pat from bed.

"Through the window Pat saw they were parked next to a large mound or hillside," Karla Turner wrote. "Incredibly, she saw a large doorway open outward, and the truck pulled inside, into the hill. The interior was very dimly lit, but as the vehicle stopped inside, Pat saw a strange being"—three feet tall, with slanted eyes—"standing as if waiting for their arrival."[2860]

Similar underground operating stations appear in the absence of mountains. Voyages to subterranean alien cities recur throughout Harvey-Wilson's alien abduction cases.[2861] In the blink of an eye another experiencer, Carlos Diaz, found himself in a cavern after a UFO flew above his head in Mexico in 1981. The cavern's "strange illumination" resembled that of Fairyland: "It was everywhere but I couldn't find the source."[2862] Just as the dead wind up beneath our feet, so do abductees.

The UFO-monument connection is also explored in Chapter 8, but a few tidbits are worth reiterating. Recall that nearly all monuments began as sepulchral sites, or later hosted burials in the vicinity. Many are modern UFO hotspots, focal points around which alleged "window areas" well up. Orbs of light—definitionally UFOs, even when too small to be spacecraft—are perennial anomalies at such sites, once described as ghost or faerie lights. It seems only fitting that Whitley Strieber's New York cabin was within walking distance of a Delaware burial site with two graves.[2863]

Flying saucers display an affinity for bodies of water, which are not only faerie haunts but repositories of souls. The ocean is an underworld. Less-celebrated accounts persist where UFOs plunge beneath or emerge from the

waves. The abduction of Filiberto Cardenas, for example, involved flight aboard a UFO that took him through a "tunnel beneath the sea."[2864]

We may also note flying saucers' mild aversion towards urban areas. Though plenty of sightings occur above cities, most seem relegated to sparsely-populated areas verging on or deep within the wilderness, once the haunt of faeries and spirits.

Plan 10 from Inner Space

Most researchers ignore the fact that UFOs are commonly seen above modern burial sites. In reality, graveyards and cemeteries should be regarded as flying saucer hotspots. Because of the sheer volume of cases, appearances of UFOs and aliens around contemporary burial sites have been compiled in Appendix C. While contemporary researchers like Preston Dennett and Scott Corrales have noted this trend, it was, as ever, presaged in Keel's observations.

"Cemetery sightings have become commonplace throughout the world," he wrote in 1968, "perhaps because cemeteries are deserted at night and offer excellent landing space" (an interpretation which, despite Keel abandoning the hypothesis the year prior, still holds vestiges of ETH thinking).[2865]

Orthodox Ufologists contort themselves trying to explain this correlation. Certainly the contemplative, mindful state encouraged by cemeteries causes one to be more observant, so perhaps the incidence of flying saucers seen hovering above our dead is overstated. Yet in many cases, witnesses are not deliberately visiting gravesites, but are only nearby, or passing in their cars.

Other researchers insist that extraterrestrials are gathering genetic material from the dead, retrieving implants from abductees who have passed away, or that—like a parody of Ed Wood's 1959 camp classic *Plan 9 from Outer Space*—aliens are intergalactic grave robbers. Corrales even went so far as to play with the idea that UFOs are "piloted by 'recycled' humans,"

their bodies plucked from fresh graves and reanimated to serve as flying saucer flight crews.[2866]

Though few and far between, some cases imply a type of harvest indeed takes place. Perhaps the most dramatic example comes from Indonesia, where a motorcyclist passing a cemetery in 2002 spotted a flying saucer suspended low above the gravesites, noiselessly shining a spotlight onto plots and pulling what seemed to be human figures from the ground. The witness was paralyzed until the craft departed.[2867]

Interplanetary body snatchers seem a little too literal-minded, a little too 1950s pulp sci-fi for an accurate interpretation. Why wait until people die to press them into intergalactic service, when thousands of people disappear each year? Why not dematerialize the implants, leave them in bodies, or perform the extraction before corpses are interred? Why wait until after a person is six feet under to gather genetic material, especially when aliens appear so keen to collect it while subjects are alive?

Everything from previous chapters points to a simpler, albeit metaphysical answer—that, while UFOs may indeed gather the dead from graveyards and cemeteries, the harvest may be more spiritual than physical. They may be collecting souls. This idea is closely tied to demonic interpretations of the phenomenon, presented in Chapter 16.

A less sensational perspective implies flying saucers are simply interested in "what we call death," either pulled to it like moths to a flame or, like psychopomps, somehow invested in the process of dying. Support for this interpretation can be found in the number of UFO sightings at memorial services and funeral homes.

"In the 1960s, we had a great many sightings directly over funeral homes and mental hospitals," Keel remarked in a 1979 lecture. "I could never figure that out."[2868] Always ahead of his time, he had explored such connections three years earlier in *The Eighth Tower*, writing, "In some cases the UFO lights appeared over homes nightly for weeks until one of the residents died."[2869]

This discussion skirts close to UFOs as death omens, which are covered in Chapter 16. Since omens, by definition, occur *before* death, our current exploration focuses on UFO activity reported afterward, or at the moment people shuffle off this mortal coil. A few examples:

- Sometime in the 1930s, Merton Haskell of Palermo, Maine claimed to see balls of light on a dozen occasions over two years. "The last time anyone ever saw it was the night my grandfather died and it was sighted by my father on a stone wall, a line between our farm and the next," Haskell explained in 1969. "This was the closest it ever got to our property. It was never seen by anyone after that."[2870]

- In another early example, a witness and his two sisters encountered a being on their household stairway at their mother's death in 1937. Fifty years later, the brother spotted the cover of Strieber's *Communion*, the closest representation of the entity's face he had seen since.[2871]

- In 1951, an Australian mother whose infant had recently passed away was rounding up cattle with her dog when she noticed a house-sized object over a ridge. Upon her approach three young-faced, masculine entities exited, floating

towards her. She voluntarily entered the craft, filled with computers and other entities who telepathically conveyed comfort and condolences. Despite finding impressions of landing gear at the site, she was ridiculed for her tall tale.[2872]

- The son of contactee Howard Menger was only 12 years old when he succumbed to a fatal brain tumor. Shortly beforehand, he reassured his parents that their contacts from Orion were coming to carry him away. A strange light appeared above the dying boy's bed, followed by a "bar of light" which changed from blue to white yet failed to illuminate the walls.[2873] Menger claimed to Berthold Schwarz that same night, after his son's death, he saw four glowing figures on a distant hilltop.[2874]

- On July 30, 1965 over a dozen Chilean witnesses holding a vigil for a child killed in a street accident described a violet light filling the house. Stepping outside, several mourners glimpsed a "strange machine" mere inches above the street. It flashed before blasting skyward.[2875]

- The son of an Arkansas funeral home director rushed inside to tell his mother he saw a flying saucer over her business one day in 1967. Several days later, a complete stranger visiting a friend's gravesite told the same story, but the object could not be found upon investigation.[2876]

- A novel story out of Billings, Montana describes several children who saw multicolored lights in the sky while conducting a funeral service for their pet turtle in July 1967. A beam of white light lanced toward the Earth, containing a being the children interpreted as Jesus. Within moments, the apparition vanished.[2877]

- Angel González of Gurabo, Puerto Rico captured a UFO on film in April 1976 while taking pictures at a reverend's funeral service, unseen to mourners at the time.[2878]

- Around midnight between April 14-15, 1987, farmers attending a dead colleague's wake in Zimbabwe saw a silent craft dart across the sky. Though decorum dictated describing the object as "lozenge-shaped," its accompanying illustration could not be more phallic: two spheres at the base of a lengthy shaft, the tip of which emitted a bright white light. Once the snickers subside, consider how this object's appearance at a wake blatantly encodes the cycle of death and conception.[2879]

Above examples where lights are seen at the time of death reflect ancient beliefs that the soul leaves the body as a luminous orb, typically via the mouth. The incidence of strange illumination accompanying death in the historical record cannot be overstated: such anomalies often manifested at the earthly departures of Christian religious figures. St. Columba's 597 death was accompanied by "an immense pillar of fire, which seemed to us, as it ascended upwards at that midnight, to illuminate the whole earth like the summer sun at noon." "At the same time and hour" of Pope Leo IX's 1054 death "all over the world appeared to men a circle in the sky of extraordinary brightness which lasted for about half an hour." "A great light" filled the sky when St. Gregory passed away in 1320.[2880]

That our souls may so closely resemble UFOs should give Ufologists pause. Chapter 15 explores this connection further.

Finally, entities resembling Greys pop up in outright hauntings. Experiencers like Jeff Ritzmann catch glimpses of Otherworldly intruders in their homes. Haunted houses may even *attract* UFOs: one alien abductee claimed to hear voices in her childhood home, find extra staircases which flashed in and out of existence, see chairs rock of their own accord, and find paper dolls missing. This was all *before* she and her sister shared a "dream" of a UFO in the backyard. The phenomena seemed to follow her later in life, so whether the house was haunted or *she* was haunted remains inconclusive.[2881]

Therianthropes and “one offs”

Despite the ubiquity of Grey aliens in popular culture, it is ill-advised to speak monolithically about extraterrestrials’ appearance. Over the decades they have varied widely in face and form, with trends ebbing and flowing through the years: early on, humanlike Space Brothers dominated, giving way to short, hairy dwarfs and little green men, followed by art-deco robots and, in the modern era, the triumvirate of reptilians, insectoids, and Greys. Interspersed throughout these trends are “one offs,” creatures of every imaginable humanoid configuration including death figures like clowns and Grim Reapers, seen once and never again.

Notably, most find antecedents in folklore. Beautiful deities, NDE light beings, and beautiful elves prefigured Space Brothers. Both dwarfs and modern Greys match numerous fae folk descriptions from the depths of time —Strieber has long referred to the short, blue creatures of his encounters as *kobolds*, drawing upon German folklore. With the exception of robots, all others exhibit varying degrees of therianthropy, a potent shamanic motif.

Before focusing on the Greys, which dominate modern imagination, consider these half-human, half-animal forms. It is exceptionally unlikely that any race evolving on another planet would so closely correspond to lifeforms found on Earth, yet persistent reports describe avian beings, entities with mantis heads, and anthropomorphic lizards.

Most of their terrestrial counterparts are affiliated with shamanism or death. UFO occupants with dog heads are rare, but nonetheless reported, reminding us of "man's best psychopomp." Similarly, birdlike beings (most famously the dubious "Blue Avians" championed by UFO promoter Corey Goode) are revered the world over as soul guides. As noted in Chapter 6, mantises—the most common insectoid form—hold potent spiritual meaning in some cultures. Reptiles, especially snakes, not only symbolize wisdom, death, and deception, but are also associated with reincarnation: tombstones in Western cemeteries sometimes use the *ouroboros*, a snake biting its own tail, to signify immortality.[2882]

Even some "one offs" like the entities from the 1973 Pascagoula abduction can be interpreted as spirits. Author Greg Bishop points out the striking resemblance between the Pascagoula aliens and Hopi kachinas. Artistic interpretations of the creatures' skin oscillates between something resembling elephant hide and mummy wrappings, obviously funerary.

"An appearance of dense folding typifies mummies [in abductions] who take their name from analogy with the wrappings of ancient Egyptian dead," wrote Bullard, noting the minor trend of similar alien epidermis in other accounts. Bullard collected reports of UFO occupants with skin described as "wrinkled, towel-like, bandaged, wrapped in silvery tape, or mummy-like."[2883]

Another ghostly "one off" appeared in 1973 to two children playing by a lake near Sandown, Isle of Wight. They watched as a tall being in a pointed hat (drawn like a kachina in subsequent depictions) entered a metallic "hut" nearby. The creature reemerged with an odd hopping gait and introduced

itself, first via megaphone, then by scrawling in a notebook—"Hello and I am all colours, Sam"—and finally speaking in a slurred voice.[2884]

When asked if it was a ghost, the being answered, "Well, not really, but I am in an odd sort of way."

"What are you then?" the children demanded.

"You know," the being replied without further elaboration. It invited the children into its "hut," which appeared quite technological inside. They conversed for half an hour before the children bade it goodbye.[2885]

(Mis)identification

Although "Sam the Sandown Clown" didn't appear particularly spectral, practically all UFO occupants display supernatural abilities associated with spirits of the dead or faeries. They can phase through objects, manifest and disappear in the blink of an eye, slowly fade away, appear hazy or transparent, glow, glide, levitate, hover, and shapeshift—all byproducts of highly advanced extraterrestrial technology, Ufologists assure us, despite the precedent of these attributes in ancient soulcraft. Drawing the line between ghosts and aliens has long proven difficult, as Bullard noted across dozens of interactions:

> [Another] type [of UFO occupant] bears looser ties with aliens and approaches the idea of ghostly apparitions. Alan Godfrey encountered a ghostly woman walking her dog prior to his abduction, perhaps demonstrating that UFO witnesses are prone to other strange observations or that strange events run in packs. Mona Stafford saw a figure with a biblical appearance in her parents' house, David Stephens saw spectral faces and Betty Andreasson saw shadowy and glowing figures at various times. A Kitley Woods witness saw a man with a cowboy hat in his truck but moments later could find no trace of the phantom hitchhiker. One witness claimed that beings materialized and disappeared around the house, another sensed an invisible being, and in good ghost story tradition, a cat hissed at an unseen presence in the house of the Aveley witnesses. The figures or the reports of them remain vague in a number of cases.[2886]

Unable to wrestle with such ambiguity, early researchers—Keel notwithstanding, of course—defaulted to the ETH. Coral Lorenzen discussed spirit-alien confusion as early as 1962 in her book *The Great Flying Saucer Hoax*, noting the propensity for farmers to misidentify extraterrestrials as ghosts.[2887] Despite his open-minded outlook, a similar stance appears in editor Charles Bowen's 1969 collection *The Humanoids*, which describes an "illiterate" Brazilian farmer's interpretation of a UFO and its occupants as ghosts.[2888] How silly!

Even if unintended, such assumptions carry with them the whiff of classism, that poor, uneducated witnesses are incapable of perceiving flying saucers for what they truly represent; there is a tacit conflation of simplicity with inaccuracy. After all, belief in ghosts is *superstitious*, while extraterrestrials are *scientific.* But what if our first impulse—the gut reaction our ancestors would have recognized as spirit contact from the Otherworld—is closer to the truth?

Turning to this chapter's primary focus, we find witnesses mistakenly (or correctly?) identifying Greys as ghosts on a regular basis. Under hypnosis, Anne Strieber described "a little white ghost with little feet" which entered her and Whitley's residence and roused her from sleep.[2889] While under hypnotic regression with Karla Turner, alien abductee Barbara reported her kidnappers "look like ghosts, they look so hollow…."[2890]

In the 1970s, the Parker family watched a "fiery craft" ascend from an Illinois soybean field. Their son awoke with wet, dirty socks, and began experiencing peculiar medical ailments. The Parkers moved to another home but, in classic haunted house fashion, the new tenants of their previous

residence could not bear to stay. They complained of visits from "diminutive big-headed ghosts with large black eyes."[2891]

Following his June 1959 time lapse of six hours in conjunction with a UFO sighting, Daniel Pelley experienced a variety of subsequent encounters, including "a ghost in my room. I never forgot the face. It was looking at me, very close, examining me. It had large eyes and pale skin but it didn't appear alien... It was more human looking than a monster."[2892]

Greys' anatomy:

Skin

In an excellent essay from the November 1994 *MUFON UFO Journal* entitled "Why Are the Grays Gray?", Martin Kottmeyer quoted a passage from Budd Hopkins's *Missing Time* where alien abductee "Virginia Horton" claimed, "there was so much gray… it seemed like the gray had a meaning to it…." In his typically thoughtful, thorough fashion, Kottmeyer dissected the color's symbolism in religion, myth, and folklore.[2893]

> In ancient Jewish mysticism, the gray globe of the Sephiroth Tree of the Cabala, the Chokmah, stood for Wisdom. The Chokmah was linked with the globes of the Crown, the white globe, and Understanding, the black globe, and Mercy, the blue globe. In early Christianity, gray was an emblem of Christ risen, a blend of the divine light of creation and the darkness of sin and death. In astrology, gray is the color of Aquarius. A child born under the sign is peaceable like gray, cursed to dwell in gray and moderate circumstances, blessed by a gray temperament, knowing neither white ecstasy or black despair. The occultist C.W. Leadbeater regarded gray as associated with depression and fear. Walter Kilmer's aura studies suggested the grayer colors were typical of diseased bodies and duller intellects. The gray alchemical spirit of lead caused madness. Though some of these symbolisms are contradictory and culturally embedded, they do seem to demonstrate meanings constructed from blends of black and white color symbolisms and from visceral physiological response.[2894]

Grey is therefore a liminal color, occupying a moral ambivalence between dark and light. Today grey and white, alongside the blackness of "shadow people," are frequent ghost colors. Grey, white, and green—the most commonly reported extraterrestrial hues—each exhibit longstanding associations with death or immortality. Even alien outliers colored brown symbolize rot, while Strieber's blue kobolds share a root with grey: the Old Irish *glas* can mean green *or* grey, while the same word in Welsh denotes blue.[2895]

"Grayness is also symptomatic of aging, sickliness, and death," Kottmeyer continued. "… everything about the Grays implies the realm of the dead. They skirt virtually every characteristic of life beyond movement." Eating and breathing matter little to these emotionless beings, who just as rarely urinate and defecate. They even "outsource" reproduction. "In their need to revitalize their decrepit constitutions and monochrome lifestyles by stealing the essences of humankind, they are fundamentally no different than the undead of literature and film like vampires. Appropriately, we are told they come from a dying world."[2896]

Kottmeyer based his observations upon trends seen across eyewitness testimony. One abductee, for instance, described a Grey's skin as "the color… of a dead person, kind of ashen."[2897] This unhealthy pallor suggests either bloodlessness—a feature shared with faeries in some traditions[2898]—or lividity, the cessation of blood circulation at death which deprives the skin of color and warmth.

Chills and cold spots are tropes in ghost stories both genuine and fictional. A drop in temperature often signifies the presence of a spirit, and ghosts

themselves, when touched, are "cold as the grave." The Greys' skin seems unnaturally frigid, too. Joan B. George of Arkansas described the extraterrestrial hands she felt in 1973 as "intensely cold, like a dead person."[2899] Six years later, Harry Joe Turner used similar language: "The entities' complexions were very pale, with skin that was cold to the touch 'like they was dead.'"[2900]

While many supernatural realms are temperate, others are frigid. Malidoma Patrice Somé's shamanic journeys (Chapter 7) include descriptions of the Otherworld as exceptionally cold.[2901] To the Inca, hell was not infernally hot, but instead represented "a frigid realm of punishment in the bowels of the earth."[2902] Even our modern Otherworld—outer space—is characterized by low temperatures.

Beyond their unhealthy temperature, Greys in many accounts also exude sulfurous odors (i.e. the smell of decay).[2903] The buzzing noises accompanying them bring to mind clouds of flies swarming fresh corpses. When grasped, their flesh is found soft, spongy, or crumbly, compared to putty, clay, marshmallows… or rotting flesh.[2904]

Like desiccated corpses disintegrating when touched, the Greys seem excessively fragile. Grappling with his abductors, Travis Walton claimed their muscles "yielded with a sponginess that was more like fat than sinew."[2905] In another famous example, recurring experiencer Patsy Wingate grasped the throat of a Grey and squeezed, snapping its neck with only her grip—its surprised compatriots dragged it from the room.[2906]

The idea that spirits cannot be embodied represents a relatively recent misnomer. "Notions of demonic corporeality are more rarely expressed but

not unknown," wrote medieval historian Richard Kieckhefer. Some ancient manuscripts claim unwanted spirits may be physically hit during rituals, "because the spirits can indeed be struck when they assume bodies for the sake of apparition." One medieval story explicitly describes an embodied ghost: "a woman who captured a spirit, carried it into a house on her back in the presence of certain men, one of whom later told that he saw the hands of the woman sunk deep into the spirit's flesh, as if its flesh were putrid and not solid, but fantastic."[2907]

"The image of pallid, unhealthy fungus-like skin cuts across all categories so not only are humanoids ashen and gray, but humans [aboard UFOs] too appear as pale and 'Nordic,'" Bullard wrote.[2908] Mushrooms, gatekeepers of consciousness associated with death and rot, spring to mind—in the words of someone who encountered a Visitor at Strieber's cabin, "I had the impression of a naked, damp creature come up from the woods…."[2909]

Greys' anatomy:

Skeletons

Greys' anatomy hints they may have more in common with the human dead than visiting extraterrestrials. With the exception of their leadership class they are short, evoking faeries and the small souls of Chapter 3. Their large heads and eyes find precedent in some, though not all, faerie descriptions, and identically-proportioned figures are a recurring subject in shamanic rock art.[2910]

Beyond these correlations, their humanoid orientation strongly implies the Greys are somehow related to us. Unless symmetrically-formed bodies—two legs, two arms, two eyes, two nostrils, one head and one mouth—are somehow optimal for *all* intelligent life in the universe, regardless of their environment, the odds of this form arising independently on another planet are staggeringly low.

However, if "aliens" are or *were* human, this configuration would be expected. Though orders of magnitude larger, the juxtaposition of their oversized heads and delicate bodies conjures up images of human fetuses; recall that both miscarriages and infants who died unshriven joined the faeries (see Chapters 4 and 17).

Whitley Strieber expressed regret over *Communion*'s iconic cover art, which he felt "communicate[d] the idea of an alien presence far more

forcefully than I had intended… Up close, there was something deeply human about her. One did not get the impression so much of alien as of human strangeness, and the feeling that one was face-to-face with a living aspect of a very deep mystery, which is the mystery of man."[2911]

Consider the challenge of drawing a Grey's skeleton, and how you would differentiate it from a living specimen. Their emaciated physique more-or-less resembles a collection of animated bones, held together by but the barest covering of skin. Greys' spindly limbs and necks are rail-thin—as Strieber described them, "hard inside, soft on the surface, as if made of bone covered by deerskin," devoid of "muscle or fat."[2912]

In fact, Greys deviate from human anatomy in only a handful of ways. Admittedly, some have fewer digits than we do. Their skulls and eyes are oversized, but that can be reconciled, as seen below. Certain accounts also describe longer arms and necks than we have.

While this last point could undermine comparisons to the human dead, similarly-disproportioned ghosts inhabit folklore. For instance, Japanese *taka-onna* are female ghosts whose long necks stretch to peep through lovers' windows. Bengali *sankchinni* can lengthen their limbs at will.[2913]

Greys conspicuously lack sex organs in most reports. So do human skeletons. Departing souls in medieval art were often sexless,[2914] and ambiguous gender characterizes death figures in myth and legend.[2915]

No need to rely on the word of armchair comparativists, however—just take a look at alien abductees, who draw these comparisons themselves. Grey aliens look like "a cross between a skeleton and a walking insect," said

one abductee to Mack. They are "skeleton like… little and brittle and creaky," claimed another remembering their past life as an extraterrestrial.[2916] One of Budd Hopkins's subjects described an infant alien hybrid with skin "so thin it's see-through… It's alive, but it's sort of, well it looks almost like a skeleton…."[2917]

Even the Ufological establishment seems incapable of distinguishing Greys from human skeletons. During the shameful 2015 Roswell Slides debacle, images of a mummified Native American boy were touted as "proof" of a recovered alien corpse.[2918]

Grey's anatomy:

Skulls

Despite being the most "alien" aspects of their physiology, Greys' large heads and eyes resemble human skulls, albeit exaggerated. It is not uncommon to find eyewitnesses comparing extraterrestrial visages to those of corpses: "His face looks like he's dead," Karin told Mack, "it looks like he's been rotting."[2919] When her experiences first began, recurring abductee Suzy Hansen couldn't shake the impression of "a skull with large black eye sockets"; she eventually made sense of this image after New Zealand UFO researcher Harvey Cooke revealed that skulls were a recurring motif reported by abductees.[2920]

"The head was slightly larger than a human head (in proportion to its body) and formed a crest on top," a FREE respondent said of a being encountered while meditating within four hours of their UFO sighting. "The eyes were just like the eyes of a skull, with sockets in which I could see the two holes deep in each socket where the optic nerve would normally be."[2921]

Large eyes represent a hallmark of eyewitness descriptions and pop-culture depictions, a trope stretching back at least to faerie folklore, if not the grave itself. Though not as drastically oversized, our own eye sockets are significantly larger than our eyes themselves (see Chapter 4). Like empty sockets, alien eyes are mostly lidless.

It seems only appropriate, should aliens be the human dead, that their eyes feature so prominently: eyes are not only "windows to the soul," but are associated with divinity and death.[2922] Abrahamic angels were often described as covered in eyes, and the eye itself could be considered something of a sideways yonic symbol, the gateway of life.[2923]

Aliens' eyes seem to be the source of their power, used to hypnotize, calm, and telepathically relay messages to UFO experiencers. We have these abilities, too—eye contact is valued in day-to-day conversation to convey authenticity. It may even facilitate telepathy. Many under the influence of psychedelics have stared into another's eyes, hoping to awaken psychic communication; in his 2020 study of "psychedelic telepathy," Petter Grahl Johnstad found that some psychonauts recommend "that trippers hoping for a telepathic experience should look deeply into one another's eyes, which they claimed serve as a gateway into other people's consciousness."[2924]

Those brave enough to stare into alien eyes describe communication, love, gnosis, fear, or sadness. Their fathomless depth reminds us both of empty eye sockets and the inky blackness required for scrying (Chapter 6). Some report Greys' eyes are actually protective gear hiding the mysteries of the universe.

Said one experiencer, "Their eyes are shields… necessary to protect human beings from what they would otherwise be exposed to. This would overwhelm them." The experiencer asked for a mere glimmer of what lay beyond, and the being "allowed some of it to leak out," filling her with "an influx of universal knowledge and infinite love."[2925]

Within descriptions of Greys' "true" eyes we find allusions to visibly beholding the divine or *theophany*, perilous revelations which, regardless of the religion, often drove witnesses mad. This conforms not only to Strieber's commentary—he believes all knowledge resides within the Visitors' eyes, including the time of one's death[2926]—but also a half-remembered childhood account from Wren Collier.

A "particularly vivid dream" found Collier attacking a Grey watching his brother while he slept. "The eye turned out to only be some sort of shield or visor," he wrote. "Underneath was an array of tiny red and green lights, like a field of stars." It was like "gazing into the void."[2927]

Working our way down the Grey's face, we find vestigial or entirely absent noses, mirroring open nasal cavities, and tiny or absent mouths. While not conforming to human skulls, small mouths figure in folk art. Holy figures are often depicted with tiny mouths to signify their disinterest in worldly pleasures.[2928] In ancient Celtic sculpture, such as a head pillar found at Entremont, France, the dead entirely lack mouths "to signify silence and death." These dead visages also lack ears—like human skulls and most Greys—and feature slit eyes, square chins, and elongated heads.[2929]

This final detail brings us to the loose association between ancestors and large heads, perhaps the Greys' defining feature. Beliefs that the departed possessed oversized skulls can be seen in both ancient and modern indigenous traditions. In some cultures, large-headedness signifies ancestral power and knowledge, as among the Kwakiutl of British Columbia, who hold their predecessors wore "very large" head rings compared to those used today.[2930] The head rings are integral components in initiation into the

Kwakwa̱ka̱’wakw’s *hamat’sa* society, which revolves around contacting the spirits.[2931]

In Africa, Yoruban ancestor effigies are topped with oversized heads because heads represent “the seat of character.”[2932] Similar cranial emphasis appears in ancestral sculpture throughout the continent, including art from Zimbabwe, Zaire, Zambia,[2933] and the Congo, evident in Bembe *nkiteki* figures.[2934] A few accounts of Ireland’s Tuatha Dé Danann—faerie predecessors, deities, or a deceased human race—describe them as “long-headed.”[2935]

Indigenous people the world over practiced cranial deformation, first mentioned in Chapter 8, where infants’ heads were bound to permanently elongate their skulls as they grew. The topic is much in vogue among ancient alien theorists, who believe people in the distant past met bobble-headed extraterrestrials and, deifying them, mimicked their appearance. Though the actual motives remain uncertain, most archaeologists view cranial deformation as a signifier of group affiliation or social status.

Regardless, it stands to reason that—just as contemporary ghosts return with injuries or body modifications reflecting their living state—cranially deformed ancestors would return with oblong heads intact, casting doubt upon whether large heads should be viewed as “alien” at all.

“Taken” again

Chapter 4 illustrated how kidnapping is a pastime favored by all denizens of the Otherworld, from faeries to ghosts and spirits. Without belaboring the point, we see identical behavior from extraterrestrials, up to and including an increased risk of abductions during inclement weather.

Correlating storms and UFOs is difficult, but a hint appears in the testimony of Ted Rice, who recalled “a dark, swirling atmosphere” upon returning home after an abduction, accompanied by what his family perceived as a tornado. “They’d been out looking for me because the storm was coming up, and nobody could find me until it blew over,” he said.[2936]

“A sound like rain would often fill the house as the Visitors approached from above,” Strieber claimed.[2937] Spirits, of course—including the kidnapping dead of the Wild Hunt—were often blamed for similar weather patterns.

Flying saucers are more often accompanied by a mysterious fog, sometimes of a strange quality or color, calling to mind the “misty days” that signified an increased risk of faerie abductions. Dozens if not hundreds of UFO sightings begin with ground-level clouds enveloping witnesses, reminiscent of the transportive weather to the Otherworld from medieval literature.[2938] Fog features often enough in ghost stories to be considered cliché.

"I no longer consider that ghosts can be photographed, though I am prepared to consider that fogs, mists and unusual images may be a sign of anomalous phenomena, perhaps electromagnetic radiation of some kind," wrote English paranormal researcher Alan Murdie. "However, they are not ghosts and may be compared with the ripples you get in a pond when there is an otter about. However, they are not the otter itself!"[2939]

Interactions while sleeping or on the verge of slumber represent another staple of spirit contact. As noted in earlier chapters, the psychopomp Hermes could command mortals to sleep, a talent shared with faeries and modern aliens. Dead loved ones appear in bedrooms or during dreams, the exact conditions under which extraterrestrial abductors so often appear. Like their ghostly counterparts, aliens snap into or out of bedrooms without warning, regardless of any intent to kidnap.

Whether these take place in dreams, reality, or something in-between seems immaterial—reality is more subjective, dreams more objective than any of us wish to admit, and the profound personal changes witnesses report speak for themselves. Without dismissing physical aliens entirely, author Nick Redfern feels that:

> ...a very good argument can be made that such encounters—all throughout history with magical, ethereal, god-like, alien-themed entities—occur in a much altered state of mind... Many such encounters begin in bedrooms, in the sleep state… I'm not saying—at all—that people are dreaming these experiences and that's all there is to it; in fact, quite the opposite. I believe that these entities—who over the centuries have manifested as gods, demons, angels, djinn, elementals, aliens—have the ability to invade the human mind and manipulate the sleep state, particularly the state of *hypnagogia* during which the human mind is very susceptible to strange

> and fantastic imagery and voices. In fact, I think a further argument can be made that perhaps what we perceive as the dream state may actually be closer to the realm that these things inhabit on a permanent basis, rather than a physical 3-D world like ours.[2940]

"What we perceive as the dream state" has gone by many names over the years—Fairyland, the Otherworld, another dimension, the astral realm—but was always understood as related to "what we call death": a liminal space where we rove nightly, straddling the borderland between the living and the dead.

The siren call of hungry greys

Ufologists of the ETH persuasion typically narrow the motivation behind alien abductions to a few key goals, the most common of which include spiritual development, general scientific study, and above all, the harvesting of genetic material (Chapter 17). This may involve DNA samples or, most commonly, sexual procedures ranging from physical copulation between humans and aliens (an ancient theme throughout spirit contact) to the highly technical, sometimes invasive gathering of human sperm and ova.

Because few interactions are more emotionally charged than sexual intercourse, some researchers speculate this genetic harvest is a red herring, that the Greys' true interest lies in human interaction itself. The aliens lack emotions, abductees often tell us, and as such are fascinated by our capacity to *feel*. A review of alien abductions reveals an underlying commodification of human empathy: according to one experiencer, human-alien hybrids "can grow physically… but emotionally they're dead. They need us to do that—nurture the babies."[2941]

Katharina Wilson claimed the aliens she encountered often presented her with graphic, traumatizing imagery or deliberately placed her in stressful situations. "The only emotion or feeling I received from the 'others'… was *curiosity*," she claimed. "It was pure *curiosity.*"[2942]

The Greys put Bret Oldham through similar emotional trials:

> I know one thing for sure: the Greys are very interested in human emotions. Many of the experiments done on me were based around monitoring and measuring my emotional reaction to certain situations that they would create and place me in. It could very well be that they use implants in humans as not only a tracking device but also as a way to monitor our emotions as we live our everyday life and go through the wide array of emotions that our life experiences bring upon us.
>
> …They have no emotion other than something that is contrived for a purpose. They seem to exhibit what I would describe as a hive mentality.[2943]

This lack of emotion has led Oldham and others to wonder whether the Greys "are biological robots who are all programmed with the same software," perhaps sent by actual extraterrestrials in lieu of lengthy physical travel.[2944] The notion is not without merit, satisfactorily explaining both the Greys' bipedal orientation—they, like us, are optimized to navigate Earth—and their emotionless demeanor.

In short, they might be sentient probes imbued with highly advanced artificial intelligence, controlled by actual extraterrestrials who have never left their homeworld. Whitley Strieber, whose opinion of the Visitors has changed over time and will likely continue to evolve, most recently played with the idea in 2020's *A New World*. "That they may, therefore, be machines doesn't seem to me impossible, either, nor does the idea that a machine might be conscious," he wrote.[2945]

Yet our human dead have need of artificial servants as well. The entire concept of robots may be rooted in Egyptian afterlife belief, where slaves surrendered their lives—and afterlives—in the service of pharaohs, interred in tombs to mindlessly attend their needs in the Tuat.

"Since a Pharoah needed to be served in the afterlife, his personal servants and slaves were buried with him," wrote Mike Hockney. "Later, models and statues of people (figurines known as *ushabtis*) served as substitutes for the slaves, and would do any menial work required in the afterlife in place of the dead person himself. This was the origin of the notion of a robot: a machinelike being doing dreary tasks." Similar artificial attendants are evident in the famous Terracotta Army buried with unified China's first emperor, Qin Shi Huang.[2946]

Another possibility behind the Greys' emotional obsession also originates in the East. Various Buddhist traditions describe *hungry ghosts*, spirits of the dead who cling to existence instead of fading away, doomed by evil deeds, violent deaths, the neglect of their descendants, or attachment to worldly pleasures. An intense, almost animalistic need for human emotion drives these spirits—they are obsessed with the pleasures of the flesh, but never satisfied.[2947]

"In Buddhist beliefs, the hunger of ghosts represents a more metaphorical dimension," wrote professor Katarzyna Ancuta. The dead can either become enlightened by abandoning their "unconscious tendencies" which have caused their suffering, or they can remain wed to those emotions and endure "the patterns of his/her past existence" once again. "A spirit that decides to pursue revenge (apparently the most common reason for the spirits to

remain on earth) instead of giving up its earthly emotions cannot move on to be reborn and remains in the 'intermediate existence.'"[2948]

Though many variations exist, hungry ghosts derive their name from an inability to swallow food past their thin necks and tiny mouths, attributes also seen in descriptions of Greys. In fact, artistic depictions of hungry ghosts sometimes reflect alien anatomy: skeletal limbs, outsized heads, sickly skin, even an association with light phenomena. Buddhism's hungry ghosts likely derive from the Hindu concept of pretas, beings further embodying faerie-alien attributes like short stature and the consumption of detritus.[2949]

As astutely pointed out by Barbara Fisher, it is not their appearance, but rather hungry ghosts' craving for physical sensation that provides the best comparison to the Greys. Fisher cites Strieber's latest writing on the Visitors: "For us, everything is always new. They may know reality outside of time. We don't really know what the next second will bring. They hunger to share our sense of newness… Could it be that there are physical beings who can no longer taste of life but long to do so? "[2950]

The metaphor of hungry ghosts has taken on new life outside a religious context, finding poetic power in describing the impulses and attachments stemming from addiction. Shamanic practitioner David Kowalewski believes that "addicted discarnate souls often feel the need to continue their substance abuse, and may well possess a living addict to do just that. They are still fixated on getting the next 'fix'…."[2951]

This concept grew to greater attention among Forteans with Joe Fisher's chilling 2001 book *The Siren Call of Hungry Ghosts*. Fisher's experience

cannot be summarized here—and should not be, for it deserves to be read—so a quick thumbnail sketch must suffice.

While investigating the Toronto Spiritualist scene, Fisher (no relation to Barbara) found himself enchanted by the channeled presence of a departed Greek girl named Filipa. Fisher became emotionally involved in Filipa's story to the point of infatuation, at the expense of his earthly relationships. Many of the channeled details provided to Fisher, some quite obscure, were verifiable, while others were grossly inaccurate. Over time, Fisher grew to believe the spirits he encountered were deceptive, low-level intelligences drawing energy from the living by forging parasitic connections.[2952] Fisher latched upon the hungry ghost concept, writing:

> In his out-of-body journeyings. Robert Monroe tells of encountering a zone next to the Earth plane populated by the "dead" who couldn't or wouldn't realize they were no longer physical beings. "It wasn't nice," writes Monroe in *Far Journeys*. The beings he perceived "kept trying to be physical, to do and be what they had been, to continue physical one way or another. Bewildered, some spent all of their activity in attempting to communicate with friends and loved ones still in bodies or with anyone else who might come along...."
>
> This thickly-peopled "dead zone" just beyond the frontiers of physical existence tallies precisely with the realm of the hungry ghosts described in the teachings of Tibetan Buddhists. The hungry ghosts, characterized by intense greed, are depicted as beings with tiny mouths, thin necks and gigantic bellies. They are tortured by their insatiable hunger even more than the pain of not being able to find and consume what they crave. Their wants and desires are seen as a desperate attempt to feed their poverty of spirit as well as to obliterate their most basic fear, the fear that they may not exist. After death, say the

> Buddhists, the earthly individual's powers of resistance will be tried and tested by the hungry ghosts' siren call.[2953]

Fisher's entire ordeal could easily be transplanted to a Ufological context, particularly if one holds a negative view of alien abductions. The channeled presence was not only emotionally predatory, but a sexual undercurrent pervades the proceedings, and deception played a prominent role. Even if Filipa was in some way beneficial, the relationship evokes ancient concepts of shamanic spirit lovers. (As seen in the following sections, the fact that these intelligences were channeled through a human medium does not preclude an "extraterrestrial" source.)

As a parting aside, the Greys' emotionless demeanor is highly incongruent with faerie behavior, which is overwhelmingly portrayed as passionate. The same can be said for many, though by no means all, hauntings. Given how these phenomena otherwise closely overlap, this discrepancy is puzzling, without a fitting solution. Perhaps these phenomena are somehow fundamentally different. Perhaps emotions, like ego, wane with time on the other side. Perhaps aliens and faeries represent two parts of an afterlife whole and, much as our brains are bifurcated into an analytical left side and an artistic right side, work in tandem towards shared goals.

E.T. phone home

While recording himself singing in 1957, Friedrich Jürgenson "started to notice at this time some quite strange phenomena; inexplicable fade-ins and fade-outs on the tapes; abstract visions and telepathic messages." Because of this accidental innovation, Jürgenson is among those credited with discovering electronic voice phenomenon (EVP), one of the most common ghost hunting techniques used today. ("Among those" is critical: Jürgenson may have discovered EVP earlier, but he did not report it publicly until spring 1959, three months after parapsychologist Raymond Bayless published similar findings in the *Journal of the American Society for Psychical Research*.)[2954]

Jürgenson not only recorded messages from the dead but, at the same time, began receiving telepathic messages from outer space in 1959, acquiring

> …a message about a Central Investigation Station in space where they conducted profound observations of Mankind. [...] My friends spoke about certain electro-magnetic screens or radars, that were frequently transmitted, day and night, in batches of thousands to our three-dimensional life levels and, like living beings, had a mission as mental messengers. Undoubtedly one could see these radars as half-living robots that, remote controlled, had the ability like an oversensitive television or radio to correctly register and transmit all our conscious and unconscious impulses, feelings, and thoughts.[2955]

Ghost hunters rarely remark on EVP's intergalactic pedigree. Equally undiscussed are examples where these anomalous voices appear to come from extraterrestrials, rather than from the dead. Though the origin and identity of all spirit contact remains mysterious—as John Keel quipped, "We can't believe a damn thing that comes through"—this shared vector of communication suggests once again that ghosts and aliens have more in common than mainstream researchers accept.[2956]

Over the decades, parapsychologists have grown to realize EVPs are not secure transmissions between the living and the dead, but rather interdimensional "party lines" where all manner of presences can barge in uninvited.

- Following a UFO sighting outside Sheffield in late 1957, Englishman Philip Rodgers recorded voices who claimed "in sharply clipped accents" to hail from outer space. The voices also sounded mechanical, issuing such cryptic statements as "Ship is real: People," "Sputnik," and phrases in alien gibberish like "Ya-du pardu!" (Shades of McKenna's psilocybin-induced glossolalia.) None of the voices were audible at the time of recording.[2957]

- Bret Oldham claims to have intercepted audio of both ghosts and aliens through his "Ghost Box" or "Spirit Box," another electronic tool for paranormal investigation consisting of a radio which scans through frequencies to purportedly catch snatches of spirit communication. In one instance, he and fellow experiencer Sandy Nichols received an oddly mechanical reply, prompting them to ask the presence

about their own alien abductions. The voice identified itself as coming from the Greys, claiming they sought "sperm" for "babies."[2958]

- On another occasion, Oldham captured snippets of a conversation while sleeping. The voices commented on the crystals Oldham kept on his nightstand before a male voice said, "He knows." A whirring sound followed, accompanied by a frightened, "Oh my God, oh my God!"

Oldham speculated the ghosts were reacting to an alien abduction unfolding in his bedroom; we might as easily ask if these errant souls were responding to psychopompic aliens who had come to collect. "I had captured thousands of EVPs, and it was rare to hear a ghost that sounded frightened," he wrote.[2959]

- Brazilian researcher Sonia Rinaldi began researching EVPs before moving into instrumental transcommunication, a similar but more sophisticated technique using advanced electronics. Rinaldi's work met great success until around 2002, when she intercepted additional voices claiming to be extraterrestrials.

"They were just making themselves known, though their presence had been around much longer," wrote Rosemary Ellen Guiley. Rinaldi was initially so disturbed she shuttered her laboratory, but later grew to trust the intelligences, which "assured her that their purpose was not to harm, but to improve contact with Earth."[2960]

Despite its lauded application in ghost hunting, parapsychologists have always entertained EVP's potential for extraterrestrial contact. Long before Jürgenson and Bayless, famed rivals Thomas Edison and Nikola Tesla were locked in a race to invent technology which could communicate beyond the

grave.[2961] Tesla himself claimed to have detected signals from interplanetary civilizations in 1899.[2962]

Another prolific EVP researcher, Konstantin Raudive, was inspired by Jürgenson's 1964 book *The Voices from Space* and embarked on a lifelong pursuit collecting over 100,000 audio tapes.[2963] Raudive—who plays a significant role in the next chapter's discussion of Whitley Strieber—in turn inspired Sarah Estep. As of 2007, Estep had amassed 25,000 recordings, 3,000 of which, she claimed, were the product of extraterrestrial and interdimensional communication.[2964] Again, we find parapsychology (née Spiritualism) and Ufology hopelessly intertwined from the beginning; only recently did researchers tear this union asunder.

A related subset of Fortean studies is entirely dedicated to telephone calls from the dead, pioneered by researcher D. Scott Rogo, working in tandem with Bayless. The character of these interactions varies widely. In some circumstances, the dead contact living loved ones before the receiver is aware of the caller's demise, during which communication is clear and typically colored by messages of hope or reassurance. In other examples, the caller seems unable to hear the living, or the connection may be poor.[2965]

"Mysterious telephone calls also play a major role in many UFO and occult incidents," John Keel wrote. "Apparently the phenomenon can selectively interfere with any kind of electrical apparatus on the planet."[2966] Keel grew increasingly frustrated with the phantom callers plaguing his Point Pleasant, West Virginia investigations in 1966-1967:

> My bills were now astronomical. I was constantly being cut off in the middle of conversations, or foreign sounds were injected into my line. Somebody would strum a one-stringed guitar or blow a shrill whistle while I was talking… I often heard the distinct sound of an extension being picked up or put down. Electronic beeps, eerie music, hollow metallic voices, all became common on the blasted instrument. My gentle protests to the telephone company turned into howls of rage.[2967]

Paranormal afficionados attribute these mysterious calls to a variety of sources from flying saucer occupants to Men-in-Black to author Gray Barker, who admitted to pulling pranks on Keel throughout the years. If not from Barker, it seems prudent to classify these as prank calls from "spirits" and move on.

"I don't think [UFOs] are created by observers, any more than ghosts are," said Colin Wilson in 1999. "I think that at least some of them are, in fact, 'spirits' of the kind who were summoned up by mediums in the 19th century, and who are 'wanderers' between two worlds—juvenile delinquents of the spirit world, like poltergeists."[2968]

Predictably, EVP has been used to capture alleged faerie voices, though these are much rarer and, as ever, the difficulty of distinguishing them from ghosts remains. Seldom do phantom voices identify as fae folk—usually, listeners jump to conclusions.

For instance, an alien abductee compelled to write the Striebers related seeing one of "Santa's elves" peering through the living room curtains from her front porch during childhood. Decades later, moments after finishing *Communion,* the elf allegedly called the witness. Instead of a traditional ring,

their phone sounded three chimes "like a light mallet on a single bell, perfectly even." Upon answering, "all I could hear was a simple voice, 'Send Whit the letter.'"[2969]

Placing too much emphasis on the *electronic* nature of this contact—that somehow paranormal forces manipulate circuit boards, or that our technology easily picks up supernatural energy—runs the risk of overlooking the fact that *spirits can communicate through whatever medium they choose*. Synchronicities are arguably the grandest means by which messages from the Otherworld reach us, reality itself serving as a canvas.

Spirits may pen letters. Ufologist William F. Riefer started receiving a "tremendous amount" of peculiar phone calls in the late 1950s, as well as correspondence from "an individual who [had] a grudge against the entire human race with heathen overtones." Upon investigating, Riefer learned the writer had been dead for around five years. The postal service returned all other Ufologists' correspondence with the sender, but Riefer and his colleague James W. Maney would always "get a reply."[2970]

Most frequently we find direct, intimate communication between spirits and individuals spanning all five senses, perhaps even tapping into our sixth. Prior to the electronic revolution, simpler methods of spirit contact were employed like automatic writing, mediumship, and channeling.

Ground control to major Atum

"Whereas mediumship is a term most often applied to communication with the dead, channeling is used for interaction with various non-physical beings, including angels, nature spirits, totem or guardian spirits, deities, demons, higher intelligences, and extraterrestrials, as well as spirits of the dead," wrote Guiley.[2971] The primary difference between mediumship and channeling seems to be the level of autonomy mediums retain—ancient Greek necromancers sometimes called channeling "ventriloquism," produced by "some sort of power that took up residence in the stomachs of one or more individuals, took partial possession of their voices, and uttered prophecies in muttering fashion."[2972]

The alleged ability of UFO intelligences to communicate through this vector once more suggests they are spirits, or at least traffic in the same realm as spirits, perhaps a fundamental level of consciousness. Channeling and mediumship manifest across all spiritualities and religions, from animism to Christianity, issuing from the mouths of shamans and saints alike.

"Channeling, like mediumship, has ancient roots," Guiley explained. "The ancient Egyptians used states of mystical trance to communicate with the gods. In ancient China, shaman-like people used trance states to interact with the spirit world. Channeling is recorded in the history of early India, and in ancient Greece it was used for oracular prophecy. Many spiritual leaders have received their guidance through channeling; examples are the prophets

of the Old Testament and Muhammad, who received the teachings of the Koran while in trances and in dreams."[2973]

As noted in Chapter 10, mediumship and channeling were no more valued than in Spiritualism and Theosophy, both of which influenced Ufology with messages from interstellar spirit guides alongside the dead and faeries. Though Theosophy waned significantly in the wake of World War II,[2974] its core experience endured in Ufology's fledgling years, which saw contactees channeling flying saucer occupants in a manner substantively indistinguishable from mediums channeling spirits.

"Generally speaking, there has been a trend over the decades, moving from physical to non-physical forms of alleged contact with extraterrestrials," wrote Richard Dolan. "But even during the 1950s, communication with extraterrestrials via Ouija board, spirit mediums, and channeling was fairly common."[2975] In addition to those from previous chapters, consider these examples:

- The I AM religious movement was founded after Guy Ballard hiked Mount Shasta and met "the Count of Saint Germain." The entity administered a mysterious liquid to Ballard before spiriting him away in a circular "White Flame" in which they visited buried cities in the Amazon, Yellowstone National Park, and the Grand Tetons, under which twelve Venusian masters—similar to the Ascended Masters of Theosophy—lived in a golden sanctuary. "Like so many of the early contactees, Ballard was gifted with the apparent ability to channel his golden-haired Venusian friends, including the 'Tall Master of Venus,'" wrote Gorightly and Bishop.[2976]

- After his release from prison in 1950, convicted seditionist William Dudley Pelley published *Star Guests: Design for Mortality*, a collection of channeled automatic writing claiming "a vast horde" of "alien spirits" migrated to Earth from Sirius in the antediluvian past, producing "a race of hybrid beings."[2977]

- In 1952, Enid Joan Brady's Holly Hill, Florida mediumship practice shifted from spirit to extraterrestrial communication, earning her the scorn of fellow Spiritualists. Like Ballard, Brady's contacts hailed from the paradisical, disease-and-war-free planet Venus. The Venusians told her they commanded a space base orbiting the Earth, from which they launched missions to "save us from our destructive selves." The frequency of these missions was set to increase in 1962.[2978]

- Lucille McNames claimed regular physical and telepathic contact with aliens since her 1966 flying saucer sighting, culminating in two books of channeled material. Wrote Leo Sprinkle, "One message, for scientists who study electronic communication with spirit personalities, contained this statement: 'We have methods by which to nudge the patterns awake after having lain dormant, often for eons. Memory patterns are part of the soul's Akasha that are reflections of one's deeds and actions throughout all of his/her lifestreams.'"[2979]

- After her UFO contact in 1940, Ida M. Kannenberg became so concerned with the voices in her head that she sought hospitalization, yet was given a clean bill of mental health. She continued to receive extraterrestrial messages, however, which sometimes responded to her questions.

  In one instance circa 1978 she asked, "Into what are we being initiated?" The presence replied, "Into a worldwide organization dedicated to the purpose of helping peace and justice return to the world."[2980]

- Psychic and UFO experiencer Jacquelin Smith channeled aliens who revealed their relationship to owls. "They are using the owls symbolically. There is an archetypal image that is mirrored to the humans, this goes in on a subconscious level and connects with the human's genetic memory bank. Because humans think with symbols, they are touching uson that level, and that goes back to the beginning of humankind, and how we see owls."[2981]

While too expansive to fully elaborate, some of the most famous UFO channeling sessions were overseen by parapsychologist Andrija Puharich over the course of several decades. In addition to his involvement in numerous governmental projects researching psi phenomenon, Puharich investigated self-proclaimed psychics like Uri Geller and Hindu mystic D.G. Vinod.

In 1952 Vinod introduced Puharich to "The Nine," a group of channeled extraterrestrial intelligences from beyond space and time who once interacted with mankind as the ennead of Egyptian deities. From March 1974 onward, Puharich contacted The Nine at his headquarters in Ossining, New York with help from psychic Phyllis V. Schlemmer. [2982]

Author Stuart Holroyd chronicled the proceedings and, while skeptical, detected *something* authentic in Schlemmer's channeling. Holroyd described how she would leave her body to make room for "Tom," the ancient Egyptian god *Atum*, to take control and use Schlemmer's "vocal mechanisms" to spread The Nine's messages.[2983]

Tom assured those present that Earth is uniquely beautiful, but mankind is not alone in the universe, that death is illusory, and that we must act with

spiritual responsibility. The Nine further revealed that Earth, in the words of Schlemmer scholar Palden Jenkins, is filled with reincarnated souls from other worlds, and forms a sort of controlled "bottleneck in the passing through of souls."[2984] (There is some indication, perhaps overstated, that screenwriter Gene Roddenberry was inspired to create *Star Trek* after he was commissioned to adapt a script based on The Nine's revelations.)

Despite his own dubious claims, contactee George Adamski dismissed channeling as a poor tool for contacting Space Brothers: "You can never check on the sender of a trance message. Every mock spirit or evil impersonator could come and tell you that his name was Ashtar or Aetherius and that he lived in a spaceship. I think that these entities are having a heyday leading astray the gullible mediums and their public…."[2985] Fair enough.

Today, nuts-and-bolts Ufologists still resist channeled messages. Channeling is "not falsifiable, not verifiable, and therefore could easily be fabricated," Richard Dolan argues. "… my own conclusion is that the large majority of claimed channeled transmissions and telepathic 'downloads' are false. Sadly, there is a prevalence among too many to disregard the concepts of science when reviewing such claims."[2986]

This is a frustrating position, as many alien abductions occur without corroborating physical evidence and are equally unfalsifiable, equally evasive regarding scientific proof, yet are treated much more charitably by researchers like Dolan. That we should even concede to demands for scientific "proof" regarding what is clearly a spiritual phenomenon further perplexes. Moreover (and Dolan admits as much) many contemporary

Ufologists readily accept telepathic communication in alien abductions—what is channeling, if not a form of telepathy at a distance?

We should not abandon critical thinking, but eyewitness testimony is the bedrock of Fortean investigation. Jettisoning claims of channeling while selectively retaining aspects of UFO contact which conform to our personal paradigm is intellectually dishonest. Turning to the FREE study once more, we find people reporting these experiences with a regularity warranting serious discussion: 28% of respondents felt they "became able to channel information from other dimensions."[2987]

In addition to channeling, extraterrestrials contact humans through other means typically reserved for spirits. "Shortly after its invention, the Ouija enjoyed great popularity due to the interest in spiritualism and to the thousands of World War I bereaved who tried to find ways to communicate with their loved ones who had been killed in the war," wrote Guiley. "Most paranormal investigators do not recommend uses of talking boards because they often seem to connect users to low-level spirits. However, many cases of talking board use in automatic writing and communication with spirits of the dead have been benign, even productive, in nature."

Though primarily used to contact spirits, aliens bleed through during Ouija board sessions. The infamous "Gulf Breeze Six"—U.S. intelligence analysts who abandoned their West German military post in July 1990—visited Florida's famed UFO hotspot at the behest of a Ouija board.[2988] Children playing with a Ouija board in Utah found it accurately predicted where (Roosevelt Hospital) and when (8:00 p.m., February 26) a UFO would appear.[2989]

Arriving, they found, "to their surprise, the UFO had kept the appointment," Preston Dennett wrote, having collected numerous similar examples. "They all ran outside and observed a 'kind of an orange ball, orange to red, kind of in a circle, bigger than an ordinary light.' The light was circular in shape, and began moving toward them, blinking on and off. Its apparent size was one-third that of the moon."[2990]

As in EVPs, mediumship, and channeling, it is impossible to determine exactly what lies at the other end of Ouija board communication. However, the appearance of aerial craft or light phenomena in conjunction with such messages, like in the example above, strengthens the argument that UFO intelligences—not necessarily extraterrestrials, but *UFOs*—can be contacted mentally.

Some controversial characters have fashioned entire careers from manifesting UFOs on-demand. Steven Greer, who peddles such fantastic claims, utilizes a set of highly-refined protocols to allegedly "call down" UFOs. His reputation notwithstanding, attendees on his expeditions often report results, though chicanery can never be fully ruled out.[2991]

Perhaps more authentically, in June 1991 a Bantu witness told his workmate that their traditional *Nyau* dance the night before—which calls ancestors into our world—had drawn the attention of a white, vertically-oriented, cigar-shaped light in the sky. The object emitted red flames from its rear side. The dancers perceived the UFO as a ghost or witch, causing them to "beat the drums even harder and sing even louder." The following morning, a farmer attending church in the village reported that "witches" had

been pranking him, flooding his room with bright light "from the cemetery side" of his house.[2992]

How are extraterrestrials in spaceships receiving mental communication? Why would they show up to a dance meant to bring forth the dead?

Interrupted journeys

The scenario should be familiar by now: drivers spot strange shapes darting across the sky. Motors are killed. Headlights doused. Radios sputter with static, or cease altogether. Then, without warning, the apparitions jet into the night, and electronics spring to life.

The fascinating topic of vehicular malfunction in conjunction with UFO sightings is worthy of its own book. It is difficult pinpointing exactly when this trend emerged: a motorcycle headlamp struggled in a 1909 sighting; a few vague accounts come from the 1940s; an ominous "air blimp" silenced an automobile radio in 1952. It wasn't until the 1954 French flap and 1957 Levelland, Texas sightings that car trouble became commonplace.[2993] The *earliest* incidents actually come not from witnesses, but science-fiction authors. Wrote Martin Kottmeyer:

> In March 1906, a story appears in *Argosy* by one Guy Chase Hazzard that exploits the ancient fears of comets by suggesting that comets might be able to somehow make the world's electricity disappear. 'Forty-One Nights of Mystery' describes the chaos of civilization collapsing as lights fail and motors stop running. Mobs riot as all manifestations of electricity cease. When the comet recedes, electricity returns and civilization re-builds.
>
> A couple years later, a story called 'The Planet Juggler' by J. George Frederick appears in the November 1908 [issue] of *All-Story* that combines extraterrestrial menace with superior invention. A rogue scientist from Canopus threatens to

> drop the earth into the sun if our supply of gold isn't sent to him. To prove he means business he first cuts off electricity in the area of New York, then he nudges the earth from its orbit.[2994]

Skeptics see this precedent as evidence that UFOs are more folklore than fact. Readers will instead see the fingerprints of Greg Bishop's Co-Creation Theory, the idea that cultural expectations are subsumed by these phenomena, even when originating in fiction. A feature appears in popular culture, then finds its way into a handful of accounts before "snowballing" into a hallmark of the UFO phenomenon.

However, this trope may have begun in ghost stories. Flickering lights and malfunctioning electronics are part-and-parcel for hauntings, perhaps a natural extension of superstitions surrounding candles and the spirit world.

Claude Lecouteux chronicles multiple beliefs throughout parts of Europe. Flickering candles might signal a ghost's presence. Candles extinguishing on their own are "a herald of death." "If the candle on the altar goes out of its own accord, the preacher will die within the year," and if "candles on one side of a married couple are casting a weaker light, the member of the couple on that side will die first" in Prussia.[2995] These anxieties would have naturally been grafted upon electric lighting.

Though less-celebrated in parapsychology than Ufology, the rise of the automobile generated numerous stories of car malfunctions in the presence of spirits.

- "The Ghost Girl of Fifth Street Hill," a phantom hitchhiker from West Virginia, vanishes into smoke before any Good Samaritan reaches her destination. In a 1958 account, a man ignoring the specter soon found "his engine died, the lights went out, and the radio stopped playing. He got out and saw the girl run back down the hill. As she did, his car came back to life."[2996]

- Between Industry and Ohioville, Pennsylvania, a stretch of road nicknamed "Mystery Mile" (Kelley Road) displays malevolent supernatural forces which agitate animals and cause car trouble, variously attributed to occult rituals or a Native American curse. Whatever the cause, stalls are frequent along the road.

  "Legend trippers have experienced car problems there for years," wrote Thomas White and Tony Lavorgne. "It is said that if you stop your car to investigate the area, it may not start again—or at least not quickly. Once they are off Mystery Mile, the vehicles seem to operate normally."[2997]

- Irene Heath experienced paranormal car trouble near Ipswich at Four Sisters Crossroads at Stratford St. Mary on several separate occasions. The first time a tire blew inexplicably, the next her gas tank suddenly emptied. She walked from her stalled car to a service station and back, refueled, and turned on the heater. The interior, however, grew colder, and *something* was in the back seat.

  "She sensed rather than saw something hairy with uplifted arms reaching out towards her, with three fingers on each arm and talons or claws on each finger," Peter Underwood wrote. Heath managed to get home, only to have her car careen out of control weeks later, *again* at the Four Sisters Crossroads.[2998]

- A 1925 murder on Broad Mountain, Pennsylvania left lingering effects for motorists. Passing the spot where the victim's burnt body was found, drivers would hear unearthly cries, and "claimed that their cars suddenly came to a stop when

they reached the spot of the murder," wrote Marlin Bressi. "Many others claimed that their headlights began to blink in an erratic and inexplicable manner."[2999]

- A decapitated ghost haunts Faversham, Kent, at a locale known as "Diana's Walk." Despite being named after the Wild Huntress herself, the specter is believed to have been mortal, doomed to retrace the steps she took before she was murdered. In June 2011 a witness said she and family members had seen Diana some three decades earlier. "We all saw it—a figure in white that crossed the road—it was very strange, a cold atmosphere suddenly descended upon us, the car stalled, and this figure materialised."[3000]

In short, there seems little ghosts are capable of which aliens are not, and vice versa. Ghosts could be aliens. Aliens could be ghosts. All or none could be spirits. The point is that any attempt to separate these phenomena represents an artificial imposition on a reality which will never yield to our narrow, language-bound definitions.

Our perception of what lies behind UFOs must remain, like the phenomenon itself, ever-fluid. We must be unafraid to look both back to humanity's past and into our future for answers. Few have accomplished this task as elegantly as Whitley Strieber.

14

WHITLEY STRIEBER



When he crawled into bed the day after Christmas, the author was enjoying what many would call a comfortable life: happily married, a son, a successful career in New York City, several novels to his name, including two adapted into major motion pictures. Here, in his upstate cabin getaway, he could relax.

Fate had different plans, however, and he was pulled into an unknown country beyond his comprehension, a dreamland of half-remembered terror and spiritual insight. Though they had subtly snaked through his childhood, this night, December 26, 1985, the Visitors would make their presence fully known to Whitley Strieber.

The intervening decades stripped much from Strieber's life. Despite the resounding success of 1987's *Communion*, his writing career never seemed

to regain its promising trajectory. He was now "the anal probe guy," a kook who believed he had been abducted by aliens.

Yet he weathered this drastic change as gracefully as anyone, his measured demeanor conveying a strength few could hope for under such circumstances. Many people disbelieve Whitley Strieber's fantastic claims; few critics today have the temerity to suggest outright fraud. It is evident that, regardless of what began in 1985, *he* believes something otherworldly occurred, and has remained open to any and all interpretations.

Perhaps most impressively, he has allowed his views to adapt through the years. Strieber has wrestled with his experiences over the course of more than a dozen non-fiction books, and within each one a familiar refrain emerges, one his wife Anne noted early on: "This has something to do with what we call death."

No one has written more extensively, elegantly, poetically, or earnestly about the connection between alien abductions and our final journey. The sheer size of this oeuvre warrants close examination. To accomplish this succinctly, emphasis is placed upon Strieber's *interpretation* of the phenomenon rather than his countless individual *experiences,* though these naturally factor over the next several pages, as they have in previous chapters.

A shamanic narrative slowly comes into focus as one examines Strieber's non-fiction output. The titles of his primary corpus, when placed within the chronology of his life, correspond closely to the initiate's journey: *The*

Secret School, which, though written later, describes childhood election by the spirit world; *Communion*, initiation; *Transformation*, struggle and change; *Breakthrough*, realization; and *Confirmation*, acceptance of his role as shaman.

The content of these titles also loosely parallels the Five Stages of Grief, emotions generally corresponding to denial, anger, bargaining, depression, and acceptance. Through his work, Strieber grieved the death of his old life, not only his career but his worldview. Though the themes are present in his earlier work, Strieber's post-*Confirmation* output displays a marked tonal change, shifting focus from firsthand experience to broader concepts, philosophizing what the Visitors represent and our relationship to death. It seems almost as if Strieber gave himself permission to discuss loftier metaphysical topics, embracing his status as fully-vested shaman.

Enrollment in *The Secret School*

Louis Whitley Strieber was born on June 13, 1945 in San Antonio, Texas to a "fairly wealthy" family and lived a straightforward childhood characterized by the freedom of that era: roving the woods, causing low-level trouble, etc., carefree so long as he returned by dinnertime.[3001] Even then, he noted "occasional intrusions from another reality," as when he found a window mysteriously ajar while home alone. He called law enforcement, which

dispatched an officer.

> …he stopped in the front of the house, came up the walk with his gun in his hand, and he was terrified. Terrified. And he went upstairs. I followed him and he shone his flashlight out on the roof and I thought I saw someone. But I was a little boy, I could have just been scared. He said, "Well, there's nobody there," and he literally ran down stairs and drove away.
>
> The next thing I remember it was morning. My family came home at about 11 a.m. That's the sort of thing that would happen.3002

Reality ebbed and flowed with unreality in Strieber's adolescence. He found more peculiar memories dislodged by the events of 1985, explored a

dozen years later in *The Secret School.*

Like a burgeoning shaman, the spirit world had elected Strieber for a greater purpose, introducing him to a broader reality in his youth. Lessons of "the secret school" took place in 1954 during clandestine, imaginal, nocturnal meetings in the forest of the nearby Olmos Basin—a fitting setting for animist revelation—taught by a mysterious figure known as "the Sister of Mercy."

"What a school," he wrote. "Its classes were held in the theater of the unconscious and buried there, it seems, until the moment when their recovery would be essential."[3003]

The curriculum ("nine lessons of my ninth summer" held in "groups of three") emphasized the mutability of time, a lynchpin for the quasi-visionary realm in which class was held. For the Visitors, "the future is like a pool of water to their right, the past a block of ice to their left," he wrote. "The present is the force that fixes the potential that lies in the future, turning it into the ice of the past. They seek back into the past to melt, change, and recreate, then refreeze their history."

Strieber learned not only of humanity's potentially calamitous future, but also its distant past—as well as his own. Through his contact, Strieber accessed a previous incarnation spent in ancient Rome as tutor to Gaius Octavius, future emperor Caesar Augustus.[3004]

The Secret School also features Strieber's near-fatal childhood illness, first mentioned in Chapter 7. His intense fever was the culmination of "one

bout of sickness after another," perhaps caused by a leukocyte deficit. [3005]

"Usually sicknesses, dreams, and ecstasies in themselves constitute an initiation," Eliade wrote. "That is, they transform the profane, pre-'choice' individual into a technician of the sacred."[3006]

"… this particular battle with death was a very powerful one, and it changed me profoundly," Strieber admitted. "The figure of death became part of me, as things do in childhood, absorbed into the meaning of one's being." Strieber noted the shamanic parallels, that across "all human mystery traditions, the journey through death has been the essential movement that frees the soul to see into other realms." Following a slow recovery, he realized "the battle with death had changed me. I was no longer quite as fearful as I had been before. In a deep way, death had become a friend."[3007]

As for *why* the Visitors chose Strieber, there are a few hints. In his words, he had at least "two factors that can lead to abduction: unusual stress in childhood and being part of a family that includes older members who have been involved in some way."[3008]

Strieber claims involvement in *another*, earlier secret school from August-October 1952 at Randolph Air Force Base, where military personnel "utilized something called a Skinner Box" to enhance his learning abilities. Researchers speculate secret government programs like Strieber's may seek to unlock psychic abilities in children through trauma.[3009]

Like so many swept into shamanism, Strieber's relationship with the Otherworld may have also been hereditarily preordained. In 2011, Strieber recalled finding a curious photo of his father (a suspected U.S. intelligence officer) in "a North African setting," "his eyes closed and his hands folded on his chest" as he lay in "a coffin being held up by two men in soutanes and fezzes."

Only 12 years old, Strieber brought the photo to his father, who wordlessly ripped it up and flushed it down the toilet.[3010] Though not indicated elsewhere in his work, could Strieber's father have been involved in some sort of initiation himself, either a mystery school or some other organization appropriating the shamanic motif of burial alive?

For many future shamans, ecstatic experiences alone fail to sufficiently prepare them for the vocation—they must also be taught the traditions of past generations practically, in normal, lucid consciousness. With the exception of Strieber's illness, the events of *The Secret School* seem to constitute not *initiation*, but *instruction*.

"Both in North Asia and elsewhere in the world ecstatic election is usually followed by a period of instruction, during which the neophyte is duly initiated by an old shaman," wrote Eliade. "At this time the future shaman is supposed to master his mystical techniques and to learn the religious and mythological traditions of his tribe."[3011]

In some traditions, this shaman could be alive *or dead*, begging the question whether Strieber's Sister of Mercy was a Visitor, one of the human dead, or both. His first impression of her was that she was "really old—too

old—and I was concerned that she might be a skeleton… Maybe she was a dead nun who had come out of her grave." Peeking behind her wimple once, he beheld a face that looked like "as if a giant moth"—a psychopomp symbol—"was staring out at me." Like the medieval dead, the Sister of Mercy was also preoccupied with dancing: "We danced the backward dance, going past the ages, deep into time. And as we danced in 1954, we joined to our dance in Rome, and to another dance, long past… Everything is dance, she would say…."[3012]

Instruction complete, the Visitors came sporadically, delaying Strieber's full initiation for over three decades.

Communion with the ecology of souls

The Visitors appeared in Strieber's work prior to his conscious recollection.

"People can follow [your conversation with the phenomena] even pre-*Communion*," paranormal scholar David Metcalfe observed in a 2021 interview with Strieber. "They can follow that conversation that's been happening as this presence has interacted with you through fiction, through *Wolfen* and *The Hunger*, and the books prior to *Communion*… and then after that, that quest for trying to figure out questions…."[3013]

Strieber agreed the werewolves of his debut novel, 1978's *The Wolfen*, prefigured his Grey Visitors, the vampire in *The Hunger* (1981) beautiful "blond" aliens. "As it seems the phenomenon is kind of circling me and getting closer and closer to my conscious awareness, I then write a book about the dangers of nuclear war, which turns out to be a huge issue in the phenomenon," he reflected, "Then a book about the environment, which is another huge issue in this thing." Strieber's final pre-*Communion* work, *Cat Magic* (1986), was "about Wicca and the faerie-faith."[3014]

Perhaps this half-remembered connection to the Otherworld is what drew Strieber to the work of George Gurdjieff in 1970, the same year he married Anne Mattocks.[3015] Strieber found an affinity for Gurdjieff's "sensing exercise."

"To do it, you sit quietly and place your attention on your body, first one limb and then another, then your torso and head, until you are no longer in your mind, but concentrating your attention on your body," he explained. "Over the years, I had found that sensation deepened, slowly becoming something more than just awareness of the body. The exercise is simple, but also an amazingly effective way of opening the inner door to the soul."[3016]

Strieber eventually came to understand these forays into an altered state of consciousness drew the Visitors' attention, or at least rekindled their interest in him. Three years after his initiation, Strieber managed to ask why the Visitors had come for him. "We saw a glow," they replied.[3017]

"At the time, I assumed that this meant the glow of cities, signs of intelligent life," he wrote in 2017. "The real meaning was that when we place our attention on physical sensation there is an amplification of some kind that must give off a glow. That must have been what the visitors saw and why they came to me in the first place."[3018] Strieber must have been glowing brightly in late 1985. Through both independent recall and subsequent hypnotic regression, he pieced together a terrifying narrative, compiled in *Communion.*

In the middle of the night on December 26, Strieber awoke to a sound "as if a large number of people were moving rapidly around" downstairs. He sat up, listened, then inexplicably laid back down as if nothing was amiss. Within moments, the bedroom door slowly moved. A short figure, maybe 3 ½ feet tall, wearing a wide-brimmed hat atop its dark-eyed face,

peeked around the edge. This robotlike figure rushed him, and his next memory was of short creatures in blue coveralls carrying him, paralyzed, to a depression in the forest (shades of shamanic burial alive). More beings, some wearing masks, surrounded him. Among them an indifferent feminine presence watched, her gaze immortalized on the cover of *Communion*.[3019]

The same (or a similar) being has attended many of Strieber's subsequent encounters. As remarked in Chapter 3, its feminine aspect and intimate connection to Strieber evoke not only the concept of the fylgja, the Norse double, but equally conjure seductive female faeries, shamanic spirit wives, Mother Earth, and even Abrahamic figures like the Shekhinah and Blessed Virgin Mary. Later, Strieber "contemplated the implications of my contact with the great feminine image of *Communion*: to deepen my inner search and also to take personal responsibility for the condition of my soul."[3020]

Their relationship evolved significantly over the decades, always vaguely predatory, yet adopting an overtly sexual component with reverential overtones. In 2016, he described her as "the goddess of my heart, my beloved and terrible friend… Beloved, dangerous presence, an invisible tiger and an invisible saint. There was a sense of the empty menace of the cruising shark and a love richer than any I had ever known or would ever know again."[3021]

Author David Halperin brings a character from Strieber's short story "Pain" into the mix, penned mere days after the December 26 events.

"Whitley Strieber's abducting visitor appears to have been identical in his unconscious mind with his fictional [dominatrix] Janet O'Reilly, who in turn is death incarnate," he wrote. "There may be a similar allusion in the skeletal ribs of some *sheela-na-gigs*… grotesquely malformed female nudes, squatting with legs parted and hands tugging open their labia, carved onto [European] churches with the aim (perhaps) of warding off evil through their revulsion and dread. " To Halperin, the almond-shaped Grey eyes are an expression of this yonic motif.[3022]

Following his brief moment in the forest in 1985, Strieber ascended to a foul-smelling, domed room bustling with non-humans. "Tiny people were now moving around me at great speed," he wrote. "Their quickness was disturbing, and in a curious way ugly."[3023]

In total, Strieber described four types of entities: a "small robotlike being" in his bedroom; "slender and delicate" Greys standing "about five feet tall" with "mesmerizing black slanted eyes" and "an almost vestigial mouth and nose"; smaller Greys "with similarly shaped heads but round, black eyes like large buttons"; and "a large group of short, stocky ones" who were pug-nosed, wide-faced, and broad-mouthed, with gleaming eyes, wearing "dark-blue coveralls."[3024]

Strieber eventually dubbed these "kobolds" after German faeries dwelling in houses and mines. His subsequent descriptions emphasize their azure hue (we get the word "cobalt" from kobolds' dark blue appearance), bringing them into alignment with the longstanding association between the color blue and death. Blue ghosts and ghost lights are not

uncommon,[3025] as are blue psychopomps, like the Etruscan Charun and Hindu Yama. Blue also features in some descriptions of Norse revenants, the draugr.[3026]

"Often when the dwellers in the underworld are not represented as entirely dark, they have a dark band round their eyes, or the skin about their eyes and on forehead and temples is blue or black," Herzog wrote.[3027]

Calling to mind the masked faces Strieber reported, Herzog added that dark bands "sugges[t] a mask… a mask is so often a main feature of the Death-Demon, since this mask gives expression to humans' immediate feeling about those who have just died: a feeling which is associated with the apparent nearness of the dead and his extreme distance from us, the visible presence of the body and the deepest concealment of the person."[3028] Bear in mind that masks played a critical role in Roman relationships with the dead, where wax or plaster molds of the departed's faces enjoyed prominent placement in homes, reminders of the ubiquity of the past and present, the dead and living comingling.[3029]

"When they used to come to the cabin, they would come up from below —underground," Strieber said of the kobolds in a 2021 interview with podcaster Jim Harold. "They're not entirely scary. They have a sardonic, heavy-handed sense of humor… *I think that they are the ones who control the movement of souls* [author's emphasis]… I think they may be human… us in another form."[3030]

Once Strieber reached this domed room in the sky, the Visitors began their medical procedures, the most innocuous of which included an incision

on his forefinger. "I'm not gonna let you do an operation on me," he protested. "You have absolutely no right."[3031]

"We do have a right," came the Visitors' reply. "Five enormous words," Strieber reflected. "Stunning words. *We do have a right*. Who gave it to them?" (Perhaps they, like Crofton Croker asserted regarding elves, "divided among themselves the souls of men.")[3032]

The most egregious violation of Strieber's consent came in the form of what has since been immortalized as an "anal probe":

> … two of the stocky ones drew my legs apart. The next thing I knew l was being shown an enormous and extremely ugly object, gray and scaly, with a sort of network of wires on the end. It was at least a foot long, narrow, and triangular in structure. They inserted this thing into my rectum. It seemed to swarm into me as if it had a life of its own. Apparently its purpose was to take samples, possibly of fecal matter, but at the time I had the impression that I was being raped, and for the first time I felt anger.[3033]

The intervening years saw this procedure take on a salacious life of its own, an oft-referenced popular culture punchline ignorantly assumed to be a staple of alien abductions. In reality, "anal probes" figure infrequently in extraterrestrial kidnappings. Strieber has remained adamant about the experience, however, claiming it caused medical ailments for decades afterward.[3034]

While not dismemberment *per se*, this pain directly reflects the torture of shamanic initiation, what Eliade deemed the "rape of the soul" in Central and Northern Asian belief.[3035] Functionally speaking, Strieber's anal probe was a form of sexual assault, which is orders of magnitude more common in alien abductions than gathering "fecal samples." While uncouth to modern sensibilities, the anus also serves as a gateway to the soul in some mythologies: the devious Japanese *kappa*, a chelonian water spirit, seeks victims' *shirikodama*, a "soul ball" found in the anus which, when removed, kills it owner.[3036]

Further shamanic/animist motifs in Strieber's abduction came in the form of apocalyptic images ("the world blowing up") and ego death: "'Whitley' ceased to exist. What was left was a body in a state of raw fear so great that it swept about me like a thick, suffocating curtain, turning paralysis into a condition that seemed close to death."[3037]

Reading *The Communion Letters*

"Abruptly, my memories end," Strieber wrote of the following morning. "There isn't even blackness, just morning. I had no further recollection of the incident." Like a newly-minted shaman in the aftermath of their initiation, Strieber experienced discomfort and illness. His "disposition got worse. I became mercurial, frantic with excitement about some idea one moment, in despair the next." He also battled "a distinct sense of unease and a very improbable but intense memory of seeing a barn owl staring at me through the window sometime during the night."[3038]

At the time, Strieber attributed this to a screen memory. Given the reputation of owls as psychopomps, this seems less certain today. Nor was the owl the only psychopomp animal Strieber encountered during his lifetime of numinous experiences: as a youth, he recalled "hearing a wolf howling and seeing one on the roadside. Even as I told that story I remember being a little confused. Since then it has lingered, the image of the wolf in the clearing and the sound of its voice echoing through the night."[3039]

These psychopomps represent but one aspect of death which surfaced during this period. "I recalled seeing a familiar face during the initial stages of the experience—a school friend who had joined the Central Intelligence Agency," he later wrote. "But when I tried to look him up, I was appalled and confused to discover that he had died months before the night in

question… I was among those who had seen a dead man with the aliens. There was nothing ghostly about him at all."[3040]

Under hypnosis with Budd Hopkins, Strieber also recovered a troubling image of his son Andrew sitting amidst "a beautiful, green expanse." This "relaxing" vision morphed into one of concern as he realized "the park represents death, and he's there because he's dead." (Thankfully, Andrew did not pass away.)[3041]

Despite all its science-fiction trappings, Strieber immediately realized his experience bore the fingerprints of something much more complex than mere kidnapping by flying saucers. He carefully avoided identifying his abductors as extraterrestrials, instead coining the term "the Visitors."

> Certainly the long tradition of [faerie] lore suggested that something had been with us for far more than the forty or fifty years since the phenomenon took on its present appearance... I thought perhaps the visitors were somehow trying to hide themselves in our folklore.
>
> Another thought was that the visitors might really be our own dead. Maybe we were a larval form, and the adults of our species were as incomprehensible to us, as totally unimaginable, as the butterfly must be to the caterpillar. Perhaps the dead had been having their own technological revolution, and were learning to break through the limits of their bourne.[3042]

Alongside these possibilities, Strieber speculated the Visitors represented gods springing from the Collective Unconscious, or some kind of internal

awakening. To this day, Strieber entertains a hodgepodge of these hypotheses, each component's prominence ebbing and flowing through his writing as his thinking continues to change.

Compelled to share these feelings with the world, Strieber took a drastic step away from novels to author not only a work of non-fiction, but an autobiographical one at that. In 1987, he presented his manuscript for *Body Terror* to Anne. She didn't object until that evening when *in her sleep,* in a semi-channeled "basso profundo voice," she proclaimed: "The book must not frighten people. You should call it *Communion*, because that's what it's about."[3043]

The book was kicked from publisher to publisher before finding a home at Avon Publications. Despite its stark departure from his earlier work, *Communion* was a resounding success. For six months it remained on best-seller lists, moving 3.5 million copies during that time and, along with its follow-up *Transformation*, earning over $1 million within a year. With this success came equal amounts of scorn and mockery from predictable segments of society—there were even baseless accusations that Strieber had become a "UFO cultist." [3044]

More beneficially, *Communion* also drew the attention of experiencers, reassuring them that they were *not* crazy, as friends and family may have suggested, but instead experiencing a fundamental aspect of human existence. A tsunami of 200,000 letters from experiencers overwhelmed Anne and Whitley, which the couple selectively compiled in 1997's *The*

Communion Letters (today, the correspondence is housed in Fondren Library's Archives of the Impossible at Houston's Rice University). [3045]

Strieber recalled the moment of his wife's most profound insight:

> Anne was reading our mountains of letters as fast as she could, and making notes of similarities as she went along... I can recall going into her office and seeing on the wall a yellow sheet with a list of typical observations in one column and numbers in another. I noticed that she had written at the top of the sheet, "This has something to do with what we call death."[3046]

Journeys through *Transformation*

"I have been deep into the dark and found extraordinary things there," read the opening lines of *Transformation*. "The visitors did not go away when I finished *Communion*. On the contrary, they came rushing into my life and would not stop."[3047]

Hot on the heels of *Communion*, Strieber released a sequel of sorts in 1988 full of additional insights and experiences. While nothing quite matches the shock of its predecessor, the book presents its own brand of existential horror—not *Communion*'s fear of the unknown encroaching into one's life, but more the overwhelming profundity of realizing how expansive reality can become, and one's smallness when held in juxtaposition.

"Increasingly I felt as if I were entering a struggle that might be even more than life-or-death," he mused. "It might be a struggle for my soul, my essence, or whatever part of me might have reference to the eternal. There are worse things than death, I suspected. And I was beginning to get the distinct impression that one of them had taken an interest in me."[3048]

At this point in his life, Strieber was still unsure as to exactly how malevolent the Visitors could be. A theme of soul consumption runs through *Breakthrough*. Like the Egyptian soul-devourer Ammit, Strieber

wondered at numerous points whether his "goblinlike" Visitors were "soul-eaters" or "soul predators." Above all, "they appeared to be involved with what happens to man after death"… perhaps stewards of reincarnation.[3049]

"The visitors have said, 'We recycle souls,' and—of the earth—that 'this is a school,'" he wrote. "It may be exactly that—a place where souls are growing and evolving toward some form that we can scarcely begin to imagine.[3050]

These suspicions about the Visitors' relationship to death were rendered explicit during the doldrum between *Communion*'s completion and landing a publisher. On May 30, 1986, "a small being dressed in white"—perhaps his female handler—entered Strieber's room and, staring at him with "light-blue eyes," intoned in a singsong voice, "I want to talk to you about your death."[3051]

The being warned Strieber that his "metabolism [had] been altered," and he could no longer eat sweets. Despite the prediction's absurdity, Anne soon after dreamt her husband ate a chocolate bar and "just dropped dead." He ceased this guilty pleasure forthwith.[3052]

The being also warned Strieber he would "take one of two journeys on behalf of [his] mother." One, if taken, would end in death, the other life. He didn't know what to make of this prediction until, *en route* to console his mother over the loss of his grandmother, Strieber became convinced his airplane was doomed to crash. He was wracked by all-consuming panic… then "just changed. One moment I was a miserable, terrified little man, and the next there was this wonderful sense of freedom."[3053]

> Gone was my dread. Now there was a preciseness to death, a sense of absolute correctness about it. It did not belong to the dark at all. I belonged to the dark. Death was a part of the grace of nature.
>
> My fear was gone. I accepted my situation. I was ready.3054

The flight attendant then announced their uneventful descent. "A changed man, a profoundly changed man, left that airplane," he wrote. "I had been brought face-to-face with death... How will death feel? What will I do? How will I be as I die? I know how I will be. I have already died a little."[3055] Strieber had fully died to death.

Though he didn't articulate as much, there is a marked similarity between Strieber's experience and those undergoing NDEs in the absence of trauma—recall the "near-near-death experiences" mentioned in Chapter 1. For instance, P.M.H. Atwater investigated an NDE from a man who, while standing by a roadside, was *nearly* (but *not*) struck by a car, yet nonetheless reported an out-of-body experience and life review. "His perception of what seemed to be his fate apparently initiated or was somehow important in jump-starting [a] near-death scenario complete with life-changing effects," Atwater concluded.[3056]

While their potential for negativity remains in his writing through the present day, by the end of *Transformation* Strieber came to see the Visitors

in a manner more consistent with ancient views of spirits, or even faeries: capricious, capable of benevolence or malice, yet ever a catalyst for change.

"When I challenged my own fear of them they responded by taking me on a journey deep into my unconscious terrors," he wrote. "They made me face death, face them, face my weaknesses…."[3057]

Concluding *Transformation*, Strieber asserted that the Visitors communicate in theatrical symbolism; can easily enter our minds; are ancient, or at least endeavor to appear as such; and taught him that human beings possess a separable soul, which they can affect and draw out at will. (Strieber began experiencing OBEs in earnest during this period, bilocating and allegedly appearing to other individuals as a doppelgänger.)[3058] He added that the Visitors—at least sometimes—embody a definite physicality.[3059]

This last point adds a curious wrinkle to Strieber's mythology. On one occasion with the Visitors he remembered seeing a drawer full of "stacks of bodies like their own," lifeless, wrapped in transparent film. He concluded that "they use bodies to enter our reality as we use scuba gear to penetrate the depths of the sea."[3060] If this ability extends to human bodies already walking the Earth, it calls to mind both traditions of spirit possession and Ruth Montgomery's "walk-ins" (see Chapters 5 and 17).

"In a very real and astonishing way they may have freed themselves from bondage to their bodies, and the rule of death," Strieber mused.

There is the tacit implication, therefore, that the Visitors' true nature lies in another dimension, perhaps the ecology of souls itself.[3061]

The implant

Following *Transformation*, Strieber refocused on fiction for several years. It was during this period (May 1989, to be precise, though typos place it several years later) that he received his implant.[3062]

Around 3:15 a.m. Strieber was roused by the sound of tires on his cabin's gravel driveway and the garage door creaking open… despite a locked gate barring entry to the property and an armed alarm system protecting his home. From outside, a voice calmly intoned, "Condition red." A man and woman—"perfectly human"—entered the bedroom, and he was paralyzed.[3063]

"Somebody began doing something to my ear, and all the while there was a voice speaking in a sort of singsong," he wrote. "I have never been able to remember what was said. The next thing I knew, I was plunged into the kind of blackness that comes when you are on the operating table and the anesthesia hits." He awoke beside Anne, who, as usual, "had not been disturbed during the night."[3064] It was not until "later in that day" that "a little bump" in his ear "began to hurt."[3065]

Despite Anne's objections, Strieber later tried having this implant removed, to no avail. During surgery the object retreated to his earlobe, afterward moving back to the top of his ear. Only a fragment was recovered. Upon analysis, Dr. William Mallow of San Antonio's Southwest

Research Institute allegedly claimed it consisted of metal with "proteinaceous cilia attached to it." [3066]

One time in Mallow's office "the thing turned itself on," causing Strieber's ear to flare red, a buzzing sensation filling his head. He was rushed into a signals acquisition lab where a transmission was detected but never disclosed.[3067]

Strieber recently claimed a pair of men approached him out of a crowd at a San Antonio library event nearly 30 years later, telling him, "Mr. Strieber, we were involved in the signals acquisition at Southwest, and we just want to tell you it's the strangest signal that we've ever acquired, and it is still under study to this day." They then "turned around and rushed out."[3068]

As explored shortly, this device—as well as its surprising inventor—greatly influenced Strieber in recent years.

Breakthrough* to *Confirmation

"… the more the experience directed itself toward the soul, the more intellectually helpless I felt," Strieber wrote in 1995's *Breakthrough*. "The soul is a dead concept in Western science and philosophy, an archaic leftover from the middle ages. Of course, most of us still believe in the soul, but what does that matter when thought has failed to meaningfully address its existence for two hundred years? I don't know how to think in terms of the soul. Science offers me no empowerments. Philosophy is lost in a maze of its own making."[3069]

If not completely alleviated, the terror of Strieber's earlier work is at least mitigated in *Breakthrough*. "Many things have fallen away, many fears," he wrote. While there are allusions to the Visitors' darker motives—including Charles Fort's idea that human beings are "property" of some higher intelligence, or that the Visitors wish to consume our souls—the book's overall tenor leans positive.[3070]

Strieber reasserted the possibility that our existence represents "a school for souls, a sort of masterpiece of illusion in which we take the lessons that carve our beings." Properly integrated, lessons learned on Earth allow humans to "so radically shift their physical perspective that they can actually reach the world of the soul and gain its powers while they are alive." Some reach these paths independently, while others need intervention from the Visitors.[3071]

"One thing that had become clear was that they didn't want slaves or genes or souls or anything remotely like that, or they would have taken them," he argued. "You don't get wooed by somebody who is attacking you, and we were being very carefully wooed. The visitors were here to become a couple with us, and they were acting much more like an impatient, imperfect, and overeager lover would act than like a predator."[3072]

Strieber continued unpacking the Visitors' connection to death, noting both the incidence of dead loved ones seen during alien abductions and the beings' appearance during NDEs. People "see the visitors during brushes with death," he wrote, listing snippets from correspondents: "'I died on that hospital bed, and when I did I saw a thing like on the cover of your book.' 'She said she was my mother, and told me that I had to go back, that I could not yet enter the light.' 'They were in a white tunnel with me.' 'I saw your visitors after a near-death experience. They were glad to see me, and we all got upset when I had to go back.'"[3073] (In this final experience, note the resemblance to the overjoyed elves greeting Terence McKenna upon his arrival into the DMT realm.)

Though not attended by trauma, Strieber himself was granted a glimpse into the ecology of souls in late January 1993. On the cusp of wakefulness he rushed skyward into a wild array of stars and colors and, looking back, beheld the Earth awash in the light of multitudinous souls lying in stark contrast to the "terrible" darkness ahead. It was "a dark from beyond the

edge of the universe. By contrast, the clusters of stars were far warmer and more alive—a real joy to see—than normal stars."[3074] He continued:

> Here, the light was alive. The glow around me was composed of conscious beings in mass and multitude, and I saw that surrounding earth is a huge, organic presence that represents the final, superconscious, and ecstatic limit of life. This was why we exist. It is where we go when we die, and it contains not just humanity, but an entire mirror of every single thing that has ever been touched by the transformative power of death.
>
> …I had entered the world of the dead…
>
> In the end, this is where I would take my flawed soul, to this glory.[3075]

As with others who have contacted the numinous, Strieber's proximity to the Otherworld is contagious. In late 1988, filmmakers hoping to catch a glimpse of the Visitors took up residence in Strieber's cabin, necessity dictating he spend the night camping close by with his son in "the stone circle I had built on the site of my first encounter." Around 6:00 a.m. he awoke and, glancing towards the cabin, saw "a small, hooded figure made of silver mist" move from the deck into the forest. (Strieber later discovered this trajectory intersected the Native American burial site on his property.)[3076] Going inside, one of the filmmakers reported he had been roused by several thumps on the couch where he slept.[3077]

"Against the gray light coming in a nearby window, he had seen a small figure, which had at first seemed to be a child," he reported. It had "big, black eyes" and a "very narrow face." Suddenly, it "transformed into an apparition with the head of an eagle or falcon."[3078]

The significance of birds as psychopomps and soul avatars need not be reiterated. Strieber later claimed a similar incident occurred while the cabin was being built. A carpenter, fatigued and hesitant to leave his valuable tools in the unlocked construction site, decided instead to overnight in the unfinished home. He awoke to a short, squat being watching him. Intense fear washed over him, whereupon the entity transformed "before his eyes into a bird of paradise and then disappeared."[3079]

Among the filmmakers in 1988 were a handful of Strieber's friends, including Lorie Barnes who, in the previous chapter, was informed she would "one day look just like" the kobolds who visited her during pregnancy. Barnes claimed to have been walking the road near Strieber's cabin when she saw her brother, missing for 17 years and declared dead eight years prior. He wore "a kind of white robe or toga" tied about the waist with a rope, not having aged a day. The apparition appeared "quite solid," with only a hint of translucence.[3080]

"I was shocked," she told Strieber. "I said, 'Jonathan, what are you doing here?' And he said, 'I've just come to tell you, sis, you're in the right place.' I couldn't figure out what he meant by that."[3081] He disappeared, and Barnes returned to the cabin shaken. Hearing this story, Anne sagely

predicted, "'The Visitors will be here tonight'… and that's what happened."[3082]

Late 1994 was trying for Strieber. His mother passed away October 3. Death threats and turbulent finances prompted a return to San Antonio from New York. Throughout this unstable, liminal period his "meditations got more and more intense," manifesting presences which touched his shoulders and his cheek.[3083]

The night before their move Strieber, distraught, asked the Visitors to divulge their true form, their "final reality." Nothing happened, and he went to bed. Shortly, a glow appeared outside, and Strieber rushed to the window to behold "one of the most beautiful things I have ever witnessed. An enormous ball of light floated majestically away from the house and out over the front lawn," throwing off "hundreds of narrow shafts of light" which, as they lit his skin, filled him with a prickling sensation. It was "an absolutely shocking sense of intimacy with another person."[3084]

"This was the person I had been meditating with all these years," not a Visitor or a Christ or a Buddha, but "an ordinary person." "I felt reasonably sure that I had seen beyond the boundaries of this life, and what I had seen implied the existence of human beings in very different states from the physical… On that night, I saw a dead man in his true state, shining with a living light."[3085]

1998's *Confirmation*—in which Strieber discussed his implant in-depth for the first time—continued his focus on soulcraft, drawing connections between the timing of alien abductions and life transitions during predawn

hours, "the time when sleep is deepest, when most deaths and births occur, when our dreams are at their most powerful." Strieber also addressed the similarity between light orbs and concepts of the soul, the topic of our next chapter.[3086]

"Hundreds of [UFO] witnesses report, for example, that they see balls of light that seem to have conscious direction," he explained. "They are a commonplace of the experience that links it to other visitation imagery. In many cultures, they are associated with the souls of the dead… there is something about the close encounter experience that is deeply involved with death and the dead."[3087]

Strieber expressed frustration that UFO contact, if taken seriously, could lead us to "the borderland between life and death," yet is so often trivialized. This ignorance perpetuates our destructive trajectory. Were our culture to treat these encounters respectfully, we might confront our imperfections and find a way to allow our souls to lead our corporeal selves, rather than vice versa.[3088]

The Visitors, Strieber asserts, seem to have already accomplished this, their souls "more independent from the body, from the material. While they do have a body, their body, the material aspect of it, is no longer so dominant… we must ask ourselves which side is dominant, what value, what influence the material side has for them. Perhaps extraterrestrials are beings whose material side only follows the spiritual side."[3089]

Strieber holds out hope that the scientific establishment may yet recognize the profundity of such experiences. "In the past, as scientific

understanding has increased, the borders of what is considered to be supernatural have been pushed farther and farther back," he wrote. "What was witchcraft in 1650 was science in 1750, and, if the soul exists, I suspect that the same process will eventually include it within the boundaries of the known. So our science may someday also include a technology of the soul, and the curtain between the worlds of the living and the dead will finally be raised."[3090]

The Master of *The Key*

Confirmation represented an almost imperceptible shift in Strieber's writing about the Visitors. References to theologians and spiritual teachers crept into the text alongside the rote UFO encounters populating past volumes. One could argue that, over a dozen years after contact at the cabin, Strieber finally felt comfortable enough to unabashedly engage the metaphysical nature of the Visitors.

Embracing his shamanic role, Strieber began advocating for both personal and global transformation through spiritual discipline. Though it is wholly unfair to characterize him as a cult leader—he exhibits none of their financial motives, narcissism, or authoritarian tendencies, and there is no organized infrastructure surrounding his teaching—the accusation would be more accurate at this phase of Strieber's career, rather than in the post-*Communion* years.

This spiritual emphasis is no more apparent than in 2001's controversial *The Key*, in which Strieber transcribed a lengthy conversation with a diminutive being in a Toronto hotel room. He described the presence, which visited him in the middle of the night during *Confirmation*'s book tour, as having "deep set" eyes and a wizened complexion. It wore a tunic and, despite a certain "alienness," appeared human. Over the course of their dialogue, Strieber learned this being, the Master of the Key, was

dead[3091]—perhaps the "dead man in his true state" who had long attended his meditations.[3092]

The Key reads exactly like a channeled work. The Master of the Key himself is a stark departure from Strieber's Visitors and kobolds, more closely resembling a wizened faerie or one of Theosophy's Ascended Masters.

"H. P. Blavatsky was the first person to introduce the concept of the Mahatmas (also called adepts or Masters) to the West," wrote Pablo D. Sender. "...a new Ascended Master would not die but would take the body up with him... The fact that the Mahatmas retain their bodies is of great importance… But the physical body is where the Masters' evolutionary development is the least apparent. It is said that if we see an adept on the physical plane, we may not even recognize him as anything more than a good and wise man."[3093] In accordance with these Theosophic principles, Strieber emphasized the Master's physicality, going so far as to recall his pungent odor.[3094]

The Key is replete with spiritual messages, much of it difficult to follow. As noted in Chapter 6, the Master of the Key declared meditation a crucial component in building an "afterlife vehicle," a "radiant body" of "conscious energy" to scout the pathways of death in preparation for our final journey. Those with lucid control over their radiant bodies can not only navigate the afterlife, but perform miracles among the living. According to the Master of the Key, one such figure was Jesus Christ, who allegedly appeared many times on Earth yet simultaneously dwells within us.[3095]

"The great error of the present is the way your religions externalize Christ," he chided. "You are always calling upon Christ. But you had better call on your own heart, for it is in your heart that his mansion is founded."[3096]

"The living and the dead share the same world," he continued. "Their lives and beings are intertwined with yours. They see all that passes here, but can only affect it indirectly, if they can make themselves heard in the minds of the living." The dead might "appear as innocent children," awaiting the appearance of a body into which they may reincarnate. "Some are aware enough of radiant being to try to ascend, but they always drift back, or if they become lost, are returned to earth."[3097]

Themes of soul collection rear their head in *The Key*. "Human souls have been harvested [for Otherworld slavery] for thousands of years… by whomsoever wishes to and can. Until mankind establishes his own place in the cosmos, there will always be those who use you like cattle."[3098]

Strieber naturally asked the Master of the Key about the Visitors, and was told they enforce Earth's perpetual reincarnation cycle. "When you see UFOs, you see prison guards," he answered. "They also act within your society to confuse you about your own past, and to prevent progress in areas such as propulsion, which might enable you to spread into the heavens. This is all done to prevent you from escaping." Incongruously, alien abductions are for humanity's well-being, brutal but not unkind. "The kitten is terrified of the veterinarian. To subdue the little creature, violence is unavoidable."[3099]

This is but the briefest sketch of the messages Strieber received. Concluding their conversation, the Master of the Key instructed Strieber to consume "a white liquid that he'd had in one of the glasses from the bathroom." No residue could be found in the glass the following morning. Strieber later called this amnesia-inducing beverage "the Milk of Nepenthe" (lethe), used to dampen "the anguish of remembering the pleasures" of another realm.[3100]

"Listening to the Master appears to have broken a barrier in me," Strieber reflected. "I began to see the dead quite frequently and would find myself communicating with them." In one example, he perceived Anne's long-forgotten aunt Marcelle, of whom she had never spoken, alongside her father. In another, an Australian friend and medium riding in their car claimed an old friend whom he had never mentioned, dead since the early 1970s, accompanied them on the ride.[3101]

The Key proved controversial not only for its overtly spiritual tone, but because a subsequent 2011 edition contained significant deviations from the original printing. In defense, Strieber claimed the 2001 manuscript was "secretly censored by unknown parties. Crucial changes were made, that had the effect of obscuring and diminishing the message of the book."[3102]

2011 also saw the release of *Solving the Communion Enigma*, which presented a Whitley Strieber fully skeptical of the Extraterrestrial Hypothesis. Chief among his arguments were associations between the Visitors and the dead. The book also explicitly articulates a theory coloring Strieber's views to this day, that the dead represent a core element of UFO

contact. "… the entire enterprise of close encounter is about dropping the veil between those who are in physical form and those who the Master said are in 'radiant' form"—i.e. the dead.[3103]

After *Solving the Communion Enigma*, Strieber took another hiatus from Visitor-centric books. With the exception of *The Path*, focused on Tarot, his next phase of non-fiction focused on his relationship with Anne.

Anne's *Miraculous Journey*

On October 16, 2004 a massive brain hemorrhage brought Anne Strieber to the brink of death. "I had a near-death experience, but not one that involved crystal cities and angels," she recalled after her six weeks in hospital. "No, I was taken to the World of the Dead by my dead Siamese cat, who seemed disgusted by the fact that I couldn't find my way to the place myself."[3104]

The Siamese was their son's childhood pet Coe, gone several years. "I sensed that my visitor's true identity was different," she remembered. "Coe was certainly there, but the world of the dead does not work like the world of the living. I had a powerful feeling that I was in the presence of my mother…." Though not traditionally a psychopomp, this feline was well-versed in the subtleties of life and death: "I heard him say inside my head, 'These *stupid* humans—don't even know how to find the world of the dead on their own!'"[3105]

Coe escorted Anne to a busy underground space resembling a subway or bus station full of travelers lugging bags and suitcases. "I somehow knew that they weren't going to be able to go on, to catch that subway or bus until they were willing to put their packages *down*," she said. "I heard a disembodied voice that sounded a bit like a loudspeaker announcement say, 'You can keep going if you want to,' and I knew that meant I had the

choice of whether to live (and return to the world) or die (get on that bus or train to wherever)."

Reflecting later on this imagery, Whitley wrote, "… we must leave the baggage of life behind if we are to ascend wholly into timelessness."[3106] In that moment, Anne chose to return to life, embarking on a long road to recovery.[3107]

Following her hospitalization, Anne became mildly psychic, or, more accurately, she "somehow 'knew' where I was needed and what I was supposed to do in the greater scheme of things. It was a subtle change—it was never anything I could prove—but I felt 'led,' rather than being in the usual human state of floundering through life."[3108] Her husband agreed that she had somehow changed, often thinking, "What has my wife become?"[3109]

Anne "had ventured deep into the undiscovered country, returning as a modern version of the shaman, a master of travel between the worlds," he wrote years later. "And she had a message: that country is undiscovered no longer. We come and go, and we are learning the secrets of this greatest of all journeys. Our modern shamen— walkers between the worlds—are the growing legion of people like Anne, the near-death experiencers."[3110]

Like Kenneth Ring, Whitley Strieber came to view NDErs as "teachers… pointing the way to this new way of being human and this new kind of mankind—free of belief, past all the confusions of mythology, and yet more spiritually alive than ever before… Man in god. Man as god."[3111]

Sometime after her NDE, Anne also met a mysterious stranger while making copies with Whitley at an office shop. Overwhelmed by the amount of equipment, she pointed out "a rather stocky and unassuming-looking black man" deftly operating one of the machines. She said, loud enough to be heard, "If we can't figure out how to use the machine, we can ask this gentleman who is clearly doing just fine."[3112]

The man spun on his heel, pointed at Whitley, and said, "You are very lucky, treasure this woman. She will live a long time and you will both someday taste the water and the wine." "Then he left," Anne recalled. "I realized that I had met an angel."[3113]

Nine years later, tragedy struck again. An examination following a seizure revealed Anne had multiple terminal brain tumors. The following year, she and Whitley published an account of their voyage through her illness entitled *Miraculous Journey,* an introspective meditation on life, death, gratitude, and acceptance. "This is a story not only of survival against impossible odds," she wrote, "but of surrender to even more impossible odds and the letting go of forgiveness."[3114]

Long live *The Afterlife Revolution*

Anne Strieber passed away on August 11, 2015—but according to her husband, she is far from gone. Strieber claims contact with his wife began "within hours of her passing." The night she died, Whitley met Anne in an out-of-body state.

> We soared out into a region that seemed almost like it was under water. Shadowy enormous forms loomed around us, watching us alertly. Then we broke into the sweetest light I have ever known, moving faster and faster, farther and farther. Anne was laughing a bit at my persistence, but I would not go away —until, finally, I was caught short by the cord that connects the soul to the body. She rose away from me, gazing back, smiling, and then was gone.[3115]

Friends like Belle Fuller and Clare Henry would call Strieber claiming contact with the departed: "[I] heard Anne's voice in [my] ear say, 'Tell Whitley I'm all right.'" Anne's communication eventually grew into a daily occurrence both subtle and overt, appearing in synchronicities, dreams, and even audible manifestations.[3116]

"Not a day passes that my body is not startled anew by her absence," Strieber wrote. "And yet my mind knows that she's here. Right now, this moment. Here. I hear her speak to me, see various manifestations, get

convincing reports from others that are so varied and consistent that they qualify as personal knowledge."[3117]

Whitley Strieber, no stranger to introspection, became even more contemplative in his writing, and in 2017 released *The Afterlife Revolution*, listing Anne as co-author. At this juncture, he expressed confusion as to whether he was interacting with "Anne as a separate, nonphysical entity, or the Anne who is part of my own soul… I am accepting that it is probably part of both."[3118]

As of the book's publication, Anne only physically appeared to Strieber once after her death. ("On that occasion, when she finished speaking to me in a particularly intense way, full of the speed and spontaneity of physical conversation, I glimpsed a small light go flashing away out of our apartment.") Instead, contact primarily came through Strieber's "heart and mind," facilitated by Gurdjieff's sensing exercise.[3119]

Many of the messages imparted by Strieber's late wife align with Gurdjieff's notions of ego, which we lose upon transition. "As I left my body, 'Anne' became a memory," she told her husband. "You're you, but also everybody. It's really a warm, joyous moment… Ego dies, not self… I'm not Anne anymore, I'm me. But I'll always be Anne for you, Whitley." She wished not to devalue ego—it is our "key social tool"—but rather to convey its impermanence, and how the ego can cloud happiness.[3120]

Anne claimed the key to existence was to "have joy… When you ascend, you ascend into laughter. You can't understand the Big Bang unless you understand it as an explosion of happiness. The instant that consciousness

realized that it was alone, it laughed with surprise. That was the beginning of everything, soul laughter."[3121] Strieber reflected:

> Ego can laugh, but not like that. This is because ego can never experience the innocence of objective love and happiness...
>
> The place to start on this sweet work of letting ego go is to take ourselves more lightly. Ego cannot observe itself objectively. It cannot understand itself or hold a mirror up to itself. But the soul can understand it, for the soul was present at its creation and has observed it throughout all of the body's life…
>
> But to realize this, we must first go beyond the conventional definition of "soul." If we think of it at all, we might vaguely imagine an echo of what we can see of ourselves, that is to say, ego. I have even heard people speak of "afterlife ego" and "soul ego." But soul is not ego and it isn't similar to ego. Truly, our souls are undiscovered countries. They at once lie within us and live in all being and all time, knots of consciousness that have a definite sense of self, a definition that is all their own, but equally a sense of conscious infinity.[3122]

Anne sparked other insights. Following their conversations, Strieber perceived modern mankind's denial of its immortality as a sort of "soul-blindness," which in turn degrades our relationship with the dead: "It looks as if you're intentionally ignoring us," Anne complained. "The first time you ignored me, I was upset. Then I got mad at you. I yelled. You acted as if I didn't exist. It was weird and confusing."

Our souls, removed from the ecology in which they once thrived, atrophy in zoos made of Materialist cages. To liberate ourselves, we must reintegrate with our ancestors. "… a species is not whole unless a relationship between the living and the dead is an ordinary part of life," Strieber concluded.[3123] This certainly sounds like a call back to ancient belief systems like animism and shamanism which, while on the rise in Western culture, remain relegated to its fringe. Instead, our stodginess endures—social etiquette still demands conversations refrain from the topics of sex, death, religion, and politics (we might well add "UFOs" to the mix, but, as this work illustrates, such an addition might be redundant).

Strieber of course asked his wife about the Visitors. They are "inward beings" who "live in reality," she explained, as opposed to mankind, which only dwells "on the surface." He also learned the Visitors play a critical role in reaffirming our relationship to the other side, "the enrichment of souls on both sides of the bridge."[3124] According to Anne:

> The ones you and I call the visitors are practiced at moving between densities. When they tunnel down into your density, the human dead can follow them, or they can be brought. This is being done to make those of you in the physical aware that [the dead] still exist. It's part of the fight against soul blindness and it's also the foundation of bridge building.[3125]

Bridge building—another potent shamanic metaphor tied to the afterlife. "The Gāthās make three references to this crossing of the Činvat bridge,"

Eliade wrote of Zoroastrianism. "In the first two passages Zarathustra… refers to himself as a psychopomp. Those who have been united to him in ecstasy will cross the bridge with ease; the impious, his enemies, will be 'For all time... dwellers in... the House of the Lie.' The bridge, then, is not only the way for the dead; in addition… it is the road of ecstatics."[3126]

Anne also overtly tied her husband's kobolds to the dead, claiming they were "people who've done wrong trying to regain themselves by helping others." The process involves "embed[ding] experiences like you and the close encounter witnesses have in your DNA. Future generations will be born with this record in them. Because of this, they'll be able to take things farther. The huge increase in close encounters is about stepping up this process."[3127]

Strieber concluded, "Everything [the Visitors] have taught us comes down to this: it is the soul, not the body, that is the most important part of any living creature and especially those who are like us, not only conscious but intelligent."[3128]

When mama was moth

The most compelling anecdotes of *The Afterlife Revolution* come in the form of an unassuming insect: a large, white moth. The moth first appeared on Strieber's home security camera in 2016, accessed from hundreds of miles away while at a conference in Arkansas where he strongly felt Anne's presence. The creature had inexplicably found its way into his Los Angeles residence, flitting about the living room. Coming home, no moth nor carcass could be found. He thought nothing more of it.[3129]

Around a year later, Strieber's phone received a notification during another conference speech "literally at the moment I had said the word 'Anne'." The moth had returned. Home again, he found a carcass—though it was a different species, much smaller—and asked Anne aloud, "Do you have anything to do with this?"[3130]

In his head, yet distinctly independent, he heard, "I can talk to you."[3131]

Later appearances by the moth were verified by third parties. While speaking of it with his son Andrew, Strieber's phone received *another* notification. "I turned on the app. At the exact moment that I had said 'maybe it all has something to do with mother,' the white moth had passed in front of the camera."[3132] Whether a physical insect or a conjured denizen of some numinous realm, the moth was there—small, nocturnal, winged, a

symbol of the human soul itself (for more on moths and souls, see Chapter 3).

The moth appeared twice more in mid-February 2018 at Big Sur, California while Strieber and several others, including his friend and podcaster Jeremy Vaeni, were speaking at the famous Esalen Institute. At dinner one night "a white moth appeared and flew up and down the table" before ascending and disappearing. "Then, at the final banquet in a private dining room, a white moth flew around and landed on Jeremy Vaeni's head! (Anne loved his approach to the unknown and his show.)"[3133]

Stepping into *A New World*

To his credit, Strieber remains agnostic regarding the nature of his Visitors: "I'm still not sure what they were, frankly," he admitted in a 2021 interview.[3134] Such honesty regarding UFO contact is refreshing in a field otherwise characterized by baseless certainty.

This does not mean he lacks opinions. 2020's *A New World* saw Strieber reasserting many of his older suspicions: the Visitors are at least sometimes physical, lack a veil separating the living from the dead which also drops for us in their presence, can be both beneficial and predatory, etc. He seems resigned to their dualistic nature.

"They are not our enemies," he wrote. "They are not our friends. I am all but sure that their purpose here is to become our teachers and in return to be rewarded with the sharing that they seek."[3135] The notion of soul harvesting or consumption also appears.

"When you are physically face to face with them—which I have been on a few rare occasions—you feel not only the devastating power of their reflective eye, but also the sense of the predator," Strieber explained. "They're wary, too, I suspect because they sense our predatory nature as well. The difference is that they hunger for our souls while we think in terms of lashing out at their bodies."[3136]

Alongside these observations appear newer tidbits obliquely hinting at the Visitors' relationship to death. Some engage in what sounds alarmingly like possession, or the desire for earthly pleasures like the previous chapter's hungry ghosts. Looking back upon Strieber's work with hungry ghosts in mind, one discerns a passing resemblance between his sensing exercise and the methods by which the channeler brought Filipa to Joe Fisher's attention.

"It must be understood that contact with the visitors in all their strangeness and power is also contact with the part of humanity that is in a nonphysical form—that is to say, the dead," Strieber declared. Yet he remains firm that the Visitors—if not the kobolds, then at least the Greys—are not the human dead themselves. They have a corporeal component, but this is secondary to their spiritual nature.[3137]

"Unlike us, when they are killed, they don't lose contact with the physical world," he explained. "They can keep acting in it from the nonphysical level." For support, he cites the experience of one witness who began using a laser pointer to interact with lights in the sky. This contact culminated in a nosebleed, leaving him paranoid. "He began sleeping with a pistol in his hand. One night, he woke up to see a six-foot tall entity standing at the foot of his bed. He fired the pistol at it, causing it to disappear in a flash of light… There followed a shift into a sinister haunting…."[3138]

Strieber's fascination with the afterlife continues apace in *A New World,* at one point relating a late-night ramble in the forest where he asked the

Visitors, "What does the universe mean to you?"

"At once, my mind's eye was filled with the vivid and deeply shocking image of a coffin."[3139] One interpretation would be that existence is a slow march towards entropy, not resistant to death, but *defined* by it.

Another possibility is that the Visitors were referring to *our* reality as death. This reading finds congruence with both faerie lore—in which deaths in Fairyland mean births on Earth, and vice versa—as well as beliefs conceptualizing the afterlife as a mirror image of our own existence. Strieber seems to favor these interpretations.

> …We are not just having a close encounter with what appear to be nonhuman beings but also with ourselves.
>
> If the mirror universe is where what appear to be aliens come from, then maybe it is, just as Homer thought, also where our dead go. After her near-death experience in 2004, Anne felt that there was a sort of breathing between this and another universe, and that when we died here, our consciousness was transferred to another version of ourselves there.[3140]

In short, Whitley Strieber's experiences seem to have brought his views full-circle back into an ancient, quasi-ancestral model, where the dead live second lives in the Great Beyond.

Afterlife tech

Strieber describes his implant as more-or-less lying dormant between the mid-1990s and 2015. In September of that year "a dramatic change" occurred: "I happened to be in a room with a white wall that the sun was shining on, when I realized that I could see a neat oblong slit in my right eye. It was filled with movement. When I concentrated, I could see words racing past, but too fast to read more than the fact that they appeared to be typing."[3141]

Adamant that this was no mere hallucination—"technology was being applied"—Strieber learned to catch more of these random words as they flew by, finding they "increase[d] the richness of [his] associative process." Through subsequent blasts, the implant "revolutionized [his] writing ability,"[3142] supplying Strieber "with unique insights, such as the material on the social consequences of overpopulation, the relevance of the mystery of the fine-structure constant to understanding the nature of reality… and many, many other things."[3143]

We are again reminded of A.A. Popov's description (via Eliade) of the smallpox-ridden Avam Samoyed shaman: the spirit of a blacksmith "forged his head and taught him how to read the letters that are inside it. He changed his eyes; and that is why, when he shamanizes, he does not see with his bodily eyes but with these mystical eyes."[3144]

Wondering what intelligence lay behind this marvel, Strieber eventually asked, "'Who are you?' The reply came back at once, and slowly enough to read clearly: 'It's me, Anne.'" Her insistence to not have his implant removed came rushing back.[3145]

As startling as this message was, it paled in comparison to the revelation received on September 17, 2019. Strieber had just settled into bed after his 3:00 a.m. meditation when he heard several knocks. Unlike the poltergeist activity he normally experienced, these raps came from a pair of men at the front door. In a slightly altered state of consciousness, Strieber welcomed the figures inside. (He also recognized one of them, now in his thirties, as a child he had met in 1996—the boy and his two sisters, apparent psychics, had been in the presence of "an individual who may have been from the Department of Defense.")[3146]

These mysterious men presented a small, unremarkable, "portable typewriter" which they claimed was the source of the words Strieber had been seeing. Before their unceremonious departure, the guests asked whether or not he planned to remove his implant and outlined how it worked:

> He then explained that the words I see aren't generated outside of my mind but are drawn up from deep in my unconscious. When they are typed, they appear in the slit. Thus, they are drawn from a level of my mind that I cannot reach to the edge of consciousness where I can make use of them.

> I asked how in the world that might work without any communications device [on the typewriter]. He explained to me that it was in the typewriter's platen. So I asked again how it worked. He said that he didn't know but that it had been developed by a Dr. Raudive.[3147]

As Strieber later pieced together, they meant EVP pioneer Konstantin Raudive, first mentioned in the previous chapter. Though Raudive extensively experimented with afterlife communication technology throughout his career, he never developed anything as sophisticated as Strieber's implant. Yet it seems, in Strieber's words, "he was continuing to work on the creation of this technology *from the other side* [author's emphasis]."[3148]

Circumstantial evidence suggests Raudive's consciousness survived his 1974 demise. Voices claiming to be him frequently appear in parapsychological communication sessions to this day.[3149] Raudive even allegedly phones fellow researchers like Sarah Estep from the afterlife, leaving ominous, guttural messages on their answering machines:

> I'm as fine as a dead one can be. Dear Sarah, thank you very much for everything you did for the propagation of the Voices... You are one of the first… contacted by this meaning. Thank you very much [for] all the work you did. We are very proud and honored that we could contact you. I must interrupt now. This was the first contact. This is Konstantin Raudive speaking.[3150]

Could Raudive—like dead Egyptian farmers continuing to toil the fields of the Tuat—have designed Strieber's implant *after he died?* If true, this assertion supports the idea that the afterlife mirrors our own reality, an evolving society where technology continues to progress.

As noted in our previous chapter, similar ideas, while by no means popular, are not new. They found their way into Ufology long ago. Summarizing a May 3, 1969 lecture delivered by UFO enthusiast Sir Victor Goddard, Charles Bowen reported, "he went on to suggest that UFOs may well be the work of departed ones, in that the consciousnesses of the 'dead' can return to display, for example, the wonders of the 'new world' in which they find themselves. To take the idea even farther, could not the consciousnesses of those who had been technically skilled in this present world of ours return to demonstrate—for example—the advanced 'aerial machines' of their new world?"[3151]

Strieber now believes his implant is "connected more, I think, to the world of the afterlife than it is to aliens."[3152] *If* Strieber is correct, and *if* other alien abductees' implants are similar to his, this discovery upends decades of Ufological speculation. We are no longer dealing with extraterrestrial tracking devices, but spiritual telephones.

A life lived

It is easy, perhaps even natural, to feel the slow creep of cynicism when looking across Whitley Strieber's body of work. Few authors in the modern era have produced as fanciful a corpus. A fiction novelist who later claims interaction with the supernatural, often manifesting themes from his own work? The scenario *begs* for criticism.

And perhaps that is the most compelling counterargument. If a fabricator of lies, Strieber threw his entire career away at the height of his popularity for the short-term success of *Communion.* In that case, it was a miscalculation, as none of his later work, including his fiction, has achieved equal popularity; the career equivalent of a kamikaze attack, a guaranteed success offering little hope of survival afterward.

"Whitley Strieber was supposed to be the next Stephen King, a pop-horror writer whose golden pen produced books begging for big-screen adaptations," wrote Drew Millard in a 2019 interview. "Strieber was going places, and it was going to take something absolutely crazy for him to not get there." The claims put forth in *Communion* came with a price, "and that price is relegation to the fringes of society. Whitley Strieber understood this, but didn't care." By the final years of the millennium, Strieber "let his obsession with the paranormal torpedo his ability to be taken seriously."[3153]

We find another riposte to Strieber's critics within his pre-*Communion* novels: books like *The Wolfen* and *The Hunger* are *good.* This is not to say his non-fiction output is inferior—they have their own peculiar charm—but they are neither coherently nor straightforwardly structured. In short, should he have chosen to lie about his interactions with the Visitors, a novelist like Strieber could have easily crafted an airtight, internally-consistent yarn out of whole cloth, a harrowing sci-fi tale conforming to pop-culture extraterrestrial tropes complete with a tidy beginning, middle, and end.

That, however, is not what we are left with. Strieber, and by extension his work, remains embedded in ambiguity. There are no certainties, only connections. Assumptions are put forth, then revised. Mistakes are made. Humility is on full display. We see pain and joy, terror and beauty—we see a life lived. Whatever Whitley Strieber has learned over the past several decades, he has been gracious enough to afford us the opportunity to learn with him.

15

THE SOULCRAFT OF UFOS

OBJ



Up until now, this book has admittedly been rather dismissive of the mechanized appearance of the UFOs themselves. It is certainly true this represents the greatest weakness in an ecology of souls model, or even more basic comparisons of extraterrestrials to fae folk. Notions of afterlife technology notwithstanding, the appearance of structured craft runs contrary to most Westerner's beliefs surrounding death.

Yes, UFOs *appear* to be spaceships, and their occupants *appear* to be extraterrestrials… but they exhibit behavior and attributes at odds with mainstream models of how the universe is supposed to work. Appearances, like the UFO phenomenon itself, can be deceiving.

At the risk of overselling such a distinction, plenty of "alien abductions" occur in the absence of structured craft. Witnesses may only see lights, or simply find themselves instantly transported from their beds into another space—almost always interpreted as the interior of a flying saucer.

Simultaneously, a substantial amount of abductions *do* feature machines in the sky, and any intellectually honest opposition of the ETH must account for this. As Terence McKenna said of belief systems, "If it's real, it can take the pressure."

This obstacle is easily overcome if one adopts a Co-Creation model, or the notion that the intelligence behind UFOs, like faeries, can shapeshift. Modern witnesses don't expect to see Artemis pulling a golden chariot through the clouds, or elves commandeering stagecoaches across the sky. They would question their sanity. Perhaps there is a meta-positioned intelligence which realizes this and—to appear fantastic, yet still believable to contemporary sensibilities—taps into the treasure trove of popular culture we have created.

Other possibilities exist, however. The appearance of UFOs may *not* be illusory—they may exist exactly as they appear, and only need be *interpreted* differently.

Wheels within wheels

While not uniformly so (more on that in a moment), a plurality of UFOs are circular or spherical. Perhaps the first person to connect this to soulcraft was psychiatrist Carl Jung, who held a longstanding interest in the supernatural. In 1958, he penned *Flying Saucers: A Modern Myth of Things Seen in the Skies*, and immediately perceived a deep connection to the unconscious:

> What as a rule is seen is a body of round shape, disk-like or spherical, glowing or shining fierily in different colours, or, more seldom, a cigar-shaped or cylindrical figure of various sizes...
>
> ...The figures in a rumour can be subjected to the same principles of dream interpretation.
>
> If we apply them to the round object—whether it be a disk or a sphere—we at once get an analogy with the symbol of totality well known to all students of depth psychology, namely the mandala (Sanskrit for circle). This is not by any means a new invention, for it can be found in all epochs and in all places, always with the same meaning, and it reappears time and again, independently of tradition, in modern individuals as the "protective" or apotropaic circle, whether in the form of the prehistoric "sun wheel," or the magic circle, or the alchemical microcosm, or a modern symbol of order, which organizes and embraces the psychic totality.3154

Using the mandala as a "psychological totality symbol," Jung painted a picture of the UFO as the self, the soul exteriorized. "This symbol, by reason of its antiquity, leads us to the heavenly spheres, to Plato's 'supra-celestial place' where the 'Ideas' of all things are stored up," he mused. "Hence there would be nothing against the naïve interpretation of Ufos as 'souls.'"[3155]

Circles, and by extension UFOs, encompass the entire individual, "not the ego but the totality composed of the conscious and the unconscious," our polypsychic character reconciled and unified.[3156] Whether this soul belongs to the witness, the dead, or the entire world is inconsequential. The mandala is us, yet also everything; *we* are everything.

(We might simultaneously perceive Jung's totality as its inverse—circular UFOs resemble the numeral zero, the nothingness of death. Though undoubtedly coincidental, the Mayans represented their concept of zero, closely associated with death, as a lozenge shape approximating a UFO.)[3157]

Pragmatists find Jung's abstract pontification uncomfortable. "Though a hero and mentor to anti-ETH New Age theorists, Jung himself thought UFOs themselves (as distinct from whatever myths, dreams, and fantasies they triggered in human imaginings) are probably spacecraft from other worlds involved in quiet exploration of the earth," wrote Fortean author Jerome Clark.[3158]

It is unclear how Clark arrived at this conclusion, as Jung's public opinion was wholly ambivalent about the phenomenon's true nature. Such an inference can only be drawn by selectively quoting his writing. Similarly, armchair Ufologists on social media, having never read Jung but nonetheless confident enough to level criticism, lash out with arguments that meta

materials and radar returns point to physical, structured craft. Jung actually addressed this very issue.

> The simultaneous visual and radar sightings would in themselves be a satisfactory proof of their reality. Unfortunately, well-authenticated reports show that there are also cases where the eye sees something that does not appear on the radar screen, or where an object undoubtedly picked up by radar is not seen by the eye.[3159]

Ironically, aviators refer to radar data obtained in the absence of physical verification as "ghost echoes."[3160] Jung continued:

> If these things are real—and by all human standards it hardly seems possible to doubt this any longer—then we are left with only two hypotheses: that of their *weightlessness* on the one hand and of their *psychic nature* on the other. This is a question I for one cannot decide.[3161]

In short, Jung settled upon UFOs as either physical presences with a psychic nature, or psychic presences with a physical nature. This ambivalence disquieted him: "… where should such a thing come from? If weightlessness is a hard proposition to swallow, then the notion of a materialized psychism opens a bottomless void under our feet."[3162]

Jung's speculation builds off eons of belief symbolizing our souls, even existence itself, as circular. Funerary art from Deir el-Bahari depicts an aspect

of Osiris's soul as an aerial disc, perhaps borrowed by the Zoroastrian fravashi (Chapter 5).[3163] Such representations may also be tied to life's cyclicality, i.e. reincarnation: to Egyptians, the potter's wheel symbolized mankind's evolution.[3164] Buddhist teachers still educate the laity on our recurring travels through life, death, and rebirth (*Saṃsāra*) using a round diagram called the *bhavachakra* ("wheel of life" or "wheel of becoming"). Similar wheels, those of repeated birth (*punarjanman*) and death (*punarmrityu*) feature in Hinduism. Some strands of Rabbinic Judaism utilized comparable concepts, embodied in *gilgul* ("the wheel").[3165] We may surmise that crop circles, pisky beds, and the circular dances of faeries, the dead, and shamans likewise encode our passage through the ecology of souls.

Even in Christianity, "the wheel is a symbol of the endless force of divine power," wrote photographer and funerary art scholar Douglas Keister. It represents "eternity, continuation, and progress."[3166] Though Ufologists fondly point to Ezekiel's aerial wheel as evidence for Biblical flying saucers, a traditional interpretation of the wheel remains equally valid, if more conservative.

These beliefs, reinforced by the immortal cycle enacted daily by the discs of the sun and moon, imparted reverential status to circles and related shapes like spirals among early humans. Here we find another Jungian concept: the flying saucer as an "eye of God, gazing from heaven… laying bare the truth and pitilessly exposing every cranny of the soul."[3167] This suggests the Grey aliens' prominent eyes are more than coincidental—the entire UFO experience may revolve around ocular imagery.

As noted in Chapter 8, circles feature prominently in various traditions, including Western magic, where they protect against harmful spirits, and sacred geometry, where they reflect the "navel of the world," an *omphalos* umbilically connecting our world to the celestial poles. The circle is both unknowable and immeasurable. It is infinite, its boundary defined by *Pi*, an irrational number which neither ends nor repeats.[3168]

Ancient monuments' circular construction may reflect any of these concepts: the mandala, the navel of the world, the eye of god. Native American medicine wheels can easily be conceptualized as another totality symbol, an independently-emergent variation on the mandala, oriented towards stellar alignments to facilitate communion with the spirit world.[3169] Scandinavian art depicts similar designs, known as "sun wheels," occasionally "referred to as the 'glory of the elves.'"[3170]

Ancient earthworks often resemble divine eyes, as noted by F.W. Holiday: "Most of the disc barrows are indeed marked with a central Eye… Anciently, there was a belief that the Eye of God sped about the sky keeping watch on the earth… But what sort of phenomenon could have given rise to this extraordinary lore?" [3171]

Perhaps if only in some vague, mythopoetic way, flying saucers serve as umbilici between realms, facilitating travel to the Otherworld not through anti-gravity or warp drives, but by mere virtue of their sacred circumference —not metal ships, but mobile portals.

Yet UFOs are not uniformly circular. Chapter 8 illustrated how many ancient monuments share their design with common UFO shapes… do these

contain additional symbolic meanings tied to the cycle of birth and death, like Jung's mandala?

Shipshape ship shapes

After saucers and spheres, the most common UFO shape is that of a cigar. Jung emphasized its phallic (and therefore fertility-related) quality, a masculine symbol standing in opposition to the circle's yonic nature. Going further, he noted how these engendered aspects combine in the *coincidentia oppositorum* of the Taoist *yin-yang*, itself an icon of totality.[3172] More practically, the cigar shape viewed end-on is a circle, from its side a vaguely-rounded ellipse.

The image of a cylinder spewing flame from its rear also resembles a torch, commonly carved on Western tombstones and mausoleums. Imagining a classic "rocket ship" image—tip pointed skyward, flames below—we see a torch upside down.

"The inverted torch is a purely funerary symbol," Keister wrote. "It is unlikely that it will be found anywhere but the cemetery." In funeral iconography, an inverted torch still burning "suggests that the soul (fire) continues to exist in the next realm," while a flameless inverted torch "simply means life extinguished."[3173]

Even less-common UFO shapes hide secret meanings pertaining to life and death.

- **Cross**-shaped aerial wonders appear throughout the historic record, calling to mind the Christian symbol of resurrection.[3174]

- Another common UFO shape, the **egg**, carries obvious fertility associations.

- Though largely unknown in other regions, Brazilian witnesses have long reported notorious **box-shaped** UFOs colloquially called *chupas*, rectangular objects in the sky so named because of their rumored reputation for "sucking" blood from victims. While this seems hyperbolic, chupas have reputably afflicted observers with illness and even death. They are commonly likened to refrigerators, but their shape evokes caskets in equal measure.[3175]

- An **acorn**-shaped UFO allegedly crashed near Kecksburg, Pennsylvania on December 9, 1965.[3176] Keister wrote that, "like the egg, the acorn symbolizes prosperity and fruitfulness" when used in cemeteries, and can also represent male sexuality or "truth and the power of the spirit that is obtained by two sources: the natural world and the world that waits to be revealed."[3177]

- Nearly two years after Kecksburg, "a luminous disc" appeared near the Delaware River before shapeshifting "into something like a perfect **chrysanthemum**," leaving the witnesses in telepathic contact with its "soulless" occupants.[3178] This flower "symbolizes longevity, immortality, fullness, and completeness because its dense blooms last into the winter."[3179]

- **Horseshoes**, which ward off evil when carved upon headstones,[3180] correspond to UFOs like one appearing over Suffolk in 1983.[3181]

- **Hourglasses** on tombs—sometimes winged—symbolize the passage of time,[3182] resembling a UFO seen in 2015 "giving off a whitish blue light" in the vicinity of Nevada's infamous Area 51.[3183]

- In 2019, Roger Ward and Amy Maloney saw "a big gray **anvil** in the sky" near Elmsdale, Nova Scotia,[3184] a shape "symboliz[ing] the primordial forging of the universe" in funerary art.[3185]

"The signs appear in the heavens so that everyone shall see them," Jung wrote. "They bid each of us remember his own soul and his own wholeness, because this is the answer the West should give to the danger of mass-mindedness."[3186]

Afterlife after lights

Focusing on symbolic abstractions risks undermining the objective, physical nature many UFOs exhibit. The association between circles and souls may have been inspired by actual observations of ghost lights, a phenomenon mentioned throughout this work—after all, any spherical object seen at a distance appears as a disc. Perhaps this gave rise to the ancient association between anomalous balls of light and human souls.

In Vedic cosmology "the soul is a microcosm of the sun," Surya, an "inner light" hiding within our hearts just as the sun daily retreats beneath the world. China's first poetic anthology, *Shijing,* attributes souls a "very bright, very glorious" appearance.[3187] Japanese folklore speaks of *hitodama* ("human balls/souls") which appear as misty, pale blue or green orbs with spiraling tails.[3188]

Australian aborigines told European settlers that, while they had always seen *min min* lights—ancestral souls or spirits in the form of ghost lights either watching over witnesses or guiding them to doom[3189]—they became more frequent after colonization, perhaps as a function of the island continent's increased population.[3190]

As addressed in previous chapters, some African cultures see no contradiction in their ancestors' souls simultaneously manifesting as luminous orbs, mechanical craft, or apparent UFO occupants. They are one and the same.

Ten thousand miles away, Ardy Sixkiller Clarke spoke to an indigenous North Dakotan witness who met a "star person" reeking of sulfur. After briefly discussing horses (psychopomps again), he "dropped to the ground and turned into a ball of light" before joining other orbs to transform "into a huge craft," which flew away.[3191]

Though this shapeshifter spoke of returning to his "planet," New World belief commonly associates ghost lights with souls and spirits. Long before Ufologists whimsically posited interstellar ships, the Apache felt Texas's famous Marfa Lights were lost souls, perhaps bereaved lovers wandering the wilderness.[3192]

"The Cherokee claim luminous balls have been seen in their homeland since ancient times," Clarke wrote. "The legend has it that the lights are the wives and mothers of warriors looking for their loved ones."[3193]

Inuit shamans find themselves inhabited by "a mysterious light" illuminating secrets of both our realm and the Otherworld, "a luminous fire" described across North American practice.[3194] When disembodied—either at the point of death, or at will by a skilled medicine man—this illumination manifests as a ghost light, according to tribes like the Muscogee.[3195]

Despite the distance, such belief remains consistent further south. For the Aztecs, death was "a way for the light to show itself."[3196] "We regard the orbs as our ancestors," a Mexican Zapotec informant explained.[3197] To the Sanumá of the Brazil-Venezuela border, "invisible sphere[s]" reside in all living things, especially humans, "vital force[s]" which can outwardly manifest as tiny people.[3198]

Ancestors visit Amazonian tribes like the Shuar in the form of anomalous lights, but tribe members "do not differentiate among ancestors or UFOs or themselves," explained Clarke, befitting their animist perspective. "They perceive them as the same; all ultimately are us." As with the Zapotec, "this relationship expands to include the People from the Stars."[3199]

In Europe, orbs of light were often death omens, souls, faeries, or any combination therein (Chapters 4 and 16). The conflation of stars with souls, outlined in Chapter 10, owes a debt to this thinking. Christianity eagerly subsumed such ideas and, like other pagan beliefs, demonized ghost lights, attributing them to souls trapped in purgatory. Medieval art sometimes depicted souls of the damned in hell as fireballs or blazing spheres.[3200]

Firsthand testimony reinforced Christian soul-orb belief. Caesarius of Arles (468-542) cited a vision of the soul as "spherical in nature, like the globe of the moon." The Abbot of Morimond (c. 10th century) perceived his true self as "a glassy spherical vessel, with eyes before and behind, all-knowing and seeing everything at once," bringing to mind the 360° vision some NDErs report.[3201]

Jacques Vallee's and Chris Aubeck's *Wonders in the Sky* features numerous examples of luminous aerial phenomena in Western antiquity interpreted as human souls.[3202] Though rarely at the forefront of our day-to-day thoughts, these associations haunt the back of our minds, permeating language itself: Christ spoke of inner light, the fundamental positivity of human nature is conceptualized as a light, apotheosis results in *enlightenment*, etc.

Luminous orbs appear frequently in hauntings and (while often simply misidentified dust motes or insects) show up on camera during ghost investigations. The parapsychological literature is filled with reports of light phenomena observed at the point of death, during séances, and as part of afterlife communication. In addition to seeing beings comprised entirely of light, NDErs assume similar forms themselves, saying things like, "I might have been a little sphere," "a little ball of energy," "an energy pattern," etc.[3203]

In short, the only thing separating ghost lights from UFO lights in modern imagination is *context*. A brilliantly-lit orb bobbing down the stairs in a haunted house is a ghost; soaring above Area 51, this exact same phenomenon is interpreted as an extraterrestrial spacecraft.

Such ideas will never enjoy airtime on television or in the latest UFO documentaries, but remain fashionable in less-publicized corners of Ufology. In 2016's *The Super Natural*, Whitley Strieber and Jeffrey Kripal entertain the idea that orbs of light reported in UFO encounters are actually conscious plasmas—though they remain ambivalent as to whether these represent an unrecognized form of intelligent life or, as per the traditional interpretation, souls of the dead.

> …this notion is shockingly new: the soul as a plasmalike energy that can superpower our imaginal capacities and so generate the movies of visionary experience. Here the soul is an exotic form of energy interacting with a primate nervous system, and the symbol and the mythical narrative are the means of focusing, working with, projecting, even materializing that energy. Here the soul is a conscious star gently blazing inside a skull. Here the soul is a UFO that has landed

> for a time in a body-brain, in what Whitley suggests is "a sort of biological technology" for the soul. Hence all those "conscious machines" of the UFO literature —that, after all, is what we may well be.[3204]

A related framework, albeit more formal, forms a hypothesis by Eric Ouellet, Canadian liaison for the Parapsychological Association. Ouellet proposed UFOs, especially those of the luminous, spherical variety, might represent mass-induced psi effects. His 2015 book *Illuminations: The UFO Experience as a Parapsychological Event* makes a compelling case bringing UFOs into closer alignment with tulpas (see the Philip Experiment covered in the Introduction) and poltergeist phenomena. For instance, Ouellet astutely observes how the "falling-leaf motion" often attributed to UFOs resembles "a motion noted in a number of poltergeist events," particularly apports.[3205]

Transcendental transportation

"Flying saucers don't fly," John Keel wrote. "They merely float as 'ghosts' float."[3206] Even UFOs appearing as "structured craft" exhibit abilities otherwise attributed to souls or ghosts like shapeshifting, shrinking, invisibility, and the ability to pass through objects at will. For example, in October 1969, a French couple watched a car-sized object lift off the ground and into a forest, "passing through [the trees] as if they did not exist."[3207] UFOs seem completely devoid of mass, with some witnesses explicitly noting a lack of turbulence or air displacement in sightings.[3208]

Put another way, UFOs enjoy the same talents as their occupants. Distinctions between the two may be inconsequential, as some indigenous interpretations hold. They may all be one phenomenon masquerading as separate components.

These ghostly faculties arise whenever UFOs travel into mountains—abodes of faeries and the dead—not by traversing sci-fi airlocks, but by simply penetrating the landscape. As a boy, Ufologist Bob Teets watched what he believed to be the imminent crash of a flying saucer onto a West Virginia hillside, only to see the object pass "into the hill" in clear view without incident.[3209] We are reminded of how Eliade described shamanic initiation among the Inuit of Smith Sound: walking into the darkness, "if he is predestined to become a shaman, he will enter a cave; if not, he will bump into the cliff."[3210]

Despite never coalescing into a hypothesis *per se*, similarities between ghosts and UFOs themselves have been discussed since the beginning of Ufology. "It may be that the shape of a human spirit—if it has any shape—is that which we have come to associate with the UFOs," Arthur Constance wrote in the November 1957 issue of *Flying Saucer Review.*[3211]

Ray Palmer—a controversial figure from Ufology's earliest days, prone to credulously accepting fictions as facts—recorded "a dangerous theory" two months before his 1977 death. Palmer shared his idea with the "first" flying saucer witness, Kenneth Arnold. Drawing upon his understanding of the latest developments in physics, Palmer came to an alarming conclusion: "I think that the flying saucers are the spirits of the dead."[3212]

In addition to these rich comparisons, eyewitness testimony supports a connection between human souls and UFOs—both those appearing as craft and as luminous orbs.

- In 1912, a man traveling home to Codigoro, Italy saw a glowing orb hovering in the distant sky. The object awaited him at his destination and, believing it to be a ghost, he shouted and raised his hand to dispel the specter. A slap to his cheek sent him to the ground, leaving behind a skeletal hand mark.[3213]

- A photograph taken near England's Cumberland Fells by Owen Moran in July 1968 left the boy baffled. It showed "a pale light resembling the head of a woman in profile, wearing a bonnet or cloak tied under the chin." Moran's confusion stemmed not from the apparition, but rather from the fact that they had tried to take a photo of "a bright UFO-type light" which had been playing along the barren hills.[3214]

- In November 1978 "Jenny" was dog walking in Walsden, England when her pet alerted her to a flying saucer shrouded in green mist. When the object split into two balls of light, Jenny "felt 'joined at the soul'" with the UFO, its departure grieved like the loss of "a very best friend."[3215]

- After a climber lost her way in the Bavarian Alps, a "big ball of light" coalesced into "a tall, rather Chinese-looking gentleman." He kindly set her upon the path to safety before bowing, then "disappeared as a ball of light." According to Hilary Evans, the area was especially precarious, claiming a life one year later.[3216]

- Alien abductee Suzy Hansen claims her first memories come from "before I entered this life. I recalled having no body and instead, I was in the form of a soul, a bright ball of purple light, consciously aware of my surroundings."[3217] (Stories like Hansen's involving prebirth souls and their possible relationship to aliens are addressed in Chapter 17).

- Karin (an alien abductee John Mack studied whose story has appeared in previous chapters) recalled her transport into a UFO as "a speed-of-light movement because you are light. You are moving at light speed… You're basically tucked in a ball."[3218]

- As exemplified in the previous chapter, much of Whitley Strieber's work is characterized by orbs, which he often connects to the human soul. After her death, Anne informed him, "those orbs people record… are souls moving slow enough to be seen and detected."[3219]

Even if these *are* souls, they could still represent interstellar travel—or *astral* travel. In one instance circa 2007, Strieber was in meditation when he saw the image of a man fishing in a river on a boat. Before his reverie ended, the man looked quizzically at Strieber "as if he was seeing something that he didn't understand but also didn't see as a threat… Did he see a glowing orb, perhaps, that was me?"[3220]

Psychic Ingo Swann claimed a mysterious government agent once assigned him to remote view a set of coordinates on the far side of the moon. Swann was astounded, as his sessions seemed to show some sort of civilization (surely impossible), including various humans hard at work mining. While remote viewing is normally a one-way affair, the beings allegedly *saw* Swann, gesturing in his direction.[3221]

If they could indeed see his consciousness—his soul—how did Swann appear to them? As a ghost? A light? A flying saucer? We might ask ourselves how we might perceive extraterrestrials, astrally remote viewing Earth from their own planet.

This possibility appeared at least as early as a 1962 book by Dr. John Manas. In *Flying Saucers and Space Men: A Scientific and Metaphysical Dissertation in Interplanetary Travelling*, Manas wrote:

> It is a well-known fact to all metaphysicians and occultists that even a clear and strong thought can be projected and be sent many thousands of miles away and be materialized at its place of destination, and under proper conditions, to be seen by

> men. All these phenomena are not mysteries or miracles… This is the truth about UFO [sic], commonly known as "flying saucers," space ships and space men….[3222]

Ideas similar to Manas's slowly diffused through Ufology. "It would seem, therefore, that earthbound 'entities' or spirits produce images of 'flying saucers,'" Jacques Vallee wrote in 1965.[3223] In 1971, John Keel entertained the idea that UFOs represent "astral travelers" visible only to psychically-sensitive witnesses.[3224]

"Spacecraft are a very rudimentary sort of travel," John Mack wrote, conveying the sentiments of Sequoyah Trueblood (Chapter 12). "Sequoyah says the time will come when such vehicles will not be necessary and we will be able to 'travel anywhere as spirits.' The so-called aliens have already mastered a way to materialize instantly from millions of light-years away…."[3225]

Speculation along these lines also appears in the work of Raymond Fowler, Ann Druffel, and, more recently, Micah Hanks.[3226] Hanks speculated intelligences behind UFOs "may have even divorced themselves from the necessity for having bodies at all, favoring instead a variety of 'psychic embodiment' that frees them from having any physical and intellectual confines."[3227]

Though such exteriorization of the self is traditionally unlocked through intense, disciplined meditation, that didn't stop the madcap McKenna brothers from trying to build a literal "after-death vehicle of some sort" while studying psychedelics in the Amazon. According to Terence, his brother

Dennis "set out to immanentize the soul, to actually force it to physically appear in nearby physical space as a kind of little, spinning, disc-shaped object which would follow you around… a union of spirit and matter" similar to the alchemical Philosopher's Stone, born in the crucible of psilocybin intoxication.[3228]

Even Terence McKenna's fans find the ordeal difficult to comprehend, and his book *True Hallucinations*, which covers Dennis's experiment, obscures the results behind McKenna's trademark syntactic flourishes. By all appearances Dennis failed to obtain results, at least in the way he intended: "We have not condensed the stone into visible space, but we have generated it in our heads," he intoned mid-trip. "It does not immediately appear as a visible vehicle, but first as a teaching—the teaching we are hearing in our heads right now. Later, the words will be made flesh."[3229]

"Dennis had thought that the flying saucer would emerge out of his body as a spinning violet disk of translinguistic matter that would become showerhead, pizza, or Mercedes, depending on what you needed at the moment," Terence later mused. "He thought it would become matter in the act of appropriate activity. Instead what emerged was a totality symbol."[3230]

Soulcraft soul craft

Thus far, we have explored the possibilities that UFOs might symbolize souls, or even *be* souls. The remainder of this chapter focuses on another, wilder hypothesis: that UFOs transport souls of the dead.

The idea of afterlife "vehicles" being anything more than metaphorical seems absurd. As Captain Kirk quipped in *Star Trek V: The Final Frontier*, "What does God need with a starship?" Previous chapters have outlined the mythological basis for afterlife technology *ad nauseum*. Enough talk of second lives in the Tuat, or implants designed by Konstantin Raudive from the Great Beyond—does any evidence from UFO literature suggest the possibility that flying saucers are "soul ships"?

On the incidence of light orbs in antiquity, Kripal noted their commonality across Mediterranean cultures. For example, Neoplatonism described "the soul's body of light" as a spherical "shining *vehicle* [author's emphasis]," or *augoeides ochema*.[3231]

"The historian of religions Ioan Couliano went so far as to describe this spherical soul-vehicle as a kind of ancient 'space shuttle' traveling back and forth between the earthly body and outer space, where the gods were believed to inhabit, or *be*, the stars," Kripal wrote.[3232]

Support for this possibility hinges on the reliable comparativist standbys of eyewitness testimony and spiritual tradition. A few compelling examples:

- Among the many Marian apparitions reported at Fátima (Chapter 11) were globes of light which vanished into the sun. One priest explained this as "a heavenly vehicle that carried the Mother of God from her throne above."[3233]

- Following the Battle of Tehumardi in 1944, witnesses on the Estonian island of Saaremaa claimed regular sightings of a cigar-shaped aircraft piloted by silver-suited Ufonauts who scoured the battlefield for dead bodies. Though the Soviet officials prohibited any discussion, rumors whispered that the object was a "vessel of the dead," which had been seen in earlier years.[3234]

- In his book *Link and Communiqué*, John E. Best contacted various personalities from beyond the grave, including that of his deceased fiancée, a nurse named Marjorie. Among her regular, evidential messages was the revelation that her occupation extended into the afterlife, where she was charged with visiting various hospitals. To fulfill her mission, Marjorie was granted access to a special vehicle which reads much like a flying saucer, traveling thousands of miles an hour both on and off-planet.[3235]

Over his years working in the Amazon, Graham Hancock developed a relationship with shaman and visionary artist Pablo Amaringo, whose paintings tried to replicate the images seen under the influence of ayahuasca. These images often featured objects resembling UFOs. Before Amaringo's death, Hancock pressed him on exactly what these shapes represented.

"He told me that the 'flying saucers' in his visions were not mere spacecraft but rather 'vehicles for entering and leaving the spirit world,'" Hancock said.[3236]

Amaringo elaborated elsewhere that "these vehicles may take many shapes, are able to attain infinite speed, and can travel underwater or under the earth. The beings traveling in them are like spirits, having bodies more subtle than ours, appearing and disappearing at will. They belong to extraterrestrial civilizations that live in perfect harmony."[3237]

If one can move beyond the concept's initial buy-in—admittedly a tall order—the idea of UFOs as afterlife vehicles rewards a certain explicative elegance, reconciling their technological aspects with High Strangeness, at least to a degree. It also fits nicely into the idea that both spirits and UFOs travel along straight lines between places of power, as mentioned in Chapter 9—afterlife vehicles presumably follow some of the same rules as their occupants.

The question arises: for what destination are these soul ships bound?

Starships as star ships

Even if we are not meant to take the idea of soul ships literally, ample reasons encourage us to embrace UFOs as such on a symbolic level. First and foremost, the craft haunting our skies signify *transportation*.

The very term "psychopomp" means to *guide* or *lead* the soul. As such, most figures embody the theme of navigation. Psychopomp animals are overwhelmingly beasts with specialized navigational capabilities, seeing in the dark or traversing great distances otherwise difficult for or unattainable by humans. These traits are obvious in psychopomp animals like dolphins (which travel under or across oceans), birds (soaring in the sky, unimpeded by terrain), and horses.

Horses were monumentally important to ancient mankind. Their endurance, strength, and speed rendered vast distances manageable, and upon their backs horses carried civilization itself in the form of religion, trade, and conquest. For these reasons horses were not only regarded as psychopomps among early peoples but draft animals capable of pulling the sun itself. Some Central Asian kurgans, oriented in the shape of gigantic wheels to symbolize the solar chariot, contain as many as 30 horses alongside human remains.[3238] In many ancient depictions, suns and horses are synonymous.

The sun, while an *identified* flying object, is nonetheless a glowing aerial disc. Therefore, on a deep level, horses symbolize UFOs, or more accurately,

both symbolize psychopomps; the same can be said of birds. We examine the importance of psychopomp animals to UFO sightings in Chapter 16.

Though horses dominated overland travel until relatively recently, any mode of transportation can signify passage to the afterlife—consider Anne Strieber's railway station from the previous chapter, a thoroughly modern image nonetheless conveying the theme of travel into the next life. Prior to the Industrial Revolution, however, the most effective way to reach far-flung locations was via ship.

"Virtually all civilizations use an image of a boat with the body of the deceased to represent a voyage or the crossing over to the 'other world,'" wrote Keister. "The boat also suggests a return to the cradle or the womb."[3239]

The inaccessibility imposed by mountain ranges, oceans, and (to a lesser degree) rivers undoubtedly inspired cultural beliefs in the afterlife as a distant, undiscovered—yet earthbound—country. Though cultures like the Polynesians embraced the transportive capacity of the seas, others viewed these vast expanses as obstacles to travel. Even with seaworthy vessels, it was impossible to know the full extent of what lay beyond the endless horizon.

Pinpointing the earliest example of ship-psychopomp symbolism is a fool's errand. "Sailing is the oldest form of travel in the beyond," Lecouteux wrote. "It would subsequently become the most common mode of transport in the otherworld."[3240] Like transoceanic voyages, travel to the afterlife was rarely considered brief or instantaneous.[3241] It was, in the fullest sense, a *journey.*

The afterlife boat with the most pop-culture cache is that of Charon, the Greek ferryman of Hades. Elsewhere in Europe, the Lechitic figure *Niya,* sometimes identified as a psychopomp, is suspected to derive its name from the Proto-Indo-European **nāu* ("to flow") or Latin *navis* ("boat").[3242]

Some sagas feature Odin helming ferries, and Norse burials are famous for their inclusion of ships. On rare occasions the revered dead were launched to sea in boats, though unlike fictional depictions, these were likely *not* ignited by flaming arrows.[3243] More often, "Viking funerals" involved burying entire ships as grave goods along with the dead.[3244] In other instances "stone ships" surrounded graves, elliptic rock circles arranged in the shape of hulls. Remains of dogs and horses appear commonly at such burials.[3245]

The Norse cultural diaspora to places like Ireland and the British Isles gave rise to similar ship burials, commingling with existing boat-Otherworld associations at Anglo-Saxon sites like Sutton Hoo.[3246] The Irish deity (and modern psychopomp) Manannán mac Lir possessed a boat capable of autopilot. In places like Rathlin, ominous ships served as death omens: islanders held that "a boat with six oarsmen," always riding a violent storm, heralded doom for members of one particular family.[3247]

Afterlife ships are by no means relegated to western Europe. One retelling of the Native American legend of Hiawatha—a historical figure who became a folk hero—features a magical, supernaturally-fast, aerial canoe which bears him to the afterlife after uniting the Iroquois Confederacy.[3248] It is a "solar barque" which transports not only Ra, but Egyptian pharaohs into the afterlife. Like the Norse, Egyptians sometimes entombed fully functional

boats alongside the dead, like the one discovered in Khufu's tomb in 1954.[3249]

In Asia, "boat-coffins" litter the cliffs of China's Wuyi Mountains.[3250] According to Vedic cosmology, the dead reach the netherworld traveling alongside the sun "via sailing a boat on the primeval ocean."[3251] Boat symbolism remains essential in Buddhism to this day: "The *yana* that one finds appended to such important Buddhist denominations as the Mahayana means vehicle or boat," explained afterlife scholar James R. Lewis.[3252]

In island Southeast Asia "the 'ship of the dead' or 'flying ship' as it is often termed, whether the coffin proper or a small model used in rituals, is loaded with cosmic symbols," wrote Pierre-Yves Manguin. "It is also a representation of the encompassing cosmological sphere."[3253] The words "boat" and "coffin" are interchangeable in some of these cultures.[3254] In Borneo, souls travel to the afterlife in a ship tipped with a bird-shaped prow and stern.[3255]

Finally, boats are a shamanic symbol *par excellence*, particularly in this corner of the world. Eliade lists three "real or symbolic" shamanic vessels in Indonesia and Melanesia: "(1) the boat for the expulsion of demons and sicknesses; (2) the boat in which the Indonesian shaman 'travels through the air' in search of the patient's soul; (3) the 'boat of the spirits,' which carries the souls of the dead to the beyond."[3256]

Ships bearing the departed are also a staple in NDEs.

- In 2004, Adrian began feeling weak while watching his daughter. He barely mustered the strength to call a neighbor to watch her before collapsing to the floor. All negativity faded away as Adrian was "drawn out" of his body into another realm. "A large ship" sailed into view accompanied by a tall, glowing, feminine "creature" who drew him toward her. Wishing to see his daughter again, Adrian resisted and instantly snapped back into his body.[3257]

- Clinical death during surgery in June 2006 sent Harold soaring through the air. Below him, a tropical island harbor held a peculiar vessel: large, triple-tiered, with a single sail. On the top deck "tiny people" crowded, laughing and calling to him. Harold nearly reached the ship before medical personnel resuscitated him.[3258]

- Another NDEr experienced visions induced by internal bleeding in September 2011. Without warning he found himself beside a man and a boat, both of whom seemed composed of fluorescent white glass. Though the being remained silent, the experiencer sensed it was responsible for bringing him from Earth.

  The boat began moving down a narrow, "metallic, glassy and white" tunnel before lurching to a halt. The NDEr turned around and saw another figure, "more authoritative looking than the first," who silently and easily plucked him out of the tunnel. "So this is how I could have died," the NDEr reflected as he returned to life.[3259]

What happens when, having mapped the planet, the Land of the Dead eludes us still? Where does that unknown country go? This conundrum, arising in our current secular predicament, leaves global culture but one option: the Otherworld lies in the stars.

How do we get there? Not by any traditional means… yet our culture cannot bring itself to abandon the psychopomp's boat. Its symbolism is too powerful. Instead, we reimagine these boats as extraterrestrial space*ships*, a comfortable "scientific" veneer gilding a phenomenon which in fact is more ancient, more unknowable, more truly *alien* than we could possibly imagine: death itself.

Anyone can clearly track this trend as it evolves through UFO sightings, starting with the earliest histories of airborne anomalies. "The notion that mysterious aerial objects may be connected with an afterlife is actually an ancient concept," wrote Brent Raynes in a February 1982 *MUFON UFO Journal* article. "So called 'soul ships' cruise the night skies, according to the old legends, picking up the souls of the recently departed."[3260]

Centuries before flying saucers, witnesses described literal sailing ships navigating the heavens. As early as 760, French skies were "filled with human figures, ships with sails and battling armies," Aubeck and Vallee wrote. "Several individuals stated they had been abducted by aerial beings." Such sightings inspired superstitions blaming bad weather on *tempestari*, sorcerers dwelling in the supernal realm of *Magonia*, where "ships come out and sail upon the clouds."[3261] As seen throughout Vallee's work, a clear continuity links these sky ships to modern starships, their motives and habits remaining consistent while their *perception* keeps pace with the cultures in which they are observed.

Since they seem capable of adopting whatever form pleases them, some researchers believe ominous, black, "phantom helicopters" actually represent shapeshifted flying saucers. It is a paranoid interpretation, but such aircraft

are sometimes reported in the vicinity of UFO sightings and cattle mutilations, and seem at least *symbolic* of UFOs' role as psychopomp vessels. Wrote Dennis Stillings in the July 1987 *MUFON UFO Journal*:

> The tricksterish nature of the phantom helicopters is well documented by Tom Adams, John Keel, and George Andrews.
>
> Many connections can also be made between helicopters and Hermes/Mercurius. Like Hermes, the helicopter is a "savior," a "duty angel," the "Holy Helos" that rescues people from danger under the most difficult of circumstances; it is a messenger (delivery of mail, serum, etc., to remote, inaccessible places in emergencies) and a psychopomp to the dead. Like Mercurius, the helicopter is inherently unstable, and achieving stability is the main problem of helicopter design. It has been said that "airplanes want to fly, helicopters want to fly apart."
>
> Other odd, imaginative statements are made about the helicopter. It is a mechanical Pegasus and "can do anything a horse can do"....[3262]

Circumstantial ephemera, far from conclusive, further imply continuity between psychopomp boats and flying saucers. Norse "stone ships," while meant to outline the shape of boats, are arranged in a pattern equally describable as yonic, sharing the same basic curvature seen in Grey alien eyes, cigar-shaped UFOs, or flying saucers viewed from the side. Boat-coffins unearthed in the Philippines yield skeletons exhibiting cranial deformation.[3263] In his analysis, Jung sometimes interpreted UFOs seen in dreams as symbolically "manned by spirits, a space-ship that comes out of

the beyond to the edge of our world in order to fetch the souls of the dead."[3264]

From a mythological perspective, most boats of the dead are capable of flight, sometimes staffed by ferrymen described as "grey" or swathed in mist, as in Phaeacian or Teutonic traditions.[3265] Even the ports of call visited by psychopomp boats resemble modern flying saucer destinations: "the otherworld for the Celts was composed of islands," Lecouteux wrote.[3266] What are planets but islands lost amidst the sea of space, a primeval ocean filled with the "cool waters of the stars," as the Egyptians phrased?[3267]

Comparing extraterrestrials to psychopomps is an excursion into fertile, virgin territory. These parallel mythologies share deep motivic resonance, but scholars have largely avoided connecting them. Our final chapters on UFOs examine the phenomenon through traditions of death and rebirth, manifesting as both the alien Other and as a dormant aspect of ourselves.

16

ALIENS AS THE OTHER

OBJ



Every parent tells their children monsters are not real. Most of us believe this. Among Forteans, this becomes a critical inflection point: do we reassure our sons and daughters, trading our convictions for a good night's sleep? Do we reveal our suspicions, that reality is populated by a thousand invisible terrors hovering a half-inch from your face, and risk their lapse into perpetual fear? Or do we choose a measured approach—"There *are* nasties elsewhere, but not in your closet or under your bed, honey, and they certainly can't hurt you"? (In case anyone is wondering, the answer comes to you with abject clarity when they cry out at 2:00 a.m.—you *definitely* tell them monsters aren't real!)

The fact of the matter is that these things *do* hurt people. Even if they don't tangibly exist, paranormal encounters *seem* to exist and, as discussed

at length, the *trauma* is real. Psychological distress is extremely common, including anxiety, depression, and even full-on psychotic breaks. More disturbing are reports of *physical* ailments, ranging from illnesses to flesh-and-blood wounds—even death—after brushes with the supernatural.

Death from above

Despite their reputation for miraculous healing, UFOs cause physical harm more often than any other anomaly. If craft come close enough, even passive witnesses report afflictions after sightings like chronic pain, burns, contusions, inflammation, eye irritation, and neuropathy, both temporary and permanent. Abductees suffer flesh wounds, blisters, nosebleeds, and reproductive difficulties. All battle varying degrees of mysterious illness causing headaches, gastric issues, respiratory complications, vertigo, and dehydration.[3268]

Why this occurs is up for debate. One of the most popular theories holds that UFOs emit radiation. This is supported by measurable environmental aftereffects detected at sighting locations and the common symptoms of skin and eye irritation. In milder cases these resemble sunburns and conjunctivitis, with more extreme cases manifesting in burns of deepening severity and temporary blindness.[3269] In the famous 1980 Cash-Landrum case from Texas, the craft (which may admittedly have been terrestrial) released an intense heat which partially melted a car dashboard; afterwards, the witnesses suffered headaches, nausea, blisters, vomiting, diarrhea, and fainting.[3270]

"By morning friends feared Cash was near death," Jerome Clark wrote. Within a week, skin and hair began sloughing off and falling out, and Vickie Landrum's eyesight never fully recovered. "A radiologist who reviewed the victims' medical records for MUFON concluded, 'We have strong evidence

that these patients have suffered damage secondary to ionizing radiation,'" reported Clark. "'It is also possible that there was an infrared or ultraviolet component as well.'"[3271]

It is tempting to blame some extraterrestrial power source for this damage, but the answer may not be so simple. Gregory Little reported a case from Kentucky where three UFO witnesses underwent hypnotic regression for their missing time, only to emerge with the same symptoms they had experienced after their sighting: fatigue, dermal sensitivity, the feeling of their faces and eyes burning, etc.[3272] This implies a metaphysical component may be at play.

There is some indication that the Sumerian dead must endure extreme heat and "cross a fire in order to reach the netherworld."[3273] Such ideas reflect the dangers of theophany, coming into close proximity with the divine (Chapter 13): Icarus flies too close to the sun and is burned, Moses beholds a burning bush, the Judeo-Christian God's breath is a cleansing fire.

Even lesser spirits like ghosts have a longstanding reputation for "frightening people to death" in both the West and the East. The Japanese averted their eyes from ghostlike *wanyudo* yokai, spinning "fire wheels" that burned and maimed anyone caught looking their way. The European dead also inflicted wounds similar to UFOs.

"A thousand stories tell us that the individual who comes in contact with the dead comes away from it with a souvenir in the form of a burn mark," wrote Lecouteux. "One exemplum explicitly states… 'Touched on the arm by the dead man, skin and flesh were seared through to the bone'…."[3274]

With a little imagination, the ailments UFO witnesses describe seem not unlike curses from faeries, who blinded transgressors and paralyzed their limbs. Where scorned faeries (and offended ancestors) once blighted crops, UFOs today leave behind burned vegetation. Just as Europeans attributed the vagaries of "bad luck" to faeries, some Ufologists, noticing an uptick in misfortune, begin to suspect something greater than mere chance is at work.

Richard Duke's involvement in the "Collins Elite," covered later, came to an end when he started experiencing "problems and more problems," including ill health for him and his wife. "I left… And I got well, my wife got well… I don't dabble anymore."[3275] We are also reminded of the perils surrounding Rick Strassman's Chapter 6 DMT experiments, including cancer.

Most disturbingly—and pertinent to their role as death symbols—UFOs *kill* people, both slowly and instantly. While wholly anecdotal, many have noted the number of Ufologists claimed by aggressive cancers and sudden cardiac arrest; radiation can generate tumors and weaken the heart.[3276] Some believe "UFO investigators' disease" comes from shady government agencies protecting "the truth" behind UFOs. Others think it arises from the phenomenon itself, inflicted at a distance or accumulating over time from visiting irradiated landing sites.[3277]

While such losses may or may not be attributed to UFOs, plenty of cases explicitly link deaths with UFOs and their occupants. During his investigation of the previous chapter's Brazilian chupas, Vallee learned no less than five individuals reportedly died after encountering them, confirmed both by fellow witnesses and law enforcement. In one instance, Ribamar Ferreira described how Abel Boro died on October 17, 1981 while the pair were hunting: the

object engulfed Boro in "a glittering glow," and when Ferreira returned with help, they found him dead, "his body white 'as if drained of blood.'"[3278]

Another, unrelated Brazilian incident from 1996 involved a UFO sighting and numerous witnesses who spotted a foul-smelling "devil" in the vicinity of Varginha. Rumors abound that, while in the process of capturing and killing the creature, policeman Marco Eli Chereze was forced to wrangle it with his bare hands (no specimen ever surfaced, of course). While a fantastic story, it is true that Chereze was dispatched to investigate, and died within a month. The cause of death was unclear, though Chereze had been hospitalized shortly after the encounter for "a small tumor" which arose in his armpit.[3279]

Tokens

A wealth of universal folklore, too abundant to exhaustively enumerate, treats anything anomalous in the sky as heralding great change: regime transitions, royal births, warfare, famine, natural disasters, plague, and, of course, death. Meteors and comets are among the most common harbingers, the latter especially ominous because they remain visible for months on end, returning years later with a cyclical consistency evoking dynastic ascent and decline.

In ancient times, tails of comets seen over Persia and Korea pointed towards nations from which war could be expected.[3280] According to the stela of Gebel Barkal, a star appeared above the Nubian army circa 1460 BC, killing and routing troops.[3281] Chinese observers in the 7th c. BC used meteors to predict military campaigns and rulers' deaths, coming to view them as dragons whose actions brought blessings or catastrophes in equal measure.[3282] The direction of shooting stars in Germany indicated someone in a nearby residence was soon to die, or that a friend of the witness had just passed away.[3283] Strange lights in the sky allegedly accompanied plagues, including the Black Death in Europe.[3284]

In the New World, Chile's Araucaria believed comets and shooting stars were ill omens from snake-bodied storm gods called *cherruv*e.[3285] According to Edgar Herzog, an archaic ceremony once practiced by southern California's Acjachemen featured a tribesman disguised as a coyote who "breaks into the funeral procession to devour raw a piece of the corpse… hailed by names

meaning not only 'thief'" but also "man-eater," "man-eating monster," "the sea-serpent," "meteor," and "globular lightning.'"[3286] This imagery highlights a widespread psychopomp/trickster connection: many indigenous people, including the builders of Göbekli Tepe, associated aerial objects with wolves and foxes, the latter sharing luxuriant tails with comets.[3287]

Airborne harbingers of doom appear in the Western historical record at least as early as the foundation of the Roman Empire, where a comet coincided with the 44 BC assassination of Julius Caesar.[3288] According to Dio Cassius's *Annals of Rome,* another assassination nearly 150 years later, that of Emperor Pertinax, was accompanied by three stars encircling the sun, corresponding in witnesses' minds to the three contenders for the throne: "These heavenly bodies were so very brilliant that the soldiers kept continually looking up at them and pointing them out to one another, declaring moreover that some dreadful fate would befall the usurper." In the 5th century, the death of Frankish king Merovech—namesake of the Merovingian Dynasty—was preceded by "twenty rays" crossing the Parisian sky from east to west.[3289] When spotting Halley's Comet in April 1066, Anglo-Saxons immediately knew a great change was at hand; six months later, their king was killed in the seminal Battle of Hastings.[3290]

Rumors persist that an omen in the sky preceded an American "kingly" death. According to Ufologist Salvador Freixedo, the "very same day [President Franklin D.] Roosevelt was informed that the first atomic bomb had been armed, a 'big ball of light' was seen circling around over the White House, and, precisely one month later, Roosevelt was dead."[3291]

More modest aerial death omens appear as small light orbs or ghost lights, discussed at length earlier vis-à-vis faeries, UFOs, and astral projection. As mentioned in Chapter 13, strange lights accompanying our earthly departure are not unusual. Even when seen outside this context, they still indicate impending death to people all over the world (Chapter 4). There is no need to reiterate these superstitions, but strengthening their connection to the UFO phenomenon may serve our discussion.

Few have researched these portents more thoroughly than Chris Aubeck, who refers to them as *tokens*, "stemming from the Anglo-Saxon verb *tácen*, meaning 'to point out, to indicate.'" (While tokens are neither exclusively aerial nor exclusively luminous—they include a variety of phenomena discussed in previous chapters—we will adopt this term for ease of use when discussing death omens in the sky.) Both *Wonders in the Sky* and Aubeck's essay "Tokens: UFOs as Omens of Human Death" feature many examples.

In the latter, Aubeck examines a survey of Adams County, Illinois residents conducted by Anglican minister Harry Middleton Hyatt in 1935. The volume includes, of all things, a section dedicated to anomalous lights, its 45 brief accounts providing a glimpse into early 20th century American folk belief free of "flying saucer" baggage.

Yet, as Aubeck's work reveals, numerous parallels can be drawn between these anomalies and UFOs, including their affinity for places of rest: burial sites and bedrooms. Much as a flood of light might herald the arrival of night-time alien invaders, tokens from the Adams County collection are often first noticed by the light they cast upon the ceiling. One example:

> My daughter was sitting in the room, I was already in bed, when she ran and jump[ed] into the bed shaking and saying, "Mother, look up at that light. I see red lights and all kind of lights on the ceiling." I look[ed] up to the ceiling and saw nothing but lights, silver, gold and red. All at once it went out the window just like a spirit would go. I said, "Daughter, we will hear something bad." And the next day I got word my son was dead. I always see something when someone dies.3292

This token's color calls to mind those of Welsh ghost lights, which signified women's deaths when they were white, men's deaths when they were red. It also resembles some deathbed Ufological activity.

Two years after their shared UFO sighting and missing time, Mona Stafford learned of Elaine Thomas's fatal heart attack on September 26, 1978. According to Stafford, a nurse watched "light beams shining in the window" and a light which "bounc[ed] off the walls and ceiling" of the hospital room at the time of her death. Thomas had told staff not to worry—"it was just the UFO entities." A few hours later she passed away.[3293]

Tokens in the form of light orbs are one thing, but what about structured craft and UFO occupants? Perusing the paranormal literature, one perceives a vague, disquieting trend where witnesses regularly find themselves in ill health, even dying, following experiences. Such is certainly the case when rifling through compendia like Albert Rosales's database of humanoid encounters, though these often occur too long after sightings to draw direct conclusions.

Below are a few examples where aliens and structured craft, rather than orbs of light, precede death or misfortune.

- A great wind making "such a rumbling noise that it sounded like an earthquake" filled Prague on July 20, 1571, announcing the march of a phantom army through the streets. "Behind the soldiers came something resembling a large round 'chariot' drawn by oxen," metallic and wheelless. The chariot caused a great fire as it crossed the square, then disappeared in a rain of fire which "persisted until dawn. That year there was a great famine and many people died" (note the resemblance to the Wild Hunt).[3294]

- In 1932, a bevy of peculiar humanoids allegedly besieged a small hamlet near Zhytomyr, modern Ukraine. The creatures lacked waists, their upper bodies pulsing with flame. Villagers in the direct vicinity of sightings died, causing many to flee.[3295]

- Days after a bedroom encounter with three Grey aliens left him "sunburned" in 1952, an Idaho boy riding in the backseat of the family Buick received telepathic communication from an unknown source. The car T-boned another vehicle near Blackbird, sending everyone to the hospital except the boy. He later reported encounters with flying saucers and Men-in-Black.[3296]

- After seeing a UFO for the second time in 1971, three Finnish brothers decided to open fire on the landed craft, allegedly damaging it. A third sighting found three short, thin occupants floating into the yard, telling the brothers they had been reckless, and declaring matter-of-factly that they would "die quite soon." Despite their health, all three passed away shortly thereafter from strokes.[3297]

- Thousands in Sicily (including law enforcement) saw "a UFO as big as an ocean liner" on September 14, 1978, followed by appearances in Rome the next two evenings. On September 28, Pope John Paul I died of a heart attack, despite a recent clean bill of health.[3298]

- Contactee Ted Owens demonstrated large scale psychokinetic effects throughout his life thanks to ongoing contact with "space intelligences." Just prior to his death on December 28, 1987, Owens and his neighbor both reported ships and lights above his home.[3299]

- In November 1989, a tall humanoid appeared in a glowing light and descended to the Nikopol, Ukraine balcony of Lubov Ivanovna Stefan. When it told Stefan to "expect a relative to soon die," she initially thought it was mistaken—after all, she had recently buried her father. The figure then extended an invitation to visit its planet for three days, which Stefan declined. The being asked once more before begrudgingly reentering its craft and departing. Within two weeks, her husband's cousin died of stomach cancer.[3300]

These modern reflections still carry anxieties of the past. Jung noted how our fear of death sometimes manifests UFOs in dreams, a catalyst bleeding into waking sightings.

> The apparent increase in UFO sightings in recent years has caused disquiet in the popular mind and might easily give rise to the conclusion that, if so many space-ships appear from the beyond, a corresponding number of deaths may be expected.

> We know that such phenomena were interpreted like this in earlier centuries: they were portents of a "great dying," of war and pestilence, like the dark premonitions that underlie our modern fear.3301

Like most predictions, tokens are only understood in hindsight. Confirmation bias certainly plays a role—plenty of flying saucer sightings are *not* followed by death—and, as referenced numerous times, a majority of explicit predictions from UFO occupants fall flat. The Chapter 12 deaths predicted by Betty Andreasson and Rita Malley are outliers.

So what *are* UFOs when they appear as tokens? Perhaps entropy itself. In later years, Wilhelm Reich (Chapter 8) believed UFOs were agents of Dead Life Energy, a negative form of orgone responsible for "deterioration in the environment manifesting in the destruction of rocks, trees, forests, and the drying up of the atmosphere."[3302] This concept may find supporting evidence in the odors of decay—typically sulfur compounds—overwhelmingly reported by alien abductees and UFO witnesses.[3303]

Another option is that they are *ourselves*. The previous chapter illustrated how, whether as structured craft or anomalous lights, UFOs can represent exteriorized human souls. If this is the case, perhaps tokens should be viewed as a variation on doppelgängers, death omens in their own right. In both cases the soul, separated from the body, has left its owner weak and susceptible to death—tokens are symptoms, rather than predictions or causes, of one's imminent demise.

The intense psychological effects of UFOs can leave experiencers contemplative as to their own place in the universe. Following his 1965 observation of a landed UFO and occupants at Valensole, France, eyewitness Maurice Masse saw the object again, this time in the night air above a field he owned. Speaking with Vallee, he reminisced that the sight was "'the best thing you could wish to anyone,' adding that *a witness shouldn't say anything about it*, not even to his family: 'One always says too much.'"[3304]

Vallee perceived an introspection in Masse found in other witnesses: "He also told us that he had started to think a lot about death."[3305]

Ghosts of Mars

Skeptics often wield Occam's Razor to suggest the simplest explanation for any mystery is the most likely. This is a misreading. In truth, the adage holds that "among competing hypotheses, the one with the fewest assumptions should be selected." Explanations should not unnecessarily multiply variables.

Ergo, the notion that flying saucers and/or their occupants represent the souls of dead extraterrestrials pushes the envelope of absurdity. Not only is the persistence of consciousness after death presumed, but so is the existence of intelligent life elsewhere in the galaxy. However, if an ecology of souls exists—and it seems to, judging from millennia of evidence—it should logically extend everywhere, to the farthest reaches of our universe.[3306]

Despite this work's overall rejection of the ETH, it seems highly probable that intelligent life exists somewhere out there… it just doesn't seem to visit Earth aboard physical spaceships. The previous chapter proposed that UFOs may represent intelligences projecting their consciousness across the stars. A leap from that possibility to "ET ghosts" is quite manageable.

"I suspect that there are other worlds in which the veil between the living and the dead has long ago fallen, and the whole species is evolving as one, partly injected into time and partly in timelessness, and both elements working together toward the discovery of a greater whole," Strieber wrote, flirting with the idea of ET ghosts in 2016. "I suspect that our visitors—at least, the aliens among them—are already like this."[3307]

Judging from the testimony of out-of-body experiencers, neither time nor space impede travel in the astral realm. Theoretically speaking, the incomprehensibly vast distances discouraging physical journeys between planets would do little to deter ET ghosts. The speed of light is fast, but the speed of thought is instantaneous.

Dutch scientists Matla and Zaalberg van Zeist claimed to learn as much from a spirit in 1913. Guided by the deceased Russian revolutionist Magda Verouchine, the brothers constructed several apparatuses for drawing in and communicating with the dead (our "afterlife tech" motif again). Through these devices, spirits told the van Zeists that the soul's amoebalike energy moves through the universe after death so quickly it seems imbued with "the power of being everywhere at once. In reality it moves from place to place... Eventually the soul is able to leave the solar system and wander at will through all of space."[3308] If our souls are capable of interstellar travel, presumably other lifeforms' souls are as well.

By all appearances, no shortage of ghosts roam outer space. Even conventional astrophysicists find it likely that the Milky Way is littered with dead civilizations. An early 2021 paper from California Institute of Technology researchers "found potential self-annihilation to be highly influential in the quantity of galactic intelligent life… if intelligent life is likely to destroy itself, it is not surprising that there is little or no intelligent life elsewhere." The authors contend solar systems closer to the galactic center have likely seen civilizations rise and fall, their fates sealed by supernovas, climate change, or atomic warfare.[3309]

Evidence of a nuclear holocaust may exist much closer to home. Less conventional researchers like Dr. John E. Brandenburg (veteran plasma physicist and Senior Propulsion Scientist for Madison, Wisconsin's Orbital Technologies Corporation) believe they have found evidence for such devastation on Mars. Brandenburg's controversial ideas suggest a conflict between Martians and another civilization—a literal war in heaven—left behind observable nuclear residue in the form of Xenon 129 isotopes.

> The pattern of xenon abundance in the Martian atmosphere is different from any other planet or meteorite. Xenon, a heavy element, has many stable isotopes, and the pattern of their abundance is a fingerprint for the processes that have affected the bodies where it occurs. The xenon 129 appears to come from a large violent reaction like a nuclear bomb of tremendous size… The xenon isotope mass spectrum of the Mars atmosphere matches that from open air nuclear testing on Earth and is characteristic of fast neutron fission rather than that produced by a moderated nuclear reactor.[3310]

While Brandenburg admits that Xenon 129 is produced elsewhere via the normal fission decay of uranium, the Mars levels are significantly higher and "differ starkly from the isotopic mass spectrum of xenon elsewhere in the solar system." It remains possible some other, natural mechanism produced concentrations this high, but science is at a loss for any satisfactory alternative. The only place we have observed such a spike is in the presence of atomic weapons testing on Earth.[3311]

Is our entire *universe* haunted? Perhaps in the distant past flying saucers *were* physical, extraterrestrial spaceships, but today appear as displaced

residual hauntings, echoing the ghostly wagons, horses, and automobiles manifesting on Earth. (Imagine an alien MUFON equivalent receiving reports of phantom Ford Pintos!)

This might explain some inconsistencies across phenomena. Despite their tight overlap, discrepancies nonetheless exist between reports of faeries and UFO occupants, not the least of which are their attire and modes of transportation. Maybe the former are *our* dead, the latter the dead of another world.

The romantic idea that we linger amongst the ruins of an interstellar civilization appeals to our desire to proverbially "have our cake and eat it, too." In this model, UFOs can be both extraterrestrials *and* spirits, ancestors *and* ancient aliens.

Gods of space

In 2020's *Intimate Alien*, David Halperin reconfigures the infamous Roswell crash and its accompanying alien bodies as a modern myth. "What is the myth about? *Death*—dramatized in a tale whose tenacity bears witness to its power, yet not quite like anything in the classical mythologies. The Greeks, I once wrote, imagined the gods to be immortal. The Ufologists know better."[3312] In nearly every alleged flying saucer crash before or since, no UFO occupants survive; if they do, it is rarely for long. Faced with the terrifying power of the atomic age, humanity codified its anxieties in a new breed of legend where even gods bleed.

Because the topic appears repeatedly in previous chapters, our discussion of flying saucer occupants as some sort of deity, or deities, is relatively brief. UFO experiences clearly fit common religious narratives: both phenomena seem omniscient, easily mold reality, present unfathomable love and existential terror in equal measure, and exhibit an abiding preoccupation with our souls, often awakening latent spiritual insight. They seem more embedded in a nebulous *elsewhere* than our waking reality, dwellers not only of the overworld and underworld, but our dreams or even ourselves. Their presence, as Jung noted, encodes *totality*, the oneness that is, was, and forever shall be.

Alien testimony couldn't render these connections any clearer, the entities sometimes claiming they inspired gods and goddesses of old, their names and appearances similar or even identical. Travis Walton described one of his

captors as "the epitome of her gender," not unlike characters seen across the Greco-Roman pantheon.[3313] Space Brothers (and Sisters) from the contactee era, whose lineage continues into beautiful "Nordic" aliens today, share these idealized physiques, as illustrated by one abductee who described her alien handler as "a Greek Athlete."[3314] (Rarely boasting darker complexions, though; the fact that these humanoids so often appear Caucasian suggests much about the role expectations play in forming these apparitions in the West.)

Because of these similarities, "flying saucer pareidolia" seizes ancient alien theorists scrutinizing world religions: the Star of Bethlehem becomes a hovering UFO, Christ an extraterrestrial, manna from heaven "angel hair," Vimanas interstellar battleships, Aztec sculptures rocket ships, Australian petroglyphs Greys, every pagan god and goddess a Nordic, etc. Anyone seeking a list of these comparisons need only turn on the television—there is no need to belabor them. Anything written here could be summed up thusly: "Take any 'ancient alien' theory that the gods were actually extraterrestrials and invert the assumption."

"On the surface, these comparisons are provocative and even sometimes attractive, since the connection that they draw between ancient gods and the modern UFO phenomenon is in fact a plausible one," wrote Jeffrey Kripal. "There *are* some genuinely uncanny comparisons to be drawn here. Still, the way that this approach handles ancient religious texts and artifacts, that is, as relatively unproblematic records of real historical events (records which few if any of the reductive comparativists can actually read in their original languages) is extremely naïve."[3315]

As a religious scholar himself, Kripal's brand of comparativism hews more towards agnosticism. We should not assert, for example, that the Blessed Virgin Mary was a space alien, nor that every extraterrestrial is a religious figure—rather, "what the good comparativist will do is say, 'It looks to me like something similar is going on in those two contexts, but I don't have the slightest idea what it is. But it obviously takes on different mythological frameworks depending on the culture and time period in which it happens.'"[3316] In short, UFOs *may* be divine, but to act as if we know exactly what the divine *represents* is folly.

The phenomenon itself warns us against drawing such conclusions. English Ufologist Tony Dodd asked a discarnate alien through an abductee serving as medium, "Are you what we call gods?"

"This is how some of you perceive us, but you do not understand the nature of things," came the reply.[3317]

What we *can* and *should* say is that the UFO phenomenon—at least partially—serves a similar cultural function today as spiritual narratives once did. Yet our ecology of souls model hinges upon the existence of a spirit world; it is disingenuous to claim neutrality after hundreds of thousands of words arguing otherwise. Without claiming it as truth, can an argument be mounted that interpreting "UFO occupants as spirits" is *more* accurate than "UFO occupants as aliens"?

If we look to the precedent set by terrestrial cargo cults, we find interactions with other cultures neither creating new religions nor supplanting existing belief systems, but rather becoming *incorporated into them*. Societies embracing cargo cults simply added outside contact into their

animist worldviews. We can only assume the same story would unfold with visitation from the stars—even if we *are* dealing with extraterrestrials, it is unlikely they inspired religion, but rather added another wrinkle to our mythological tapestry, rendering their true nature something of a moot point.[3318]

Enter the *sylph*

If aliens are indeed deities, their variety shares greater congruency with polytheism than monotheism. Abrahamic interpretations are cornered into reductively labeling UFO occupants angels or demons (as examined at this chapter's end). Polytheism on the other hand, particularly animism, supplies an endless number of gods and goddesses.

The extraterrestrials "are caretakers of nature and natural forms," Betty Andreasson was told. "They have been caring for it since man's beginning."[3319] This testimony warrants an interpretation closer to Theosophic faeries, i.e. nature elementals, when looking at UFOs. Theosophists believed faeries were essentially minor pagan deities, stewards of the environment guiding flora and fauna through their endless cycle of death and rebirth.

Chapter 4 explained the importance of Paracelsian cosmology—itself a sort of "Early Modern animistic worldview"—to Theosophic faerie belief.[3320] One category of elementals fits modern extraterrestrials better than others. Alongside the undines (water), gnomes (earth), and salamanders (fire), Paracelsus described a fourth variety, *sylphs*, associated with air.

This was not, it seems, literal air, but in the words of mystic Manly P. Hall, an "invisible, intangible, spiritual medium," the ether surrounding our world.[3321] These notions may have been influenced by the Kabbalistic concept of demons "occupy[ing] the space between the Moon and Earth"—the same region, by sheer technicality, where flying saucers appear.[3322]

Despite their aerial affinity, the sylphs' "true home was upon the tops of mountains," claiming lifespans of centuries or millennia, never growing old and all the while imbued with perfect senses.[3323] At the same time, sylphs exhibited a transitory existence not unlike todays UFOs: "They have no fixed domicile, but wander about from place to place—elemental nomads, invisible but ever-present powers in the intelligent activity of the universe."[3324]

When commanded to reveal themselves, sylphs historically manifested "in human form, sometimes in battle array marching in good order, halting under arms, or encamped beneath magnificent tents; sometimes on wonderfully constructed aerial ships, whose flying squadrons roved at the will of the Zephyrs." Another text describes sylphs "carrying off men from every locality and showing them their beautiful women, their Republic and their manner of government, and then setting them down again on earth in divers [sic] parts of the world."[3325]

Their corporeality is fleeting. "The sylphs sometimes assume human form, but apparently for only short periods of time," Hall continued. "Their size varies, but in the majority of cases they are no larger than human beings and often considerably smaller. It is said that the sylphs have accepted human beings into their communities and have permitted them to live there for a considerable period…."[3326] According to some, sylphs were mortal, but lacked souls.[3327]

Sylphs were often muses, bestowing epiphanies upon artists and scientists alike. The beings which met Facius Cardan in 1491 (Chapter 12) are often identified as sylphs and, like modern extraterrestrials, passed along arcane knowledge. Hall wrote that "the peculiar qualities common to men of genius

are supposedly the result of the cooperation of sylphs, whose aid also brings with it the sylphic inconsistency."[3328]

Paracelsian elementals offer another framework accounting for the pernicious dissimilarities between aliens and faeries—yes, they are of common origin, but embody separate aspects of our world, manifesting with slight differences. Though exceptions exist like the sluagh and Tylwyth Teg, faeries typically inhabit earth and water more often than air, bringing them into alignment with gnomes and undines respectively, more than sylphs. There is even the possibility that, should his model of elementals prove accurate, aliens represent a *fifth*, additional category of which Paracelsus would have had no knowledge: outer space.

Animist perspectives are useful, but other polytheistic models are not without merit when looking at the UFO mystery. We find surprising correspondences to the gods and goddesses of other pagan pantheons, particularly those charged with escorting souls to the afterlife.

A psychopomp pantheon

One of this work's central theses proposes that aliens serve as psychopomps. It is an unorthodox notion. Building a supporting case takes time, demanding slow and careful execution. Hopefully previous chapters have lain sufficient groundwork to render the idea palatable; this and the following four sections drive their similarities home with some of the clearest connections yet.

To reiterate some of the salient points presented thus far: like psychopomps, aliens lead us into other realms, brandish wands, and engage in liminal, tricksterish behavior; seem interested in human souls; exercise power over life-and-death; exhibit therianthropic attributes; and appear in NDEs. UFOs themselves appear to be a modern reworking of a potent psychopomp symbol, the ship to the Otherworld. Alien abductees' lives overlap with shamanism, a vocation characterized by leading souls to the afterlife—and, as initiations involving dead shamans suggest, sometimes "it takes a psychopomp to make a psychopomp."

These archetypes cut through the UFO phenomenon to varying degrees. Some alien abductees report literal psychopomps aboard flying saucers, evidenced by frequent encounters with beings resembling Jesus Christ. Elsewhere, the figures themselves are absent, but their iconography endures. Revisiting some of Chapter 2's more prominent psychopomps clarifies these under-appreciated comparisons.

- Ufologists have long drawn parallels between aliens and **angels** (Abrahamic), as covered in depth at the end of this chapter.

- In 1976, a woman claimed she interacted with a dog-headed man during a trancelike state; a month later found her unexpectedly pregnant. Around the same time, she regularly started perceiving hundreds of small lights twinkling about her in hues of white, blue, and gold, though no one else could see them. Eleven years passed before she stumbled across an image of **Anubis** (Egyptian) and was startled by the similarity. Her son independently reported dreams with the same entity.[3329]

- **Barnumbir** (Australian), like other psychopomps represented by stars, is analogous to anomalous lights in the sky. Some legends even describe Barnumbir "dancing over the waters," calling for the dead to follow her in a "spirit canoe" to an afterlife island "behind the mists" brimming with "beautiful, loving women" and plentiful resources.[3330]

- Any number of encounters with Nordic females may represent **Daēnā** (Zoroastrian) or even **Freya** (Norse). It is interesting to note Freya's association with cats, two of which pull her chariot.[3331] Did the Striebers' cat Coe reflect this archetype when he guided Anne to her afterlife train station?

- The **Grim Reaper** (European folk) appeared to a Latvian UFO witness in July 1972 after he returned home from work. A "star" had descended above the roof of his apartment building, revealing a female silhouette. As it drew closer, the figure's features came into focus: holes gaped where the mouth and nose should have been, accompanied by large, black eyes, perhaps sockets themselves. Convinced

he was meeting Death, the witness tried lashing out, but was paralyzed. He watched the being until it receded into the sky as a small light orb. Four years later, another tenant shared a similar visitation with the witness.[3332]

- Previous chapters illustrate qualities shared between **Hermes** (Greek) and the UFO phenomenon, from his reputation as trickster to his associations with sleep, fertility, liminality, roads, and music. His lineage is likewise affiliated with faeries, fathering the god Pan. His mother, the nymph Maia, was one of the Pleiades, an identity lent to the eponymous constellation. Millennia before we blamed flying saucers for such transgressions, Hermes engaged in proto-livestock mutilation by stealing and sacrificing Apollo's cattle.[3333]

Hermes is commonly depicted with an erection, speaking both to both shamanic iconography and UFO occupants' obsession with human reproduction—by extension, *genetics* (Chapter 17). Some believe the snakes encircling Hermes's winged kerykeion encode the double-helix formation of DNA.[3334]

Abductees report extraterrestrials not only brandishing wands, but wearing insignias evocative of the kerykeion. Sketches from Herbert Schirmer's December 3, 1967 encounter near Ashland, Nebraska feature winged snakes on the upper-right chest portion of each alien's uniform.[3335] Identical emblems appeared in the abductions of Bill Herrmann (1978) and Filiberto Cardenas (1979, Chapter 13).[3336]

In a 1954 book, Daniel Fry claimed telepathic contact with an extraterrestrial being named Alan. Wrote Jean Sider in the July 2000 *MUFON UFO Journal*: "Even though Alan is a first name used often in English-speaking countries, I think that its roots are contained in ALAUNS (or ALAUNUS), a Celtic god corresponding to MERCURIUS for the Romans"—in other words, Hermes.[3337]

- **Manannán mac Lir** (modern Celtic) possesses a mythical, self-driving ship. Like today's aliens, he is a trickster, fond of illusions, and finds close association with bodies of water (in his case, the sea). Manannán's perambulations can sound like flying saucer travel: "In both the Isle of Man and western Ireland it was said that

Manannán traveled with his magical mist, moving on three legs that rolled like a wheel," Daimler wrote.[3338]

- The **Northern Lights** (various) obviously resemble other, more mysterious aerial phenomena. A lifelong experiencer corresponding with the Striebers nearly died from pneumonia in late 1934 before two beings entered the bedroom "in an elongated envelope. They and their conveyance were like the Northern Lights." The beings took the child to a huge, crystalline ballroom where couples danced to indescribable music, laying a crystal in the witness's hand before returning to Earth. The pneumonia miraculously vanished.[3339]

- John Keel noted a tendency for UFO sightings to occur on Wednesdays,[3340] inadvertently echoing earlier belief that faeries favor the same day.[3341] Wednesday —the middle, liminal day of the week—is a psychopomp's day as well. In Spanish, Wednesday is *Miercoles*, named after **Mercury** (Roman).[3342]

In English, it is famously named after **Odin** (Norse).[3343] Like aliens and faeries, Odin claims a plethora of names and is served by bird and dog messengers, animals whose connections to UFOs are explored momentarily.

A longtime alien abductee awoke to footfalls in her kitchen on September 12, 1995. Realizing it was another visitation and wanting nothing to do with it, she forced herself back to sleep, where she "dreamed" of chasing a "child" through the kitchen. Catching it, she saw the child was actually a human-alien hybrid with "a sweet elfish face." She asked its name, and was answered by "a perfectly ordinary middle-aged woman" who "walked through my front door."[3344]

"I don't quite remember…" the witness wrote, "but it was something like 'O'dan.'"[3345]

- **Pushan** (Hindu) commandeers the "identified flying object" of the sun across the sky. Like psychopomps from other traditions (and arguably aliens), he oversees transition, exercising power over journeys and roads—liminal symbols. He also supervises marriages (reflected in human-alien unions) and cattle (shades of livestock mutilation).[3346]

Several legends depict Pushan as toothless, his teeth either broken or knocked out.[3347] Toothlessness features across various alien descriptions. Witnesses rarely remark on Greys' teeth, if they have any. José Antônio da Silva (Chapter 11) deliberately noted the toothless mouths of his abducting dwarfs.[3348]

These are admittedly poor fits for Pushan. A better correspondence might be the humanlike aliens Travis Walton encountered. In his recollection, none of these beings ever moved their mouths: "I did not even see teeth exposed, if they had any." The first "human" Walton encountered "had a dark complexion, like a deep, even tan"—although Hindu deities are traditionally presented in lighter hues, one cannot help imagining Walton's entity as someone of Indian descent.[3349]

If this connection seems tenuous, recall that Walton's abduction may have begun with his *literal death.* Moreover, his initial impression of the UFO was an idle assumption "that the glow was the *sun* going down in the west [author's emphasis]."[3350]

The first "human" that Walton met sported entrancing "golden hazel" eyes[3351]—**Savitr**, another Hindu sun deity sometimes identified as a psychopomp, is depicted with golden eyes.[3352] Like a soul guide, this being escorted Walton from a dank, stifling portion of the "craft" into a bright, refreshing, open space filled with "light like the sun."[3353]

- In 1991 a group of newspaper journalists investigating predictions of alien contact in a Bulgarian meadow were astounded to see triangular and cigar-shaped UFOs dart through the night sky and land on a nearby hill. Shadowy figures filled the tree line, illuminated by the residual glow. The psychic who had made the prediction was in attendance, and claimed a short entity with an oversized head, large eyes, and a birdlike beak hid nearby.

Falling into a trance, the psychic claimed to see visions of pyramids and a being identical to **Thoth** (Egyptian). Asked if it was **Hermes Trismegistus**, the presence answered, "It is not important what people call me. I am not here for that reason."

The exchange included various prophecies, some of which came true, including a prediction of 1991's August Coup. The incident ended with the appearance of a red falling star. As they left, several witnesses described the impression of "large gates made out of light" in the meadow behind them.[3354]

- Beautiful women seen during abductions also resemble **Valkyries**, who, like aliens, become lovers to mortal men, travel on storms, and share attributes with faeries (norns).[3355]

Though not explicitly Ufological, John Keel investigated claims from various people who met these winged warrior women: "They're Valkyries, you know," quipped one artist. "They have a wonderful sense of humor, but they also get very angry if you contradict them."[3356]

- Despite his weak reputation as such, recall that **Zeus** (Greek) was worshipped as a psychopomp by a Syrian cult c. 312-63 BC.[3357]

In 1982, "Christine Smith" endured an alien abduction while driving in Yorkshire. Hypnotic regression revealed interactions with beings who have been coming to Earth for "centuries." According to Smith, we once called these presences "gods." She identified one of the beings as "Zeus, it's the first name, Akaber." Smith's abductors were accountable to "a force greater than them," interpreted as what "we call" God.[3358]

A psychopomp menagerie (pt. 2)

Psychopomps come in more modest forms, of course. Alongside deities, cultures designated specific animals as leaders into the Great Beyond, their appearances falling upon a spectrum from fully bestial to half-human therianthropes. Chapter 13 outlined how, outside of Greys and Space Brothers, most aliens resemble animals anthropomorphized into insectoids, reptilians, and avian humanoids.

Therianthropic forms afflict experiencers too, betraying the shamanic structure underpinning UFO contact. Consider the Australian case from 1974 where an alien abductee embodied a fox (Chapter 7), or a tale Steve Boucher (Chapter 11) related where he acquired the wings and beak of a bird while astral traveling: "Unfortunately, the highly ecstatic nature of my emotions caused me to get pulled back into the physical body, so I never got to complete the transformation."[3359] Harvey-Wilson reported a similar phenomenon among abductees like Helen, who would "become an eagle" whenever entering her trances.[3360]

Beyond such wild tales, even "natural" animals demonstrate connections to UFOs. By some accounts, these are purely illusory, projected into alien abductees' minds as screen memories. Others maintain actual transformations occur—as John Mack put it, "aliens appear to be consummate shape-shifters, often appearing initially to the abductees as animals."[3361]

There are still others who adamantly insist these are mundane, flesh-and-blood animals anyone might encounter on an average day. Whatever their true nature, we once deemed them psychopomps.

- **Birds & owls.** With a little imagination, anyone can see birds' resemblance to UFOs. Both travel great distances by maneuvering silently through the air, hovering in place at will as hummingbirds can, or held aloft on the wind. Ancient cultures combined aerial discs with avian imagery, equating birds with the sun and other, more mysterious flying objects.[3362] Inscriptions from Middle Eastern civilizations include various winged discs whose identities remain open to debate.[3363]

The first time Barbara Fisher (involved in a story from Chapter 9) saw a UFO was at age 12 in West Virginia during broad daylight. Her mother remarked, "Look at that bird!"

"I look up and I don't see a bird. But what I *do* see… past the leaves on the tree is a silver, upside-down bowl just doing a stairstep float down the blue sky until it disappeared behind houses," Fisher remembered. Her mother insisted she could see a peculiar red bird, "but there was no bird where she was pointing." Despite never seeing it fly away, she later convinced herself both that it had, *and* that her daughter had said nothing to the contrary at the time.[3364]

An example from 2017 features another bizarre UFO-bird appearing differently to separate witnesses. Cyndi Vojvoda and her husband were attending a paranormal event and Halloween party on Michigan's Mackinac Island dressed respectively as an alien and Giorgio Tsoukalos (from the television series *Ancient Aliens*). Vojvoda was thrilled when, around midnight, her longstanding wish to see a UFO was granted.[3365]

"We both looked up and said, 'Do you see that?'" she later wrote. "It was a massive object taking up one third of the sky and traveling from one horizon to the other, straight across the sky." Vojvoda described the object not as a traditional flying saucer, but rather as a living, orange, tentacular "jellyfish-like creature," perhaps

organic but nonetheless an unidentified flying object. "After the encounter my husband and I compared notes and I was shocked to hear that what he saw was completely different. He described the creature as a thunderbird or massive Native American bird. He said it was dark in color and he could see its wings flapping. Although the size was the same the description itself was very different than mine."[3366]

Equally bizarre, those involved in the United States government's remote viewing program reported "miniature flying saucers" hovering through buildings, balls of light traversing hallways, poltergeist phenomena, and "giant birds walking through the gardens at one of the scientists' homes" while their experiments took place.[3367]

UFOs appearing as birds to some witnesses, as flying saucers to others? Aerial jellyfish and thunderbirds? Mini UFOs in the company of giant birds? Absurdity abounds. Ufologists predictably retreat to the safe catchall explanation of "screen memories," but UFOs' shapeshifting talents are well documented. From a Jungian perspective, these transformations make perfect sense: if UFOs represent exteriorized souls, it would be odd if they *didn't* appear as birds, given their shared symbolism.

Even within the craft, impressions of birds haunt abductees. Virginia Horton, whom Budd Hopkins interviewed, described various winged animals among her alien abductors, declaring "birds were very interesting" to them.[3368] One correspondent to the Striebers confessed ornithophobia stemming from ongoing abductions—pigeons were especially disturbing. "Their gray skin and huge, flat black eyes terrified me and they made soft whispering sounds."[3369]

The most celebrated bird imagery comes from Betty Andreasson, who famously beheld "the holographiclike representation of the death and rebirth of the legendary Phoenix" during a 1967 abduction.[3370] The *phoenix* is, of course, a famous solar symbol of renewal found in various mythologies where it repeatedly self-immolates, but unfailingly rises from its own ashes, born anew. No one could hope for a more obvious symbol of the human soul.

Another experiencer, Lisa, saw something similar during an alien abduction. "I looked up at the ceiling over me and saw images that looked like vultures or the phoenix bird. There seemed to be two of them... trying to chase each other off…

Then there appeared a spirit form" with "white hair and a beard." Lisa panicked and felt yanked into the clouds before returning to bed through a tunnel.[3371]

Just as birds might have once indicated faeries in disguise, today's aliens also transform into birds, both partially and entirely (some excellent examples from Strieber appear in Chapter 14). One dramatic example comes from abductee Lucretia Heart, who stumbled upon a classic Grey alien in a Pacific Northwest forest at 19 years old. Recognizing similar creatures from earlier experiences, her main source of surprise was its appearance in broad daylight, rather than the cover of night. The Grey seemed alarmed at being spotted. It immediately fled, simultaneously imposing "a very powerful image of a big white owl" into Heart's mind. The suggestion was overwhelming. "It wasn't just that I suddenly had an image in my mind of a big owl, I also had the *idea* planted firmly there as well," she recalled.[3372]

Once regarded as both death omens and psychopomps, owls are seen today as heralds of flying saucers, thanks in no small part to the work of Mike Clelland, whose thorough, thoughtful analysis shows without a doubt that the two are *somehow* connected. Superficially, owls' eyes resemble those of Greys, their silent nocturnal paths the trajectory of UFOs. Owls appear surprisingly often before, during, and after UFO contact, both as "normal" birds and grossly oversized apparitions. Most importantly, they are *messengers*, whether from the subconscious or the beyond. Clelland's output reinforces many connections found in this book—owls are not only linked to UFOs, but are profoundly important to ancient sites, shamanism, death, the divine, and, most importantly, our souls.[3373]

- **Deer.** As with owls, some draw parallels between the large, black eyes of Greys and those of deer, another psychopomp. Whereas birds often embody solar aspects, deer find lunar associations via their relationship to the goddesses Artemis (Greek) and Diana (Roman).

Since Chapter 5 explains deer's reputation as faerie animals, it is unsurprising to find them in alien abductions as well. Deer appear prominently in experiences from Katharina Wilson (Chapters 11 and 13)[3374] and Mike Stevens (Chapter 9), the latter

of whom regularly spots strange aerial lights and *multiple* white deer while driving home at night—in the wild, *one* would be rare, *two* unprecedented.[3375]

Budd Hopkins documented Ufology's most famous deer, one engaging in classic Fairy Tale behavior: leading a maiden to the Otherworld. Of her first encounter in 1950, Virginia Horton recalled gathering eggs at her grandfather's Manitoba farm when she suddenly came to, a gash on her leg bleeding underneath her untorn jeans. A decade later at age 16, Horton encountered "a beautiful deer in the woods" after mysteriously disappearing from a family picnic in France. "… it was as though I had walked out of the woods and claimed that I saw a unicorn." She returned to her family with blood on her blouse, though no wound was found.

Under hypnotic regression, Horton described wandering into the forest, where the deer "dematerialized." Short, large-headed beings then welcomed her aboard their flying saucer. A grandfatherly old "man" awaited her, a presence first met during her 1950 abduction. While the entire affair seemed quite jovial, they did extract a blood sample from Horton's nose.

Horton had the distinct impression "there was a person inside this deer" as it bade her farewell. "But it wasn't a final good-bye," she said. "It was like an 'I'll-see-you-again' good-bye."[3376]

- **Bees.** Witnesses often compare the buzzing noise that UFOs generate to swarming bees, insects regarded as psychopomps since ancient Greece. They also describe Greys as "dronelike," alluding to an insectine hierarchy, with some alien procedures likened to stings (one of Mack's subjects felt something "'like a bee bite' which caused 'a funny feeling' to run down her left shoulder and upper arm and caused her to go to sleep").[3377]

In the 1950s, author Gerald Heard published *Is Another World Watching? The Riddle of the Flying Saucers,* in which he proposed that other planets might be ruled by advanced insects, of all things. Heard so admired the communication skills of terrestrial bees that he wondered if they could "act as go-betweens" serving humans and races from other worlds.

"If we could get into touch with our bees, might not our power to communicate with them—or at least their sense that we were 'communicable,' sensible, rational, educable creatures—possibly come sometime to stand us in good stead?" he asked. Within this crackpot theory, Heard unwittingly reestablished the ancient role of bees as intercessors between the living and the dead.[3378]

Prominent Fairy Investigation Society member Marjorie Johnson brought together bees and aliens in a peculiar line of speculation. Citing Theosophical "Ancient Wisdom," Johnson wondered if bees originated on Venus.

"My contributor Mrs. Georgina K. Evason had a Venusian visitant one night, and was shown a vision of a bee in flight," she wrote. "She was told that bees travel on the humming sound vibrations just as the spaceships and flying saucers are said to do." Johnson also mentioned Rev. Flower Newhouse, who saw "a mammoth bee… a Venusian household pet" during an offworld OBE accompanying one of Theosophy's Ascended Masters. "It is interesting to note that these three foregoing references to the bee and the planet Venus come from three quite separate, independent sources," Johnson concluded.[3379]

- **Horses.** Livestock of all sorts not only serve as psychopomps across the globe, but also attract the attention of whatever intelligence lies behind their mysterious mutilations. Farmers have reported the inexplicable deaths of domesticated animals for centuries, blamed on everything from angry gods to faeries to flying saucers in the modern era. Though cows seem victimized most often, the first American livestock mutilation was actually a horse named Snippy, who in 1967 was found with her head and neck entirely stripped of flesh only two days after failing to return home.[3380]

ETH champions believe contemporary livestock mutilations represent alien experiments or DNA collection. Their true motivation, however, may be symbolic. Horse sacrifice once played an integral role in complex beliefs venerating psychopomp horses, a practice prevalent in burials of Indo-European royalty.

If UFOs' *lingua franca* is indeed symbolic, maybe livestock mutilations aren't experiments—they are *offerings*. Once we made such sacrifices ourselves; today, this

responsibility falls upon the intelligence to which we once sacrificed, i.e. death itself. Like a loyal cat leaving dead songbirds on its owner's doorstep, it prepares grave goods for us, psychopomp offerings meant for interment but instead abandoned to rot in the sun.

Just like birds, horses metaphorically stand-in for the sun—i.e. a radiant aerial disc, by transitive association a flying saucer. Horses convey riders to the Otherworld. Their large, dark eyes resemble those of Greys, and some aliens even present equine heads.[3381]

Circumstantial observations from eyewitnesses, mostly nonsensical High Strangeness, bolster this aspect. One alien abductee "was shown horses on a tiny screen, and told that they had also been 'changed.'"[3382] In September 1962, a Flossmoor, Illinois witness saw eight flying saucers above her home, one containing "someone who looked as if he were sitting on a horse."[3383] The clatter of horses' hooves allegedly accompanied a Grey alien spotted wandering a Ukrainian village in 1989.[3384]

Full-bodied horses appear in UFO reports as screen memories or transformative symbols, depending upon one's perspective. In July 1982, three witnesses in British Columbia became disoriented after spying several white horses on the opposite side of a fence; hypnotic regression suggested these were actually tall, pale humanoids from a flying saucer landed elsewhere in the field.[3385]

Abductee Nona told John Mack she was stargazing when a cloud approached, transforming into a spaceship which whisked her above the trees, then dropped her onto an "incredible white horse" without saddle or bridal. She returned to normal consciousness, unsure whether she had been dreaming or swept into a waking reverie. A thought filled her mind: "Jesus, all I need to do is ask, and I will be given anything I need to know. If I trust my true self, I can do what I need to do without reins."[3386]

Saucer dogs

The sheer volume of cases involving dogs and UFOs demands closer scrutiny. Some connections are surely coincidental: ETs allegedly hail from the *Dog Star* Sirius, the Japanese deemed falling stars *celestial dogs*, an atmospheric phenomenon called *sun dogs* explains some UFO sightings. However, man's best friend appears in conjunction with flying saucers as early as the contactee era.[3387] Jean Sider, who studied alien names in the hope they might reveal their owners' true identities, alleged that George Adamski's extraterrestrial contact Orthon derived his namesake from *Orthos*: a two-headed Greek dog, littermate to Cerberus, slain by Heracles.[3388]

The most famous "saucer dog" is Big Bo, an amiable 385-pound alien canine first encountered by Missouri resident Buck Nelson. In the 1950s, Nelson claimed he visited the moon, Mars, and Venus, all accompanied by Bo, his own dog Teddy, and the Venusian Little Bucky. During one pit stop, Nelson watched as the spacemen's children "rode Big Bo like a pony."[3389]

Whitley Strieber has compared a subset of his Visitors to dogs in recent years. In 2011, he described being awoken by the sensation of "a pack of feral dogs" lingering underneath his bed.[3390]

"I have only glimpsed them," Strieber elaborated in 2020. "I can say that they are very small, about the size of a miniature terrier. They are not dogs, but they run in packs and race around at breakneck speed." He also mentioned in passing a "long interaction" with a black dog in 2019. It "was

not a physical experience, but it was powerful," imparting the impression of "a careful and penetrating mind."[3391]

Strieber's apparition and Big Bo would be right at home keeping pace with travelers on a lonely lane in the British Isles. Animals resembling faerie dogs —Black Shuck, Barguest, etc.—appear with startling regularity alongside UFOs and in window areas like America's Skinwalker Ranch and Marley Woods, or Rendlesham Forest and Cannock Chase in the U.K. Consider a few selections:

- In April 1897—concurrent with the infamous airship wave rocking America at the turn of the century—the city marshal of Farmersville, Texas saw a strange vehicle in the sky, aboard which he spotted a pair of men and "something resembling a large Newfoundland dog" onboard. He believed they were "Spaniards."[3392]

- In 1966, drivers hoping to spot UFOs above Eliot, Maine instead glimpsed an enormous, dark dog from their parked car. As they ran after it, a shadowy, odorous figure approached the last witness in line, who fled back to the vehicle. By the time his friends found him, he seemed delirious, demanding to return to the site of his encounter, but was restrained.[3393]

- Another witness in 1966 reported a reddish-brown greyhound which entered her bedroom, trailed by a dozen beings in hooded monks' robes. They performed surgery on her head with a golden needle, leaving a lingering headache. Two weeks later, a similar, singular presence made "mental" love to the witness and showed her visions of an underwater city.[3394]

- On September 9, 1973, "ten big, black hairy dogs" left a landed flying saucer to cavort among the dead in Savannah, Georgia's Laurel Grove Cemetery. The craft doused its light after landing.[3395]

- In 1982, John Keel described a Long Island, New York incident where "'hundreds of dogs, of all sizes and breeds' block[ed] roads and converg[ed] on a field where UFOs had previously been seen."[3396]

- A Spanish witness stumbled upon a large, black dog escorting two Greys towards a landed flying saucer in 1986. (The same "Spaniards" seen in Texas almost a century earlier?)[3397]

- In 1993, David Jacobs wrote of an abductee who "saw a wolf in her bedroom one night. The wolf was standing squarely on her bed looking her in the eyes. She clearly remembered its fur, fangs, and eyes."[3398]

- In late 2005, alien abductee Mike Stevens found himself fully dressed in the middle of the night, "waiting for something" outside his house. Boredom eventually led him around to the front door, where a basketball-sized ghost light waited, hovering two or three feet above the grass. As soon as he made eye contact, the light rose to shoulder height, and a message filled his mind: "This is a big white dog and it's about to pounce on you." Stevens braced for impact… but none came. Opening his eyes, he discovered he was enveloped in blue light, floating 15 feet above the ground. "Next thing I know, I woke up in bed screaming."[3399]

- Kristin, an NDEr and lifelong experiencer of UFOs and OBEs, shared with Mike Clelland a period of time when she and her live-in boyfriend endured activity highly suggestive of alien abduction: strange scoop marks on her body, night terrors, bright lights flooding the bedroom, etc. Their memory the night of the lights is jumbled, but Kristin's boyfriend clearly remembered seeing a pack of large, black dogs through the window, writhing in an eerie dance.[3400]

Another story Clelland collected involved Bert Jannsen, a Dutch researcher and UFO witness who, along with his wife Heather Clewett-Jachowski, organized a tour of British sacred sites. The couple debated whether or not to take the group in search of crop circles. After some discussion, they decided to scout a location for the following day, one popular among crop circle enthusiasts. On the way there, they almost hit a pair of white birds with their car and, shortly thereafter, an owl started traveling just ahead of them, as if leading them somewhere. The owl disappeared, then reappeared on a fencepost, leaving Heather with the impression "she was *seeing through the eyes of the owl*," much as a shaman might. When her normal awareness returned, the couple was at Knob Hill, a completely different destination than intended.[3401]

The owl reappeared *again* on the drive home, leading them to a dirt road where they stopped the car. That's when Heather saw a "huge black, wild looking cat-dog animal that came out of the South Field and crossed the road." The creature had a large, blocky head, pointed ears, and red, glowing eyes. The following morning, she was shocked when a tour participant showed her a book of British legends depicting "the Hounds of Hell"—an exact match for her sighting the evening prior.[3402]

As with other animal psychopomps appearing in the company of UFOs, plenty more tidbits hint at saucer dogs, but trying to discern their meaning proves frustrating. During his investigation of Point Pleasant, West Virginia's "TNT area"—ground zero for the Mothman incident—John Keel found a large, solitary, bare footprint accompanied by "huge dog tracks… so deep the animal who made them must have weighed two hundred pounds or more." He was perplexed.[3403]

Similarly bewildering are the visions of Ed Walters, primary witness (and later hoaxer) of the Gulf Breeze UFO case. After snapping a picture of a flying saucer on November 11, 1987, Walters claimed a blue beam paralyzed him and lifted him off the ground. An unpleasant odor arose as a computerized voice filled his head: "We will not harm you." What followed were images of dogs, "flashing… just as if they were turning the pages of a book."[3404]

Perhaps these clues amount to nothing. Some, like David Jacobs, assume the dogs are screen memories, as in the wolf example above. This was also Katharina Wilson's reaction. Like most of her abductions, her memory is vague and dreamlike: she remembered traversing a hallway terminating in a window overlooking "a typical English landscape" populated by large, grey dogs. "These things are aliens trying to camouflage their true appearance!" she realized as one of them charged the window.[3405]

If not screen memories, then perhaps we are dealing with psychopomps. Wilson's pastoral landscape, of course, resembles any number of afterlife descriptions. Dogs are profound psychopomp symbols, more so than we

realize. In alchemical tradition, dogs symbolize *mercury*, a metal named after the Roman psychopomp.[3406]

Other saucer dogs act like psychopomps by literally *guiding* abductees into the Great Beyond. One abductee, Carol, remembered "an imaginary dog who took me for walks *to places where children couldn't go* [author's emphasis]."[3407]

Another interviewed by Kenneth Ring recalled following her dog deep into a forest as a five-year-old girl. Her pet acted as if "he was following someone or something." The entire community turned out to search for the girl, who only under hypnotic regression remembered being examined by a trio of men aboard a "spacecraft." Her way out of the woods was guided by an orb of light.[3408]

"Where was my dog during my experience?" she later wondered. "He seemed to lead me in but he was nowhere around when I awoke on the ground."[3409]

The most famous case connecting anomalous dogs, aliens, and the dead is Alan Godfrey's abduction, first mentioned in Chapter 13. On November 28, 1980 Godfrey, a policeman in Todmorden, England, saw a domed shape on the road ahead, spinning and thrashing the vegetation below. Simultaneously terrified and compelled, Godfrey unsuccessfully tried radioing his station—and was suddenly a hundred yards down the road, the object nowhere to be found.[3410]

Snippets of memory coalesced under hypnosis, turning into a 15 minute alien abduction. After failing to start his car, Godfrey was hit with a beam of

light, lost consciousness, and floated into the craft. Now in a round room, Godfrey met eight short robots led by a man named "Joseph" with "a biblical appearance": bearded, mustached, and wearing a skull cap.[3411]

A large black dog was also in attendance. "Well, I think it's a dog," he recalled. "Horrible. Just looks like a dog. Like the size of an Alsatian."[3412]

Joseph spoke telepathically with Godfrey as the robots examined his toes, telling him they had met previously. Godfrey suddenly recalled several odd events from his life, beginning with a light orb seen in his childhood. He also remembered hitting a woman walking her black dog with his car when he was 18, but when he stopped, he found no trace of them; Godfrey returned home with two hours missing. Finally, and most pertinently, Godfrey caught up with an old friend a decade before his abduction, only to learn after their conversation that he had passed away months prior.[3413]

“The ones who control the movement of souls”

In addition to their correlations with psychopomp deities and animals, a mountain of circumstantial evidence implies aliens somehow *guide us* through liminality, the transitional periods of life up to and including death. Anyone doubting the extent to which we have elevated our extraterrestrial saviors need only look at how alien abductees speak of their ET handlers.

Many deem them “spirit guides,” quietly leading them through life since early childhood, their assumptions bolstered by claims directly from aliens themselves. The Rosales database details dozens of beings in spaceships identifying as personal guides, guardians, and protectors, stretching back into Ufology’s earliest days.

For instance, contactee Calvin Girvin’s Venusian contact Cryxtan bade him farewell in 1954 with the charge, “Follow your inner thoughts. You will be well-guided from now on and your service to us will be outstanding and important.”[3414] Nearly 40 years later, Kelly Cahill “got the idea” that the oddly familiar being from her abduction “was like the keeper of [her] soul.”[3415]

These sentiments are not isolated. 69% of FREE study respondents agreed that their “UFO experiences were ‘arranged’ or ‘designed’ by a higher intelligence,” while 62% “believe that there is a higher power guiding my life,” with aliens playing roles in both.[3416]

Common wisdom holds religious thought is so ingrained in humanity that even atheists succumb to spiritual instincts. We are programmed to tribalize, joining others elevating the same ideals, be it Christianity, Scientology, the New Age, or Environmentalism. Perhaps this partially explains the recent resurgence of ancient alien speculation—it scratches the "God itch" in a way modern Materialism tolerates.

Even when not espousing ancient alien tropes, many abductees succumb to religious impulses. Some claim their dire eschatological warnings can only be avoided by the elect, those lucky few who will be saved following nuclear Armageddon by the extraterrestrial rapture or raised from the dead, Second Coming-style. Antonio Tosca's 1983 abduction from Santa Catarina, Brazil, for example, left him with the conviction that extraterrestrial "great masters would return, earth would become a paradise and a machine would raise the dead."[3417]

Tosca's dramatic prediction speaks to how we grant aliens supernatural dominion over life and death, another psychopomp trait. Several examples from previous chapters, including the Walton abduction, imply extraterrestrials can reanimate the dead. Given the similarity of alien abductions to other contact modalities—experiences which predominately skirt the border between life and death—the question arises: do *all* abductions fall upon a "near-death spectrum"? Is *every* alien abductee returned from the dead?

This stance seems a bit extreme, a bit reductive. Its appeal, if it has any, arises from our lack of linguistic tools to describe the numinous. A more conservative claim asserts these experiences occur *when the soul leaves the*

body; while all souls vacate when we die, not every visit to the astral realm means death is involved.

Recall Strieber's estimate of his kobolds: they "control the *movement* of souls," not death alone. Strieber's idea was likely influenced by his associate Lorie Barnes, who believed the Visitors represented "soul techs," commonly identifying as "doctors" taking a "look at your soul."[3418]

Caught red-handed

If this logic is correct, it stands to reason these "soul techs" would be involved in the most dramatic of all events, our journey to the other side. A handful of experiencers have come to the same conclusion over the years. As mentioned earlier, Elaine Thomas believed the strange lights surrounding her just prior to her death were UFO entities—not mere observers, but "coming to get [her]."[3419] Similar lights above his deathbed led Howard Menger's son to the same interpretation: "They are from Orion and are coming to take me away" (Chapter 13).[3420]

"I had another feeling at the time, which I have not written about, like they were collecting souls of the dead," said a member of an Australian television team after filming intense UFO sightings above New Zealand in late 1978. "They were far more psychic than anything."[3421]

Some surviving indigenous beliefs equate extraterrestrials with psychopomps in all but name. After her mother's fatal heart attack, the daughter of one of Ardy Sixkiller Clarke's informants "believed the star ancestors had come to take her mother home, but there was no way of proving it." Another indigenous informant from Alaska told Clarke that her grandfather claimed the Star People "come for you" when you "cross over," taking both spirit *and* body.[3422]

Comparison, speculation, and belief are one thing, but as the adage goes, actions speak louder than words. We have already noted several ways in

which the behavior of UFOs and their occupants resemble psychopomps, from their tricksterish nature to appearances alongside the dead. Even the "tractor beams" with which flying saucers ensnare abductees resemble psychopomp tools.

"Hel is thought of as having a rope," Edgar Herzog wrote, "and Yama, the Indian god of death, has either a net or a noose of rope with which he captures souls… One could multiply examples, but the Sirens deserve particular mention… their name is derived from the Greek *seira* or *seire* which means 'rope,' 'noose,' or 'lasso.'"[3423]

A few stories suggest aliens are sometimes caught "red-handed" interacting with the dying.

- Albert Rosales collected a case in which 13-year-old Laudelino Ortiz heard strange murmurs while exploring the Puerto Rican forest in 1947. From his hiding spot, he watched a trio of beings—classic Greys—carrying a strange, transparent, crystalline object uncannily resembling a coffin. The otherworldly pallbearers marched into the woods opposite the trail before Ortiz fled.[3424]

- Fortean author F.W. Holiday drew direct comparisons between psychopomps and two 1965 sightings along a notoriously dangerous stretch of road in Wiltshire. In the first, motorists barely dodged what appeared to be an accident victim in the road just before seeing two large spheres, one orange and aerial, the other dark and near the ground, accompanied by a pair of humanoids wearing dark suits and headgear.

The next month a similar being was observed in the area in conjunction with "a naked, blood-covered youth," both of whom disappeared by the time the driver turned around to investigate. Holiday found it curious these individuals who "seem to have died violently are seen in close proximity to masked or hooded figures… doing exactly what Scandinavian [Valkyrie] lore suggests—mounting a sort of lifeboat operation for the benefit of humans traumatically recapitulating the tragic circumstances of their deaths…."[3425]

- Whitley Strieber related the story of one Jo Sharp who met seven short aliens described as "Chinese mushrooms" just prior to her death in late 1986. In her words, each wore wide-brimmed "coolie" hats and suits of various colors. The beings offered "words of comfort," touching her with their "slimy and soft" hands. One wearing yellow, the leader, instructed the others to lift her to the ceiling. Sharp resisted, but suddenly found herself "in a verdant park" effused with the setting sun's rays. There she received a blue silken robe (traditional Chinese garments for the deceased) and returned to bed, where she passed out.

"Upon regaining consciousness she found herself to be in her own bed," wrote close family friend Yensoon Tfai. "After this episode, Mrs. Sharp's condition declined rapidly" and she succumbed to diabetes complications and liver cancer. [3426]

- According to Penny Smith, the blond Nordic aliens from her abductions told her they "assist people at death to minimize the fear, disorientation and trauma," but sometimes enlist "ascended humans" to help.[3427] (Curiously, a North Carolinian informant described the Little People seen by terminally-ill Cherokee as "blond-heads").[3428]

- In 1990, a Ukrainian grandmother was riding the bus with her grandson when a flying saucer started following them. The craft was spotted again at home, and after a time the grandmother fell asleep in a chair. She was awakened when her grandson ran inside and yelled, "Grandma, the flying saucer has come for you!" Unnerved, they eventually went to bed without incident until she awoke in a

strange location. Before her stood a young, beautiful woman who said she wished to "take her soul" to another planet. She declined and fell asleep.[3429]

- During her investigation of a crop circle which mysteriously vanished near Knobel, Arkansas, JoAnne Scarpellini learned that a local, elderly Mason had claimed his entire life to be an alien, evidenced by his penchant for "knowing things."

"Upon his death he would be claimed by, and taken away by, aliens," she wrote. Regarded as a crackpot, his funeral on June 6, 2003 in Bond Cemetery involved a Masonic ritual. Multiple witnesses claimed the ceremony drew clouds, thunder, and lightning to the burial site, but no rainfall. The weather cleared upon completion.

"Then Saturday morning, the next day, the crop formation was found about 400 feet from the cemetery"—the same one which later disappeared.[3430]

- Alien abductee Alberto confided to Michael Carter that a tall, bearded, tunic-wearing being had taken him to the edge of death itself. The presence manifested in Alberto's living room, telling him it had been researching death. Alberto found himself in a full-fledged NDE, his soul leaving his body to race down a tunnel towards a steadily growing white light.

"The being then stopped him from entering the bright light but told him that when he is dead, he is instructed to go through the bright light and not to stop," Carter wrote. "Alberto then found himself back in his living room, but the 7-foot-tall human-looking being was gone."[3431]

- Many of Steve Boucher's encounters suggest the aliens interacting with him are psychopomps. In one experience, a Grey identified itself as something akin to a "gate-keeper" whose responsibilities included overseeing souls "coming and going from the earth." The being had brought Boucher to a "high place" to prepare him for reincarnation, and offered to ease his anxiety by allowing him to speak with "a

soul who just returned from there." (This story, which involves Boucher's "prebirth memories," is revisited in the next chapter.)[3432]

- Speaking with abductee Will, John Mack learned a brush with death elicited a stern response from his aliens: "This little shit is going to do this as often as he can, bring it right to the brink… the little shit knows that we're not going to let him die, that we're not done yet."[3433]

- Raymond Fowler collected a report from a nurse where a "deathly ill" elderly patient "awakened to see a group of small gray creatures with big heads standing around her bed. They seemed to be examining her." As she fully emerged from sleep, she started, and the beings vanished.[3434]

Taken in conjunction with previous chapters and the three appendices, these anecdotes lend further credence to the possibility that whatever we call "extraterrestrials" are in fact involved in the dying process.

A vast majority of researchers still resist the notion. From its earliest days, sci-fi thinking seized the "scientific discipline" of Ufology, and the idea of psychopomp aliens became undesirable. Anyone ascribing aliens power over life and death was pushed to the earliest speaker slot at conferences, their booths the rear of the vendors' area, just past the restrooms, between the airbrushed UFO license plates and the guy selling alien-repelling helmets.

Ufologists can diminish these accounts as much as they wish, but they aren't going away. Eyewitness testimony should be heard, *especially* when it

contradicts our cherished biases.

In truth, the comparison to psychopomps is so powerful that it doesn't even matter if UFOs exist at all. "Our rational-scientific side has buried our unconscious (psychic) side, and the soul is fighting back with the UFO myth," Barry Downing offered.[3435]

On a metaphoric level, the UFO leads ideas out of imagination and into our lives by embarking on a journey of katabasis deep into our Collective Unconscious—the Underworld, destination of psychopomps—and returning into the light of awareness with our latent fears, hopes, and dreams in tow. No one can declare with certainty whether consciousness persists beyond death, but in the flying saucer we are reassured that somewhere, something else endures.

The war in heaven

Though it may seem gauche, thoroughness compels us to raise the possibility of ulterior motives behind UFO contact. A standard Judeo-Christian interpretation of alien abductions, popular among American Evangelicals, blames the phenomenon on demonic activity, especially negative interactions. Accordingly, positive UFO occupants become misidentified angels.

The resemblance so-called extraterrestrials bear to angels or demons is beyond debate—wiser folklorists and Forteans have mined their similarities *ad nauseum*, many of them inferable from previous chapters. Abrahamic texts chronicling "Watchers" and "Nephilim" read like extraterrestrial intervention, aliens and demons manifest similar odors,[3436] people use the same methods to repel both aliens and demons, etc.[3437]

Reasserting these observations at length would not only prove redundant, but would undermine this book's primary focus (these connections can be explored in the work of researchers like Guy Malone, Joe Jordan, or Barry Downing). Our interest lies not in a laundry list of correspondences between aliens, angels, and demons, but rather in what said correspondences imply about the ecology of souls: primarily, are we dealing with *guides* or *harvesters*?

The war in heaven:

Angels

"If we want to believe that the mysterious light forms are heavenly messengers of God, then this is what we will see in their name," mused Andrew Collins. "Yet today such religious conviction has mostly given way to mechanistic views of the world, in which phenomena of this sort are the vehicles of space aliens, the reason why we have come to consider that manifesting light forms, so-called UFOs, are nuts-and-bolts spacecraft."[3438]

Should they prove interchangeable, angels' evolution into aliens clearly encourages interpreting the latter as psychopomps. Even if "guardian angels" are aspects of ourselves—a popular notion in New Age belief—this statement holds true, as the Higher Self can also fulfill the psychopomp role, shown in the Zoroastrian Daēnā guiding the Lower Self into the afterlife. Just like faeries leading travelers astray, or UFOs enticing abductees down isolated roads, guardian angels have a reputation for subconsciously nudging us into fated situations and locations, changing lives in the process.

"Subliminal urges from one's Higher Self for acting on some transcendental agenda… come in various and sometimes devious ways," wrote Robert H. Coddington. "Perhaps most commonly, one is hit by an unexpected urge—perhaps even a nagging one—to undertake some action that hasn't been thought of or seriously considered at the conscious-mind level."[3439]

At the risk of preempting the next chapter, combining angels, aliens, and ourselves certainly streamlines these phenomena's complexity, reframing telepathy in an interesting way: the "voice" of the alien is already inside your head, hence their frequent fluency in witnesses' native tongues. We find rough correlation in theophany's warning that perceiving the divine carries inherent danger—thus, teachings where angels serve not only as messengers of God, but serve as the actual Voice of God, lest direct contact cause inadvertent harm (possibly inferred from Exodus 20:19: "… do not have God speak to us or we will die"). Telepathy could be a clever technique to circumvent the risks of divine communication.

Combining angels and the self admittedly contradicts religious tradition. They are typically discrete entities. That humans could be angels, or even *become* them after death, is another Swedenborgian fantasy (although the belief that ancestors can intercede between Heaven and Earth is universal).

Rather, Abrahamic angels are overtly non-human, and above all *weird*: they are covered in eyes, a motif which, albeit to a less extreme level, still dominates flying saucer lore. The Biblical angelic salutation—"Be not afraid"—is actually more commonly reported in UFO encounters than "Take me to your leader" ever has been.

The war in heaven:

Demons

The trope of warring extraterrestrial factions tidily fits the angel-demon dichotomy, as do the diametrically opposed natures of Space Brothers (or Nordics) and Greys. Less literally, this conflict is embedded within each of us, the fundamental struggle between good and evil at the heart of every person. To that end, it seems reasonable—especially if angels are our Higher Selves—that demons might signify our lowest, basest components.

This, of course, is roughly where the term originates. As explained in Chapter 3, the Greek daimon or daemon was originally morally ambivalent, and had strong connotations with the self. Christianity demonized daemons, lumping them together with malevolent spirits from the Middle East.[3440] Psychology marginally reclaimed daemons when Sigmund Freud and Carl Jung proposed we each possess a "shadow self," unconscious but not inherently evil. To Jung, the unacceptable aspects of one's personality were prone to projection, manifesting at both individual and societal levels.[3441]

"The psychic totality, the self, is a combination of opposites," Jung wrote. "Without a shadow even the self is not real. It always has two aspects, a bright and a dark…."[3442]

Are demons a facet of ourselves? Physicalized doubles like doppelgängers are capable of alien or evil actions. Even if harboring no ill will, doubles still

precede death. If demons (by extension negative aliens) *are* part of ourselves, this may somewhat explain the oppressive fear found in many encounters. The experience would naturally parallel our internal disposition, rendering frightening abductions not negative by nature, but mere reflections of the fearful part within us. To use a psychedelic metaphor, our mindset provides the "set and setting" for these encounters.

A popular interpretation maintains these encounters are frightful because the entities involved somehow "feed" upon base emotions. This view hews closer to traditional Abrahamic demons which, instead of aspects of ourselves, are wholly exterior, independent forces.

Though conceptualized in Christianity as fallen angels loyal to Satan, demonic origins worldwide are as varied as the cultures in which they appear: everything from anthropomorphized emotions to "death energy" to the evil dead are demonized. Even psychopomps themselves earn the title, evidenced by Edgar Herzog's use of the phrase "death-*demons*" in *Psyche & Death*, a work referenced extensively in this and previous chapters.

If some of the above origins sound familiar, it is because they were regularly attributed to fae folk. Though some Theosophists and New Agers equate angels and faeries, this is historically a minority stance.[3443] The Christian church quickly ensured that anything it could not claim as a saint became a demon, including spirits of place and minor deities. Faeries' habit of consorting with members of the community outside the church (e.g. cunning folk, witches, and indigenous populations) did little to improve their reputation in Christian eyes.[3444]

In Iceland, for example, "with Christianity came full hostility between the new faith and the old," wrote Einar Ólafur Sveinsson. "The Church further introduced a whole new world, teaching the existence of Satan and devils and Hell, and a great deal of new magic came with these concepts from the European mainland. The old beliefs and the darker Christian superstitions entered into partnership, each influencing the other, but they did not coalesce until much later, and then only in part."[3445]

Because demonology has paralleled faerie belief for so long, it is nigh-impossible to distinguish the two in many instances. Faeries were slandered as fallen angels. Medieval and early modern belief blamed them for illness,[3446] possession,[3447] and soul theft. Faeries tormented clergy with a zealotry matched only by hellspawn, and the devil himself appropriated the hirsute bodies and cloven hooves of *satyrs* and *fauns*.[3448] Numerous qualities shared between aliens and demons listed above are equally attributable to fae folk: they kidnap, retreat underground, flee at the sight of crosses, iron, prayers, salt, etc.[3449]

None of this means faeries *are* demons, only that Christianity's rigid structure offered no room for a liminal category between the living and the dead, to say nothing of betwixt angels and demons. A reading of actual faerie beliefs (and by presumed extension, aliens) suggests they are mostly ambivalent actors in the ecology of souls.

"Even those who saw fairies as demons, however, tended to class them separately from the demons who served Lucifer in Hell," explained Morgan Daimler. "In this view there were two distinct classes of demons: a lesser

group who might punish men and cause mischief, but rarely did great evil, and a greater group who were truly malevolent and destructive."[3450]

The idea that demons could be spirits of evil humans is not widespread in contemporary popular culture, which eschews malevolent ghosts in favor of spirits which never lived. The belief is actually quite widespread, adding an additional level of complexity and ambiguity to our discussion: if demons could be the dead… and the dead could be faeries… and faeries could be aliens—then aliens, by the transitive property, could be demons.

The same mechanism by which the dead became land spirits (Chapter 4) allowed anyone of significantly poor reputation to become a devil. Criminals executed or buried on unhallowed land, often the same abandoned pagan spaces conceded to fae folk, rendered differentiating spirits from faeries, demons, or the dead ambiguous. Ne'er-do-wells faded into local legend as malicious spirits of place, demonstrating the same proclivities and abilities afforded to all non-humans like shapeshifting.[3451]

"The distinction between demon spirits and demonic ghosts is hard to draw," wrote faerie folklorist Katharine Briggs. Quintessential European examples include Glam from the Icelandic saga *Grettir the Strong*; the Roaring Bull of Bagbury, a wicked Shropshire man's spirit which transformed into a demonic bovid; and the Great Giant of Henllys, a rich Welshman who terrorized churches as a "terrible monster" after death, proclaiming, "I was bad as a man, and I am worse now as a devil."[3452]

These beliefs were once common worldwide. "Another category of demons are created every day from the newly dead, who were believed to linger about in close contact with the living," wrote Rosemary Ellen Guiley of Jewish

belief. "The spirits of the wicked dead became demons."[3453] Superstitions "that a man who dies a sudden or violent death, becomes a demon" were as common in India as in Europe.[3454] Demarcations between angry ghosts and what we would call demons often blurred in Hellenic stories: *goetia*, the magical summoning of spirits, originates in Greco-Roman necromancy.[3455]

In fact, Freud felt demons betrayed our secret feelings toward death, writing, "The fact that demons are always regarded as the spirits of those who have died recently shows better than anything the influence of mourning on the origin of the belief in demons."[3456]

Ergo, anyone claiming extraterrestrials are demons in disguise might as well say they are the evil dead.

The war in heaven:

Soul harvesters

The hypnotic regression of Gerry Armstrong's Chapter 11 missing time event revealed a curious detail: after entering the UFO, a red-dressed woman approached him and ripped the cross from his necklace. "It's not right to worship," she scolded.[3457]

Armstrong's encounter speaks to the longstanding ambivalence "faeliens" exhibit towards the Christian God. In a 16th century account from Sicily, a witch described how as a child she had pledged herself before faerie royalty. With her allegiance, she received great fortune in exchange for sexual intercourse as long as she refrained, as the king and queen explicitly warned her, from worshipping God or the Virgin Mary.[3458]

Around the 13th century, a man skipping Sunday mass stumbled upon an isolated locale "filled with powers of the air," (sylphs, perhaps?) "all of them small like dwarfs with deformed features, and dressed as abbots." Presiding over these demons, much like a faerie queen or a supervising Grey, was "one taller than the others, who was dressed as a priest." The dwarfs chided the man for missing mass before beginning their own ceremony. Ominous mumbles rose as their leader splashed each with holy water "as a punishment for their guilt." Reaching the interloper, he administered "not water droplets but blows."[3459]

These encounters suggest that at least some extraterrestrials, faeries, and demons believe we "should" be worshipping pagan deities or, more ominously, malevolent forces. In early Christian thought, the two were interchangeable, leading some to argue faeries actively worshipped Satan.[3460] Recall the faeries from the Cornish "Selena Moor" story, condemned for their "star worship," and consider the Solomonic magical perspective that demons "live in stars and constellations."[3461] (The theme continues today, of course. Not only are demons thralls to the Dark Lord, but some alien abductees claim their captors worship "not Jehovah; they worship Satan."[3462])

These factors can be interpreted several ways depending on one's convictions. A more charitable reading holds these entities simply stand in opposition to Abrahamic religion, not malicious, but simply aligned differently in the ecology of souls. Modern pagans would likely find this conclusion most attractive.

On the other hand, anyone raised in the church perceives an obviously sinister agenda. A majority of this book interprets UFO phenomena as positive, or at least neutral. Yet a great deal of contact seems unambiguously negative, at least on face value; as discussed in Chapter 12, the lack of consent in alien abductions is particularly distressing. Therefore—*without endorsing any interpretation's or religion's superiority*—it seems only fair to discuss the possibility that these interactions are negative, to literally play "devil's advocate," if you will.

This is especially relevant because, outside ETH-centric convictions that aliens plan on conquering the planet, negative perspectives on UFOs are overwhelmingly preoccupied with the sovereignty of our souls. As discussed

in our next (and final) chapter on UFOs, extraterrestrials are sometimes blamed for possession, an accusation more often reserved for demons. Simon Harvey-Wilson summarized Barry Downing's four demonic hypotheses of UFOs and alien abductions thusly:

> The first, which he calls the 'secular-scientific theory,' claims that technologically advanced aliens masquerading as divine beings have provided us with misleading religious beliefs... Secondly, Downing refers to the 'secular-psychic' theory which suggests that, by becoming too technologically minded, humanity has repressed another equally important part of itself within its unconscious. This part is now attempting to redress the resulting imbalance by manifesting UFO and abduction events... Downing's third theory is a 'secular-supernatural' one which he largely attributes to Keel who suggests that aliens with powerful paranormal abilities originate from another dimension and tend to regard humans as a form of amusement, which means that we would have great difficulty meeting them on equal terms or believing what they tell us... Fourthly, Downing proposes the 'religious-supernatural' theory which claims that aliens are entirely the work of the devil and have been "set loose on Earth in preparation for the end and the Second Coming of Christ."[3463]

Thankfully, Harvey-Wilson hastens to add that Downing's hypotheses "seem to be partly the product of a limited religious perspective."[3464] They are also incomplete, proposing origins rather than motivations—for instance, exactly how alien abductions "prepare for Armageddon" remains unclear. To that end, researchers have proposed diverse ideas, including the notion that flying saucers are here to sow doubt in Christ's mission, spread tragedy, or engage in vaguely-defined spiritual warfare. Each has its own strengths and weaknesses.

The most compelling evidence, however, points to an agenda shared with the fae folk: the harvesting of human souls. This premise—which clearly repurposes Chapter 5's "faerie teind to hell"—perverts the traditional psychopomp role. Instead of leading souls peacefully to the afterlife, extraterrestrials intercept souls, leading them astray for their own nefarious ends.

In addition to European faerie lore, soul-harvesting aliens are prefigured in legends like the Japanese *katawaguruma* yokai, who is not only a nude, dead-woman-cum-demon, but manifests the flying saucer motif by appearing as a large, flaming wheel which *steals impure souls*.[3465] More broadly speaking, another variation on the harvest theme, the soul-devourer, appears in diverse mythologies around the world, notably as the Egyptian crocodile-hippopotamus-lion deity Ammit.

Smatterings of the consumption/harvest motif appear throughout Ufology's history. John Lear, once a fixture of the discipline, famously believed the moon housed a "soul collector."[3466] In the 1970s, the impressive UFO experiences of Brian Scott took a sinister turn when, via automatic writing, an extraterrestrial intelligence offered his wife "all the money in the world. It only wanted one thing in return—her soul."[3467] Famed flying saucer whistleblower Bob Lazar confirmed in an interview with George Knapp that aliens view humans as mere vessels, perhaps "containers of souls."[3468]

Soul-devouring was a major concern Whitley Strieber expressed early in his contact with the Visitors. Despite his overall positive evaluation of UFO contact, John Mack admitted that some alien abductees fear their extraterrestrial handlers "want to take their souls from them." To varying

degrees Mack's subjects described the existential terror that their consciousness might "cease to exist" in the presence of these entities.[3469]

By far the most robust mythologization comes from researcher Nigel Kerner, whose interesting, albeit selective perspective perfectly mirrors the faerie teind to the devil. His unambiguously-titled *Grey Aliens and the Harvesting of Souls* argues that Greys appearing in NDEs wish to intercept our souls, and the afterlife "tunnel" is in fact a quantum soul vacuum of sorts, to which ignorant, "heavier" souls are especially susceptible. "Lighter" enlightened souls can escape this attractive force. If not harvested, heavier souls fall into a darker spectrum, enduring as ghosts.[3470]

According to his assistant Danielle Silverman, Kerner suspected our souls "might be a derivational information field that comes out of a natural cadence that came into the Universe with the big bang. This field holds the power to maintain information in what he called a morphogenetic electro-spatial field...." The Greys, artificial inventions themselves, see within our divine spark a reflection of their superior progenitor race, and wish to combine our souls with their own soulless bodies for both metaphysical and practical reasons, perhaps as power sources.[3471]

The idea that Greys somehow lack souls ties into suggestions from previous chapters that their race is somehow stunted, either by dint of their robotic origin or their technological overreach. Their need for our souls is a metaphysical variation on the idea that their race is dying and requires our genetic material.

Kerner does not hold a monopoly on this idea. In addition to precedents from faerie and vampire lore, it runs through Ufological thought. "They've

got no souls," Kelly Cahill recalled in a flashback of her 1993 abduction.[3472] A 1962 New Hampshire abduction left its victim with the impression that the aliens' "primary needs are our minds, spirit and soul. They could produce bodies, but not souls."[3473]

The following chapter's discussion of female alien abductees nursing human-alien hybrids in "baby presentations" indicates the extraterrestrial interest lies not in actual nourishment, but something less tangible. Even mothers who fail to lactate are encouraged to pantomime breastfeeding, to which the infants sometimes react favorably, perhaps indicating some sort of "energetic" transfer.[3474] Strieber's latest thinking holds that the Visitors predate on the energetic body, a variation on the "hungry ghost" concept.[3475]

The war in heaven:

Final Events

These ideas sound patently absurd—yet, for all the alleged ETH obsession dominating governmental circles, at least one faction of authorities seriously entertained the idea that UFOs visit Earth seeking human souls. Nick Redfern's groundbreaking 2010 book *Final Events* unearthed the eschatological ethos surrounding the "Collins Elite," a shadowy faction embedded within the United States government. It is perhaps *the* definitive work connecting aliens to demons, and comes highly recommended.

According to Redfern's informants, the loose confederacy of the Collins Elite began pursuing the demonic connection to UFOs after information came to light linking Jack Parsons—father of modern rocketry and founder of NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratories—to infamous magician Aleister Crowley. Crowley's influence on Parsons's occult practice is now a matter of public record. The Collins Elite perceived a disturbing "coincidence" in the timing of Parsons's 1946 "Babalon Working" and the rise of the modern UFO era in 1947. Parsons opened a door, they thought, perhaps only barely cracked previously, which flooded our reality with negative, deceptive entities from beyond.[3476]

The Collins Elite (named for a New York demonologist who was recruited early on) eventually drew many conclusions arrived at in previous chapters: the UFO phenomenon trafficked in theatrical symbolism; was somehow tied

to the astral realm; and was far more communicative via altered states of consciousness than through technological means. By the late 1960s and early '70s, concerns emerged that UFOs sought to "derail the train to Heaven." Even though Christianity roughly served as their guiding framework, there remained "the nagging suspicion that religion and history did not tell the *whole* story."[3477]

"The role of the entities, they by now largely fully accepted—even if conventional Christian teaching did not—was to assist in the capture and utilization by even stranger, hellish beings of an admittedly poorly-defined energy extracted from human souls," Redfern wrote. These "deceptive, demonic" beings were "somehow connected with the realm of the dead and the afterlife," perhaps paving the way for the ascendancy of the Antichrist himself.[3478]

Although ostensibly disbanded, prevailing wisdom holds there is no such thing as a "temporary" government program, and Redfern asserted vestiges of the Collins Elite survived up until his book's publication; presumably, its acolytes scattered to play background roles in today's trendy UAP research.[3479] Flying saucer fans insisting that UFOs are wholly nuts-and-bolts craft piloted by extraterrestrials fail to comprehend the delicious irony that government officials—the same authorities they are convinced "know" the "true nature" of their beloved UAP—still embrace what are by all definitions "occult" viewpoints and practices, including remote viewing.

Labeling flying saucers and their occupants angels or demons constitutes a shallow, selective interpretation of the phenomenon. Yet as frustrating as this reductivism can be, it aligns more closely with an ecology of souls

perspective, and as such should not be dismissed outright. That whatever lies behind the UFO phenomenon *may* exert a negative influence over our souls seems highly likely, but that should not be taken as condemnation of contact as a whole. Anyone living in the turbulent 2020s can see the dark places where "all or nothing" thinking leads.

To reiterate Chapter 12's conclusion, a more suitable approach lies in understanding alien morality on a spectrum, not unlike the faeries—some are positively predisposed, others negative, a vast majority persuadable either way. To borrow a pop-culture reference, consider the "alignment charts" popular in roleplaying games, outlining a matrix of character affiliations: good, evil, and neutral, each with their own subsets of lawfulness, chaos, and neutrality. (Despite this nuance, roleplaying games themselves were mired in race essentialism for decades: an orc was always evil, an elf always good, etc. It is a narrow way to view the world, and the community has since reevaluated this stance.)

Better still is viewing UFOs—and the paranormal as a whole—as an *ecology*. Like tornadoes and tigers, they have their own goals and needs which may align partially, wholly, or not at all with human conventions. Psychopomps are famously neutral, after all.

This approach is apparent in the work of researchers like Paul and Ben Eno who, while not denying the possibility of actual demons, view a large number of infestation, oppression, and possession cases as parasitic, rather than intrinsically "evil" by nature. These parasites "are not the spirits of dead people, nor are they the psychic remnants or residue of anything," the Enos

wrote. "They're not fallen angels or servants of Satan. They're life forms just as we are…."[3480]

The prospect need not be frightening. For all the lack of consent apparent in alien abductions, it appears some small part of us remains inviolable. For example, Isabel (whose experiences have been explored in previous chapters) remembered her aliens "were after… 'the human soul,'" yet she also declared, "They can't just take our souls because they cannot come into this world physically. But they can fool you into handing it over."[3481]

We all realize this, on an intuitive level. Like vampires at our door welcomed across the threshold, we must extend an *invitation* to negativity. Our souls cannot be taken from us—we hand them over of our own volition, piece-by-piece in thought, word, and deed, by what we have done and by what we have left undone. Evil means nothing without human hands to guide it. Each of us holds the power to deny it.

UFO researchers frequently speculate that many more people are abducted than consciously realize it. If true, this suggests "alien abductions" may represent a universal component of existence, just like death… or rebirth.

17

ALIENS AS OURSELVES

OBJ



So-called "extraterrestrials" may, in fact, originate closer to home than our "alien" labels evince. Recall Terence McKenna's assertion that the soul is "so alienated from us in our present culture that we treat it as an extraterrestrial," how "the most alien thing in the cosmos is the human soul." His elegant observations speak to the intimacy of UFO interactions, contact so personal it often seems tailor-made for each specific witness.

What follows explores the possibility of aliens as ourselves—both individuals and humanity as a whole. Previous chapters have already played with variations on this idea: the unbroken evolution connecting our dead to aliens by way of faerie folklore; the possibility that aliens may be human ghosts or ancestors; and speculation that the UFOs themselves, whether

light orbs or structured craft, may represent our own spirits or exteriorized souls.

Keeping these earlier comparisons in mind, this chapter focuses on correspondences between UFO phenomena and doubles, the Higher Self, and, most importantly, reincarnation… a process into which the human-alien hybrid program might actually grant us a glimpse.

The hybrid program

"Death is psychologically as important as birth, and like it, is an integral part of life," Jung wrote. "… seen in correct psychological perspective, death is not an end but a goal, and life's inclination towards death begins as soon as the meridian is passed."[3482]

It is impossible to speak of death without birth, a truth encoded in reincarnation traditions. Earlier discussion indicates the Otherworld's obsession with life's cyclicality, not only death but reproduction and, by extension, sexuality. UFOs are no exception, of course. The craft themselves overwhelmingly manifest in phallic and yonic shapes, Greys resemble human fetuses, and interactions between abductees and aliens repeatedly feature sexual and reproductive components. There even exists a common belief that the phenomenon somehow orchestrates romantic relationships between experiencers, a "love bite" magnetically attracting them to one another.[3483]

This reproductive preoccupation is no more apparent than in the alleged "human-alien hybrid program." Supposedly the extraterrestrials, their own procreation somehow atrophied, seek to infuse their dying race with human genetic material—the exact same motivation behind many faerie kidnappings. Ufologists like David Jacobs adamantly contend the hybrid program indicates sinister interplanetary forces are midway through a slow invasion of our planet spearheaded by an incognito, half-alien vanguard already walking among us.

Although hinted at in earlier abductions and clearly preceded by mythological human-spirit unions (King Arthur's conception was arguably an Otherworld hybridization effort), the work of Budd Hopkins is primarily responsible for bringing these ancient tropes into the UFO era circa the early 1980s. According to Hopkins and those following in his footsteps like Jacobs, the hybrid program appears throughout alien abductees' lives in stages.

In the broadest strokes, extraterrestrials select human candidates early in life, eventually gathering their sperm or eggs. Collection may involve invasive procedures, manual stimulation, or actual intercourse, either with aliens or other human abductees. These gametes are combined with alien genetic material and, in the case of female abductees, impregnated back into a human host (alternately, some speculate both the sperm and eggs come from abductees, with a third, non-human constituent added). After some time—never a full-term pregnancy—the child is taken from its mother.

The “half-made-its”

Female alien abductees often claim their pregnancies end abruptly not in miscarriages, but the sudden disappearance of *all* fetal tissue. While the incidence of “missing fetus syndrome” (MFS) is likely overstated—plenty of medical conditions can present pregnancy symptoms in the absence of a viable embryo—some cases seem genuinely anomalous.[3484]

Many Ufologists assume MFS signifies the extraterrestrial retrieval of human-alien hybrids from the womb. Although women commonly report themselves “opened up” by non-human entities who examine, or even physically remove their fetuses *in utero*, it is worth noting that these children are *dead* afterward, at least on a practical level; while abductees might encounter them later during “baby presentations” (discussed momentarily), they no longer exist to the rest of us. These children are never carried to term and thus, if they ever existed at all, are no more among the living than miscarriages or stillbirths. Perhaps they were always fated to remain within the ecology of souls.

In short, MFS might be another manifestation of aliens’ duties as psychopomps—recall how some Eastern figures like Jizō specialize in escorting the souls of miscarried babies, and how Perchta surrounded herself with unbaptized children. “This image of the Death-Demon surrounded by children almost certainly symbolizes life, transforming and renewing itself with sorrow,” Herzog mused.[3485]

This interpretation of MFS is not entirely foreign to Ufology. Vanishing Twin Syndrome—where one child is miscarried and absorbed by its sibling(s), the placenta, or its mother—is relatively common, occurring in up to 30% of multifetal pregnancies, but its root cause remains unknown, providing fertile ground for suspected extraterrestrial intervention.[3486] A couple who lost a child in this fashion were surprised to learn their surviving twin not only knew about her missing sibling, but "talk[ed] to her all the time… she's on the spaceship."[3487]

With this in mind, perhaps the Greys' fetal appearance is more significant than its passing resemblance reveals. As with all who take Ufology seriously but reject the ETH, there are various schools of thought surrounding exactly what this might mean. One idea proposed by Dennis Stacy and Jake Kirkwood suggests the Greys are "psychic projections, an imaginal caricature of a foetus," projected by those suffering guilt from undergoing abortions and miscarriages:

> Indeed, they are the very embodiment of guilt, literally and figuratively. In reality, they are avenging angels.
>
> Thus the abduction experience is a played-out drama which reverses the roles of victim (the unborn foetus) and victimizer (the original abortee). The hybrid baby is the soul, or animus, of the aborted foetus restored to life. In other words, the foetus hasn't really been aborted at all, but lives on in a 'heaven' (aboard a 'Mother Ship' yet) from which it can never return in physical form… Abduction, repeated as often as may be necessary, is an attempt to expiate guilt….[3488]

It is an interesting, if highly problematic, hypothesis. Beyond the thorny issue of broadly slandering those suffering spontaneous or induced abortions as "victimizers," the issue of male alien abductees is glossed over as "psychosomatic symptoms of sympathetic pregnancy."[3489] The proposal also hinges upon the overgeneralization of UFO contact as a negative experience, and fails to account for alien abductees who have never *been* pregnant, a significant cohort.

This being said, Stacy and Kirkwood's core conceit, the uncanny resemblance of Greys to fetuses, remains powerful. Hal Puthoff (investigator of remote viewing at the Stanford Research Institute in the 1970s) offered an alternative line of speculation much more congruent with ancestor veneration and the longstanding belief that unbaptized children fell into league with faeries. Addressing the editor of *Flying Saucer Review* in a 1982 letter, he wrote:

> Since UFO occupants are often reported to have the appearance of young children, or, more often, foetuses, has anyone ever looked for a correlation between [close encounters of the third kind] and miscarriages or stillborns in the family of contactees?
>
> The concept I wish to raise is that perhaps "other-dimensionals" begin entry into our realm during the process of birth, and those that abort for some reason or another end up participating in a reality that is closely tied to the physical realm, both with regards to their own personal form, and with regard to the desire to interact with us—sort of "half-made-its," as it were.[3490]

No need to rework MFS into the modern alien abduction mythology—older traditions, unrestrained from Materialism, account for similar phenomena. As noted, departed infants often found "second lives" of sorts among the fae folk, a fate perhaps enjoyed by the numerous miscarriages and stillbirths one Aran Islander endured; as recorded by Lady Gregory, her only child which persevered passed away after nine months, by all appearances a faerie changeling.[3491]

"Hard delivery, or barrenness… was sometimes taken to be a fairy curse, probably called down by the unfortunate positioning of a house," Briggs wrote.[3492]

These correlations may even grant insight into the frequent, unsettling sounds so often reported across all paranormal phenomena. "The two types of audio hallucinations most frequently reported are the sounds of a baby crying and the sound of an unseen car door slamming," according to John Keel. "The baby crying phenomenon is common not only among UFO witnesses but among thousands of 'ghost' and monster witnesses as well."[3493]

If not for the hybrid program, why are extraterrestrials so invested in pregnancy? In ancient Greece and other parts of the world, children not only made the best spirit servants after death, but also the most potent sacrifices.[3494] The disturbing possibility arises—especially if "aliens" and "demons" are identical—that MFS may not constitute retrieved hybrid fetuses, but offerings taken by spirits.

Less uncomfortably, we may be misidentifying fertility deities. Like the gods, goddesses, ancestors, and (some) faeries of old, modern aliens exercise complete control over abductees' ability to conceive, rendering not only the fertile infertile, but vice versa.[3495] Female experiencers sometimes become pregnant after menopause or even hysterectomies. Predictably, researchers invested in the ETH like Jacobs propose technological solutions including "extrauterine gestational sacs," but this does nothing to diminish the enigma's mythological precedent.[3496]

Unlike the macabre "soul harvesters" of the previous chapter, aliens may not *reap* souls, but instead *sow* them.

Baby on board

Viewing alien abductees in a shamanic light renders the entire hybrid program unsurprising. Chapter 7 mentioned the frequency with which some shamans engage in sexual congress with spirit helpers, liaisons equally common in faerie folklore. Contemporary alien abductees might also interpret these interactions as transcendental: in conversation with John Mack, Whitley Strieber compared his female handler to "a second wife with whom I'm having a secret relationship… the sensation of intercourse moves through your whole body, and you become totally devoted to it for longer than I do in normal intercourse… a level of sexuality I'm normally not involved with is engaged. It's very, very powerful."[3497]

Historically speaking, these experiences fall upon a broader spectrum of Otherworldly unions, from consensual "bridal theology" to violative *incubi* and *succubi* attacks, some of which allegedly produced hybrid offspring of their own. As may be recalled, some shamanic traditions describe spirit lovers returning "at night when others [are] not around" to introduce these children to their human parents.[3498] A fitting analogue can be found in the "baby presentations" many alien abductees report.

Prior to these formal introductions, experiencers may catch a glimpse of rows upon rows of jars or tubes filled with liquid, as many as a hundred, either free-standing or slid away in drawers, each housing an embryo or fetus.[3499] These "incubatoriums" presumably gestate children retrieved from abductees until fully developed, yet witnesses sometimes sense these bodies

are lifeless.[3500] Furthermore, the aliens themselves have been observed treating these fetuses—which we assume represent the precious culmination of incredible effort—as entirely disposable.

"In a few instances, abductees report watching as aliens deliberately destroy fetuses in the 'fetal nursery' scenario," Karla Turner noted.[3501] Are these "hybrid babies" simply human fetal tissue, the physical detritus left behind after psychopomp aliens escort the souls of miscarried children into the afterlife?

Despite their technological façade, folkloric antecedents of alien incubatoriums exist. Graham Hancock noted a similarity to the "soul trees" seen in some Siberian shamanic visions, where nests containing future shamans sit in orderly rows among the branches, awaiting tutelage by a raven spirit. Hancock further compares this to a tree reported by Mack's subject Karin: "On the branches of the tree there were large nests with thick twigs and an eagle sitting quietly and peacefully in each one."[3502]

Provided the children in the incubatoriums are *not* dead, they are taken to term and await introduction to their human parents. Baby presentations, which Jacobs noted in 180 of 700 alien abductions circa 1999, typically involve infants, though toddlers and adolescents are reported as well.[3503] The abductee is implored to hold, embrace, and speak with the hybrid. Women are strongly urged to nurse, even when they are not lactating, an act which Jacobs claims "seems to satisfy the watchful aliens nonetheless… After holding the baby for a while, women report that the baby seems 'better.' It appears to have a bit more energy or to be thriving slightly." This could indicate that a spiritual transference of some sort—soul, love, psychic energy,

call it what you will—is taking place, though some mothers miraculously claim to suddenly produce milk, to their surprise.[3504]

Rarely do these children appear healthy. Jacobs described the typical hybrid as "lifeless, yet it is not dead."[3505] "He looked dead," one abductee put it.[3506] "It's really sad, they all look like they're dead," said another.[3507]

Few apprehend the wisdom in such statements. These hybrids are clearly the same children taken from their mothers' wombs, or, more mundanely, miscarried—to reiterate, in *our* reality they *are* dead.

Parents often find themselves repulsed by their hybrid progeny, whose descriptions perfectly mirror infant faerie changelings: listless and weak, with large heads, wizened complexions, oversized eyes, and rail-thin limbs. The baby presentation's emphasis upon nursing represents another holdover from faerie folklore, as changelings were sometimes substituted for the express purpose of obtaining human milk. Notably, the fae folk subsided not on the physical qualities of food, but rather its essence or *foyson*, perhaps granting insight into the aforementioned "spiritual transference" of baby presentations.[3508]

To be clear, changelings were *not* human-faerie hybrids—they were fae through-and-through. To that end, interactions closely paralleling Ufology's baby presentations are difficult to pinpoint in faerie folklore. The motif seems scattered, fractured across various stories, not only those of changelings but also tales of women recruited to serve as midwives or wetnurses to faerie babies.

One of the closest matches comes from a woman traveling between Loughrea and Slieve Echtge who was whisked away by a mysterious stranger to a home where she was shown an infant. "She understood she was to give suck to it and so she did, and came away," wrote Lady Gregory. "And when she was away out, she saw that the man that brought her was her brother that was dead, and that is the reason she was chosen."[3509]

Unlike changelings, alien hybrids rarely take up residence in abductees' homes, instead remaining in the Otherworld (aboard UFOs). This choice is not unheard of in other traditions, however. Certain Amazonian tribes believe that spirit hybrids born to human fathers and mermaid mothers stay underwater, fulfilling their destinies as "great shaman[s] of that dimension." In India, Saora mothers might birth spirit children who dwell in the Otherworld, their relationships confined to breastfeeding whenever their non-human fathers deliver them under cover of darkness. An Algonquin legend speaks of a hunter who fathered a son with one of 12 spirit maidens; after a time, he was fetched to visit his child's home in the sky.[3510]

Star children & hubrids

While not exhibiting the parasitical tendencies of changelings, two human-alien hybrid variants *do* allegedly live among us, if Ufologists are to be believed. New Agers refer to the more benign subset as "Indigo Children" or "Star Children," adolescents appearing wholly human but displaying exceptional intelligence, talent, beauty, empathy, and psychic abilities. Star Children are a modern interpretation of offspring obtained through human unions with gods, folk heroes, and, of course, the fae.[3511]

In stark contrast to changelings, human-faerie hybrids were imbued with "a strange mystic nature," bold and reckless, presenting a love for "music and song," Lady Wilde wrote. "They were passionate, revengeful, and not easy to live with."[3512]

We might draw further comparisons, as Jenny Randles did, to Kenneth Ring's "Omega Prototypes" and, by extension, NDErs or (perhaps) even shamans. "Star Children" and "Omega Prototypes" represent "just two names for the same essential concept," Randles wrote.[3513]

Far more sinister—and stupid—are alleged "hubrids," human-alien hybrids living among us easily passing for human beings. David Jacobs speculates these sleeper agents, the culmination of successive generations of hybrids growing more and more human, represent the end stages of the long extraterrestrial takeover. Fear not: they are dullards, incapable of the most basic human actions. Jacobs's 2015 book *Walking Among Us* explains how

these hubrids latch on to abductees in their daily lives, soliciting them for all manner of advice like how to cook, eat, or arrange furniture.[3514]

Jacobs's assertion that these "human-stage hybrids are indistinguishable from humans" actually reinvents folklore describing spirits the same way.[3515] Countless ghost stories feature specters who have "forgotten" how to function among the living, but are otherwise indistinguishable from everyday individuals. A seer out of Walton County, Georgia remembered his father's warning as a boy while waiting at a bus stop.

"Look over there," he said, pointing to a man with his back to them. "That's a ghost." The future seer objected, adamant it was only a man. "Nah, that's a ghost," his father insisted. "You ain't never gonna see his face, watch." The figure stood still as their own bus came and went.[3516]

"The lights inside the bus was bright, you know, and I watched, but I never seen him get on the bus," the seer later recalled. "When it drove away, he was gone. Now I tell you I ain't seen him get on, but he was gone when it left."[3517]

We have met the alien and it is us

While not normally thought of as such, human-alien hybrids are therianthropes by definition, especially if one ascribes to the ETH. This supposition, when scrutinized, undermines the physicality of the hybrid program—from a genetic standpoint, surely cats and dogs are more closely related than humans and extraterrestrial lifeforms, yet even they remain wholly incompatible. It is highly unlikely we could procreate with something so foreign.

Hybrid program proponents typically dismiss this criticism with the catchall of superior alien technology, but this fails to explain hybrids successfully conceived through physical sexual intercourse. While rare, this has been reported, as in the famous Villas Boas case. Other solutions to the conundrum rely upon ancient alien clichés, that we somehow share common ancestry with our extraterrestrial kidnappers.

While both explanations are certainly possible, it is frustrating that Ufologists rarely afford a second thought to the most obvious answer: they are compatible with us because they *are* us. Abductees may not be dealing with aliens and hybrids, but ancestor spirits and recently-minted souls. The shared appearance of Greys and fetuses suggests as much, to say nothing of hybrid children, which are even closer to being fully human. Perhaps the fetal proportions—atrophied, sexless bodies topped by oversized heads and eyes—are holdovers from our fundamental state on the other side, our true form if

you will, which we grow out of yet return to after death, evidenced by universal traditions speaking of "small souls."

At this juncture, the temptation to explore what hybrids, MFS, incubatoriums, and baby presentations may reveal about reincarnation is strong, but doing so would undermine later discussion involving prebirth memories. Instead, we approach reincarnation from another angle, namely soulcraft (with a detour into doubles and the Higher Self) before bringing together these disparate threads.

Seeing double

It should be stressed that the hybrid program is just one proposed motivation behind the alien harvest of human genetic material. Others suspect aliens use abductees' DNA for human cloning, a suspicion bolstered by numerous cases where witnesses encounter *themselves*. Many experiencers in this book claim as much. For instance, an abductee named Virginia was "introduced to her cloned sister in the Beings' 'sky house,'" the culmination of medical procedures performed upon her.[3518]

Cloning efforts have a long and complex history. Though the process commonly occurs in nature, artificial cloning of complex organisms like mammals has only been a scientific reality for Earthlings since 1996, when Dolly the sheep was successfully replicated in Scotland. Since then, no humans have been cloned… officially.

Rumors persist that, despite the practice's widespread illegality, governments and other factions have nonetheless cloned *Homo sapiens.* At least one such organization, the Raëliens (a UFO religion mentioned in Chapter 11), openly claims as much: in 2002, they allegedly produced "Baby Eve," the first of several subsequent clones born around the world. These Raëlien clones, while widely believed to be hoaxes, speak to the science-fiction obsession permeating the flying saucer mythos.[3519]

Human cloning remains elusive, at least in the traditional sci-fi sense. Yes, it is obviously possible, but it cannot as-yet produce the results popular

culture conditions us to expect. Genetic copies are not immediately-obtained duplicates.

Put another way, a clone derived from a 45-year-old, Cockney-accented, obese amputee must not only start as an infant but—unless subjected to the same environmental stimuli—will speak with a different accent, retain all their limbs, and remain a healthy weight. As of today on Earth, an identical snapshot of your current manifestation cannot be manufactured immediately, to say nothing of how nonlocal consciousness may play a role in identity.

While some report younger or different versions of themselves ("That baby is me," wept one Puerto Rican experiencer),[3520] these current impossibilities are important to keep in mind when reviewing selected examples of clones and UFOs:

- Ardy Sixkiller Clarke spoke with a Belize abductee who claimed he met his double in 1963. While this copy primarily dwelled on another world, the two exchanged places for two weeks "and no one ever knew the difference." The two last met the night the witness graduated college.[3521]

- On February 28, 1974, Dirant Mello Ferraz was suddenly transported from his Brazilian kitchen to a featureless room. A door materialized on the wall, through which an egg-shaped machine passed and released "a double of himself." The being reassured the witness that he meant no harm before vanishing through the wall and appearing on a television screen *inside Ferraz's home*.[3522]

From this vantage point—which now seemed within the double's own eyes—Ferraz watched the imposter interact curtly with his sister, displaying an ignorance of how to perform basic tasks like writing or handling money.[3523] (This dualistic perspective shift is not uncommon in abductions: Judy Doraty's March 13, 1980 abduction involved her simultaneously remaining beside her car and observing a calf mutilation aboard a craft.)[3524]

Ferraz remained in this "other place" for several days, the "screen" sometimes switching off. During these intervals, he learned his captors were not invaders but rather "work[ed] for the good of the human race itself" and only "sought to conclude some tests."[3525]

"The double seemed concerned about the welfare of plants and trees," wrote Irene Granchi. When he suddenly returned home, Ferraz's wristwatch—frozen since his abduction—caught up instantaneously.[3526]

- While sleeping in his truck after it mysteriously died on Spain's National Highway 320 in December 1977, Miguel Herrero Sierra awoke to a bright light and calls for help. He investigated and found a large "hat-shaped object" by the road. Once inside, the intervening three hours—which felt much shorter—involved over a dozen beings in white outfits who appeared human, including Sierra's double. It was identical save for "the scar which I bear on my left cheek," which appeared on the opposite side. For safety reasons, the captain of the craft prevented the witness from touching "his negative," as he called it. Before his release, Sierra learned that the beings had been visiting Earth for millennia.[3527]

- In early 1978, David Brown encountered a wedge-shaped object in the wilderness while fighting in the Rhodesian Bush War. A few weeks later, he noticed a similar object dart across the sky while on patrol, accompanied by missing time.

Flashbacks revealed that a hooded dwarf had escorted him through the forest and into a vacant room aboard a landed craft. While inside, Brown "found himself facing his double… wearing a blue cloak and hood." His next memories were of rejoining his

patrol in the same outfit, then standing in a hospital ward. Rows of men lay on beds, jars at their feet crammed with bloody human body parts.

Brown saw another man he knew, whose own double pressed "a large key" to his friend's temple. "Don't worry," Brown reassured him erroneously, "it's only your brother." However, deep down Brown "knew it wasn't his brother: they were absolutely identical!" Something pierced Brown in his side, and he found himself at a conference table with "oriental people" who patched his wound with a ribbon.

His final recollection was of a reptilian grabbing him by the throat, staring "into his soul." Fragments of subsequent experiences later emerged: hoofed women, drinking a strange liquid, his own dismemberment, and the discovery of "an abandoned baby," believed to be his own.[3528]

- Following a violent motorcycle crash on February 28, 1984, "Tom Fraser" of Surrey awoke in a bright room surrounded by short, grey-skinned beings with angled eyes. Nearby, he saw another surface identical to the one he lay upon, atop which stretched "a body, motionless and apparently unconscious… remarkably like myself." The beings said they would heal Fraser, and he passed out.

Upon regaining consciousness the "dead" body had vanished, and Fraser was dressed similarly to his doctors. Vague memories of the craft's interior came to him after he awoke in hospital, suffering only a broken arm, incongruous with the accident's severity.[3529]

- On his return home from photographing dolmens in Spain in July 1985, Xavier Clares Jerez noticed several oddities: missing time, a new haircut, 250 extra kilometers on his odometer, muddy tires, and a strange, sticky substance all over his car. Reaching Barcelona, he discovered over 34 hours had elapsed. Jerez was further alarmed when his photos developed into images of green, demonic faces and clawed hands.

Hypnotic regression revealed an extensive encounter featuring anomalous mist, sticky "rain," and a descent into a cave where strange beings from "Cassiopeia"

performed medical procedures on Jerez. They also ate the sandwiches he had packed, humorously enough.

Stranger still, he recalled sitting in his car with an exact replica of himself, down to his clothing, in the backseat. The only difference was its longer hair. Jerez dropped his double off in Barcelona, where a friend allegedly spotted it several days later in a part of town he had not visited for months.[3530]

- In 1987, a Diné informant told Clarke that he had an identical "biological twin" raised by aliens on another planet who visited him annually since childhood. He speculated everyone possessed such doubles, though they did not share the same soul.[3531]

- Alien abductees Lisa and Pat told Karla Turner they saw "clones of their bodies" aboard UFOs, as well as "a room full" of lifeless humans, "beautiful and identical." Turner related another case where "a man was told that a duplicate of his body could be used to 'replace' him if he didn't 'cooperate' with the aliens. Lisa, too, was told other people wouldn't be able to distinguish her cloned body from the original, should they choose to replace her."[3532]

- A recurring English witness encountered his double in the summer of 2003 after his dog brought his attention to a rapidly-approaching object. Three eight-foot-tall, black, reflective beings stood before him, his copy in tow. The double not only appeared identical, but displayed the witness's accent and mannerisms. Before vanishing, the double cryptically instructed, "You have got to move yourself, you've got to start finding the rest now."[3533]

Simply put, our current understanding of cloning cannot account for reproductions so faithful as to be indistinguishable. That may well change in the future, but until then, recontextualizing alien-derived "clones" through autoscopy may prove more fruitful. Ages ago, these would certainly have been understood as supernatural doubles, though few alien abductees treat these as death omens today.

As present both in faerie folklore and some doppelgänger traditions, these "clones" are perfect save one small detail: the length of Jerez's hair, for example, or the location of Sierra's scar. The danger Sierra faced when nearly touching his mirror image evokes the risk of disturbing sleepers while their souls are out-of-body. David Brown's experience, mired in symbolism, certainly seems more metaphysical than literal: a psychopomp dwarf escorts him to the Otherworld where he sees the dying as well as his own soul, and another man's double wielding the psychopomp's wand (the key). His side is pierced, he faces death (the reptilian, perhaps the Satanic dragon), and is resurrected, Christlike.

The wandering soul possibility is supported by the above cases from Belize and Brazil, where "clones" take the place of experiencers during their absence. This scenario unfolds regularly enough to be treated as a subset of such reports. The simplest explanation suggests these individuals never left Earth, but their consciousness, soul, or another part of them merely "wandered away." (Another explanation—no more explicative, but more acceptable to modern sensibilities—is that these individuals were experiencing something akin to fugue states, a medical condition touched upon in Chapter 11.)

Another datapoint refutes the idea that these are physical clones: researchers, even those who are not alien abductees, see their doubles as well. Jim Moseley apparently had "a phantom twin." In another example, a British UFO documentarian met a Brazilian witness who nervously confessed he feared the filmmaker would kidnap him—"the captain of the flying saucer had looked exactly like the Britisher right down to his neatly trimmed goatee."[3534]

Disappointed fans wrote Brad Steiger "complaining of [his] outrageous and insulting behavior" during conferences he never attended. "There were claims that I had openly berated my audience, calling them stupid for accepting the very premise of UFOs," he lamented. It is easy to suggest these imposters were governmental disinformation agents… until one considers similar correspondence praising Steiger for besting Carl Sagan in debates, despite having never met the skeptic. Surely any agent wishing to diminish UFOs' validity would support, rather than refute, Sagan's position.[3535]

John Keel met similar adversity. Someone claiming to be his secretary would follow up with witnesses.[3536] The manner in which correspondence preceded his hotel arrivals suggests a doppelgänger was roving about,[3537] to say nothing of Keel's assertion that "a duplicate John Keel has appeared on several occasions."[3538] It seems mere proximity to flying saucers draws out the soul.

Some speculate the UFO occupants themselves might be copies of one another. This thinking is especially common regarding more humanlike entities, including Nordics. Does their uniformity come from cloning or from

ego death—the stripping away of individuality that goes hand-in-hand with dying?

"I am convinced that the human workers I have encountered during my experiences were clones," Bret Oldham wrote. He further wondered if these clones were replicated humans pressed into indentured servitude by the Greys, who lack individuality themselves.[3539] Beyond wardrobe changes and the larger, supervising entities, little distinguishes them from one another.

As remarked, these taller Greys mirror faerie kings and queens. Faerie lore presents its own tangential cloning connection in the form of changelings, quasi-doubles in their own right. The term "fetch," the Irish doppelgänger equivalent, is also used to describe these faerie substitutes.[3540]

A curious Irish tale involves a druid who searched for the missing Queen Etain for over a year until he learned she was imprisoned beneath the hill Bri Leith. When they started digging, "50 beautiful women, all of the same age, same size, same appearance in form, face, and dress, and all of them so closely resembling the abducted lady" emerged from the hillside. The true queen was only identified through "unmistakable tokens."[3541]

One case expresses the clone-UFO-changeling constellation better than any other. Antônio Álves Ferreira, a repeat childhood experiencer from Brazil, described visiting another world while a perfect double was left in his stead, observed via viewscreen. His clone was "so heavy that it was impossible" for his father to carry it—an attribute featured across changeling tales (Chapter 4).[3542]

Accounts of "cloned" alien abductees fit into a broader autoscopic tapestry involving OBEs during UFO contact (Chapter 11) and more traditional bilocation tales. All seem to signify the wandering soul. Whereas clones in such stories seem quite physical, sometimes allowing themselves to be touched, bilocation examples are less corporeal.

Fittingly, these doubles are often viewed by third parties, as doppelgängers traditionally were. The scenario happens often with "repeaters." Whitley Strieber claims others have seen him on several occasions while he was elsewhere.[3543] Raymond Fowler's father, asked to pray for his friend's flight anxiety, supposedly appeared in the airplane aisle to offer comfort.[3544] Betty Andreasson saw "Bob Luca's double stand in a doorway a few moments before he stepped forward and merged with the image."[3545] Gerry Armstrong would be spotted in places contradicting his alibis.[3546] Though perhaps nothing more than another one of his pranks, Gray Barker claimed to observe contactee Barbara Hudson's double at the 1970 Giant Rock Convention.[3547]

Suffice to say, it is more parsimonious to assume clones, doubles, and OBEs during abductions all represent a singular phenomenon, rather than multiple phenomena. Which interpretation is closest to the truth—physical or spiritual—is anyone's guess, although the metaphysical components of UFO contact as a whole certainly support the latter.

The greatest alien there is

Obviously, abductees' clones and doppelgängers could represent their wandering souls. But what of *the aliens themselves*? Since faeries were sometimes doubles (Chapter 5), can we assume the same of modern extraterrestrials?

Incongruous details like Sierra's scar seem to preclude the idea that we are dealing with time travel, i.e. that "clones" are encountering their past or future selves. On the other hand, some experiencers firmly believe this to be the case. Fowler not only experienced "time slips," but once saw himself emerge from behind his cellar furnace wearing black dress pants and a white shirt—an act and attire he later replicated, unplanned.[3548]

This disregard for linear time is echoed in folklore surrounding our doubles. They know our destinies, with variants like the vardøger literally pantomiming our future behavior. It is also claimed that faeries and extraterrestrials perceive time differently, as do our Higher Selves—our own internal psychopomps.

"My guess is that the 'Grays' reported in the ASC [altered state of consciousness] our culture calls 'abductions' are indeed distorted views of the greatest alien there is—the Self, the deep nature of the human psyche," Paul Devereux penned in a 1995 *MUFON UFO Journal* article. "A meeting with this alien is long overdue."[3549]

Remembering the ever-present caveat that *spirits are deceptive*, UFO contact has alluded to this possibility for over six decades.

- Contactee Buck Nelson primarily interacted with "Little Bucky" of Venus, but the name is rarely remarked upon. His designation literally implies "little self of the overworld," i.e. Nelson's diminutive soul.[3550]

- An experiencer touched by one of Strieber's Visitors had the impression of being asked, "What do you want?" She later recalled thinking, "To know what you are," but heard herself say aloud, "To know what I am."[3551]

- Another abductee asked an alien, "Why are you even talking to me?" and was told, "Because you are me."[3552]

- A French abductee in the 1970s described a white being with an "elongated head" which "came up to him and approached so close that their chests touched, and promptly the two bodies 'fused'… he could now 'understand everything.'"[3553]

- "If you don't know where you are, then there isn't any point of my telling where I am from," argued Betty Hill's abductors when discussing their star map. Perhaps, as UFO scholar Miguel "Red Pill Junkie" Romero contends, this is a reworking of the old saying, "Know thyself."[3554]

In one instance, Steve Boucher's alien handler "started to tell me things that touched me, things about myself, and my life. It was like he knew me." Like many other abductees, Boucher believes aliens can speak to him even when they are not around, which, strength and clarity notwithstanding, functions identically to our internal monologue.[3555]

A hypnotic regressionist claimed to access Boucher's subconscious, and the exchange reads like dozens of similarly-obtained "extraterrestrial" conversations: "I control the information that [Steve] receives. I release it as I see fit." Boucher's subconscious described itself like an intercessory angel or saint, carrying information between his conscious self and the aliens, but admitted Boucher sometimes conflated this part of his mind with the UFO occupants themselves.[3556]

It is the Me within Thee

Alongside these shared identities the drumbeat of universal oneness, unification, totality, etc. continues unabated. John Mack and his subjects preferred calling this oneness "Source."[3557] Perhaps the earliest use of this term comes from contactee Dana Howard, who in 1957 wrote that mankind must one day "draw our knowledge direct from source."[3558]

"They believe all that exists is of God and is God," one experiencer said.[3559] Other alien abductees receive similar messages: "We are all one with the one who is all," "It is the Me within Thee,"[3560] "Welcome back, you're here, you're loved and with the One."[3561]

These blurred distinctions are consistent with the principle of *monism*, the notion that there is no true separation between anything in existence. Monism rejects Cartesian dualism. In monism, any perceived divisions are imaginary or arbitrary, even—especially—separations along spiritual-physical or mind-body boundaries.

Talk of "the One" also harkens back to concepts where individual consciousness represents an attempt by the universe to experience itself, an idea originating primarily in the East. "'The One' is an all-encompassing immortal principle in the Vedas," wrote Gregory Shushan. "It is the culmination of the deities, the elements, the celestial bodies, and the *atman*"—the true soul, an inward divinity some equate with the Higher Self.[3562]

As a Christian equivalent, Jesus instructs in Luke 17:20-21, "The coming of the kingdom of God is not something that can be observed, nor will people say, 'Here it is,' or 'There it is,' because the kingdom of God is in your midst." Some translations read "the kingdom of God is *within you*." As Irish Capuchin Franciscan monk Brother Richard explained:

> Each Christian, in the mystical understanding of Christianity, is to become a place or a locus of the incarnation… in what the early Christians called "the transformation of the self," into as near an approximation to God as it's possible to become while still remaining a human being. The old term for that was theosis. This was the divinization of humanity… from the very earliest days of Christianity, [this] was understood as being the goal of the Christian faith. It wasn't just to be a good, moral person, but the morality, the goodness, evolved from an encounter with the divine that slowly saw a transformation or a raising of the person to being as alike to God as it's possible for us to be.[3563]

For centuries, theologians have entertained a *pandeistic* doctrine wherein God "became the universe," embedded within everything—including ourselves. Within this lurk older mythologies wherein the corpse of a dead deity provided the physical foundation for the universe (the giant Ymir to the Norse, the dragon *Tiamat* to Babylonians, *Pángǔ* to the Chinese, etc.). It is itself a macrocosm of shamanic dismemberment. Death fuels birth.

Even modern secularists find the idea inescapable. Today's atheism remains reincarnative in scope: "We are star stuff," the adage goes, referencing the universe as a closed system to which nothing new is added,

nothing old removed. After we die, our components which once comprised older complex systems—atoms and molecules—endure to be remade anew.

The revelation that God lies within us consistently manifests in meditation and psychedelic use—remember, entheogens release the "inner god." Predictably, it also cuts across UFO literature, particularly Whitley Strieber's output. From a correspondent's NDE/UFO experience related in *The Communion Letters:*

> He was about six feet tall, with long white flowing hair, white beard, and beautiful eyes filled with light. The love was so immense. I knew him, but did not know how I knew him. We talked with our minds and I asked him who he was. He said, "I am God." He asked me, "What is your name?" I said, "Bill." He said, "What is the difference, as Bill is God, God is Bill, it's all the same."[3564]

When her husband asked, "Who is god?", Anne Strieber quipped, "We are."[3565] The Master of the Key shared the same sentiment:

> Stop imagining that you are not Christ and that God is somewhere outside of you. Face the true contents of your own being. Seek the kingdom within you and you will find the kingdom everywhere.[3566]

“You face the visitors, you face yourself”

Of the female Visitor he first met in 1985, Strieber “bore toward her the same feelings of terror and fascination that I might toward someone I saw staring back at me from the depths of my unconscious.”[3567] In the intervening decades, Strieber refined this concept, but his visceral reaction remained intact.

“They’re not negative, they’re just difficult, hard to deal with, hard to face,” he said in 2021. “You face the visitors, you face yourself. And if that is not something you like to do, then it’s going to be difficult.”[3568]

Any controversy surrounding these ideas should not overshadow their explicative value. The omniscience and intimacy of UFO occupants and experiences make perfect sense as manifestations of the Higher Self, as does the presence of elderly “wise ones” reported in some abductions. Jung described the “wise old man” archetype we often apply to God as “a typical personification of the Self.”[3569]

Issues of consent—equally troubling in witch trial testimony regarding faeries—miraculously vanish. These beings have permission to interact with us not only because they are authors of the universe, but they are also *ourselves*, the only thing we *truly own* in this life.

“I think we’re property,” Charles Fort concluded after investigating the impossible in 1919’s *The Book of the Damned*.[3570] The word’s root, the Latin

proprius, signifies "one's own" or *individual.*[3571]

Some of Ufology's most insightful thinkers, from Strieber to Mike Clelland, have wondered whether the UFO phenomenon might be self-generated. This neither indicates it is fantasy nor wholly internal, but rather emphasizes the deep personal meaning of contact.

"I feel like the phenomenon has been manifesting in a way to match my deeply personal set of, dare I say, needs," Clelland wrote in 2011. "… could it be that there's a part of me, or some higher self (or future self, or astral self, or my soul-self) that's reaching outward, and meeting some mysterious energy halfway?... A mystery is being laid out before me, seductively urging me to follow. And in a very real sense, it's my mystery, and my path alone."[3572]

"What is *really* behind our experiences?" Strieber asked. "We are. This is a human thing. However, I would also say that it indicates that we—and our world—are vastly different, and far more strange, than we have ever dreamed, or dared imagine."[3573] Aliens, by extension human beings, may be walking contradictions: interior yet exterior, ourselves yet the Other.

The divine feminine

Strieber's lady Visitor is worth further exploration through the lens of the Higher Self. His primary handler's presentation as the opposite sex speaks to the traditional duality of existence, the divine feminine which resides latent in males, the divine masculine in females. Her presence is, as Jung argued regarding flying saucers, a completion of Strieber's own totality. The sexual unions found in abductions speak to this fulfillment, as well as the hybrids themselves, which unify two species as one: *coincidentia oppositorum.*

A worthwhile (if time consuming) undertaking might compare how often supervisory figures—taller Greys in abductions, faerie royalty in older tales—appear as the primary witness's opposite sex. Though plenty of same sex pairings can be found, an informal survey of UFO literature certainly lends the loose impression this is less common. David Jacobs described the "Taller Beings" as predominantly male in his book *Secret Life*, but admits "the majority of abductees in this study are women," going so far as to generalize abductees in the book with feminine pronouns.[3574]

Unlike the smaller "worker" or "drone" class, these Greys are the only ones exhibiting anything resembling personalities, suggesting a modicum of *humanity*, for lack of a better term. Jacobs further describes how Taller Beings often employ the pronoun "us": "You are very special to us," "You are helping us," etc. This is typically interpreted as shorthand for the extraterrestrials, but alternatively could indicate that the supervisor and the abductee are one, despite the perceived sexual incongruity.[3575] (Of course, if

Taller Beings are abductees' Higher Selves, we are left asking what smaller Greys represent. Take your pick from ancestor spirits, spirit helpers, etc.)

Mike Stevens, last mentioned in the previous chapter, described visits from *four* aliens. Viewed psychologically, each corresponds to an aspect of himself: two militaristic males (his predominant masculine self), a small "boy" (his inner child), and a female who, while seemingly in charge, tended to lurk in the corner of his bedroom (the feminine self, dwelling in his subconscious). Keeping with our psychopomp symbolism, this supervisory female showed him a box containing something resembling an arrowhead, intoning, "This is the key."[3576]

Male alien abductees might identify more closely with female Taller Beings than vice versa. One hypnosis session manifested before the patient a rotating disc, four feet wide, in front of his forehead (third eye); within was "a young lady" who identified herself as his "Self-Control." Like Christ with Thomas the Apostle, she bade him to touch her to prove her physicality, stepping from the flying saucer before the session ended.[3577]

Another abductee was escorted to a room where he saw a female entity housed behind amber glass. He felt she "was related to the taller one and to myself." Whether this implies all three were related—witness, female, and Taller Being—or that she was their progeny, the scenario still suggests unification and totality.[3578]

From the beginning, Strieber felt he "might love" his female companion "almost as much as I might my own anima."[3579] Jeffrey Kripal unpacked their relationship thusly:

> …any male heterosexual encounter with a feminine presence in a Christian culture will be framed as heretical and will be at best ignored and at worst demonized and persecuted. It will be *alien*. This is Whitley's real crime and the deeper reason that *Communion* was so vehemently rejected by fundamentalist Christians. He was offering what is essentially a feminine divine and a male heterosexual spirituality, neither of which can fit into the gender grammar of the monotheistic West.[3580]

Our earliest religious practices, including animism, featured the divine feminine as a staple of spiritual expression. Goddesses were celebrated in fertility dances and rituals, some held at the ancient monuments covered in Chapter 8.[3581] Peering back into the mists of time we find *sibyls*, pagan prophetess-goddesses of unclear origin, renowned to magicians the world over, their influence even wending its way into the church's Christmas Mass as recently as the 1500s.[3582]

Female divinities featured in early Judaism (the Shekhinah). Kripal points to "good evidence that the biblical God once had a spouse, a Goddess, as it were, but She was long ago banished from memory and proper belief."[3583]

The divine feminine expresses herself at both the societal and individual level. Recall feminine Norse doubles like the hamingja, or Zoroastrianism's Daēnā, simultaneously a psychopomp divinity and the individual's "religious conscience in the shape of a damsel of unsurpassed beauty, the fairest of the fair in the world."[3584]

Gnostics combined the self and the divine feminine in Sophia, a concept borrowed from Greek philosophy's personification of wisdom. Sophia in all

her beauty embodies the human soul yet also God's feminine aspect, attributed the creation of our material world.[3585] Never meeting a mythology he didn't like, Jung connected Sophia to the highest archetype of the anima.[3586]

Recurring UFO contactee Christopher Bledsoe learned from a beautiful feminine presence that the "aliens" who healed his Crohn's disease were not extraterrestrial, but rather "angelic, divine." This lady, "revered in secret circles," describes herself as "the Mother" and sometimes takes the form of a bull with a crown on its head."[3587] This resembles the Egyptian goddess Hathor, often shown with a bovine head, who as a mother-goddess shares close association with the Gnostic Sophia.[3588] Bledsoe's son Ryan explained the message this modern Sophia relayed and how it turned the family's strongly-held Christian conviction on its head.

> I think that she's here to guide us to become like her. This is what she told my father, she said that some day when you die and even after that, you'll be as we are… your spirit, when you die, it goes into these orbs, and then it exists in an eternal place, or the heavenly realms, some people might call it…
>
> …I think she's part of that group that is responsible for the creation of everything. Life, matter, maybe, I think she is the missing part of that Trinity. Whereas its usually known as the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost… well, what she told my father is that it's the Father, the Son, and the Mother.[3589]

One informant living in Belize told Ardy Sixkiller Clarke that he met the "stone woman" of Mayan legend in conjunction with a UFO, describing her as

"magnificent," "beautiful," "glow[ing] like a star," "taller than our women," wearing "a long white dress with embroidery." "Some people believed she was a ghost," he told her. "A few thought she was an angel. Others believed she was the Virgin Mary. I always believed what the elders told me. She was a woman from the stars and finally I know the truth."[3590]

Overwhelming feminine manifestations are not restricted to alien abductions. Whoever this figure is, she finds her way into psychedelic trips, hauntings, BVM apparitions, and even Bigfoot habituations (see the next chapter), often as spectral Women in White like the Welsh *Y Ladi Wen*. In faerie stories, she may be their Queen, or any number of figures including the banshee. We are left to ponder whether witnesses encountering this archetype face the Other, the divine, themselves—or all three.

The odd couple

A small subset of alien abductees believe every human being—or at least select individuals—experiences a dual existence, paired with another soul along life's journey. As yet another expression of the Higher Self and even older polypsychic soul perspectives, the idea is not new, but presents a novel wrinkle in this soul's identity, which is regarded as wholly extraterrestrial.

Few have explored these perspectives. On one occasion in his Manhattan apartment, Strieber noted a "striking" impression that the Visitor into whose eyes he gazed "was another form of myself" or "somebody who inhabits me."[3591] Other alien abductees might feel they are "part alien," related to our closing discussion of extraterrestrial "past lives."

This concept runs throughout John Mack's work. Mack used the term "dual identity" to describe cases where abductees felt "capable of experiencing [themselves] as both human and alien… As an alien they see the world from an alien perspective." Abductions once more become struggles towards totality. "The alien self is sometimes perceived as the lost or abandoned soul of the human self, linked once to a common source. The felt task then becomes one of integrating the split-off alien self or soul and becoming whole once again."[3592]

These "odd couples" represent a critical lynchpin for understanding both doubles and reincarnation vis-à-vis alien abduction. By far the most in-depth examination of this topic is *The Dual Soul Connection* focusing on Suzy

Hansen, a figure mentioned in previous chapters who has experienced paranormal activity and UFO contact since childhood.

Hansen noted a "disconcerting" ability to predict UFO phenomena. In one instance, she knew five lights would appear in the sky minutes before she and a friend saw them from her balcony. "I experienced the profound and unexpected feeling that part of my awareness was there on the balcony, but at the same time, it was as if a part of me was up in the sky with the lights," she reminisced. "A strange 'dual awareness' is the best way to describe it; a feeling of 'another self.'"[3593]

As Hansen slowly came to grips with her alien abductions, a grand narrative coalesced which reframed an encounter from eight years old, when she "was reintroduced to the fact I have a dual soul," something she had been aware of before birth but long since forgotten. Prior to incarnating on Earth, her "ancient soul-source" selected adaptations for her life, divided the wisdom of eons into its most useful constituents, and became a soul. Supervising the entire incarnation process, as well as decisions throughout Hansen's life, is a "Universal Governing Body."[3594]

> The familiar soul, the blue ball of light, would accompany me in this life, as would two others from the group of souls present, souls which had entered lives already and had left their human forms to be present at this meeting. Decision-making is not restricted to the individual soul, but is a consensus of consciousness between several souls. We would all become part of something together, but the blue soul is the one I have had a long connection with in previous lives, and this would continue in the new life.[3595]Prior to arriving on our planet, another soul from an alien species paired with Hansen's, allowing her and others to "operate on two levels," "answering 'the call' from Earth," a mission by now familiar to readers. This union of

> opposites allows "the Grey species to observe humanity from within, rather than from without," learning about the emotions and "human personality characteristics" they lack. In exchange, they assist the "whole persona" with "problem-solving."[3596]

In an interesting twist, humans may be called upon to leave their bodies as orbs of light to work *as* Grey aliens, performing psychopomp duties like alleviating the suffering of the terminally ill or extending their lives. Whenever Hansen becomes a Grey, her humanity remains vestigial, but nonetheless present in the background. Despite the patently metaphysical flavor of her experiences, flying saucer pageantry remains at the fore, complete with apparently-physical "craft" and assurances that we are dealing with an actual, embodied species.[3597]

Hansen admitted she "struggled to come to terms with this awareness of duality," constantly feeling "as if I had 'two brains' and 'two heads.' In a sense, dual soul humans are experiencing two lives and two purposes." She now believes that when we die, we return to the Well of Souls, where the soul divides once again.[3598]

"The original soul-source will be offered choices: return to rest in the peace of the Field of Consciousness to await another opportunity of life, or remain in the soul state and assist the Greys in other ways," she wrote. "The Grey identity however, will not come to any demise through the death of the human form. It will not necessarily return to the soul-source but may simply continue as a working life-form, inhabiting another Grey body."[3599]

Not every Grey is involved in a Dual Soul relationship. Hansen's appraisal of the hybrid program—wholly positive, as she has "never seen any evidence" of negativity across her experiences—largely focuses on human-alien unions at a soul level, although she does believe she has met "a transgenic or hybrid entity."[3600]

It is interesting to compare the Dual Soul model to a report from Betty Andreasson, who once watched aliens remove *two* fetuses from an abductee. "One fetus had normal white eyes but the other had big black eyes like the alien entities," Fowler wrote.[3601]

The Dual Soul Connection features coauthor Rudy Schild, who tries to make Hansen's story more appetizing to modern tastes by applying the nascent field of quantum physics. His explanations seem strained—the Dual Soul idea, for all its fantastic elements, is best understood outside the restrictions of science. There is no need to reinvent the metaphysical wheel. On one level, Hansen's story obviously reifies basic psychology, the rational Greys representing either our subconscious or analytic "left brain."

Spirituality is more rewarding still. The Dual Soul idea clearly resembles polypsychism (Chapter 3). Alongside accounts of doubles and faerie co-walkers, we also find a "plurality of existences."

Initially used to describe reincarnation and past lives, "the notion of a plurality of existences has also been used to refer to a related but somewhat different idea," wrote James R. Lewis. "Namely, that the same soul *simultaneously* incarnates in different bodies, sometimes at great distances from each other, as when one claims to be in both a terrestrial and an extraterrestrial incarnation simultaneously."[3602]

The Dual Soul model also resembles belief surrounding Higher Selves or guardian angels. The Greys guide humans "via communication and interaction," Hansen claims. She feels she has "cheated death" on numerous occasions, narrowly escaping the fatal consequences of "accident, illness, and assault." As one medical professional remarked, "Somebody wants you alive, Suzy."[3603]

Everybody's talkin' 'bout a new way of walkin'

Suzy Hansen also described the need for her human and Grey sides to remain in balance. At least once her handlers warned her that human emotions were "weighing her down."[3604] The question naturally arises as to how an over-dominant Grey personality would manifest in a human being.

An answer may lie in reports of "walk-ins," first mentioned in Chapter 5 as a possible reinterpretation of the faerie changeling phenomenon. Walk-ins lend further credence to the idea that our corporeal selves are but mere vessels, from which our souls may vacate only to be substituted by another spiritual presence. Abductee Linda Porter claimed aliens were "amused by the human obsession with funerals… since old bodies are no more than 'empty beer cans.'"[3605]

Walk-ins are often regarded as "highly evolved souls here to help humanity that, to avoid the delay of spending two decades growing up, contact living people who, because of the frustrating circumstances of life or for some other reason, no longer desire to remain in the body." The inciting incident is typically—predictably, at this stage—trauma, with a high occurrence following NDEs.[3606]

The walk-in concept is ancient, but was codified by Ruth Montgomery in the late 1970s. Montgomery claimed "tens of thousands" of walk-ins exist at any given time, and include a legion of historical figures, particularly spiritual leaders. With 1979's *Strangers Among Us*, she expanded the idea to include

extraterrestrial walk-ins, a belief that has since enamored New Agers and fringe Ufologists. The book includes a handful of examples where beings from other worlds have inhabited human bodies, one of which complained at the state of the human condition, replete with chronic illness and general discontent.[3607]

"He dislikes having to live among earthlings," Montgomery related, "yet, having chosen to do so and having agreed to complete certain tasks, he is bound by his choice." In an echo of faerie capriciousness, Montgomery asserted these interlopers "mean no harm, which does not mean that they are not sometimes lethal in their activities when they approach too near to human beings." The aliens view us "like toys or marionettes," operating our bodies "without too much difficulty, but they are not many in number."[3608]

Montgomery revised this assessment several years later, finding enough examples to compile 1985's *Aliens Among Us*, introducing the idea that simple proximity to UFOs allows these exchanges to take place. In one interview, she was told extraterrestrial walk-ins occur "during a brief coma when a human of appropriate talents is within range of the equipment on spaceships." The amnesia associated with missing time is simply "another level of consciousness," abductions are both physical *and* mental, and the motivation for alien walk-ins stems from the common sense of "mission" described elsewhere.[3609]

Montgomery also reiterated the theme of consent in such encounters. Some aliens "temporarily exchang[e] bodies with earthlings 'with or [3610]without permission,'" while others "replace souls wishing to depart."[3611]

UFO accounts have long suggested our bodies' nature as vessels for something greater, eligible for soul "transfers" or "swaps."

- Omnec Onec claimed to be a Venusian spirit who took over the body of seven-year-old Sheila Gipson who died in a car crash in Tennessee in 1955.[3612]

- In June 1967 "Vivenus Starchild" broke onto the contactee scene with an appearance on Long John Nebel's *Party Line* radio program. Starchild claimed everyone on Earth has a "twin soul" on Venus who can only visit Earth after their paired soul dies. Starchild arrived on Earth after "Viv," her terrestrial double and a failed singer, committed suicide. Greg Bishop and Adam Gorightly suggested this metaphorically indicated "Vivenus killed off her old self to be born anew in Venusian flesh—a symbolic way of leaving her old life behind."

- A German witness watched Greys "inject" another soul while separated from his body one night in 1995. When it "left him" sometime later, he felt "a happiness that [he] had rarely known in [his] life which remains undiluted to this day, save for a little sadness and a strange kind of homesickness."[3613]

- Two years later, a witness in Bezhetsk, Russia met three Nordics from the planet "Galeya" in his apartment. Their female leader, Zuri, invited him to leave Earth with them in astral form to escape his "sufferings." They planned to replace his soul with another, which would turn his body into a "bio-robot." He refused. [3614]

Around the same time that a Visitor appeared in Strieber's apartment (mentioned earlier), he awoke with the sense that "there was somebody inside of me… As I came into consciousness, a youthful voice, shrill with fear, cried out, 'I'm being trapped inside a body.'"[3615] Maybe his Visitor was one of Lorie Barnes's "soul techs," monitoring or installing a Dual Soul.

The earlier examples Karla Turner collected from Lisa and Pat bring clones into play, implying their souls could somehow transfer to these new bodies.[3616] This process is detailed in Turner's *Masquerade of Angels* regarding Ted Rice, who told her that, as a child, his extraterrestrials "made a duplicate body… so that when, for whatever reason, they took your soul and put it in that cloned body, your mother never knew there was any difference."[3617] The resonance with changeling lore need not be said.

Rice even described the soul transferal procedure, where an alien woman placed a "black box with [his] soul" inside it upon his "new body," relocating his consciousness (Chapter 12 and the Epilogue). Similar boxes allegedly containing soul energy feature in other alien abductions, including those of Katharina Wilson.[3618]

Linda Porter, mentioned earlier, described how aliens "lifted out" her soul from her body and placed it in a new one during a severe infection as a child. She also saw this procedure performed on a terminally-ill middle-aged man who presumably recovered.[3619]

Close encounters of the sixth kind

While the two are related, afterlife scholar James R. Lewis described walk-ins as "a complete supplanting" of an individual's soul, rather than the "overshadowing" found in possession cases. Today's pop-culture depictions are mostly demonic, but possession has a storied history in Ufology.

In a 1969 document compiled by the Library of Congress for the Air Force Office of Scientific Research, Lynn E. Catoe perused existing flying saucer reports before concluding that "a large part of the available UFO literature is closely linked with mysticism and the metaphysical... Many of the UFO reports now being published in the popular press recount alleged incidents that are strikingly similar to demonic possession and psychic phenomena."[3620]

One of the most famous incidents surrounds Doreen Wilkinson, a New Zealand UFO investigator who suddenly began acting out of character, making sexual advances towards fellow researcher John Stuart. "This 'supernatural possession' occurred around the same time that a 'space man' appeared before Stuart and Wilkinson and telepathically instructed the pair to cease and desist with UFO investigations or their lives would be in danger," Bishop and Gorightly wrote. Wilkinson and Stuart shuttered their research group in December 1954 after the former was sexually assaulted by an invisible assailant in her hotel room.[3621]

William Baldwin's *CE-VI: Close Encounters of the Possession Kind* details this facet of UFO contact at length. Some instances are positive, others

negative. Little differentiates them from spirit attachment other than the entities' dubious testimony that they are extraterrestrial or have "never been on this planet," which could be said of any non-human spirit.[3622]

Baldwin uses "Spirit Releasement Therapy" to cleanse subjects of extraterrestrial attachments. Some of the accounts he collected strikingly resemble Hansen's Dual Soul model. In one instance, a woman named Carla discovered she had a brother from another solar system who, rather than incarnate himself, chose to lag behind in the spirit world. He wished for Carla to "withdraw so he could live through her body, or at least move aside so he could take over." Luckily, her alien brother realized the magnitude of his presumption and "agreed to go," after which (in a parallel of the German story above) her life improved.[3623]

The specter of undiagnosed mental illness looms large, of course. A schizophrenic character runs through stories of two souls inhabiting one body, bringing to mind diagnoses of dissociative identity disorder and other breaks from consensus reality. It is not enough to simply handwave away these stories with medical jargon, however, as our current understanding of human nature may be fundamentally flawed in today's Materialist society. Kripal espouses "the Human as Two," a concept first mentioned in Chapter 3:

> The problem here is a very simple one: As knowing subjects, we are not one but two. Until we recognize the Human as Two, we will not be able to see and accept the illusory nature of our little selves, our little cultures, and our little religions. Nor will we be able to recognize the cosmic vastness of who we really are. Consciousness is not ego. Consciousness is not culture. And yet no ego or culture can exist without "It."[3624]

Distinguishing between doubles, Dual Souls, walk-ins, and extraterrestrial possession can be tricky. These topics messily spill over into one another. For example, experiences where people are temporarily replaced by "clones" are worth viewing in the context of possession or walk-ins.

In short, they might only be reporting the *sensation* of physical abduction while clones assume their identities. In actuality, their souls might be observing their bodies being possessed. "Clones" may constitute imposters solely in spirit, presences inhabiting bodies while the rightful tenants remain temporarily evicted—homeless souls helplessly watching from the astral realm as spiritual squatters capture their physical selves.

Reincarnation gone right

The true worth of any ontology lies in its ability to incorporate outliers. Like an ill-constructed bridge, any framework buckling under the stress of the peculiar reveals underlying weaknesses flawed from the beginning. Houses should be built on rock, not sand—or, to reiterate St. Terry of McKenna's words, "If it's real, it can take the pressure."

Such is the state of the ETH. Its insistence upon the *physical* (nuts-and-bolts spacecraft, flesh-and-blood aliens) cannot weather the deluge of spiritual aspects found in reports, unless it expands to encompass the metaphysical. In doing so—which it must if it seeks to retain its explicative power, as such aspects cannot simply be ignored—the ETH's entire first-order logic collapses. Why presuppose physicality if the model invariably incorporates the non-physical?

This work highlights manifold issues undermining Materialism, but few contradict the paradigm as directly as reincarnation. The work of Ian Stevenson and Jim Tucker, briefly mentioned in the Introduction, remains particularly compelling. Reincarnation reports also persist across UFO contact in general: more than a quarter of FREE respondents indicated "the ETs gave them a message of reincarnation," with slightly fewer (22%) receiving information about past lives.[3625] ETH adherents defending Materialism would have us believe one-in-four alien abductees are either liars or mentally ill.

Mainstream researchers' disregard for reincarnation is primarily both modern and American. Chapter 10 illustrated how the earliest figures in Ufology, the contactees, many hailing from the United States, spoke at length about the spiritual dimensions of flying saucer interactions. Contemporary Ufologists "across the pond" readily embraced these metaphysical components, openly discussing reincarnation in England's *Flying Saucer Review* at least as early as the late 1950s. Two aspects dominated contactees' reincarnation talk: their past lives were predominantly extraterrestrial and originated *within* our solar system, rather than some far-flung planet. (These criteria are largely—but not entirely—absent in modern claims, as seen shortly.) Howard Menger, for example, claimed to be a reincarnated Saturnian.[3626]

By contrast, the American intelligence apparatus adopted an antagonistic stance towards UFOs, treating them as a national security threat with Project Sign, founded in the immediate aftermath of Kenneth Arnold's 1947 flying saucer sighting. American researchers took this posture in kind, doubling down as "abductions" gained prominence over contactee experiences in the 1970s-80s. While some prominent Ufologists like Leo Sprinkle refused to ignore the phenomenon's spiritual implications, several decades passed before American researchers and experiencers broached reincarnation in any lasting and meaningful way. The topic's endurance in Ufology today owes a great debt to John Mack, whose work in the 1990s refused to shy away from reincarnation, and, of course, Whitley Strieber.

Strieber's partnership with NDE researcher Kenneth Ring in the same era (Chapter 11) represented a profound inflection point in Ufology, forcing researchers to reconcile their discipline with soulcraft. Several years earlier in

1988, Strieber bravely stated "it was clear that the soul was very much at issue," adding, "I cannot forget my memory of the visitors' claim, 'We recycle souls.' It had also been said to other participants."[3627]

- Several of Mack's subjects were either explicitly told by aliens about reincarnation or intuited it themselves. "Maybe they help recycle souls," Dave wondered, adding that the aliens' concerns extended beyond any abductee's single life into their *multiple* lives.[3628]

Credo Mutwa echoed this in conversation with Mack: "the *mantindane* may follow you not only in this lifetime but in many others as well."

"Abductees also commonly experience a poignant sense that they have themselves become too separated from Home, Source, or God and will cry and rage against the fact that they have been incarnated or reincarnated back on Earth," Mack wrote.[3629]

- In 1962, a young Ron Card met a Venusian who told him not only that death as we know it doesn't exist, but upon Card's own demise he might choose to return to Earth or another planet. "You can call the death experience a change of worlds," he said.[3630]

- Lester Rosas met "Laan-Deeka" and "Sharanna" in Puerto Rico in early 1967 after receiving their telepathic communication. The beings, which hailed from (you guessed it) Venus, discussed reincarnation, proclaiming that only "advanced earthlings who obey nature's laws" were allowed to perpetuate their spiritual development through future lives.[3631]

- On April 29, 1989, four beings took "Roger" from Orlando, Florida aboard a craft filled with terrestrial and alien animals. They also showed him a "film" of his friend Nancy, who was in a hospital setting "on another ship." The aliens would not allow her to be reborn because she had already been born "too many times."[3632]

- The Volzhsky, Russia bedroom of an elderly WWII veteran was invaded in 1991 by a female alien who told him that when he died, his "biological mass will die but the soul will remain and may then enter another person in time."[3633]

Loathe though Ufologists may be to admit it, the possibility that reincarnation is the core purpose behind UFO contact draws disparate aspects of the phenomenon together, providing at least a baseline from which we can begin to understand High Strangeness. The alien obsession with our souls starts to make sense. OBEs become expected. Walk-ins shift from the New Age fringe into flying saucer orthodoxy. Hansen's Dual Soul idea, even if not entirely accurate, no longer feels like a "woo woo" outlier. Even the hybrid program can be tidily reframed in the context of reincarnation, as discussed at this chapter's end.

Try as they might, ETH proponents cannot escape the vast number of alien abductees who, like NDErs, insist upon discussing their past lives, existences into which they were once incarnated. Some memories are recalled through hypnotic regression, others relayed during abductions or actively recalled. In their past lives, Mack's subjects described living through WWII, serving in the United States Civil War, living in pre-Columbian America, selling wares as a Moroccan merchant in the 1200s, even painting the interiors of Egyptian

pyramids.[3634] Memories may even reach into prehistory when experiencers describe visions of mythical vanished continents like Atlantis or Lemuria.[3635]

Many stories imply UFO contact stretches across multiple lives. Eva told Mack she had been abducted as a boy in the 17th century.[3636] In Leo Sprinkle's book *Soul Samples*, entirely dedicated to reincarnation and UFOs, a white male attending the University of Wyoming remembered being a Native American "hiding in some bushes and watching a huge object slowly descending toward the Earth." Once inside, an odd "little man" told him, "You won't remember this event until another lifetime when you will be a white man."

Experiencers also describe psychic talents in their past lives. One subject told Sprinkle she had served as an Egyptian prophetess before dying from an insect sting. The trauma manifested in her current incarnation as entomophobia.[3637]

If flying saucers "have something to do with what we call death," then perhaps all of us contain these memories somewhere deep inside ourselves. Unlike most of us, however, alien abductees live in a world where past lives are not only remembered, but bleed through into everyday existence. Whether these individuals actually recall historical events or are merely fantasy-prone is up for debate—but the idea of reincarnation neatly fits into the ecology of souls, of which UFOs seem an integral component.

Beyond typical accusations of mental illness and fabrication, even some esoterically-inclined minds believe abductees do not recall their own past lives, but rather the lives of others. To employ Theosophical jargon, they pull

books out of the Akashic records where all events, past, present, and future, are shelved. Mack himself noted this possibility.

"It is not necessary to postulate that a past life identity belongs literally to the individual abductee in the same way that our bodies are only ours while we inhabit them," he wrote. "As biologist Rupert Sheldrake has suggested, it is possible that there exists a kind of eternal collective memory on which we all may draw." Mack cited Sheldrake's "morphic resonance" concept (quite similar to Jung's Collective Unconscious) through which individuals might "tune in to particular people in the past who are now dead," conflating them with their own previous incarnations.[3638]

Why am I such a misfit?

While most abductees lived their past existences on Earth, a significant portion mention *alien* past lives. Unlike those of the early contactees, these incarnations rarely took place in our solar system, instead originating in as-yet unexplored galaxies. After decades of investigating our nearest planetary neighbors, evidence of life remains elusive; we instead pushed the borders of the Otherworld further and further into space, and metaphysical Ufology followed suit.

Suspicions of alien past lives often appear in the wake of NDEs. "While researching the near-death phenomenon, I routinely encountered both child and adult experiencers who would say things like 'I feel like an alien' (or 'a misfit' or 'a foreigner')," P.M.H. Atwater discovered. "And they'd admit to being homesick for what they had to leave behind in order to come to earth." Interestingly, Atwater learned adults typically ascribed this "home" extraterrestrial qualities, while young NDErs overwhelmingly described "multidimensional realms."[3639]

Researcher Scott Mandelker differentiated alien past lives from spirit walk-ins by coining the term "Wanderers," aliens who transferred souls with humans at birth, continuing across multiple incarnations. Mandelker believes Wanderers are much more common than walk-ins.[3640] A similar concept, "born-ins," describes "the soul[s] of beings who decided to come to Earth for a specific purpose," choosing the daunting path of birth instead of taking over fully-grown bodies. Walk-ins by contrast represent the easier path.[3641]

These concepts overlap significantly with the Star Children mentioned towards the beginning of this chapter, to the extent they are sometimes considered one and the same. Jenny Randles's book *Star Children* features multiple individuals claiming they possess extraterrestrial souls. They invariably speak of incarnating on Earth to administer much-needed spiritual aid to humans. One such individual whom Randles interviewed was Gary, a Northamptonshire jelly salesman whose actual purpose included warning of impending catastrophes. He discovered his true self after a UFO sighting left him with "a terrible sense of loss and desertion."

Jayne, who also spoke with Randles, described the same feeling after returning from an OBE that took her to an alien desert populated by orbs of light: "Why have I not been taken? Why have they deserted me?" This led her to seriously entertain whether she was once an extraterrestrial. (Interestingly, Jayne was a psychopomp—she worked at a clinic for the terminally ill.)[3642]

Whatever the terminology, some modern abductees swear that a part of them once was alien, souls swapped long ago for terrestrial lives.

- Natalie's second UFO encounter on June 26, 1980 involved a demonstration of alien telepathy and invisibility, including the admonition that she must begin using her "*previous* abilities." She learned that she had died long ago when her own spacecraft crashed on Earth.[3643]

- In 1985, seven-year-old Andrey Zabava awoke in a circular room surrounded by hooded "doctors" after he fell off his bicycle in Ukraine. As an adult, Zabava came to believe he was the reincarnation of "Janefarlz," perhaps a Grey.[3644]

- Circa 1988, Arlene O. of Cincinnati, Ohio said she believed her recurring dreams of involvement in "a great experiment" to "seed this planet" indicated her extraterrestrial soul.[3645]

- Vickie B. from Glendale, California experienced her first dream of another world around age five or six. By adulthood she had fully embraced her identity as an alien from the planet "Sananda," going so far as to believe *all* humans were extraterrestrials deep inside. Her previous body, she was told, lay in suspended animation on a ship somewhere in outer space.[3646]

- In hypnotic regression with Mack in the 1990s, Paul remembered a frightful abduction which included explanations of "some relationship between us" and the aliens, that he was "from them." Paul detected "a kind of split in his awareness." His "alien identity… understood that they were trying to help him," while his human side had "trouble understanding who [he was]." Similarly, another of Mack's subjects felt that his son was "from there… incarnated as 'part ET.'"[3647]

- "I'm a gray in my soul," Karin admitted to Mack in *Passport to the Cosmos.* In fact, she rejected her given name, Deborah, in favor of "Karin" because it represented "her truer, soul name."[3648]

- Around 2000, another abductee described something akin to a Dual Soul: "I feel I am an extraterrestrial in human skin, so my extraterrestrial side totally agreed to the experiences, but my human self had a problem."[3649]

Whether fully or partially, the idea that we swap souls with extraterrestrials suggests not that aliens are us, but vice versa—or, more likely, that these terms are so interchangeable as to become meaningless. Everything has a soul, all derived from the same source. As this constitutes an animistic perspective, an animist analogy seems best.

Like rain we fall to Earth, joining others in the river of life to flow untold miles toward the sea where all becomes one before evaporating to begin anew. The raindrops falling in, say, Chicago are not identical to raindrops which fell earlier in Chicago; part of them may well be the same at the molecular level, while other parts could have once quenched the Indian subcontinent, or some equally foreign land. Just the same, our current existence may be formed entirely or partially from past lives to create a unique Self: either human or alien, or something in between. Whether these components arose from extraterrestrials or faeries or Hindu psychopomps is immaterial; they are different from, yet the same as us. The only guarantee is they are wholly of the One.

A raindrop is not an ocean, but contains within a microcosm of the ocean. The source always remains the same, the system closed. God is both within and without. We *are* star stuff. This is the first law of Hermeticism, authored by Hermes Trismegistus himself: as above, so below, the great embodied in the meek.

In the cloud

Between evaporating from the sea and falling to Earth, moisture is held within clouds. Our souls seem to inhabit a similar liminal state, if claims of "prebirth memories" are to be believed. In religions rejecting reincarnation, "preexistence" usefully explains where our souls dwelt before entering our bodies, "sometimes conceived of as a spark of the divine descending into matter from a pure spiritual realm in order to partake of the lessons offered in the sphere of ordinary life."[3650]

Traditions where reincarnation is not instantaneous may describe similar realms, like the Buddhist Bardo. The Ho-Chunk shaman Thunder Cloud described how he received his abilities from "Earth Maker" in an interstitial existence.[3651]

> I (my ghost) was taken to the place where the sun sets (the west)… While at that place, I thought I would come back to earth again, and the old man with whom I was staying said to me, "My son, did you not speak about wanting to go to the earth again?" I had, as a matter of fact, only thought of it, yet he knew what I wanted. Then he said to me, "You can go, but you must ask the chief first." Then I went and told the chief of the village of my desire... Then I was brought down to earth... There I lived until I died of old age... As I was lying [in my grave], someone said to me, "Come, let us go away." So then we went toward the setting of the sun. There we came to a village where we met all the dead… From that place I came to this earth again for the third time, and here I am.[3652]

Though literally the opposite of their typical focus, NDE researchers have collected numerous accounts of "premortal existence" from which people cross the threshold *into* life, both as recalled states of being and components of life reviews. In addition to dancing white clouds, experiencer Roy remembered "a giant building" which held "hundreds of robed people talking with one another among golden beams of light. There was a lady standing next to two massive doors." Within, he met God and asked to be reincarnated.[3653]

Another experiencer whose mother battled pregnancy complications before his premature birth even claimed an NDE *in utero.* "A being of bright golden light" with "massive hands... cradled and caressed" him as a fetus while he watched "the spirits or the spirit bodies of other babies that were about to be fitted with their earthly body… swirling around this powerful being who was holding me." These prebirth souls "even looked like they could have been coming forth every time he spoke." The experiencer was pulled "backwards down a dark tunnel" before landing "with a thud" in his mortal form.[3654]

Predictably, prebirth realms as presented by alien abductees involve UFO pageantry, typically spaceships or other planets. Steve Boucher spontaneously remembered standing atop "a ridge, or mountain" in a "high place" before his birth, from which he beheld Earth in its entirety. "I feel that I must have been standing somewhere on the moon, perhaps on the edge of a crater," he determined.[3655]

While Boucher perceived himself as a human boy, others remember themselves as luminescent orbs.[3656] Abductee Casey shared with Karla Turner visions of his prebirth self, "a ball of golden light" created by aliens in a

technological environment complete with computer terminals.[3657] Suzy Hansen remembered her prebirth soul as "a bright ball of purple light, consciously aware of my surroundings," attended by "a council of wise beings." Part of this realm involved "a boundless white space, a place of quietude."[3658]

Witnesses might meet unborn souls they will later come to know. Hansen touchingly recalled a blue glowing orb presented to her long before she was even married, being told, "You will *love* this… This will be your son." It was revealed the two had been connected throughout previous lives. When he was four years old, Hansen's son explained how he "knew [her], a long, long time ago."[3659]

Similarly, both unborn and miscarried children appear in NDEs. In one example, a mother 11 weeks pregnant stopped breathing and spoke with the son inside her.[3660] Another woman flatlined during surgery and met a daughter she had lost, as well as her miscarried granddaughter.[3661]

Even Strieber's output contains hints at the Visitor's prebirth presence, or at least their early intervention. Upon meeting a ghostly woman in a dreamlike state on October 27, 2019—"at once a stranger yet also very familiar to me"—he asked her, "How long have you known me?"[3662]

"Since you were born," she answered before the encounter ended.[3663] A similar exchange was selected for inclusion in the Striebers' *The Communion Letters*, where an Arkansas experiencer asked how long her aliens had been visiting her.

"The reply was both before and after I was in the womb," wrote the correspondent. She learned she "was a 'chosen' one for them and the Supreme Being."[3664] This intimate relationship and selection feels both shamanic and quite Christian.

"The Goldi, the Dolgan, and the Tungus say that, before birth, the souls of children perch like little birds on the branches of the Cosmic Tree and the shamans go there to find them," Mircea Eliade wrote.[3665] Jeremiah 1:5 says: "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, before you were born I set you apart; I appointed you as a prophet to the nations."

Some are chosen, others volunteer. UFO researchers open to the phenomenon's spiritual components often justify the lack of consent in abductions by suggesting aliens and abductees reached some sort of "prebirth agreement" to incarnate and participate, similar to the ultimatums found in NDEs.

Even so, this explanation feels callous in light of the trauma some alien abductees suffer. A friend of Ted Rice's told him, "You're overreacting, and besides, you can't do anything about it. Your higher self gave permission for it on some level, probably before you were reincarnated. It's all been planned, so you may as well kick back and enjoy it."[3666]

In this view, alien abductions simply represent the terms and conditions of reincarnation. The prevalence of this idea, which might find a rough corollary in the gilgul of Jewish Kabbalistic tradition, cannot be overstated.[3667] In his past life explorations, William Baldwin found "between 50% and 70% of any group will recall the experience of choosing to come to planet Earth from somewhere else."[3668]

Agreements to participate in alien abductions from prebirth and past lives pepper Mack's research. For instance, Peter sensed he volunteered "back ten life-times" to come to Earth and participate in the hybrid program.[3669] Karin agreed her experiences were consensual, but remained unsure whether they constituted "a presoul agreement or a 'this life' agreement." Catherine told Mack abductees choose to come to Earth "after a kind of council or debriefing" in the presence of Source, their exact destinations determined by what lessons they need to learn.[3670] As Ian Stevenson and Jim Tucker noted in their reincarnation research, all of us, including alien abductees, gradually lose knowledge of our true selves. [3671] This is expected—the aliens "know that you're going to lose the knowledge of the Source."[3672]

Casey, mentioned above, also volunteered to return to Earth. "It's time," he said. "My feeling is that it's a difficult decision to make… knowing I really change, knowing I will not be myself, that I elected to do it." A desire "to feel more than just inside" (i.e. become embodied) led to this agreement. "But it's like, there is reason, there is purpose, and I have to do it and want to do it, and it's time to do it, and I can, and I go."[3673]

Elizabeth Richmond underwent hypnotic regression years after seeing a red, sunlike object with her husband above Black Hills National Forest in 1973. Apparently, their car had levitated into an enormous flying saucer piloted by Greys. One named "Maag" or "Mog" told Richmond they had produced a pair of daughters together. Like "many others," she had long ago volunteered to reincarnate on Earth in preparation for an imminent "new era of world peace."[3674]

Despite coming to terms with his experiences, Steve Boucher's prebirth memories feature an elaborate bureaucracy involving soul contracts which, while consensual, display a slightly sinister flavor. The Greys, according to Boucher, can either be positive or negative (like the fae), functioning as "mercenaries" within the ecology of souls. The vaguely-alluded-to council of entities acts unilaterally.[3675]

"Once you give them your consent or implied consent in some cases, you become trapped on the wheel of karma and find yourself living on earth in debt slavery, sometimes for hundreds of lifetimes," he explained. "You have sold yourself into slavery and have now essentially become property." Boucher says he "begged and pleaded" with the council "not to be sent here," but was threatened with assignment "somewhere far worse."[3676]

Boucher's resentment resembles an exchange Mike Clelland recovered under hypnosis. While recognizing the technique's power for personal growth, Clelland remains refreshingly agnostic towards memories retrieved under hypnotic regression, neither discounting them nor treating them as entirely factual. In November 2017, alien abduction researcher Mary Rodwell regressed Clelland. [3677]

"What came through was jumbled and emotional," he wrote, "and I didn't know what to make of it." In both this and a subsequent 2018 session with Yvonne Smith, Clelland focused on the night of March 10, 2013, when he saw a large round structure while camping in Utah (Chapter 9). Under hypnosis, he remembered possibly leaving his body and entering a smooth hallway, escorted by two Grey aliens.[3678]

"*I'm not me,* I'm one of them," Clelland explained. He then found himself in "a conference room like you would have in a hotel," attending what felt like a meeting or a "trial." Clelland remembers an emphasis on "a job I came here to do," but felt slighted by the pain and sadness of being human.

"Why does it have to be SO hard?" he asked. "They didn't tell me it would be this hard being here."[3679]

The presences, unable to relate, instead reaffirmed his mission: "You agreed to this and now it's happening. *Right now!*"[3680]

Others share Clelland's urgency, but the exact nature of the mission remains inconsistent across reports. As we have seen, the task may be global or personal, environmental or spiritual, yet its core meaning stays intact: modernity has led us down a dark path, and these individuals hold the key to a better existence.

In *Passport to the Cosmos*, Catherine told Mack she was incarnated to "force us through the isolation" of separation from Source and "make different connections with the Energy" so we might "disengag[e] once again from the physical… If you keep the knowledge of the Source, that kind of defeats the purpose of the experiment, which continues over many lifetimes." Gary recast this in an evangelizing light: "More shamans" must unite to "lift the consciousness of their people."[3681]

To that end, alien abductees describe our world as a place for souls to develop. Recall Strieber's Chapter 14 assessment that this planet "is a school… where souls are growing and evolving."[3682] In order to learn their

lessons, souls might deliberately choose lives of adversity, as Catherine did, growing up in "extreme poverty."[3683]

This suggests an alternate perspective on the incidence of trauma that alien abductees report. UFO contact is not an accidental result of hardship, hardship is a deliberate result of UFO contact.

Others evoke psychopomp symbolism in the form of transit stations, deeming Earth a liminal zone where souls learn valuable lessons before continuing on their way. New Zealand author Robin Collyns proposed in 1974's *Did Spacemen Colonise the Earth?* that our world began as a "waystation for reincarnated souls from other parts of the universe."[3684] Building off testimony from Audrey, an alien abductee from Devon, Jenny Randles entertained a notion that "earth is like a giant transit lounge where entities from various worlds go about their business—sometimes as themselves (i.e. in their own bodies), sometimes by inhabiting earth bodies in a form of spirit possession… but also by a programme of genetic interbreeding…."[3685]

Whether stations or schools, the message is clear: We are sojourners. This world is not our home. Earth, perhaps our very reality, is nothing more than a pitstop in the ecology of souls.

Water-bearers from the Well of Souls

Clarity in a field as contradictory as Ufology is vanishingly rare. While any overarching hypothesis ignores large subsets of data by necessity, a "Theory of Everything" regarding UFOs should dismiss the *fewest* reports possible. This is the cardinal sin of the ETH: a vocal contingent of biased researchers willfully ignore the highly spiritual nature of UFO contact. If our discussion reveals anything, it is the frequency with which these elements occur, even in cases otherwise considered "extraterrestrial" by Ufology's rank-and-file.

These are not a minority. As a hallmark of contact, High Strangeness should strengthen, rather than weaken testimony. At the very *least*, UFOs fail to conform to our current Materialist model of reality.

Every researcher should beware their own pet theory's allure. Minds made up are stagnant minds, and stagnant minds calcify. "Belief is the enemy," John Keel warned.[3686] With that in mind, what follows eschews the conservative language of previous chapters—"it seems," "perhaps," etc.—only to streamline conversation (similarly, the term "alien" is a placeholder for some sort of guiding force or entities beyond description). It should be taken as speculation, not some definite truth.

So who are these little green men over which so much ink has been spilt? Ourselves? The Other? Gods or Goddesses? Ancestors? In discerning their nature, perhaps we should remember the designer's old adage: form follows

function. They are any and all these things. We need not determine their identities, only their purpose.

Since they are ever-present at death and rebirth, let us assume our aliens are psychopomps and psychogogs, water-bearers from the Well of Souls leading us both across transitions and through existence. Leo Sprinkle felt an "excellent model" of UFO activity came from early flying saucer researcher Morris K. Jessup, who proposed a psychopomp metaphor: "aliens are the sheep dogs" for humanity, subservient to the higher powers or Source, depending upon one's perspective.

"If we (sheep) follow the Higher Forces (shepherds), then all is well," Sprinkle explained. "If we do not, then the aliens (sheep dogs) come after us and nip our heels! And it hurts!"[3687]

This managerial metaphor reflects how we are told time-and-again that aliens see themselves as "Earth gardeners"[3688] or "custodians."[3689] Reincarnation is their domain, bringing to mind both fertility deities and faeries as "nature elementals" overseeing the creation of life. This explains the presence of Earth animals aboard some flying saucers: by necessity they manage *all* life, the entire ecology of souls, human and extraterrestrial, plant and animal.

This not only means death, but birth. Like psychopomp birds, aliens are responsible for bringing us into creation once again, folkloric storks delivering newborns to expectant mothers. Experiencers persistently report their power over our souls through phenomena like reincarnation, UFO-induced OBEs, soul transferals… and the hybrid program.

Reincarnation allows us to at last reframe this hybrid agenda as *prebirth memories from an observer's perspective*. Collections of eggs and semen are not technological terrors, but conception reified, a theatrical representation of incarnation. Vessels holding human-alien hybrids are not artificial wombs sustaining chimeric monstrosities, but rather intermediary areas where souls, some newly departed, slough off their true form—the small soul, the Grey, the faerie, *the fetal aspects which we lose as we develop, then return to after death*—in preparation for the human proportions of life anew.

As stewards of reincarnation, aliens transfer these souls to human bodies. For instance, Suzy Hansen described playing with a ball of light as a child, one destined to enter an infant's body "with assistance from the senior Grey."[3690]

We are in thoroughly uncomfortable territory, especially for Ufologists. Some, like Donald Ware, have obliquely flirted with this idea, suggesting the hybrid program's goal is to fashion bodies "to house our souls in future incarnations." Ware called this *Homo sapiens alterios*, destined "to develop unconditional love of others."[3691]

Here—appropriately enough for an imaginal phenomenon—lines blur between physical bodies and souls. Remember, the infants seen in extraterrestrial incubatoriums are the same fetuses which female abductees report missing, i.e. they are dead. Miscarried children may be reassigned. In Karla Turner's *Taken,* abductee Angie asked if the aliens had revived the child she had lost, and was told "its physical body had been stored and its soul recycled"—in other words, reincarnated. Elsewhere, Turner wrote:

> …Pat remembers finding herself in a quiet room, surrounded by Grays and waiting for something. The Gray she thought of as her "friend" appeared in the doorway, showing her a baby. He told her that she had a choice to see the baby.
>
> "No," Pat replied, "it's okay, it's fine. You'll take better care of it than I could." But in that brief glimpse, she saw a tiny, skinny baby with blue, slanted eyes. She felt that somehow this baby was a repository for the soul of the child who had died at birth, and she said she felt trusting and thankful toward her friend for showing her that the little boy had, in a sense, survived.[3692]

Hybrids in baby presentations seem sickly because they represent premature infants, or are physical shells awaiting soul-assignment. The rooms in which these baby presentations unfold are sometimes compared to playrooms, preschools, or nurseries—conforming remarkably to environments reported in shamanic visits to the Otherworld (the Cosmic Tree) and entheogen use, like Terence McKenna's DMT realm, a space "prepared for baby."[3693] Other psychedelic users agree: it was "like a nursery… there were cribs and different animals, vibrant," said one DMT study participant. "There were toys there, like I was a child," remarked another.[3694]

That these children are not always assigned to their mortal parents in the "real world" is of little consequence. If all is One, as aliens love to proclaim, we might contribute to any conception anywhere in the world.

Modeling the impossible

Suffice to say, this hypothesis is *strange*. It is far from perfect. It may be incomplete or even wholly incorrect. At the same time, it seems one of the few avenues by which we might reconcile flying saucers with 17 chapters' worth of ancient religions, mythologies, and traditions.

Using an ecology of souls model, we can sketch a rough summary of both alien abductions and the "extraterrestrial" agenda: a select few of us recall interactions with spirits (the ancestral dead, a part of ourselves, non-human psychopomps, or all three) while adrift in the astral realm. The purpose of these interactions varies. They may be positive or negative, self-induced or initiated by spirits. Dreams seem to be a favorite vector for such interaction (an awareness of the soul leaving or returning to the body may be the source of phenomena like sleep paralysis).

During these appointments we return to Source, to God, to the Otherworld where we once existed between lives. Some experiences, if remembered and integrated properly, bring about totality of the self, leading to spiritual awakening and enhanced psychic powers. Our divine spark within is rekindled.

Other visits offer a peek into the process behind reincarnation, which has been misconstrued (or intentionally disguised) as a literal human-alien hybridization program. This entire enterprise is staffed by entities which may well be "small souls"—the Greys—who chose to remain incorporeal and fulfill

their duties as "soul techs." The Grey configuration is how human souls truly appear, one step removed from fundamental soul energy, seen elsewhere as orbs of light. We retain these Grey alien proportions in the womb, only to slowly find ourselves further removed, more human, with each passing year.

The hybrids released into our world are nothing more than ourselves, reincarnated to live yet another life on Earth, assigned the duty of bringing love or, less saccharine, compassion. Here, in this planetary school, we learn the lessons which improve not only our next life, but the state of humanity as a whole. The bravest among us shamanize.

As far as flying saucer sightings in general, they may indeed be here for the fantastic purpose so often proposed by the Ufological fringe: to collect our dead in preparation for their next existence, psychopomps returning souls to Source. The realm so often interpreted as aboard an alien spaceship may in fact be the most liminal realm of all—neither heaven nor hell, Earth nor the Otherworld, but a neutral processing zone for the dead to be laundered anew.

The UFO *is* the ecology of souls. This seems to be what Anne Strieber was driving at nearly 40 years ago.

UFOs have something to do with death because they have *everything* to do with life.

18

CRYPTIDS & OTHER UNINVITED GUESTS

OBJ



Not all monsters are created equal. Some seem natural enough. Others are mired in High Strangeness. Even the configuration of some more believable cryptids—animals unrecognized by mainstream science, either extinct, out-of-place, or mythical—beggars belief. Despite this ephemerality, most cryptozoologists adhere to a Materialist paradigm, and believe cryptids can be bagged and tagged. (Parapsychology suffers a similar myopia, categorizing everything as spiritual; Ufology, for all its shortcomings, seems the only discipline capable of straddling this gap.)

It is an unfortunate obsession, because many cryptids seem quite plausible. It is reasonable to suggest that the thylacine, driven to extinction in the 1930s, endures in isolated corners of the Australian wilderness. It is another thing altogether to suggest *Gigantopithecus blacki* or some other

massive, hairy hominid roams America, or that Scotland's Loch Ness holds a surviving plesiosaur.

Still, these creatures at least exhibit a rough precedent in the fossil record. When we venture into Mothman, a winged humanoid, or Dogman—quite literally a "werewolf" by another name—odds of their flesh-and-blood nature drop precipitously.

As with UFO occupants, alongside these cryptid celebrities lurk curious "one offs" like the short, grey creature which terrified Enfield, Illinois in the spring of 1973. Initial witness Henry McDaniel said the creature boasted large, pink eyes and, most curiously, *three legs*.[3695] Skeptics and cryptozoologists alike offer silly suggestions, either an escaped ape or kangaroo or, more fantastically, an actual monster, perhaps a genetic experiment or an extraterrestrial.[3696]

Neither camp drew upon folklore. If the paranormal is indeed death-obsessed and "the Enfield Horror" represents something beyond misidentification or fabrication, it makes more sense to look for answers in mythology—perhaps the Danish *helhest*, a harbinger of death in the form of a pale, three-legged horse,[3697] or the tripod steed which once bore a County Galway victim to a faerie fort.[3698]

To that end, cryptozoology rarely finds explicative power in mythology and, when it does, remains yoked to modern scientific mores. The discipline has become brittle in its loyalty to Materialism and Colonialism. For instance, when faced with claims from North American tribes that Bigfoot can disappear, the explanation always falls into tired tropes of primitive or ignorant indigenous witnesses. Materialism says animals can't vanish at will,

and since Bigfoot is *definitely* an animal, poor perception or superstition are to blame.

Like their ETH brethren, cryptozoologists often overlook the richness of parapsychology, psi research, and consciousness studies. Yes, cryptids like Bigfoot and Nessie resemble extinct species, but little serious thought is afforded to the idea that we might be dealing with *Gigantopithecus* and plesiosaur *ghosts*, rather than surviving populations. They also deny the power myth exerts upon reality.

"Whether searching for hidden creatures or for pieces of wood, cryptozoologists and sceptics consciously refuse to accept myth as a product of the human mind, as an imaginary story," wrote Michel Meurger, whose *Lake Monsters: A Cross-Cultural Analysis* informs much of our later discussion. "They accept Man as a witness of Nature, but not as a creator of a mythified naturalism. For them myths and legends are always the echo of an objective experience; they are like archaeologists excavating the soft soil of fables looking for a hard reality."[3699]

While large, spectral black dogs and cats technically fall under the cryptozoological umbrella, they have been discussed extensively. For the discussion at hand, we turn to other beasties mentioned only in passing, creatures more of the Otherworld than our world.

Bigfoot:

Hairy ghosts

Tales of large, hairy, humanlike primates living in the wilderness have preoccupied American imagination since the 1950s. In reality, these reports are neither solely modern nor exclusively American, coming from early pioneers and indigenous tribes in the New World and prefigured in wild man belief from every culture. Researchers nonetheless hope to one day collect irrefutable proof, perhaps a living or dead specimen, to prove the existence of creatures like North America's Bigfoot or Sasquatch.

That the wild man should be so ubiquitous yet constantly evade the scientific establishment clearly implies *something else* is going on, something far stranger than rank-and-file cryptozoologists would have us believe. The flesh-and-blood hypothesis (F&BH) holds even more of a stranglehold in the Bigfoot community than the ETH does in Ufology, its adherents even more dismissive of alternate explanations. These researchers willfully overlook the preponderance of High Strangeness accompanying not just the American Sasquatch, but other hairy hominids as well: European wild men, the Himalayan *Yeti*, Russian *Almasty*, Australian *Yowie*, Chinese *Yeren*, etc. (Specific examples notwithstanding, we henceforth refer to hairy hominids in general as "Bigfoot.")

At the risk of sounding like a sales pitch, this chapter cannot address these issues more exhaustively than 2020's two-volume work *Where the Footprints*

End: High Strangeness and the Bigfoot Phenomenon written by the author and Timothy Renner. These books are recommended in order to fully appreciate just how *weird* ape-men can be in sightings. While much of what follows is familiar to readers of this duology, later discussion, particularly from psychopomps onward, is new.

Where the Footprints End compares Bigfoot to other creatures from folklore, including UFO occupants, faeries, witches, demons, archetypal Women-in-White, and, of course, spirit phenomena like ghosts and poltergeists. Much to the chagrin of F&BH proponents, Bigfoot suffers guilt by association with these "unrelated" topics. For instance, the creatures sometimes appear alongside or even *inside* flying saucers, as extensively detailed in the field work of Pennsylvania researcher Stan Gordon.

The overlap is extensive. Bigfoot share many qualities with aliens and faeries: abduction, levitation, floating, phasing, disappearing, possession, telepathy, EVP, light phenomena, electronic interference, shapeshifting, foul odors of decay, cold spots, leaving behind changelings, livestock mutilation, acceptance of offerings, aversion to prayer, resilience to firearms, and an association with what many interpret as interdimensional "portals." Furthermore, accounts where Bigfoot are not seen (dubbed "Class B Reports" by researchers) manifest activity which, seen in a house, would clearly be deemed poltergeist phenomena: lithoboly of warm stones, raps, strange odors and guttural vocalizations, etc. Hairy ape-men have even been reported manifesting during séances.[3700]

While they should not be spoken of monolithically, a plurality of Native American tribes generally regard Bigfoot as a spirit, or at least a physical

being closely connected to the Otherworld. Their identity as the dead is apparent in Klamath, Micmac, and Tlingit Bigfoot analogues—*Yahyahaas*, *Skade'gamutc*, and *Kushtakaa* respectively—the last of whom represent souls of the drowned whose cries foretell death.[3701]

Around the turn of the 20th century, it was very much *en vogue* to describe Bigfoot in American newspapers as "hairy ghosts." Some rural Americans today still use the term "haint" interchangeably for both ghosts and Bigfoot, as well as "booger," a word originating in faerie Bogeys from which we also derive "Boogeyman."[3702] Use of the word "ghost" to describe similar creatures in other cultures, like *la Calchona* in Chile, may not refer to the dead specifically but nonetheless speaks to the wild man's universal conceptualization as a spirit, rather than an undiscovered primate.[3703]

Even overseas, some regard Eurasia's *Almasty* and the Tatar *Arzurri* as human souls.[3704] While the term originated in Persia, Javanese mythology adopted the *Genderuwo* as a ghost who became a large, oft-invisible, shapeshifting ape.[3705] Parallels can even be drawn between Bigfoot and Norse revenants, the draugr, particularly their immense size, dark coloration, immunity to weaponry, and association with anomalous lights.[3706]

In recent decades witnesses have come forward claiming to be "habituators," owners of property hosting ongoing Bigfoot activity. These are practically indistinguishable from hauntings, with witnesses invariably reporting oddities incongruous with the F&BH like electronic interference, orbs of light, and even human ghosts. These disturbances can manifest inside their homes, much like hauntings—one witness saw semi-transparent

figures "in the shape of a Bigfoot" darting into rooms and vanishing, in one instance leaving behind a single, solitary, 18-inch footprint.[3707]

Earlier, we established how ghosts are inveterate shapeshifters. Setting aside this possibility, why would the human dead appear hirsute? Bigfoot and their ilk might not be the *recently* dead, but rather ancestors so distant they stretch beyond *Homo sapiens*, ghosts of a species long-vanished from the face of the Earth. They may be spectral *Gigantopithecus* or, more recently, *Homo neanderthalensis.*

The latter possibility is strengthened by Danny Vendramini's forensic reconstruction of Neanderthal skulls, which casts the species in a terrifying new light. Vendramini depicts Neanderthals as hairy hulks predating upon humans, their faces much more apelike than conventional reconstructions. Aside from their flattened noses, many Bigfoot witnesses find the resemblance uncanny.[3708]

Bigfoot:

Cannibal giants

A compelling argument can be made that Bigfoot and the giants of legend are the same class of entity. Indeed, many North American indigenous traditions speak interchangeably of what we would today call "Bigfoot" and "cannibal giants." This perspective grants access to ancient traditions where giants were sometimes the dead. In the Greek world, ghosts could grow to enormous size: in order to learn more about Homer's account of the Trojan War, Apollonius of Tyana conjured a ghost who "grew to a height of twelve cubits" (18 feet).[3709]

Edgar Herzog classified cannibal giants in both North American and Asian traditions as death-demons, "bearers of sickness… devouring Death."[3710] This archetype is rich and old, appearing in the West as *Kronos*, the Greek Titan who consumed his children; a syncretized avatar of time itself representing the ravages of entropy, the death of all things.

On a more literal level, rumors persist of giant skeletons exhumed from North American mounds (Chapter 8). Could Bigfoot represent the ghosts of the mound builders? Have we *actually* found Bigfoot remains, and simply didn't recognize them as such? The idea borders upon problematic, dehumanizing what was clearly an advanced human culture. Possible reconciliation can be found in some indigenous beliefs surrounding mankind's corruptibility.

Barbara Mann wrote that, "as among the Iroquois, the Giants of Lenâpé tradition lost their humanity due to exigent circumstances, devolving socially into cannibals while growing mystically through wrinkled spirit power into giants." Similarly, the Cherokee claimed their cannibal giants, the "Stone Coats," maintained a veneer of humanity by blending in with human tribe members. Often times, these giants came from a land to the West, site of the setting sun and the afterlife.[3711] As with so many paranormal phenomena, distinctions between real and unreal, living and dead, fantasy and reality marry in an imaginal soup.

A pottery fragment obtained from a mound near Tennessee's Clinch River further links the mound builders to Bigfoot, if only circumstantially. The shard clearly depicts a simian face. As monkeys are nowhere to be found in North America, it leaves us wondering. Did cultural exchange bring non-human primates northward, either as specimens or artwork? Does it depict a flesh-and-blood Bigfoot? Or was this image, like other effigies found at the mounds, derived from a shamanic altered state of consciousness?[3712]

Equally startling, an ape skull was unearthed at Northern Ireland's Eamhain Mhacha (Navan), a fort near Armagh—over 1,500 miles from the nearest ape habitat.[3713] Recall that the construction of European megaliths was sometimes attributed to *giants*. Large, spectral simians exhibit an affinity for ancient monuments and burial sites the world over, it seems.

- In India, hairy *rakshasas* are believed to haunt burial grounds.[3714]

- In 1967, a Bigfoot harassed a witness in Chicago's Schiller Woods Forest Preserve, a property encompassing Robinson Woods Indian Burial Ground. The creature threw stones at him and literally vanished after the witness cried to Jesus for help.[3715]

- In the 1970s, an archaeologist excavating indigenous burial grounds in the Everglades reported at least eight encounters with Skunk Apes.[3716]

- In 1972, the hairy Missouri Monster or "Momo" visited the confusingly-named town of Louisiana, Missouri. In its wake came disembodied voices in the forest and UFO phenomena, including fireballs and a "perfect gold cross on the moon."[3717] Early settlers to the area found a mysterious stonework two miles southwest, complete with chambers containing human remains.[3718]

- Fayette County, Pennsylvania—epicenter of the infamous 1973 UFO-Bigfoot flap, including George Kowalczyk's Chapter 12 encounter—featured numerous earthworks, including a 13-acre pentagonal mound near Brownsville.[3719]

- Wild men have been sighted over the years around Blue Bell Hill in Kent, England, home to Kit's Coty House, a chambered long barrow. Local folklore holds a "hairy man" can be seen standing by the stones, seen in the vicinity by campers in the 1970s and by several military personnel in 1992.[3720]

- A witness on an island in the United Kingdom (name and location withheld) encountered a strange, masculine presence within a Neolithic dolmen. As part of a group of magical practitioners, she regularly visited the location with others, but on

this occasion was alone. She respectfully entered the chamber within to meditate, something she "would do from time to time."

Despite its narrow walls, "all of a sudden this huge presence was sitting opposite me, and he filled the space," infusing the dolmen with an "overpowering musky odor," a scent often ascribed to Bigfoot. She sensed the "huge beast" stood at least nine feet tall. Her impression was that the tomb had been constructed specifically for this presence.[3721]

The incidence with which Bigfoot is seen at burial sites persists into contemporary spaces. As with UFOs, the number of hairy hominid sightings in graveyards and cemeteries is so great they should be considered "hotspots." Whether this is thanks to witness mindfulness or some strange attraction remains unclear, but it represents yet another example of Bigfoot cavorting among our dead.

Any connection Bigfoot may have to the mounds reinforces their association with both the Cosmic Mountain and subterranean spaces, traditional dwellings of supernatural creatures and, of course, the dead. Numerous tribes, including California's Yurok, contend Bigfoot stick to ridgelines. Contemporary sightings often occur in the vicinity of mountains, caves, and abandoned mines, implying they dwell within.[3722]

Bigfoot:

Near-death Sasquatch

Unlike other contact modalities, Bigfoot sightings share relatively little in common with near-death experiences. Notable absences include inaccessible knowledge, enhanced perception, ultimatums, and levitation or out-of-body experiences. Tunnels are nowhere to be found—unless we mention anomalous stick structures, a forced comparison at best—as are life reviews, with the exception of terrified witnesses who may see their lives "flash before their eyes."

Little attention has been afforded to the possibility that Bigfoot sightings involve altered states of consciousness. This discussion, while fascinating, is too extensive to pursue here, and readers are instead referred to *Where the Footprints End* Volume II, which covers the nascent topic in depth. Suffice to say, no shortage of witnesses are roused from sleep by these creatures, sometimes with symptoms resembling sleep paralysis. F&BH advocates typically dismiss elements of ASCs in sightings as the effects of "infrasound," inaudible, low-frequency vocalizations employed by other animals to disorient their prey—an interesting possibility, but overused as an explanation for the phenomenon's stranger aspects, like Bigfoot's ability to disappear.[3723]

A quick comparison of NDEs and Bigfoot reports:

- **Sound.** In addition to eerie silences before encounters—Jenny Randles's "Oz Factor"—witnesses report strange buzzes, clicks, and whistles, as well as bell chimes.[3724]

- **Sense of peace.** While not often a factor, a metaphysically-minded witness told researcher Rob Riggs that Bigfoot appeared whenever he "entered a profound state of peacefulness."[3725]

- **Landscapes.** Bigfoot encounters rarely occur in pastoral settings. They do, however, unfold in the wilderness, a romanticized locale (this is admittedly a stretch).

- **Interiors.** As noted in the previous section, Bigfoot are often seen entering or leaving underground spaces.

- **Supernatural lapses of time.** Missing time in Bigfoot encounters is rarely discussed, but happens surprisingly often. In Tillamook lore, anyone visiting the home of the Thunder giant finds time passing at a rate of one day in the Otherworld, a year in our reality.[3726] Following a 2012 Bigfoot encounter with his brother, podcaster Wes Germer remarked that "it only should've taken 30 to 40 minutes, tops. And we were there three hours, and neither of us can account for the time."[3727] A Spokane informant told anthropologist Ed Fusch that, after encountering a *S'cwene'y'ti* one morning, he found himself walking the same road that afternoon with no memory of the intervening interval.[3728]

- **Love.** Like other paranormal phenomena, Bigfoot is preoccupied with reproduction, sometimes producing human hybrids after abducting women in indigenous lore.[3729]

- **Music.** Witnesses on Scotland's Ben MacDhui, mountain home to *Am Fear Liath Mòr* or the Big Grey Man, report high-pitched singing sounds.[3730] Al Berry also noted singing during his research at the "Sierra Camp,"[3731] as did television producer Doug Hajicek at Snelgrove Lake, Ontario, a remote Bigfoot hotspot: "We heard this beautiful, operatic kind of singing that sounded like just a regular woman, singing from the edge of the lake somewhere… like she was warming up her voice. And it was really bizarre, it went on so long."[3732]

- **Beings.** Perhaps thankfully, Bigfoot fails to appear in NDEs. Two possible exceptions include a woman who met "a caveman with a hairy outfit on" in her NDE[3733] and another who encountered something which cryptozoologists would deem a "Littlefoot": "I held this very tiny little child on my chest" of a "brownish color," sporting "a big head, small hairy body and very tiny fingers."[3734]

This second example, of course, resembles an extraterrestrial baby presentation. The hair sounds like a thicker version of lanugo, with which all babies are born. Infants typically shed this covering within a few weeks of birth—could hairy bodies represent another remnant from the ecology of souls which we grow out of, like the fetal proportions of Greys?

- **Amnesia.** A surprising number of Bigfoot witnesses forget their encounters, even inexplicably returning to sleep after seeing the creatures outside their windows.[3735] In one dramatic case, a California driver forgot hitting a Bigfoot, despite leaving his vehicle significantly damaged.[3736] F&BH researchers predictably explain this as memory repression, a controversial psychological theory where victims protectively bury their trauma.

- **Healing, new abilities, and spiritual awakenings.** Rosemary Ellen Guiley noted that, like UFO "repeaters," Bigfoot witnesses tended to report "a history of otherworldly experiences and contact from an early age."[3737] In 1921, Elberta Payne allegedly saw two Bigfoot from her grandmother's Mount Shasta window while bedridden with typhoid fever, after which she recovered.[3738] George Kowalczyk experienced precognitive dreams and visions following his UFO-Bigfoot encounter, and accurately predicted an aviation accident. He also met his dead in-law. After her own Bigfoot sightings, researcher Claudia Ackley lost a significant amount of weight, acquired a new sense of mission, and implemented important, positive lifestyle changes.[3739]

- **Poltergeist phenomena.** As noted earlier, Class B Bigfoot reports correspond closely to poltergeist activity. Sightings of Bigfoot from cars also involve engine trouble more often than they should, if we are dealing with a flesh-and-blood animal. Engines sometimes die in the creatures' presence.[3740]

Two reports, while not qualifying as NDEs, bring Bigfoot into a similar setting. The first, reported in the June 9, 1857 issue of Salem's *Weekly Oregon Statesman*, involved a young man abducted from the forest by a hairy giant with glowing eyes. The creature supposedly took him to an underground lair, a domed interior lit by indirect phosphorescent light. The "slightly arched" ceiling was "composed of seashells of every conceivable shape and color." Deeper in the cave, "strains of the most unearthly music" could be heard.[3741]

After a time, the creature returned with a beautiful girl in tow, who gave the boy a card reading, "Boy, depart hence forthwith, or remain and be devoured." He escaped by prying open a trapdoor in the ceiling with his knife. The entire enterprise—specifically the intricate, domed subterranean space, dim light, beautiful music, and fellow human issuing a warning to leave—clearly resembles a DMT trip, a visit to Fairyland, or an NDE. Take your pick.[3742]

More recently, Bigfoot researcher and paranormal repeater Ron Johnson was watching television in 2009 when a ball of light appeared in his living room. It was three months after the funeral of his dear friend and colleague Darrell Smith, who had told Johnson just before he died that he was "going to learn the secret of Sasquatch" after his transition. The orb of light turned into a luminescent pillar, then a "Bigfoot type" creature.[3743]

"Ron, your friend Darrell Smith wanted me to come and see you," the creature said. "I want to take you to meet my family. Will you go with me?" Johnson agreed, and found himself in a cave with 12-14 other Bigfoot feasting on a deer carcass. The creature introduced Johnson to the others and offered venison, which he wisely declined. Johnson returned to his living room, but before the Bigfoot disappeared it offered some advice: "Be very, very careful, Ron. Something really wonderful is going to happen to you, and it's going to be very soon. Be prepared."[3744]

This echoed a similar message from Johnson's friend before his death. Shortly thereafter, Johnson and his cousin visited the site of a recent Bigfoot report and saw a creature themselves, which telepathically warned them to keep their distance.[3745] Whether Johnson "hallucinated" or dreamed his

earlier encounter doesn't matter—not only are visions and dreams legitimate vectors of spirit communication, but the experience accurately predicted a lucid, waking encounter corroborated by another witness.

The orb Johnson reported in his living room exemplifies the strong connection between Bigfoot and ghost lights. Just as ETH Ufologists reluctantly admit their synchronicities when pressed over a beer or two, most F&BH researchers confess to seeing anomalous lights in conjunction with Bigfoot, or at least in areas where large, hairy hominids are commonly spotted.

Accounts from Texas's "Big Thicket," a notorious Bigfoot hotspot, regularly feature ghost lights. In 1998, a group of campers actually saw an eight-foot-tall hairy beast *transform into* a glowing orb the size of a golf ball, then snap out of existence.[3746] A similar incident took place in Puerto Rico 23 years earlier when a tall, shaggy creature shrank into a basketball-sized ghost light before floating away.[3747]

Other light phenomena include mysterious "green flashes" like the one seen by Greg and Dana Newkirk on their Bigfoot expedition. Similar illumination appears across ghost investigations "often as a precursor to paranormal activity."[3748] In other words, the phenomenon might signify the arrival of spirits into our world. Perhaps coincidentally, during the fifth day in the reincarnation process of the *Chönyid Bardo*, "the Blessed Amoghasiddhi from the Karma family arrives with Samaya-Tara, the breath of life, in a flash of green light."[3749]

To be clear: Bigfoot are closely associated with ghost lights, a phenomenon which cultures worldwide regard as death omens or

disembodied human souls. In addition to uncanny transformations, there exist dozens of reports where Bigfoot are seen *carrying* light orbs, as reported, for example, in October 1973 near Pittsburgh. Simultaneously, a UFO was spotted traversing the area overhead.[3750] Was the creature delivering the dead to the ecology of souls?

Bigfoot:

Leading apes in Hell

Author, researcher, and podcaster Timothy Renner presciently found extensive connections between Bigfoot reports and—of all things—archetypal Women in White, Sophia herself. Reports of ghostly females consorting with wild men appear both in contemporary stories and folklore.[3751]

As Samuel Rowlands wrote in 1602, "Such as dye Maydes, do all leade apes in Hell." Renner traces the origins of this phrase—an "anti-Catholic sentiment regarding the celibacy of monks, nuns, and priests," symbolized by the virginal color white—to a variant from Thomas Campion: "They that yet have not fed / On delights amorous / She vows that they shall lead Apes in Avernus." In these instances "leading" refers *not* to psychopomp duties, but rather sexual intercourse. "The 'she' in this verse is Proserpina, in her Renaissance role as queen of the faeries," Renner wrote.[3752]

One of Renner's most compelling correlations comes in the form of Perchta, a Teutonic figure mentioned in previous chapters, sometimes regarded as a psychopomp or leader of the Wild Hunt. Perchta often wears white. Her retinue consists not only of children's souls in the form of ghost lights (heimchin), but also the Perchten or *Percht,* a cohort of *hairy wild men*.[3753]

Bigfoot also connects to psychopomps by way of Odin, a figure who influenced the European wild man archetype. The *wodewose, wodwose,* or *woodwose*—simultaneously a tall, hirsute wild man, faerie, and pagan nature god—displays this both thematically and etymologically. Like Perchta, Odin sometimes leads the Wild Hunt, as do giants in general.[3754]

Broadening our perspective, Bigfoot's behavior mirrors psychopomps in several ways. They are often regarded as tricksters. They are obviously therianthropes, straddling the line between human and animal.

"Woodknocks"—the sound of raps in the forest attributed to Bigfoot striking trees with logs—reflect the psychopomp's wand or key used to enter the Otherworld (Chapter 5). Folklore often describes pathways to other realms opening after striking rocks and trees with staves. Some inadvertently ascribe woodknocks this same purpose: Bigfoot investigator Ron Morehead suspects they represent the sound of energies snapping into our reality.[3755]

Bigfoot also exhibit a strong affinity for birds, owls in particular. They both imitate them and, according to some researchers, actually raise crows to serve as lookouts, not unlike the role fulfilled by Odin's ravens Huginn and Muninn. The primate-avian relationship extends back at least to European medieval art, where apes were often depicted pursuing birds—perhaps psychopomp symbolism in its own right.[3756] Legends, particularly in the New World, sometimes describe Bigfoot analogues transforming into birds. Bigfoot tracks are typically five-toed, but three-toed tracks resembling gigantic bird footprints are found surprisingly often.[3757]

Bigfoot's possible nature as a psychopomp extends beyond trivial similarities. As luck would have it, some indigenous American populations

assign their hairy men this role. The clearest example is the *Buk'wus* of Alaska's Kwakiutl, who leads and presides over the land of the drowned dead.[3758] Others, like the Unami cannibal giant *Mesingw*, simply supervise souls of the animal kingdom, patrolling forests astride a large buck.[3759] The Zuni invoke the giant *Átahsaia* in their *Wa'templa* or "All Herds" dance; the ritual ensures the cycle of renewal by "wiping the earth" through decay.[3760] *Tsul'Kalu*, a seven-fingered, slant-eyed giant, judges the Cherokee dead before their transition to the afterlife.[3761]

Granted, these roles rarely manifest in contemporary experiences. One possible exception came from Bulgaria when a "fireball" buzzing a home in 1989 coincided with "a huge, hairy humanoid" who " apparently wanted to take possession of the witness's soul."[3762] More often, the psychopomp character of Bigfoot appears in conjunction with shamanic practice.

Bigfoot:

The ape and the shaman

At its broadest level, the Bigfoot phenomenon is well-suited for shamanism. Its very existence reenchants the natural world. A handful of modern wild man witnesses have taken on the mantle of shamanism to bring humanity into better alignment with the environment. One such individual is "SunBôw True Brother," who claims our poor stewardship of the planet concerns the Bigfoot—an idea echoed throughout UFO contact.[3763] Similar animistic messages appear whenever Bigfoot engage in telepathic "mindspeak" with witnesses.[3764]

Modern appropriations obscure older connections between our hairy brethren and shamans. Bears—which resemble Bigfoot to some degree, and are held by many tribes as humanity's cousins—are often regarded in a shamanic capacity, rending the flesh of initiates and granting healing powers.[3765] Initiatory dismemberment is also prefigured in the Norse creation of the universe from the corpse of the *jötnar* Ymir, casting giants and, by extension, Bigfoot as proto-shamans. Bigfoot's appearance around American mounds suggests that certain presences linger long after their conjuration by indigenous medicine men and women.

Brent Raynes corresponded with a shaman of Susquehannock ancestry who told him the *Yush-dush-gwa*, a race of giants who once lived alongside humans, used to travel to Earth in "Sky Canoes" to protect us against "giant

prehistoric creatures."[3766] Primates feature in shamanic initiation rites among the Mentaweians of Sumatra: "The dreamer may imagine that he ascends to heaven or that he goes to the woods looking for monkeys," Eliade wrote.[3767]

Some Alaskan tribes send future chieftains into forests to meet wild men for revelation. "Roaming the mossy damps, he might encounter the cannibal spirit *Bakbakwalanooksiwae*, from whom *Bukwus* and *Dzonoqua* [Bigfoot figures] receive their power," wrote Robert Michael Pyle. "The wanderer acquires some of that power through his ordeal and the winter ceremonial dances that greet his return. The rest of the year the Wild Man and the Wild Woman abide in the deep shadows, vaguely disturbing and malevolent presences capable of stealing children and souls."[3768]

Just as some indigenous giants were once human, shamans may come to embody Bigfoot, either intentionally or as a result of peddling black magic. Certain tribes around Great Bear Lake in Canada believe *Nakani*, their Bigfoot creature, was once "a human being, generally an Indian, who had taken on certain supernatural qualities."[3769]

An Onandaga myth from New York tells of a shaman whose powers made him gluttonous, gorging himself on human flesh. He "'increased in size,' growing 'hard scales' for skin," Mann wrote. "Ultimately, the Onondaga trapped and killed this pesky shaman, whose predation had inflicted great damage on the Iroquois."[3770] (As a humorous aside, in 2017 a self-appointed "sasquatch shaman" on holiday in North Carolina was mistaken for the beast himself, his suit of fur styled to resemble the creature.)[3771]

It is worth noting that the most salient evidence of Bigfoot's existence—footprints—constitute an expressly shamanic and psychopompic symbol. Paul

Devereux contends depictions of footprints in petroglyphs like the ones found at Bohuslän, Sweden signify the passage of the dead into the afterlife.[3772] The Yolngu of Australia refer to their shamanic dreaming tracks as *djalkiri*, "footprints of the ancestors."[3773] Some go so far as to speculate that footprints were revered in Bronze Age Europe as signs of divine visitation, or —connecting footprints to UFOs—that the earliest circle reverence derives from a pair of human feet drawn side-by-side.[3774]

Like trackways of the dead vanishing into the Great Beyond, trails of Bigfoot prints often—too often to be ignored, in fact—terminate abruptly, even in the midst of open fields surrounded by untouched snow or mud. F&BH explanations that the creatures backtrack, or jump incredibly vast distances, leave much to be desired. Since we cannot *solve* this enigma, it seems more sensible to try and *understand* it. Instead of clarifying, only compare: when Hermes stole Apollo's cattle, his footprints suddenly ended as well, wiped clean by twigs and leaves affixed to the rear of his sandals.[3775]

In the Orphic tradition, the Greek god Dionysus occasionally provided a psychopomp role due to his chthonic reputation as the son of Persephone, herself trapped in the Underworld.[3776]

"The ape has been associated with the Greek god Dionysus," wrote Elizabeth Caspari, "who was linked to the fruit of the vine and to madness"—a description evoking entheogen-inspired shamanic journeys. Celebrants partaking in his mysteries might be taken over and empowered by Dionysus himself, who exhibits many similarities to Christ, including rebirth.[3777]

Furthermore, Dionysus's clear (if circuitous) chain of custody with Bigfoot intersects with shamanism. Dionysus is often proposed as one source of the

Green Man, a figure appearing extensively in medieval European art. Depictions of both Dionysus and the Green Man feature wreaths of ivy, a floriate motif applied to the wodewose, and wild men more generally. Both the Green Man and Bigfoot express this wild man archetype.

Other scholars perceive an Egyptian genesis for the Green Man in Osiris, himself a verdigris god of fertility and, as explained in Chapter 7, a potent shamanic figure.[3778] We would be remiss not to remind readers of the common extraterrestrial appellation "little green men."

Greek adoration of Dionysus was accompanied by half-man, half-goat satyrs (Roman fauns) like Pan, whose reputation as "hairy bipeds of the woods" further informed wild man traditions.[3779] These celebrations often revolved around ritualized dance, a shamanic expression observed among faeries, the dead, and even aliens.

Faerie scholar Simon Young wrote that "the Green Men's dance was occasionally referred to as the 'Dance for the Monkeys'... It is apparent that wodewoses were seen as wild creatures of the earthy countryside, inhabiting remote areas away from human habitations, such as woods, caves and mountains, much in the same vein as monkeys in the jungle."[3780]

Today, the caprine configuration of satyrs and fauns not only represents some fae folk but even the devil himself, another Christian demonization of pagan deities. Since pagans were witches to the early church, anything keeping their company *must* be demonic. Perhaps for this reason, Bigfoot have long been referred to in folklore as "devils," often appearing at sites bearing the name: Devil's Creek, Devil's Canyon, etc. This explanation is only

partially satisfactory. Plenty of North American tribes drew similar comparisons long before Europeans arrived, calling wild men "demons."[3781]

Volume I of *Where the Footprints End* extensively compares Bigfoot to witches, magical practitioners who fall upon the shamanic spectrum. In some instances, indigenous Bigfoot characters like the Kwakiutl Dsonoqua and Seneca *Genonsgwa* can clearly be interpreted as witches, while others behave more akin to spirit familiars.[3782]

Accounts from witchcraft trials describe ape-faced familiars and even small, hairy beings resembling Littlefoot or brownies.[3783] Tituba, the Caribbean slave who played a pivotal role in the 1692 persecution of witches in Salem, Massachusetts, testified to seeing "a thing all over hairy, all the face hayry & a long nose... w'th two Leggs, itt goeth upright & is about two or three foot high."[3784]

If Bigfoot can be familiars, then they might represent an aspect of the self.

Bigfoot:

The wild man, within and without

"...a person does not have only a single, unique Double," Claude Lecouteux explained. "There are at least two: one physical and sometimes zoomorphic; the other spiritual and also able to take animal form."[3785]

Lecouteux's description eloquently captures the dualistic nature of Bigfoot which, for all its metaphysical peculiarities, nonetheless provides stronger evidence for its existence than any other Fortean phenomena in the form of footprints and alleged hair and blood samples. Bigfoot elegantly walks a tightrope between physical and non-physical.

Is Bigfoot our double? The creatures regularly mimic not only animals and machinery, but also witnesses themselves. Habituators commonly hear the names of their pets called out from the woods.[3786] After being pelted with twigs and acorns on his Michigan property in 1995, Mark Marinelli—who claims around a dozen Bigfoot sightings—shouted, "What the fuck is this?!?" Several high-pitched voices joined in a chorus from the forest, rapidly repeating his words.[3787]

Bigfoot also mime our actions. Manifold encounters end with the sense of something else pacing witnesses out of the forest. In June 1999, Colette Alexander and her roommate were enjoying a picnic beside San Lorenzo River in California when they spotted "a strange cross between human and

ape" peering at them from a large cypress bush some 30 yards downstream. It mirrored Alexander as she ate her sandwich. Upon slowing her movements, the Bigfoot followed suit.[3788] As noted in the Introduction, poltergeist phenomena emanate from both spirits *and* ourselves, suggesting at least some Class B Bigfoot reports are self-generated.

Doubles are notorious death omens. Bigfoot are no exception. Bigfoot analogues in tribal lore commonly foretell death or misfortune, much like the ghost lights with which they fraternize, or banshees, whose cries Bigfoot's howls resemble. California's Hupa, for example, believe eye contact with *Ohmah* inflicts bad luck and death.[3789] Some, like the Tlingit Kushtakaa, are even referred to via euphemisms (like faeries), lest their wrath be invoked.[3790] Orthodox cryptozoologists pooh-pooh these as overwrought superstitions, even when modern sightings presage post-traumatic stress disorder, alcoholism, illness, and *literal death* among witnesses.[3791]

"The most chilling problem I found in my own efforts to re-examine some old cases was the disturbing fact that witnesses, particularly monster witnesses, often die within six months to two years," John Keel wrote. "The apparitions seem to be omens. The deaths are usually natural—heart attacks, accidents, prolonged illnesses."[3792]

Tom Sewid, a Kwakwaka'wakw (Kwakiutl) bush guide, claims multiple sightings of *Tzoonakwa* (Dsonoqua), including one from 1992 while captaining a commercial salmon boat anchored near Village Island, British Columbia. After hearing a large thump and whistle from the beach, Sewid and his crew spotted two large, upright shadows accompanied by a foul odor.

Sewid caught two Bigfoot in the beam of his spotlight before grabbing his rifle and taking aim. He then remembered his tribe's warnings.[3793]

"You know the stories from your people, the curse… If you harm or disrespect or kill a big fellow (sasquatch), if nothing happens to you bad, something will happen to the family and loved ones around you...." Sewid desisted.[3794] If simply seeing your Double can cause misfortune, one can only imagine the devastation inflicted upon yourself after *harming* it.

For all its talk of the Higher Self, metaphysical traditions rarely pay attention to the *Lowest* Self. The *Lower* Self typically represents our corporeal state, but it seems logical to assume something else lurks below the proverbial waterline. If our Higher Selves are purely spiritual, freed from mortal wants and needs, and our Lower Selves are locked in a struggle between the two, it stands to reason our *Lowest* Selves are purely driven by survival; they are animalistic. Perhaps Bigfoot represents this—the id, the shadow. Plenty of witnesses describe the creatures as "blacker than black," or in low light, simply as tall shadows.[3795]

Should this be the case, Bigfoot tidily fall upon the same spectrum as extraterrestrials. The latter embody the evolved, spiritual Higher Self, the former our basest instincts. The extraterrestrial calls our attention toward the stars; Bigfoot, back to Earth, the wilderness.

Bigfoot may represent *anima mundi* itself, the soul of the world. Its ties to nature extend beyond mere habitat. Some researchers believe the creatures' elusivity stems from their ability to remain so still as to resemble trees; indeed, plenty of eyewitnesses believe they are approaching desiccated stumps before the objects move, revealing large, hairy hominids. Few

entertain the idea that, like some faeries, Bigfoot may literally *be* trees, or at least their spirits, yet several tribes say as much.[3796] As seen throughout this work, trees are profound symbols of both the macrocosm and microcosm, the universe itself and the individual soul.

Bigfoot remains a conundrum. Ample evidence, much of it scientifically sound, points to a flesh-and-blood animal from the fossil record clinging to survival—yet the odd outliers refuse to fade away. If cryptozoology is to retain any semblance of legitimacy as Materialism's grip loosens, it behooves the field to embrace, rather than ignore, these anomalies.

Lake monsters:

High Strangenessie (pt. 1, the dragon)

Something hides beneath the waves of Scotland's Loch Ness. It officially emerged in the historical record in the 6th century AD, during Irish monk St. Columba's sojourn among the Picts. Columba encountered a group burying a mauled corpse along the same waters from which it had been recovered. Columba dispatched a follower to cross the River Ness, and when the monster reappeared, he made the sign of the cross, commanding, "Go no further. Do not touch the man. Go back at once." The beast receded into the depths as if "pulled back with ropes," deemed by all present a miracle.[3797] (Centuries later in 1973 Donald Omand performed another full-blown exorcism at Loch Ness, this time to no apparent effect.)[3798]

Why any animal would relent at Columba's admonition has yet to be answered by cryptozoologists, many of whom contend the Loch Ness Monster, or "Nessie," represents a surviving plesiosaur. While plesiosaurs roughly match eyewitness descriptions of lake monsters worldwide—broad, flippered bodies boasting long necks—how this genus managed to survive the same event which extinguished their contemporaries the dinosaurs remains a mystery. Even alternative hypotheses like gigantic mollusks or long-necked seals fail when one considers the dearth of physical evidence accompanying Nessie. By and large, all we have are photographs and videos. Therefore it seems reasonable to assume, like Bigfoot, we are dealing with an escapee from the ecology of souls.

Remarkably few comparisons can be drawn between NDEs and lake monster encounters. While this hints at a fundamental, more disturbing possibility—elaborated later—it also affords a bit more freedom to explore the richness of High Strangeness and death symbolism surrounding these creatures.

First and foremost, all lake monsters are folklorically interchangeable with dragons. As noted elsewhere, dragons guard grave goods. They trace pathways across the landscape, and find strong association in astronomy, conflated across cultures with comets, asteroids, etc. Fantasy fiction has conditioned us to imagine dragons as primarily terrestrial or aerial, but an equal number dwell within lakes, rivers, and oceans.

Eastern dragons are particularly water-based. Water dragons also appear in the historical record throughout Europe, not only in Scotland but Germany, France, and Scandinavia.[3799] Many combine air and water in their mastery over tempests[3800] (today, monster lakes are plagued by frequent electrical storms).[3801] Some legends actually differentiate stages of dragons' development according to where they dwell.[3802]

Dragons *explicitly* represent death. Some tombstones and mausoleums are carved with dragons.[3803] Their alternate designation *wurm* or *wyrm* lent its name to actual worms, catalysts for decay and another symbol of our mortality.[3804]

"The dragon opens its hellish mouth to devour and crush living creatures, and even as it does so it can hurl them to earth with its terrible scourging tail or strangle them in a deathly embrace," wrote Herzog in his classification of

dragons as death-demons.[3805] Dragon wings suggest bird wings, recorded worldwide in depictions of psychopomps, shamans, and dead souls.

Alongside this avian aspect, dragons are obviously reptilian, most often serpentine. "Both Greek and Teutonic myths indicate that the snake-form intensifies the horror of the Death-Demon," Herzog continued.[3806] Jung noted a "widespread primitive idea" of "the snake-form of the spirits of the dead."[3807]

Although snakes can signify death, they present a rich enough symbol to sustain other meanings. These include not only knowledge and wisdom but totality, exemplified by the ouroboros looping around to consume its own tail, or hoop snakes in North American folklore, which coil themselves into circles to roll after prey like a wheel.

Turning our attention back to lake monsters, Nessie, the most famous example, offers no shortage of oddities refuting the idea of a flesh-and-blood creature. To best appreciate their scope, the work of F.W. Holiday and Nick Redfern's 2016 book *Nessie* come highly recommended.

For starters, we have very little recorded evidence of Nessie compared to Bigfoot. Witnesses report the monster(s) ducking out of sight just as they frame their shots, cameras malfunctioning, and photographs developing inexplicably foggy or blank.[3808] Video mysteriously disappears.[3809] (A complication Timothy Renner also noted regarding Bigfoot evidence).[3810] Like other lake monsters, Nessie's descent sometimes seems impossibly fast or smooth, and might cause boat motors to fail.[3811] Other witnesses report strange compulsions to look at the loch immediately before sightings,[3812] which they might forget until something triggers their memory later.[3813]

Sightings of lake monsters are generally ill-omened. Most find Nessie horrifically disturbing when observed at close range, leaving F.W. Holiday to conclude, "There is something strange about Nessie that has nothing to do with size or appearance."[3814]

This is especially true when the beast is observed on land, a rare occurrence but recorded nonetheless. George Spicer and his wife saw something horrendous cross the road and into the loch in 1933, telling reporters, "It was horrible—an abomination."[3815] Descriptions of landbound Nessie differ wildly, suggesting a shapeshifting aspect, but are sometimes compared to a hybrid camel-horse, two psychopomp beasts of burden.[3816]

Notably, paleontologists agree plesiosaurs rarely made landfall. Even when they did, they stayed near water and certainly couldn't walk with the elephantine gait some witnesses report.[3817]

Lake monsters:

High Strangenessie (pt. 2, the window)

Everything about Loch Ness itself suggests a window area. Visitors to its shores see or hear human ghosts, as Tim Dinsdale did while anchored near Fort Augustus Abbey in 1979. Some spot UFOs or large, black cats. As noted later, Loch Ness, like other lakes holding monsters, is connected to ancient monuments.[3818] Peculiar company for a plesiosaur to keep.

Perhaps this energy is what drew famed occultist Aleister Crowley, first mentioned in Chapter 16, to Loch Ness—either that, or he was simply *really* into dinosaurs. Wherever Crowley went conjuration was sure to follow, and his manor on the southeast shore, Boleskine House, was no exception. While legends of Nessie obviously predate his 1899-1913 ownership, some speculate Crowley's magical rituals strengthened whatever presence inhabited the area.[3819]

Acquaintances spoke of malevolent forces taking up residence in the walls of Boleskine, powers which lingered into Led Zeppelin guitarist Jimmy Page's 1971 purchase. Page admitted sensing "bad vibes" at the place, including the sound of a decapitated ghost's head toppling down the stairs.[3820] Boleskine house sustained significant fire damage in 2015 and 2019, and currently undergoes restoration efforts.[3821]

Not everyone interprets the energy around Loch Ness as negative. After picking the Drumnadrochit area for a satellite location of Kagyu Samye Ling Monastery in 2014, Britain's Buddhist Lama, Gelongma Zangmo, declared, "This is such a beautiful part of the country and it has a very special feel to it... Nessie is a *nāga*," a semi-divine serpentine deity. "We build the relationship with the nāga, try to please them and don't abuse the environment," she continued. "If Nessie is treated well, she will bring prosperity."[3822]

An incomplete list (expanded later) highlights how High Strangeness surrounds other bodies of water supporting monsters:

- In addition to its own lake monster *Ponik*, Quebec's Lake Pohénégamook was the epicenter of werewolf attacks in the 18th century. Another Québécois lake monster home, Lake Brompton, sees additional aberrant phenomena in the form of strange earthquakes, sudden storms, and even a Fortean rain of frogs from the sky sometime in recent memory.[3823] (Curiously, Revelation 16:13 reads: "Then I saw three impure spirits that looked like *frogs*; they came out of the mouth of the *dragon*….[author's emphasis].")

- On August 30, 1913 the crew of the HMS *Corinthian* spotted a horse-like sea serpent off Newfoundland's Grand Banks which—like other paranormal phenomena —"emitted a piercing wail like that of a baby."[3824]

- Self-styled psychic Anthony "Doc" Shiels successfully used "monster-raising" rituals to summon *Morgawr*, a sea creature lurking off the Cornish coast.[3825]

Sightings increased dramatically in 1976, coinciding with a flap of UFOs and a strange "Owlman" in Cornwall, mentioned later in this chapter.[3826]

- Canada's Lake Manitoba purportedly houses *Manipogo*, a beast described in local Assiniboin legends. Some allege the creature can change colors. Tribes associate Manipogo's cries with those of another spirit, the manitou.[3827]

- *Ogopogo*, yet another Canadian aquatic monster, patrols British Columbia's Lake Okanagan.

"According to both the Shushwap and Okanakane Indians, Ogopogo was originally a violent and unpredictable creature," wrote Hayden Blackman. "The monster was known to these peoples as *N'ha-a-itk*, or 'the lake demon,' because they believed that it was an evil supernatural entity with great power and ill intent."[3828]

Like other North American lake monsters, Ogopogo could be appeased by offering sacrifices when traversing Okanagan's waters, including venison, poultry, or even live dogs.[3829] More recently, indigenous informants have stepped forward to explain *nx̌ax̌aitkʷ*, a more preferable moniker, is not inherently evil, but rather represents a spirit who reminds us of water's sacredness.[3830]

- According to indigenous lore, a lake monster from Nebraska's Alkali (Walgren) Lake not only manifests a horrific stench, but can induce madness in anyone laying eyes upon its 300-foot-long form.[3831] Other lake monsters cause death, mania, skeletal deformations, or even something resembling stigmata: "A child, having escaped the fate of his brothers speared on the antlers of [the lake monster] *Amuluk*, found scars on his own body in the image of the monster's horns."[3832]

- The Australian outback is filled with stories of *bunyips*, vaguely-described creatures whose affinity for billabongs constitutes their only consistent feature. Escaped convict William Buckley, who lived among the aborigines for 32 years, said his hosts believed that bunyips possessed "supernatural power over human beings, so as to occasion death, sickness, disease, and such like misfortunes." To kill or harm one meant doom.[3833]

Lake monsters:

High Strangenessie (pt. 3, the faerie-Bigfoot connection)

To anyone less familiar with their folklore, links between faeries and lake monsters are not readily apparent. Yet their affiliation runs deep (pardon the pun), to the extent that, especially in Ireland and the British Isles, lake monsters are often considered faerie animals. For the moment, we postpone discussing these entities—water horses, bulls, and dogs—in favor of more general comparisons.

As with other paranormal phenomena, the importance of water to lake monsters is self-evident. Claude Lecouteux noted how "fairies could very often be considered as aquatic spirits: an anthropomorphic expression of the *Numen* reputed to dwell in such places. Fairies rarely wander far from what clearly seems to be their natural element...."[3834] This is apparent not only in water-dwelling spirits like sirens, Ladies of the Lake, etc. but also the proliferation of springs and wells associated with fae folk.

Lakes with monsters invariably host faerie legends. In some instances, as at Germany's Traunsee, faerie queens might ride "water-dragons" with the same aplomb they do horses.[3835] An age-old relationship is further hinted at in legends of the gigantic *Fomorians*, enemies of the Tuatha Dé Danann who invaded Ireland. The Fomorians came from the sea and were connected with

the *goborchiinu* ("horse heads," calling to mind a persistent description of lake monsters).[3836]

Folklorists regard lakes as an Otherworld. For some cultures, they serve as the afterlife. Rivers, too, appear in mythologies, demarcating boundaries between lands of the living and the dead.

Whereas as faeries retreat underground, lake monsters retreat underwater, functionally identical. This subterranean aspect becomes even more overt in the work of Michel Meurger, who after surveying lakes with monsters noted they share several key attributes: sudden storms (another faerie link), unfathomable depths, regular whirlpools, a rich history of drowning disappearances, and *submerged cave systems*.[3837]

Like most paranormal entities, lake monsters disappear at will, even if only submerging. Cultures cohabitating with them make offerings and ascribe them power over nightmares[3838] and illness[3839]—similar to faeries and ancestors. Lake monster bodies are traditionally "unsubstantial," calling to mind Robert Kirk's "spongious" faerie bodies.[3840]

Lake monsters are also known worldwide for shapeshifting. In a compelling link to Bigfoot, Scottish *kelpies* transform into large, hairy men.[3841] Some cryptozoologists equate Bigfoot with the *gougou*, a cannibal-giant-cum-sea-monster of Malecite, Passamaquoddy, and Mi'kmaq lore.[3842]

In his 2008 book *The Hoopa Project*, David Paulides conflated Bigfoot sightings with indigenous Californian tales of *Kamoss*, "a snake-like creature that has a head the size of a horse." Paulides suggested that Kamoss legends were misidentifications of hairy hominids crossing bodies of water.[3843] While

not a facet of tribal lore, we are left wondering whether both are forms of the same phenomenon.

Dragons (and therefore lake monsters) delight in pastimes favored by Bigfoot and fae folk, taking livestock, leaving behind changelings,[3844] and, astoundingly, even abducting victims for sexual congress. Meurger found this both in Old World tales of *Each-Uisge*, equine Scottish water spirits, and New World legends.

"The transformation of various horned serpents [in North America]… into beautiful young men, who carried their women off to their aquatic tent, is the Indian translation of the Greek myth of the rape of Persephone (Core) by Hades," he wrote.[3845]

Furthermore, the reemerge of American lake monsters each spring "at the time of the forces of renewal and rebirth" carries with it not only "a sexual character" but one of reincarnation (some North American tribes refused to speak of lake monsters any time other than winter for fear they, like European faeries, were always listening). Petroglyphs of dragon-worms often appear alarmingly sperm-like. Meurger even tied lake monsters to superstitions surrounding menstruation, illustrated in legends about "the presence of a serpent in the vagina or… *the visit of a mythic serpent, a lover of women, during their periods*."[3846]

Lake monsters:

High Strangenessie (pt. 4, the UFO connection)

As expected this late in our discussion, such correlations align lake monsters with modern extraterrestrials. Although associations between UFOs and lake monsters could have been drawn long beforehand, the two topics didn't receive much coverage in tandem until the early 1970s in the aftermath of F.W. Holiday's *The Dragon & the Disc*. Holiday—whose first book, 1969's *The Great Orm of Loch Ness*, took a more conventional approach towards Nessie—came to appreciate the manifold oddities surrounding the creature, birthing a novel (if convoluted) mythology linking ancient monuments, UFOs, and waterborne dragons (Chapter 8).

(It is worth noting how Holiday's model of the European World Tree, complete with aerial discs above and the serpent below, vaguely resembles some New World totem poles with a few key substitutions: an eagle or Thunderbird for the UFO, appropriately enough, and a Bigfoot figure at the base, sometimes flanked by "seawolves" or another lake monster analogue.)

Holiday wrote of flying saucers and lake monsters:

> Both change shape and vary their color… [both] produce great excitement in domestic animals, e.g. dogs, and both sorts of phenomena are reported to move

> about at high speeds. Moreover, monsters on land appear never to leave any excreta or other traces one associates with ponderous animals…
>
> …The sonar returns which have unquestionably been obtained from monsters are duplicated by the radar returns which have equally unquestionably been obtained from U.F.O.s… Yet—just as with monsters—no detailed close-up film of a U.F.O. has ever been shot; or, if it *has* been shot, it has never been released.[3847]

To this list Holiday added the "missing, hidden or indistinct" extremities of both phenomena, visceral witness reactions, and the tricksterish, dark narratives in which researchers of each find themselves embroiled.[3848] Like other books of its era breaking from the mainstream, *The Dragon & the Disc* enjoys a near-mythical status, despite being somewhat quaint to modern Forteans who embrace High Strangeness. Michel Meurger's *Lake Monster Traditions* has aged much better with its Vallee-ian approach, addressing the phenomena from a more psychosocial angle.

To Holiday's observations we might add UFOs' affinity for water—sometimes appearing as USOs, Unidentified Submerged Objects—and the longstanding metaphor dragons embody vis-à-vis comets. As with UFOs, fogs accompany some lake monsters like the Omaha and Mohawk *Wakandagi*, which appears in silhouette "in the mist, as through a veil."[3849]

We can reasonably assume reptilian aliens in abductions reflect a similar mythopoetic theme, perhaps that of the Satanic dragon, covered later. Betty, an alien abductee interviewed by Simon Harvey-Wilson, recalled vivid dreams of "crocodiles, lions, and snakes" surrounding her, each a potent shamanic

symbol.[3850] Encounters with dragons might leave wounds resembling the ones alien abductees find on their bodies: one Scandinavian *lindorm* encounter left a victim bedridden for three weeks with "three bleeding holes" on his right ankle (recall the occult significance of the number three).[3851]

Men-in-Black (MIB), those curious agents who predominantly seek to cover-up UFO sightings, equally harass lake monster researchers. During a 1968 vacation to the loch, Nessie hunter Alistair Baxter found his slumber interrupted by a humming, soccer-ball-sized light orb. The apparition mounted the staircase and jetted across the water, only to hover and disappear.[3852]

Baxter somehow fell back to sleep, but before breakfast was approached by a trio of black-suited men who asked whether he had seen anything strange. Baxter denied his sighting, but nightmares of large, hairy hominids and nuclear warfare punctuated his sleep for several nights thereafter. (This is not the only such report: Holiday himself once found a man dressed in black on the shores of Loch Ness staring not at the water, but at him. Nick Redfern believes he has found evidence of similar figures in the area stretching back over a century.)[3853]

Baxter's sighting speaks to another common characteristic Meurger noted around monster lakes: anomalous light phenomena, both aerial and aquatic. Speaking with a diver at Quebec's Lake Memphrémagog (home to a horse-serpent), Meurger learned that shadows in the water would burst into "sudden luminosity." Lake Saint-François features not only an impossibly black monster, but "great balls of fire" which buzz witnesses' homes. [3854]

Meurger collected similar accounts from Europe: "The Kelpie disappears like a lightning bolt. The *Ceffyl-dŵr* of Wales shines like a light, its beams bathing the surrounding area. An evening traveler who was surprised by the [British] Noggle, saw it disappear into the waves, *leaving a large wake of bluish fire.*" Meurger perceives vestiges of such accounts as far back as the epic *Beowulf*, which relates a ghost light hovering above the watery home of Grendel's mother: "Every night you could see the terrible sight of a fire on the lake."[3855]

While these may constitute disembodied souls, structured craft are reported as well. Keel went so far as to declare the area around Plattsburgh, New York—on the banks of Lake Champlain, home to *Champ*—"a very busy UFO 'window.'"[3856]

In 1971, Jan-Ove Sundberg encountered a landed flying saucer and three humanoids at Loch Ness's Foyers Bay area, mere days after Graham Snape saw a purple object over the water.[3857] Several months later, "a glowing, golden, oval object with a distinct reddish aura" shot low across the loch towards Fort Augustus.[3858]

Supposedly, "an aerial photograph" shows "what looks like a strange large craft lying on the bed of Loch Nevis" in Scotland (whether this photo depicts a crashed flying saucer or submerged ruins is debatable, but no less germane to the idea we might be dealing with another window area). Nevis is adjacent to Loch Morar, which claims its own monster in the form of *Morag*.[3859] Strange lights and banshee-like cries fill the air around Morar, and Morag notably appears whenever Macdonalds in the area pass away.[3860]

The totality implied by Jung's mandala-UFO manifests among lake monsters as well. Witnesses predominantly report humps, often three, gliding across the water; Meurger aptly compares these "looping arcs" to dragon tails in medieval European art, which twist around to form circles, distinguishing themselves from mundane reptiles. He also uncovered accounts of sea serpents biting their own tails, ouroboros-like, or enclosing victims in circular coils.[3861]

"The water horse is associated with the wheel, as are sea serpents and, more generally, all water-spirits," he wrote.[3862] This is consistent with the Celtic god Manannán, who it may be remembered traveled either in a wheellike fashion or on Enbharr, a horse capable of traversing the waves.

A disturbing implication lies in lake monster humps: while they *imply* totality, a full circle is never observed. There is a certain *brokenness* about them, an *interrupted* totality, the cycle of life *fractured*. This may provide a critical hint regarding lake monsters' role in the ecology of souls, one proposed in due course.

Lake monsters:

When dinosaurs ruled the earth

By far the simplest explanation for lake monsters' ephemerality suggests they, like Bigfoot, represent not surviving members of an extinct species, but their *ghosts*. Phantom pets are common in ghost stories, after all—why not phantom dinosaurs? The idea sounds silly, but could be applied to similar beasts around the world like the Congo's *Mokèlé-mbèmbé*, an animal which sounds identical to a surviving sauropod. But can ghosts linger for 65 million years?

The late Jim Marrs learned that remote viewers in the employ of the United States government actually turned their minds' eyes to Loch Ness on one occasion. They determined the beast *did* resemble a plesiosaur, and *could* cause physical effects like wakes—but seemed able to dematerialize. "Considering that reports of human ghosts date back throughout man's history, the Psi Spies seriously considered the possibility that the Loch Ness monster is nothing less than a dinosaur's ghost," Marrs explained.[3863]

"In Celtic literature there are specific references to the Serpent being an apparition," wrote Holiday, providing as evidence the "phantom and reptile" slain by the legendary Irish folk hero Finn.[3864] There also abound tales of the Irish *roan*, a brand of faerie capable of appearing as a human or a seal.[3865]

Dubbed *selkies* in Scotland, the amorous roan are worth noting for three reasons:[3866] first, skeptics often explain Nessie sightings as misidentified members of the loch's seal population; second, some cryptozoologists propose lake monsters are indeed undiscovered pinnipeds, albeit ones with unprecedently-long necks; [3867] and third, selkies, and by extension seals, were sometimes recast as drowned souls in northern European imagination.[3868]

This puts the experience of Carlos, an alien abductee who worked with John Mack, in a fascinating new light. After an acquaintance suggested he visit Iona's Bay of Seals to sing hymns, he:

> …traversed the one-mile width of the island, from the town of Iona to that particular beach, and "just for the hell of it," sang Gregorian chants in both Greek and Latin. To his surprise a seal came close to the shore and followed him for what seemed about half a mile as he walked along the beach, and it continued to follow him when he walked back. Charmed by the seal's friendliness and the legend's apparent authenticity, Carlos conceded, "It was a very beautiful new experience.[3869]

Given the widespread belief that ghosts can take whatever form they choose, we must ask whether lake monsters denote the human dead. The most chilling item on Meurger's "monster lake checklist" is how they historically "do not give up the bodies of the drowned."[3870] This, coupled with the preponderance of ghost lights at such locales, recasts lakes as watery purgatories.

Ghost lights, comets, sirens, and lake monsters: death omens all. We previously mentioned the ill-fortune wrought by Australian bunyips. Any Algonquin seeing *Misiganebic* knew they were doomed.[3871] In Iceland, "there are monsters in lakes, and when they stick up their heads or some other part of them is visible it forebodes plagues and other disasters…."[3872] Similar beliefs are recorded throughout Europe, including at Loch Morar, where Morag in its mermaid form might appear *before* deaths, not solely afterward.

Off the south coast of Iceland on May 22, 1917, the crew of the HMS *Hilary* spotted a cow-headed sea serpent and, never passing on "a bit of anti-submarine practice," opened fire. They scored a direct hit, displeasing the officer of the watch to the extent he requested the account's omission from the ship's log. When denied this accommodation, his mood darkened.[3873]

"Well, that makes it a certainty anyhow," he lamented. "We shall never reach port again." Three days later, the Germans' *U-88* sunk the *Hilary* not far from their encounter.[3874]

Lake monsters:

Atlantis of the loch

If monster lakes are window areas, it stands to reason major archaeological sites can be found in their vicinity, per Keel's definition. In this regard, few disappoint. By merit of the region's history, any loch housing a monster in Ireland and the British Isles lays but a stone's throw away from an ancient monument. Recall how the Chinese referred to ley lines, the invisible energetic thoroughfares connecting sacred sites, as "Dragon Paths." The appearance of dragons *and* light phenomena around sepulchral sites reveals the truly ancient age of the "window area" theory.

As mentioned, a storied history links dragons to burial mounds, either as greedy treasure hoarders or protectors of grave goods. In the latter case, the dragon becomes a liminal guardian—as Meurger put it, "a 'watcher on the threshold' of a sacred place." In the former, the dragon symbolizes greed, painting it in a role similar to other burial ground spirits unable to relinquish their earthly wealth. [3875] Despite no clear etymological link, some draw the two concepts together by pointing to similarities between the Old Norse words *dreki* (dragon) and draugr (revenant).[3876]

Distinctions blur between artificial earthworks and natural landmarks affiliated with dragons. A fine example is England's Worm Hill, at which we find the myth of the Lambton Worm. Prior to its final battle with John Lambton, this dragon coiled itself around the hill's base, terrorizing villagers

lest they offer 20 gallons of fresh milk daily.[3877] Lambton forgot to sacrifice his favorite hound after his victory—blood for blood, decreed by a witch—cursing nine generations of descendants to death outside the peace of bed.[3878] Over the intervening centuries, debate has raged whether Worm Hill is natural or artificial, but its true nature matters little: wherever there are mountains, there are monsters.[3879]

Both Old and New World monuments were constructed to resemble gigantic serpents. Large earth and stone "dragon-simulations" lie along Scotland's River Clyde and at Ach-na-Goul.[3880] The most famous example is Ohio's Serpent Mound, the largest serpent effigy in the world. Smaller structures like stone effigies from the Turner enclosure 35 miles away also depict horned, serpentine water monsters.[3881] Dragons and American monuments also intersect at Georgia's Fort Mountain (Chapter 8): some researchers speculate the lengthy stone wall kept out the *Uktena*, a Cherokee snake spirit dwelling in the Cohutta Mountains.[3882]

Ruins sometimes exist *at the bottoms of the lakes themselves.* The same diver who told Meurger about flashes in Lake Memphrémagog mentioned finding "pretty far from the shore… a little wall of five metres, all of cut stones, posed one on top of another."[3883] The modest town of Lake Mills, Wisconsin features not only one of the state's most important mound sites, Aztalan, but sightings of a monster in Rock Lake. For years, researchers have puzzled over strange pyramidal structures on the lakebed. Although recent investigations suggest these are "only" silt-covered rock piles, the pyramids' artificially remains open to debate. Again, it may not matter, imaginally speaking.[3884]

In Scotland, Each-Uisge frequently lurk "in or near ancient monuments," including the "submerged prehistoric dwellings" of crannogs, otherwise associated with faeries.[3885] In the early 1970s, divers in Loch Ness reported "half a dozen or more dome-shaped hummocks of hard sand and stones about 3-4 feet high and 20 feet in diameter" as well as a pair of parallel, 40-foot stone walls.[3886] Several years later, Nessie hunters discovered "a mother lode of stone circles" submerged elsewhere in the loch—"big ones and little ones; single circles intertwined with others; circles laid out in a straight line and circles in no particular order." 2005 saw the discovery of further structures.[3887]

As famed James Bond villain Auric Goldfinger proffered, "Once is happenstance. Twice is coincidence. Three times, it's enemy action."

Lake monsters:

The serpent & the shaman

Snakes' shamanic reputation reflects their otherworldly wisdom, present in the Christian Garden of Eden story. Creation myths from earlier cultures substitute cosmic serpents for giants, seen in the Babylonian dragon Tiamat whose dismembered corpse provided the building blocks of the universe. Shamanic initiations also reflect the "belly of the whale" portion of Joseph Campbell's monomyth, from which the hero escapes to be born anew. As variations on initiatory dismemberment, shamans' consumption by greater forces can be symbolic, like burials alive (entombed within the womb of the Earth) or literal, as when Mother Ayahuasca, herself serpentine, devours Amazonian candidates.

"The serpent symbolizes the mysterious numen of the 'mother'… who kills, but who is at the same time man's only security against death, as she is the source of life," Jung wrote. "… Whoever conquers this monster wins to eternal youth. But to this end, defying all danger, he must descend into the belly of the monster ('journey to Hell') and sojourn there for some time."[3888] (Christian parallels of Christ's interment and time in Hell are apparent.)

Transposing the monster or underworld journey into lake depths came naturally to shamanic cultures. Aquatic descent is commonplace among New World shamans from the Yucatan to the Pacific northwest.[3889] Even in the absence of physical submersion, shamans might pantomime diving and

swimming—certain Alaskan tribes describe the shaman as "one who drops down to the bottom of the sea," while the Chukchee refer to shamans' drums as "canoes," their trance as a "sinking."[3890]

Literal dives often coincide with lake monster abodes. Klamath youths gain shamanic powers after bathing where monstrous *Spu-Tuk* spirits dwell, while at Crater Lake, Oregon, "initiates are taken beneath the waters haunted by serpents, the terrible '*To Kas*' (sea-serpents), as big as trees and furnished with white horns." After being pulled to the lakebed survivors emerge shamanized, mouths and noses bloody.[3891]

Cultures including northern California's Yurok claim lake monsters impart wisdom after dragging novices below in a quasi-dreamlike state (likely an NDE). An Achómawi elder described the ordeal:

> Try to go to the summit before the sun has disappeared. On the summit you will find a lake. It is a terrible place; it is a place full of fear. There are many Tinihowis (spirits), who live in the lake. Dive into the lake. Throw yourself there head first. Don't be afraid. You are going to die. But if you are destined to see a Tinihowi, he will save you.[3892]

The implants some shamans credit as the source of their power might be gifted by or taken from dragons. In Canada, the crystalline eyes of the lake monster *Tcipitckaam* are "avidly sought" by the Micmac as a source of magic.[3893] The horned Uktena serpent of southeastern U.S. tribes sports a jeweled crest upon its forehead which Cherokee warriors covet: "The blazing

diamond is called *Ulûñsû′tĭ*, 'Transparent,' and he who can win it may become the greatest wonder worker of the tribe, but it is worth a man's life to attempt it, for whoever is seen by the Uktena is so dazed by the bright light that he runs toward the snake instead of trying to escape."[3894]

Some cultures substitute smaller serpents for the crystals themselves. Australian shamans accept "little snakes" into their bodies, bestowing "the powers of a medicine man" upon them.[3895] Both the Shawnee and Lenâpé held that natural snakes worked in accordance with the Horned Serpent spirit.[3896] Recall Chapter 6's image of snakes coursing through the guts of ayahuasca drinkers.

Lake monsters shamanize elsewhere as well. Australia's Lunga and Djara initiates enter ponds filled with "monstrous snakes" which kill and revive them with magical powers. Sea serpents carry away souls of Sumatra's Nias shamans for initiation.[3897]

According to Scottish legend, a man named Willox battled a water horse by Loch Ness. He slashed and snatched the beast's bridle with his sword, which it demanded he return forthwith. By refusing, Willox learned the monster's secrets and earned "a reputation in the area as a powerful and mysterious necromancer."[3898]

After their ordeals, serpents assist shamans in subsequent contact with the Otherworld. The ascent often characterized by ladders, ropes, etc. is equally attributable to snakes, especially in Australia. Other serpents become spirit helpers, as to Tungus[3899] and some North American shamans.[3900] This may be what several Penobscot tribesmen observed when spying on medicine man

John Neptune, who met the approach of "an immense eel" not with terror but affection, gently cradling its head and "drumming on it softly."[3901]

The question of dragons as doubles naturally arises. The correlation is weak yet present. In one Yakut myth, a "shaman's body was made of a mass of snakes,"[3902] while Lenâpé shamans were sometimes conflated with *Kitzinackas*, or "big serpents."[3903] The Uktena begins as a man in some legends, transformed by Little People.[3904] A Mohawk legend recounts a swimming brave who grasped a "water-logged tree-trunk" only to have it pull him underwater to a hut inhabited by a family of naked people; after donning a snakeskin coat and antlered hood offered to him, he became *Oniare*, the horned water serpent.[3905]

This last legend demonstrates an important lake monster motif. Witnesses' first impressions are often of logs. Logs are important to lake monster skeptics and mythicists alike. Skeptics assert most if not all lake monsters simply *are* logs, perhaps jettisoned from the lakebed by pressurized gases during decomposition. Mythicists, on the other hand, point to shapeshifting, with legends worldwide describing logs as a favored monster form. Indeed, early American settlers described lake monsters as "living logs." While the *Elbst* of Switzerland's Seelisburg Lake was a dragon, he "rarely show[ed] himself in his *true form:* sometimes he swims like a *tree trunk* covered with moss…."[3906]

Cryptozoologists have little use for the explanations of skeptics or mythicists. Their preoccupation with scientific legitimacy means they cannot afford the luxuries of fantasy, nor abide the austerity of reductionism.

But *logs*—how poetic. Few images hold such rich death symbolism. Before we ever mastered shipbuilding, the easiest means of crossing water was astride a log. Our earliest boats, dugout canoes, were little more than trees hollowed out by successive charring and scraping. A log is therefore a boat, and a boat is a psychopomp symbol. Boats are also coffins, both literally and figuratively (Chapter 15). Recall Jung's "tree of death," *totenbaum*, colloquially a coffin. Logs are literally dead trees. Viking longships—the same used for *ship burials*—proudly display dragon figureheads.[3907] The "motifs most frequently encountered in *boat-coffins* in the Philippines are the *lizard* and the *crocodile* [author's emphasis]."[3908] Writes Meurger:

> The hollow trunk, the most archaic form of boat, was equally the coffin of primitives, as attested by numerous archaeological finds, notably among the Germanic peoples… Merovingian Europe furnished curious equivalents in the coffins covered with horned dragons of Southern Germany, the backs of which were also adorned with a jagged ridge. These biers, crudely dug out of trunks, reunite the tree and the serpent.[3909]

This is not academic drivel. The log-boat-coffin-monster association is firmly ensconced in the mythological mind. Nessie witnesses often compare the creatures to overturned boats. In January 1887, Morag appeared to locals in three humps, each perceived "as death, a coffin, and a grave."[3910]

Viewing logs as death symbols even allows us to reframe cigar-shaped UFOs as variations on the theme. One young UFO witness disagreed with his mother's and sister's description of the craft they spotted in 1982 near

Glendora, California: instead of seeing a "red rectangle" with a cross inside, he perceived "a 'brown log' standing upright in the center. Positioned against this 'log' was a figure he called 'a ghost'… gather[ing] stars in a bag."[3911]

Lake monsters:

A psychopomp aquarium

With the possible exception of the Congolese water snake god Simbi, all the psychopomp potency found in logs is absent in snakes. We have fleeting suggestions, yes—Chinese emperors[3912] and Egyptian pharaohs[3913] were borne to the afterlife by dragons and snakes—but this may solely speak to the reptilian association with royalty (from which we derive "*draco*nian"). By-and-large, soul-leading snakes are sparse when compared to other animals.

More often, dragons and serpents were guardians, not only of burials but the afterlife itself. Snake deities watch the threshold to the Egyptian underworld,[3914] South America's Warao believe a snake bridge connects our world to the afterlife, etc.[3915]

The clearest psychopomp connections to lake monsters are found in a subset of faerie animals, the water *horses* and water *hounds*. While never regarded as soul leaders themselves, these aquatic creatures are responsible for most lake monster traditions in Ireland and the British Isles, and appropriate the guise of our most beloved psychopomp animals.

Our first, the water horse, has been alluded to extensively in previous sections. On the Isle of Man they are *Cabyll-Ushtey*, in Ireland *Each-Uisce*, Scotland variously *Aughisky*, Each-Uisge, or kelpies.[3916] Similar beasts are alleged throughout Scandinavia, Siberian Russia, Italy, France, the Czech

Republic, and southern Slavic countries.[3917] In Ireland and the British Isles, they appear either in the water or on land as completely mundane horses, much like the Irish pooka. Water horses welcome weary travelers onto their backs before plunging into the waves, dragging them to their doom, possibly for dinner. Not all are vicious; some take on human form after falling in love with mortal women.[3918]

Modern sightings reaffirm the water horse identity. Witnesses commonly—overwhelmingly—compare the heads of creatures like Nessie to those of horses, including prominent ears and manes, peculiar features for an aquatic species.[3919] While some manes could represent weeds or other vegetation, the feature appears too often to dismiss as such. Horse heads and manes are equally common among sea serpents, with some even describing coats of fur "like that of a horse when wet and glistening."[3920]

"The horse too is a 'tree of death,'" Jung wrote, inadvertently tying water horses to logs. "In the Middle Ages the bier was called 'St. Michael's Horse,' and the modern Persian word for coffin means 'wooden horse.'"[3921]

Dogs, another psychopomp animal, appear in the lake monster mythos as Ireland's *dobhar-chu*, or "water hound." Like their landbound "black dog" brethren—who also appear around bodies of water[3922] (perhaps they are one and the same?)—these animals are regarded as death omens. Some cryptozoologists try to identify the dobhar-chu as otters, but otters are far too playful and easygoing to match the water hound's aggressive nature.[3923]

Water canids also appear in New World legends. The Aztec dog psychopomp Xolotl was associated with the axolotl salamander.[3924] Some American lake monsters present dog-shaped heads.[3925]

Mysterious "tree trunks" and "'dogs' which come and go" haunt a lake near Foster Bar, British Columbia. A Chinook story from the region emphasizes this lake as the afterlife: a young man whose sister was abducted by spirits asked a burned tree trunk where we go when we die. In answer, the log slipped into the water, offering passage to "the land of the spirits."[3926]

Again, neither water horses nor water hounds are psychopomps, but horses and dogs are, broadly speaking. So are cattle in some Hindu traditions, bringing us to water bulls.

Less common (and less dangerous) than their equine counterparts, water bulls like the *Crodh Mara* of the Scottish Highlands might fraternize with mundane cattle, breeding to improve or diminish the lineage of herds or, more surreptitiously, leading them into faerie hills.[3927] Some believed the fae folk herded water bulls beneath the waves.[3928] Like other faerie water animals, they can be found outside Ireland and the British Isles: in 1863, Sven Anderson was fishing Sweden's Lake Källsjö when something "looking like an enormous bull" broke the waves, accompanied by foaming and a monstrous howl.[3929]

These myths may have been inspired by reports of lake monsters sporting knobs or horns on their heads, which persist into modern sightings.[3930] American tribes typically depicted these as the antlers of stags (another psychopomp animal).[3931] Alternatively, water bulls may be related to another unsolved mystery: livestock mutilation.

Time after time, lake monsters are compared to horribly disfigured farm animals. Norway's Lake Mjösa hosts a plethora of anomalies, including a 17th

century account of "a herd of pigs" stampeding the lakebed which "in the wink of an eye, transformed themselves and turned inside out like calf hides which had just been skinned." The lake dragon upon which the Traunsee faerie queen rode resembled "a skinned horse." A Bohemian peasant barely avoided mounting a water horse after noticing it lacked a bottom lip. One eyewitness at Lake Pohénégamook described its beast as a "mutilated horse," its head lacking ears. These traits could even be passed to water bull offspring: "On the island of Skye, calves with deformed ears are killed at birth" for being cattle-faerie hybrids.[3932]

The soft tissue absent in the examples above precisely matches the style of wounds inflicted during livestock mutilations. Consider how drowning poses the greatest threat to livestock's well-being during floods—floods brought about by *storms*, which faeries and dragons control. Are some lake monsters the ghosts of dead livestock?

Lake monsters:

Ammit in argyle

Lakes represent many things: the afterlife, the Otherworld, the subconscious. Within their depths we embark on katabasis and, if fortunate enough to return, receive enlightenment.

Lake *monsters* represent many things as well. Their humps, for example, resemble nothing less than the Otherworld itself, fleshy tumuli awash in the waves, rising like mythical Hy Brasil. The monster *is* the mountain.

Yet something sinister is encoded within lake monsters. Holiday positioned the dragon as evil, intrinsically linked to the divinity of the UFO yet fundamentally opposed. It does not sustain the World Tree, but gnaws at it like a cancer. Early Christianity deemed dragons the scourge of the soul, the "worm of hell," Satan himself.

Revelation 12:3 reads, "Then another sign appeared in heaven: an enormous red dragon with seven heads and ten horns and seven crowns on its heads." Later, "The great dragon was hurled down—that ancient serpent called the devil, or Satan, who leads the whole world astray. He was hurled to the earth, and his angels with him." Even here, it is a devourer: "The dragon stood in front of the woman who was about to give birth, so that it might devour her child the moment he was born."

Donald Omand, who attempted to exorcise Nessie in the 1970s, chartered a boat into Norway's "Fjord of the Trolls" several years earlier. When the boiling water revealed two humps on a collision course with their craft, his guide appeared nonplussed: "It will not hurt us—they never do," he shrugged. "They don't do physical harm. The evil they do is to men's characters."[3933]

Early in our discussion we noted that lake monster encounters have little to do with NDEs. Few if any of the hallmarks are present, yet they seem important to the ecology of souls. An argument can be made that the whirlpools found in so many monster lakes resemble afterlife tunnels, as might the long, slender necks often reported—but these, especially the latter, imply disconcerting destinations. You don't wind up in a pastoral afterlife… you wind up *eaten.*

Consider other observations. Nessie witnesses are seized with an unreasonable terror. The reassuring totality flying saucers exhibit is never fully realized in monster humps, which instead remain but *half-circles*. Similarly, when compared to boats, they are always *overturned*, implying a calamity, an interrupted journey across the Styx. Everything about lake monsters is *broken*, including their mutilated features. The lakes, as Meurger notes at length, *do not surrender their dead.* (Avernus, a Roman lake synonymous with the underworld, was named for its "birdlessness," implying Hell is not for tormenting souls, but *annihilating* them.)[3934]

Few cryptozoologists note similarities between Ammit, the Egyptian demoness who consumes unworthy souls, and lake monsters—yet the resemblance is striking. While no one ever reports seeing a

crocodile/lion/hippopotamus hybrid in Loch Ness, its constituent parts *are* reported. Nessie's humps resemble the backs of hippos, its mane a perfect match for a lion's locks. While horse heads prevail, other witnesses also describe Nessie, Ogopogo, Ponik, and other lake monsters' faces as crocodilian.[3935] Nessie, like Ammit, is often referred to with feminine pronouns. Have we at long-last found our soul devourer in a Scottish loch—Ammit in argyle?

Why an Egyptian deity would reside so far from home is anyone's guess. However, if soul devourers are real, they are likely untethered from concepts as quaint as space and time. Maybe Ammit was *called* there.

Aleister Crowley's work displays an obsession with *Choronzon*, a demon first identified by 16th century English magicians John Dee and Edward Kelly. Choronzon is famously the Demon of Dispersions and of The Abyss, e.g. oceanic depths, nothingness.[3936]

"There is no difference between [the Egyptian chaos serpent] Aapep and Ammit with consideration to Choronzon," wrote magician Michael W. Ford.[3937] Since Nessie's appearance precedes Crowley's arrival at Loch Ness by over a millennium, we are left several possibilities. Perhaps he detected this presence in the area and was drawn to it. More wildly, perhaps his conjurations somehow *stretched back into time* to manifest the beast for St. Columba.

Nessie need not be Ammit specifically—plenty of contenders exist, some closer to Scotland. Apocalyptic water dragons awaiting the end of days can be found in Germany's Seealpsee, Iceland's Lagarfljöt, and even Ireland's Loch-Bél-Dracon, where "a fiery salmon-serpent" was "identified as the

dragon of the apocalypse." All seem to rework ancient Norse myths of the "great Midgard serpent" destined to consume the gods at *Ragnarök*.[3938] In the aftermath of this particular apocalypse, one of the halls of hell will hold "the serpent *Nidhöggr*" as he "devours the corpses of the dead. "[3939]

Even if lake monsters are pure fantasy—a position we are unwilling to adopt—their existence may still speak to annihilation. The dragon's fiery holocaust is apparent in monster lakes, which are often craters formed by volcanoes or interplanetary collisions.[3940] Even Ohio's Serpent Mound is located in an eroded meteorite crater, to which it lends its name. It seems likely ancient humans, perceiving comets and meteors as dragons, encoded these cataclysms within our landscape in both myths and effigies.[3941]

The curious incidence of what cryptozoologist Ivan T. Sanderson deemed "Monster Latitudes" offers further clarity.[3942] Note how many of the lakes above fall roughly in the same region of the world, specifically the northern hemisphere. It stands to reason a single extraterrestrial object breaking apart, or perhaps a shower of numerous meteors, left a string of depressions in its wake sometime in the forgotten past.

Time filled these with water. We filled them with monsters.

Mothman:

Point Unpleasant

Since you have probably read books on Mothman—John Keel's *The Mothman Prophecies* and Gray Barker's *The Silver Bridge* most likely—a brief thumbnail sketch of the 1966-1967 events surrounding Point Pleasant, West Virginia should suffice. If you haven't, they come highly recommended… even if, as detractors complain, not every word is true.

Panic officially set in after the November 15, 1966 sighting of the Scarberrys and the Mallettes. The young couples were driving through the now-infamous "TNT area," an old WWII munitions plant, when they beheld "two bright red circles… about two inches in diameter and six inches apart" around 11:30 p.m. It became apparent these belonged to a figure, taller than a human, with "big wings folded against its back." As they fled in terror, the creature's wings opened and it followed them, reaching at least 62 miles per hour.[3943]

An unprecedented flap descended upon Point Pleasant, replete not only with further sightings of "Mothman" but mysterious strangers and UFOs, from structured craft to anomalous lights in the sky. Events came to a head the following Christmas season, a time of year when, like Halloween, the veil between the living and the dead traditionally thins. The Silver Bridge connecting West Virginia to Ohio collapsed on December 15, 1967, killing 46 of 64 victims who plunged into the icy Ohio River. It remains the deadliest

bridge disaster in United States history, all from a fracture only three millimeters deep.[3944]

Whether any relationship exists between the collapse and the High Strangeness around Point Pleasant is debatable, but John Keel certainly felt as much. Keel, who had been investigating events in the area for some time, slowly became a player in the narrative itself, befriending witnesses and experiencing anomalies like mysterious phone calls. While he suspected calamity would one day come knocking, he never grasped its magnitude, instead anticipating "a massive power failure."

"I fell back in my chair" upon hearing the news broadcast, he remembered. "… the seven-hundred-foot Silver Bridge at Point Pleasant. The bridge I had crossed a thousand times… They've done it again… Those lousy bastards have done it again. They knew this was going to happen... and when. And they gave me all that bilge about a power failure. They knew. They just didn't want me to be able to warn anyone."

While by no means a comprehensive survey of the saga, this provides a useful starting point for discussion. Immediately we see Mothman as a therianthrope, combining the human form with something winged, either a moth or a bird—both symbols of souls, psychopomps, and shamans, as well as death omens. Skeptics instantly seized upon the creature as a misidentified bird, perhaps an owl or, more realistically, a sandhill crane. (Presenting pictures of the latter during interviews, Keel claimed "not a single witness recognized it or thought it resembled what he or she had seen.")[3945]

Descriptions of Mothman tend towards vague, but sightings of a similar creature in Cornwall in 1976 were much clearer. "Owlman," as it was dubbed,

strongly resembled its American counterpart: tall and hissing, with unflapping wings and red eyes. Owlman even accompanied a Point Pleasant-like flap including UFOs and Morgawr (mentioned earlier). The primary difference was its clearly visible head—nonexistent in some Mothman reports—topped by two "pointed ears," evoking an owl's feathers.[3946] Previous chapters illustrate owls' connection to death in mythology worldwide, an association moths share, particularly in the New World—where, as luck would have it, *Mothman* appeared. Perhaps the phenomenon behind flying humanoids draws upon region-appropriate imagery.

Researchers sometimes link personal tragedies to Owlman. For example, in the summer of 2000 investigator Jon Downes was struck by a drunk driver, his friend committed suicide, three pets died, and his house nearly burned down. "When Jon told me that this was very possibly all due to a form of 'psychic backlash' that was a direct result of his investigation of the Owlman, I believed him," Nick Redfern wrote.[3947]

Mothman, on the other hand, represented a death omen on a scale typically reserved for major astronomical events like comets. Both witnesses and their relatives lost their lives in the Silver Bridge collapse.[3948] Over the years, Mothman has fostered a reputation as a harbinger of doom, to the extent Forteans grimly await tragedy whenever anyone reports flying creatures. Such fears, while not baseless, may nonetheless be overblown.

For example, the spring 2017 Mothman flap around Chicago never manifested any comparable calamity. One witness did, however, describe shapeshifting, a new attribute for Mothman but consistent with other creatures from the ecology of souls. On July 24, Guillermo was smoking a

cigarette when he saw a six-foot tall, winged humanoid perched atop Willis Tower. "He called it a 'human, insect and bird mix,'" wrote researcher Lon Strickler, adding that the creature "seemed to mutate while in flight."[3949]

Returning to the events of 1966-1967, it was only a matter of time before Point Pleasant experienced such drama. The surrounding landscape, as first noted in Chapter 8, constitutes a window area. Beyond Mothman (Mothmen?), witnesses through the present day report UFOs, Bigfoot, Goatman, run-of-the-mill ghosts, and other oddities around town.

"This part of the Ohio River Valley has always been heavily haunted," said Rosemary Ellen Guiley. "Generation after generation have had encounters with ghosts and mysterious creatures. This is in my opinion a portal area," to which "negative energy" and chemical contamination from the TNT area perhaps contributed.[3950] Others, including Keel, wondered if the very land around Point Pleasant was damned.

"Chief Cornstalk and his Shawnees fought a battle there in the 1760s and Cornstalk is supposed to have put a curse on the area before he fell," he wrote. "But what happened there before? Did someone else live there?"[3951]

Point Pleasant sits at the eastern edge of mound building territory. Its encompassing district, Mason County, contains indigenous tumuli of various sizes. Both Keel and Barker visited nearby North Charleston during their investigations, literally named "Mound, West Virginia" at the time. Structures in the region include effigies approximating Mothman itself, typically in the form of thunderbirds and other avian configurations.

"The 'Bird Man,' a winged human, is found depicted in various media, from copper plates, sandstone plaques and etched stones that have been excavated from these ancient sites," wrote Barbara Fisher, who appears in earlier chapters. "The being, whether it depicts a spirit or a shamanic human, appears in various different time periods and seems to be quite important to the cosmology of these ancient peoples."[3952] Like Fisher, other researchers perceive a direct link between Mothman and tumuli, as many sightings occur around—or *at*—the mounds.

"Over the course of several weeks in November of 1868, more than two dozen residents reported seeing a large, winged 'man' circling above two local landmarks" in the Ohio River Valley, "including what is known as the Wright-Greene Adena Indian Mounds, a group of three ancient Adena burial mounds, and the historic Johnson House," wrote investigator Barton Nunnelly.[3953]

Mothman:

The near-death flap

As with Bigfoot, NDE-like effects reported by Mothman witnesses are apparent but spotty. Because it is difficult to separate the creature from the flap itself, the following correlations come both from Mothman witnesses *and* those experiencing other anomalies around Point Pleasant at the time.

Entirely absent from the Mothman saga are life reviews, ultimatums, and any sense of peace—to the contrary, witnesses were typically seized by an irrational fear, with the exception of a handful of UFO contactees discussed shortly. None experienced levitation or OBEs in conjunction with Mothman, although many described its own "flight" more like an unnatural "float."[3954]

- **Sound.** Witnesses heard whining noises, rushing sounds (like a "vacuum cleaner"),[3955] or, most often, squeaks compared to "a big mouse" or "bad fan belt."[3956] This trend continued into the 2017 sightings ("like squeaky brakes").[3957] All bring to mind the cart of Brittany's psychopomp the ankou, whose "creaking" wheels "may be plainly heard."[3958]

- **Inaccessible knowledge.** Although only appreciated in hindsight, several people sensed something bad was headed to Point Pleasant. "It's the most terrible thing I've ever seen," reporter Mary Hyre told Keel following the bridge collapse. "But I was kind of prepared for it. You know those dreams I had... well, it was

exactly like that. The packages floating in the water. The people crying for help. Those dreams came true."[3959]

Although far from West Virginia, a Long Island witness with whom Keel corresponded during 1967 passed along several warnings under hypnosis, including a danger posed to President John F. Kennedy and "specific predictions about pending plane crashes." The messages came from "Mr. Apol," one of the mysterious MIB she had met.[3960]

"The predicted plane crashes occurred right on schedule," Keel wrote. "I was slowly convincing myself that the entities were somehow tuned to the future."[3961]

- **Tunnel experience.** While no witnesses beheld spectral tunnels, the motif is apparent in the Silver Bridge itself as well as the TNT area, which holds "miles of underground tunnels."[3962]

- **Bright light.** White, red, orange, green, blue,[3963] and purple[3964] lights were all seen in the skies above West Virginia. Mothman's eyes famously glowed or reflected red.[3965]

- **Landscapes.** The importance of a *river* and a *bridge* in Mothman mythos reifies ancient symbolism demarcating afterlife boundaries. Though not otherworldly, Keel attributed the TNT area "a harmless, pastoral appearance."[3966]

- **Enhanced perception.** Keel's "best sighting" occurred in the wee hours of April 3, 1967, when he saw a red-topped, "greenish" object in the sky. "The colors were so brilliant they were almost unearthly," he said.[3967]

- **Interiors.** The cave motif appears in the TNT area. In addition to subterranean tunnels, it is littered with domed "igloos" once used to safely store explosives.[3968]

- **Supernatural lapses of time.** Just over 20 miles from Point Pleasant, a couple in a car in Ravenswood heard "a low hum" coming from "a big ball of bluish fire" during the flap's height. She told Keel, "It seemed like we only looked at that light for a couple of seconds. But somehow it must have taken two hours."[3969]

About two weeks before the initial Mothman sighting, Woodrow Derenberger—a resident of nearby Mineral Wells and a UFO contactee central to Keel's investigation—met a mysterious figure who identified himself as Indrid Cold from Lanulos. Derenberger "regarded the ufonauts as 'time travelers,'" Keel explained, adding, "When he went off on a trip with Indrid Cold, a trip that seemed to take hours or days, he always found on his return that only a few hours of earth time had passed."[3970]

- **Love.** Like Bigfoot, Mothman is more interested in sexuality than affection. The creature "seemed to have a penchant for scaring females who were menstruating."[3971]

- **Music.** Just before Newell Partridge's Mothman sighting in Salem, West Virginia, his television began whining, ascending like "a musical scale" before dropping and repeating. Other witnesses including Keel reported "strange beeping sounds" or "electronic music" over the telephone.[3972]

- **Beings.** It takes little imagination to see vestiges of Valkyries or angels in Mothman. Indrid Cold carries with him all the similarities noted between other Space Brothers and peaceful NDE light beings. Cold may have even shimmered a bit himself: Derenberger said he wore "reflective material" under his coat, similar to that used in terrestrial astronaut gear.[3973]

- **Amnesia.** After seeing strange lights, one witness remarked, "It's a funny thing. We were so stunned we didn't even talk about it afterwards. We just sat silently at the kitchen table. We even forgot to say our 'thank yous' that morning."[3974]

Hyre told Keel she saw "a big globe of light on the river," but "forgot it completely. I didn't remember it until a day or so afterward. Then I forgot it again. I can't understand it. I've always had a very good memory."[3975]

- **Healing, new abilities, and spiritual awakenings.** Like other contactees, Derenberger reported psi phenomena in the form of telepathic communication from Cold, though he "never claimed psychic powers" himself. Cold also administered a vial of medicine for Derenberger's chronic "stomach ailments," instantly curing him.[3976]

- **Poltergeist phenomena.** Poltergeists feature before, during, and after the Point Pleasant flap. "One resident was having trouble with poltergeist phenomenon... lights moving through his house, rappings on the doors and windows, the sounds of babies crying and 'women screaming,' telephones malfunctioning—the works," Keel quipped.[3977] Perhaps coincidentally or unrelated, engine malfunctions occurred.[3978]

After welcoming a mysterious figure named "Jack Brown" into her home—likely an MIB posing as a UFO researcher—Connie Carpenter briefly forgot the incident, and "a poltergeist settled in the Carpenter household. Securely fastened pictures fell off the walls. Small objects disappeared from shelves and reappeared in unlikely places. The manifestations lasted about two weeks."

Flying saucers notwithstanding, little about the Point Pleasant flap suggests totality (though Roger Scarberry did suffer nightmares of "a great eye floating in the sky").[3979]

Equally sparse—beyond obvious comparisons to the bird-soul—are indications that Mothman itself represented some sort of double. Other doubles were reported, however. Doppelgängers followed John Keel, for instance (Chapter 17), and a certain point-of-view can recast MIB as doubles, mentioned later.

One outlandish tale from Gray Barker is worth mentioning, though it is unclear what to make of it. Following the first Mothman sightings, Ida Wentworth moved out of her house, leaving her husband Frank behind. When she finally decided to return, her journey coincided with the timing of the bridge collapse. Frank was away from the house when he heard the news, and while fearful for his wife, "he was certain she had returned, whether or not she had crashed with the bridge." Hopes were confirmed when he returned home to find a taxi with Ohio plates in the driveway.[3980]

Rushing inside, he found someone in bed. Joy turned to suspicions of infidelity, until, pulling away the covers, he was met by Mothman in all its winged, red-eyed glory. Frank fell to his knees, sobbing prayers. When he finally looked up, his landlady stood in the doorway, chiding him for the mud and "gallons of water" filling the apartment.[3981] Had Ida's winged soul, liberated in the river, returned one last time?

Mothman:

Prophecies

Keel's eponymous "prophecies" cemented Mothman's most enduring legacy, an unbroken tradition stretching back to other avian death omens like the Welsh deryn corph. Did Mothman predict the Silver Bridge disaster?

Similar superstitions and stories exist worldwide surrounding not only birds but stranger things. Rumors persist "a large, black 'man-dragon'" appeared above a Chinese dam several days before its catastrophic failure in early 1926. A famous story Keel related described a naked, green-glowing, jet-black woman with bat wings who harassed U.S. Marines during the Vietnam War in 1969, a conflict responsible for untold death and destruction.[3982] The pterosaur-like *Kongamato* is blamed for floods in sub-Saharan Africa.[3983]

But how often do sightings *actually* portend disaster? We have several notable examples, most obviously the Silver Bridge collapse itself, which presents no shortage of thematic material with which to work.

Bridges' ubiquity as afterlife symbols both in religions and firsthand NDE testimony bears repeating. Any Otherworld separated from our reality by a river or chasm must be crossed by the dead, and when they cannot ford it or cross on a ferry, they do so by bridge. Anyone traveling to the Telumni Yokut Land of the Dead must traverse a bridge guarded by a *bird*.[3984] Bridges are liminal spaces by definition, neither here nor there.

Other entities besides Mothman collapse bridges. Canadian soldiers training during WWII near England's Woodchester Park saw a "spirit" hovering above the property's lake; the following day, a pontoon bridge collapsed during exercises, consigning 20 soldiers to a watery grave.[3985] At least two English stories blame bridge failures on faeries, one a railway bridge which fell in the mid-1800s at Shap, Cumbria, the other a section of rail brought down near a Derbyshire house haunted by a faerie/ghost named Dickie.[3986]

Mothman allegedly appeared before other tragedies throughout the 20th century, but none are documented as fastidiously as the Silver Bridge event. Over the years, claims surfaced that residents observed "a bizarre winged creature" in Pripyat, Ukraine days before the notorious April 1986 Chernobyl nuclear disaster. However, as cryptozoologist Loren Coleman points out, there exists "not one thread of evidence that any winged weirdies were witnessed before the Chernobyl event."[3987]

Nick Redfern suspects these rumors accidentally originated in the afterword of a 1991 edition of *The Mothman Prophecies*, where Keel mentioned the Soviet Union "being engulfed with UFOs and monsters" alongside "Soviet atomic plants" and "little Russian towns… plunged into the same kind of *Twilight Zone* horror that once gripped Point Pleasant." Neither Pripyat nor Chernobyl were mentioned. [3988]

A recent example presents a stronger pedigree. In Japan in February 2011, witness Marcus Pules claimed to hear a "whoosh" and a noise like "a city bus's brakes when they are in need of service." He filled with dread and looked towards a nearby power plant, where a large, winged shadow

loomed, silhouetted by floodlights. A month later, another witness saw "a very big" humanoid bird at the same place. The next day, a tsunami wreaked destruction upon the Fukushima Daiichi Nuclear Power Plant, "the exact same plant [both witnesses] had seen the strange bird like creature circling."[3989]

Intimate tragedies seem far more common, if only because they are harder to verify. Consider Jon Downes's Owlman misfortunes, or the traumatic abuse experienced by a young boy who in 1981 saw "a thin black human shape" that "stood seven feet in height" with "intense red eyes" and "wings folded on its back that extended above its long thin head."[3990]

- In 1946, teens walking near a spooky house in Littlefield, Texas encountered a pair of eight-foot-tall, red-eyed, leather-winged creatures. All present allegedly "died at surprisingly young ages" from "unlikely accidents."[3991]

- "Death would claim too many of the participants in the dramas of 1967," Keel wrote. "Mrs. Mary Hyre passed away in 1970. Ivan T. Sanderson left us in 1973. Dr. Edward U. Condon, Fred Freed, and many others would be gone long before the tenth anniversary of the appearance of the winged thing in front of the old power plant."[3992]

- Keel also learned about JFK's assassination, but the information was not actionable. However, when he received a mysterious phone call predicting Martin Luther King, Jr.'s balcony murder in Memphis on February 4, 1968, he "spent some frantic hours trying to contact King by phone to warn him." Keel failed, and King was assassinated two months later to the day, on April 4.[3993]

- Kimberly Frazier and her family saw a winged shape in the sky in July 2003 while driving near Olive Hill, Kentucky. Exactly six months later, her stepdaughter's husband died in a car accident precisely where the sighting occurred.[3994]

- In 2004, Jennifer Barrett-Pellington, who designed costumes for the 2002 film adaptation of *The Mothman Prophecies*, passed away suddenly from a "brief illness." In 2006, Lisa McIntosh, who produced documentaries on topics including Mothman, died from "a rare cancer called multiple myeloma," which doctors found "extremely unusual" in someone 42 years old. Like Barrett-Pellington, it was two years after filming.[3995]

Author Micah Hanks suggested Mothman put in an appearance before the death of John Keel himself. News of Keel's demise broke within hours of Hanks learning about a friend's Mothman sighting. "Had the winged-one dropped in to make its final appearance, perhaps to check in with its old acquaintance one last time before joining him in the dimensional realm?" he playfully wondered.[3996]

Keel famously called the Point Pleasant flap "the Year of the *Garuda*" in reference to the birdlike Hindu deity, but this is a poor fit. Garuda is a protector whose primary death association comes from the *Garuda Purana*, a dialogue between him and Vishnu traditionally recited over the dead.[3997] He is benevolent. Better analogues might be found in any number of winged psychopomps or *Ītzpāpālōtl*, a skeletal, therianthropic Aztec moth goddess who presides over *Tamoanchan*, realm of infant mortalities.[3998] She is

associated with birds and fire, and is symbolized by other lepidopteran insects like butterflies.[3999]

Is Mothman actually a harbinger of doom? The jury is out. Plenty of disasters happen in the absence of sightings. Plenty of sightings happen in the absence of disasters. Broadly labeling winged humanoids negative is specious at best, especially given millennia of messages from benevolent deities in the sky. Granted, if you believe seeing Mothman is dangerous, it might well be, from the imaginal perspective of "the power of negative thinking."

Some winged humanoid sightings are actually *positive*. Andrew Colvin, who grew up in Point Pleasant, claims his family's Mothman sighting left him with new talents like a photographic memory and scholastic proficiency.[4000] Numerous tales also emerged about kind "Butterfly People" in the aftermath of the devastating tornado that ravaged Joplin, Missouri on May 22, 2011.

"Most commonly, a child would see a butterfly person, a humanoid but with colorful wings hovering above them and their adult guardians as the tornado approached," wrote Paul and Ben Eno. "Some children thought they were angels. Others talked about an 'indescribable presence.'"[4001] In one dramatic account, rescuers found a five-year-old child who had been caught outdoors in the storm miraculously unharmed. He claimed a trio of shining beings with "butterfly wings" had walked towards him across the field as the tornado raged, deflecting debris. They surrounded him until the winds subsided, then smiled and vanished. Today, a mural in honor of these winged saviors adorns a building in downtown Joplin.[4002]

Flying humanoids might best be summarized by revising Chapter 3's list of associations: Butterfly People embody the solar, light, conscious, and life; Mothman, the lunar, shadow, unconscious, and death. This is the dichotomy Keel faced during the Point Pleasant flap—a phantasmagoria blending the real and unreal, leaving him, to a certain degree, shamanized.

"Even as Keel pursued them single-mindedly, believing in their literal existence, they reflected that literalness back at him, seeming to be literal but all the while evaporating under his grasp, leading him up the garden path, driving him insane until he began to get an inkling of their ambivalence," wrote Patrick Harpur of Keel's journey. "Here we see the other side of Hermes-Mercurius, not the Trickster but the psychopomp or guide of souls. His tricks not only confuse, but also lead us towards the truth; his messages are not only misleading, but are also 'messages from the gods' whose messenger he is."[4003]

The paranormal draws the curious like moths to a flame. John Keel wisely concluded such obsessions could end calamitously should they go unchecked —fly too close, and you end up burned.

Men-in-Black:

Dead ringers

Before launching to the forefront of pop-culture awareness with the 1997 film, the Men-in-Black (MIB) appeared throughout history in fits and starts. Their notorious Point Pleasant appearances were prefigured by 1963's *Flying Saucers and the Three Men*, which described Albert Bender's interactions with them a decade earlier; this in turn "reignited attention to a phenomenon that's almost as old as time itself," wrote Adam Gorightly and Greg Bishop. "These tales of creepy black garbed men go back eons and have long been associated with the sinister doings of witches, warlocks, and other things that go boo in the night."[4004]

As if their unearthly looks and demeanor weren't enough, these ancient stories refute the shallow reading that MIB serve the United States government. If they do, then the Americans have walking corpses on retainer, and send them to interfere with foreign witnesses of all sorts of phenomena. Similar figures in other countries harass those reporting Nessie, ABCs, and even Bigfoot.[4005]

MIB encounters typically unfold within days of a paranormal experience, most often a UFO sighting. They embody the epitome of mid-20th century American authority: up to three "men," fastidiously wardrobed in white dress shirts, neckties, black suits, shoes, and sometimes fedoras, arrive at the witness's home in a pristine black automobile of older make, often a Cadillac.

Their features are often deathly pale or vaguely "foreign," up to and including their eyes, which may be slanted. Asking to speak to the witness or investigator, they are invited inside and discuss the sighting, sharing details no one else could have known. Over the course of their stay, the MIBs' condition sometimes deteriorates, their speech slowing with vague allusions to "running low" on some sort of energy. Hospitable hosts might offer them refreshment, which some seem unfamiliar with (in a handful of examples, they try to *drink* Jell-O).[4006] Invariably, the MIB level both veiled and explicit threats at witnesses before returning to their vehicle. Attempts to follow the Cadillac might find it turning down a dead-end road, where it vanishes nonetheless.

Researchers perceive echoes of the undead in this scenario, particularly vampires, who share MIB's unhealthy pallor and need for invitation inside. This same request is made by beings called Black-Eyed-Kids (BEKs), youths arriving on doorsteps typically dressed in hoodies to hide their eyes' uniformly black sclera and irises. These entities target Good Samaritans, often claiming to be lost or stranded, asking to come inside to use the telephone. Almost without exception, the witness's sense of unease is confirmed after seeing their black eyes and the request is denied.

Author G. Michael Vasey believes BEKs' ulterior motive is to "suck your life energy; feed off of it. Given permission to come in, they devour your soul." Vasey draws further connections to the acheri (spirits vaguely resembling faeries mentioned in Chapter 5) whom he describes as "soul eaters" who boast "black eyes or no eyes at all—just dark holes where their eyes should be."[4007]

Alongside BEKs, Women-in-Black (WIB) represent another MIB variation. While countless homes are haunted by female ghosts wearing black dresses, others seem more akin to MIB, appearing as physical presences who delight in threatening researchers. Death and negativity surround them, leading Nick Redfern to draw comparisons to the Irish banshee.[4008] Of course, banshees appeared dressed in white more often than black; in this sense, WIB might be the dark inversion of the gnostic Sophia (Chapter 17).

Shifting focus back to MIB, their complexions are corpselike, an observation not lost upon witnesses. A County Tipperary man visited by an MIB compared him to a walking corpse.[4009] The "cadaver-like" "Plastic-Facers" who harassed an Indiana UFO witness had "deathly-white" complexions and "glassy eyes."[4010] Canadian alien abductee Sarah Hines was approached by an MIB in 1979 who "looked like a dead person. He had a dull grey-toned face, slanted eyes and wore a black suit."[4011]

Although MIB's angled eyes favor extraterrestrials' over corpses', Chapter 13 showed how Greys resemble the dead in their own right. Some MIB clearly wear makeup, suggesting the preparations applied to cadavers at funeral homes.[4012] Anyone inviting MIB inside like Connie Carpenter might find their homes beset by poltergeists, though such activity might also arise from their UFO sightings.

These impressions extend to WIB. The Long Island MIB experiencer with whom John Keel corresponded also met a peculiar woman in "old-fashioned" clothes who spoke "in broken English." "It was as if… she were dead," the witness shivered.[4013]

Like nearly all paranormal phenomena, both MIB and BEK exude sulfurous odors, the stench of decay. Bender's MIB reeked of rotten eggs. Other odors equally suggest the dead: a Tampa WIB smelled like formalin, used in embalming, while one pair of BEK "smelled like sulfur or dirt, and death."[4014]

MIB trappings are clearly funereal. The black Cadillacs they commandeer are dead ringers for hearses. After he hypnotically regressed an alien abductee in September 1976, an MIB demanded Maine researcher Herbert Hopkins destroy his tapes—Hopkins's first thought was, "This guy looks just like an undertaker."[4015]

Hopkins's MIB somehow knew two coins, a dime and a penny, sat in his pocket. Instructed to produce one, Hopkins procured the penny. The MIB told him to watch, and the coin turned a blurry, iridescent blue before disappearing.[4016] Continued Hopkins:

> He then asked me if I knew why Barney Hill died, and I told him that I assumed it was the result of a long illness. He told me that this was not the case, that Barney Hill died because he knew too much. He then asked me if I knew how Barney Hill had died, and I told him I understood that he died of a heart attack (wrong information, I was to find out later). He then told me that this was not correct, that he had died because he had no heart, just as I no longer have a coin. This frightened me.[4017]

This implied power over life and death speaks to ancient European legends of the "Black Man" (attire, not skin color) as a fetcher of souls. Indeed, much about MIB resembles the ankou, the emaciated, black-garbed psychopomp of

Breton folklore. Like MIB, the ankou goes house-to-house in its death cart, which the Cadillac substitutes. MIB, of course, featured prominently in the Point Pleasant flap, where many witnesses described squeaking sounds exactly like the death cart's wheels. The ankou also famously wears a wide-brimmed hat, closely matching the fedoras so many MIB favor. Its shape speaks to both flying saucers and totality.

The history of the fedora itself is mired in death: its name comes from Victorien Sardou's 1882 play *Fédora*, written for Sarah Bernhardt, noted cross-dresser who both studied her roles and slept in a coffin. This, as well as modeling for death's head sculptures, served as a direct response to criticisms of her "skeletal" figure.[4018] In *Fédora*, Bernhardt wore a brimmed, center-creased hat, popularizing the fashion. The plot itself revolves around death and revenge.[4019]

The ankou is not the only death figure favoring a wide-brimmed hat. The Tzeltal *ihk'al* sometimes dons similar headwear, as does the one-eyed psychopomp Odin. Although not wearing a fedora, Keel wrote of one tall, mysterious visitor in *The Mothman Prophecies*: "One eye appeared to have a cast, like a glass eye, and did not move in unison with its companion."[4020]

Fedoras also feature in accounts of "shadow people," dark, two-dimensional figures lacking physical form. In fact, this headwear is so common that an entire subset of reports is dedicated to cataloguing "the Hat Man." The Hat Man commonly visits during sleep paralysis, even haunting UFO witnesses.[4021] One Hat Man appearing to a Georgia father in May 1992 was immediately equated with death in the witness's mind. The specter loomed over his son's crib, vanishing upon investigation. He dreamt his son

would be shot in the head, but his wife dismissed the nightmare. Several days later, their son suffered an intense seizure brought about by a high fever.[4022]

Shadows are our doubles—both literally and metaphysically—and it seems MIB could be as well. Barring some sort of godlike omnipotence, their uncanny knowledge reveals things only the witnesses themselves are aware of, evidenced by Herbert Hopkins's coins. Keel hinted at the possibility he was generating MIB phenomena himself.

"I was being led to people and cases to support whatever theory I was working on at the time," he recalled. "I tested this by inventing some rather outlandish ideas. Within days I would receive phone calls, reports, and mail describing elements of those ideas." The strangers his witnesses encountered even "mischievously adopted names from [his] obscure (damn it) novels!"[4023]

Brent Raynes recorded how a friend of Tim and John Frick—researchers who had portrayed MIB the year prior in a television documentary—started encountering the real thing. In November 2006, their friend mistook several MIB for the brothers. Later, she learned the mysterious strangers had introduced themselves to a neighbor *as* the Fricks.[4024]

Maybe Tim and John's truant souls were telling the truth. Maybe MIB are the shadow self. Maybe within each researcher lies a protective mechanism, something which realizes the true existential danger surrounding the paranormal, and actively discourages our participation.

Dogman:

Werewolf? There, wolf!

Let's be honest: *there is no way Dogman is a flesh-and-blood creature.* Whereas things resembling Nessie and Bigfoot once lived, nothing comparable to a bipedal half-man, half-dog exists in the fossil record. Human and canine evolution diverged eons ago.

Do not confuse this with a denial of their existence. They may well be real—interdimensional, spiritual, what have you—but no one will ever kill one. No one will ever catch one. Video and photographic evidence will remain blurry. Like all the more fantastic cryptids, they are bulletproof and can shapeshift. No other mammal can. Add their appearances in conjunction with UFOs, Bigfoot, and ghost lights,[4025] a talent for disappearing and invisibility,[4026] and their tendency to kill automobile engines, and we have yet another creature from the ecology of souls.[4027] Dogman should instead be appreciated for what it truly represents: a werewolf.

Accepting this reality opens up avenues of speculation denied to traditional cryptozoology. We are all familiar with tales of werewolves, although Hollywood is primarily responsible for tying their transformation to the full moon, or their vulnerability to silver bullets (silver is a widespread paranormal prophylactic, but the firearm component is new).[4028] Most traditions agree werewolves are mortal, but their lycanthropy varies between the physical and the spiritual. These transformations might be obtained by

donning wolfskin garments (especially belts), smearing magical salves on the body, or consuming hallucinogenic potions.[4029]

In short, the therianthropic form of the werewolf not only exhibits close associations with European witchcraft but shamanism in general, one of many forms magicians adopted to carry out their sacred duties. While by no means exclusive to the region, the age of werewolves' role in magical practice is evident in its appearance in ancient Greece and Rome. Explains Daniel Ogden:

> Dogs perhaps conferred the blessing of Cerberus and Hecate on the parts they snatched, whereas wolves enjoyed a kinship with ghosts, sorcerers, and witches through the werewolf. As to ghosts, Petroniux's werewolf underwent transformation in a cemetery, whereas Alibas or Lykas, the demon chased into the sea by Euthymus of Locri, was a ghost in a wolfskin. As to sorcerers and witches, the Neuri were sorcerers to Herodotus for transforming themselves into wolves once a year. Virgil's Mocris, who called up ghosts from tombs, could turn himself into a wolf, as could Propertius's bawd-witch Acanthis. Ovid's Medea even used the entrails of a werewolf in the potion with which she rejuvenated Aeson. The danger of snatching parts from a starving wolf's mouth will also have conferred power upon them.[4030]

The Greeks believed the dead could be conjured using an herb they called *cynocephalia*, or "dog-headed," which in Egypt was called *osirits*, Osiris-herb, named after the resurrected proto-shaman himself.[4031] Elsewhere, other plant medicine in the form of entheogens obviously played a role in granting lycanthropic powers, whether real, imaginary, or imaginal.

Here we find werewolves' most persistent legacy, that of *de facto* doubles, consistently depicted in horror fiction to this day. The only difference is that modern lycanthropes *become* werewolves, while older legends describe the wolfen aspect *emerging* from humans. As noted by Lecouteux and others, doubles were often attributed a zoomorphic quality, a bestial side residing within all of us.

"A careful reading of the texts reveals that it is the alter ego that takes animal form while the body lies somewhere without any apparent signs of life," he wrote. "Until recent times in Livonia, it was believed that when the soul of a werewolf had gone off to carry out its evil tasks, its body remained as if dead." Any attempt to move the body, and the soul would live its remaining days in a wolf's form.[4032]

"In a tale from Tourangeau folklore… it is said that werewolves 'peel off their soul,' that their bodies remain where they normally would be while the soul incarnates itself," Lecouteux continued. While in this form, canine doubles could inflict physical damage, maiming and even killing adversaries.[4033]

Frenzied Viking *berserkers*, bearskin-clad "Warriors of Odin," were maddened by hallucinogens into believing they became savage beasts. At least one, in his retirement, was believed to roam the land nightly in his animal form, earning the moniker *Kveldulfr*, "evening wolf."[4034]

Soul wandering werewolves likely became confused with full-bodied transformations in medieval scholarship after wounds inflicted upon animal doubles were discovered mirrored on their owners' bodies—but, as seen in previous chapters, imaginal wounds can leave physical counterparts. [4035]

Therefore, it stands to reason that modern Dogman witnesses encounter not cryptids, but *doubles*—either their own, or perhaps the doubles of others.

Distinctions between doubles and spirit helpers blur more in werewolf legends than any other tradition. Folklorist Éva Pócs noted that "the most important feature of the mora [Slavic witch], werewolf, and supernatural witch are that all of them can send their doubles to journey in the otherworld and they also have dead, demonic variants."[4036] While many traditions describe familiars as entirely separate from their masters, anyone nursing a shred of agnosticism regarding their true nature must admit there is little difference between such doubles and spirit helpers.

Because they were sites of spiritual importance, Dogman's appearance in the vicinity of burial tumuli perfectly encapsulates their shamanic and sepulchral character. Some examples appear in Chapter 8. After ghost lights and UFOs, Dogman is arguably the anomaly most often associated with North American indigenous sites. Reports are so common in mound-riddled Wisconsin that they form the backbone of investigator Linda Godfrey's career, bolstered by dozens of accounts.

Sightings arise all over the United States, however. Arminda Morales, a full-blooded Cherokee, was terrified to see a man with a German shepherd's head peer through the window of her home near Oklahoma's Poteau Mountain. Of the area, Godfrey wrote it "was undisputedly once home to the mysterious Mound Builder people and features a wealth of architectural remnants from that civilization, including the well-known Spiro Mounds." In a predictable turn of events, witnesses also report Dogman in modern cemeteries and graveyards with regularity.[4037]

Compared to lake monsters and birds, relatively few North American effigy mounds were fashioned in the shape of canids. However, modern visitors to North Carolina's Town Creek Mound are greeted by artwork depicting, in Gregory Little's words, "what takes place inside the temple": two figures, one dark and the other light, depict a stag and wolf therianthrope, respectively.[4038] Whether the shamans themselves or the spirits they conjured, their presence lingers today.

There exists ample evidence for what can best be called "werewolf shamans" among a variety of indigenous New World tribes, including those famous mound builders, the Adena. At Ayres Mound in Kentucky, for example, evidence suggests that living tribe members might actually have endured dental surgery, where teeth were removed "to accommodate the insertion of cut wolf jaws into the oral cavity." This, combined with a headdress fashioned from a wolf's pelt in effigy, would have rendered the canine appearance of any shaman startlingly lifelike.[4039]

An additional wrinkle appears when one considers how often Dogman is seen in areas of heavy Bigfoot activity. The more sensational corners of the Internet are even filled with stories of the two locked in mortal combat. What does this mean? Are we seeing the echoes of an ancient shamanic battle, playing out centuries after a victor was declared? Or, as Barbara Fisher suggests, does Dogman simply represent a cynocephalic Bigfoot variant—perhaps a shamanic member of a near-human species adopting the same wolfen qualities as their Adena brethren? Or are Bigfoot the spirits of "were-ape" shamans? The mind boggles. The safest bet, as we have seen time-and-again, is not to propose any explanation, but to simply retreat to the symbolism at play, and point out its consistency.

Dogman's obvious psychopomp connections further point to its likely relationship with the dead. To reiterate, dogs are universal psychopomps and guardians of the dead in the form of actual canids, spectral hounds, dog deities like Xolotl, and soul-leading therianthropes like Anubis and Hermanubis. Even Christianity found cynocephalic figures irresistible, most infamously replacing St. Christopher's head with that of a dog. With his canine crown, Christopher acquired psychopomp status as well, an extension of his patronage of travelers.[4040]

Philosopher John Fiske went one step further. "… the original werewolf, howling in the wintry blast, is a kind of psychopomp, or leader of departed souls; he is the wild ancestor of the death-dog, whose voice under the window of a sick-chamber is even now a sound of ill-omen."[4041]

Despite its flaws, cryptozoology grasps something Ufology overlooks: these phenomena exist within an *ecology.* It may not be the ecosystem researchers expect, but it still represents a system where each entity occupies a crucial niche. We have our *anima mundi* embodied in Bigfoot; our soul-devourers in lake monsters; our death omens in Mothman; and psychopomp doubles in Dogman and the Men-in-Black, which seem to enjoy keeping company with cryptids. We may not welcome these uninvited guests, but they all have roles to play within the ecology of souls.

The ultimatum

The ecology of souls model has a certain allure, an undeniable resilience that allows it to incorporate even the most peculiar paranormal outliers. Some readers may feel that there is little ground left to cover. After all, the previous chapters have addressed some of the greatest mysteries in existence: near-death experiences, the old gods, doppelgängers, faeries, altered states of consciousness, shamanism, ancient monuments, ley lines, and the most pervasive modern myths, those of the flying saucers and cryptids. Certainly we have left no stone unturned; the supernatural must all be sorted, then.

This is a dangerous assumption. Even if we *can* accurately interpret the paranormal as an ecology of souls—and that is a tall order—there are yet dozens of avenues worthy of exploration. This work has barely touched upon the nature of time itself, which certainly must play a role (spoiler alert: it's probably non-linear). Have we satisfactorily explained the technological fetish of the UFO masquerade? Moreover, what *is* death, anyway, or the afterlife, for that matter? What are *we*? The work has only just begun.

So you, as a reader, are faced with an ultimatum, not unlike those asked to stay or leave the near-death realm—though far less dramatic. If you wish, you can leave the ecology of souls hypothesis here, as it stands.

However, in almost any speculative endeavor, it's always more rewarding to continue. To underscore the rich potential of our model, the curious are

welcome to join us in one final indulgence. Let's look at the way this newfound perspective can be applied to one of the paranormal's most persistent motifs, and see what additional insight we might glean from such an exploration. In doing so, we may well reveal a fundamental unifying force in the ecology of souls: headlessness.

EPILOGUE

HEADLESSNESS

OBJ



We have been taught that our lives are linear. It is a concept stretching back at least to the Greek Fates, who wove our lives in threads with a discernible beginning, middle, and end. Yet our lives don't seem to be structured that way. The trajectories of our careers often look more like jagged mountain ranges than a straight, angled ascent. People enter our lives, depart, and return again years later. Love affairs flare on and off like campfires in the spring rain. Even reincarnation itself—if the previous chapters are any indication—seems to be a messy business,

The paranormal, inseparable as it is from the human condition, is no different. We are dealing with, in Timothy Renner's words, something

bearing a closer resemblance to a spider's web. In the second volume of *Where the Footprints End*, he astutely observed:

> Reporting the paranormal is often a difficult task. The nature of writing requires that tales be told in a somewhat linear narrative: one thing happens, then the next, etc. The nature of the paranormal, however, commonly runs contrary to linear causality. One thing happens... then perhaps a dozen other things occur before something else, seemingly related to the inciting incident (either directly or through some kind of synchronistic symbolism) takes place. These paranormal happenings, when mapped out, look perhaps more akin to a spider's web than a neat, clean line.[4042]

This issue has reared its head throughout this work. Should altered states of consciousness be addressed before or after shamanism? Where do you place discussion of NDEs? They're altered states of consciousness, too, but also form the bedrock for all other contact modalities. What about faeries—shouldn't they be closer to the UFO chapters? Do you first discuss the fae folk in ASCs, and circle back around to cover them independently?

The issue of headlessness is no different. Astute readers will have noticed the theme already, but finding a good place to situate it in the structure of a larger book proves nothing short of problematic, as much of what follows requires a working knowledge of *all* the topics we have covered. Separating each appearance of headlessness into their respective chapters robs the discussion of the focus it demands—yet lumping them together isn't exactly a fitting conclusion *per se*, despite its importance as a mythical, folkloric, and supernatural motif.

Thus, the need for an epilogue. By separating this issue out from the larger work, we can appreciate it as a proof-of-concept that the ecology of souls model can be applied to any recurring paranormal theme.

Supernatural skulduggery

In a 2006 dream where she held her dying pet cockatiel, experiencer Natalie met a handsome, cowboy-esque "man clad in black." The flirtatious psychopomp walked her through the bird's journey as it died. Natalie recorded the dream in her journal, but it went otherwise unremembered until 2017, when a djinn under her bed tried to kill her bird in another nightmare.

Awakening, she found the cockatiel struggling exactly as she had dreamt 11 years earlier. It languished for two weeks until, during meditation, the man in black returned to Natalie, warning her that she had 22 hours left with her pet. Her cockatiel died right on schedule.

Several weeks later, Natalie packed her belongings for a move, including an old cow skull which another mysterious figure, the psychopomp's messenger, had admired in yet another dream. Natalie had asked for spiritual support during her move, but learned that the request came with a price: her dead bird.

She rejected the offer, so the entity settled for the skull. She was instructed to leave it behind in her old residence. Although Natalie agreed, she packed the skull anyway, fully aware that her debt would eventually be collected "with interest." Sure enough, the skull was taken from her car—along with other worthless items—during a break-in overnight.

At great effort, Natalie was able to contact her psychopomp in September 2019 through a dream-induced OBE. "Without missing a beat" he provided his name as "Gwyn" ("with a 'Y'") "and then a second word that [she] didn't understand at all." Given his relationship to death, we can only assume this was the Welsh psychopomp Gwyn ap Nudd.

In retrospect, Natalie realized that an "absolutely terrifying" 2010 nightmare featured Gwyn *without a head*. It was set between her father's stroke and his death soon after. Guarding his door was a tall, slender figure wearing khaki pants and a blue t-shirt with "no head at all." His head "seemed to be invisible, it wasn't like it was chopped off." Terrified, Natalie ran to the kitchen, where a friend and a dog consoled her. The headless figure then ran towards them, slamming into her and waking her.

Natalie's experiences revolve around *headlessness*. A *skull* was collected in payment of a spiritual debt. She has a longstanding relationship with a sometimes-*headless* psychopomp in her dreams. Notably, Natalie suffers from a tumor on her pineal gland—the gland in our *heads* so closely connected to altered states of consciousness.[4043]

Headlong into the afterlife

Since ancient times, mankind has sought the seat of the soul. To grossly oversimplify the issue, the two strongest candidates have been the head and the heart. Today, we employ these terms to poetically describe our polypsychic dualism, that of our rational and emotional selves.

In film and literature prior to the 1960s, any definitive "killing blow"—the obliteration of the self—was typically a shot to the heart. It wasn't until the infamous deaths of John F. Kennedy, Ernest Hemingway, and Nguyễn Văn Lém that "headshots" became ubiquitous in media, coupled with the "strong anxieties over the new brain death diagnosis that was established by medical authorities in the late 1960s."[4044]

In our imagination, our hearts no longer contained our identities; our brains did. Medical advancements in the mid-to-late-20th century like pacemakers and portable defibrillators allowed us to push back the boundaries of death from heart disease, bringing more people back to life than ever before. A vast swathe of our current NDE data comes from victims of cardiac arrest, in no small part due to the efficacy of modern resuscitation techniques. Such cases provide a useful metric because, as Sam Parnia and Peter Fenwick note, "cardiac arrest is the final step in the dying process irrespective of cause, and is also the closest physiological model of the dying process."[4045] Cardiologist Pim van Lommel further clarified the implication in his longitudinal study of NDEs.

"The prospective NDE studies showed that an enhanced and extremely lucid consciousness can be experienced during a cardiac arrest," he wrote. "We know from other studies that during a cardiac arrest the cerebral cortex and brain stem show no measurable activity while the clinical picture shows a complete loss of all brain function."[4046] The head-heart interplay is fundamental to NDE accounts.

If consciousness is indeed non-local as van Lommel believes (i.e. arising beyond the body), pinpointing any "seat of the soul" is a fool's errand. Yet there are suggestions our heads, more specifically our *brains*, may offer the *closest* physiological approximation—for instance, the pineal gland represents a strong candidate for regulating our perceptions (Chapter 6). Four of our traditional "five senses" (and perhaps our sixth) are confined to our heads. Put short, your brain may not be your mind—every space flight has a "mission control" station on Earth—but it is likely the vehicle, the remote controlled planetary rover or satellite, by which we perceive reality.

Yes, decapitation is an effective way to die… but it can be so much more. Innumerable beheaded ghosts haunt our stories, but less celebrated are headless entities of every other description, from cryptids to UFO occupants to faeries. The importance of headlessness to the paranormal cannot be overstated, speaking to every preceding chapter. In fact, headlessness just may reveal what supernatural experiences are trying to tell us about death.

Headhunting

Before working backwards through our topics to illustrate the importance of headlessness to the paranormal, we must first establish its importance to ancient people. While literal headhunting was widespread in prehistory, modern trinkets sold as human heads today are seldom if ever authentic, instead constituting leather simulacra or animal heads treated with traditional processes.

In the past, heads were collected to ensure crop fertility, guarantee prosperous marriages, or secure afterlife servitude.[4047] Even so, collecting heads often underscored martial prowess, rather than serving any greater metaphysical purpose. Victory trophies involved fashioning drinking goblets from vanquished enemies' skulls, for instance.[4048]

Headhunting—and by extension head veneration—was once quite common in the islands of the Pacific and Southeast Asia. Heads were also associated with royalty. For example, on Nias, North Sumatra, chieftains' heads were placed in bird-ornamented coffers. The remainder of Asia engaged in headhunting less frequently compared to other parts of the world, though the practice was prevalent nonetheless among indigenous Taiwanese, Afghan, Burmese, and Indian populations.[4049] We also find ample evidence for head veneration in Turkey, from interments of actual human and animal skulls to artistic depictions of decapitation at sacred sites. This is no more apparent than at Göbekli Tepe, discussed later.

Headhunting in Africa was also less widespread than 1930s pulp serials would have us believe, largely confined to the western section of the continent. In a reflection of Nias practice, some tribes reserved decapitation for honored members, placing their heads in sacred vessels. Until at least the late 19th century, Nigerian peoples still removed their kings' heads and hearts, the latter consumed by successors to bestow authority.[4050]

Ancient Egyptians feared decapitation more than death itself. They buried "reserve head" effigies alongside mummies, perhaps as "replacements for the deceased's actual head were it to be damaged or lost and, further, as vessels for the deceased's soul."[4051] Ritual beheadings were limited to animals, owls especially, which were "relentlessly killed," their heads removed, before being "mummified and deified." This association led to the owl's use as a hieroglyph meaning "to decapitate." Elsewhere in the world beheaded animals, many of them psychopomps like horses, were also interred as grave goods.[4052]

Europe notwithstanding, New World cultures practiced headhunting and head veneration much more consistently. Broadly speaking, Amazonian tribes headhunted during warfare, while empires practiced ritual beheading. Along South America's Pacific coast the Inca,[4053] Paracas, and Nazca cultures took trophy heads and performed ceremonial decapitation.[4054]

In many cases, "the goal was to destroy or transform the body in order for the ritual to achieve efficacy," wrote J. Marla Toyne. "The role of human sacrifice within ritual practice may be related to the quest for agricultural fertility, if these oblations were immolated on a regular basis, perhaps in relation to seasonal events, such as planting or harvesting… in the Andes

violent death represented 'life given' in order to get 'life back' in the form of agricultural production, human reproduction, and cosmological order."[4055]

In Mesoamerica, contemporary scholars estimate even *one* of Tenochtitlan's *tzompantli* (skull racks) could have held 60,000-136,000 Aztec skulls, based on conquistador testimony.[4056] The origin myth of the Mayan psychopomp Xblanque involves a ball-game played with the skull of his twin, *Hun Hunahpu*. This pastime acquired a religious meaning to the Maya, who depicted headlessness in associated art and—perhaps—even played the game with actual heads and skulls.[4057]

As explored shortly, mound building populations inhabiting what became the continental United States were no strangers to ceremonial decapitation themselves.

The cult of the head

Some of the most pernicious headhunting practices appeared among European Celts. Historians' emphasis upon Celtic "head cults" has waxed and waned over time, with some scholars downplaying their existence as purely secular, e.g. "insulting one's enemies." On balance, Ian Armit's *Headhunting and the Body in Iron Age Europe* (2012) makes a good case that the head cult was "roote[d] in cosmology or religion" rather than pure military expression.[4058] Armit wrote:

> The ancient Celts have long been regarded as headhunters. Early archaeologists were quick to link new discoveries, like the carved heads from Entremont in Provence, with the classical writings of Poseidonius, who described headhunting among the Gauls. The French antiquarian Camille Jullian even devoted a section to the practice in his influential Histoire de la Gaule, describing severed heads as a 'talisman of the first order.' As early as 1911, the Saluvii of the southern French Iron Age were even included in wide-ranging discussions of headhunting focused primarily on the emerging ethnographic record.[4059]

Allusions to this Celtic cranial obsession appear as early as 225 BC, when the separated head of Roman consul Gaius Atilius Regulus was "brought to the Celtic kings."[4060] Today, ringforts and other European monuments regularly yield decapitated remains.

The head cult closely followed the Celtic diaspora. "Whenever a skull shows up, some very ancient religion is at play," wrote Brian C. Muraresku, referring to "the various death cults that have been archaeologically catalogued across the Celtic strongholds of the British Isles, Belgium, France, and Spain—where de-fleshing of corpses, ritual decapitation, and decorative skulls are all attested."[4061]

While certain aspects clearly relate to warfare, some perceive a reverential impulse behind Celtic headhunting. Of early scholars' views, Armit wrote:

> …the Celts were clearly no mere headhunters. Rather, they practiced the 'exaltation' or 'veneration' of the head, which manifested itself in the display of enemy heads, the depiction of gods and of the dead, and a range of other practices, where the disembodied head stood for the whole being. Heads were apotropaic and prophetic and contained the individual's spiritual force; they were associated with regenerative powers and fertility and could mediate between this world and the next. They lay at the core of Celtic cosmology and religious practice.
>
> …*the head [w]as the seat of the soul* [author's emphasis], and thus severed heads could retain special powers after death. By cutting off and keeping the heads of their enemies, warriors could gain control over the spirits of the dead.[4062]

The origins of this preoccupation—beyond shamanism, addressed in due course—we can only infer from mythology.

"Certainly there is no shortage of Celtic examples of magical decapitations," wrote Philippe Walter. "The Irish mythological texts that constitute the best conservatory of the Celtic tradition in this regard offer the example of *The Feast of Bricriu*, during which there takes place a decapitation… instead of dying, the decapitated individual picks up his head and leaves."[4063]

Walter perceived a resemblance between these myths and the Hindu deity *Karṇa* from the Rigveda, whose separated head not only embodies the seasonal cycle, but evokes UFO imagery: "Like the sun that has reached the middle of the autumn sky, the head falls to the ground in front of the army, like the red-disked sun from the mountain as it sets… The decapitated head of Karṇa shines like the globe of the sun as it departs the sky."[4064]

Although ever-evolving mythologies undoubtedly traveled with Indo-European languages as they diffused, we need not look so far afield to find headlessness. Scandinavians invading Ireland and the British Isles brought with them tales of *Mímir*, the Norse mythological figure whose severed head Odin carried, offering counsel and sharing arcane knowledge (a possible origin for the word "memory").[4065] This is *not* to suggest that the Celtic head cult originated with Mímir—it predates invasion—but rather to suggest, as legends are inclined, that these mythologies might have mixed with earlier belief.

In fact, Mímir's fate resembles that of Welsh giant-king *Brân the Blessed*. Mortally wounded, Brân instructed his followers to behead him, but continued to speak on his voyage home and for seven years afterward.

According to legend, Brân's buried head lies beneath the Tower of London, where its eastward gaze wards off invasion yet.[4066]

Brân displays additional parallels to the Fisher King, guardian of the Holy Grail in Arthurian mythology. Subsequent authors described this character's wounds similar to Brân's, even identifying the first Fisher King as "Bron." Moreover, one Welsh retelling of the Percival legend finds the hero discovering not the Holy Grail, but a severed head instead.[4067] There is some indication Brân may have served as a Welsh psychopomp.[4068]

Another belief inextricable from the Celtic head cult is the veneration of a nebulous deity named *Crom Cruach* ("bent bloody one" or "crooked heap"). His other names include *Crom Dubh* ("black stooped one" or "dark croucher") and *Cenn Cruiach*, perhaps meaning "head of the hill." This latter title invites confusion, as *cenn* can denote both a "head" leader or a *literal* head. What is clear is his importance to the pagan Irish, who made offerings to the god to ensure crop fertility—indeed, *cruach* can signify a stack of grain, offering a possible interpretation as "head of wheat."[4069]

Harvests symbolize death, rebirth, and beheading, offering clear parallels between the farmer's scythe and the executioner's blade. Heads were sometimes buried, seedlike, to ensure bountiful crop yields. Furthermore, universal belief points to the head as a phallic symbol.[4070]

Although speculative, some researchers identify Crom Cruach with "a round stone in the shape of a head which once sat in the middle of a stone circle in an area of County Cavan known as Magh Slécht, the Plain of Prostrations or the Plain of Slaughter."[4071] If indeed Crom Cruach represented

an actual *head* god and not a chief deity, one can only imagine the influence such a figure exerted upon head veneration in Ireland.

Voluntary & Vital

Two important points must be emphasized. First, not all decapitations were restricted to enemies. We see respected cultural leaders beheaded after death, as in Nias and Nigeria. Even Mesoamerican victims of ceremonial decapitation sometimes sacrificed themselves willingly, as to offer oneself to *Huītzilōpōchtli* "was a tremendous honor and a guaranteed ticket to a blessed afterlife fighting in the sun god's army against the forces of darkness."[4072]

Secondly, headless figures and disembodied heads in ancient paintings, carvings, and sculpture were *not* synonymous with warfare, *nor did they always signify death*. As Armit notes, "Celtic art need not of course have any connection to headhunting," with plenty of bodiless heads "shown as sleeping, dreaming, or dead." Others have their eyes open "and the face appears to be alive." The same can be said of examples from Scythia.[4073]

Representations of headlessness throughout Celtic countries are notoriously old: artwork in Pech Merle cave (c. 25,000-16,000 BC) shows headless figures, some overtly differentiated from the dead.[4074] Given his tendency to appear in architectural ornamentation solely as a living head, some speculate the Green Man's origins connect to the Celtic head cult.[4075]

In the New World, inscriptions at Chichén Itzá indicate a "divine headless man"—fully alive—carried out rituals.[4076] Amorphous, missing, or invisible heads feature in pictographs from Alaska's southern coast, including a

depiction of five figures rowing a boat, all their heads detached.[4077] Therianthropy's most common depictions, wherein shamans' heads are substituted with those of animals, can be seen as a variation on headlessness—their human heads have been replaced by something else. Lower Pecos petroglyphs from southwest Texas, for example, show shamans alternately with antlers or without heads entirely.[4078]

Disembodied heads carried profound spiritual significance throughout ancient cultures—but why? We see allusions to wisdom, power, immortality, and fertility, with little clarity regarding specifics. Perhaps additional insight can be gained by tracing the theme of headlessness backward through previous topics.

Headless cryptids and cryptid heads

Even when the creatures do not appear beheaded, many cryptid witnesses remark upon their heads—or absence thereof. Such is the case with lake monster reports, which often describe either just a head or, inversely, headless humps moving through the waves. (As a passing curiosity recalling decapitated Egyptian owls, Michel Meurger noted the deepest point in Lake Memphrémagog—where the "horse-serpent" dwells—lies in the shadow of a mountain called Owl's Head.)[4079]

Are there headless Bigfoot? Witnesses sometimes remark upon their *necklessness*, which may speak to the same theme. On May 21, 1966, teenagers saw—in broad daylight, from their car parked near Morristown, New Jersey—a six-foot-tall, hairy biped whose "head was either pulled down into the shoulders, or it was headless."[4080] In 1976, factory workers near Ipoh, Indonesia saw a "10-foot headless ghost."[4081] Timothy Renner collected a report in August 2020 from Gettysburg, Pennsylvania (known for ghosts, but equally rewarding regarding UFOs and Bigfoot) of an enormous, broad figure lacking both legs and its head which appeared to witnesses after a bush shook violently.[4082]

Legends are more rewarding. Plenty of giants are beheaded. Celtic mythology features the giant *Curoi*, who, after asking a hero to lop off his head, simply picked it up and walked away.[4083] Similarly, a Hawaiian hero decapitated "the hairy one," *Kanaloa-Huluhulu*, and tossed its head into a ravine, lest it recover. "People say Kanaloa-Huluhulu, the giant is forever still

wandering around trying to find his head."[4084] One can even make an argument that the most notorious Biblical beheading, that of John the Baptist, signifies a decapitated wild man: John covered himself in furs, lived in the wilderness, and famously survived on locusts and honey.

By far the most renowned headless cryptid is Mothman. Residents of Point Pleasant mentioned "no discernable head," "no head or neck," a "towering, headless creature,"[4085] or eyes "placed very low."[4086] The trend continued in subsequent sightings elsewhere: in 1975, a "bird without a head" flew above a French home, preceding poltergeist activity.[4087]

Mothman's headless, owlish image remains contentious. While acknowledging that "the more owl-like description should not be ignored," Karac St. Laurent argues that "the classic image of the Mothman… is reported only in the minority of reports pertaining to it and other winged humanoids. Rather, most witnesses, such as the well-known Linda Scarberry, described the Mothman as human-shaped with wings attached to the shoulder blades"—*with*, it should be noted, a head.[4088]

Objections aside, flying entities lacking heads preceded the Fátima BVM apparitions by two years. Four young shepherdesses saw "a figure like a statue made of snow which the rays of the sun had turned somewhat transparent" hovering above a ridge in Portugal. It was headless. One of the witnesses, Lucia Abóbora, became a central player in the events of 1917.[4089]

Along with these paranormal celebrities lurk other headless things:

- In 1664, a headless werewolf attacked a flock of sheep in Benediktbeuern, Germany.[4090]

- In 1982, nurses Tracey and Leanne were taking a shortcut near Bat's Hogsty earthwork in Hampshire, England when they spotted something weaving quickly through the trees. It suddenly appeared next to the car, keeping pace, revealing itself as a man-sized, headless figure. As they approached a bridge, it jumped into the ravine.[4091]

- Night nurse Wilma Huañapaco suddenly found herself paralyzed on duty at her La Paz, Bolivia hospital in August 2001. Through sheer will she turned around, and was confronted by a green-glowing, headless figure. The apparition vanished, leaving Huañapaco in a stupor.[4092]

We also find cryptids and spirits who are nothing *but* disembodied heads. In Malaysia and Thailand, disembodied heads respectively known as *Penanggalan* and *Krasue* prey upon expectant mothers; both dangle entrails behind them as they traverse the jungle,[4093] and are associated with light orbs.[4094]

Several indigenous American tribes describe spirits which take the form of gigantic disembodied heads. To the Iroquois, Wyandot, and Tuscarora, these were variously named "Big," Great," or "Flying Head."[4095] In some traditions, these were the reanimated heads of defeated giants.[4096] Their long hair, tipped with claws, granted them levitation on stormy gusts of wind, and roughly resembles the viscera trailed by southeast Asian head-demons.[4097]

Because they were typically attributed large, glowing eyes, cryptozoologists—who never met a Materialist explanation they didn't like, as long as it retains a hint of exoticism—speculate these entities represent an immense, undiscovered owl species.[4098] Again, we are asked to believe that people who lived outdoors for countless generations cannot differentiate between birds and something far stranger.

Headless aliens, alien heads, and decapitated abductees

"Giant winged beings, usually described as headless, are an integral part of the UFO phenomenon," John Keel wrote. "Headless winged creatures were reported over Scandinavia in 1946, and on November 16, 1963, four teenagers in Kent, England, claimed that they had witnessed the landing of a spherical globe of light while returning home from a dance. A giant, headless figure with batlike wings waddled from it and terrified them, they said. A decade earlier, a six- to seven-foot-tall man with wings reportedly appeared in Houston, Texas. UFOs were also seen at the time."[4099]

Other tidbits, perhaps circumstantial, suggest the importance of heads to the UFO phenomenon. Contemporary descriptions consistently focus upon UFO occupants' heads, which are often so oversized that it might be said that the head has a body, rather than vice-versa. In their basic circular shape, disembodied heads are indistinguishable from flying saucers, viewed from the proper angle. Heads also resemble light orbs, attested to by mythological interpretations of the sun as a divine head. An apocryphal legend features the head of John the Baptist, after its presentation to Herodias, "whirl[ing] up in the sky."[4100] Thus, severed heads might be viewed as totality symbols, despite mortal indications otherwise.

Beyond Keel's examples above, we find headless beings regularly associated with UFOs.

- In 1909, witnesses along Kentucky's Chaplin River spotted "a fierce-looking" aerial "apparatus" that resembled a shooting star, but refused to travel linearly. It appeared to be piloted by a headless man.[4101]

- On February 17, 1949, Alain Berard opened fire upon a trio of short, headless beings after they emerged from a bright object that had landed on his French farm.[4102]

- In 1969, a Salt Lake City couple returning home from vacation encountered car trouble and, with it, a UFO. After their apparent abduction, the final leg of their journey included a slow-moving camper. Passing it, the female witness saw inside "two beings dressed in black leather suits, but the beings lacked heads, having only dim outlines of heads with evil, Cheshire-Cat grins. The camper rounded a curve and was lost to view a moment, but never reappeared, as if it vanished."[4103]

- A Surrey boy awoke in 1973 to find a headless figure at the foot of his bed. It vanished, but when the boy looked outside, several similar figures scrambled into a domed flying saucer, which departed before his mother looked.[4104]

- Two motorists reported lights in the sky above Tasmania in April 1983. Leaving their car to get a better view, they paused for a passing motorcyclist—who had no head.[4105]

- The summer of 1989 saw numerous reports of headless humanoids across Russia's Vologda, Chernushinsky, and Leningrad regions, some associated with

UFOs. In one instance, several children from a village claimed a spherical object landed and released a tall, headless being in dark clothing.[4106] Jacques Vallee dubbed this "The Glasnost Wave."[4107]

Like some cryptids, aliens can appear solely as heads. Writing of one abduction, Katharina Wilson remarked, "This is strange—all I can see are their heads… The face is contorted and pudgy… I know it is alive, but how can it exist in this state?"[4108] Alien abductees like Mike Stevens see disembodied heads in their second story windows; his reappeared during a visit to a foreign landscape. "There's this black backdrop with this giant face that filled a good part of the horizon and it feels like that's why I'm supposed to be here."[4109]

Alien abductees themselves are not immune to all this headlessness. Some surgeries go beyond cranial manipulation into brain removal, or full-on decapitation. Though later retracted, Whitley Strieber claimed that one of his experiences included the decapitated head of fellow abductee "Kathy Davis" (Debbie Kauble) on a shelf.[4110]

Perhaps the most dramatic beheading comes from alien abductee Ted Rice. In the example from Chapter 12, Rice remembered a "light beam" which "swiftly severed [his] head from [his] body." The female surgeon "placed it in a basket-sized container on the floor." His next memory was hearing "a noise like a large resuscitator in the distance" as he "look[ed] down on row after row of short tubs or containers."[4111]

Headless hunts and hotspot heads

Like other haunted locations, roads host a plethora of headless ghosts. Their predecessors, ley lines, are no exception. For example, spectral men lacking heads materialize and vanish along the ancient trackway of England's May Hill ley. Dowsers have detected some ley lines, like the one at Scotland's Easter Aquhorthies, not within or just above the land, but rather "at head height."[4112]

Some of the Wild Hunts traversing these energetic pathways incorporate headless riders or leaders like the Danish Græn Jette. Just before Walpurgis Night on April 29, 1506, armies in red and white clashed near Denmark's Hart Forest, the former missing their heads.[4113]

A decade later, a woman near the French-German-Swiss border saw her dead husband among the Wild Hunt, as well as a figure who offered "a large golden head from which she had to drink." The act, which caused no ill effects, has puzzled folklorists for centuries, but may speak to head cults, shamanism, or entheogens, as seen shortly.[4114]

Ley lines lead to ancient monuments. As with so many other topics, the appearance of skulls and headless imagery at these sites is worthy of its own book, but we are only permitted a section of a chapter. Suffice to say, the amount of evidence, from decapitated remains to sculpture, remains staggering. Western civilization itself may even be founded on such discoveries: legend holds Capitoline Hill, one of Rome's nexuses of power,

was established after builders of the Temple of Jupiter unearthed a human skull (*caput* being Latin for "head").[4115]

One of the oldest, if not *the* oldest, sites associated with head veneration is Göbekli Tepe. As many historians have remarked, the construction of the Great Pyramid of Giza is almost three times more recent to today than Göbekli Tepe was to the Great Pyramid. With it arose the earliest skull cult, accompanied by "large-scale feasting" which likely included consumption of fermented, perhaps psychoactive, beverages. Archaeologists point to onsite evidence for "repeated and substantial cutting" performed postmortem on human crania.[4116]

"One such skull had a hole drilled into its left parietal bone, 'the position of which was carefully chosen so that the skull might hang vertically and face forward when suspended,'" Brian C. Muraresku explained.[4117] It is unclear whether these skulls belonged to enemies or revered ancestors.[4118] Either way, they fit into neighboring Levantine skull veneration, where the "archaeological distinction between an 'ancestor cult' and the more wide-spread practice of 'trophy heads' is not straightforward insofar as the processing of the skulls may be comparable, and these two categories are often porous over time."[4119]

The iconography apparent at Göbekli Tepe speaks to numerous themes previously discussed. Lynn Meskell wrote:

> The idea of a headless body representing a deceased state of being at [the later site] Çatalhöyük has precursors in the Anatolian Neolithic, specifically in the famous

> Göbekli stela, where headlessness, masculine sexuality and raptor imagery (if not vultures) appear in direct association. Uncovered recently by [the site's original excavator] Klaus Schmidt, a monumental T-shaped pillar (some would say phallic) divided into upper and lower registers, reveals a raptor juggling a sphere (or skull?) on the upper portion while a headless man with an erect penis adorns the lower section. The ithyphallic headless male is associated with a bird directly to his left and a series of other creatures with fangs, claws and stingers is placed above him covering the lower register. These specific creatures are redolent of danger and potential death as is the iconographic tradition at this site.[4120]

The simplicity of Göbekli Tepe's "T-shaped pillars" belies their rich symbolism. Dozens have been found since Schmidt's discovery, the largest 20 feet tall, weighing 50 tons.[4121] These pillars, the earliest megalithic architecture in existence, seem to represent vertical figures *lacking heads*.[4122]

"In low relief, spindly arms wrap around the sides of the stones," Muraresku wrote. "Human hands with tapering fingers meet on the front, frozen above decorative belts." Seeing these, Schmidt himself said, "If gods existed in the minds of early Neolithic people, there is an overwhelming probability that the T-shape is the first known monumental depiction of gods."[4123]

Thus, we can reasonably assume two qualities early humans equated with headlessness: divinity and altered states of consciousness. The second assumption is a bit more tenuous, but at the very least, death is an ASC. The likelihood of entheogen consumption at Göbekli Tepe, as well as the pillars' peculiar aural effects (Chapter 8) strengthens the argument.[4124]

Working our way west, we find separated heads unearthed at tombs and ringforts in Scandinavia, Ireland, and the British Isles.[4125] Some were punished, some ritualized, others a combination: two headless skeletons buried at Knowth were interred with dice and gambling pieces, suggesting they were ceremonially executed for cheating.[4126] A Neolithic passage tomb at Tara contained "more than 250 cremation deposits… as part of its ritual construction, followed by over 1,500 skulls and burials inserted into the mound above."[4127] Hillforts at Gloucestershire's Bredon Hill, Wales's Dinorben, and Breidden Hill have all yielded partial or full human skulls, suggesting "human heads were put on display" at such locations.[4128]

Tragically, the human skulls once found in North American mounds were plundered long ago as souvenirs or for the "scientific" purpose of phrenology. Franz Boaz, for instance, collected 200 indigenous skulls from American earthworks, all on the Smithsonian Institute's payroll; he was famously haunted by nightmares.[4129]

That skulls and decapitated remains can still be found in the mounds today is a testimony to the practice's frequency. There is some evidence among the Adena that bodies were cremated, but their skulls were retained.[4130] Some beheaded skeletons were meticulously arranged to draw attention to their headlessness: three of twelve skeletons at Ohio's Kiefer Mound were lain in a circle, their skulls nestled between their thigh bones.[4131]

Evidence for sacrificial decapitation abounds in art. In Alabama, "dancing 'priests' holding decapitated heads are engraved on shell objects and the ceremonial flints depicted in the other hand of the 'priest' have been found at Moundville in a grave containing 11 decapitated skeletons."[4132] Archaeologists

speculate “dramatic sacrifices” took place at Cahokia, featuring upwards of 50 individuals, supported by burials of headless, handless skeletons.[4133]

A clearer picture of headlessness begins to form. Predictably, the answers might lie in shamanism and altered states of consciousness.

Headless rites

Why were heads venerated? We see universally-applied proposals that they held "soul-substance," or were "life-fertilizers" symbolizing rebirth, regeneration, and transformation.[4134] Egypt's dead needed their heads intact for afterlife entrance, as did the Nazca.[4135] Yet the head's most underappreciated aspect is its liminal character, "linking the worlds of the living and the supernatural."[4136]

"This liminal quality appears time and again in the ethnographic accounts, as severed heads are repeatedly implicated in rites of passage, moments of creation, and periods of transition," explained Armit.. "… the disembodied human head, still fleshed and 'frozen' at the point of death, gave material expression to the fragile boundary between this life and the next."[4137]

Accordingly, the Greco-Roman necromancer's toolkit included severed heads to contact the departed.[4138] There are indications of *cephalomancy* continuing throughout Europe unbroken from prehistory.[4139] In North America, certain tribes like the Cherokee felt the "Sky spirit" was released when the head was opened, and used skull bowls filled with water and sacred stones to commune with spirits.[4140]

Likewise, the acquisition of enemies' heads may have served to "incorporate the wild, untamed outside world (as represented by enemy groups) into the fabric of the community."[4141] Armit continues:

> Bringing home their victims' heads transformed these 'semihuman' creatures into tamed spirits that could become part of the community. Journeys into enemy lands to obtain heads at the same time elevated the status of the headhunter, whose ability to move between 'worlds' took on a mystical quality, similar to the trance journeys of shamans. Thus… the headhunter is effectively a 'shaman on the march.'[4142]

Shamanic headhunters and head-borne spirit familiars come together in traditions of the infamous Burmese headhunters, the Naga. In addition to taking human heads, the Naga also took those of tigers and leopards, treating them with the same purification rituals. In doing so, some Naga became were-leopards. Spoke one: "My soul does not live in my body. It lives in the leopard. It is not in me now. It visits me in sleep. I meet it in dreams… If anything happened to my leopard in the day, my soul would come and tell me. I would get the same wounds."[4143]

Most anthropologists resist reframing headhunters as shamans, but none deny the importance of headlessness to shamanism. Legendary proto-shamanic figures are often beheaded. Osiris was sometimes headless,[4144] and while Orpheus famously suffered decapitation, his head continued prophesying, like Mímir.[4145]

As extensively covered in Chapter 7, shamanism worldwide focuses on alterations to the head, with decapitation serving as one of the most enduring motifs in initiatory dismemberment. Depending on one's

perspective, this either occurs to the astral body or is purely metaphorical—either way, it signifies great change and awakening.

Societies may theatrically pantomime such beheadings, as in the case of British Columbia's Nisga'a, who take initiates and pretend to kill them while they slip away into the wilderness. In their place, an effigy is decapitated and buried before their triumphant return a year later astride an artificial animal, their new totem.[4146]

Even in non-shamanic traditions, headlessness carries great initiatory weight. This is no better represented than in the 14th century romance *Sir Gawain and the Green Night.* To grossly summarize, a gigantic green figure—shades of Osiris, the Green Man, and wild men—enters Camelot on New Year's Eve, challenging anyone to strike him with his axe, on the condition he return the blow in 366 days. No one volunteers. King Arthur almost accepts the burden before his nephew, the young Gawain, beheads the Green Knight. The giant gathers his head and departs, but not before reminding Gawain of his commitment.

Unable to shirk his duty, Gawain sets off at the appointed time, and over the course of his adventures accepts a magic sash he learns will protect him from bodily harm. Gawain arrives at the Green Chapel, described as little more than a burial mound. Inside, he offers his neck to the Green Knight, who withholds the killing blow twice before, on the third, merely nicking Gawain's neck.

The giant reveals himself as an acquaintance transformed by magic, the entire saga orchestrated by the villainous Morgan le Fay to test Arthur's knights. Only because he tried to conceal his magical sash was Gawain

harmed. Ashamed, he returns to Camelot to confess his deception, but the Knights of the Round Table absolve Gawain of his sin, and the young man's honor and virtue are restored. In addition to themes of bravery, initiation, and rites of passage, *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* is also believed to teach submission to God's will.[4147]

Initiation—but into what? Perhaps the secrets of existence itself.

Modern occultists employ "The Headless Rite" to summon all manner of spirits. Also called the "Bornless" (e.g. eternal) rite, this powerful, versatile ritual was initially used to invoke *Akephalos* ("Headless One") for the exorcism of demons, culminating in magicians embodying Akephalos themselves. Aleister Crowley recontextualized the Headless Rite as a form of purification by deifying the self.[4148]

However, the supremacy Akephalos exerts over possessing demons also imbues the user with authority to conjure and command spirits. In other words, the magician is able to say, "Since I have your attention…." Some suggest the Headless Rite is best performed under the stars in the direction of Orion, a constellation *below the ecliptic*—the stellar underworld—featuring a *headless hunter*. It is worth noting that Göbekli Tepe, like many other ancient sites, exhibits alignment with Orion as well.[4149]

Akephalos's true identity remains murky, as it is "not commonly found in either a Hellenic or Egyptian context, and is rarely even mentioned elsewhere" in the Greek Magical Papyri (PGM).[4150] Karl Preisendanz, original translator of the PGM into German, suggested numerous possibilities before settling upon Osiris, perhaps syncretized with the dwarfen protector of Egyptian households, *Bes*.[4151] David Frankfurter supposes the "headless" title

was "an esoteric priestly epithet for acclaiming a god's solar nature at a time when identification with the sun was a form of ultimate glorification for gods all around the Roman empire."[4152]

Perhaps Akephalos is so difficult to identify because it is everyone and no one. It is all of us, the god within. Magic and shamanism are simply culture-bound techniques by which we access altered states of consciousness, arguably the *actual* meaning behind so much headless symbolism: "to have one's head in another realm."[4153]

Headlessness is also a perennial feature in psychedelic trip reports. For example, one salvia user reported seeing their upper body as a headless, glowing torso.[4154] No better ASC metaphor exists than headlessness. Drugs "go to our head," altering perception with "head highs." Just as heads separate from bodies, so our consciousness separates from our physical selves.

No matter how hard our society tries to reduce psychonauts to overgeneralized "druggies," the headlessness they seek, if respectfully approached, is a lofty goal. It constitutes an attempt to move beyond the self. Our most recognizable feature, our faces, define our heads; a headless body, therefore, is an egoless body. Physical headlessness is death, spiritual headlessness is *ego death*.

The publisher's summary for philosopher Douglas E. Harding's *On Having No Head* perfectly encapsulates the idea: "Headlessness, the experience of 'no-self' that mystics of all times have aspired to, is an instantaneous way of 'waking up' and becoming fully aware of one's real and abiding nature."[4155]

Headless faeries

As go ghosts, so go faeries. We have already alluded to headless ghosts, but demons and non-human spirits, themselves inseparable from faerie history, also feature missing heads.

Examples stretch into antiquity. Ancient Egyptian Christian protective amulets warded off headless beings.[4156] In the Testament of Solomon, a demon identified as *Murder* seeks a constant supply of victims' heads, placing them on his decapitated torso before they are eventually consumed by an internal fire and replaced.[4157] We find similar headless fiends in the Japanese *kubikajiri*, Slavic *igosha*, and Chinese *Wu Tou Gui*.[4158] English witch Elizabeth Clark confessed in the 17th century to consorting with a spirit familiar in the form of an ox-headed greyhound which "could shape shift into a headless child."[4159]

Headless horsemen like the dullahan defy categorization solely as death omens, ghosts, demons, or faeries. Sometimes both rider and steed appear headless. Although the most famous examples come from Ireland and the British Isles, analogous equestrians inhabit cosmologies as distant as southern Asia. Small roadside shrines dot the central Indian landscape, depicting the headless horseman *Thakur Baba*. This being, which appears in dreams and visions to both high- and low-caste Hindu believers, is associated with the departed, controlling the wandering spirits of unmarried men who meet untimely deaths.[4160]

Beyond the dullahan, headless faeries are hard to come by. *The Violet Fairy Book* presents a Eurasian story where headless dwarfs beset a minister, but, like other entries in Andrew Lang's and Leonora Blanche Alleyne's series, the line between fiction and folklore is not readily apparent.[4161] One exception rooted in folklore is the Suffolk *Galley-Beggar*, a skeletal figure fond of sledding down hills, its head underneath one arm.[4162] Other faeries obliquely flirt with the motif. It may be remembered that Chapter 4's Green Children of Woolpit claimed "St. Martin's Land" as their home; over a century later, the head of St. Martin of Tours was exhumed in 1323 and placed in its own reliquary in France.[4163]

More tantalizing still is a lintel fragment obtained from Villa Roma in Nîmes in 1992, which "bears two head-niches flanked by two apparently male human figures carved in low relief and displaying traces of red paint."[4164] They may be faerie psychopomps. Armit described the find:

> The right hands of these *diminutive figures* [author's emphasis] are held out to support the full-size human heads that would presumably have occupied the niches, while their left arms are raised high above their own heads. Combined with their curious, half-sitting posture, these arm gestures give a strong impression that the figures are in movement, perhaps even dancing. Most intriguingly… the opposing face of the lintel bears a further shallow relief showing two rearing horses, apparently in combat. The paired humans have previously been identified as likely psychopomps, and it is tempting to suggest that the paired horses occupy a similar role.[4165]

Headless psychopomps

Armit's temptation is well-founded, given horses' inescapable reputation as psychopomps. Headless horses carry spectral riders and pull phantom death coaches, but also appear all by themselves or in the company of spectral hounds.[4166] Solitary, headless horses feature in Asia as well. The Japanese *Kubi-kire-uma* is a yokai horse with no head, and when not carrying a deity wanders alone on New Year's Eve and Setsubun holiday marking the start of spring—transitional periods.[4167]

Decapitated horses also marked the transition of death, buried as grave goods. This practice flourished in Celtic and Norse cultures in particular. In County Laois, for instance, a middle-aged woman's remains were discovered in close proximity to a beheaded horse's skeleton. Horse skulls excavated from ringfort entrances suggest they may have fulfilled a liminal, protective role as threshold guardians.[4168] Sweden's Eketorp Fort revealed a "striking concentration" of horse leg bones and crania, perhaps once mounted on poles.[4169] Norway's Oseberg Ship burial contained over a dozen horses, all decapitated, interred with what may have been a shaman on his final journey. Identically-mutilated steeds are buried at Viking Age graves at Brimnes, Dalvik, and Hrifunes, Iceland.[4170]

"The horse is identified with the cosmos and the sacrificing of it symbolizes (that is, *reproduces*) the act of creation," Eliade wrote. "The initiation is in fact a conquest of immortality and a change over from the human to the

divine state."[4171] Ergo, beheaded horses assist in establishing "headless" human consciousness.

In remarkable continuity with ancient Egypt, pre-Viking burials sometimes included beheaded birds of prey like the decapitated owl found at a grave in Valsgärde, Sweden.[4172] Headless humans and birds coincide in Old World art from Göbekli Tepe to Spain, where pottery recovered in Uxama dating to the 2nd century BC features avian creatures interspersed with human heads in boxes.[4173] Paquimé, Mexico features several tumuli, a horned-serpent mound, and "a beheaded bird-effigy pyramid."[4174]

Archaeologists find decapitated dogs and their lone skulls in Native American burials from Early and Middle Archaic times, including one at Kirkland, Kentucky. Whenever consumption can be ruled out, these burials suggest rituals pertaining to the dog's psychopomp status.[4175] Similar grave goods exist in the Middle East from the late Persian or early Hellenistic period.[4176]

A small (though significant) subset of spectral black dog witnesses report no heads, evident in sightings from Suffolk, Shropshire, Sussex, Cumbria, and Dartmoor.[4177] Some of these legends survived into the New World, particularly the southeastern United States, where headless ghost dogs can be found in Alabama[4178] and North Carolina folklore.[4179]

Curiously, although sightings of headless figures are often death omens, we see relatively few psychopomp deities lacking heads… perhaps because, as residents of the Otherworld, they have no need of a liberated consciousness. A noteworthy outlier is the ankou who, when not wearing its wide-brimmed hat, is missing its head. The beheaded could become

beheader, as in an 1888 tale where a young man named Goazic returned from a five year Otherworld visit only to discover that he had been absent for five *centuries*. Among the living, he encountered an old man who told him his debt was overdue before lopping the boy's head off with a scythe, tossing his corpse in the death cart.[4180]

In another European tale, a man literally follows a talking skull into the Otherworld. As the head rolls before him, he witnesses various spectacles: a pair of bickering crows; a man pulling water from a bottomless pail; a house which, whenever opened, releases birds; a castle full of ghost lights. The skull tells him the lights were those of the living. Any that extinguish signify death.[4181]

Furthermore, his cranial guide explained, the crows had been brothers who never stopped feuding, the man with the pail a priest obsessed with riches, the birds redeemed souls. The man learns he has wandered for 300 years, and hastily returns home to find generations dead, his memory forgotten. As he attends Mass, a white dove flutters about the altar. "The stranger was kneeling, motionless and fixed in place, and when he was touched, he fell into ashes and dust."[4182]

Although not a psychopomp *per se*, the Hindu deity *Vajrayogini* wears a necklace of up to 50 skulls. She is closely associated with death and reincarnation, advising followers not to fear their final transition—to die to death.[4183] In her decapitated form, she is closely associated with another deity, *Chhinnamasta,* a headless goddess of self-sacrifice. Notably, *she has severed her own head*, and as such opens the way for spiritual self-realization. Chhinnamasta embodies many of our recurring themes:

paradoxes, sexuality, and kundalini awakening—something which, in another context, might be called shamanic initiation.[4184]

Liberating the halo

Everything returns to death in the end. The universe succumbs to entropy. Our journey through previous chapters returns to the transitory moment itself, the ultimate altered state of consciousness, the force which all paranormal phenomena orbit: the quintessential headlessness of the near-death experience.

Anyone in an out-of-body state during astral travel or NDEs becomes headless, in the consciousness-sense. Though not always interpreted as such, the "360° vision" NDErs report implies headlessness—the hyper-conscious awareness released from physical limitation. They are discorporated. Some employ the term "discorporation" synonymously for out-of-body experiences; in scientific circles, discorporation signifies a sort of medical "Philosopher's Stone," the unattainable-yet-priceless goal of head transplantation, a technique which, if mastered, could bring humanity to the cusp of immortality.

"Beheading is significant symbolically as the separation of the 'understanding' from the 'great suffering and grief' which nature inflicts on the soul," Jung wrote. "It is an emancipation of the 'cogitatio' which is situated in the head, a freeing of the soul from the 'trammels of nature.'" The goal is "a *unio mentalis* 'in the overcoming of the body.'"[4185]

Missing heads clearly symbolize changes in consciousness—not only the change accompanying supernatural encounters, but the final stage of

liberated consciousness experienced at death. If apparitions from ghosts to cryptids, faeries to flying saucers are somehow Co-Created with ourselves, and headlessness is an integral archetype, what are these phenomena trying to tell us? In the pragmatic spirit of *realpolitik*, what practical ramifications does headlessness hold for the supernatural—*realübernatürlich*, if you will?

Our final steps take us into *cephalophores*, saints carrying their own severed heads depicted in religious artwork. Not every beheaded saint (there are many) is a cephalophore. The body or head must remain animate. One early example is Saint Nicasius of Rheims, who according to legend, recited Psalm 119 before his beheading in 407. As he spoke the words, "My soul cleaveth unto the dust," his head was separated, only to finish the verse: "Quicken thou me according to thy word."[4186] Upwards of a hundred Christian cephalophores exist, including Saints Denis, Justus, Aphrodisius, Gemolo, Ginés de la Jara, Osgyth, Valerie, and Paul the Apostle.[4187]

Christian scholars trace cephalophores to a 4th century homily from John Chrysostom, who declared that martyrs' heads terrified the devil more in death than in life.[4188] However, it is impossible not to view them as part of a continuum stretching back to Göbekli Tepe. Neither are cephalophores solely Christian. Readers will see obvious precedents in Mímir, Brân the Blessed, Chhinnamasta, and Karṇa.

Recall how Karṇa's severed head resembled the sun—luminous, fiery red—and consider the challenge confounding artists depicting cephalophores: where do you put the halo?

There is no consensus. Some artists keep the halo around the severed head, some leave it where the head once sat, others compromise and do

both, or use the entire figure. While we are conditioned to expect glowing circles akin to lens flares, other halo shapes include circles of stars, simple lines, diamonds,[4189] almonds (*vesica piscis*),[4190] and even squares,[4191] hexagons,[4192] and triangles, the latter used to signify the Trinity.[4193] We find chevron shapes texturing halos in early 14th century Byzantine chalice veils.[4194] Eastern traditions add smoke, flames, lightning, and other ornamentation to their deities' mandorlas.[4195]

Astute observers will note how *the above halos all correspond to the most common UFO shapes*. Critics will rightly point out that art is not reality—but, as Oscar Wilde famous quipped, "Life imitates Art far more than Art imitates Life," a possibility more likely than ever in a reality where Co-Creation exists.

Bright lights are among the most common signifiers of paranormal activity, associated with literally every phenomena, as previous chapters stress at great length. While light beings are a staple of all contact modalities, NDEs especially, some encounters with paranormal entities specifically speak of this luminosity coming *from the head*.

A County Kerry seer around Christmas 1910 first saw faerie lights before realizing that they held two forms bathed in "a pure dazzling radiance" concentrated "like a halo." It "seemed to radiate from or rest upon the head of each being."[4196] Thirty-five years later, a Northern Plains Indian claimed that he stumbled upon a cylindrical spaceship crashed on his ranch, complete with dazzling white occupants who survived for five months before they were rescued. "Their hair was white… When the sun shined on it… it looked like a halo surrounded their heads."[4197]

Although artists most commonly reserve halos for holy figures, they also appear in medieval manuscripts like the *Luttrell Psalter* around revenants' heads, perhaps signifying their "postmortem power." The only way to dispatch such abominations was through decapitation or, as in modern zombie films, a headshot—only then could the undead's consciousness be freed.[4198]

Halos persisting after decapitation, halos shaped like UFOs, halos around supernatural beings, haloed revenants released through beheading… the implication is clear. When the physical self withers, another part of us persists after *death*, i.e. *losing our heads*—death *liberates the halo*, the divine light within us all. Just as Karṇa's severed head becomes the setting sun, our *selves*, separated from the physical, embodied world, ascend in the form of the UFO, the ghost light, the soul. Consciousness reified.

To speculate boldly, *this is not a metaphor.* It is the most accurate model we possess.

We see these luminous things haunting the sky or bobbing across burial grounds and sense intelligence, connection. There is no difference between the light itself and the beings within. They might be the souls of those before us. They might be our own souls wandering during bouts of temporary headlessness.

They might be our collective souls. In a meditation led alongside her husband Terence in 1986, Kathleen McKenna described the UFO perfectly:

> …find your center, the light... feel that light of yourself moving into your head and letting everything else out of it… let your head become like a cloud of light. When it gets strong, that floats up above your head so you have a sphere of light that you can feel and see just above the top of your head that seems to get more charged as you perceive it. And then it grows. The light is growing, the sphere is growing rounder and fuller and softer until it meets the lights of your neighbors. And we have a huge halo over us together. If you travel through it, in your light, you'll encounter everyone… we can charge that halo of light to be stronger and bigger than us… it becomes a sphere, a dome above and beneath us which meets the light of the spirit of this place, the spirit that lives here. It's partly in the Earth and partly in the air, and very old and wise with a sense of humor. And so we're all inside our collective luminous egg which we could take anywhere actually, but perhaps for now we should just greet the spirit of this place and gradually breathe and draw the white light energy back into ourselves, into our circle and into our individual spaces.[4199]

This seems to be the space awaiting us—pure love, pure connectedness. In this sense, the concept of headlessness—i.e. the liberation of the soul's light from the body—is fundamental to the concept of the ecology of souls. This light, this love, may well be the base material from which all of reality is molded, and we, these scintillating fractals of the greater whole, *exist to allow it to experience itself.* If we cleave to this perspective, there is no such thing as a life poorly lived, for the living is its own reward. By feeling the emotions, by enduring the pain, by simply just *being*, we fulfill the mandate placed before each of us.

But even these claims of transcendent love remain speculatory. No one can say for certain what awaits us after our final breath. The best we can do is rely upon the wisdom of those who seem to have pierced the veil and

returned intact: the shamans, the alien abductees, the captives who escaped Fairyland… the near-death experiencers.

"… we do not know what death is," Whitley Strieber wrote in *Transformation.* "Maybe *not* taking the death journey would be the real punishment. Perhaps this life is a sort of sentence, to be endured until the day and hour of completion and then to end in anguish and terror. Only afterward do we find out how foolish our fears were."[4200]

We can only approach the chasm with faith.

The road goes ever on and on

Perhaps this is the true purpose behind the paranormal: to bolster our resolve in preparation for our final journey. Along the way, we are forced to face death, meeting strange travelers as our path crosses the border into the Otherworld either accidentally—through chance encounters, alien abductions, spontaneous OBEs, NDEs—or deliberately, in the form of psychoactive substances, meditation, and shamanic initiation. Some never reach these heights—or depths—because they are traveling in the wrong direction, towards a destination doomed to disappoint. Others experience not mountains of profundity, but rather gentle peaks and valleys of revelation, those quaint moments where the veil thins and we ask ourselves, "What if…?"

Even those pilgrims on the correct path must persevere wastelands of mundanity connecting these moments, but the ground beneath our feet remains ever-present. Whether standing triumphantly on the *axis mundi*, trudging aimlessly across a prairie, or languishing despondently during katabasis, the underlying strata, the bedrock of reality itself, the Otherworld, lies unchanged, waiting patiently in its constancy for us to appreciate it.

We are always embedded within the ecology of souls.

AFTERWORD

OBJ



Glimmers of red, green, and white faintly indicate where I should step as I creep downstairs to write this afterword, a clarion call of creaks threatening to summon a wife and two toddlers. We're between Christmas and Epiphany in North Georgia, and everyone is exhausted from rebuilding the Union Pacific in our living room the night before. My wife tried her best to ensure the safety of imaginary passengers under constant threat of errant feet, but last night tragedy struck and the remnants still litter the floor, a minefield of blue locomotives staring back with empty, smiling faces. I step on a derailed boxcar and wince.

I have embarked on this sunrise katabasis for nearly a year now, sacrificing a lot of things in the process: time with my family, hobbies, chores. But today—today is the final day. What have I learned? Will I emerge with wisdom, or will I chance a glance behind like Orpheus?

To continue the metaphor from the epilogue, writing this work has been a journey. I am not certain my destination is where I thought it would end. When Death is your heading, anticipate an arduous road ahead. This excursion has been nothing if not lengthy, leading me to check my compass at the midway point—Is this the right path? Should the road be this *long?*—but one does not author a new mythology lightly.

I thought it would fit into a single book. How quaint. The Otherworld apparently had different plans for me.

I never intended to write Joshua Cutchin's Paranormal Theory of Everything, but here we are. In some sense, I have been working on this theory in my head for over half a decade, sussing out exactly how the paranormal *might* all fit together.

Hopefully I present a cogent case that the paranormal seems to be an intimately human enterprise, tied not only to our deaths, but our lives as well. Most things are defined by their opposites—light and dark, highs and lows, interiors and exteriors. Death cannot exist without life, and paranormal phenomena challenge this dichotomy by forcing us to straddle the threshold, the liminal zone no better embodied than in near-death experiences.

I harbor concerns about my own objectivity. How's this for a secret? I *hated* alien abductions involving prebirth memories and reincarnation. This stemmed not from any deep-seated personal ideology, but rather from how messy it made everything. I simply didn't know what to do with these stories, never mind incorporate them into my Fortean worldview.

And this is precisely why I decided to engage with them. One of my guiding philosophies is to lean into, rather than shy away from, anything that challenges my interpretation, be it political, spiritual, or paranormal. Durable epistemologies are the best epistemologies, and like muscles, they only strengthen under stress. "If it's real, it can take the pressure."

Hindsight reveals the wisdom of this approach. Over the course of writing the last 260,000+ words, I have actually become quite enamored with the ideas herein, which is cause for additional concern. Street wisdom holds, "Don't get high on your own supply." "Belief is the enemy," quoth St. John of Keel. I hope within a year of publication to have adopted new ideas, or at least look upon those in this work with a different perspective.

On the topic of perspective, another thing troubled me: I am a Christian. My convictions manifested a dipole of apprehension. First, is my work too heavily influenced by Abrahamic tradition? Though I tend to downplay my faith in my writing, even going so far as to recognize the abundance of truths in other spiritualities, I have nonetheless weathered criticisms that my writing misrepresents paganism, that I should refrain from speaking about a metaphysics I do not practice. I personally feel that restricting commentary to one's own experience leads to an isolated, intellectually poorer, more hostile world. (God, haven't the last few years provided ample evidence of this?) But I understand. It is my sincere hope I have handled other faiths with equity and respect.

The other end of my concern, something I am generally less guarded against, is that my work isn't Christian *enough.* Readers and colleagues alike ask me how I reconcile my Fortean interests with my faith. A fair question,

and one I dwell upon at length in my personal life. The short answer is that I identify as a "Weirdo Christian," or at least someone embracing the religion's truly mystical origins. "Christian animist" or—as my lovely editor Barbara Fisher has suggested—"Christian mystic" might be a better fit.

In any case, my God does not punish people for curiosity. He does not punish people for asking questions.

By way of explanation, I am like a child fascinated by clockwork. I want to pry apart the metal casing, disassemble the gears, see how the teeth interlock, fidget with the springs. I want to learn how the clock functions, and reassemble it. I want to learn how, with our tiny human minds, we can chart the passage of something as ineffable, fluid, inviolable, and immense as time with something as rigid, precise, fragile, and tiny as a wristwatch.

But knowledge is not wisdom, and a clock is not time. That little boy learns no lessons of punctuality or mindfulness, no matter how dutifully he studies the gears. He has no better concept of the true nature of time than when he first started, and in fact the entire supposition upon which clocks function—linear at worst, cyclical at best—may be faulty. Moreover, there are other, more natural ways of measuring time besides clockwork: hourglasses, sundials, seasons, birth, growth… death. A mechanism for approximating the phenomenon is apparent, a better understanding of the *human* interface perhaps grasped, but the mysteries remain.

Such is my approach. Paranormal experiences are the clock, my faith time. Over the years, I have slowly convinced myself genuine anomalies exist, but remain unsure what to make of them. I can hypothesize all I wish, but I

remain gazing upon the gears in awe of the greater majesty encoded. I have no idea how reality works. I can only see how we *think* it works.

If the paranormal exists, it is subservient to a higher power—the God I worship. I don't know its true nature beyond *love*, but even that can be unrecognizable to human hearts in a universe where the most beautiful things are fleeting. Yes, I want to avoid my own death for as long as possible, but so what if a paranormal being kills me? There are worse things: harming others, a life wasted, even the obliteration of the soul, if such a thing exists. (Incidentally, I'm terrified of lake monsters now, something I never thought I'd say.)

The key is to focus not upon entropy, but the renewal it brings. All souls are laundered through all things. Death is merely the process by which they are assigned within the ecology.

Other Christians, perhaps even those closest to me, will treat this work as anathema. I'm lost, they might say. Others will point out that belief in God does not equate with Christianity. Jesus Christ must be present. They will see my comparisons of Him to Odin, Osiris, Dionysus, etc. as heretical flirtation. Yet these similarities are not new; they have been explored extensively by scholars, and remain inescapable.

True stories do not borrow from other stories—but the *truest* story, the archetypal story, appears everywhere unbidden.

For me, such consistencies strengthen, rather than weaken my faith. In a backwards way, it confirms my convictions—if these archetypes are universal, then they are truthful. They all represent the Otherworld, reaching out to

bridge the gap, a truly Strieberian communion. If people can embody archetypes (and I fully believe they can), perhaps this was one source of Christ's divinity, as a concrescence of these motifs. His embodiment of these truths is a way of interfacing with my Higher Power which, for me, yields the most spiritual resonance. For you, it might be different, though you're welcome to join me.

This truth transcends any single time, any single figure. It extends to ourselves.

Athanasius of Alexandria said that Christ "became what we are that He might make us what He is." As *coincidentia oppositorum*, the Word made flesh, Christ's totality aligns with all sorts of concepts modern Christians have yet to incorporate—the Philosopher's Stone, reincarnation, the UFO. If we ask Him into our hearts, the invitation is extended for us to become the union of opposites ourselves. I fully admit my faith needs shamans; what are we waiting for, Christians?

Anyone reading a book by me hoping for insight regarding the meaning of life, *please* look elsewhere. If you insist, I'll try.

Death is so fundamentally a part of the human experience that we will never escape it, despite the constant stream of promises from the pop-science crowd. "Ashes to ashes, dust to dust"—it is encrypted within our name, *human*, sharing a Latin root with *humus*, soil. That same root gives us *humilitas,* to be grounded, near to the earth: *humility.*

This, in my opinion, is the point. To show humility, to show compassion, to realize that, while we should never neglect our individuality, we are all one

when everything is said and done. While I remain unconvinced that a just universe would deny immortality solely because someone didn't meditate, didn't go to church, didn't go to South America for an ayahuasca session—didn't take the time to forge an "afterlife vehicle"—we do need to put our own houses in order, so to speak, if we stand any chance of evading Ammit's maw.

Kindness is an integral part of that. So is conquering fear.

If approached properly, this self-alchemy yields profound effects. In the dark night of the soul, you'll hear a whisper. It will grow, no longer a whisper, but something louder, still indecipherable, yet understood at the very core of your being.

It is the sound of Göbekli Tepe's T-shaped pillars, ringing when struck. It is the chant of those emerging from the cave at Eleusís, blinking in the light of a new day. It is the transmission from Zeta Reticuli, the mushrooms' message, the faeries' song, the cryptids' howl, the death cart's squeaking wheel. It is the words spoken by beings of light.

Die to death, it whispers.

Start living.

The Companion Book

The Endnotes, Bibliography, and Index for both print volumes of *Ecology of Souls* have been combined into a third supplemental book, titled: *The Ecology of Souls Comapnion.* This book also contains three appendices. This supplemental material can either be purchased as a physical copy, or accessed by visiting the website address provided below:

www.joshuacutchin.com/ecology-of-souls-companion

All the Endnotes are provided in this eBook, and there's no need for an Index due to the search application. *The Companion Book* is meant for readers of the print versions.

About the Author

In addition to writing, Joshua Cutchin is a published composer and maintains an active performing and recording schedule as a tuba player based out of Atlanta, Georgia. He has appeared on dozens of programs including Coast to Coast AM, and is regularly invited to speak at paranormal conferences about his books. Joshua contributed to Robbie Graham's 2017 essay collection *UFOs: Reframing the Debate*, as well as David Weatherly's 2018 collection *Wood Knocks: Vol. 3*. Cutchin has also appeared on the hit History Channel television show Ancient Aliens. He is a recurring guest on *Where Did the Road Go?*, and maintains an online presence at JoshuaCutchin.com.

Other Books by Joshua Cutchin

A Trojan Feast

The Food and Drink Offerings of Aliens, Faeries,

and Sasquatch (2015)

The Brimstone Deceit

An In-Depth Examination of Supernatural Scents,

Otherworldly Odors, and Monstrous Miasmas (2016)

Thieves in the Night

A Brief History of Supernatural Child Abductions (2018)

Fairy Films

Wee Folk on the Big Screen (2022, editor and contributor)

With co-author, Timothy Renner

Where the Footprints End

Volume I: Folklore

High Strangeness and the Bigfoot Phenomenon (2020)

Where the Footprints End

Volume II: Evidence

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2022

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